

THE COMPLETE WORK

ALL SIXTEEN PARTS IN ONE VOLUME

The Wars of Punjab

Every war fought on the soil of Punjab — from a battle on the Ravi that survives only in a hymn, to a border drawn in five weeks by a man who had never seen the country.

C. 2600 BCE — TODAY

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

SIXTEEN PARTS · SEVEN HUNDRED AND THIRTY PAGES

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

How to Read It

This is the whole book in one file. Each of the sixteen parts also exists on its own, and each is designed to be read without the others.

The Punjab is the ground between the passes and the plain of India.

Everything that has ever entered the subcontinent by land has come through four or five gaps in the north-western mountains, and everything that came through them arrived here. **That single fact of geography is the subject of this book**, and it explains more of what follows than any king, any faith or any army in it.

What each part contains

- **Roughly a dozen wars**, each set out the same way: who fought, where, what happened, why the winner won, why the loser lost, and one story worth remembering.
- **A certainty label on every one.** **CERTAIN** means contemporary evidence — a witness, a document, a building, a coin. **LIKELY** means good sources writing later, generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition. **The labels are applied to every source equally, including the ones the author grew up with.**
- **A timeline of the whole part on one page**, and five patterns carried forward into the next.
- **A reference section** — the words used, the sources, and an honest note on what historians still disagree about.

THE RULE THIS BOOK RUNS ON

One question is asked of every source in all sixteen parts: **who is writing, and what do they need you to believe?**

For most of this history the Punjab does not speak for itself. Its wars reach us through Greeks writing four centuries late, Chinese pilgrims describing ruins, Persian secretaries counting the dead for the men who paid them, victory pillars carved by winners in distant provinces, and British officers explaining a casualty return to London.

That changes in Part Seven, when somebody here watches an army sack a town and writes it down in Punjabi — and from then on it never stops.

Where this book has found a witness with no reason to lie, it says so, because those are rare and they are worth more than everything else put together.

AN IMPORTANT CAVEAT

This is a strong draft and it has not been through an independent fact-check. Every date, figure and attribution in it should be verified before the work is relied on or published. A companion document — the verification ledger — lists **376 numbered claims** across Parts 3 to 16, ordered by risk, for exactly that purpose.

Every casualty figure in these pages is an argument rather than a count, and the book says so wherever it gives one.

The Sixteen Parts

5	Part One — The First Recorded War. <i>c. 2600 BCE – 500 BCE.</i> How a river was turned into a weapon, why ten kings lost to one, and what happened in the land of five rivers before anybody thought to write it down.
35	Part Two — The Persians and Alexander. <i>c. 545 BCE – 325 BCE.</i> The richest province on earth conquered without a battle being recorded — and then, two centuries later, the greatest soldier in the world turning back at a river.
79	Part Three — Mauryas to Kushans. <i>322 BCE – 250 CE.</i> Four foreign peoples conquer the land of five rivers in four hundred years, and every one of them arrives by the same road.
129	Part Four — The Guptas and the Huns. <i>c. 250 – 650 CE.</i> India has a golden age and the Punjab is not invited to it — invaded wave after wave, until a king almost nobody has heard of stops it.
174	Part Five — The Arabs, the Shahis and Mahmud. <i>712 – 1030.</i> One dynasty finally does what nobody in this book had managed — stands at the passes and holds them — and what happened when it stopped.
218	Part Six — Ghurids, Prithviraj and the Mongols. <i>1175 – 1320.</i> The Punjab as the wall northern India shelters behind — and the men who command the wall keep ending up on the throne.
268	Part Seven — Tughlaqs, Timur and the Lodis. <i>1320 – 1526.</i> Two centuries belonging to Delhi on paper and to nobody in practice — and the first Punjabi account of an invasion, written by a man who watched one.
316	Part Eight — Mughals, Suris and the Gurus. <i>1526 – 1605.</i> India conquered, lost and conquered again; Lahore the capital of an empire for thirteen years; and a book compiled at Amritsar in 1604.
361	Part Nine — The Gurus and the Mughals. <i>1605 – 1708.</i> The century in which a community acquires an army — and then does what no power in this book had managed: builds something that does not die with its leader.
409	Part Ten — Banda Singh and the Hunted Years. <i>1708 – 1748.</i> A movement with no ruler and a price on every head takes a province from the largest empire on earth, loses it, is hunted for thirty years, and comes out organised.
457	Part Eleven — The Afghans and the Ghallugharas. <i>1748 – 1767.</i> Nine invasions by a man who never lost a battle here and never kept the country — and a community that loses half its people in a morning and takes Lahore three years later.
502	Part Twelve — The Misls. <i>1767 – 1799.</i> Twelve states, no overlord, one shared capital — and thirty years to discover that the system only worked while somebody was trying to destroy it.

545	Part Thirteen — Ranjit Singh. 1799 – 1839. Forty years in which the Punjab is a country — a border the British did not cross, an army Europe took seriously, and one design flaw that destroyed all of it.
591	Part Fourteen — The Anglo-Sikh Wars. 1839 – 1849. The hardest fighting the British ever met in India, lost by a state that murdered itself and fought to the end by an army its own government had given up on.
637	Part Fifteen — The Loyal Province. 1849 – 1919. Conquered, disarmed, irrigated and turned into the recruiting ground of an empire — and then told, in a walled garden, what the arrangement had been worth.
685	Part Sixteen — The Line. 1919 – <i>today</i> . A province governed across religion for twenty years, a border drawn in five weeks, and ten weeks in which the Punjab did to itself what no invader in the previous fifteen parts had managed.

A note on the page numbers

Each part keeps its own internal page numbering in the footer, because each was made to stand alone. **The numbers in the left column above are the pages of this combined volume**, and every part is bookmarked in the PDF outline, so the sidebar of any reader will jump straight to it.

IF YOU READ ONLY ONE THING

The argument of the whole book is in **Part Sixteen**, in the section called *The Last Chapter* — the accounting, the rules this history seems to run on, and the one number that matters most.

In the eleven hundred and fifty years since the Hindu Shahis lost Kabul in 870, the Punjab has governed itself for about eighty-four of them.

Everything else in these seven hundred pages is the working.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART ONE OF SIXTEEN

The First Recorded War

How a river was turned into a weapon, why ten kings lost to one, and what happened in the land of five rivers before anybody thought to write it down.

C. 2600 BCE — 500 BCE

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EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



What “Punjab” Means, and Why Everybody Fought Over It

Punjab is not really a place. It is a doorway. And for four thousand years, everybody who wanted to get into India had to kick that door down first.

The word *Punjab* is Persian. **Panj** means five. **Aab** means water. So Punjab simply means “**Five Waters**” — the land held between five rivers: the **Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas** and **Sutlej**. All five eventually pour into the Indus.

But that name is younger than the land it describes. It turns up in writing from the **1300s** — in Ibn Battuta’s travels and in Persian chronicles of the Delhi Sultanate — and it became the everyday name under the Mughals. Long before that, the same land had a Sanskrit name: **Sapta Sindhu**, “Seven Rivers,” because the old counters added the Indus itself and one more — usually reckoned as the Kabul, sometimes as the now-dried-up Saraswati. So when you read very old texts, remember: the Punjab of 1500 BCE was *bigger* than the Punjab on a modern map. It stretched from the edge of Afghanistan in the west to somewhere around Delhi in the east.

Through this book, “Punjab” means whatever Punjab meant *at that time*. In the ancient chapters it includes Peshawar, Taxila, Multan and Lahore. After 1947, when the land was cut in two, we will follow only **Indian Punjab**.

Why this one patch of land has more battlefields than almost anywhere on earth

Look at a map of India. The whole subcontinent is walled off: the Himalayas to the north, ocean on two sides, jungle and desert elsewhere. There is essentially **one easy way in by land** — through the mountain passes of the north-west, and then straight across the plains of Punjab.

So Punjab is the corridor. And it has three qualities that make it a permanent war zone:

- **It is flat.** No mountains to hide behind, no cliffs to defend. Armies can march anywhere. Cavalry can charge anywhere.
- **It is rich.** Five rivers means brilliant farmland, fat cattle, and full granaries. An invading army can feed itself here — and can also loot enough to pay for the whole campaign.
- **It is the toll booth.** Every trade route from Central Asia to the Ganges passes through it. Whoever holds Punjab taxes everybody.

Put simply: **Punjab is a flat, rich hallway with no door.** That is the whole reason for the next 3,500 years of bloodshed.



How sure are we? A quick honesty label

Ancient history is not like modern history. Some of what follows is written in stone, and some of it is a story passed down for a thousand years before anyone wrote it. So every war in this part carries a small tag, and here is what the tags mean:

TAG	WHAT IT MEANS
CERTAIN	Written down at the time, or close to it, and backed by inscriptions or digging in the ground. We know it happened.
LIKELY	Recorded in very old religious or scholarly texts that were passed down carefully. Almost certainly based on real events, but we cannot date it to a year.
STORY	From the great epics — the Mahabharata and Ramayana. There may be a real war buried underneath, but the version we have is literature, not a report.

This is not a way of dodging. It is the opposite: it is the only honest way to tell you what really happened without pretending to know more than anyone actually does.

The 700 Years With No Wars At All

CERTAIN

c. 2600 – 1900 BCE — the Indus Valley (Harappan) Civilisation

Before any war was ever recorded in Punjab, Punjab already had cities. Enormous ones. **Harappa** sits on the old bed of the Ravi in today's Pakistani Punjab. **Mohenjo-daro** lies further down the Indus. These were among the largest cities on earth at the time — with brick sewers, public baths, standard weights, and street grids so neat they look designed by a modern town planner.

And here is the strange thing. In roughly a century of digging, archaeologists have found **no clear evidence of organised warfare** in this civilisation. No mass graves of soldiers. No burned-out war levels. No palace, no throne room, no carvings of a king trampling his enemies — the sort of thing every other ancient civilisation produced by the cartload.

Be careful with that, though, because it is argued about. The archaeologist **Edward Cork** showed in 2005 that if you actually count the objects, the share of tools-and-weapons at Indus sites is often *higher* than at comparable sites in the Middle East — we just do not find them in graves and temple offerings, because the Indus people did not put them there. So the honest statement is not “the Harappans were peaceful.” It is: **we have not found the war, and we cannot yet read the writing that might tell us about it.**

So the first thing to say about war in Punjab is that for the first 700 years of its recorded existence, **there does not seem to have been much of it.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Massacre That Never Happened

In the 1940s, the most famous archaeologist in British India was **Sir Mortimer Wheeler**. He found some scattered human skeletons in the lower streets of Mohenjo-daro. He also knew the Rigveda, which is full of a war god called **Indra** smashing enemy forts. Wheeler put two and two together, made about fifty, and wrote a line that became famous: “*Indra stands accused.*”

The picture he painted was dramatic — invading Aryan war-bands storming in and butchering the peaceful city-dwellers in the streets. It went into schoolbooks all over the world. Millions of children learned it as fact.

Then people actually checked. Across **nine years** of excavation, the total number of skeletons found was about **thirty-seven** — for an entire city. They were not killed at the same time. They were not lying where fighters would fall. Crucially, **not one of them was found in the fortified citadel**, which is exactly where defenders would have made a last stand. There were no weapons with them, no armour, no burnt destruction layer over the final city.

The archaeologist **George Dales** took the claim apart piece by piece and gave it the title it has kept ever since: *the mythical massacre*. The cities were not stormed. They were slowly abandoned — as rivers shifted, water tables rose and salt crept into the soil.

The lesson, and it matters for this whole book: a good story about a battle can survive for eighty years without a single fact holding it up.

SO WHY DOES RECORDED WAR START WHERE IT STARTS?

The Harappans wrote — we have thousands of little inscribed seals. But **nobody can read their script**. Until someone cracks it, we have their plumbing but not their politics. Real recorded war in Punjab therefore begins with the next people, who did not build in brick but did compose poetry — and whose poetry was memorised, word for word, for three thousand years.

The War of the Ninety-Nine Forts

LIKELY

WON BY King Divodasa and the Bharata tribe

WHEN Roughly 1500–1450 BCE. Fought, the hymns say, over “forty autumns.”	WHERE The hill country on the north-western rim of Punjab, where the plains meet the mountains.
WHO King Divodasa of the Bharatas against Shambara , a hill chieftain of the Dasa people.	RECORDED IN The Rigveda — the oldest surviving book in any Indo-European language.

Why it happened

Around 1500 BCE a group of cattle-herding, chariot-driving, hymn-singing tribes were spreading across the Punjab plains. They called themselves **Arya**. Their wealth was not land — it was **cows**. Cows were money, food, dowry and status all in one animal.

The people already living in the hills at the edge of the plains had something the newcomers did not: **forts**. Stone and mud strongholds up in the folds of the mountains, where a chief could sit on the loot of the plains and be almost impossible to dig out.

The chief in question was **Shambara**. The Rigveda credits him with an absurd number of strongholds — *ninety-nine*, and then a hundredth. Whether he really had ninety-nine forts or whether that is just poetry for “a great many,” the meaning is the same: **this man controlled the high ground, and the high ground controlled the passes**.

What happened

This was not one battle. It was a grinding, generation-long campaign — the hymns say it took **forty autumns**, and that in the fortieth year Shambara was finally found “dwelling in the mountains” (Rigveda 2.12.11). That is not a poetic flourish. That is a manhunt.

The Rigveda describes the end of it in the voice of the god Indra:

“I, in my exhilaration, broke apart all at once the nine and ninety fortresses of Shambara — and the hundredth.”
Rigveda 4.26.3, on behalf of King Divodasa

Strip the god out of it and what you have is a long war of attrition in which a mobile, chariot-borne people slowly took apart a network of static hill forts, one after another, until there was nothing left to run to.

WHY DIVODASA WON

- **Mobility beats masonry.** Chariots and horses let the Bharatas choose where and when to fight. Shambara's forts could only sit and wait.
- **He was patient.** Forty years is a strategy, not an accident. He was not trying to win a battle; he was trying to exhaust an enemy.
- **He cut off supply.** A hill fort eats the plains below it. Control the plains and the fort starves on its own.
- **One leader, one plan,** passed down inside one family across decades.

WHY SHAMBARA LOST

- **Ninety-nine forts is a weakness, not a strength.** Split your men between a hundred places and you are strong nowhere.
- **Forts cannot chase.** He could never destroy the enemy army, only survive it — which means he could never actually win.
- **No allies.** The record shows him fighting alone. There was nobody to relieve a besieged fort.
- **Time was on the other side.** The attackers were growing in numbers each generation; he was not.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Hundredth Fort

The Rigveda does not say “he destroyed all Shambara's forts.” It says he destroyed **ninety-nine — and then the hundredth**. That little extra clause is one of the oldest pieces of storytelling in the world, and it is doing exactly what a good storyteller does today: building suspense.

Ninety-nine is the long grind. The hundredth is the last hiding place. Somewhere in the hills above Punjab, around 1460 BCE, a man who had held out for forty years ran out of forts. The poets who sang about it were still singing about it centuries later, and their listeners still knew exactly what that number meant.

WORTH KNOWING

The most famous warrior-king of the entire Vedic age comes directly out of this family, one or two generations later. His name was **Sudas** — usually called Divodasa's son, though the Rigveda's habit of calling him *Paijavana*, “son of Pijavana,” leaves room for a generation in between. He is next.

The Battle of the Ten Kings

LIKELY

Ten kings against one. One river. And the single oldest battlefield trick in Indian history.

WON BY

King Sudas of the Bharatas — outnumbered, and decisively

WHEN Somewhere between 1450 and 1300 BCE. This is the oldest datable battle fought on Indian soil.	WHERE On the banks of the Parushni — the river we now call the Ravi — near a village remembered as Manusa, west of Kurukshetra.
WHO WON Sudas Paijavana, king of the Bharatas, with his sub-klan the Tritsus and his priest Vasishtha.	WHO LOST A coalition of ten kings and their tribes — the biggest alliance the Rigveda ever describes.
RECORDED IN Rigveda, Book 7, Hymn 18, verses 5–21 — composed by Vasishtha, who was <i>there</i>.	SANSKRIT NAME Dasharajna — literally “Ten Kings” (<i>dasha</i> = ten, <i>rajan</i> = king).

Who exactly was on the other side

The Rigveda names them. Read this list slowly, because you are looking at the ancestors of half of Punjab, Pakistan and Afghanistan:

TRIBE	WHO THEY BECAME, OR WHERE THEY WERE
Puru	The biggest tribe of the region. Later merged with the winners to form the Kuru kingdom.
Anu	Settled along the Ravi and Chenab. Ancestors of the later Madra, Kekaya and Sivi peoples of central Punjab.
Druhyu	Pushed north-west. Associated with the founding of Gandhara — the Peshawar–Taxila country.
Yadu & Turvasha	Two allied tribes who later spread south and east; the Yadus loom large in later Indian legend.

Paktha	Widely thought to be the ancestors of the Pakhtuns / Pashtuns . The name has barely changed in 3,400 years.
Bhalanas	Possibly from the Bolan Pass country in Balochistan.
Alina	Probably from the far north-west, around Nuristan in eastern Afghanistan.
Shiva	Ancestors of the later Sivi of the Jhang district — a tribe Greek writers would meet 1,100 years later.
Vishanin	“The horned ones.” Possibly a helmet or headdress marking, not a place.
Vaikarna	Two tribes of this name are mentioned together — “twenty-one peoples” of the Vaikarnas.

Also named in the fighting: the Simyu, the Bhrigu, the Matsya, and the Kikata.

Why it happened — three reasons stacked on top of each other

1. The sacked priest

This is the human reason, and it is the most quoted. Sudas had a chief priest called **Vishvamitra**, who had served him well and had helped him win earlier campaigns. Then Sudas replaced him with a rival called **Vasishtha**.

To modern ears, sacking a chaplain sounds trivial. In 1400 BCE it was not. The chief priest ran the rituals that were believed to *make* the king’s victories happen. He was part general, part chancellor, part spiritual insurance policy. Removing him was a public statement that his family’s power was over.

Vishvamitra had connections. He went to the Purus — the tribe with the biggest grievance against Sudas — and, by every reading of the hymns, he is the man who wired the coalition together. The rivalry between Vishvamitra and Vasishtha became so famous that Indian literature was still writing about it two thousand years later.

2. Cattle and water

The practical reason. Sudas’s people held the good land on the eastern bank of the Ravi. That meant **the best grazing and the water rights** — and in a cattle economy, that is the whole ballgame. The tribes on the far side wanted the herds, and they wanted the river.

3. He had simply grown too big

Sudas had inherited a strong kingdom from Divodasa and expanded it hard. Every neighbour he had was a neighbour he had squeezed. Eventually ten of them worked out that separately they were snacks, and together they might be a meal.

What actually happened, step by step

The hymn does not tell the story in neat order — it is a victory song, not a battle report, and it jumps around. But when you line the verses up, this is the shape of it.

1. **The coalition assembles on the far bank.** Ten kings, from as far away as Afghanistan and Balochistan, converge on the Ravi. On paper this should be over in an afternoon. Sudas is badly outnumbered.

2. **The enemy engineers the river.** This is the decisive act, and it comes from the losers, not the winners. Verse 8 says the enemy tried to “*waste her waters*” — they cut into the Parushni. The most likely reading: they tried to dam or divert the river, either to make a dry crossing for their own army or to cut the water off from Sudas’s herds and fields. Verse 6 says they went at it “*like fishes urged by hunger*.” They were in a rush.
3. **The river turns on them.** Whatever they built, it did not hold. Verse 5 says that though the floods had spread widely, they were made “*shallow and easy for Sudas to traverse*” — and verses 8 and 9 then name the river directly. Sudas got across on a suddenly fordable river. Then the water came back.
4. **The rout.** Verse 9 says the enemy fled towards the Parushni and “*e’en the swift returned not*.” Verse 10 describes them scattering “*like cattle unherded from the pasture*.” Two named leaders, **Kavasha** and the king of the **Druhyus**, are described in verse 12 as being “*overwhelmed in the waters*.” They drowned.
5. **The mopping up.** Verse 11 has the Vaikarna tribes cut down “as the priest clips grass” — which is a very calm way of describing a massacre. Verse 13 says Sudas broke the enemy’s strongholds and “seven castles,” and handed the loot to his own people.
6. **The bill.** Verse 14 gives a number, and it is the oldest casualty figure in Indian history: “*sixty hundred, yea, six thousand, and six-and-sixty heroes*.” Scholars argue about how to add that up — anywhere from 6,666 to 66,666. Nobody thinks it is an accurate headcount. Everybody agrees it means **a catastrophe**.

A FAIR WARNING

The hymn is a hymn. Almost every action in it is credited to the god **Indra**, not to a human commander. When we say “Sudas breached a dyke,” what the text literally says is that Indra made the waters shallow and then swallowed the enemy. Serious scholars — the Sanskritist **Stephanie Jamison** among them — warn that the description is “anything but clear,” and that we should be careful about reconstructing tactics from a religious poem. The version above is the mainstream reading, and it is a reading, not a transcript.

WHY SUDAS WON

- **He knew the ground.** It was his river. He had lived on it. He knew where it could be crossed and what it did when it rose. The coalition was mostly made of people from hundreds of miles away.
- **He let the enemy's own plan kill them.** The single most valuable thing a commander can do is turn the opponent's clever idea into the thing that destroys him. That is exactly what happened on the Parushni.
- **One commander.** One man decided everything, instantly. On the other side, ten kings had to agree.
- **Morale and belief.** Do not dismiss this. Vasishtha's job was to make an outnumbered army certain that a god was standing beside it. Armies that believe they cannot lose fight very differently from armies that hope they might win.
- **He fought with his back to home.** His supplies, his people and his herds were behind him. Every man knew what was at stake if he broke.

WHY THE TEN KINGS LOST

- **Ten commanders is no commander.** The most reliable rule in military history: a committee cannot fight. Somebody has to be able to say "now," and nobody could.
- **They attacked across a river with the river behind them.** If it goes wrong, there is nowhere to run. It went wrong.
- **They gambled everything on one piece of engineering.** Rivers in Punjab are not reliable. Betting the whole battle on a hastily-cut channel in flood season was reckless.
- **They were fighting for loot, not survival.** Verse 7 says the tribes joined "for love of spoil." Men who came for cattle go home when the cattle stop looking free. Men defending their homes do not.
- **No shared language, no shared drill.** Tribes from Nuristan, Balochistan and the Punjab plains had never trained together and could barely coordinate.
- **They underestimated him because the maths looked easy.** Ten to one flatters everybody involved into thinking they need not try very hard.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Battle That Was Really a Fight Between Two Poets

Strip away the chariots and the drowning, and the Battle of the Ten Kings has a very odd centre: **it was set off by an argument between two priests, and it was recorded by the winner of that argument.**

Vishvamitra composed Book 3 of the Rigveda. **Vasishtha** composed Book 7. They are two of the ten "family books" that form the oldest core of the text. In other words, both men were great poets, both men have their work preserved in the same scripture, and they hated each other.

Vishvamitra was Sudas's priest first. He is credited in his own hymns with getting Sudas's army safely across the Beas and Sutlej on an earlier campaign — the rivers, he says, lowered themselves for him. Then he was replaced. And the man who replaced him then wrote the official account of the war that Vishvamitra's new friends lost.

So everything we know about the biggest battle of the Vedic age comes from the pen of the man who took Vishvamitra's job. Verse 21 of the hymn even names the poets who "pledged eternal gratitude" — a victory lap in verse.

The point is not that Vasishtha lied. It is that the oldest war report in India was written by a participant with a grudge, and we have no second opinion. That is a problem you will meet again in this book — with Mughal court historians, with British officers, and with everyone else who ever wrote up a battle they had a stake in.

The Second Front: Sudas Against Bheda on the Yamuna

LIKELY

WON BY King Sudas — again, and immediately

WHEN Immediately after the Battle of the Ten Kings — probably the same season or the next.	WHERE On the Yamuna, at the eastern edge of Sudas’s territory — the opposite end of his kingdom from the Ravi.
WHO Sudas and the Tritsus against King Bheda. Three tribes — the Ajas, Sigrus and Yakshus — end up paying tribute to the winner.	RECORDED IN Rigveda 7.18, verses 18–19 — the tail end of the same victory hymn.

Why it happened

This is the oldest example in Indian history of a lesson every commander learns the hard way: **when you are busy fighting on one border, somebody will come at the other one.**

Sudas had just spent everything he had on the Ravi, at the western end of his lands. Two hundred and fifty miles east, on the Yamuna, a king called **Bheda** saw the opportunity — a kingdom whose army was far away and exhausted, and whose herds were sitting unguarded. He pulled together three tribes and moved in.

What happened

Very little detail survives, which itself tells you something — it was short. Verse 18 says Indra “subdued fierce Bheda.” Verse 19 is more specific and more interesting: with the Yamuna and the Tritsus helping, Indra “*stripped Bheda bare of all his treasures,*” and the surrounding peoples then brought tribute.

So: Bheda was not merely defeated. He was stripped. His wealth was taken, and his neighbours immediately started paying protection money to the winner.

WHY SUDAS WON

- **Speed.** He turned a whole army around and hit the second threat before it had time to consolidate what it had grabbed.
- **Reputation.** He arrived carrying the news of what he had just done to ten kings. Half of Bheda's alliance was probably beaten before the fighting started.
- **Veteran troops.** His men had just fought the biggest battle of the age and survived it. Bheda's had not fought anything.
- **He made an example.** Stripping Bheda "bare of all his treasures" was not greed. It was advertising — a message to every other neighbour about the cost of trying this.

WHY BHEDA LOST

- **He mistimed it.** He moved after the western battle was decided instead of during it. A month earlier and Sudas would have been trapped between two armies.
- **He believed the odds instead of checking them.** He assumed a man fighting ten kings must be finished. He was not.
- **No plan for failure.** Opportunists rarely have one. When the opportunity closed, he had nothing left.
- **Small allies, small stakes.** The Ajas, Sigrus and Yakshus were minor tribes with no reason to die for Bheda's ambition.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Map of Punjab Is a List of Who Lost

Here is the most extraordinary thing about these two battles, and almost nobody points it out.

After Dasharajna, the beaten tribes scattered — and where they went became the political map of the north-west for the next two thousand years.

The **Druhyus** went north-west and are linked to the founding of **Gandhara**, the country of Taxila and Peshawar. The **Anus** settled the central Punjab rivers and became the **Madras of Sialkot**, the **Kekayas** of the Jhelum, and the **Sivis** of Jhang. The **Pakthas** are almost certainly the **Pashtuns**. And the **Purus** — the largest tribe in the losing coalition — did something cleverer than all of them: they made peace with the winners and merged.

That merger of **Bharata and Puru** produced the **Kuru** kingdom: the first proper state in South Asian history, the place where the Vedas were finally organised into the form we still have, and the setting of the Mahabharata.

And the country itself may be named after the winners. **Bharat** — the official name of India in its own constitution — is widely traced back to the **Bharata** tribe, of which Sudas was one king among several. It is not the only explanation on offer (later tradition ties the name to a legendary emperor Bharata instead), but the tribal derivation is the one most historians lead with. If it is right, the name of a nation of 1.4 billion people goes back to a cattle war on the banks of the Ravi.

The Salva Invasion — The War That Killed India’s First State

LIKELY

The most important war in this chapter that you have never heard of.

WON BY

The Salvass — a tribe nobody now remembers

WHEN Late Vedic period — usually given as around 900 BCE, though that figure is a modern estimate, not a date any text supplies.	WHERE Kurukshetra itself — the Kuru heartland, in what is now Haryana.
WHO The Salva tribe — a non-Vedic western people linked to the Trigarta country of Punjab — against the Kuru kingdom.	RECORDED IN <i>Jaiminiya Brahmana</i> 2.206 and <i>Shankhayana Shrautasutra</i> 15.16 — dry ritual texts, which is exactly why they are trustworthy.

What was the Kuru kingdom, and why did it matter?

Remember the merger at the end of the last section — Bharata plus Puru. That fusion, somewhere around 1200–1000 BCE, produced the **Kurus**, and the Kurus produced something genuinely new in South Asia: **a state**.

Not a tribe. Not a chief with a war-band. A state — with a capital (Asandivat, modern Assandh in Haryana), a settlement hierarchy that archaeologists can still see in the ground, a standardised religion, and taxation. Their king **Parikshit** is praised in the Atharvaveda as ruling a “thriving, prosperous realm.” His son **Janamejaya** performed the horse sacrifice and is called a great conqueror.

For roughly two centuries, the Kuru country was the political and cultural centre of the subcontinent. The Vedas were arranged there. This was the peak of Punjab’s importance in Indian history — and it would never be the centre again.

What happened

And then a western tribe called the **Salvas** came over the border, beat the Kurus in their own heartland, and **scattered them out of Kurukshetra**.

That is nearly all we know. There is no battle narrative, no named general, no casualty figure. What we have are two ritual manuals mentioning the Salvās as outsiders who broke Kuru dominance, and a scholarly reconstruction — chiefly by the Harvard Sanskritist **Michael Witzel** — putting the pieces together.

But the consequences are enormous and completely visible:

- The Kuru state **never recovered**. It limped on, split into two, and by around 500 BCE had dissolved into small republics. Kautilya, writing his manual of statecraft centuries later, lists “Kuru” not as a kingdom but as one of the corporations “living by the title of king” — an oligarchy of men who all called themselves royal.
- The centre of Indian civilisation **shifted east**, to Panchala, then Kosala, then Videha, and finally to **Magadha** in Bihar, which would go on to produce the Mauryan empire.
- Punjab stopped being the heart of India and became its frontier. **Every war in the rest of this book flows from that change.**

DO NOT CONFUSE THESE TWO EVENTS

Around 875 BCE — a generation or so after the Salvā war — the Kuru capital at **Hastinapura** was wrecked by a flood. The archaeologist **B. B. Lal** dug the site and found the settlement layer ending in exactly that: a great flood that “washed away a considerable portion of the settlement.” Later tradition says a king named **Nichakshu** abandoned the ruined city and refounded his capital far away at Kaushambi.

These are **two separate disasters** — one a war recorded in Vedic texts, one a flood found in the soil. Popular accounts often mash them into a single story. They should not be.

WHY THE SALVAS WON

- **They hit the head, not the limbs.** They went straight for Kurukshetra — the political and ritual centre. Break that and the whole structure loses its meaning.
- **They were outside the system.** Vedic texts call them non-Vedic. They were not bound by the alliances, marriage ties or ritual obligations that restrained everybody inside the Kuru world.
- **They came at a succession crisis.** The last Kuru king, Uicchaiḥśravas, appears to have **died without an heir**. There was no obvious person to rally behind.

WHY THE KURUS LOST

- **Over-centralised.** A tribe that loses its capital moves on. A state that loses its capital loses everything — the treasury, the records, the rituals, the legitimacy.
- **Complacent frontier.** Two hundred years of dominance had turned the west from a war zone into an assumption.
- **No heir.** The single most common way ancient kingdoms die.
- **Successful states get soft, and successful states get resented.** Both were true here.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Tribe That Broke India’s First State and Got No Statue

Think about the scale of this for a moment. The **Kuru kingdom** is the setting of the **Mahabharata** — the longest poem ever composed, a text a billion people still know by heart in pieces. Kurukshetra is the most famous battlefield in Indian literature. The Bhagavad Gita is spoken there.

And the people who actually, historically brought that kingdom down were the **Salvas** — and there is not one epic about them, not one temple, not one hero's name that survives. We do not know who their king was. We do not know what happened on the day. We know only that they came, they won, and Indian civilisation packed up and moved east.

The Salvas themselves eventually gave up, adopted Vedic culture, married into their neighbours and vanished into the population around Alwar. They beat the greatest kingdom of their age and were absorbed by the losers within a few generations.

History does not remember the winner. It remembers whoever hired the better poet. The Kurus had the Mahabharata. The Salvas had nobody.

The Kurukshetra War

STORY

The most famous battle ever fought on the Punjab plain — and the one we can say least about.

WON BY

The Pandavas and their Panchala allies — at ruinous cost

READ THIS FIRST

The Kurukshetra war belongs in this book because it is set on Punjab soil, because nearly every Punjabi kingdom of the ancient world fights in it, and because it is the war most people picture when they picture ancient India. But it must be labelled honestly. The **Mahabharata** was composed between roughly 400 BCE and 400 CE — many centuries after any war it might be based on. No archaeology confirms the events. What we probably have is a real conflict whose details are now unrecoverable — a battle that was, in the words of the historian **A. L. Basham**, “magnified to titanic proportions” and so “formed the basis of the story of the greatest of India’s epics.” Basham himself guessed it happened around the beginning of the 9th century BCE.

When was it? Nobody agrees

The range of serious and semi-serious proposals is enormous, and it is worth seeing them side by side just to understand how open the question is:

PROPOSED DATE	WHO PROPOSED IT, AND ON WHAT BASIS
3102 BCE	Traditional Hindu dating — the start of the Kali Yuga.
3067 BCE	B. N. Achar, using planetarium software on the astronomical descriptions in the text.
c. 1000 BCE	Argued by a number of historians and archaeologists. Often quoted as the mainstream figure — but there is <i>no</i> real consensus.
c. 900 BCE	A. L. Basham — “around the beginning of the ninth century.”
c. 950 BCE	The historian John Keay, and V. S. Dubey.
836 BCE	B. B. Lal, matching it to the Painted Grey Ware archaeological layer.
c. 750–350 BCE	Asko Parpola, placing it much later in the same pottery sequence.

Note: Michael Witzel’s often-quoted “1200–800 BCE” is not a proposed date for the battle. It is his dating of the period when the Kuru kingdom held power — the world the epic is set in.

Why it matters here: almost every Punjab kingdom is in it

Whatever its historical basis, the epic preserves something priceless — **a memory of who the powers of the Punjab were and whose side they took.** And the pattern is striking: the north-west lined up almost solidly on the losing side.

PUNJAB POWER	LED BY	SIDE AND FATE
Madra Sialkot	Shalya	Kaurava. Became the last Kaurava commander-in-chief. Killed by Yudhishtira.
Gandhara Taxila / Peshawar	Shakuni	Kaurava. The dice-player who starts the whole quarrel. Beheaded by Sahadeva on the last day.
Trigarta Jalandhar / Kangra	Susharma	Kaurava. Supplied an entire army corps of suicide troops. Killed by Arjuna.
Sindhu-Sauvira	Jayadratha	Kaurava. Held four Pandavas off for one day — the day Abhimanyu died.
Kamboja Horse country of the north-west	Sudakshina	Kaurava. Beaten by Arjuna on day 14.
Kekaya Jhelum country	Six royal brothers	Split — five on one side, one on the other. A civil war inside a civil war.
Kshudraka & Malava	—	Kaurava. The same republics Alexander would fight 700 years later.
Sivi, Ambashtha, Bahlika	—	Kaurava, with the Ambashthas switching sides mid-war.

Why one side won, if we take the story on its own terms

WHY THE PANDAVAS WON

- **Unity of purpose.** Seven armies, one aim, one supreme commander (Dhrishtadyumna) and one strategist (Krishna) whose authority nobody questioned.
- **They targeted commanders, not soldiers.** Every one of the war's turning points is the removal of an enemy general — Bhishma, Drona, Karna, Shalya, in that order. Kill the head and the eleven armies below it stop working together.
- **They were willing to be ruthless.** Every single one of those four kills involved a trick, a technicality or an outright deception. It is the moral wound at the centre of the epic — and it is also why they won.
- **Smaller and tighter.** Seven divisions that trusted each other beat eleven that did not.

WHY THE KAURAVAS LOST

- **Too many allies, too little loyalty.** Eleven armies, assembled by obligation, debt and trickery. Several of their best men openly wanted the other side to win.
- **Divided command.** Four commanders-in-chief in eighteen days, each with private grudges against the others — Karna refused to fight at all while Bhishma led.
- **They fought as champions, not as an army.** Their whole strategy rested on individual heroes. When the heroes fell, there was no system underneath.
- **Rigid formations.** The great wheel-formation that trapped Abhimanyu was a masterpiece — and a trap for its own side, because it needed everyone to hold position exactly.
- **Duryodhana would not stop.** Every offer of settlement was refused. A war you cannot end except by winning is a war you will probably lose.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — BRAVERY

The Sworn Ones of Trigarta, Who Attended Their Own Funerals

Trigarta — the country around Jalandhar and Kangra — sent a full army corps to Kurukshetra. They were called the **Samshaptakas**, “the sworn ones.”

Their oath was simple: **kill Arjuna, or die**. No third option, no retreat, no surrender. And they did something before the battle that is hard to read even now — they **performed their own funeral rites in advance**. Each man carried out the ceremonies for his own death, so that whatever happened to his body on the field, the rituals would already have been done properly.

Their commander, King **Susharma**, knew perfectly well he could not beat Arjuna. That was never the plan. His job was to *occupy* him — to drag the best warrior on the enemy side to the far end of the battlefield and keep him there. And on day thirteen it worked exactly as designed: while the Samshaptakas held Arjuna away, Drona formed the wheel-trap on the other side of the field and the boy **Abhimanyu** was killed inside it.

Arjuna eventually destroyed them to the last man. But they had already done their job — and they had already buried themselves.

How the King of Sialkot Was Tricked by a Road Full of Free Hotels

Shalya, king of Madra — that is Sialkot, in the heart of Punjab — was the Pandavas' own uncle. Their mother Madri was his sister. He set out with his army to fight *for* them.

On the road east, he found the most wonderful thing. Every few miles there were rest-houses, feasts laid out, entertainers, cool water, fresh bedding — a royal welcome stretching the entire length of his march. Shalya assumed his nephew Yudhishtira had arranged it. Delighted, he sent for whoever was responsible and, in the grand manner, **offered them any boon they wished**.

Out stepped **Duryodhana**, leader of the other side. He had built the whole road of hospitality himself, for exactly this moment. His boon: *fight for me*.

Shalya was a king. A king's word given is a king's word kept. He had just promised his entire army to the enemy of his own nephews, and he could not take it back.

So he went to war on the wrong side — and then spent the entire war sabotaging it. He blessed Yudhishtira before the fighting. He agreed in advance to undermine Karna's confidence. Made Karna's charioteer on day seventeen, he spent the day praising Arjuna, mocking Karna with a parable about a crow that thought it was a swan, and quietly steering him away from killing Pandava princes he could easily have killed. Karna lost that duel partly because his own driver talked him out of believing he could win it.

The epic gives him a grim send-off. After the war, when Queen Gandhari walked the battlefield among the dead, she found Shalya's body with **the birds eating his tongue**.

The Great Cattle Raid: Trigarta Against Matsya

STORY

Forget the epics for a moment. This is what a real war in Iron Age Punjab actually looked like.

WON BY

Matsya — thanks to two disguised guests in the palace

WHEN

In the epic's timeline, the year before Kurukshetra. Deliberately timed for the seventh and eighth days of the dark fortnight.

WHERE

The Matsya kingdom, south-east of Punjab proper, raided from the Trigarta country (Jalandhar-Kangra).

WHO

King **Susharma of Trigarta**, backed by the Kauravas, against King **Virata of Matsya**.

WHAT WAS AT STAKE

Cows. Nothing else. In Sanskrit the episode is literally called the *Gograhana* — “the seizing of the cattle.”

Why it happened

Two reasons — one personal, one cold.

Personal: Susharma of Trigarta had been beaten in war, repeatedly and humiliatingly, by a man called **Kichaka** — the commander of Matsya's army and the king's brother-in-law. Then news came that Kichaka was dead, killed in murky circumstances. Susharma's reaction was immediate: *the man who beats me is gone, and the country he protected is now defenceless.*

Cold: He took the plan to **Duryodhana**, and argued the case in one line — Matsya is “abounding in corn” and has no protector. **Karna backed it.** But the Kauravas had a second motive Susharma did not much care about: the Pandavas were hiding somewhere in their thirteenth year of exile, and if they were found before the year was out, they owed another twelve years in the forest. A big loud raid was a good way to **flush them out.**

The plan — and it was a genuinely good plan

They designed a **two-pronged, two-day operation**:

1. **Day one, from the south:** Susharma and the Trigartas drive off the southern herds. Virata must respond — a king who lets his cattle be taken is finished.

2. Day two, from the north: with Virata's entire army chasing Susharma in the south, the Kaurava high command sweeps in from the opposite direction and takes the northern herds against no opposition at all.

This is a textbook diversion. Split the enemy's attention, force him to commit, then hit the space he has just vacated. On paper it should have worked perfectly.

What happened

Round one went almost exactly to plan. Virata marched south with his sons and — unknown to anyone — four disguised Pandavas among his staff. In the fighting, **Susharma captured King Virata alive.** That should have been the end of it.

Then a very large cook in the royal kitchens stopped pretending to be a cook. **Bhima** smashed through the Trigarta line, freed Virata, and took Susharma prisoner instead.

Round two went spectacularly wrong. The Kauravas swept in from the north on schedule — Bhishma, Drona, Karna, Kripa and Ashvatthaman, the finest soldiers of the age. And there was nobody home except the young prince **Uttara**, whose charioteer was a dance teacher named **Brihannala**.

Uttara, seeing the greatest army in India drawn up in front of him, panicked completely and tried to run: *"Let the cattle go anywhere, let my city be desolate."* His charioteer refused, told him that death in battle is better than flight, and then — having got the boy back into the chariot — swapped places with him.

Brihannala was Arjuna. He recovered his great bow from where it had been hidden in a tree, blew his war-conch, and fought the entire Kaurava high command by himself.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE FUNNIEST SCENE IN ANCIENT INDIAN WARFARE

The Generals' Clothes That Became Dolls' Dresses

Arjuna could have killed them. He did not — several were his own teachers and his great-uncle. So instead of a slaughter he used a weapon called the **Sammohana astra**, which put the entire enemy command **to sleep** where they stood.

Bhishma. Drona. Karna. Kripa. Ashvatthaman. The most feared warriors on the subcontinent, laid out unconscious in a field.

And then Arjuna turned to the boy Uttara and told him to go and **collect their upper garments.**

Why? Because Uttara's little sister wanted new outfits for her dolls.

That is how the raid ended. Trigarta's king was a prisoner, the Kaurava high command woke up in an empty field half-undressed, and the finest cloth in India went home in a chariot to be cut up into clothes for a girl's toys. There is nothing else quite like it in the whole of ancient war literature.

WHY MATSYA WON

- **Hidden strength.** They had two of the greatest warriors alive working in the palace as a cook and a dance teacher. No intelligence report in the world was going to catch that.
- **They counter-attacked instead of negotiating.** Bhima's instinct — hit back now, hard — was right. Delay would have lost the king.
- **Mercy as strategy.** Putting the Kaurava generals to sleep instead of killing them avoided turning a cattle raid into a blood feud with all of Hastinapura.

WHY TRIGARTA LOST

- **An intelligence failure, not a planning failure.** The plan was excellent. It was built on one assumption — that Matsya had no great warriors left — and that assumption was wrong.
- **He attacked on emotion.** Susharma moved because his personal enemy had died, not because the strategic moment was right.
- **He captured the king and then relaxed.** Taking Virata should have been followed by an immediate withdrawal. Standing around on the field gave Bhima the opening.
- **Two allies, two agendas.** Trigarta wanted cattle; the Kauravas wanted to expose the Pandavas. Neither got what they came for.

WHY THIS RAID MATTERS MORE THAN THE EPIC BATTLE

Kurukshetra is a literary event. **The Gograhana is what actual warfare in the Punjab looked like for most of history:** a neighbour waits until your best soldier dies, comes over the border in the dark half of the month, drives off your cows, and goes home. No territory changes hands. No empire falls. Just cattle, pride and a score to settle. That pattern ran in this land for three thousand years — you will see it again in the Sikh *misl* period in Part 12, almost unchanged.

Gandhara Against Avanti: Punjab's First Named Victory

LIKELY

WON BY

King Pukkusati of Gandhara

WHEN	WHERE
Middle of the 6th century BCE — around 550–520 BCE.	Not recorded. Gandhara’s capital was Taxila; Avanti’s was Ujjain — about 1,500 km apart.
WHO	RECORDED IN
Pukkusati (Sanskrit: Pushkarasarin) of Gandhara against Chanda Pajjota — “Pradyota the Cruel” — of Avanti.	The Buddhist commentarial tradition — chiefly Buddhaghosa’s <i>Papanchasudani</i> on the Dhatuvibhanga Sutta. Pali texts often call him king of Takkasila (Taxila) rather than “Gandhara.”

Why it happened, and what happened

By the 6th century BCE the old tribal world was consolidating into sixteen big powers, the **Mahajanapadas**. Two of them were expanding fast in opposite directions: **Gandhara** in the far north-west, and **Avanti** in central India under a king whose own people nicknamed him “the Cruel.”

Gandhara at this moment was probably the strongest state in the north-west. Kashmir was under its control, and modern scholars think the Punjab kingdoms — **Kekaya, Madra, Ushinara and Sivi** — were its vassals. When Pukkusati pushed outward, he ran into Pradyota.

The commentary records the outcome in a single flat sentence: Pukkusati “*waged war against Chanda Pajjota of Avanti and defeated him.*” **Punjab beat central India.**

And then he could not finish the job — because a Punjab tribe called the **Pandavas** (a real historical people, nothing to do with the epic’s five brothers) rose up behind him, threatened by his own expansion. Pradyota was saved not by his own army but by a rebellion in his enemy’s rear.

WHY GANDHARA WON

- **A deep manpower base.** Vassal kingdoms across Punjab and Kashmir meant Pukkusati could raise soldiers from a very wide area.
- **North-western cavalry.** Gandhara and its neighbour Kamboja were the horse-breeding heartland of ancient India. Everyone else bought their war-horses from this region.
- **A secure eastern flank — bought, not fought.** Pukkusati had an active friendship with Bimbisara of Magadha, the other rising power. He never had to worry about the east.

WHY AVANTI LOST, AND WHY GANDHARA COULD NOT FOLLOW THROUGH

- **Avanti fought far from home** against a horse-army on ground that suited it.
- **Pradyota's reputation worked against him.** A king called "the Cruel" by his own tradition does not attract willing allies.
- **Gandhara's own empire was its weakness.** Vassals held down by force revolt the moment the army marches away — and that is precisely what the Pandava tribe did.
- **No plan for a two-front war.** The same mistake Sudas had avoided nine centuries earlier.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The King Who Beat an Empire and Was Killed by a Cow

Pukkusati and **Bimbisara** of Magadha never met, but they became friends through the merchants who travelled between their kingdoms. Bimbisara treated Gandharan traders so well — housed and fed at royal expense, no tariffs at all — that word got back.

Pukkusati opened the friendship properly, sending **eight priceless muslin garments in lacquered sandalwood caskets**. Bimbisara answered with something stranger: a **sheet of gold, roughly two and a half metres long**, engraved with the teachings of the Buddha, sent all the way to the Gandharan frontier on the back of the state elephant with full ceremonial honours.

Pukkusati read it alone. Then he shaved his head, put on saffron robes, and **walked away from his throne**.

He travelled on foot most of the way across northern India looking for the Buddha, taking a wrong turn on the way, and one night took shelter in a potter's hut. Another traveller came in and asked to share the shelter. The two men talked through the night, and the stranger taught him a discourse on the six elements. Only towards the end did Pukkusati realise who he was sitting with.

He went out at dawn to find a robe and a begging bowl so he could be ordained properly. On the way, a stray cow — running after her wandering calf — **gored him to death in the street**.

The most powerful king in the north-west, the man who beat Avanti, killed by a loose cow in a Magadhan lane while shopping for a bowl.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

c. 2600–1900 BCE	The Indus cities. Harappa and Mohenjo-daro. No evidence of war. No readable records. <i>The famous “massacre” was invented in the 1940s.</i>
c. 1500–1450 BCE	The War of the Ninety-Nine Forts. Divodasa vs Shambara. Forty years of siege warfare in the hills. Won by Divodasa.
c. 1450–1300 BCE	The Battle of the Ten Kings. On the Ravi. Ten tribes against one king. The river became the weapon. Won by Sudas.
immediately after	The Yamuna campaign. Sudas turns east and strips King Bheda of everything. Won by Sudas.
c. 1200–1000 BCE	Bharatas and Purus merge. The Kuru kingdom is born — the first true state in South Asia.
c. 900 BCE	The Salva invasion. The Kurus are beaten and scattered from Kurukshetra. Indian civilisation shifts east forever. Won by the Salvas.
c. 875 BCE	A flood destroys Hastinapura. The capital is abandoned. (<i>Not a war — and not the same event as the Salva invasion.</i>)
date unknown	The Kurukshetra war and the Trigarta cattle raid — the great epic traditions, set on this soil. Both won by the Pandava side.
c. 550–520 BCE	Gandhara defeats Avanti. Punjab's first victory recorded under a king's own name. Won by Pukkusati.
c. 535 BCE	The Persians arrive. <i>Part Two begins here.</i>

Four patterns that will repeat for the next three thousand years

- 1. In Punjab, water is a weapon.** The very first battle we can name was decided by a river. It will happen again and again — Sikh armies fighting with their backs to the Sutlej, British engineers at Sobraon, tanks bogged in flooded sugarcane fields near Khem Karan in 1965. Five rivers cut this land into compartments, and every commander who ever fought here had to answer the same question: *what do I do about the water?*
- 2. A coalition loses to a single command.** Ten kings lost to one on the Ravi. Eleven armies lost to seven at Kurukshetra. You will watch this happen to the Malloi and Oxydracae against Alexander, to the Rajput confederacy against Babur, to the Marathas at Panipat, and to the Sikh army in 1846 — every time, a bigger force that could not agree fast enough.
- 3. Punjab's tribes were built for war and left almost no records.** The grammarian Panini, writing around 500 BCE, describes the peoples of the five rivers with a special term — *ayudhajivin sangha*, “corporations that live by weapons.” These were republics of armed men. And yet before Alexander we cannot name a single battle any of them fought. **The silence is missing paperwork, not peace.**

4. **The winner is whoever gets written about.** Vasishtha wrote up the Battle of the Ten Kings and we have no other account. The Salvas destroyed India's first state and left no name behind. Throughout this book, ask of every battle: *who wrote this, and what did they want you to think?*

COMING NEXT — PART TWO

Persians and Alexander, 535–325 BCE. Cyrus and Darius take the north-west and put Punjabi soldiers into the Persian army — men from Taxila fight the Greeks at Thermopylae and Plataea. Then Alexander comes the other way: the elephant battle against Porus on the Jhelum, the wagon-fort of the Kathaioi at Sangala, the mutiny on the Beas where his own soldiers finally beat him, and the wall at Multan where the greatest conqueror in the world jumped alone into an enemy city and took an arrow through the lung.

Words Used in This Part

Sapta Sindhu

“Seven Rivers.” The oldest name for the Punjab region, from the Rigveda. Bigger than modern Punjab.

Panj-aab (Punjab)

Persian for “Five Waters” — the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej.

Rigveda

The oldest Indian text, roughly 1500–1200 BCE. A collection of over a thousand hymns, memorised word-perfect for about 3,000 years before being written down. Our only source for the earliest wars.

Parushni

The Rigvedic name for the river **Ravi**.

Dasharajna

“Ten Kings.” The Sanskrit name for the Battle of the Ten Kings.

Bharata

Sudas’s tribe. The winners of Dasharajna — and the origin of India’s own name for itself.

Tritsu

The ruling sub-clan of the Bharatas, the group Sudas personally led.

Dasa / Dasyu

Terms used in the Rigveda for enemy peoples, often fort-dwellers like Shambara. Later the word *dasa* came to mean “servant” or “slave.”

Purohit

Chief priest of a king. Far more than a chaplain — closer to a chancellor with religious authority. Losing the job, as Vishvamitra did, was a political earthquake.

Janapada / Mahajanapada

“Foothold of a people” — a tribal territory. By 600 BCE sixteen big ones (Mahajanapadas) dominated northern India; Gandhara and Kamboja were the two in the north-west.

Gana-sangha

A republic or oligarchy — a state run by an assembly of many “kings” rather than one. The Punjab was full of these.

Ayudhajivin sangha

Panini’s term (c. 500 BCE) for a “corporation living by the profession of arms” — a republic of professional fighters. He applies it to the Trigartas, Yaudheyas, Kshudrakas, Malavas and others of the five rivers.

Gograhana

“The seizing of the cattle” — the name of the Trigarta raid on Matsya, and the standard form of warfare in the Punjab for most of history.

Akshauhini

The epic unit of army size — in theory 21,870 chariots, 21,870 elephants, 65,610 cavalry and 109,350 infantry. Almost certainly a poetic number rather than a real establishment.

Samshaptaka

“Sworn one.” A soldier under an oath to kill a specific enemy or die trying. Trigarta supplied an entire corps of them.

Ashvamedha

The horse sacrifice — a ritual a king performed to claim supremacy over his neighbours. Sudas performed one after Dasharajna.

Painted Grey Ware

A distinctive pottery style found across Punjab and the upper Ganges, roughly 1200–600 BCE. It is the main archaeological fingerprint of the late Vedic and Kuru world.

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- V. S. Agrawala, *India as Known to Panini* (on the *ayudhajivin* republics)

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

Where scholars differ, this part follows the mainstream reading and says so. The main open questions in this chapter are: whether the Battle of the Ten Kings can be reconstructed tactically at all (Jamison says no); whether it was the model for the Kurukshetra story (Witzel says yes, Hiltebeitel calls that “baffling fancy”); when — or whether — the Kurukshetra war happened; and whether Pukkusati was a real, datable king at all.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART TWO OF SIXTEEN

The Persians and Alexander

How the richest province on earth was conquered without a single battle being written down — and then, two centuries later, how the greatest soldier in the world was stopped by his own tired men on the bank of the Beas.

C. 545 BCE — 325 BCE

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Day Punjab Stopped Being the Middle of the World

In Part One, Punjab was the centre of Indian civilisation. In Part Two, foreign empires walk in through the door and the centre never comes back.

Something enormous changes between the end of Part One and the start of Part Two, and it is worth stating clearly before we begin.

Until about 900 BCE, the land of the five rivers was where Indian history *happened*. The Kuru kingdom, the first real state in South Asia, sat on the Punjab plain. The Vedas were arranged there. Then the Salvas broke the Kurus, the centre of gravity rolled east to the Ganges, and Punjab became something different: **a frontier**. The rich, flat, tempting edge of India, facing the passes.

And in the 6th century BCE, something came through those passes that Punjab had never seen before — not a tribe, not a raiding chief, but **a world empire**. The Achaemenid Persians ruled from Egypt and Greece to the Indus. Punjab was not the centre of their world either. It was their *twentieth province*. But it was, by a very long way, their richest one.

Three things change forever in this chapter

- **Outsiders start writing about Punjab.** For the first time we have descriptions of this land written by people who came from somewhere else — Persian kings carving province-lists into cliffs, Greek historians interviewing travellers, Macedonian officers keeping campaign diaries. It is a completely different kind of evidence from the hymns of Part One.
- **Punjab enters world history.** Soldiers from the Peshawar valley and the Indus march across the Hellespont and burn Athens. That is not a legend. It is in Herodotus.
- **The pattern of the next 2,300 years is set.** Invader comes through the passes → Punjab's separate little states fight him one at a time → they lose one at a time. You will watch this exact sequence again with the Arabs, the Ghaznavids, the Ghurids, the Mongols, Timur and Babur.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

Same system as Part One. **CERTAIN** means contemporary evidence — an inscription carved at the time, or an eyewitness account. **LIKELY** means it is reported by good sources writing later, and most historians accept it.

STORY means it may well be legend.

Part Two has much more **Certain** in it than Part One — but it comes with a new problem. Almost everything we know about Alexander in Punjab comes from *his own side*. Nobody on the Indian side wrote a word about him that survives. Keep that in mind on every page.

Cyrus the Great Comes East — And the War Vanishes

LIKELY

WON BY

Persia — probably, partly, and nobody wrote down how

WHEN Roughly 545–530 BCE .	WHERE Afghanistan and the country west of the Indus — the Kabul valley, Swat, and the edge of Gandhara.
WHO Cyrus the Great , founder of the Persian Empire, against the hill peoples of the north-west.	THE PROBLEM Not one ancient writer describes a single battle, siege or surrender. We have only fragments.

Who was Cyrus, and why does he matter here?

In about thirty years, one man built the largest empire the world had yet seen. Cyrus took Media, then Lydia in Turkey, then Babylon — and by around 539 BCE he had run out of west to conquer. So he turned east, through what is now Afghanistan.

What happened next is one of the strangest holes in ancient history. **The Persians ended up owning the Indus country. Nobody recorded them taking it.**

What we actually have

Four scraps, and that is all.

1. **Arrian, writing 600 years later, says the trans-Indus peoples “paid tribute to Cyrus.”** Notice the word: *tribute*, not conquest. And it covers the Kabul and Swat valleys — not the Punjab plain.
2. **Pliny says Cyrus destroyed a city called Kapisa** — probably Begram, north of Kabul. That is one clause in a geography book, six centuries after the event.
3. **A disaster in the Makran desert.** Local people told Alexander’s officers in 325 BCE that Cyrus had once tried to cross the Gedrosian desert and came out “*with only seven of his men.*”
4. **Ctesias says an Indian killed him.** In this version Cyrus fought a people called the Derbices, who “*suddenly brought up some elephants which had been kept in ambush*” and scattered his cavalry. Cyrus fell from his horse

and “*an Indian wounded him mortally with a javelin under the thigh.*” He died three days later. Ten thousand fell on each side.

HANDLE WITH CARE

Every one of those four is shaky. The “seven men” story was told to Alexander’s men by locals, and its whole purpose was to make Alexander’s own catastrophic desert march look heroic by comparison — and it pairs Cyrus with **Semiramis**, a completely legendary Assyrian queen. As for the Indian javelin: Herodotus says Cyrus died fighting the Massagetae, Xenophon says he died peacefully in bed, and Berossus says he died against the Dahae. **Ctesias is the least reliable of the four — and his is the only version in which India kills Cyrus.**

Did an Indian king actually beat him? The theory that will not die

The Indian historian **Buddha Prakash** proposed something very attractive: that **Pukkusati of Gandhara** — the king who beat Avanti in Part One — organised the north-western tribes into a confederacy that acted as “a bulwark” against Persia, and that *the army Cyrus lost in Gedrosia was actually destroyed by Punjabi and Gandharan forces.*

It is a wonderful story. It is also, honestly, unprovable:

- **No source connects the two.** Not one. It joins two separate bodies of evidence with a guess.
- **The dates do not hold still.** Scholars cannot even agree whether Pukkusati ruled before or after the Persian conquest.
- **It uses a fiction as evidence.** The Gedrosia story is late propaganda. You cannot build a real battle on top of it.
- **And the Behistun inscription is silent.** When Darius later lists Gandara as a Persian province, he mentions no earlier resistance at all.

The fair verdict: **an attractive and entirely unprovable idea.** What it really tells us about is the modern world, not the ancient one — how nations read their own resistance back into a documentary blank.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Conquest That Left No Fingerprints

Think about what is missing here. The Persian Empire took the single richest province it would ever own — a province that would pay **almost a third of the imperial budget** — and there is no account of the campaign. No battle name. No general. No siege. No treaty. Nothing.

Compare that with what we *do* have from the same empire: Darius's exact battle dates carved on a cliff, down to the day of the month, for skirmishes against rebels in Afghanistan. The Persians were perfectly capable of recording a war. They simply did not record this one — or if they did, it has not survived.

And it is not just the Persians. On the Indian side there is **total silence**. Not a single Indian text of any kind mentions the Persian conquest of the Indus. The largest empire on earth annexed north-western India and Indian literature does not notice.

That silence is the most important fact in this whole chapter. It is why almost everything you are about to read comes from Greeks, Persians and Macedonians — people describing Punjab from the outside, often without going there.

Darius Takes the Indus — The Spy Voyage

CERTAIN

The first documented case in history of somebody surveying a country before invading it.

WON BY

Darius I of Persia — with a map, not a battle

WHEN

The survey around **519–516 BCE**; the annexation somewhere in **518–515 BCE**.

WHERE

Gandhara first, then **Hindush** — the Indus country, reaching to about the Jhelum.

WHO

Darius I of Persia against whatever local kingdoms and republics stood in the Indus valley. None of their names survive.

HOW WE KNOW

Darius’s own inscriptions, carved into rock while he was alive — the hardest evidence in this entire book so far.

The evidence that dates the conquest: a missing word

Around 520 BCE, Darius had a huge inscription carved into a cliff at **Behistun** in western Iran, listing the twenty-three lands he ruled. Two of them are ours:

“...Bactria, Sogdia, **Gandara**, Scythia, **Sattagydia**, Arachosia and Maka; twenty-three lands in all.”

Behistun inscription, c. 520–518 BCE

Look at what is *not* there. There is no **Hindush** — the Indus province. And on every later inscription Darius made, Hindush is there.

That single missing word does something no story can do: **it dates the conquest**. Gandhara was Persian by 520 BCE. The Indus was not. Between that inscription and the next one, Darius took it.

What happened in between: the voyage of Scylax

Here is Herodotus, writing about seventy years later:

*“Darius, desiring to know of the river Indus... where it runs out into the sea, sent with ships, besides others whom he trusted to speak the truth, **Scylax also, a man of Caryanda**.”*

They set out from Caspatyrus, sailed down the river to the sea and then west across the ocean, and “in the thirtieth month” reached Egypt. “After these had made their voyage round the coast, Darius both subdued the Indians and made use of this sea.”

Herodotus 4.44

Read that last sentence again, because it is the whole point. **First the survey. Then the conquest.** Darius sent a Greek sea-captain to chart the Indus and the ocean route home, waited thirty months for the report, and only then annexed the province.

This is a professional imperial operation — reconnaissance, mapping, logistics, and only afterwards the army. It is the reason there is no dramatic battle story: by the time the Persian army arrived, **they already knew the ground better than the people living on it.**

ONE HONEST WRINKLE

Herodotus says they sailed “down the river towards the east” — and the Indus flows *south-west*. This is the standard objection to the whole story. The best answer, from the scholar A. D. H. Bivar, is that Caspatyrus was near **Peshawar**, and the fleet first sailed east down the **Kabul river** — which really does flow east — and only turned south after joining the Indus near Attock. Nobody has located Caspatyrus for certain.

What Punjab and the Indus were worth

Herodotus lists what each Persian province paid in tax every year. The numbers are astonishing:

PROVINCE	ANNUAL TRIBUTE	SHARE OF THE WHOLE EMPIRE'S REVENUE
India (the 20th province)	360 talents of gold dust	About 32% — roughly a third of everything
Babylonia and Assyria	1,000 talents silver	About 7%
Egypt, Libya, Cyrene, Barca	700 talents	About 5%
Lydia	500 talents	About 3.4%
Gandhara + Sattagydia + neighbours (the 7th province)	170 talents silver	About 1.2% — one of the poorest districts in the empire

In modern weight, 360 talents of gold dust is roughly **eight to nine tonnes of gold, every single year** — a cube of solid gold about 75 centimetres on each side. India paid more than four times what Babylonia paid. It paid seven times what all of Egypt paid.

And notice the contrast inside our own region: **the Indus plain was the treasure. The Gandharan hills were nearly worthless.** That gap — rich plains, poor hills — will drive a thousand years of raiding, and you will see it again in every part of this book.

WHY PERSIA WON

- **They looked before they leapt.** Thirty months of survey. No Indian power had ever been studied like that.
- **Overwhelming scale.** Persia could bring the resources of Iran, Mesopotamia, Anatolia and Egypt to bear on one river valley.
- **Professional administration.** They did not need to destroy anything. They installed a satrap, fixed a tax, and moved on.
- **They took Gandhara first.** Securing the hills gave them the passes, the base and the manpower before touching the plain.

WHY PUNJAB LOST

- **There was no “Punjab” to defend it.** The region was a patchwork of small kingdoms and armed republics with no common ruler, no common army and no common plan.
- **Nobody saw it coming.** The Persians spent two and a half years mapping the country and apparently nobody worked out why.
- **The prize was too rich to defend.** A wealthy farming plain with no natural barriers is the easiest kind of country to take and the hardest kind to hold.
- **Being conquered was survivable.** Persian rule meant paying tax, not being destroyed. For a local king, submission was often the rational choice — and that logic is why it happened so quietly.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE FUNNY ONE

The Giant Gold-Digging Ants of India

Herodotus had never been to India. He wrote down what Persians told him. And what they told him about where the gold came from is the best thing in his entire book.

Out in the sandy desert beyond the settled land, he says, there live **ants** — “**in size smaller than dogs but larger than foxes.**” These ants dig burrows, and as they dig they push up sand from below, exactly as ordinary ants do. But the sand of that desert is **full of gold.** So the ant-hills are heaps of gold dust.

Here is how the Indians steal it, according to Herodotus, and every detail matters:

Each man harnesses **three camels** — **two males on the outside and one female in the middle** — and the female must be a mother who has *left her young calves behind at home*. They ride out at the hottest hour of the morning, because that is when the ants go underground to escape the heat. They fill their bags from the ant-hills as fast as they can. Then they turn and run.

The ants come boiling out of the ground — they smell them, Herodotus says — and “*this animal is superior to every other creature in swiftness.*” The chase is desperate. The male camels start to tire.

But the she-camel in the middle does not tire, because she is running home to her calves. And that is why she is harnessed in the middle, and that is why the Indians get home with the gold — most of them.

It is nonsense, of course. But it is *brilliantly constructed* nonsense — the heat, the timing, the camel psychology all hang together perfectly. And the most likely explanation is charming: in the high country of Ladakh and Tibet, gold is genuinely found in the earth thrown up by **marmots**, large burrowing rodents. Somewhere along a very long chain of translation, “marmot” became “giant ant.”

The same passage of Herodotus contains one of the earliest descriptions of **cotton** in European literature: *“the trees which grow wild produce wool which surpasses in beauty and excellence that from sheep.”* He got the plant right and the ants wrong.

A SMALLER TRUE STORY

Herodotus also records that the Persian governor of Babylon kept so many **Indian hunting dogs** that *“four large villages in the plain, being free from other contributions, had been appointed to provide food for the hounds.”* Four entire villages, exempted from all tax, existing only to feed one governor’s dogs from Punjab. Ctesias adds that Indian dogs “are very large and even attack lions” — a claim you will meet again, in a form that is even harder to believe, at Sangala.

Punjab's Soldiers Burn Athens

CERTAIN

The most extraordinary fact in this chapter, and almost nobody in Punjab knows it.

WON BY

The Greeks — with Punjab's men on the losing side

WHEN 480–479 BCE. Athens burned in June 479; the decisive battle was that August.	WHERE Greece — Athens, and the plain of Plataea in Boeotia. About 4,000 km from home.
WHO Contingents of Indians and Gandarians in the army of Xerxes, then of Mardonius, against the allied Greek cities.	HOW WE KNOW Herodotus lists them by name, by equipment and by commander.

What they looked like

When Xerxes marched on Greece he took soldiers from every province of the empire, and Herodotus catalogues them. Two entries are ours:

*“The Indians wore garments made of tree-wool, and they had bows of reed and arrows of reed with iron points.” Their commander was **Pharnazathres son of Artabates**.*

*“The Parthians and Chorasmians and Sogdians and **Gandarians** and Dadicans served with the same equipment as the Bactrians” — reed bows and short spears, Median-style headgear. Their commander was **Artyphius son of Artabanus**.*

Herodotus 7.65–66

Three things to notice, because they say a lot about what Punjab was in 480 BCE:

- **“Tree-wool” is cotton.** In an army where everybody else wore wool, leather or linen, the Indians turned up in cotton. Nobody in the Mediterranean world had it.
- **Cane bows and cane arrows.** A distinctively Indian technology — light, fast, and made from a material the rest of the empire did not use.
- **Iron arrowheads.** These were not primitive troops. Punjab was making good iron.

And then there is the cavalry. Herodotus says the Indian horsemen “*both rode horses and drove chariots, in which were harnessed horses **or wild asses.***” The Indian wild ass — the *khur* — still survives in the Rann of Kutch. Nothing else in the largest army the ancient world had ever assembled looked remotely like that.

A CORRECTION WORTH MAKING

You will often read that Indian and Gandharan soldiers fought at **Thermopylae** — the famous stand of the 300. **Herodotus does not say that.** The units he names in those assaults are the Medes, the Cissians, and then the Immortals. Indians were in the army and therefore in the theatre, but placing them at the Hot Gates is a modern embellishment. This book will not repeat it.

The bit that is certain, and astonishing

After the Persian fleet was smashed at Salamis, Xerxes went home and left his general **Mardonius** in Greece with a hand-picked army. Herodotus tells us exactly who Mardonius kept — and this is the key passage of the whole section:

*“Mardonius chose out for himself first all those Persians who are called 'Immortals'... and after them of the other Persians those who wore cuirasses, and the body of a thousand horse: also **the Medes, Sacans, Bactrians and Indians, foot and horsemen both.**”*

Herodotus 8.113

Out of an army drawn from forty-odd nations, Mardonius kept **five**: Persians, Medes, Sacae, Bactrians and Indians. In other words, the professional judgement of the best general in the Persian Empire was that **the men from the Indus were among the five nationalities good enough to win a war with.**

That army reoccupied Athens in June 479, and when Mardonius pulled out a few weeks later he “*set fire to Athens and cast down and destroyed whatever was left standing of the walls, houses or temples.*”

Which means, plainly: **soldiers from the Peshawar valley and the Indus plain helped burn Athens to the ground.**

Plataea, August 479 BCE

Then came the largest battle of heavy infantry the ancient world had yet seen. Herodotus gives Mardonius’s line of battle nation by nation, each matched against a Greek city. Here is where our men stood:

PERSIAN CONTINGENT	FACING
Persians (the best troops)	The Spartans
Medes	Corinthians, Potidaeans, Orchomenians, Sicyonians
Bactrians	Epidaurians, Troezenians, Tirynthians, Mycenaeans and others
THE INDIANS	Hermionians, Eretrians, Styreans, Chalcidians

Sacae	Ambraciots, Anactorians, Leucadians, Aeginetans
Greek allies of Persia (Boeotians, Thessalians, Macedonians)	The Athenians, Plataeans, Megarians

Hold that image. On a hot morning in central Greece, men from the Indus stood in a battle line facing men from **Eretria** and **Chalcis** — two small towns on a Greek island. Neither side can have had the faintest idea what the other was.

WHY THE GREEKS WON

- **Armour.** The Greek hoplite wore a bronze helmet, a breastplate and greaves, and carried a heavy shield. The Persian line was mostly light infantry in cloth, with wicker shields.
- **The shield wall.** Greek hoplites fought locked together as one machine. The Persian army fought as forty separate national contingents, each with its own weapons and its own habits.
- **Close quarters.** Persia's strength was archery. Once the Greeks closed the distance, bows were useless and the fight became a shoving match between armoured men and unarmoured ones.
- **Mardonius attacked on bad ground** — and when he was killed, the whole coalition had nothing holding it together.

WHY THE PERSIAN ARMY LOST

- **An empire is not an army.** Forty nations, forty languages, forty ways of fighting, no common drill.
- **Only the Persians themselves fought to the end.** Herodotus says the Persians died hard around Mardonius; the other contingents mostly broke and ran for the stockade without properly engaging. The Indians almost certainly belong to that second group.
- **Wrong weapons for the job.** Cane bows and short spears are excellent for skirmishing in hill country. They are close to useless against a wall of bronze.
- **No reason to die there.** A Greek at Plataea was defending his home. A man from the Indus was 4,000 km from his, fighting for a king he had never met.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Four Thousand Kilometres From the Five Rivers

We know no Indian casualty figure from Plataea. Herodotus gives none. We do not know the name of a single soldier from the Indus who marched into Greece, or of one who came back.

But think about what that march actually was. A man from Gandhara or the Indus plain, conscripted or recruited around 481 BCE, walked out of the Punjab, across Iran, across Anatolia, over a bridge of boats spanning the sea into Europe, down through Thrace and Macedonia, into Greece. He was there when Athens burned. He stood in a battle line the following summer against people from an island he could never have heard of. Then, if he lived, he had to walk home — through a hostile country, in winter, with an army that had just been destroyed.

It is almost certainly the furthest from home any Punjabi soldier fought until the World Wars — and it happened 2,500 years ago. You will find no monument to it anywhere in Punjab.

Gaugamela: Punjab's Last Fight for Persia

CERTAIN

WON BY

Alexander of Macedon — and the Persian Empire ends

WHEN 1 October 331 BCE.	WHERE Gaugamela, in northern Iraq. Not in Punjab — but Punjab was in it.
WHO Two Indian contingents in Darius III's army, plus fifteen war elephants, against Alexander.	WHY IT MATTERS This is the last time Punjab fights <i>for</i> Persia. Five years later Alexander is on the Jhelum.

Arrian had access to a captured Persian battle plan, which makes this the best-documented battle of the ancient world. Two entries in it are ours:

- “**The Indians who were conterminous with the Bactrians**” — almost certainly Gandharans — under **Bessus**, satrap of Bactria, on the Persian left.
- “**The Arachotians and the men who were called mountaineer Indians**” — probably from Sattagydia or the Indus — under **Barsaentes**.
- And: “**about fifteen [elephants], belonging to the Indians who live this side of the Indus.**”

The first war elephants Europe ever faced — and they did nothing

This is a small, strange, enormously consequential moment. Fifteen elephants had been walked from the Indus to Iraq. They were the first elephants any European army had ever confronted.

And they never entered the battle. They are not mentioned in any account of the fighting. Afterwards, Alexander's men simply **captured them in the Persian camp**. The most likely explanation is the dullest one: after a march of thousands of kilometres, they were too exhausted to be used.

Yet those fifteen tired animals changed military history. Alexander's officers saw them, took them, and never forgot them. Within a generation every Hellenistic king in the Mediterranean was desperate for elephants — a craze that ends with Seleucus trading four whole provinces for five hundred of them, and with Hannibal in the Alps.

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **He attacked at an angle.** Alexander marched his line obliquely to the right, dragging the Persian left after him and stretching it until a gap opened.
- **He aimed at one man.** The moment the gap appeared he drove a wedge of cavalry straight at Darius personally. Kill or scare the king and the empire's army stops existing.
- **Discipline under pressure.** When the Persians broke through his own line, his phalanx held its shape instead of turning to save the baggage.

WHY PERSIA LOST

- **The one great chance was thrown away.** At the crisis of the battle, the Persian and Indian cavalry of the centre *did* break clean through Alexander's line. Instead of turning to take his phalanx in the rear — which might have won the battle and saved the empire — **they rode on to the camp to loot the baggage.**
- **Numbers without cohesion.** Again: a huge multinational army with no common training.
- **Darius left the field.** Once the king ran, everything downstream of him collapsed.
- **The elephants were a wasted asset** — brought thousands of miles and never deployed.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Two Satraps Who Commanded Punjab's Men

Both of the officers who led Indian troops at Gaugamela came to remarkable ends, and between them they explain how the Persian Empire actually died.

Bessus, who commanded the Gandharans, murdered his own king. As Darius III fled east after the battle, Bessus and a group of nobles seized him, stabbed him, left him dying by the roadside, and Bessus declared himself the new King of Kings. Alexander hunted him down and had him executed.

Barsaentes, who commanded the "mountaineer Indians," was in on the murder too. And when it went wrong, he did the obvious thing: **he fled to India** — to the very frontier province whose soldiers he had commanded. It did not save him. A few years later the Indians handed him over to Alexander, who had him killed.

The satrap of the Indian frontier ran home to the Indian frontier, and the Indian frontier sold him. That is what the Persian Empire had become by 330 BCE — and it tells you exactly how much loyalty Alexander would find when he arrived in person.

The Mountain War: Massaga and the Seven Thousand

CERTAIN

Alexander enters the north-west. Within a year he commits the act that even his admirers call a stain.

WON BY

Alexander — and it cost him his reputation

WHEN

May 327 – early 326 BCE.

WHERE

The Kunar, Panjkora and Swat valleys — eastern Afghanistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

WHO

Alexander against three tribal confederations: the **Aspasioi**, the **Guracans** and the **Assakenoi**.

THEIR NAMES

Greek versions of the Sanskrit *Ashvaka* — “horsemen.” These were the horse-breeding hill peoples of the north-west.

Why he came this way at all

Alexander split his army at Nicaea, near modern Jalalabad. **Hephaestion and Perdikkas** took the big column straight down the Kabul valley and through the Khyber Pass to bridge the Indus. Alexander took a strike force north into the hills.

The reason is straightforward and it is the reason every invader of India has had to do the same thing: **you cannot leave armed hill tribes sitting above your supply line**. Arrian calls the Assakenoi “*by far the stoutest warriors in that neighbourhood*.” If Alexander marched into Punjab with them behind him, his line back to Afghanistan would be cut within a month.

The campaign, quickly

1. **The first city, in the Kunar valley.** Alexander pushed ahead with cavalry plus **800 infantrymen put on horses** — still carrying their infantry shields — to catch the tribesmen before they reached their forts. At the walls, **a dart went through his breastplate into his shoulder**. Ptolemy and Leonnatus were wounded in the same fight. When the city fell, the Macedonians killed everyone in it, in anger at their king’s wound. It is the first of the campaign’s revenge-massacres. It will not be the last.

2. **Arigaion** was found already on fire — **the inhabitants had burned it themselves and gone**. That single detail tells you what these people had decided about surrender.
3. **The great valley battle**. The tribes massed on high ground and came down, “*emboldened by their superiority in number and despising the Macedonians, because they were seen to be few.*” Alexander split into three columns and beat them. Ptolemy, who wrote the account, deliberately left the enemy an escape route rather than surrounding them — a cool professional judgement that fewer men die when the loser has somewhere to run.
4. **The haul**. Ptolemy’s own figures: “*all the men were captured, to a number exceeding 40,000*” and **230,000 oxen**. Alexander picked the finest cattle to ship home to Macedonia to plough with.

WHAT THOSE NUMBERS MEAN

These are not battlefield tallies. 230,000 head of cattle is plausible as *the entire herd of a whole river system* seized over a season, and the 40,000 “captured” almost certainly means the non-combatant population of a district rounded up, not prisoners of war. No source says what happened to them afterwards.

The siege of Massaga

Massaga was the Assakenoi capital, probably near modern **Chakdara in Lower Swat**. Curtius describes a wall with a stone base and mud-brick above, bonded with embedded stones and timber; a torrent with steep banks on one side, and towering cliffs on two others. Inside were the garrison and **7,000 mercenaries hired from beyond the Indus**.

1. **The trap**. As Alexander pitched camp the Indians rushed out. He ordered his men *to turn and retreat* to a hill about seven stades away — pulling the defenders far from their walls. Believing they had won, the Indians “*rushed upon them with a run and with no kind of order.*” Then Alexander wheeled round at a signal and charged. About 200 Indians died; the rest were driven back inside.
2. **The wound**. Bringing the siege line up, Alexander was hit by an arrow in the ankle — Curtius says the calf. And here is the line that has been quoted ever since: he remarked that *he was called the son of Jupiter, but he felt the defects of a sick body*.
3. **The bridge that snapped**. On the third day Alexander swung a bridge from a siege tower across to the breach and sent up the hypaspists — the same men who had taken Tyre this way. Too many crowded onto it. “*The bridge received too great a weight, and was snapped asunder,*” dropping the assault party under a rain of stones and arrows.
4. **The chief killed**. The Assakenian ruler was killed by a shot from a siege engine. His mercenaries then asked for terms.

What happened to the seven thousand

This is the part every honest account of Alexander has to deal with.

Arrian’s version — from Alexander’s own officers — is the kindest: the mercenaries agreed to join Alexander’s army, marched out with their arms and camped on a hill. Then they decided to slip away in the night, “*because they were unwilling to take up arms against the other Indians.*” Alexander surrounded the hill after dark and “*cut*

them to pieces.”

Diodorus’s version is the damning one. The mercenaries left under truce and camped ten miles away, disturbing nobody. Alexander, who “nursed an implacable hostility” toward them, followed and “falling upon them suddenly wrought a great slaughter.” When they shouted that he was breaking the treaty, **Alexander answered that he had granted them leave to depart from the city — not friendship with Macedon.**

They formed a ring with their women and children inside it. The women fought: some picked up the weapons of the dead, and others, unarmed, “rushed in and grasped the opposing shields, and hindered their use.” They were killed to the last.

“And this act adheres like a stain to his military career; in all other instances he waged war according to usage and like a king.”

Plutarch, on the killing of the mercenaries

HOW TO WEIGH THE TWO VERSIONS

Notice the pattern, because it is a useful tool for the whole of this chapter. Arrian works from **Ptolemy and Aristobulus**, both of them Alexander’s own officers with reasons to protect his memory — and he gives a legal defence: *they broke the terms first*. Diodorus and Curtius work from the hostile tradition — and they say it was planned.

When the friendly source and the hostile source agree that the killing happened and disagree only about the excuse, the killing is certain and the excuse is suspect. Plutarch, a Greek writing under Rome with every reason to admire Alexander, singles this out as *the* blot on his career. That is about as close to a verdict as ancient history gets.

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **Speed against dispersal.** The Assakenoi made a deliberate choice not to fight one big battle but to defend each city separately. Alexander simply took them one at a time, faster than they could react.
- **Siege engineering nobody in India had.** Torsion catapults, siege towers, movable bridges, mining. Indian fortifications were built to resist Indian armies, and Indian armies did not have this equipment.
- **The feigned retreat.** A trick as old as war and it still worked: pull the defenders away from their own walls, then turn.
- **He led from the front** — and paid for it in wounds — which meant his army would attempt things other armies would not.

WHY THE ASSAKENOI LOST

- **They divided their forces on purpose.** Arrian says they had 20,000 cavalry and over 30,000 infantry and “dispersed one by one to their various cities.” Concentrated, that army could have fought a real battle. Split between a dozen towns, each garrison was too small to win and too big to save.
- **Walls without relief.** A siege is survivable only if somebody is coming. Nobody was coming.
- **They hired mercenaries whose loyalty ran out.** The 7,000 negotiated separately for themselves the moment their employer was killed.
- **No answer to siege machinery.** Nothing in their military tradition had prepared them for engines that threw stones over walls.

The Queen Who Kept Her Throne

When the Assakenian king was killed, his widow took command. The Greeks called her **Cleophis**.

What happened next depends entirely on who you read, and the versions are so different that they are a lesson in themselves.

Curtius says she came to Alexander with the noble women of the city carrying golden vessels of wine, placed her young son at his knees, and was pardoned and allowed to keep the title of queen — then adds, poisonously, that *“some believed it was granted more to her beauty than to pity.”*

Justin goes much further: she *“recovered her throne from him by admitting him to her bed; saving by her charms what she had been unable to secure by her valour.”* He says the Indians afterwards called her the *royal harlot*, and that the son she bore was named Alexander and later sat on an Indian throne.

Diodorus says simply that she was captured and reinstated in her kingdom.

And Arrian — the best source, working from Alexander’s own officers — does not mention her at all. He records only that Alexander captured “the mother and daughter” of the dead king.

So: was she a queen who saved her people by negotiation, a woman coerced into a king’s bed, or a footnote inflated by Roman gossip-writers? **We cannot know.** But it is worth noticing which version is the juiciest, which is the earliest, and how completely a real woman can disappear underneath other people’s storytelling.

The Rock of Aornos

CERTAIN

WON BY

Alexander — by building a bridge out of a mountain

WHEN

Spring 326 BCE (the operation ran on from the winter).

WHERE

A flat-topped massif above the Indus gorges. **Aurel Stein identified it as Pir-Sar** in 1926; others argue for Mount Ilam in Swat. Unresolved.

WHO

Alexander against refugees and fighters from all the towns he had already taken.

WHY

Partly military, mostly personal: legend said **Herakles had tried to take the rock and failed.**

What happened

Aornos was not just a fort. It was a mountain with a flat top, farmland and springs on the summit, and cliffs falling into the Indus. It could feed itself indefinitely. Everyone Alexander had driven out of Swat had gone there.

1. **Local guides came in and offered to lead him to the weak point.** Diodorus says it was an old man with his two sons. Curtius adds the price: **80 talents, with one son held hostage.**
2. **Ptolemy went up first** by a rough hidden road with the light troops, seized a position the defenders had not covered, dug in behind a stockade and ditch, and **lit a beacon fire** so Alexander could see it from below.
3. Alexander advanced next day and could not get through. The Indians, seeing that, turned on Ptolemy's stockade instead and fought hard at it until nightfall.
4. **Alexander then sent an Indian deserter through the enemy lines at night carrying a letter** ordering Ptolemy to attack downhill at the exact moment Alexander attacked from below — so the defenders would be hit from two sides at once.
5. **And then the engineering.** There was a ravine between Alexander's hill and the rock. He ordered **every single soldier to cut one hundred stakes**, and began filling the ravine — building a mound across it, wide and high enough to bring archers and catapults within range of the summit. He supervised in person, praising the men who worked hard and punishing the slow. They made a stade — about 180 metres — on the first day.
6. When the mound reached them and the engines came into range, the defenders offered to surrender — but meant to slip away by night. They did. **Alexander let them go and then attacked them.** He took 700 guards,

was the first man up the rock, and the Macedonians hauled each other up behind him. Many of the defenders were cut down; others threw themselves off the precipices.

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **He refused to accept the terrain as a fact.** The rock could not be assaulted, so he changed the shape of the ground until it could.
- **He bought the map.** Eighty talents for a guide is a bargain compared with a six-month siege.
- **Coordination at distance.** A written order carried by a defector through hostile ground, timing two attacks to the same moment, is genuinely sophisticated command work.
- **He did the work himself.** Curtius says Alexander threw the first tree-trunk into the ravine with his own hands, so that the soldiers would be ashamed not to.

WHY THE DEFENDERS LOST

- **They trusted a place instead of a plan.** “Impregnable” is a description of the past, not a strategy.
- **They left a back door uncovered** — the rough path Ptolemy climbed.
- **They fought the wrong enemy.** Turning on Ptolemy’s stockade used up their strength on a diversion instead of the mound, which was the thing actually killing them.
- **Faking a surrender was fatal.** It cost them their negotiating position and gave Alexander a free hand.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — BRAVERY

Charus and the Other Alexander

Curtius preserves a small episode from the cliffs of Aornos that has nothing to do with strategy and everything to do with why men fight.

Thirty picked young men were sent up the rock face. Boulders came down on them, and many fell into the river far below. Two of the dead are named. One was a soldier who happened to share the king’s name — **Alexander**. The other was his friend, **Charus**.

When the younger Alexander was killed in hand-to-hand fighting, Charus “*charged the enemy, heedless of everything except revenge.*” He killed several men. Then he was killed too, and fell across his friend’s body.

They are two of the very few ordinary soldiers in this entire campaign whose names survive. They survive because they died together, on a rock above the Indus, in a battle fought to beat the record of a god.

The Battle of the Hydaspes: Alexander Against Porus

CERTAIN

The hardest battle Alexander ever fought, on the bank of the Jhelum, in the rain, against two hundred elephants.

WON BY

Alexander — who then handed the kingdom back to the man he beat

WHEN

May 326 BCE — Arrian dates it by the Athenian calendar to the month Munychion. Many historians doubt that date, because the battle is fought in monsoon conditions; July is the common alternative.

WHERE

The **Hydaspes = the Jhelum**, in Pakistani Punjab. The crossing was about **17 miles upstream** of the main camp. The exact site is unknown — the river has moved.

WHO WON

Alexander, with perhaps 11,000–16,000 men in the crossing force.

WHO LOST

Porus (Sanskrit probably *Paurava*) — 30,000 infantry, 4,000 cavalry, 300 chariots, **200 elephants**.

Why it happened

Alexander crossed the Indus and came to **Taxila**, where King **Ambhi** (the Greeks called him Omphis or Taxiles) surrendered without a fight — and it is important to understand why, because it explains the whole shape of this war.

Ambhi had sent envoys to Alexander **while Alexander was still in Central Asia**. He *invited* him. He was boxed in between two enemies: **Abisares** in the hills to the north, and **Porus** across the Jhelum to the east — and one Indian tradition says Porus had killed Taxila’s previous ruler. Alexander was Ambhi’s solution to a local problem.

So the Battle of the Hydaspes is not simply “Greece against India.” **It is one Punjabi king using a foreign army against his neighbour.** That is a pattern you will see over and over in this book, and it almost never ends well for the man who invites the foreigner in.

THE GIFTS, AND THE JOKE THAT FOLLOWED

Ambhi handed over 200 talents of silver, 3,000 oxen, over 10,000 sheep, 30 elephants and 700 Indian horsemen (Curtius gives different figures). Plutarch preserves the exchange:

Taxiles: *"Why must we war and fight with one another, Alexander, if you have not come to rob us of water or of necessary sustenance?"*

Alexander: *"Can you think that after such words of kindness our interview is to end without a battle? No — you shall not get the better of me."*

They then competed in generosity until Alexander gave Ambhi **a thousand talents**. That night at dinner, an officer named **Meleager**, drunk, congratulated Alexander loudly on having *"at last found in India a man worth a thousand talents."* Alexander swallowed the insult and said only that envious men are their own tormentors — he had learned something since killing his friend Cleitus in a drunken argument two years before.

The problem: a river, a monsoon, and two hundred elephants

Porus lined the far bank of the Jhelum and waited. The obstacles were stacked:

- **The river was in flood.** Arrian: *"all the Indian rivers were flowing with swollen and turbid waters and with rapid currents."* Himalayan snowmelt plus the first monsoon rains. In winter it would have been fordable — Porus fully expected Alexander to wait for winter.
- **Every crossing point was guarded.** Porus had detachments on every practicable ford and his main army opposite the camp.
- **And the real obstacle was not water. It was elephants.** Curtius says the banks were crowded with herds deliberately maddened to produce a horrific shrieking. **Horses will not go near elephants.** Any cavalry force landing on that bank would be useless before it formed up.

The deception plan — the finest of Alexander's career

1. **He brought a navy overland.** The galleys he had used on the Indus were **cut into sections, carted across country, and reassembled on the Jhelum.**
2. **He stockpiled grain in the main camp** — visibly, ostentatiously — so that Porus would conclude he had settled in to wait for the winter.
3. **He filled skins with hay** to make float-rafts.
4. **He wore Porus out with noise.** Night after night, detachments marched up and down the bank shouting war-cries; fires were lit along the whole length of it; Ptolemy rode about with cavalry threatening crossings. **At first Porus shadowed every movement with his elephants. Then he stopped responding.** That was the entire purpose — a deliberate programme to dull the enemy's reaction time, run for weeks, and it worked exactly as designed.
5. **He left a double in his own tent.** This is the best detail in the battle, and it comes from Curtius alone: Alexander left his royal tent and regalia at the main camp and dressed **Attalus**, a young man of similar build, in the king's robes, *"to give the appearance that the king himself was still presiding on that bank."*
6. **Craterus stayed at the camp with conditional orders** — and their precision is worth reading: do not cross while Porus faces me with his whole force. If Porus takes only part of his army and leaves the elephants —

hold. **If Porus takes all the elephants against me and leaves infantry in camp — cross at once.**

Alexander's stated reason: *"it is the elephants alone which render it impossible for the horses to land on the other bank."*

The crossing

Seventeen miles upstream Alexander found a wooded headland where the river bends, with a wooded island opposite — both thick enough to hide an army. He marched the crossing force away from the bank by night so it would not be seen or heard.

Then the weather did him a favour that no plan could have arranged: **a furious thunderstorm broke and lasted most of the night**, with lightning and whirlwinds. It drowned out the noise of thousands of men embarking.

Alexander went over in a thirty-oared galley with Perdiccas, Lysimachus and Seleucus. Once past the island the boats were spotted and Porus's sentries *"rode off as fast as each man's horse could gallop."*

And then the plan nearly died. Alexander landed, formed up his cavalry, and discovered he had come ashore *"on ground which was not a part of the mainland, but an island, a large one indeed."* He had crossed one channel of a braided river, not the river. There was another channel to go — and the night's rain had swollen it past the ford. They went through anyway: **"where the water was deepest, it reached higher than the breasts of the infantry; and of the horses only the heads rose above the river."**

The son who arrived too late

Porus sent his son to the landing. Arrian, weighing his sources, follows Ptolemy: **2,000 cavalry and 120 chariots**, arriving after Alexander was already fully across. The horse-archers shattered them. **Porus's son was killed.** Every chariot was captured — **bogged down and useless in mud made by the same rain that had hidden the crossing.**

A WINDOW INTO HOW HISTORY GETS MADE

Arrian gives three versions of this small fight, and then argues. Aristobulus says the prince came with only 60 chariots and simply *drove past*, making the crossing safe. Another tradition says there was a real battle in which Alexander was wounded and **Bucephalus was killed by Porus's son**. Ptolemy says 2,000 horse and 120 chariots, arriving late.

Arrian picks Ptolemy — and his reason is proper military criticism: 60 chariots are *"too many to be sent out as a reconnoitring party, and not adapted for speedy retreat,"* and far too few to stop a crossing. The number makes no sense for any purpose. **That is how a good historian works, and Arrian was doing it 1,900 years ago.**

The line Porus drew up

Porus now had to choose: stay and face Craterus, or turn and fight Alexander. He chose to fight. He picked ground *"no clay, but... all level and hard"* — chosen deliberately so his cavalry and chariots could move.

Then he arranged his army in a formation designed for one purpose: **to make a frontal attack impossible.**

- **200 elephants in a single line across the front**, spaced about a hundred feet apart.

- **Infantry behind**, pushed forward into the gaps between the elephants.
- More infantry on both wings beyond the elephant line.
- **Cavalry on both flanks**, with the **chariots in front of them**.

The line “looked very much like a city, for the elephants resembled towers, and the soldiers between them curtain walls.”

Diodorus 17.87

Porus himself rode the largest elephant, in gold-and-silver-inlaid armour, towering over everything. He was, the sources agree, an exceptionally large man.

How Alexander took it apart, step by step

1. **He stopped and let his men breathe.** Seeing the Indian line, he halted the cavalry until the infantry caught up and rested, *“not wishing to hand over his men exhausted with fatigue and out of breath, to the barbarians who were fresh and untired.”*
2. **He refused the centre completely.** Looking at the wall of elephants, *“he resolved not to advance against the centre.”* Porus had built a fortress out of animals; Alexander declined to attack a fortress.
3. **He put nearly all his cavalry on one wing** — massed against the Indian left.
4. **He sent Coenus the long way round.** Coenus, with two cavalry regiments, was sent round toward the Indian *right*, with orders to follow the Indian horse and take them in the rear the moment they concentrated.
5. **He held the phalanx back.** Explicit orders: do not engage until you see the enemy thrown into disorder by the cavalry.
6. **He opened with a thousand horse-archers.** Missile cavalry hit the Indian left first, to shake and disorder it *before* the heavy charge. This is the tactical key of the battle.
7. **The trap closes.** The Indians pulled cavalry from everywhere to meet Alexander’s mass — and Coenus appeared behind them. They had to split, facing two ways at once, and the manoeuvre needed to do that threw their formation into confusion. **Alexander charged at precisely that moment.**
8. **Broken, the Indian cavalry fled to their own elephants for shelter** — using them, Arrian says, “as a friendly wall.”

What the phalanx did to the elephants

The mahouts now drove the beasts forward, and the Macedonian infantry came on to meet them. This is the most technically interesting fighting in the ancient world, because nobody in Europe had ever solved this problem before.

- **Kill the driver first.** Light infantry threw javelins at the mahouts and at the elephants’ eyes. An elephant without a driver is not a weapon; it is a panicking animal in the middle of your own army.
- **Use the pike.** The Macedonian *sarissa* was 15 to 18 feet long. Curtius has Alexander tell his officers beforehand that *“our spears, excessively long and strong”* were ideal against beasts and riders — and that killing the crews was the priority.

- **Go for the legs.** Curtius names the weapon: the *copis*, a heavy curved chopping sword “like a sickle,” used to cut at the elephants’ feet.
- **Open lanes.** The phalanx opened gaps in its files to let charging elephants run *through* rather than receiving them head-on.

And then the thing Porus had never planned for happened. Penned into ground too tight for them, their drivers shot down, wounded in the flanks, the elephants turned:

“Rushing forward at friends and foes alike, they pushed about, trampled down and killed them.”

Arrian 5.17

Diodorus gives it in close-up: men “trodden under foot, armour and all,” others “lifted on high, dashed back down to the ground again, dying a fearful death” — and then “the wounded elephants turned upon their own ranks and trampled friendly troops.” Arrian’s final image is quieter and somehow worse: the exhausted elephants simply **backing away, trumpeting, “like ships backing water.”**

Alexander then ringed the whole Indian mass with his cavalry while the infantry **locked shields into one dense body** and pushed forward. Hammer and anvil. And at that moment **Craterus crossed from the main camp with fresh troops** and took over the pursuit from Alexander’s exhausted men.

The bill

LOSSES	ARRIAN (FROM PTOLEMY)	DIODORUS
Indian dead	~20,000 infantry and 3,000 cavalry	over 12,000 dead, over 9,000 captured
Elephants	all survivors captured	80 captured
Named Indian dead	Two sons of Porus; the local governor Spitaces; all the elephant, chariot and cavalry commanders	
Macedonian dead	~310	~980

WHICH NUMBERS TO BELIEVE

On the Indian side the two traditions probably agree: Diodorus’s 12,000 dead plus 9,000 captured is about 21,000, and Arrian’s total is about 23,000 — Arrian very likely counted prisoners as casualties.

On the Macedonian side they do not agree at all, and here Arrian is almost certainly wrong. **310 dead in a battle Arrian himself calls the hardest of the campaign is not credible.** The military historian J. F. C. Fuller judged Diodorus’s figure of roughly a thousand far more realistic — higher than Alexander’s losses at Gaugamela, which is exactly what you would expect from a battle against elephants.

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **He attacked the one part of the line that was not defended by elephants.** The whole battle is that single decision.
- **Weeks of fake alarms bought him a free crossing.** Deception was not a trick here; it was a sustained campaign of its own.
- **Combined arms.** Horse-archers to disorder, heavy cavalry to break, pikes to hold, light infantry to kill mahouts, fresh troops to pursue. Every arm did the job it was best at, in sequence.
- **He turned the enemy's best weapon into the enemy's worst problem.** Two hundred elephants killed a great many Indians that day.
- **Craterus's conditional orders** meant the army on the wrong bank could still act correctly without being told what was happening.

WHY PORUS LOST

- **A static defence against a mobile enemy.** Porus had to guard everywhere; Alexander only had to cross somewhere.
- **He let himself get tired out by noise.** Reacting to every alarm for weeks and then ceasing to react is precisely the trap that was set for him.
- **His formation had no reserve and no flexibility.** A single line, however terrifying, can only fight forwards. When his cavalry was destroyed on the wings, the "city" of elephants had no way to turn.
- **Elephants are a weapon that can be turned around.** No other weapon in history so reliably kills the side that brought it.
- **Chariots in the monsoon.** Three hundred chariots, on ground made soft by rain, contributed nothing and were captured.
- **His allies did not come.** Abisares was four hundred furlongs away and never arrived. That absence may have mattered as much as any tactic on the field.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE GREATEST SURRENDER IN INDIAN HISTORY

"Treat Me As a King Treats a King"

Porus did not run. Arrian is explicit that he behaved "*not only as a general but also as a valiant soldier*" — and points out, pointedly, that **he did not flee as Darius had done**. He kept fighting from his elephant while his cavalry was destroyed around him and riderless elephants rampaged through his own line. Only after taking a wound in the right shoulder did he begin to withdraw.

Alexander wanted him alive and sent **Ambhi of Taxila** to talk to him. It was a serious misjudgement. Arrian says that Porus, seeing his old enemy riding up to accept his surrender, **wheeled his elephant round and raised a javelin to strike him** — and would have killed him if Taxiles had not spurred out of range. (Curtius has a bloodier version in which the cast goes home, killing Taxiles' brother.)

Alexander then sent **Meroes**, an old friend of Porus. Overcome with thirst, Porus dismounted, drank, and agreed to be taken to Alexander.

Curtius preserves the scene at the end. Porus was barely conscious, his limbs failing. His mahout saw it and **ordered the elephant to kneel** so the king could get down — and every other surviving elephant, trained to follow the lead animal, **knelt too**. When Macedonian soldiers began stripping the wounded king's armour, **his own elephant turned on the looters and drove them off**, until it was brought down by missiles.

Then the exchange that everybody remembers. Plutarch's version is the sharpest:

Alexander: How do you wish to be treated?

Porus: *"Like a king."*

Alexander: And have you nothing else to say?

Porus: *"All things are included in my 'like a king.'"*

Curtius gives a longer version in which Alexander asks what madness made him fight, knowing Alexander's reputation, and Porus answers that he had thought no man stronger than himself; the battle taught him otherwise; and he is not unhappy to be second to Alexander. Asked what should be done with him, he says: ***"What this day advises you."***

Why Alexander gave the kingdom back

He did not just spare Porus. He **restored him and enlarged his kingdom**, treating his wounds, Curtius says, *"no differently than if he had fought on his side."* Arrian says Porus ended up ruling seven nations and over two thousand cities; Plutarch says fifteen nations and five thousand cities.

Admiration was real. But so was arithmetic:

- **Alexander had no Macedonians to spare.** Garrisoning Punjab was impossible; he needed a local ruler.
- **A king who owes you his throne, his life and an enlarged kingdom is the cheapest instrument of control there is.**
- **And he needed a counterweight to Ambhi.** He formally reconciled the two enemies and left them balanced against each other — each one's ambition checked by the other's. It is a piece of political engineering as careful as the battle plan.

BUCEPHALAS

Alexander's horse died at the Jhelum. Arrian, quoting Onesicritus, says he died *"not from having been wounded by any one, but from the effects of toil and old age; for he was about thirty years old."* Plutarch says most writers claim wounds. The name means "ox-head," from a mark on the horse.

Alexander founded two cities: **Nicaea** ("Victory") near the battlefield, and **Bucephala** at the crossing — conventionally identified with modern **Jhelum** city, with Jalalpur Sharif traditionally shown as the horse's grave. Plutarch adds that he also founded a city named after his dog, Peritas.

Sangala and the Fort Made of Wagons

CERTAIN

WON BY Alexander — and the city was erased

WHEN Later in 326 BCE, after crossing the Ravi.	WHERE Disputed. Candidates: Sangla Hill (Cunningham), Sialkot (the majority view), or east of the Ravi near Gurdaspur.
WHO The Kathaioi (Kathas) and allied free tribes, against Alexander with Porus’s Indian troops alongside him.	THEIR RECORD They had already beaten Porus and Abisares together — the two greatest kings of the Punjab — and sent them home with nothing.

Who the Kathaioi were

These were not a kingdom. They were one of the free tribal republics of central Punjab — the *ayudhajivin sanghas* we met in Part One, “corporations that live by weapons.” Arrian says they were “*very daring and skilful in war*”, and he gives the proof: **Porus and Abisares had campaigned against them with a great army and “were forced to retreat without effecting anything.”**

Crucially, Arrian adds that **the Oxydracae and the Mallians were “in the same temper” as the Kathaioi**. The free tribes of the Punjab were coordinating. That coordination becomes the story of War Ten.

The wagon fort

The Kathaioi did something Alexander had not seen in India. They drew up on a hill in front of their city and **ringed it with three rows of wagons** — a laager, a fort made of carts.

1. **Cavalry failed immediately.** The defenders would not come out to meet horsemen; they climbed onto the wagons and shot down from them. Alexander recognised the problem instantly — this was infantry work. **He dismounted and led the phalanx up himself.**
2. **The first ring fell easily.**
3. **The second ring was much harder.** The defenders packed into a smaller circle, which made it *stronger*, not weaker. And they used a tactic Arrian singles out: **crawling underneath the wagons and stabbing out through the gaps between them.**

4. **The third ring was never contested.** The defenders ran for the city and shut the gates.

The siege

Alexander could not surround the whole wall — the circuit was too long for his infantry. On one side lay a lake, which he found was **shallow**, so he posted cavalry all round it.

Twice the defenders tried to break out at night. The first time they came down off the walls in the second watch and ran straight into the cavalry pickets; finding the lake guarded too, they went back inside. Alexander then built a **double stockade**.

The second attempt was betrayed by deserters. Alexander put **Ptolemy** at the lake gap with hypaspists, Agrianians and archers, told him to block the escape and **signal with a bugle**, and ordered every other commander to advance the moment they heard it — promising, *“Nor will I myself withdraw from the action.”* Ptolemy dragged the abandoned wagons across the escape route and had his men throw up earth mounds. At the fourth watch the Indians opened the lake gate and ran into it. About 500 died.

Then **Porus arrived with his remaining elephants and 5,000 men** — fighting for Alexander now.

The siege engines were brought up but never needed. **The wall was mud-brick, so the Macedonians simply undermined it and went up on ladders all round.** Then Alexander **razed the city to the ground** and gave its territory to the Indians who had submitted voluntarily.

THE NUMBERS DO NOT WORK

Arrian gives **17,000 Indians killed and over 70,000 captured**, against fewer than 100 Macedonian dead and 1,200 wounded.

Curtius describes the fighting differently — linked chariots rather than a ring of wagons — and says the Indians lost **8,000** men before retreating into the town. (He names neither the city nor the tribe, and his figure covers only that first battle outside the walls, not the storming.)

Seventy thousand captives is not believable for a single Punjabi town. Estimates put the town's whole population at roughly 80,000, which would mean Alexander carried off essentially everybody and killed 17,000 more on top. The realistic reading is that Arrian's figures are round numbers covering the town and all its dependent countryside. **Neither writer is giving a headcount.**

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **He changed arm immediately.** The moment cavalry failed he got off his horse and made it an infantry battle. Most commanders take a day to admit that.
- **He blocked the exit before pushing the door.** The lake, the stockade, Ptolemy's bugle plan — the whole siege is about closing escape routes first.
- **He read the building material.** Mud-brick walls do not need catapults. They need spades. He saved days by noticing.
- **He now had Indian allies.** Porus's elephants and men were fighting on his side four months after the Jhelum.

WHY THE KATHAIOI LOST

- **The wagon fort was the wrong answer to the wrong enemy.** It was a superb device against Indian cavalry armies — which is exactly how they had beaten Porus. Against disciplined heavy infantry it was a wall that could be walked over.
- **They fell back into the city.** Once inside, all their mobility and all their advantages were gone.
- **Their allies never came.** The Mallians and Oxydracae were "in the same temper" but did not march.
- **They were betrayed from inside.** Deserters gave away the second breakout.
- **They were beaten by their own last victory.** Having crushed Porus with the same tactics, they had every reason to trust them. That is how good armies lose.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Handsomest Man Is King, and the Dog That Would Not Let Go

The Greeks were fascinated by the Kathaioi, and the details they recorded — through Alexander's own naval officer Onesicritus — are unlike anything else in the campaign.

They chose their king by looks. Strabo says flatly that the Kathaioi "*choose the handsomest person as king.*" More disturbingly, he says a child was judged in public two months after birth as to whether it had "the beauty of form required by law and is worthy to live." And the men "*dye their beards with many most florid colours for the sole reason that they wish to beautify themselves.*"

And Strabo records something else — one of the two earliest datable Western descriptions of *sati*, the burning of widows — the other also comes from Alexander's expedition, reported by Aristobulus at Taxila. He gives the Kathaioi's own explanation for the custom: it existed, they said, because wives had sometimes poisoned their husbands, and Diodorus independently reports the same origin story. Whether or not that is how it began, it is a real piece of evidence about how the practice was explained in the Punjab in 326 BCE.

And then, from the neighbouring kingdom of **Sopeithes**, comes the best animal story in ancient literature. The king gave Alexander **150 fighting dogs** and offered a demonstration. A lion was released, and the dogs went in. One got a grip and would not let go. To prove the breed, a man began **cutting off the dog's own leg, slowly**. Diodorus: "*The dog uttered neither yelp nor whimper, but continued with his teeth clamped shut until, fainting with loss of blood, he died on top of the lion.*"

Curtius reports the story and then adds the single most useful sentence any ancient historian ever wrote: "***plura transcribo quam credo***" — **I write down more than I believe.**

The Battle Alexander Lost — On the Bank of the Beas

CERTAIN

He was never beaten in a battle. He was beaten in an argument, by his own soldiers, in Punjab.

WON BY

Alexander’s own army — the only force that ever stopped him

WHEN Around July 326 BCE.	WHERE The Hyphasis = the Beas, in Indian Punjab. This is the furthest east any Macedonian soldier ever stood.
WHO Alexander against the Macedonian army, with Coenus son of Polemocrates speaking for the men.	WHAT WAS AT STAKE Whether the Macedonian empire would swallow the Ganges valley as well.

Why they refused

Diodorus explains the state of the army, and it is worth reading slowly:

*“Alexander observed that his soldiers were exhausted with their constant campaigns. They had spent almost **eight years** among toils and dangers.”*

*“The hooves of the horses had been worn thin by steady marching. The arms and armour were wearing out, and **Greek clothing was quite gone**.”*

*“This was the season also... of the heavy rains. These had been going on for **seventy days**, to the accompaniment of continuous thunder and lightning.”*

Diodorus 17.94

Seventy days of monsoon. Leather rotting, iron rusting, men in borrowed Persian clothes because nothing from home could reach them. Curtius puts the whole thing into one line that ought to be carved somewhere: **“Victors in everything, we are destitute of everything.”**

And what was on the other side of the river

Twelve days of desert, then the Ganges. Beyond that, the empire of the **Nandas** under a king the Greeks called Xandrames — that is, **Dhana Nanda** of Magadha. The reported strength:

SOURCE	INFANTRY	CAVALRY	CHARIOTS	ELEPHANTS
Diodorus	200,000	20,000	2,000	4,000
Curtius	200,000	20,000	2,000	3,000
Plutarch	200,000	80,000	8,000	6,000
Arrian	<i>Gives no numbers at all — only that the people were “good agriculturists, and gallant in war” with “a much greater number of elephants than the other Indians,” of “surpassing size and courage.”</i>			

Alexander's men had just fought **two hundred** elephants and found it the hardest day of their lives. They were now being asked to march twelve days into a desert and then face somewhere between three and six *thousand*.

THE BEST ANCIENT CRITICISM OF ANCIENT NUMBERS

Curtius puts the sceptical case in Alexander's own mouth: nobody could keep herds of elephants larger than other countries keep herds of cattle, and *“rumour never reaches pure truth; those reporting make everything greater than fact.”*

He was right to doubt it, and the doubt did not help him at all. **What matters in a mutiny is not what is true but what the soldiers believe.**

Coenus speaks

Alexander called an assembly and made the case for going on. The officers said nothing. Then **Coenus** — one of his best generals, a man who had commanded the flanking move that won the Hydaspes — stood up.

Curtius describes what happened first, and it is the finest moment in his whole account: the officers stood mute, staring at the ground; then a murmur rose; then groans; then weeping broke out across the assembly — **and Alexander himself could not keep his eyes dry**. His anger turned to pity. Only then did Coenus step forward and **take off his helmet**, the proper way to address a king.

He was careful. He established that he spoke for the men and not for himself — *“we have already carried off the rewards of our labours”* — and then made his argument:

- **The arithmetic of attrition:** *“how many Macedonians and Greeks started with you, and how few of us have been left”* — dead in battle, crippled by wounds, killed by disease, or scattered in garrisons across Asia.
- **The precedent:** you sent the Thessalians home when you saw they had had enough. Do the same for us.
- **The quiet accusation:** some Greeks had been settled in the new eastern cities *“not indeed all of them of their own free will.”*

- **The human argument:** they wanted to see their parents, wives and children, and to come home “*as great men, whereas they departed small.*”
- **The warning:** “*Do not lead us now against our will; for you will no longer find us the same men in regard to dangers.*”
- **The practical alternative — and this is the part usually missed.** Curtius has Coenus propose that if Alexander must go further into India, he should go *south*, where it is narrower, and reach the ocean directly: “*Why seek by a detour a glory that lies to hand?*” **That is exactly what Alexander then did.**
- **And the line that landed:** “*Self-control in the midst of success is the noblest of all virtues, king.*”

Three days in the tent

Alexander dismissed the assembly, annoyed at Coenus’s plain speaking and at the silence of everyone else. The next day he announced he would go on and would compel no Macedonian — *those who wished could go home and tell everyone they had deserted their king.* Then he shut himself in his tent and admitted nobody for three days (Curtius says two).

Nobody came. The army did not break.

So he offered sacrifice to cross the river, and the omens were unfavourable. That is the mechanism of the climbdown, and it is a masterpiece of face-saving. A king cannot be seen to be overruled by his soldiers. A king may be overruled by the gods. He announced they were turning back.

“*There arose a loud shout such as you would expect from a large and joyful multitude, and many of them wept*” — and they blessed him “***because by them alone he suffered himself to be conquered.***”

Arrian 5.28

WHY THE SOLDIERS WON

- **They held the only thing he could not replace.** Alexander could get money, food, elephants and allies in India. He could not get another Macedonian phalanx.
- **They asked, they did not rebel.** Nobody drew a weapon, nobody named a rival king. It was impossible to punish and impossible to refuse.
- **Coenus was the right man.** Senior, decorated, personally loyal, with nothing left to gain. A junior officer saying the same words would have been executed.
- **They offered him a way out** — go south to the ocean instead. He could yield and still be conquering something.
- **They waited him out.** Three days of royal silence and not one man cracked.

WHY ALEXANDER LOST

- **Eight years without a proper rest.** Every army has a limit and he had found his.
- **He had no answer on supply.** No replacement equipment, no clothing, no remounts, 5,000 km from home in a monsoon.
- **His own success had made the next war unimaginable.** They had beaten 200 elephants; they had been told there were 4,000 more.
- **He had nothing left to offer.** The men were already rich. You cannot bribe a soldier who wants to go home with more money.
- **And he could not threaten them,** because “go home then and say you deserted your king” only works if somebody blinks. Nobody did.

The Camp Built for Giants

Before he turned back, Alexander did two things on the bank of the Beas.

First he built **twelve enormous altars** to the twelve gods — Arrian says “as high as the biggest towers,” Diodorus says fifty cubits, about seventy-five feet — as thank-offerings and as monuments to how far he had come. Plutarch says that long afterwards the Indian kings of the east still went to them and *offered sacrifices in the Greek manner*.

Then he played a joke on the future.

He marked out the ground for a camp **three times the size of the one his army actually used**, with a ditch fifty feet wide and forty feet deep. Inside it the infantry built huts containing **beds five cubits long** — over two metres. The cavalry built **mangers twice the normal size**. Plutarch adds oversized armour, higher horse-mangers and heavier bridle-bits, all left scattered about.

The purpose, says Diodorus, was “*to make a camp of heroic proportions and to leave to the natives evidence of men of huge stature, displaying the strength of giants*.” Curtius names it exactly: a ***fallax miraculum*** — a false marvel, manufactured for posterity.

Alexander could not conquer the Ganges. So he left behind the furniture of an army of giants, so that the people of Punjab would tell their grandchildren that giants had come to the Beas and turned back of their own accord. **It is one of the earliest deliberate attempts on record to fake the physical evidence for future generations — and it was done in Punjab.**

TWO HONEST FOOTNOTES

On Coenus. He died of illness about two months later, just before the fleet sailed. Curtius has Alexander remark bitterly that Coenus had made so long a speech “*as if he alone would see Macedonia again*.” Every modern insinuation of poisoning grows from that one royal quip — and Curtius himself does not make the accusation. The sources say illness.

On whether it was a mutiny at all. This is live scholarship. Timothy Howe and Sabine Müller argue there was no mutiny: Alexander had reached the eastern boundary of the old Persian Empire, which was his actual objective, and stopped because he had finished — and that the “mutiny” framing was borrowed by later Roman-era writers from Tacitus. Elizabeth Carney points out that the word *mutiny* assumes an army built on absolute obedience, which Macedonian armies were not. Waldemar Heckel: “*their words were not those of mutineers but of men who begged their king*.”

Something real happened — an army that would not go on and a king who did not make it. Whether to call that a mutiny is a fair question, and this book leaves it open.

The Mallian War: The Arrow at Multan

CERTAIN

The largest tribal alliance Punjab ever raised — and it fell apart before it fought.

WON BY

Alexander — who very nearly died doing it

WHEN November 326 – February 325 BCE, on the march down the rivers.	WHERE Central and southern Punjab, between the Chenab and the Ravi. The final citadel is usually placed at Multan.
WHO The Malloi (Sanskrit <i>Malava</i>) and the Oxydracae (<i>Kshudraka</i>) — the two great free republics of the Punjab.	THEIR STRENGTH Reported at 80,000–90,000 infantry, 10,000 cavalry, 700–900 chariots.

The alliance that should have worked

The Malavas and Kshudrakas were old enemies. Facing Alexander, they made peace — and they did it in the most serious way available to them. Diodorus says they sealed it by “**giving and receiving ten thousand young women**” in marriage between the two peoples.

Think about the scale of that. Ten thousand marriages to bind an alliance. This was not a handshake; it was two nations fusing themselves together to face one man.

And then Diodorus adds the sentence that decides the war:

*“Even so they did not come out to fight together but **fell into a dispute over the command** and retired into the neighbouring cities.”*

Diodorus 17.98

The greatest coalition in Punjab’s history collapsed because **they could not agree who would be general**. If that sounds familiar, it should — you read the same story on the banks of the Ravi in Part One, where ten kings lost to one.

The desert march

Alexander gave them no time to reconsider. He took the hypaspists, archers, Agrianians, javelin-cavalry and half the Companions, camped near the Chenab, rested the men, and **ordered every man to fill his water containers.**

Then he marched the rest of that day and all night — **about 45 miles in roughly 24 hours, across waterless country.**

At daybreak he was at a Mallian city. Arrian says it plainly: **the Mallians had not believed an army could cross the desert.** Most of them were outside the walls and unarmed. They were killed where they stood. With his infantry still strung out behind him, Alexander “*made use of his cavalry in place of a stockade*”, ringing the walls with horsemen until the foot came up.

What followed was a methodical destruction, city by city: about 2,000 killed at the first; a second town found abandoned and its people run down in flight; a third stormed by Peithon; a fourth — a Brahmin town — where the defenders **set fire to their own houses and died in the flames**, and about 5,000 were killed. Then the main Mallian force, perhaps 50,000, was caught and broken at a river crossing.

The citadel, the ladder, and the arrow

The survivors packed into their strongest city. And here Alexander did the thing that no other commander in history has done.

1. The Macedonians broke a small gate and got inside the outer wall. The Indians abandoned it and packed into the inner citadel.
2. **Perdiccas's column was late** — because many of his men had not even brought ladders, assuming from the empty walls that the place was already taken.
3. Alexander, furious at the slowness of the ladder-bearers, **snatched a ladder out of a man's hands himself, put it against the wall, and climbed it under his shield.**
4. Three men followed: **Peucestas**, carrying the sacred shield Alexander had taken from the temple of Athena at Troy; **Leonnatus**, his bodyguard; and **Abreas**, a soldier on double pay for distinguished service, on a second ladder.
5. Alexander reached the battlements and cleared his stretch of wall. The hypaspists below, terrified for him, surged up after him — and **their combined weight snapped the ladders.** Nobody else could get up.
6. He was now standing alone on an enemy wall, shot at from the towers on both sides, “*conspicuous both by the brightness of his weapons and by his extraordinary display of audacity.*”
7. **So he jumped down inside.** Arrian even gives us his reasoning: to stay was to be shot for nothing; but if he leapt into the fort “*he might perhaps by this very act strike the Indians with terror*” — and if not, he would “*die not ignobly after performing great deeds of valour.*”

Inside, with his back to the wall, he killed several men including the Indian commander, and drove others off with thrown stones, until the defenders stopped approaching and simply shot at him from all sides.

Abreas was shot through the forehead and killed. Then an arrow went “*under the breast through his breastplate into the chest.*” Ptolemy’s report gives the clinical detail that settles what happened: “**air was breathed out from the wound together with the blood.**” His lung was punctured.

He fought on “*as long as his blood was still warm,*” then went dizzy and fell forward onto his shield. **Peucestas stood over him with the shield from Troy; Leonnatus covered the other side. Both were wounded.** Curtius says Peucestas was struck by three javelins and “*protected the king rather than himself.*”

Outside, the army went berserk. Men broke their remaining ladders in the rush; some drove pegs into the mud-brick to climb; **some made human ladders of one another.** Others smashed a gate with axes. And when they got in:

“*Neither the old, nor women, nor infants were spared.*” — Curtius

“*The Macedonians killed all whom they met and filled the city with corpses.*” — Diodorus

THE ARROW ITSELF

Plutarch says the arrowhead was **three fingers broad and four long**, lodged against a rib, and that the wooden shaft had to be **sawn off** before the head could be cut out. Curtius calls it a two-cubit arrow and names the surgeon **Critobulus**, who was afraid to operate in case he was blamed — until Alexander reassured him: “*Won’t you be innocent, since the wound I have received is incurable?*” The barbed head had to be widened out of the flesh.

Arrian gives two versions of who did it: a physician of Cos named Critodemus, or **Perdiccas, with his sword, at Alexander’s own order**, no doctor being present. Either way “*there was such a copious effusion of blood that Alexander swooned again — and the effect of the swoon was that the effusion of blood was stanch.*” He fainted, and fainting saved his life.

WHY ALEXANDER WON

- **He attacked before the alliance could assemble.** The entire campaign is one long exercise in arriving too early.
- **He crossed ground they had ruled out.** 45 miles of waterless desert in a day was, to the Mallians, simply not a thing that armies did.
- **He split them and beat them separately** — which is only possible because they had already split themselves.
- **His army’s attachment to him personally.** Men who make ladders out of each other’s bodies to reach a wounded king are not a normal army.

WHY THE MALLOI AND OXYDRACAE LOST

- **They could not agree on a commander.** Everything else follows from this. Ten thousand marriages could not solve what one general would have solved.
- **Two free republics, two sets of leaders, no way to make a decision fast.** The very thing that made these societies admirable made them helpless against one man with total authority.
- **They fell back on their cities.** Their strength was numbers in open country; they shut themselves in walls instead.
- **They ruled out the desert route** and therefore did not watch it.
- **They fought a war of separate last stands** — brave, and militarily hopeless.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Army That Would Not Believe He Was Alive

The main army was four days away at the river confluence when word arrived that Alexander was dead. A letter came saying he lived. **They did not believe it.** They assumed the generals had forged it to hold the army together — and they were terrified: leaderless, in a hostile country, five thousand kilometres from home, with no idea how to get back.

So Alexander, with a hole in his lung, had himself carried to the riverbank and put in a boat to sail down to the camp — **and ordered the awning cut away from the stern so that he could be seen.**

They still did not believe it. Arrian says they supposed “*that Alexander’s corpse was being conveyed on the vessel*” — until he lifted his hand to the crowd. Then a great shout went up, and men wept.

The guards brought a litter to carry him from the boat to his tent. **He refused it and called for his horse.** When they saw him get into the saddle, Arrian says, the whole army clapped so loudly that “*the banks of the river and the groves near them reverberated with the sound.*” Near the tent he got down and **walked**, so they could see him walk. The men crowded in, “*touching his hands, others his knees, others only his clothes*”, and threw garlands and flowers over him.

Afterwards his friends reproached him for fighting in the front rank like a private soldier instead of a general, and he was visibly annoyed at it. Then an **old Boeotian soldier**, whose name nobody bothered to write down, came up and said in a broad country accent:

“Alexander, it is the part of heroes to perform great deeds!”

— and quoted a line of poetry to the effect that **the man who does anything great is fated to suffer for it.** He was the king’s favourite from that day on.

AND THE SURRENDER THAT FOLLOWED

The Oxydracae sent their city leaders, their provincial governors and 150 of their most notable men with full powers to make a treaty. Their explanation for not submitting earlier is one of the proudest statements in ancient literature: they had held out because “*they excelled other races in the desire to be free and independent*” — and **their freedom had been secure “from the time Dionysus came into India until Alexander came.”**

Alexander demanded a thousand of their best men as hostages. They sent “*the thousand best and tallest men*” — and, without being asked, **500 chariots with charioteers.** He returned the hostages and kept the chariots.

Seven Years, and Then Nothing CERTAIN

Alexander went on down the Indus, fought his way through Sindh, sent his fleet home along the coast under Nearchus, and marched the army through the Gedrosian desert — where he lost more people than in any battle of his life, most of them soldiers' wives, children and camp followers. He died at Babylon in June 323 BCE, aged 32.

Now watch what happened to his Indian conquest.

326 BCE	The satrap west of the Indus — probably Nicanor , though Arrian does not name him — is killed in a revolt in Swat , while Alexander is still in India.
325 BCE	Philip , the satrap of the Punjab, is murdered by his own mercenaries . Alexander writes to Ambhi and to a garrison commander named Eudemus telling them to hold the province “ <i>until I send a satrap</i> .” No satrap is ever sent .
323 BCE	Alexander dies at Babylon. His generals confirm the existing arrangements in India because none of them can reach it .
c. 322–319	Chandragupta Maurya overthrows the Nandas and takes Magadha — the very empire Alexander's army refused to face.
c. 318–317	Eudemus murders Porus and seizes his elephants.
316 BCE	Eudemus marches west with 120 of Porus's elephants to join a war in Iran, loses, and is executed. The last Macedonian troops leave. Greek rule east of the Hindu Kush is over .
c. 317–305	Chandragupta takes the Punjab — annexing everything Alexander's satraps had held.
305–303 BCE	Seleucus tries to take it back and fails . He gives up Arachosia, Gedrosia and the Paropamisadae — the whole Afghan and Punjab frontier — and receives 500 war elephants and a marriage alliance in exchange.

Alexander's conquests east of the Indus lasted about seven years, and no surviving source describes a single battle in which the Macedonians lost them. They simply walked away, and Chandragupta walked in. Twenty years after the Hydaspes, a Macedonian king came back to reclaim the ground and had to buy his way out of the attempt with four provinces.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — AND A CORRECTION

The Printer's Mistake That Created a Famous Story

You will read almost everywhere that **young Chandragupta Maurya met Alexander, insulted him, and had to run for his life**. Half of that story is a typing error.

Here is what the ancient sources actually say.

Plutarch says only this: *“Androcottus, when he was a stripling, saw Alexander himself”* — and later remarked that Alexander *“narrowly missed making himself master of the country,”* because the reigning Nanda king *“was hated and despised for the baseness of his origin.”* That is a vague claim about having seen Alexander. It is chronologically possible and completely unverifiable.

Justin is where the dramatic version comes from. Early printed editions of Justin read that Sandrocottus gave offence to *“Alexandrum”* and fled for his life. That looked like independent confirmation, and the story took off.

But the manuscripts do not say “Alexandrum.” They say “Nandrum” — the Nanda king. The German scholar Alfred von Gutschmid established the correct reading in the 19th century, McCrindle printed it in 1893, and Thomas Trautmann had to re-establish the point in 1971 against historians who had quietly revived the misprint. Chandragupta offended **Dhana Nanda**, was condemned to death by *him*, and fled from *him*.

A famous scene in Indian history rests on a 16th-century typo.

And yet the underlying point survives, and it is a sharp one. Alexander’s army stopped at the Beas partly out of fear of 200,000 Nanda infantry and thousands of elephants. Within five years, a young Indian adventurer overthrew that same army — using the very unpopularity of its king that Alexander’s own informants had described to him at the riverbank. **The Nandas were beatable. Alexander was told so. He just could not get his men across the river to find out.**

The Whole Chapter on One Page

c. 545–530 BCE	Cyrus the Great comes east. The trans-Indus peoples begin paying tribute. No battle is recorded. Won by Persia — probably.
c. 519–516 BCE	Scylax sails down the Indus on Darius's orders. Thirty months of survey.
c. 515 BCE	Darius annexes the Indus. It becomes the empire's richest province, paying about a third of all imperial revenue. Won by Darius I.
480–479 BCE	Punjab's soldiers march into Europe. They help burn Athens and fight at Plataea. Won by the Greeks.
331 BCE	Gaugamela. Indian troops and 15 elephants in the last Persian army. Won by Alexander.
327–326 BCE	The mountain war. Aspasioi, Massaga, the massacre of the 7,000, Queen Cleophis. Won by Alexander.
spring 326 BCE	The Rock of Aornos — taken by filling a ravine. Won by Alexander.
May 326 BCE	The Battle of the Hydaspes. The Jhelum, in a storm, against 200 elephants. Won by Alexander — who then restored Porus.
326 BCE	Sangala. The Kathaioi's fort of wagons. The city is razed. Won by Alexander.
July 326 BCE	The Beas. The army refuses to go further. Twelve altars and a camp built for giants. Won by Alexander's own soldiers.
326–325 BCE	The Mallian war. The great alliance splits; Alexander leaps alone into a citadel and takes an arrow through the lung. Won by Alexander.
316 BCE	The last Macedonian troops leave Punjab. Won by nobody — they simply walked away.
c. 317–305 BCE	Chandragupta Maurya takes the Punjab. <i>Part Three begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Three

1. **The coalition problem, again.** In Part One, ten kings lost to one on the Ravi. Here, the Malavas and Kshudrakas bound themselves together with ten thousand marriages and then *could not decide who would command*. Alexander destroyed the largest alliance Punjab ever assembled without it ever fighting as one. This is the single most reliable pattern in Punjab's military history, and it will decide Panipat, Chillianwala and Sobraon.
2. **Somebody always invites the invader in.** Ambhi of Taxila did not lose to Alexander; he *hired* him, to solve a quarrel with his neighbour Porus. That decision opened the door to the whole campaign. You will meet Ambhi

again under different names — Jaichand, Adina Beg, and others — for the next two thousand years.

3. **Rivers decide everything.** Part One's great battle was won by breaking a dyke. Part Two's is won by a night crossing in a thunderstorm. The five rivers are not scenery in this book; they are the main tactical fact of the entire region.
4. **Punjab is where the momentum runs out.** Alexander conquered from Greece to the Indus without ever being stopped. He was stopped on the Beas. Not by an army — by distance, weather, exhaustion and the plain refusal of tired men. The same thing will happen to invader after invader.
5. **Conquering Punjab is easy. Holding it is not.** Persia held it for two centuries by taxing lightly and interfering little. Alexander held it for seven years by force and lost every satrap he appointed. That difference is worth remembering every time an empire in this book marches in.

COMING NEXT — PART THREE

Mauryas, Greeks, Sakas, Parthians and Kushans, 322 BCE – 250 CE. Chandragupta and Chanakya throw the Macedonian garrisons out of Punjab and build India's first empire on top of them. Seleucus tries to take it back and trades four provinces for five hundred elephants. Then the Greeks come back the other way under Demetrius and Menander, and after them the Sakas, the Parthians and the Kushans — four foreign dynasties in four centuries, all of them ruling Punjab, all of them eventually becoming Indian. And at the end of it, the armed republics of the five rivers rise up and throw the greatest of them out.

Words Used in This Part

Achaemenid

The name of the Persian imperial dynasty founded by Cyrus the Great, ruling from about 550 to 330 BCE.

Satrap / satrapy

A Persian provincial governor, and the province he governed. Roughly equivalent to a viceroy.

Gandara / Gandhara

The Persian and Indian name for the country around Peshawar and Taxila.

Hindush

The Old Persian name for the Indus province — from the same root that gives us *Hindu*, *India* and *Sindh*. It began as a river name.

Sattagydia

A Persian province of the north-west, probably around Bannu and Dera Ismail Khan. It vanishes from the records after about 480 BCE and nobody knows why.

Behistun inscription

A vast trilingual text carved into a cliff in Iran around 520 BCE on Darius I's orders. It is the single most important document for dating the Persian conquest.

Talent

An ancient unit of weight, roughly 26 kilograms. Used for measuring tribute in silver or gold.

Hydaspes, Acesines, Hydraotes, Hyphasis

The Greek names for the **Jhelum**, **Chenab**, **Ravi** and **Beas**. You will see them constantly in Greek sources.

Phalanx

The Macedonian heavy infantry formation — a dense block of men carrying pikes, fighting as a single body.

Sarissa

The Macedonian pike, 15 to 18 feet long. Held in both hands, it out-reached every hand weapon in the world at the time.

Hypaspists

Alexander's elite infantry guard — lighter and faster than the phalanx, used for assaults and difficult ground.

Companion cavalry

The Macedonian heavy cavalry, Alexander's personal strike force and the arm he usually led himself.

Agrianians

Light infantry javelin troops from the Balkans, used by Alexander for mountain and skirmishing work.

Mahout

An elephant driver. In battle, killing the mahout was the fastest way to neutralise the elephant — and often to turn it against its own side.

Laager

A defensive ring made of wagons. The Kathaioi used three of them at Sangala.

Stade / stadion

A Greek unit of distance, roughly 180 metres. Ancient distances in this chapter are usually given in these.

The vulgate

The historians' name for the Alexander tradition that runs through Diodorus, Curtius and Justin — all downstream of a writer called Clitarchus, who was not present and wrote to thrill. Arrian, drawing on eyewitnesses, is generally the better source, but not always.

Kharoshthi

The script of ancient Gandhara, clearly derived from the Aramaic used by Persian administrators. Uniquely among Indian scripts, it runs right to left. It is the Persian Empire's most lasting gift to Punjab.

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A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The main open questions in this part are: whether Cyrus ever campaigned east of Afghanistan at all; where Caspatyrus was and whether Scylax's voyage happened as described; whether Alexander's massacre at Massaga was premeditated or a response to a broken truce; the true casualty figures at the Hydaspes and Sangala; where Sangala actually was; and whether the events on the Beas should be called a mutiny. Where scholars differ, this part follows the mainstream reading and says so.

And one thing to keep in mind on every page. Every word we have about Alexander in Punjab was written by his own side — mostly by officers who served him, and by Roman-era writers copying them. Not one line survives from an Indian who watched him come. When you read that 17,000 died at Sangala, or that 70,000 were carried off, remember who is counting.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART THREE OF SIXTEEN

Mauryas to Kushans

Four foreign peoples conquer the land of the five rivers in four hundred years — Greeks, Sakas, Parthians, Kushans — and every single one of them arrives as an invader and ends up Indian.

322 BCE — 250 CE

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Four-Hundred-Year Habit

Part Two ended with Alexander's men walking out of Punjab. Part Three is about what walked in afterwards — and about the strangest pattern in the whole book.

Here is the shape of the next four hundred years, and it is worth having in your head before the details start. Punjab is conquered from the north-west four separate times by four different peoples: **Greeks, then Sakas, then Parthians, then Kushans**. Each arrives with cavalry, foreign gods and an unfamiliar language. Each takes Taxila, takes the plain, and sets up a court.

And then, every single time, the same thing happens. Within two or three generations the conqueror is minting coins in Indian scripts, putting Indian gods on the reverse, taking Indian titles, marrying into Indian families and endowing Indian religious buildings. **A Greek ambassador sets up a pillar in central India to the god Vishnu and calls himself a devotee. A Kushan emperor puts the Buddha on his gold coinage in Greek lettering. A Saka warlord's family becomes the most important patrons of Buddhism in the north-west.**

This is the four-hundred-year habit, and it is the single most important thing in this part. **Punjab in these centuries is not a place that resists foreigners. It is a place that digests them.**

Four things that make this part different

- **India acquires an empire, and Punjab is what it is built on.** Chandragupta Maurya starts here, in the north-west, with the garrisons Alexander left behind. The first great Indian state is assembled from the outside in.
- **Coins become the main evidence, and they are strange evidence.** Something like thirty Greek kings ruled in this region whose names appear on *no written source anywhere in the world*. We know they existed only because they made money. You will meet several of them.
- **Punjab becomes the most cosmopolitan place on earth.** Greek sculptors, Buddhist monks, Persian administrators, Chinese silk, Roman gold and Central Asian cavalry, all in the same cities at the same time. This is the world that produces Gandharan art.
- **And it ends with a genuine Punjabi victory.** The last war in this part is fought by the armed republics of the plain, on their own account, against the greatest empire in Asia — and they win it.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — an inscription cut at the time, a coin, an eyewitness.

LIKELY

means good sources writing later, generally accepted.

STORY

means legend or tradition, which may have a real war underneath it.

Part Three has a particular problem. Most of it comes from four kinds of source that never talk to each other: **Greek and Roman historians** writing centuries later and at second hand; **Buddhist legend**, which cares about lessons rather than dates; **Chinese official histories**, which are excellent but only look at India sideways; and **coins**, which are contemporary and truthful and cannot tell you a single thing about what happened.

Where those four disagree, this part says so.

Chandragupta Clears Out the Macedonians

LIKELY

The first Indian empire began as a rebellion against a garrison, in the north-west, by a young man nobody can identify with confidence.

WON BY Chandragupta Maurya — and, honestly, partly by Greek civil war

WHEN Roughly 322–317 BCE, in the years right after Alexander’s death in 323.	WHERE The Punjab plain, Gandhara and the Indus — the satrapies Alexander had left behind him.
WHO Chandragupta Maurya and his adviser Chanakya, against the Macedonian governors and their troops.	THE EVIDENCE Two short passages in Roman-era historians, and a large amount of Indian tradition written down much later.

What the Greeks say happened

The most important sentence in this war is from **Justin**, a Roman writer summarising a lost earlier history. India, he says, after the death of Alexander, had shaken the yoke of servitude from its neck and put his governors to death — and the author of that liberation was **Sandrocottus**, which is the Greek form of Chandragupta.

Then Justin adds a line that is easy to skip and worth stopping on. Having freed India, Sandrocottus **turned that freedom into servitude of his own**.

Orosius, later, says much the same: that after Alexander’s death the Indians killed his officers and rose in revolt seeking their freedom under the leadership of a certain Androcottus.

So the Greek tradition is clear on the shape of it. **This was a war of liberation in the north-west, and it produced a conqueror.**

What actually happened to the Macedonian garrisons

Here is the honest and slightly deflating part, and it matters.

1. **They were already falling apart.** **Philip**, the satrap of the Indus country, was assassinated by his own mercenaries in about 325 BCE — before Alexander was even dead. **Nicanor**, another commander, was killed in the north. Alexander’s arrangements in Punjab were unravelling within months of his leaving.

2. **The best Greek troops were pulled out to fight each other.** When Alexander died, his generals began a forty-year war over his empire. **Eudemus**, the Greek commander in India, treacherously killed **Porus** — the same Porus who fought Alexander on the Jhelum in Part Two — seized his elephants, and in about 317 BCE marched west out of India with a hundred and twenty of them to join the fighting. He was defeated and executed shortly afterwards.
3. **Peithon withdrew to Kandahar in 316.** The Macedonian presence in India simply drained away westward.
4. **Chandragupta pushed at a door that was already swinging.** He did fight, and he did take the north-west, and the Greek sources credit him with killing governors. But the empire he pushed over was mostly holding itself up by then.

WHERE HIS ARMY CAME FROM — AND A TRANSLATION FIGHT

Justin says Chandragupta gathered a force of *latrones* — a Latin word that early translators rendered as “robbers”, which produced a century of writing about a bandit chief who became an emperor.

The word is not that simple. It can mean a mercenary soldier, a hunter, or an irregular fighter, and Indian historians including **Raychaudhuri** argued that the early translators had chosen the most insulting available option. The alternative reading is far more probable: **Chandragupta recruited mercenaries, hill fighters and the armed republics of the Punjab** — the same peoples who had fought Alexander in Part Two and had every reason to want the garrisons gone.

If that is right, then **the army that founded India’s first empire was substantially a Punjabi army**, and the Mauryan state was built with north-western manpower before it ever touched the Ganges.

WHY CHANDRAGUPTA WON

- **He struck at the moment of maximum confusion.** Between Alexander’s death and the Greek generals sorting out their war, the north-west had no functioning authority for years.
- **He recruited the people who were already angry.** The republics and hill peoples of Punjab had been fighting garrisons on their own account since 325.
- **He had a strategist.** Whatever the truth of the Chanakya legend, the campaign shows planning: the north-west first, the Ganges second, in that order and not the other way round.
- **Nobody was coming to help the Greeks.** Every Macedonian with ambition was three thousand kilometres west, fighting for a bigger prize.

WHY THE GREEKS LOST PUNJAB

- **Alexander’s settlement was never real.** He left local kings in place under Macedonian supervisors and marched away. That arrangement needed his personal authority to hold, and he died.
- **They were hated.** The Greek sources themselves record that the occupying troops had provoked deep hostility, and that priests and local leaders encouraged revolt.
- **Their garrisons were tiny and isolated.** A few thousand men spread across a country of millions, with no reinforcement route that anybody was using.
- **Their commanders left.** The single biggest factor. India was a sideshow to the war over Alexander’s empire, and the professionals went where the prize was.

The Man Whose Family Nobody Can Agree On

Chandragupta Maurya founded the largest empire India would have for two thousand years. We do not know where he was born, who his parents were, or what community he came from.

Buddhist sources make him a member of a warrior clan. Jain sources have a different account again. Brahminical tradition, in the play *Mudrarakshasa*, makes him low-born — and the Greek writers, who had no stake in the Indian argument, also suggest humble origins. Later tradition attached him to Punjab, to Bihar, to Nepal, and to at least three different clans. **Every one of these traditions was written down centuries after he died, by people with a reason to prefer their version.**

Justin gives him the origin story of a folk hero rather than a king. A wild elephant of great size, he says, came up to Chandragupta of its own accord and, as if tamed, took him on its back. In another passage a lion approaches him while he sleeps, licks the sweat from him, and walks away without harming him.

Those are omen stories, and they are the sort of thing that gets told about a man *because* nobody knows where he came from. You do not need a miracle to explain the ancestry of a prince.

The founder of India's first empire is, biographically, almost a blank — and that blank is the strongest single piece of evidence that he really did rise from nowhere. Everyone who came after him needed him to have been one of theirs, which is exactly what happens to a man who was nobody's.

The Nanda War — Eating From the Edges

STORY

The most famous strategy in Indian history was supposedly learned from a mother scolding her child over a hot dinner.

WON BY

Chandragupta and Chanakya — on the second attempt

WHEN

Roughly **322–320 BCE**, overlapping with the war in the north-west.

WHERE

From the Punjab eastward down the Ganges to **Pataliputra** — modern Patna.

WHO

Chandragupta against **Dhana Nanda**, the last Nanda king of Magadha.

THE EVIDENCE

Buddhist and Jain traditions and a much later Sanskrit play. Almost nothing contemporary.

Why the Nandas were beatable

Remember from Part Two what Alexander's men were told at the Beas: that the kingdom ahead of them could field two hundred thousand infantry and thousands of elephants. It was the largest military power in India and it terrified an army that had never been stopped.

They were also told the other half, and the Greek writers record it clearly. **The Nanda king was despised by his own people.** Curtius and Diodorus both pass on the same information — that he was of low birth, said in one version to be a barber's son, and was hated for it. **Alexander was standing on a riverbank being told simultaneously that the enemy was enormous and that the enemy was unpopular.** He acted on the first half.

Chandragupta acted on the second, and it took him about five years.

The lesson at the doorway

Here is the famous story, and its label is *Story* for good reason.

In the tradition, Chandragupta and Chanakya attack the Nanda heartland directly, marching on the capital first — and are beaten badly. Fleeing afterwards in disguise, Chanakya overhears a mother scolding a small boy. The child has grabbed a hot cake and burned his fingers because he went straight for the middle. **“You are as foolish as**

Chandragupta,” the mother says. **“He attacked the centre of the kingdom instead of starting from the edges, where it is cool.”**

Chanakya takes the point. They begin again: secure the frontier provinces first, take the outlying territory, build allies and strength on the periphery, and only then close on the capital.

1. **Secure the north-west first.** This is why War One and War Two belong together. The Punjab was not a sideshow to the Nanda war; it was the base for it.
2. **Build an alliance.** The tradition gives Chandragupta a partner, a mountain king called **Parvataka**, whom many scholars have tried to identify with Porus or his family. If there is anything in it, the invasion of Magadha was launched by a Punjab–hill coalition.
3. **Take the provinces, then the capital.** Pataliputra falls last, not first.
4. **Dhana Nanda is destroyed**, and the Mauryan empire begins from a throne in Bihar that was won using an army raised in the north-west.

HANDLE WITH CARE — AND KEEP THE LESSON ANYWAY

The hot-cake story appears in Buddhist and Jain traditions written centuries later, and it has the exact structure of a teaching tale: a wise man humbled, a lesson from an ordinary woman, a strategy learned from a kitchen. It is almost certainly not something that happened.

But the **strategy** it describes is real, and it is visible in what Chandragupta actually did. He did secure the periphery before the centre. His empire was assembled outside-in. And the same principle turns up in the *Arthashastra*, the manual of statecraft traditionally attributed to Chanakya, in the form of the *mandala* theory — the idea that your neighbour is your enemy and your neighbour’s neighbour is your friend, and that a kingdom should be approached as a set of rings from the outside.

The anecdote is fiction. The doctrine underneath it was taught, written down, and used.

WHY CHANDRAGUPTA WON

- **He attacked the right target for the right reason.** He went after an unpopular king, not a weak one — a completely different calculation, and the correct one.
- **He started from the edges.** Whatever the source of the idea, the method is sound and is still taught.
- **He had a frontier base with a fighting population.** Punjab gave him manpower that was already mobilised and already hostile to the existing order.
- **He lost first and adjusted.** The tradition insists on an early defeat, and the fact that a hero-legend keeps an embarrassing failure in it is a point in its favour.

WHY THE NANDAS LOST

- **Size is not the same as support.** The largest army in India belonged to a king his own people would not fight for.
- **They had no answer to a war on the rim.** A centralised state that concentrates everything in the capital cannot respond to an enemy eating the provinces one by one.
- **They had made themselves the point of the state.** Kill the dynasty and there is nothing underneath — the same failure you will see again with Mihirakula in Part Four.
- **Their reputation had already been used against them.** The information that beat them was circulating on the Beas in 326 BCE. It just took an Indian to act on it.

The Beas, Five Years Later

Stand on the bank of the Beas in the monsoon of 326 BCE with the Macedonian army, as they were in Part Two. They will not cross. They have been told what is on the other side: two hundred thousand foot, three thousand elephants, the greatest power in India. Alexander argues for days and then gives up, builds twelve enormous altars, and turns around. It is the only time in his life he is stopped.

Now move forward five or six years to the same riverbank.

The kingdom that frightened the best army in the world has been overthrown by a young man from the same region, using soldiers recruited from the very peoples Alexander had just finished fighting — and the reason it worked is the piece of information that Alexander's own scouts had handed him at that riverbank and that he had not known what to do with. **The Nandas were hated. That was the whole weakness, and it was in the briefing.**

There is a line in Plutarch, written centuries later, that makes this almost unbearable. He says that Androcottus — Chandragupta — had seen Alexander himself when he was a young man, and afterwards used to say that Alexander **narrowly missed making himself master of the country, because the reigning king was hated and despised for the baseness of his origin.**

We cannot verify a word of it. It is chronologically possible and completely unprovable, and Part Two already warned you about the famous version of this story that turned out to rest on a printer's error.

But keep the shape of it, because the shape is true whether the meeting happened or not. **The empire on the far bank could be taken. Alexander was told so, at the river, by people who lived there. He turned back — and an Indian who was listening did it instead.**

Seleucus Comes Back — And Sells Half of Afghanistan for Elephants

LIKELY

The only war in this book that ends with the loser getting the better long-term deal, and both sides knowing it.

WON BY Chandragupta Maurya — decisively, and possibly without a battle

WHEN	WHERE
305–303 BCE.	Somewhere east of the Indus. No location is recorded anywhere. Nobody knows.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Seleucus I Nicator, Alexander’s former officer and now ruler of Asia, against Chandragupta.	A handful of lines in Appian, Strabo, Plutarch and Justin. No campaign account survives.

Why it happened

Seleucus had spent twenty years fighting for a share of Alexander’s empire and had ended up with the largest piece of it — Syria, Mesopotamia, Iran, and everything east. In his own mind, that inheritance included India, because Alexander had taken it.

So around 305 BCE he came east to collect. **Appian says simply that he crossed the Indus and made war on Sandrocottus.**

What happened next, which is remarkable

1. **No battle is described.** Not one ancient writer names an engagement, a place or a date. Appian goes straight from “waged war” to “until they came to an understanding with each other.”
2. **Seleucus gave up four provinces.** Strabo lists what changed hands: **Arachosia (Kandahar), Gedrosia, the Paropamisadae (the Kabul valley and the Hindu Kush foothills), and Aria (Herat).** That is, roughly, the eastern half of modern Afghanistan and the country down to the Makran coast.
3. **He received five hundred war elephants.** Strabo says the provinces were given to Sandrocottus upon terms of intermarriage and of receiving in exchange five hundred elephants.

4. **There was a marriage agreement.** The Greek word is *epigamia*, and what exactly it meant is argued about — a dynastic marriage, or a general right of intermarriage between the two peoples.
5. **And then the two states stayed friendly for generations.** Seleucus sent an ambassador, **Megasthenes**, who lived at Pataliputra and wrote the *Indika*, the first substantial Greek description of India. His successor sent another. The border did not move again.

WAS THERE ACTUALLY A BATTLE?

This is a live argument. The military historian **John D. Grainger** puts it about as honestly as it can be put: it is unknown whether there was a pitched battle at all — and yet the outcome was a decisive Indian victory. Those two statements sit together perfectly well. **A commander who arrives, assesses the situation and negotiates away four provinces has lost, whether or not anybody died.**

A minority view, argued by **Hartmut Scharfe** in 1971, held that Seleucus actually kept overlordship and Chandragupta became a subordinate. Essentially no other scholar has accepted it, and the terms make no sense on that reading. Nobody hands over four provinces as the winner.

What tipped it was almost certainly arithmetic. Chandragupta could put an enormous army into the field close to home. Seleucus was at the end of a very long march, with an unfinished war waiting for him in the west — and he knew what he needed more than territory.

WHY CHANDRAGUPTA WON

- **Numbers, close to home.** Plutarch claims six hundred thousand men, which is a fantasy figure, but the underlying point stands: the Mauryan state could field more soldiers in Punjab than Seleucus could bring across Iran.
- **He was fighting on ground he had just conquered and organised.** The north-west was his base, not his frontier.
- **He had the one commodity his enemy urgently wanted.** Elephants were the strategic weapon of the age and India was the only supplier that mattered.
- **He knew Seleucus had a war behind him.** Time was worth more to Seleucus than land, and Chandragupta priced accordingly.

WHY SELEUCUS SETTLED

- **His real enemy was in Turkey, not India.** Antigonos, the most dangerous of Alexander's successors, was preparing for a war that would decide who owned Asia.
- **The four provinces were expensive to hold and worth little.** Mountain country, thin revenue, hostile populations, enormous distance.
- **An eastern frontier that stays quiet is worth a great deal.** He converted a permanent military problem into a permanent friendship, and it held for a century.
- **And he was right.** Which is the point of the story below.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE BIGGEST ARMS DEAL IN THE ANCIENT WORLD

What the Elephants Did Next

Follow the five hundred elephants, because almost nobody does, and their journey is the reason this obscure treaty belongs in world history.

They were handed over somewhere in the north-west around 303 BCE. Then they were walked — across Afghanistan, across Iran, across Mesopotamia, and up into Anatolia. It is a distance of something like four thousand kilometres, and every one of those animals had to be fed on the way. Feeding a single working elephant takes a very large amount of fodder every day. Five hundred of them is a marching town.

In **301 BCE** they arrived at a place in central Turkey called **Ipsus**, where Seleucus and his allies met Antigonus in the largest battle of the age — the one that would finally settle who inherited Alexander's empire.

The elephants decided it. Antigonus's cavalry, under his son Demetrius, charged and drove the enemy horse off the field, and then found that they could not get back: **the elephant line had been moved across behind them, and horses will not face elephants**. The best striking force in the army was locked out of its own battle. Antigonus, in his eighties, was killed where he stood.

Seleucus took the largest share of the spoils and founded the dynasty that would rule the Middle East for two hundred and fifty years.

The Hellenistic world was shaped at Ipsus, and Ipsus was won with animals bought from Punjab. Chandragupta gained an empire from the deal; Seleucus gained one too. It is the rarest thing in this book — a war that ended with both sides better off, and the only reason it worked is that each of them wanted something the other did not value.

The Two Revolts of Taxila

STORY

The empire's richest western city rebelled twice in one lifetime, and both times the complaint was the same: not the emperor, the officials.

WON BY

The Mauryan empire — once by negotiation, once with difficulty

WHEN

The first around **c. 272 BCE** under Bindusara; the second later in the same reign, and possibly a third under Ashoka.

WHERE

Taxila — Takshashila — the great city of the north-west, and its province.

WHO

The citizens of Taxila against the imperial administration; the princes **Ashoka** and **Sushima** sent to deal with it.

THE EVIDENCE

The *Ashokavadana*, a Buddhist legend collection written down centuries later — plus one piece of unexpected corroboration.

What the legend says

1. **Taxila revolts.** The emperor Bindusara — Chandragupta's son — sends his son Ashoka to put it down.
2. **He sends him with nothing.** In the story, the emperor refuses to provide weapons or chariots for the expedition. Ashoka was not the favourite son, and the tale is clear that this was meant as a humiliation. Gods then supply the missing equipment, which is how you can tell you are reading a legend.
3. **The city opens its gates.** This is the part worth keeping. When Ashoka arrives, the citizens come out and explain that **they are not opposed to the emperor or to the prince — they are opposed to Bindusara's oppressive ministers.** Ashoka enters the city without a fight.
4. **It revolts again.** Before Bindusara's death Taxila rises a second time. This time the eldest son, **Sushima**, is sent — and fails.
5. **And there is a third story, later and darker.** Under Ashoka, his son **Kunala** is sent to Taxila as viceroy. In the legend, a queen alters a letter from the emperor by adding a single dot to a word, turning an order that the prince should *study* into an order that he should be *blinded* — and Kunala, believing it to be his father's command, obeys it.

WHY THIS IS LABELLED STORY — AND WHY IT STILL TELLS YOU SOMETHING TRUE

The *Ashokavadana* is Buddhist devotional literature. Its purpose is to show Ashoka's transformation, and every episode is shaped to that end. The dot-in-the-letter story is a folk motif. The gods handing out weapons is not history.

But look at the grievance the legend puts in the citizens' mouths, and then look at what Ashoka himself carved on rock.

In his **Separate Rock Edicts**, addressed to his officials in the provinces, Ashoka worries about exactly this. He tells his officers that all his subjects are his children; he warns them against acting out of jealousy, anger, cruelty, haste or laziness; and he orders **regular inspection tours specifically to check that officials are not mistreating people**. An emperor does not build a formal inspection system to solve an imaginary problem.

The legend and the inscriptions agree on the diagnosis even though only one of them is history: the Mauryan empire's weak point in its distant provinces was its own officials.

WHY THE EMPIRE HELD TAXILA

- **It sent princes, not just armies.** A member of the royal family arriving in person makes negotiation possible in a way that a general cannot.
- **It could distinguish a tax revolt from a secession.** Taxila was not trying to leave the empire. Recognising that is what let the first revolt end without a siege.
- **The province was worth the effort.** Taxila sat on the trade routes to Central Asia and was one of the wealthiest cities the empire owned.
- **And it built machinery to prevent a repeat.** The inspection tours in the edicts are a genuine administrative answer to a genuine problem.

WHY IT KEPT HAPPENING

- **Distance.** Taxila to Pataliputra is a very long way. Officials that far from the throne can behave as they like for years before anyone notices.
- **The city had its own identity.** It had been a Persian provincial capital, a Greek prize and an independent kingdom within living memory. It did not think of itself as a district.
- **Wealthy cities have leverage.** A place that generates a large share of the imperial revenue knows it is expensive to punish.
- **And nothing was fixed structurally.** Within fifty years of Ashoka's death, the north-west was gone.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Complaint That Nobody Expects

Almost every revolt in this book is about who rules. This one is not, and that is why it deserves its own page.

The people of Taxila did not march out to say that the Mauryas were foreigners, or that they wanted their old kings back, or that they refused to be part of an Indian empire. According to the tradition, they came out of the gates and said, in effect: **we have no quarrel with the emperor and none with you. Your ministers are robbing us.**

Whether or not those words were said, the story survived because everyone recognised it. Taxila is months away from Pataliputra by road, and in that gap an imperial officer is the whole government.

And the response is what makes it remarkable. The prince did not sack the city. He listened and went in without a fight — and, if the tradition's sequence means anything, that same man later built the only empire in the ancient world with a formal system for inspecting its own officials.

The most sophisticated administrative idea of the ancient Indian state may have started as a complaint shouted at a prince outside the walls of a Punjabi city.

Hold on to Taxila. You will see it again in every part of this book until the sixth century CE, when it stops appearing — because by then it is a field of broken foundations, burned in the Hun invasions of Part Four and never rebuilt.

The War That Ended in Writing

CERTAIN

The only war in this book whose most important consequence was carved on rocks in Punjab, in two scripts, by a man announcing that he would not do it again.

WON BY

Ashoka — who then publicly said it was not worth it

WHEN The Kalinga war around 261 BCE ; the edicts carved from roughly 257 BCE onward.	WHERE The war was in Odisha. The declaration is in Punjab and Gandhara — Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra, and Kandahar.
WHO Ashoka , third Mauryan emperor, and the north-western population who had to be told what he had decided.	THE EVIDENCE His own inscriptions, cut into rock in his lifetime, on his orders. As certain as evidence gets in this book.

Why a war in Odisha belongs in a book about Punjab

Because of where he chose to announce it.

The Kalinga campaign was fought on the east coast, about two thousand kilometres from the five rivers, and this book will not pretend otherwise. What happened afterwards, though, is a Punjab story, and here is why. **Ashoka took the most personal statement any ancient ruler ever made about war, and had it cut into rock faces on the north-western frontier, in the local script, for the people there to read.**

At **Shahbazgarhi** and **Mansehra**, in the Gandhara country, his major edicts are carved in **Kharoshthi** — the right-to-left script of the north-west that Part Two described as the Persian empire’s lasting gift to Punjab. Elsewhere in the empire, the same edicts are in Brahmi. Further west, at **Kandahar**, a version was cut in **Greek and Aramaic**, for populations who read neither Indian script.

This is an emperor translating himself. The Mauryan state had worked out that a message carved in a language nobody local can read is not a message.

What the thirteenth edict actually says

Rock Edict XIII is the famous one, and it is worth being precise about its contents, because it is quoted constantly and read carelessly.

1. **It gives numbers, and terrible ones.** A hundred and fifty thousand people deported, a hundred thousand killed, and many times that number dead afterwards. An emperor publishing his own casualty figures is close to unique in the ancient world.
2. **It expresses remorse in the first person.** The text says the Beloved of the Gods felt remorse at the conquest of Kalinga, because conquering a country that has not been conquered before means killing, death and deportation, and that this is deeply painful to him.
3. **It says the suffering of the innocent is the worst part** — that even those who escape are hurt by the injury done to those they love.
4. **It renounces conquest as policy.** It states that the only true conquest is conquest by *dhamma* — by right conduct — and asks his sons and grandsons not to think of new conquests.
5. **And it names foreign kings.** It lists the Greek king Antiochus and, beyond him, four more rulers — the kings we know as Ptolemy, Antigonus, Magas and Alexander. This is the single most useful passage in Indian history for fixing dates, because those five men can be dated from Greek sources.

THE ONE DETAIL THAT KEEPS THIS HONEST

Rock Edict XIII, with all its remorse and its casualty figures, is carved across the empire — including at Shahbazgarhi in the north-west.

It is not carved in Kalinga. At the two sites in the conquered country itself, Dhauli and Jaugada, that edict is left out — along with two others — and two different texts are put in its place: the ones addressed to his officials about treating people justly.

Historians have argued about why for a century, and there is no settled answer. The obvious reading is uncomfortable and hard to dismiss: **the emperor's public grief about the massacre was published everywhere except to the people who had been massacred.**

None of this makes the edicts fraudulent. Ashoka did stop conquering, and there is no evidence of another war of expansion in a reign of nearly forty years, which is an extraordinary record. But this book's rule applies to him as to everyone: **always ask who is writing, and where they chose to put it.**

WHAT ASHOKA GOT RIGHT

- **He wrote to the frontier in the frontier's own script.** Kharoshthi in Gandhara, Greek and Aramaic at Kandahar. The empire understood that Punjab and the north-west were a different world and addressed them as one.
- **He put policy on stone rather than in an archive.** Paper burns and officials lie. A rock face beside a road is a promise the government cannot quietly withdraw.
- **He made his officials the subject.** The edicts are largely about the behaviour of the administration — the problem Taxila had revolted over twice.
- **And he actually stopped.** Whatever the motive, no further war of conquest is recorded in his reign, and that is not nothing.

WHAT IT DID NOT FIX

- **An empire that renounces war still needs an army.** Ashoka did not disband his; his successors could not use it.
- **Moral authority does not transfer.** The system depended on the personal reputation of one emperor, and it did not outlive him by fifty years.
- **The frontier remained a governor's problem.** Punjab was still administered from two thousand kilometres away by men whose conduct required inspection tours to control.
- **And the passes were still open.** The message carved at Shahbazgarhi faced west, towards the road that Demetrius would come down in ninety years.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Emperor Who Wrote to Strangers

Somewhere around 257 BCE, a man in Kandahar was employed to carve an Indian emperor's religious and moral programme into rock in fluent, idiomatic **Greek**. It was found in 1958, and it is not a rough translation — it is competent Greek prose, using Greek philosophical vocabulary to render Indian ideas.

Beside it, the same message in **Aramaic**, the old administrative language of the Persian empire, still in use across the region two generations after that empire had ceased to exist.

Think about what that document required. The Mauryan court had to know that a Greek-speaking population existed out there. It had to employ somebody who could think in both languages well enough to find Greek words for concepts that had no Greek words. It had to decide that those people's opinion was worth the cost of the stonemason.

And it had to want to be understood. **An empire that only wants obedience does not need translators. It needs tax collectors.**

That is the thing about these inscriptions that survives every argument about Ashoka's sincerity. All across the north-west, in three scripts and two languages, a government carved messages into rock explaining itself to its own frontier — not proclaiming victories, not listing conquests, but explaining what it thought a ruler was for.

Nothing like it exists again on this soil for a very long time. The next several hundred years of Punjab's history, as the rest of this part will show, are recorded almost entirely on coins.

185 BCE — The Empire Ends at a Parade

LIKELY

India's first empire was not conquered. It was killed by its own commander-in-chief during a review of the troops.

WON BY

Pushyamitra Shunga — the general who inspected an army and used it

WHEN

c. 185 BCE, about forty-seven years after Ashoka's death.

WHERE

Pataliputra — but the consequence lands immediately on the north-west frontier.

WHO

Pushyamitra, the Mauryan *senani* or commander-in-chief, against Brihadratha, the last Mauryan emperor.

THE EVIDENCE

The Puranas, and a much-quoted passage in Bana's *Harshacharita* written eight centuries later.

What happened

The account that everyone quotes comes from **Bana**, the seventh-century writer you will meet again in Part Four as the biographer of Harsha. He describes it in a single vicious sentence: that the commander Pushyamitra, **on the pretext of showing him the whole army on parade, crushed his master Brihadratha and took the kingdom.**

That is essentially all we have for the event itself. The Mauryan empire — the largest state in Indian history to that date, the empire of Chandragupta and Ashoka — ends in one line, at a military review, at the hands of the man whose job was to command its soldiers.

Why the empire was already finished

1. **The succession had fractured.** After Ashoka the sources become confused and contradictory, with several claimants and an empire that may already have been governed in halves.
2. **The provinces had drifted.** Kalinga went its own way; the Deccan slipped; and crucially, **the north-west was no longer under real control.**
3. **The economy that carried it was enormous and expensive.** A state that runs on a vast bureaucracy and a standing army needs its revenue to keep flowing from provinces two thousand kilometres away, and by 200 BCE that was not happening.

4. **The army was the last functioning institution**, which is precisely why its commander was in a position to take the throne.
5. **And the frontier was undefended.** Within a very few years of the coup, Greek armies came back through the passes — this time from the other direction.

ON THE PERSECUTION STORIES — AND HOW TO READ THEM

Pushyamitra is accused in Buddhist sources of persecuting Buddhism. The *Ashokavadana* tradition says he offered a bounty for the head of a Buddhist monk — a hundred coins each — and it names **Sakala**, modern Sialkot, as the place he proclaimed it. Another text says he burned scriptures and destroyed hundreds of monasteries; the sixteenth-century Tibetan writer Taranatha says the doctrine was wiped from the north within five years.

This is contested ground, and it is contested for modern political reasons as well as historical ones, so here is the state of the evidence plainly. **Étienne Lamotte** found the Buddhist accounts inconsistent with each other on basic points. **Romila Thapar** points to the absence of archaeological evidence for widespread destruction in this period. **H. C. Raychaudhuri** argued the coup cannot be read as a religious uprising at all. Others, including **K. P. Jayaswal**, suggested that if there was repression it was aimed at Buddhist communities that were politically aligned with the Greeks — a security measure rather than a theological one.

There is also a dating problem inside the accusation itself. The bounty in the story is quoted in *dinaras* — a word that comes from the Roman *denarius* and does not enter Indian usage until centuries after 185 BCE. **The coin in the story had not been invented yet.** That does not prove the underlying memory false, but it does show the text being written a very long way downstream of the events.

Against that: the accusations are old, repeated, and specific about places. Something is being remembered.

The defensible position is that Pushyamitra was a Brahminical restorationist who revived the old royal sacrifices, that Buddhist tradition remembered his reign as hostile, and that the claims of mass destruction are not supported by anything in the ground. Anyone who states more than that in either direction is arguing about the present.

WHY PUSHYAMITRA SUCCEEDED

- **He already had the army.** The shortest route to a throne in a failing state is to be the person the soldiers already obey.
- **He restored the old rituals.** He performed the *ashvamedha*, the horse sacrifice — the ancient ceremony by which a king claims supremacy — which was both a religious act and a public announcement that the Mauryan experiment was over.
- **He fought the Greeks and could say so.** Kalidasa's play *Malavikagnimitra*, written centuries later, has his grandson **Vasumitra** defending the sacrificial horse against Yavana cavalry on the bank of a river called the Sindhu. Late evidence, but it shows what the dynasty was remembered for.

WHAT INDIA LOST IN THE COUP

- **The north-west, immediately.** The Shungas were a Ganges power. Punjab was not theirs and would not be Indian-ruled again for a long time.
- **The administrative machine.** The inspection tours, the edicts, the standardised provincial government — all of it goes, and nothing replaces it.
- **The idea of a single Indian state.** It does not seriously return until the Guptas, five hundred years later, and even then it does not cover Punjab.
- **And it created the vacuum that the rest of this part fills.** Four foreign dynasties walk through the door that opened in 185 BCE.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE IRONIC ONE

Ashoka's Great-Grandson and the Man on the Parade Ground

Two men stand on a parade ground in about 185 BCE.

One is the great-grandson — or thereabouts — of the emperor who published his own casualty figures and asked his descendants never to conquer anything again. He is reviewing an army he has inherited and does not command in any meaningful sense.

The other is the man who does command it.

There is a hard question underneath the scene, and this book is not going to pretend to answer it, because nobody honestly can. **Did the Mauryan empire fall partly because it had talked itself out of the business of force?**

It is an old argument. Nineteenth- and twentieth-century historians, some of them with obvious agendas, blamed Ashoka's pacifism for the collapse. Others have pointed out, correctly, that the empire survived him by nearly fifty years, that its actual problems were succession, distance and money, and that no ancient state that size lasted much longer anyway. Ashoka never dissolved his army — Rock Edict XIII warns forest peoples that the emperor still has power and expects them to behave.

What is not in doubt is the sequence, and the sequence is the story. **An emperor announces that conquest is not worth what it costs. Two generations later, his family is removed by the officer in charge of the army, at a parade, and within a few years foreign cavalry is back in the Punjab.**

Put those facts next to each other and resist the urge to draw the obvious moral. The obvious moral is the reason this period gets argued about so badly. But the facts are the facts, and they are in that order.

The Greeks Come Back — Demetrius Through the Passes

LIKELY

A hundred and forty years after Alexander's men refused to go on, their descendants came back down the same road — and this time they stayed for two centuries.

WON BY

Demetrius I of Bactria — who put an elephant's head on his own head

WHEN Roughly 200–180 BCE , accelerating after the Mauryan collapse in 185.	WHERE The Kabul valley, Arachosia, Gandhara, Taxila , the Indus and the western Punjab.
WHO Demetrius I , king of Bactria, son of Euthydemus, against whatever authority was left in the north-west.	THE EVIDENCE Overwhelmingly coins . A few lines in Strabo, Polybius and Justin. No battle account at all.

Who these Greeks were

Bactria — the country around Balkh in northern Afghanistan — had been settled with Greek colonists by Alexander and his successors. Around 250 BCE its governors broke away from the Seleucid empire and set up as independent kings. **Strabo says the Greeks who made Bactria revolt grew so powerful, because of the fertility of the country, that they became masters not only of Ariana but of India.**

These were not visitors. They had been in Central Asia for three or four generations, they spoke Greek and minted Greek coins and built Greek cities, and they were also thoroughly of that region. When Antiochus III came east in about 206 BCE and besieged Bactria, the settlement he reached included recognising the local dynasty and betrothing his daughter to a young prince, described by Polybius as a *neaniskos* — a youth.

That young man was **Demetrius**, and about fifteen years later he came through the passes into India.

What happened

1. **He takes the Kabul valley and Arachosia**, the very provinces Seleucus had signed over to Chandragupta in War Three. The 303 BCE settlement is undone.
2. **He comes down into Gandhara and the Indus country.** Taxila is taken; the coin finds there are extensive.

3. **The Mauryan collapse is the trigger.** Ancient and modern accounts agree that the destruction of the Mauryan dynasty by Pushyamitra is what opened the door. **India's first empire fell in 185 and Greek armies were in the Punjab within a few years.**
4. **A separate Indo-Greek kingdom emerges.** Within about twenty years there are Greek kings ruling from India rather than from Bactria — the first clearly being **Apollodotus I**, whose coins cluster in Gandhara and the western Punjab.
5. **And they start behaving like Indian kings almost immediately**, which is the theme of the rest of this part.

THE MOST HONEST SENTENCE ABOUT THE INDO-GREEKS

Something like **thirty to forty Greek kings and queens ruled in Bactria and north-western India across two centuries**, and the great majority of them are attested by nothing whatsoever except their coins. No history mentions them. No inscription names them. We know their faces, their titles and roughly when and where they ruled, and nothing else at all.

The chronology of the whole period has been reconstructed largely by numismatists — **Osmund Bopearachchi's** work is the standard — from coin styles, mint marks, overstrikes and hoard distributions. It is a genuine intellectual achievement and it is also, unavoidably, a scaffolding.

This means any date in this section may move. Where this part gives a year for an Indo-Greek king, read it as an estimate with a decade of give either side.

WHY THE GREEKS GOT BACK IN

- **The door was open.** The Mauryan frontier administration had gone and the Shungas were a Ganges power with no interest in the Indus.
- **They already held the far side.** Bactria is on the strong side of the passes — exactly the position that Part Five will show decides everything.
- **Cavalry and siegecraft.** Greco-Bactrian armies were technically sophisticated and had the Hellenistic world's engineering behind them.
- **They came as a kingdom, not a raid.** They founded cities, appointed governors and issued a currency. This was annexation from the start.

WHY NOBODY STOPPED THEM

- **There was no north-western state left to stop them.** Taxila had been an imperial province for a century and had no independent army of its own.
- **The Shungas had just fought a civil war.** A new dynasty consolidating in Bihar was not going to campaign on the Indus.
- **The republics were not yet reorganised.** The Yaudheyas and their neighbours are a factor again later in this part, but not in 185 BCE.
- **And the passes were unguarded.** This will be the last time this book says it politely.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Wore an Elephant

Pick up a silver coin of Demetrius I and look at the portrait, because it is one of the most deliberate images in ancient history.

He is shown wearing an **elephant's scalp as a headdress** — the animal's skin drawn over his head, with the trunk and tusks rising above his forehead and the ears framing his face.

This was not a fashion. It was a quotation, and every literate person in the Hellenistic world would have caught it instantly. **Alexander had been portrayed exactly this way after his Indian campaign**, and the elephant scalp meant one thing: *the conqueror of India*.

So here is a Greek king, born in Central Asia, four or five generations after Alexander, putting on the costume of a dead Macedonian to announce that he has done the thing Alexander's army refused to finish. It is the ancient equivalent of a man being photographed in someone else's uniform.

And the coins tell you the rest of the story too, if you keep looking. Within a generation or two, the coinage of his successors carries **Greek on one side and Kharoshthi on the other** — Indian script, Indian titles, Indian weight standards — and Indian gods start appearing on the reverse. One of Demetrius's own issues may already carry the goddess Lakshmi.

He arrived dressed as Alexander and his grandchildren were minting money for Indians to use, in the local script, with local gods on it. That is the four-hundred-year habit, visible on a piece of metal you could hold in one hand.

Menander of Sialkot Marches on Pataliputra

LIKELY

A Greek king ruling from Sialkot got further into India than Alexander ever did — and is remembered in India not as a conqueror but as a man who asked a monk what a chariot was.

WON BY Menander I — and then unwon by a civil war back home

WHEN Reigned roughly 165/155–130 BCE. Even the start of his reign is disputed by a decade.	WHERE Capital at Sagala — Sialkot. Territory from the Kabul river to the Ravi, and campaigns far to the east.
WHO Menander, known in Indian sources as Milinda, against the Shungas and whoever else stood in the way.	THE EVIDENCE An enormous coinage, two Indian literary references, a prophecy, and a Buddhist dialogue.

The march east

Three separate Indian sources describe Greek armies pushing deep into the Ganges plain in this period, and they are worth taking one at a time because they are very different kinds of evidence.

- 1. Patanjali, the grammarian, writing around 150 BCE.** In his *Mahabhashya* he needs examples of a particular past tense — the one used for recent events within the speaker’s own lifetime — and he reaches for two: “*arunad Yavanah Saketam*” and “*arunad Yavano Madhyamikam*”. “**The Yavana was besieging Saketa.**” “**The Yavana was besieging Madhyamika.**” This is a grammar textbook, which makes it almost uniquely valuable: nobody lies in a grammar example. He picked those sentences because his readers would recognise them as things that had just happened.
- 2. The Yuga Purana**, a strange short apocalyptic text. It says that after conquering Saketa, the country of the Panchalas and the Mathuras, the Yavanas — wicked and valiant — will reach Kusumadhvaja, which is Pataliputra; that on reaching its thick mud fortifications all the provinces will fall into disorder; and that a great battle will follow, fought with tree-like engines, meaning siege machinery.
- 3. Strabo, quoting Apollodorus**, says that more tribes were subdued by the Bactrian Greeks than by Alexander — **by Menander in particular** — if he really crossed the Hypanis, the Beas, and advanced eastward.

Notice that last conditional. Even the Greek source is hedging. But put the three together and the picture is consistent: **in the middle of the second century BCE, an army from Punjab under a Greek king went east and reached the gates of the Mauryan capital.** Alexander's men had turned back at the Beas. Menander's did not.

Why he did not stay

The *Yuga Purana* answers this, and it is one of the most quietly devastating passages in Indian literature. The Yavanas, it says, intoxicated with fighting, **will not remain in the Middle Country; there will be a civil war among them, arising in their own land, and there will be a terrible and ferocious war.**

That is exactly what happened, and it is the subject of the next war in this book. **The Greek advance into India was stopped by Greeks.**

THE STRONGEST OBJECTION, AND IT IS A SERIOUS ONE

The numismatist **Joe Cribb** has argued that there is no coin evidence for Menander east of Taxila, and that the Indian literary references to a march on Pataliputra may belong to somebody else entirely — possibly the Kushans, two centuries later, whose reach into the Ganges plain is much better attested.

That deserves to be taken seriously. Coins usually follow armies, and their absence is a real argument. Against it: Patanjali is contemporary, and a raid or a campaign does not always leave a mint behind it.

There is a further complication worth knowing. Some numismatists now think there were **two different Indo-Greek kings called Menander**, separated by decades, and that older accounts have merged them into one very long and very impressive reign.

The safe version: Greek armies from Punjab campaigned deep into northern India in the second century BCE; Menander was the most powerful Indo-Greek king; the association is likely but not proven.

WHY MENANDER WAS SO SUCCESSFUL

- **He ruled from inside India, not from Bactria.** Sagala is a Punjabi city on the Punjabi plain. His power base, his revenue and his recruits were all local.
- **He had the best coinage in the region**, and more of it than any other Indo-Greek king. A ruler who can pay reliably can campaign for decades.
- **He fought a Shunga state past its best.** Pushyamitra's dynasty had never recovered the reach of the Mauryas.
- **He was accepted by his Indian subjects.** His coins carry Kharoshthi legends and Indian royal titles, and Buddhist tradition adopted him outright. A foreign king who is not resented is a foreign king who can take his army far from home.

WHY IT DID NOT LAST

- **Civil war at home.** The Greek kingdoms spent the later second century BCE destroying each other, which is War Nine.
- **The line was too long.** Sialkot to Patna, held with a cavalry army, against a country that has depth. Everybody who tries this in this book fails at it.
- **No institution behind the man.** His kingdom fragmented on his death into a scatter of small realms, several ruled simultaneously.
- **And something worse was moving.** While the Greeks fought each other, the Sakas were coming off the steppe behind them.

What Is a Chariot?

Menander is one of very few foreign rulers in Indian history whom Indian tradition adopted rather than resented, and the reason is a book.

The *Milindapanha* — “The Questions of Milinda” — is a Buddhist text in Pali in which King Milinda, that is Menander, debates with a monk named **Nagasena**. It is a real classic of Buddhist literature, and its most famous passage is an argument about a vehicle.

The monk asks the king how he came. In a chariot, says Menander. So Nagasena asks him to point to the chariot. Is the axle the chariot? No. The wheels? No. The frame, the yoke, the reins, the goad? No, none of those. Then is the chariot something separate from all of them? No. Then, says Nagasena, **there is no chariot — “chariot” is only a word we use for a collection of parts assembled in a certain way.**

And then he turns it around, because the argument was never about transport. **In exactly the same way, he says, there is no permanent self called “Nagasena” — only a body, feelings, perceptions and thoughts, working together, and a name we give the arrangement.**

Menander, in the story, concedes the point and becomes a supporter of the faith.

Consider where this is set. **Sagala — Sialkot — in the second century BCE.** A Greek king, heir to the philosophical tradition of Athens, sitting in a Punjabi city arguing about the nature of the self with an Indian monk, in a debate that both sides thought worth writing down.

Plutarch adds the ending, and it is startling. When Menander died in camp, he says, the cities of his kingdom quarrelled over his remains, and the dispute was settled by **dividing his ashes equally so that each could carry a share away and raise a monument over it.**

That is precisely what Buddhist tradition says was done with the relics of the Buddha. **A Greek king from Punjab was buried like an Indian saint, and the man who recorded it was a Greek writer in Roman Boeotia who almost certainly had no idea what he was describing.**

The Greek Civil Wars — And the Chariot Through the Blood

LIKELY

Nobody defeated the Greeks in India. They spent sixty years defeating each other, and the last act was a son driving a chariot over his father's body.

WON BY Nobody at all — this is the war that destroys the winner

WHEN	WHERE
Roughly 170–130 BCE for the main phase, with fragmentation continuing for a century after.	Bactria, the Kabul valley, Gandhara and the Punjab — Greek against Greek, throughout.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Eucratides I against the house of Euthydemus and Demetrius; then everyone against everyone.	One lurid passage in Justin, and a vast confusing mass of coins.

What happened

- Eucratides seizes Bactria**, around 171 BCE, overthrowing the dynasty that Demetrius belonged to. He is competent, ruthless and successful, and he calls himself Eucratides the Great on his own coinage, which tells you something about him.
- He then invades the Indo-Greek kingdom.** The Greeks in India and the Greeks in Bactria — the same people, two generations apart — go to war with each other over the Kabul valley and Gandhara.
- He is besieged and survives it in a way that is barely credible.** Justin says that a king called Demetrius, ruler of the Indians, penned him in with sixty thousand men, and that Eucratides, **with a garrison of only three hundred soldiers, held out for four months by continual sallies** and escaped. Treat both numbers as literary. Treat the siege as real.
- He pushes into India as far as the Indus**, and holds ground there for a time before Menander takes much of it back.
- And then his own son murders him.** Returning from India, Justin says, **he was killed on the march by the son with whom he had shared his throne — a son who did not conceal the murder but drove his chariot through his father's blood and ordered the body to be thrown out unburied.**

6. **The Greek position never recovers.** Bactria falls to nomads within about fifteen years, and in India the Greek kingdoms fragment into a scatter of small realms ruling simultaneously in different valleys.

ON THAT MURDER STORY

Justin is a Roman epitomiser writing centuries later, summarising a lost work, and the passage is exactly the kind of thing a summariser keeps because it is memorable. The chariot detail is unverifiable.

What is verifiable is the outcome. **Eucratides' coinage stops abruptly around 145 BCE**, his successors are short-lived and confused, and the whole Greco-Bactrian kingdom collapses within about fifteen years of his death. Something violent happened at the top, and the numismatic record and the story agree on the date.

WHY THE GREEKS WERE UNBEATABLE — AND BEAT THEMSELVES

- **No Indian power could touch them for sixty years.** The Shungas could not reach the Indus, and the north-west had no state of its own.
- **Their military system was excellent.** Combined arms, good cavalry, real siege engineering, and disciplined infantry.
- **And every one of those advantages was turned inward.** The best army in the region spent two generations fighting the second-best army in the region, which was made of the same people.

WHY THEY DESTROYED THEMSELVES

- **No rule for the succession.** Hellenistic kingship went to whoever could take it. That is survivable in a large empire and lethal in a small one.
- **Two capitals, one people.** Bactria and India pulled in opposite directions and there was never a mechanism to decide between them.
- **They were a ruling class, not a population.** A few tens of thousands of Greeks governing millions of Indians and Bactrians. Split that class and there is no reserve.
- **They stripped the northern frontier to fight in the south.** Which is exactly when the nomads arrived — and that is War Ten.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Thirty Kings Who Left Nothing But Money

Here is the strangest fact in this entire book, and it belongs to the Indo-Greeks.

Somewhere between thirty and forty Greek monarchs ruled in Bactria and north-western India between about 250 BCE and the first century CE. We have their names. We have their portraits — realistic, individual portraits, in high-quality silver, showing men and at least one woman ageing across a reign, jaw by jaw and wrinkle by wrinkle. We know their royal titles: the Saviour, the Just, the Unconquered, the Victorious.

And for most of them, that is the entire historical record. Not one written source anywhere in the world mentions them. No chronicle, no inscription, no letter, no poem, no legend. They ruled Punjab and Gandhara, they raised armies, they fought, they lost, they died — and the only evidence that any of it happened is coins turned up by ploughs.

Whole reigns have been reconstructed from the mint marks on a few hundred pieces of silver. Wars are inferred from *overstrikes* — a coin of one king hammered flat and restruck with another king's face, which is what a conqueror does with the captured treasury of the man he has just beaten. **You can read the collapse of a dynasty in the fact that one man's portrait is showing faintly through the metal underneath another man's.**

Think about what that means for everything else in this book. These kings were not obscure. They were the government. They controlled Taxila and Sialkot and the Kabul valley in an age of literate, well-organised states — and they vanished so completely from the written record that we do not know what a single one of them did on a single day.

The winner is whoever gets written about. Menander is remembered because a monk wrote down an argument with him. The other thirty had no monk, and so they have faces and nothing else.

The Sakas Take Taxila

LIKELY

A migration two thousand miles away in the grasslands of Central Asia pushed one people into another until, several collisions later, Punjab had new masters.

WON BY **Maues and Azes — the Sakas, who India would call Scythians**

WHEN Roughly 90–20 BCE , the conquest spreading over two generations.	WHERE Gandhara, Taxila , the Punjab plain, and eventually down into Sindh and Gujarat.
WHO Maues , then Azes I , against the fragmented Indo-Greek kingdoms.	THE EVIDENCE Coins, a dated copper plate from Taxila, and the archaeology of the city itself.

Why they came

This is the first time in this book that a war in Punjab is caused by something happening in Mongolia, and it will not be the last.

Somewhere in the second century BCE, a people the Chinese called the **Yuezhi** were driven west out of the frontier country of China. They collided with the **Sakas** — the Central Asian people the Greeks called Scythians — and pushed them off their pastures. The Sakas moved south and west, into Bactria, and in about 130 BCE they finished off what the Greek civil wars had left of the Greco-Bactrian kingdom. The last Greek king in Bactria, Heliocles, disappears around then.

Having taken Bactria, they came down the passes.

Note the sequence carefully, because it is the mechanism behind half of this book. **Nomads move on the steppe. Two thousand miles away, a farmer in the Punjab has a new landlord.** The same chain of events will produce the Kushans in War Twelve and the Huns in Part Four.

What happened

1. **Maues takes Gandhara and Taxila**, some time around 90–80 BCE. He is the first Saka ruler in India whose coinage is substantial, and he adopts a title the Greeks would recognise and the Persians used: **King of Kings, the Great**. His coins carry it in Greek on one side and Kharoshthi on the other.

2. **We have a dated document.** A copper plate from Taxila, recording a Buddhist relic dedication by a man named **Patika**, is dated in the reign of the great king **Moga** — which is Maues. It is the sort of unglamorous administrative object that is worth more than a chronicle.
3. **Azes I finishes the job**, around the middle of the first century BCE, extinguishing most of what was left of Greek rule in the Punjab. An era beginning in **58/57 BCE** is associated with him, and its relationship to the later Vikrama era of Indian tradition has been argued over for a hundred and fifty years.
4. **They govern through satraps.** The Sakas brought with them the Persian provincial system, and the words come with it: *kshatrapa* and *mahakshatrapa*, satrap and great satrap. **These titles enter Indian political vocabulary here and stay for centuries.**
5. **And they patronise Buddhism heavily**, almost immediately. Saka officials and their families appear again and again in the north-west as donors to monasteries and stupas.

WHAT TAXILA LOOKED LIKE WHILE THIS WAS HAPPENING

Taxila is not one city but several, built beside each other over centuries, and the excavations let you walk from one conquest to the next.

The Indo-Greek city — **Sirkap** — is laid out on a grid, with a main street and regular blocks, in the standard Hellenistic town-planning pattern used from Sicily to Afghanistan. The Sakas moved in and lived in it. They did not raze it and start again; they repaired it, extended it, and put up their own religious buildings inside somebody else's street plan.

In one part of Sirkap stands a shrine known as the **double-headed eagle stupa**, and its decoration is the single best summary of this period in one object. The niches on it are framed in three completely different architectural styles at once: **a Greek pediment, a Persian arch and an Indian gateway, side by side on the same wall**, with a Central Asian bird on top.

Nobody designed that as a statement about cultural fusion. It is just what a builder in Taxila had in his pattern book.

WHY THE SAKAS WON

- **They arrived while the Greeks were fighting each other.** Sixty years of civil war had left a dozen small kingdoms where there had been one power.
- **Horse archers, in numbers.** The steppe military package — mobility, missile fire, and the ability to refuse battle — against static kingdoms.
- **They took the north side first.** Bactria before Gandhara, Gandhara before the plain. The same correct sequence Persia used in Part Two.
- **They kept the existing machinery.** Greek legends on the coins, existing cities, existing mints, existing officials. Continuity is cheaper than conquest.

WHY THE GREEKS IN INDIA ENDED

- **They had already spent themselves.** War Nine is the reason War Ten was easy.
- **They lost the reservoir.** Bactria was where Greek manpower came from. Once it was gone, the Indo-Greek kingdoms could not replace losses.
- **They were fighting the wrong direction.** The kingdoms in India were oriented east and south, towards each other and towards the Ganges, when the danger was behind them.
- **And they did not disappear so much as dissolve.** A handful of Greek kings hang on in eastern Punjab for decades afterwards; then the names stop appearing and the population simply becomes part of the north-west.

A Butterfly in Mongolia

Trace the chain backwards, because when you lay it out end to end it is genuinely astonishing.

A farmer somewhere near the Jhelum in about 80 BCE pays his taxes to a new official with an unfamiliar name and an unfamiliar accent. That is his whole experience of the event.

Behind that official is a Saka king who has taken Taxila. Behind the Saka king is the loss of the Bactrian pastures. Behind that is the arrival of the Yuezhi, pushed west off their own lands. And behind the Yuezhi is a war they lost, on the Chinese frontier, against a confederation called the **Xiongnu — a conflict fought roughly four thousand kilometres away by people who had never heard of the Punjab and would not have been able to place it on a map.**

The Chinese histories record the start of that chain in detail, because for them it was a border war. They have no idea what happened at the far end of it.

This is the thing to carry out of this war and into the rest of the book. **Punjab's history is not only made in Punjab.** The five rivers sit at the end of a very long corridor, and pressure applied anywhere along it eventually arrives here as cavalry.

You will see the mechanism again with the Kushans in two wars' time, and with the Huns in Part Four, and with the Mongols in Part Six. **Every one of those invasions starts as somebody else's problem, thousands of kilometres away, and ends as a change of government on the Jhelum.**

Gondophares and the Parthians

LIKELY

The third foreign dynasty in a century — and the one that ended up, improbably, in the Christian Bible stories.

WON BY The Indo-Parthians — for about one generation

WHEN Roughly 20–50 CE, with the dynasty lingering in pockets afterwards.	WHERE Sistan and Arachosia first, then Gandhara, Taxila and the western Punjab.
WHO Gondophares, against the late Saka rulers of the north-west.	THE EVIDENCE Coins, one dated stone inscription, and a Christian apocryphal text written in Syriac.

What happened

This is the shortest of the four conquests and the least consequential, so this part will not stretch it.

- 1. Parthian nobles from eastern Iran move east.** The Parthian empire that ruled Iran had a loose structure with powerful regional families, and one of them built a kingdom of its own in Sistan and Arachosia.
- 2. Gondophares takes Gandhara and Taxila** from the Sakas, some time in the first quarter of the first century CE, and rules from there.
- 3. We can date him, unusually precisely.** An inscription from **Takht-i-Bahi**, in the Peshawar country, is dated to the twenty-sixth year of Gondophares and to a year of a longer era, and this pair of numbers is one of the anchor points for the whole chronology of the region.
- 4. The kingdom does not survive him by much.** Within a generation the Kushans are coming down from Bactria, and the Indo-Parthian territories are absorbed.

WHY HE IS HERE AT ALL

Gondophares matters for this book for three reasons that have nothing to do with the size of his kingdom.

First, **he shows how fast the north-west changed hands** — Greek, Saka, Parthian and then Kushan inside about a hundred and fifty years, all ruling from the same cities and using the same mints.

Second, **his dated inscription is one of the few fixed points** in a period where almost every date is an estimate.

Third, and most unexpectedly, **his name travelled further than his kingdom ever did.**

WHY THE PARTHIANS TOOK IT

- **The Saka kingdoms had fragmented** into competing satrapies within two generations of conquering the place.
- **They came from the near side of the mountains**, from Sistan and Kandahar — a short campaign into a divided country.
- **They inherited rather than rebuilt.** Same cities, same coinage system, same administrative titles. The satrap system the Sakas introduced carried straight over.

WHY IT LASTED ONE GENERATION

- **It was one man's achievement.** The kingdom is essentially Gondophares, and it comes apart into local rulers after him.
- **It faced the wrong way.** Its centre of gravity was in Afghanistan, while the danger was gathering in Bactria to the north.
- **The Kushans were a different order of thing.** A unified confederation with the manpower of the whole Yuezhi migration behind it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE THAT GOT AWAY

STORY

The Palace in Heaven

There is a Christian text called the *Acts of Thomas*, written in Syriac probably in the third century CE, and its opening is set in India.

In it, the apostles divide up the world and India falls to **Thomas**, who does not want to go. He is effectively sold as a slave to a merchant acting for an Indian king, and taken east. The king's name, in the Syriac text, is **Gundaphar**.

The king wants a palace built and gives Thomas the money for it. Thomas, being an apostle rather than an architect, gives the money away to the poor over a period of months, and reports at intervals that the work is progressing well.

Eventually the king comes to inspect his palace and finds an empty field. Thomas tells him that the palace has been built, but that **he will not be able to see it in this life** — that it is waiting for him in heaven, paid for with what he gave away.

The king imprisons him. Then, in the story, the king's brother dies, is shown the palace in the next world, and comes back to report it — and Gundaphar is converted.

Now the reason this is in a book about the wars of Punjab. For centuries, **Gundaphar was assumed to be pure invention**, a made-up name in a made-up story. Then, in the nineteenth century, coins began turning up in the Punjab and Afghanistan bearing the name **Gondophares**, and an inscription was found at Takht-i-Bahi dated in his reign.

The king in the legend was a real king, ruling in the right region at roughly the right decade.

That does not make the story true. Nobody can show that Thomas went to India, and the palace is a parable that exists in other forms elsewhere. What it shows is something else, and it is the theme of this entire part: **first-century Punjab was connected to the wider world closely enough that its king's name was circulating in Syriac in the Middle East, attached to a story that people wanted to tell.**

Taxila in this century traded with Rome, took Chinese silk, used Greek script, prayed in Persian-arched Buddhist shrines and was ruled by an Iranian dynasty. Somebody, somewhere along that road, heard the name of the king of the Indians. It stuck.

The Kushans Take Everything

CERTAIN

The fourth and largest conquest — and the one that turned Punjab and Gandhara into the crossroads of the ancient world.

WON BY

The Kushans — who built the empire everyone else had failed to

WHEN

Roughly **30–150 CE**, from Kujula Kadphises to Kanishka.

WHERE

From Bactria and Kabul across Gandhara and the Punjab and deep into the Ganges plain.

WHO

Kujula Kadphises, then **Vima Kadphises**, then **Kanishka** — the greatest of them.

THE EVIDENCE

A vast coinage, the Chinese *Hou Hanshu*, and one inscription found in 1993 that rewrote the family tree.

Who they were

They were the Yuezhi — the people whose westward migration in War Ten had knocked the Sakas into India in the first place. Having taken Bactria, they settled there and split into five chiefdoms.

The Chinese *Hou Hanshu* tells the next part with admirable brevity. **The prince of the Guishuang — that is, the Kushan section — named Qiujiuque, attacked and destroyed the other four chiefs and made himself king.** Qiujiuque is **Kujula Kadphises**. The same passage says he then invaded Parthian territory, took the Kabul region, and died at over eighty years old.

That is one paragraph in a Chinese court history covering the birth of an empire that would rule from Central Asia to Bihar.

What happened

1. **Kujula unifies the Yuezhi and takes Kabul**, pushing the Indo-Parthians out of Gandhara.
2. **His successors take the Punjab and push east.** Vima Kadphises introduces a substantial **gold coinage** — the first large-scale gold currency India had seen, minted from the enormous flow of Roman gold coming in through the sea trade.

3. **Kanishka, from about 127 CE, is the peak.** He rules from **Purushapura — Peshawar**, with a second capital at Mathura, and his reach into India is far greater than any predecessor's in this part.
4. **And we know that because of the Rabatak inscription.** Found in Afghanistan in 1993, written in Bactrian in Greek script, it lists the cities and regions that submitted to Kanishka — including **Saketa, Kausambi, Pataliputra** and Champa. It also gives the Kushan royal genealogy in order, which settled arguments that scholars had been having for a century.
5. **Punjab is at the centre of it, not the edge.** This is the crucial point. Under the Kushans, the Peshawar valley and the Punjab plain are not a frontier province of a Ganges empire or a distant outpost of an Iranian one. **They are the imperial heartland.**

WHAT THAT MEANT ON THE GROUND

The Kushan empire sat astride the Silk Road at the point where four worlds met, and it taxed the traffic. The consequences show up everywhere in the archaeology of the north-west.

Roman gold coins arrive in quantity and are melted down for Kushan issues. **Chinese silk** passes through. Buddhist monasteries multiply across Gandhara on an enormous scale. And in the workshops of Gandhara, sculptors trained in a Greek tradition of drapery and anatomy begin carving Indian religious subjects — including, for the first time, **the Buddha as a human figure rather than as a symbol**. Be careful with that last claim, because it is one of the most argued-over questions in Indian art history: the Kushan-era workshops at **Mathura** have an equally strong claim to have got there first, and which school invented the Buddha image is not settled.

Kanishka's coinage is the clearest single window into the period. On the reverse, in Greek lettering, appear Iranian gods, Greek gods, Hindu gods — and the Buddha, labelled **BODDO**. **A Central Asian emperor ruling from Peshawar, minting coins in the Greek alphabet, in the Bactrian language, showing an Indian teacher, for a market that ran from Rome to China.**

WHY THE KUSHANS WON AND HELD IT

- **They unified before they invaded.** Kujula spent his career destroying his rivals among his own people first. Every other conqueror in this part invaded while still divided.
- **They held both sides of the passes.** Bactria and Gandhara under one crown, which is the combination Part Five will show decides everything.
- **They took the trade instead of just the land.** Their revenue came from taxing the traffic between empires, which is far more reliable than farming.
- **They sponsored everybody.** Buddhist, Iranian, Greek and Hindu cults all appear on their coins. A ruling house that endorses every god in its territory does not have a religious opposition.

WHY NOBODY COULD RESIST THEM

- **The north-west had been changing hands every forty years.** No local power had had time to build anything.
- **The Indo-Parthian kingdom was one man deep,** and he was dead.
- **The Ganges kingdoms were divided,** as they had been since the Shungas faded.
- **And the Kushans were not raiding.** They were a state — dated inscriptions, a gold currency, cities, a religious policy. Nothing in India at that moment was in the same category.

The Tallest Building in the World, at Peshawar

Kanishka built a stupa at his capital, and for centuries afterwards travellers who saw it could not stop talking about it.

Chinese pilgrims came through Peshawar over a period of five hundred years and each of them described it, and they do not agree about the height, because the thing burned down and was rebuilt more than once. The figures they give run into the hundreds of feet, and they describe a great tower on a stepped base topped with tiers of gilded copper discs. **Whatever the true dimensions, it was reckoned by people who had travelled from China across the whole of Asia to be the most impressive building they had seen anywhere on the journey.**

It was excavated at the start of the twentieth century, at Shah-ji-ki-Dheri outside Peshawar. The base alone is enormous. And in the ruins the excavators found a metal casket with an inscription naming Kanishka, containing bone fragments — presented as relics of the Buddha, and later sent to Burma.

Treat the identification of the relics with the caution it deserves. Treat the rest as solid.

Here is the point. **In the second century CE, the tallest and most famous building known to the travellers of Asia stood at Peshawar, and it was paid for by a Central Asian emperor as a monument to an Indian religion.**

Nothing about that sentence would have seemed odd at the time. That is what the four-hundred-year habit does when it is allowed to finish. The invader of 30 CE is, by 130 CE, the largest religious patron in India and the man Buddhist tradition would remember alongside Ashoka.

And two hundred years later, in Part Four, the whole of it — the stupa, the monasteries, the workshops, the city — is burned by the next people to come down the same road.

90 CE — The War Over a Marriage Proposal

LIKELY

Seventy thousand cavalry were sent across the highest mountains on earth because of a diplomatic insult, and they were beaten without a battle by a man who cut a supply line.

WON BY

Ban Chao of Han China — with a fraction of the men and no pitched battle at all

WHEN 90 CE.	WHERE The Tarim Basin, in what is now Xinjiang — reached from Gandhara across the Pamirs.
WHO The Kushan viceroy Xie against Ban Chao, the Han protector-general of the Western Regions.	THE EVIDENCE The <i>Hou Hanshu</i>, the official history of the Later Han. A single detailed account, from one side.

Why it happened

The Kushans had been useful allies. They had helped Han forces in Central Asia, and on that basis the Kushan king made a request that in his own world was entirely normal between allied powers: **he asked for a Han princess in marriage.**

Ban Chao refused, and detained the envoy who brought the request. In Chinese court terms, marrying a princess to a barbarian ruler on demand was a humiliation and a precedent. In Kushan terms, the refusal — with the envoy held — was a public insult from a partner.

The greatest empire in India and the greatest empire in East Asia went to war over a wedding that did not happen.

What happened

- The Kushans send an army over the Pamirs.** The *Hou Hanshu* gives the figure as seventy thousand cavalry under the viceroy Xie. Even discounted heavily, this is one of the most difficult marches ever attempted — the passes are among the highest used by any army in history, and there is nothing to eat on the way.
- Ban Chao refuses to fight.** Badly outnumbered, he ordered his troops to fortify, gather in supplies, and stay behind their defences. **He had grasped the one fact that decided everything: an army that has crossed**

the Pamirs cannot feed itself where it lands.

3. **The Kushan army starves.** Its supplies run down. It cannot storm the fortifications and it cannot forage a country that has been stripped.
4. **Xie sends for help.** He despatches messengers to the kingdom of Kucha, asking for supplies and support.
5. **Ban Chao is waiting for them.** He had anticipated the move, placed men on the route, and ambushed and killed the messengers.
6. **And then he makes his point.** He sent the evidence back to the Kushan commander so that Xie would know his message had been intercepted and no help was coming.
7. **The Kushans ask for terms.** Xie sent envoys to apologise and requested permission to withdraw. Ban Chao let the army go, and after this the Kushans resumed sending tribute missions to the Han court.

INTERROGATING THE NUMBERS, AND THE SOURCE

Seventy thousand cavalry across the Pamirs is not a plausible logistical proposition and should be read as “a very large army” written by the winning side. Horses need fodder daily and there is none at that altitude.

And the account comes entirely from the Chinese record, written to celebrate one of the Han dynasty’s most admired officers. There is no Kushan version. No Indian source mentions this war at all.

What supports it: the *Hou Hanshu* is a serious administrative history, not a legend collection, and it is precise about the diplomatic sequence in a way that fabrications usually are not. The tribute missions afterwards are recorded too. **The war happened, the Kushans lost it without a battle, and the number is advertising.**

WHY BAN CHAO WON

- **He refused the battle he was supposed to fight.** Outnumbered many times over, he made the engagement about supply instead of about combat.
- **He understood the enemy’s real problem.** The mountains had already done most of the work before the Kushans arrived.
- **He guarded the communications, not the front.** The whole campaign turned on one ambush on a road.
- **He let them go.** A destroyed army makes a permanent enemy; a released one makes a tributary. He got the second.

WHY THE KUSHANS LOST

- **They fought for prestige, not for anything they needed.** The war had no objective that could be captured.
- **They crossed the worst terrain on the planet to reach the fight.** Their army arrived already half beaten by the road.
- **Cavalry cannot besiege.** Faced with men behind walls who would not come out, the greatest mobile army in Asia had nothing to do.
- **They had one line of communication and did not protect it.** The single most avoidable mistake in the whole of this part.

The Only Time These Two Worlds Touched

In 90 CE, an army of the empire ruled from Gandhara and the Punjab fought an army of Han China. It is one of the very few direct military contacts between the Indian and Chinese worlds in the whole of ancient history, and almost nobody in either country has ever heard of it.

Think about what had to be true for it to happen. A Central Asian dynasty ruling from Peshawar had to be powerful enough to consider itself an equal of the Han. Chinese officials in the Tarim Basin had to be close enough to Gandhara to have an opinion about it. And both governments had to be running a diplomacy sophisticated enough for a marriage refusal to count as a national insult.

Punjab in the first century CE was not on the edge of anything. It was a great power, in correspondence with the other great powers, and it went to war with China the way France might go to war with Spain.

And here is the part that ought to stay with you. This is the highest point the north-west reaches in this entire book — the moment when the land of the five rivers is the centre of an empire that trades with Rome, argues with China, mints gold, and produces the sculpture that will define Buddhist art for two thousand years.

The defeat in 90 CE was not fatal. Kanishka's reign, the peak of Kushan power, comes a generation *after* it. But it is the first crack, and the next war is the second one.

From here, this part goes downhill, and the people who push it downhill are Punjabis.

The Republics Throw the Kushans Out

CERTAIN

After four hundred years of being conquered by everybody, the farmers of the plain organised themselves and removed the greatest empire in Asia.

WON BY

The Yaudheyas and the free peoples of the five rivers

WHEN

Building through the **second century CE**, decisive in the **third**, complete by about **250 CE**.

WHERE

The whole plain — Rohtak, the Sutlej–Yamuna country, Bahawalpur, the hills and the doabs.

WHO

The **Yaudheyas, Arjunayanas, Kunindas, Malavas and Audumbaras** against the Kushan empire.

THE EVIDENCE

Their own coins and seals — and, decisively, an inscription put up by an enemy.

Who these people were

They were the *gana-sanghas* — republics, run by assemblies of clan heads rather than kings, electing a war-leader when they needed one. You met them in Part Two, when the Malloi and Kshudrakas nearly killed Alexander. You met them again in War One of this part, supplying the manpower that made Chandragupta's empire possible.

They had been there the entire time. Under the Mauryas, the Greeks, the Sakas, the Parthians and the Kushans, the same communities kept farming the same land, kept their assemblies, and kept an armed population. Empires came and went above them.

And in the second and third centuries CE, they stopped putting up with it.

The inscription that proves it

The single best piece of evidence comes from an enemy, which is what makes it so good.

Around 150 CE, the Saka ruler **Rudradaman** — a great satrap in Gujarat, a descendant of the Saka conquerors of War Ten — had a long inscription carved on a rock at **Junagadh**. It is a boast, as these things are. And in the middle of the boast, he claims to have **destroyed the Yaudheyas by force**, and explains why that was worth mentioning: because they were **unwilling to submit, and were made proud by having manifested their title of heroes among all Kshatriyas**.

Read that again, because it is unusual. **This is a foreign ruler, on his own victory monument, pausing to explain that the people he beat were famous for refusing to submit and were rightly proud of it.** You do not write that about a minor tribe. You write it to make your own victory sound larger.

And he did not destroy them, because their coins carry on afterwards for another two hundred years.

What happened to the Kushans

1. **The empire was squeezed from the west.** In Iran, the Sasanian dynasty overthrew the Parthians in 224 CE and pushed east almost immediately, taking Bactria and eventually Gandhara. Part Four opens with that war.
2. **Which cut the Indian half off from the Central Asian half.** Kushan power depended on holding both ends of the trade route. Once the western end was gone, the eastern end was a rich province with no reinforcements.
3. **And the republics rose in the middle of it.** Yaudheya coinage of this period is abundant and confident, and it carries a legend that is a political statement: *Yaudheya-ganasya jaya* — **victory to the Yaudheya nation.** A seal from Bijaygarh calls them **the Yaudheyas who hold the spell of victory.**
4. **Others rose with them.** The Arjunayanas and the Malavas struck coins announcing their own victory in the same grammatical form. The Kunindas minted in the hills. **Across the whole plain, communities were putting the word for victory on their money at the same time.**
5. **By about 250 CE the Kushans are gone from the Punjab,** and a rump dynasty lingers around Mathura, minting worse and worse gold, until it disappears in the following century.

WHY THE REPUBLICS WON

- **They waited for the right moment.** Not in Kanishka's reign. They moved when Persia had cut the empire in half.
- **Every man was already a soldier.** There was no army to raise. A republic of armed farmers does not need to mobilise; it only needs to decide.
- **They could not be decapitated.** There was no king to kill and no capital to take. This is the exact opposite of every other polity in this part, all of which died when one man did.
- **They had outlasted five empires already.** Persistence is a strategy, and it had been working for six hundred years.

WHY THE KUSHANS COULD NOT HOLD

- **Two fronts, one army.** Sasanian Persia in the west and rebellion in the east at the same time.
- **Their empire was a trade route.** Cut it in Bactria and the whole revenue model collapses.
- **Their capital faced the wrong way.** Peshawar is superb for an empire that spans the passes and fatal for one that has lost the far side.
- **And nobody came to help them.** They had become an Indian dynasty, and it did not save them — which is the last note this part will sound.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE THIS PART HAS BEEN BUILDING TO

Victory to the Nation

Four hundred years, and look at what has passed over this ground.

Macedonian garrisons. A Mauryan emperor with a bureaucracy and inspection tours. A Greek king in an elephant-skin hat. Another Greek king arguing about chariots with a monk in Sialkot. Saka satraps. An Iranian dynasty whose king's name reached Syriac scripture. A Kushan emperor who put the Buddha on gold coins and fought China.

Every one of them ruled from a capital and issued money with a face on it — *his* face, *his* title, *his* claim. That is what a coin was for.

And then, at the end of this part, the coins in the soil of Rohtak and Ludhiana and Bahawalpur start saying something different. No portrait that matters. No king. Six words of Brahmi: ***Yaudheya-ganasya jaya***.

Victory to the Yaudheya nation. Not to a man. To the assembly, to the *gana*, to the people who voted.

We do not know the name of a single Yaudheya leader. Not one. There is no Yaudheya chronicle, no epic, no capital we can point to with confidence, no monument. They were beaten by Rudradaman and carried on; they were ruled by Kushans and carried on; and when the moment came, they threw out the largest empire in Asia and went back to farming.

They are, on the evidence, one of the longest-lived political communities in Indian history — and their entire surviving voice is one word, stamped in copper, hundreds of thousands of times, and dropped in the dirt.

Every empire in this part wrote its name on something expensive. The people who outlasted all of them wrote theirs on the cheapest object they had, and it is the one you can still pick up in a ploughed field.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

c. 322–317 BCE	Chandragupta clears out the Macedonian garrisons. Alexander's satraps are killed or withdraw west to fight each other. Won by Chandragupta Maurya.
c. 322–320 BCE	The Nanda war. Beaten attacking the centre, Chandragupta starts again from the edges and takes Pataliputra. Won by Chandragupta.
305–303 BCE	Seleucus invades and settles. Four provinces to India, five hundred elephants to Seleucus, and a marriage treaty. Won by Chandragupta — possibly without a battle.
301 BCE	The Punjab elephants win the Battle of Ipsus in Turkey and decide who inherits Alexander's empire.
c. 272 BCE onward	Taxila revolts twice. The complaint both times is the imperial officials, not the emperor. Won by the Mauryas — the first time by negotiation.
c. 261 BCE	The Kalinga war — and Ashoka's remorse, carved afterwards on rocks at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in Kharoshthi, and at Kandahar in Greek and Aramaic.
c. 185 BCE	Pushyamitra kills the last Mauryan emperor at a military parade. The empire ends and the north-west is left open. Won by the Shungas.
c. 200–180 BCE	Demetrius comes back through the passes, taking Kabul, Gandhara and Taxila, and wearing Alexander's elephant scalp on his coins. Won by the Greeks.
c. 165–130 BCE	Menander of Sagala — Sialkot — marches east to Saketa, Mathura and the walls of Pataliputra. Won by Menander, then given back.
c. 170–145 BCE	The Greek civil wars. Eucratides seizes Bactria, invades India, and is murdered by his own son, who drives a chariot through his blood. Won by nobody.
c. 130 BCE	The last Greek king of Bactria disappears. The Sakas take the country north of the passes.
c. 90–20 BCE	Maues and Azes take Taxila and the Punjab. The satrap system enters Indian government. Won by the Sakas.
c. 20–50 CE	Gondophares and the Indo-Parthians take Gandhara — and the king's name ends up in a Syriac gospel legend. Won by the Parthians, for one generation.
c. 30–80 CE	Kujula Kadphises unites the Yuezhi and takes Kabul and Gandhara. Won by the Kushans.
90 CE	The Kushan–Han war. Seventy thousand cavalry sent over the Pamirs over a refused marriage, and starved out without a battle. Won by Ban Chao.

c. 127–150 CE	Kanishka rules from Peshawar , the Rabatak inscription lists his Indian conquests, and Gandharan art gives the Buddha a human face.
c. 150 CE	Rudradaman claims to have destroyed the Yaudheyas — “unwilling to submit, proud of their title of heroes among the Kshatriyas.” He had not.
c. 224–250 CE	Sasanian Persia cuts the Kushan empire in half, and the republics of the plain throw out what is left. Won by the Yaudheyas and the free peoples of Punjab.
c. 250 CE	The Kushan century ends. <i>Part Four begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Four

1. **Punjab digests its conquerors.** This is the defining pattern of Part Three and it does not survive Part Four, which is why it matters. Greeks, Sakas, Parthians and Kushans all arrive as foreigners and all become Indian within two or three generations — Indian scripts on their coins, Indian gods on the reverse, Indian titles, Indian religious patronage. **The question to carry forward is why this stops working.**
2. **Punjab’s wars are started somewhere else.** A defeat on the Chinese frontier pushes the Yuezhi west, which pushes the Sakas south, which changes who collects tax on the Jhelum. Nothing in that chain has anything to do with Punjab. You will watch the identical mechanism produce the Kidarites and the Huns in Part Four, and the Mongols in Part Six.
3. **Whoever holds both sides of the passes holds everything.** The Kushans are the great success of this part and they are the only power in it that ruled Bactria and Gandhara together. The moment Persia takes the far side, the Indian half falls within a generation. **This is the single most reliable rule in the entire book** and Part Five is built on it.
4. **Kill the king, end the state.** The Nandas, the Mauryas, Eucratides’ kingdom, Gondophares’ kingdom — every monarchy in this part dies with one man. The one polity that cannot be decapitated is the republic, because there is no head. **The Yaudheyas outlast every empire in these four hundred years by having nobody important in them.**
5. **The winner is whoever gets written about.** Thirty-odd Greek kings ruled here and left nothing but their faces on silver. Menander survives because a monk wrote down an argument. The Yaudheyas survive because they stamped one word on a great deal of copper. **In Part Four this problem becomes total: not one contemporary Punjabi account survives of any war in that entire chapter.**

COMING NEXT — PART FOUR

The Guptas and the Huns, 250–650 CE. Sasanian Persia takes Gandhara and finishes the Kushans. For a hundred years the republics of the plain govern themselves — the longest stretch of self-rule Punjab gets between Alexander and Ranjit Singh — until Samudragupta arrives at the frontier and takes their submission on paper. Then the passes open again, and keep opening: the Kidarites, then Toramana and Mihirakula of the Alchon Huns, ruling the Punjab from Sialkot. Skandagupta stops them once and it breaks his empire. A king nobody remembers breaks them for good at Sondani. And by the end of it, Taxila — the city that has been in every part of this book so far — is a field of mounds, and stays one.

Words Used in This Part

Yavana / Yona

The Indian word for Greeks, from “Ionian”. It later broadens to mean any westerner. When a Sanskrit text says *Yavana*, ask which century before assuming it means Greek.

Gana / gana-sangha

A republic — a state run by an assembly of clan heads rather than a hereditary king. The Yaudheyas, Malavas, Arjunayanas and Kunindas were all of this type.

Kshatrapa / mahakshatrapa

Satrap and great satrap — provincial governor titles brought into India by the Sakas from the Persian system. Rudradaman was a mahakshatrapa.

Ashvamedha

The horse sacrifice. An ancient royal ritual in which a horse wanders for a year, escorted by an army, and any king who stops it must fight. Pushyamitra revived it.

Arthashastra

The manual of statecraft traditionally attributed to Chanakya. Cold, practical and detailed. Its *mandala* theory is the “eat from the edges” principle written as doctrine.

Mudrarakshasa

A Sanskrit play about Chanakya’s political manoeuvring after Chandragupta’s victory. Written centuries later; the source of much of the popular Chanakya legend.

Ashokavadana

A Buddhist collection of legends about Ashoka, written down centuries after him. The source for the Taxila revolts and the blinding of Kunala. Devotional, not documentary.

Kharoshthi

The right-to-left script of the north-west, derived from Aramaic. Ashoka’s Gandhara edicts are in it, and so are the Indian sides of Indo-Greek and Saka coins.

Dhamma

The Prakrit form of *dharma*. In Ashoka’s edicts it means something like right conduct — a public ethic rather than a specific religion.

Sagala

Ancient **Sialkot**. Capital of Menander; and later of the Hun king Mihirakula in Part Four.

Takshashila

Taxila. The great city of the north-west — Persian province, Greek prize, Mauryan trouble spot, and the place four dynasties in this part chose to rule from.

Sirkap

The Indo-Greek city at Taxila, laid out on a Hellenistic grid and then lived in by Sakas, Parthians and Kushans in turn.

Milindapanha

“The Questions of Milinda.” The Pali dialogue between King Menander and the monk Nagasena. A classic of Buddhist philosophy set in Punjab.

Yuga Purana

A short apocalyptic Sanskrit text that describes the Yavana advance on Pataliputra as prophecy. Contested as a source, and the only Indian account of that campaign.

Mahabhashya

Patanjali’s great commentary on Sanskrit grammar, around 150 BCE. Its examples accidentally record the Greek sieges of Saketa and Madhyamika as recent events.

Yuezhi

The Central Asian people, displaced from the Chinese frontier, whose migration pushed the Sakas into India — and who later became the Kushans themselves.

Hou Hanshu

The official history of the Later Han dynasty. Our main source for Kujula Kadphises and for the Kushan–Han war of 90 CE.

Rabatak inscription

A Bactrian-language inscription in Greek script, found in Afghanistan in 1993, giving Kanishka’s conquests and the Kushan royal genealogy. It settled arguments a century old.

Overstrike

A coin hammered flat and restruck with a new ruler’s design. Since the old image often shows through, overstrikes let numismatists reconstruct wars nobody wrote down.

Sources used for this part

- Justin, *Epitome of Pompeius Trogus*, Books XV and XLI — for Chandragupta, Seleucus and Eucratides
- Appian, *Syrian Wars*; Strabo, *Geography*, Books XI and XV; Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*; Orosius — for the Seleucid–Mauryan settlement
- Polybius, Book XI, for Antiochus III in Bactria and the young Demetrius
- Megasthenes, *Indika*, surviving in fragments quoted by later writers
- The rock edicts of Ashoka — Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in Kharoshthi, Girnar, Dhauli and Jaugada, and the Greek and Aramaic inscriptions from Kandahar
- Patanjali, *Mahabhashya*; the *Yuga Purana* (John Mitchiner’s translation); the *Hathigumpha* inscription of Kharavela
- *Milindapanha*, in the Rhys Davids translation
- The *Ashokavadana*, in John S. Strong’s translation; Bana, *Harshacharita*; Kalidasa, *Malavikagnimitra*
- The Taxila copper plate of Patika; the Takht-i-Bahi inscription of Gondophares; the Rabatak inscription of Kanishka; the Junagadh rock inscription of Rudradaman (Kielhorn’s translation)
- The *Hou Hanshu*, chapter on the Western Regions, in John Hill’s translation
- The *Acts of Thomas*, for the Gundaphar legend
- John Marshall, *Taxila* (1951), for Sirkap and the archaeology of the north-west
- Osmund Bopearachchi on Indo-Greek and Bactrian coinage; Joe Cribb on Kushan and Indo-Greek numismatics
- John D. Grainger on the Seleucid–Mauryan war; Étienne Lamotte, Romila Thapar, H. C. Raychaudhuri and K. P. Jayaswal on Pushyamitra and the persecution question

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions in this part are unusually numerous. They include: whether Chandragupta's *latrones* were bandits or mercenaries; whether the Seleucid–Mauryan war involved a battle at all; almost every date in the Indo-Greek sequence; whether there were one or two kings called Menander; whether Menander's army really reached Pataliputra; how much of the Ashokavadana preserves anything historical; the scale and reality of Pushyamitra's persecution of Buddhists; and the precise chronology of the Kushan kings, which the Rabatak inscription improved but did not settle.

Two warnings in particular. First, the chronology of the Indo-Greeks is a numismatic reconstruction, not a record. It is careful and impressive work, and it is still an inference. Any date given here for a Greek king may move by a decade in either direction, and some of the kings may need to swap places.

Second, and more important: **almost nothing in this part was written by anyone who lived in Punjab.** The Greek and Roman writers were working at second and third hand, centuries later, from lost books. The Chinese histories are excellent and are looking at India from the side. The Buddhist texts are teaching, not reporting. The Sanskrit sources that mention these events are mostly later, and one of the most important of them is a grammar textbook that recorded a siege by accident.

What Punjab itself left behind from these four hundred years is coins. Hundreds of thousands of them, honest about who was in charge and silent about everything else — and, at the very end, a copper coin with no king on it that says *victory to the nation*.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART FOUR OF SIXTEEN

The Guptas and the Huns

Four hundred years in which India had a golden age and Punjab was not invited to it — invaded from the passes wave after wave, until a king almost nobody remembers finally broke the worst man in this book.

C. 250 CE — 650 CE

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Golden Age That Happened Somewhere Else

Every Indian schoolbook calls this the classical age — poetry, mathematics, the zero, Kalidasa, temples. Almost none of it happened in Punjab. Punjab spent these four hundred years being fought over.

There is a habit in Indian history writing that this part has to break before it can start.

The period from about 320 to 550 CE is normally told as the story of the Gupta empire — a settled, wealthy, confident state on the Ganges, with a court that produced some of the finest work in Sanskrit and some of the best mathematics on earth. That is all true. It is also a story about a different part of India. **The Guptas never really ruled Punjab.** They touched it, listed it, taxed parts of it on paper, and fought on its edge. They did not govern it the way they governed Magadha or Malwa.

What actually happened on the five rivers between 250 and 650 CE is a completely different story, and a harder one. It goes like this. The Kushan empire that ended Part Three dies. For about a hundred years, the old armed republics of the plain govern themselves again — the only long stretch of self-rule Punjab gets between Alexander and Ranjit Singh. Then the passes open, and they keep opening: the Kidarites, then the Alchon Huns under Toramana and Mihirakula, then a long slow fragmentation. By the time the period ends, the Buddhist civilisation of Taxila and Gandhara — one of the great cultures of the ancient world, four centuries in the building — has been physically destroyed and never comes back.

Four things you need to hold in your head

- **“Huna” is not one people.** Indian sources use the single word *Huna* for at least two, probably three, different groups arriving over 150 years — Kidarites, then Alchon, with Hephthalites next door. They were not the Huns of Attila, though they were relatives and rivals of the same broad Central Asian world. When a Sanskrit inscription says Huna, treat it like the word “foreigner”: accurate about the direction they came from, useless about who exactly they were.
- **Punjab in this period is written about almost entirely by outsiders.** Our sources are a Persian king’s cliff inscription, Chinese pilgrims and envoys, victory pillars set up in Madhya Pradesh, and a Kashmiri poet writing six hundred years later. **What survives from inside Punjab is a handful of stones — the most important of them a monastery dedication in the Salt Range, dated by the reign of a Hun king, which describes no event at all.** Not one narrative account written in Punjab about any of these wars survives. That absence is the single biggest fact in this part.
- **Coins do a lot of the work here.** When there are no chronicles, money becomes the record. Who struck it, in whose name, in what metal, and how badly — that is how we date the arrival and departure of whole dynasties. You will see coins used as evidence on nearly every page.
- **This is the period Gandhara dies.** Taxila, the great university city of Part Two and Part Three, is a ruin by the end of it, and stays a ruin. That is not a footnote. It is the largest single loss in the whole book.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

Same three as before. **CERTAIN** means contemporary evidence — an inscription carved at the time, a coin, or an eyewitness. **LIKELY** means it is reported by good sources writing later and most historians accept it. **STORY** means legend or a much later tradition, which may have a real war underneath it.

Part Four is unusually lopsided. Several of these wars are known from a single carved stone, which makes the *fact* of the war certain and everything else guesswork. Others are known only from a poet writing after six hundred years. You will see both labels used honestly, sometimes in the same war.

Persia Takes Peshawar — The Quiet End of the Kushans

LIKELY

A superpower swallowed the north-west and left one sentence about it, carved on a wall in Iran.

WON BY

Sasanian Persia — in a war nobody described

WHEN Roughly 230–270 CE , in two pushes a generation apart.	WHERE Bactria, the Kabul valley, Gandhara, and the Indus — the country just west and north of the Punjab plain.
WHO Ardashir I and his son Shapur I of Persia, against the last strong emperors of the Kushan house.	THE EVIDENCE One enormous royal inscription, and several thousand coins. No battle account of any kind.

Why it happened

Part Three ended with the Kushan empire cracking — beaten in the north-west by the Han Chinese, and then having its Punjab provinces pulled away by the armed republics of the plain. An empire in that condition is a target.

At exactly that moment, Iran changed hands. In 224 CE a provincial nobleman named **Ardashir** destroyed the Parthian empire that had ruled Iran for four centuries and founded a new dynasty, the **Sasanians** (the ruling family of Persia from 224 to 651 CE). New dynasties need victories, urgently, because a new dynasty is just a successful rebellion until it wins a war somebody else recognises.

Ardashir looked east and saw a rich, tired empire sitting on the road to India. **The Kushans had spent two hundred years advertising their wealth in gold coinage. That advertisement worked exactly as well as you would expect.**

What happened, as far as we can tell

1. **Ardashir moves east, some time in the 230s.** He takes Sistan, Merv, Balkh and Khwarezm — the whole northern approach. The Arab historian **Tabari**, writing about seven hundred years later, says that after this the

kings of the Kushans, of Turan and of Makran sent envoys to him offering submission. Seven hundred years is a long gap. Treat it as a memory, not a report.

2. **Shapur I finishes the job, some time between 240 and 270.** Shapur was one of the most successful soldiers of the ancient world — the man who captured a Roman emperor alive. His eastern campaign is not described anywhere. We only know its result.
3. **The result is carved on the Ka'ba-ye Zartosht.** On the wall of a stone tower at Naqsh-e Rostam in Iran, Shapur had a long inscription cut in three languages, listing what he ruled. The list includes **Hindustan**, and **"Kushanshahr up to Peshawar"**, and on to the borders of Kashgar, Sogdia and Tashkent. This is a contemporary document written on the winner's orders. On its own terms it is **CERTAIN**.
4. **Persia installs governors and calls them Kushan kings.** The men Persia put in charge of the east took the title *Kushanshah* — "King of the Kushans" — and struck coins in the old Kushan style, same shape, same script, same standing king at a fire altar, with the Persian god Ahura Mazda quietly swapped in. Modern historians call them the **Kushano-Sasanians**.
5. **A rump Kushan state survives in the east.** Around Mathura, and probably in parts of the Punjab plain, later Kushan kings — Vasudeva II, Shaka, Kipunada — keep minting into the middle of the fourth century, almost certainly as somebody's dependants. Then they stop, and the Kushan name disappears from India for good.

WHAT "UP TO PESHAWAR" DOES AND DOES NOT MEAN

Shapur's inscription is a claim of overlordship, not a map of occupied territory, and the phrase stops at Peshawar. There is **no evidence at all** that a Sasanian army fought on the Punjab plain, crossed the Jhelum, or garrisoned anything east of the Indus. What Persia took was the mountain approach and the river frontier — the doorway, not the house.

That distinction matters for the rest of this part. **Whoever holds Gandhara and the Kabul valley can enter Punjab whenever they like.** From 250 CE onwards, that doorway is almost always in foreign hands.

WHY PERSIA WON

- **They picked their moment.** They attacked an empire that had already lost its Chinese war and its Indian provinces. Nobody in Iran had to beat the Kushans at their best.
- **They came from the strong side.** Persia's power base in Iran sat directly against Bactria, the Kushan empire's richest and most exposed half.
- **They took the passes first.** Sistan, Merv, Balkh, Khwarezm — the whole northern arc — before touching Gandhara. Standard practice for anyone competent, and almost nobody in this book does it.
- **They did not try to govern India.** They installed governors under a local-sounding title, kept the existing coinage and left the machinery alone. Cheap, and it worked for a century.

WHY THE KUSHANS LOST

- **Two fronts, one army.** They were being pulled apart by Persia in the west and by the Yaudheyas and their neighbours in the east at the same time.
- **Their empire was a trade route, not a country.** Kushan wealth came from the Silk Road caravans. Cut the road in Bactria and the whole structure starves.
- **Their capital was in the wrong place.** Purushapura — Peshawar — sits right at the mouth of the passes. Excellent for an empire that faces both ways. Fatal when the west turns hostile.
- **Nobody in India came to help.** The Kushans were foreign rulers who had become Indian. When the crisis came, they were still foreign enough that no Indian power fought for them.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

You Can Watch an Empire Die in the Metal

We have no account of the Kushan collapse. What we have instead is their money, and it tells the story better than a chronicle would.

Start with a gold coin of **Kanishka**, around 130 CE. It is heavy, it is nearly pure gold, and the design is confident: the emperor standing in a heavy coat and felt boots, sacrificing at an altar, with a god on the back and clean lettering all around.

Now put next to it a gold coin of **Kipunada**, one of the last Kushan kings, around 350 CE. It is the same design. It is meant to be the same coin. But the gold has been cut with so much base metal that it is pale, the weight has dropped, the die has been copied from a copy from a copy, and the king's face has degraded into a few scratched lines. **The lettering has become a pattern that imitates lettering. The mint no longer employed anyone who could read it.**

Nobody wrote down the fall of the Kushan empire. Nobody needed to. Two hundred years of decline sit in a coin tray, in order, in metal you can weigh — an empire that kept making the same promise on the same coin long after it had stopped being able to keep it.

The Free Century — When Punjab Governed Itself

LIKELY

The longest stretch of self-rule between Alexander and Ranjit Singh, and it has no chronicle, no king list, and no name.

WON BY

The republics of the plain — Yaudheyas, Madrakas, Kunindas, Audumbaras, Trigartas

WHEN Roughly 250–350 CE, between the fall of the Kushans and the arrival of the Guptas.	WHERE The whole plain: Rohtak and the Sutlej–Yamuna country, Sialkot, the Kangra hills, the Beas–Ravi doab, Bahawalpur.
WHO Half a dozen <i>gana-sanghas</i> (tribal republics — states run by an assembly of clan heads, not a king).	THE EVIDENCE Almost entirely coins and clay seals. No history of these states was ever written.

Why this counts as a war

Because you cannot get from “Kushan province” to “independent republic minting its own money” without fighting, and Part Three ended with exactly that fight — the revolt that threw the Kushans out of the plain.

What we have here is the aftermath, and the aftermath lasted about a hundred years. **For roughly four generations, no empire ruled Punjab.** The land of the five rivers was governed by its own people, in its own way, using a political system that had already been old when Alexander met it: the republic, run by an assembly, electing a war-leader when it needed one.

And we know almost nothing about it, because the men who governed it were not in the habit of carving their achievements into rock.

Who these people were

- The Yaudheyas.** The biggest and most militant. Their country ran from around Rohtak across the Sutlej–Yamuna plain and down into Bahawalpur. Their coins carry the legend *Yaudheya-ganasya jaya* — “victory to the Yaudheya nation” — and the god Karttikeya, the god of war, on the front. A clay sealing found at Bijaygarh calls them “**the Yaudheyas who hold the spell of victory.**”

2. **The Madrakas.** The people of Madra, around **Sakala** — **modern Sialkot**. You met their city in Part Three as the capital of the Greek king Menander. It is about to become the capital of a Hun.
3. **The Kunindas.** The Sivalik foothills and the upper Yamuna–Sutlej valleys, minting handsome silver coins in the name of a ruler called Amoghabhuti.
4. **The Audumbaras** in the Beas–Ravi country around Pathankot, **the Trigartas** in the Jalandhar doab and Kangra, and **the Arjunayanas** and **Malavas** to the south-east. Several of these names are still on the map, if you know how to look — Trigarta is Kangra, Jalandhara is Jalandhar.

WHY COINS ARE THE WHOLE ARGUMENT

A state that mints coins in its own name is claiming sovereignty. It is a public statement, in metal, that says: *we tax here, we decide value here, nobody above us*. When you find Kushan coins in the Punjab plain up to about 250 CE, then Yaudheya coins in the same soil for the next century, then Gupta coins after that, you are reading a change of government even though nobody wrote one down.

The limits are real too. Coins do not give you dates, battles, leaders, or borders. They tell you **that** Punjab was independent. They cannot tell you how it fought for it.

WHY THE REPUBLICS WON

- **They only had to beat a corpse.** The Kushan state in Punjab had been cut off from Bactria by the Persians. Its garrisons were on their own.
- **They were already armed.** These were societies where the clan and the militia were the same thing. There was no army to raise — the population was the army.
- **Nobody else wanted the job.** Persia stopped at Peshawar; the Guptas had not been invented yet. For a century there was simply no empire able to come.
- **They had beaten empires before.** The Yaudheyas had survived being crushed by Rudradaman in the second century, as his own inscription boasts. Survival is a habit.

WHY THEY LOST IT AGAIN

- **Six republics, six armies.** They never merged. Each was strong enough to defend itself and none was strong enough to defend the region.
- **No permanent command.** An assembly that elects a war-leader for a crisis is excellent at repelling a raid and hopeless at fighting a ten-year campaign.
- **They did not fortify the passes.** Not one of these states put a garrison in the Khyber or the Kabul valley. They defended their own fields and left the doorway open.
- **They wrote nothing down.** Which cost them nothing militarily and cost them everything historically. We remember the men who beat them.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

A Nation That Signed Its Name on Money

There is no Yaudheya chronicle. No king list. No capital we can point to with confidence. No temple with their name on it, no poem, no epic, no tomb.

What there is, is copper. Thousands of small copper coins, turned up by ploughs and canal-diggers across Rohtak, Ludhiana, Sonapat and Bahawalpur for two hundred years, each one carrying six words of Brahmi script: ***Yaudheya-ganasya jaya*** — victory to the Yaudheya nation.

Not victory to the king. There was no king. **Victory to the nation** — to the *gana*, the assembly, the people who voted. In an age when every other state in India was announcing the personal glory of a named man, the Yaudheyas were stamping a collective noun onto their money.

They did it for four hundred years, through the Kushans, through the Guptas, until the Huns came and the coins stop. They are one of the longest-lived political communities in Indian history, and we do not know the name of a single one of their leaders.

They were not silent. They just wrote on the smallest surface available, in the largest possible number of copies, and trusted the ground to keep it. It worked.

Samudragupta Comes to the Frontier — And Stops

CERTAIN

The greatest conqueror of the age reached the edge of Punjab, took its submission on paper, and went home.

WON BY

Samudragupta — on parchment, possibly without a battle

WHEN

Somewhere in **c. 350–375 CE**. The inscription carries no date, which is itself annoying.

WHERE

The south-eastern edge of the Punjab plain and the desert margin — Yaudheya, Madraka, Arjunayana and Malava country.

WHO

Samudragupta of the Gupta empire, against the republics; and, at a distance, the Kushan and Saka rulers of the far north-west.

THE EVIDENCE

One inscription, composed by the king's own war minister; carved on a pillar Ashoka had put up six hundred years earlier.

Why it happened

Samudragupta, who ruled from about 335 to 375 CE, is the man who turned the Guptas from a regional dynasty into an empire. His method, described in his own record, was blunt and clever at the same time: **in the Ganges plain he destroyed kings and annexed their land; everywhere else he beat people and gave the land back.**

That second policy is the whole explanation for what happens in Punjab. The north-west was not worth occupying. It was far away, it was full of armed farmers who had just spent a century proving they could throw out an empire, and beyond it sat a frontier that would need permanent defending. **What Samudragupta wanted from Punjab was a quiet flank and a tribute payment.** He got both, and the record says so.

What the pillar says

The Allahabad pillar inscription — the *prashasti* (a formal praise-poem in verse and prose, carved in stone) — was composed by a court official named **Harishena**, whose titles included *Sandhivigrahika*, minister of peace and war. He was, in modern terms, the foreign minister writing the press release.

Its Punjab passage lists the frontier peoples who submitted. Among them: **the Malavas, the Arjunayanas, the Yaudheyas, the Madrakas**, the Abhiras, the Prarjunas, the Sanakanikas, the Kakas and the Kharaparikas. What they did, in the inscription's own words, was give **"all kinds of taxes, obey orders, and perform obeisance."**

Then it goes further out, to the powers beyond the Indus. The **Daivaputra-Shahi-Shahanushahi** — that is the old Kushan royal title, *devaputra shahi shahanushahi*, "son of heaven, king, king of kings", so it means the Kushan or Kushano-Sasanian ruler of the north-west — and the **Saka** lords are said to have offered *"self-surrender, offering their own daughters in marriage, and a request for the administration of their own districts and provinces."*

READ THAT LAST SENTENCE AGAIN

Strip the flattery and it says: *foreign rulers sent embassies, sent marriage alliances, and asked to keep governing their own territory*. That is a description of diplomacy. A court poet is entitled to call an embassy a surrender, and Harishena does, and we should not.

Notice also what is **not** claimed. No siege. No named battle. No city taken. No governor appointed. For the north-west, Harishena lists titles and gestures — because titles and gestures were what there was.

Did any fighting actually happen?

Probably some, and probably not much. The honest position is this:

1. **The Yaudheyas kept minting.** Their coins continue after Samudragupta. A conquered and annexed people does not usually keep issuing money in its own name.
2. **Gupta gold appears in the region, but Gupta administration does not.** We have no Gupta land grants, no Gupta governors and no Gupta officials recorded for the Punjab plain in this reign.
3. **Later Gupta kings had to deal with the same peoples again.** If they had been absorbed in 360 CE, they would not still be there as independent actors afterwards.
4. **The most likely reality is a large armed demonstration.** An imperial army marches to the frontier. The republics count it, calculate, and buy peace with tribute and formal submission — which costs them money and dignity but leaves their assemblies, their armies and their coinage intact. Both sides get what they actually want. Only one side writes it down.

ONE CAUTION ABOUT THE PILLAR

Even the pillar's address is disputed. Several scholars think the column originally stood at **Kausambi**, about fifty kilometres away, and was moved to Allahabad later — possibly by Akbar when he built the fort. If so, its Ashokan edicts were addressed to a different city than the one they now stand in. It is a small thing, but it is a useful reminder: in this period, even the objects move.

WHY SAMUDRAGUPTA WON

- **He knew what he was buying.** He wanted the flank quiet and the tribute flowing, not a province to garrison. He priced the campaign correctly.
- **Overwhelming, visible force.** The empire that had just eaten the Ganges plain arriving on your border is an argument that does not need to be made twice.
- **He offered terms worth taking.** Submit and keep your government. Against that, fighting is a bad trade even if you might win.
- **He controlled the record.** His minister wrote the only surviving account, and wrote it as total victory. Two thousand years later, that is still the version in the textbooks.

WHY THE REPUBLICS GAVE WAY

- **They could not combine, again.** Nine separate peoples are listed. Nine separate decisions were made. Not one alliance appears anywhere in the record.
- **Their strength was defensive.** A militia can hold its own fields against a raid. It cannot threaten an empire, so it has no way to make the empire go away.
- **Submission was survivable.** The same brutal logic as under Persia in Part Two: paying is cheaper than dying, and a republic that survives can outlast the man taxing it.
- **And in the end it did not save them.** They bought a century. Then the Huns came, and there was nothing to buy them off with.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE IRONIC ONE

Three Empires on One Stone

The pillar Samudragupta's minister used was not a new one. It was a polished sandstone column already six hundred years old, put up by **Ashoka** in the third century BCE, and it already had writing on it.

Ashoka's pillar edicts are about restraint. They are instructions to his officials and his people about self-control, about care for prisoners, about not injuring living creatures, about the emperor's duty to do good rather than to be feared. They are the most famous experiment in non-violent government in the ancient world, carved by a man who took up that policy after a war he could not forgive himself for.

Harishena carved a war record on top of them. Kings destroyed, kings captured, kings restored as tributaries, tribes made to pay, a list of conquests running from Bengal to the Deccan, on the same stone, in the same beautiful script, a few inches below an emperor's public promise to stop conquering.

And it does not end there. In 1605 the Mughal emperor **Jahangir** had his own accession record cut into the same column, in Persian, straight across the older texts.

Three empires, eighteen hundred years, one pillar — and each of them treated the previous one's words as blank space. If you want the shortest possible summary of how power in India talks to its own past, it is standing in Allahabad fort.

The Seven Mouths of the Indus

LIKELY

A seven-metre iron post standing in Delhi says a king crossed the rivers of Punjab and beat somebody. Every other word of that sentence is argued over.

WON BY

A king called Chandra — almost certainly Chandragupta II

WHEN Probably c. 380–410 CE, if the king is Chandragupta II. Undated.	WHERE The Indus and its river system — either the delta in Sindh, or the five rivers themselves.
WHO “Chandra”, against a people the inscription calls the Vahlikas.	THE EVIDENCE Six lines of Sanskrit on the Mehrauli iron pillar, now standing in the Qutb complex in Delhi.

What the pillar actually says

The inscription is short, and it is one of the very few Gupta-period records that describes fighting in the north-west at all. In the standard translation, the relevant lines run: the king, in battle in the Vanga countries, turned back with his own chest the enemies who came against him united; and “**having crossed in warfare the seven mouths of the Sindhu, the Vahlikas were conquered by him**”; and the southern ocean is still perfumed by the breezes of his valour.

That is it. One clause about Punjab, or Sindh, in a poem about a dead king. And around that one clause there is a hundred and fifty years of argument.

The four things nobody agrees on

- Which Chandra?** The inscription names only “Chandra”. The majority view is **Chandragupta II** (ruled roughly 375–415 CE), on the grounds of script style, the mention of the Vangas, and the sheer scale of the claims. But serious scholars have argued for Chandragupta I, and for a completely different king, Chandravarman of Pushkarana, whose name turns up on an inscription in Bengal.
- Who were the Vahlikas?** Two readings. Either *Bahluka* means **Bactria** — the country around Balkh, north of Afghanistan — which would make this an enormous overseas campaign. Or it means the **Bahlikas of the**

Punjab, a people named repeatedly in the Mahabharata as living in the land of the five rivers. The second reading is geographically far easier and would put this war squarely in this book.

3. **Where are the seven mouths?** Either the mouths of the Indus in the delta, which suits a Bactrian campaign badly and a Sindh campaign well. Or the rivers of the Punjab system, which the ancients often counted as a bundle. *Sapta Sindhu* — the seven rivers — is one of the oldest names in this book. It appears in the Rigveda, in Part One.
4. **Where was the pillar originally?** Not Delhi. It was moved there in the medieval period, and its first home is unknown — Udayagiri in central India is the most-argued candidate, on the strength of the Gupta connection. A victory monument whose location we have lost is a victory monument that has lost half its meaning.

HANDLE WITH CARE

This is the most honest way to put it. **Something happened, and a Gupta-era king crossed a river system in force and won.** Beyond that, this part will not pretend. If the Vahlukas were the Punjab Bahlikas, this is a major Gupta campaign on the five rivers and belongs at the centre of the chapter. If they were Bactrians, it is a claim about a war fought a thousand kilometres away that may never have happened at all.

Be suspicious of anyone — in a textbook, in a documentary, in a comment section — who tells you which one it is without telling you there is a question.

What we can say about Chandragupta II with more confidence

Quite a lot, actually, and none of it from the pillar.

- **He finished the Saka war in the west.** Chandragupta II destroyed the Western Kshatrapas, the Saka dynasty that had ruled Gujarat and Malwa since Part Three, and took their territory. We know this because he took over their **silver coinage** as well, restriking their distinctive thin silver coins with Gupta types. Coinage again, doing the work of a chronicle.
- **That war gave the Guptas the sea.** With Gujarat came the western ports and the trade with Rome and Persia. It is the single most profitable thing any Gupta king ever did.
- **He married the frontier rather than fighting it.** Gupta policy under him and his father runs on marriage alliances — with the Vakatakas in the Deccan, with the Nagas. It is the same logic as Samudragupta's: buy the flanks, spend the army in one direction.

WHY THE GUPTAS WON IN THIS GENERATION

- **They fought one war at a time.** West first, into Gujarat and the sea trade. The north-west got demonstrations and diplomacy, not campaigns.
- **Money, then soldiers.** The Saka conquest paid for everything that came after, including the army that would meet the Huns two generations later.
- **They absorbed rather than destroyed.** Taking over the enemy's own currency system is a conqueror telling merchants that nothing has changed. It keeps the tax base alive.

WHY IT DID NOT LAST

- **Nothing was built in the north-west.** No fort line, no permanent frontier army, no standing command in Punjab. The Guptas treated the passes as somebody else's problem for a hundred years.
- **Prosperity in the east, exposure in the west.** The empire's wealth and its weak point were at opposite ends of it, with a very long march in between.
- **The Punjab republics were left as a buffer.** Buffers work until something arrives that they cannot stop, and then the empire discovers it has no second line.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Sixteen Hundred Years Standing in the Rain

Forget the inscription for a moment and look at the object.

The Mehrauli pillar is a single shaft of **wrought iron, about seven metres tall and over six tonnes**, made some time around 400 CE by forge-welding lumps of hot iron together, blow by blow, by hand. Nobody in Europe could make an iron object at that scale for another thousand years or more. It is, by itself, one of the finest pieces of metalwork surviving from the ancient world.

And it has stood outdoors, in the open Delhi air, through sixteen centuries of monsoons — and it has barely rusted.

That is not magic and it is not a lost secret. Modern metallurgical work, most thoroughly by **R. Balasubramaniam**, traced it to the iron's unusually high phosphorus content, which under Delhi's wetting-and-drying cycles forms a thin, dense protective film over the metal — a layer that seals the surface instead of flaking off the way ordinary rust does. The ancient smiths did not know the chemistry. They knew their ore and their process, and the process happened to be right.

There is a sad modern footnote. For generations, visitors stood with their back to the pillar and tried to link their hands around it behind them — the story was that if you could, your wish came true. Millions of arms wore a bright polished band into a protective layer that had taken centuries to form. **The pillar survived every empire in this book and was being worn away by affection.** It is fenced now.

Kidara Crosses the Great Mountains — The First Wave

LIKELY

The day India learned a new word for the enemy.

WON BY The Kidarites — the first of the peoples India would call Huna

WHEN Roughly 380–430 CE. The dating rests on coins and is argued over by decades.	WHERE Bactria first, then Gandhara, Taxila, Kashmir and the western Punjab.
WHO Kidara and his successors, against the Kushano-Sasanian governors and whatever local powers stood in the way.	THE EVIDENCE Chinese dynastic histories, Kidarite coins, and a Byzantine diplomat’s report. Nothing Indian.

Why it happened

Something enormous was moving across the steppe in the fourth century. In Europe, it produced the Huns of Attila and pushed Gothic nations across the Danube into the Roman empire. In Central Asia, it produced a series of confederations — the Chionites, the Kidarites, the Hephthalites, the Alchon — that came down out of the grass in wave after wave over roughly two hundred years.

We do not know what started it. Drought, population pressure, a collapse further east, one successful war-leader — all have been argued. **What we can see clearly is the effect: for two centuries, every settled empire from Rome to China had a horse-archer problem, and they all had it at once.**

Persia had already weakened the Kushan structure in the north-west and replaced it with governors. Governors are easier to overthrow than dynasties. When the Kidarites arrived, the doorway to India was held by a caretaker.

What happened

- The Kidarites take Bactria** from the Kushano-Sasanians, some time in the middle or later fourth century, and start minting there.
- They come south through the passes.** The Chinese *Wei shu*, compiled in the sixth century from earlier records, tells it plainly: the king of the Great Yuezhi, named **Jiduoluo** — Kidara — was brave and warlike, sent

his troops south, crossed the great mountains, and subdued the kingdoms north of Gandhara.

3. **They take the Kushan brand with them.** Kidarite coins copy Kushan and Sasanian designs and use the old titles. In Kashmir and Gandhara their money imitates the coinage of Vasudeva so closely that numismatists spent a long time untangling it. **The new masters advertised themselves as the old ones.**
4. **They push into the western Punjab.** How far east is genuinely unclear. Their coins are common in Gandhara and Kashmir, thinner on the plain. What is not in doubt is that from about 400 CE onward, the country between the Indus and the Jhelum was under a Central Asian dynasty again.
5. **They fight Persia for eighty years.** The Sasanian kings Bahram V and Yazdegerd II campaigned against them repeatedly. The Byzantine diplomat **Priscus** records that around 456 CE the Kidarite king refused to keep paying tribute to the Persian king Peroz, and the war restarted. Persia only finished them — in Bactria — with Hephthalite help.

THREE NAMES, ONE WORD

This is where the confusion in Indian sources begins, so it is worth being precise once. **Kidarites** arrive first, roughly 380–450. **Hephthalites** — the “White Huns” of Byzantine writers — dominate Bactria and Iran’s eastern frontier from roughly 450 to 560, and mostly stay north of the mountains. **Alchon** — the group of Toramana and Mihirakula — come into Gandhara and India from around 460 and are the ones who do the real damage here.

Indian inscriptions call all of them *Huna*. Chinese sources use different names again. Older history books merge the lot into “the White Huns”, which is why so much popular writing on this period is a muddle. **When you read “the Hunas invaded India”, always ask which ones, and in which decade.**

WHY THE KIDARITES WON

- **Horse archers against garrison troops.** Mounted archery gives you the choice of whether to fight at all. An army that can decline battle and reappear a hundred kilometres away cannot be pinned down by infantry.
- **They arrived at a caretaker frontier.** Gandhara was held by Persian-appointed governors with no local roots and no reason to die for the job.
- **They took the passes, which nobody was holding.** Same doorway, fourth time in this book.
- **They dressed as the previous regime.** Old titles, old coin designs, old scripts. Merchants and tax-collectors carried on. Continuity is cheaper than conquest.

WHY THE NORTH-WEST LOST

- **Nobody owned the frontier.** Persia had stopped at Peshawar. The Guptas had stopped a thousand kilometres short of it. The republics had never gone there. It was, in practice, unclaimed.
- **Gandhara was rich, exposed and unwarlike.** Centuries of monastery-building had made it one of the wealthiest religious landscapes in Asia and one of the least militarised.
- **Cities cannot run away.** Taxila, Peshawar and the great monasteries were fixed, visible and full of portable wealth.
- **The warning went unheard.** India had fifty years’ notice that a new power was on the other side of the mountains, and used it to do nothing.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Day India Learned a New Word

Languages record invasions. Sanskrit records this one.

Before the late fourth century, the word *Huna* is essentially absent from Indian writing. After it, the word is everywhere — in inscriptions, in the Puranas, in the lists of northern peoples that Indian texts liked to compile, in poetry as a byword for a distant and dangerous edge of the world. It becomes a fixed term, the way “Mughal” or “Angrez” later would.

What makes it worth pausing over is the reach of it. The same shockwave that put a new word into Sanskrit put related words into Latin and Greek at almost the same time, as Gothic refugees crossed the Danube and Roman writers reached for a name for whatever was behind them. **Two civilisations at opposite ends of the world, neither with any clear idea of the other, both suddenly needing a new noun in the same century.**

And here is the part that should stay with you. India got its warning first. The Kidarites were in Gandhara for two full generations before the really destructive wave arrived. Two generations is enough time to fortify passes, raise a frontier army, garrison Taxila, agree on a joint command.

The word entered the language decades before anyone acted on what it meant.

Skandagupta and the Whirlpool

CERTAIN

The one clear Indian victory in this entire part — and it cost so much that the empire never recovered.

WON BY Skandagupta of the Guptas — the man who bought India seventy years

WHEN Around 455–460 CE, near the start of his reign. Precise dating is impossible.	WHERE Not stated. Almost certainly the western approaches — the country between the Indus and the upper Ganges plain.
WHO Skandagupta against the Hunas — most probably Kidarites, though this is argued.	THE EVIDENCE The Bhitari pillar inscription, carved for Skandagupta himself, and the Junagadh rock inscription of 457 CE.

Why it happened

Skandagupta came to the throne in about 455 CE in the middle of a crisis, and possibly in the middle of a disputed succession. His own inscription says he restored the ruined fortunes of his family, which is not the sort of thing a king says if everything was fine.

Two enemies are named on the Bhitari pillar. One is a people called the **Pushyamitras**, who had grown powerful and against whom he fought a hard battle. The other is the **Hunas**. **The empire was being attacked in two directions at the accession of a new and possibly contested king.** That is the worst combination in politics.

What happened

1. **He fights the Pushyamitras first** and wins — the inscription describes him joining that fight in person and creating a disturbance like a terrible whirlpool, and says the earth shook under his arms. Court language, but the emphasis on personal combat is consistent and unusual.
2. **Then the Hunas come.** The inscription records the clash and records that he prevailed. It does not give a place, a date, a number, a season or a name for the opposing commander.
3. **He wins decisively enough to stop them for a generation.** This is the strongest argument, and it is not from the inscription — it is from the silence afterwards. There is no Huna power inside India again until the

470s at the earliest, and no Huna king ruling Indian territory until about 490. **Something stopped them, hard, for thirty years.**

4. **He then rules for about twelve more years**, repairs the great Sudarshana dam in Gujarat after a flood — recorded in the Junagadh inscription of 457 CE, which is where we get his date — and dies around 467.
5. **And the empire visibly weakens under him.** Gupta gold coinage in his reign gets worse: more base metal, uneven weights, hurried dies. The classic explanation is the cost of the wars. It is a reasonable inference rather than a proven one, but the coins are real and the direction is not in doubt.

THREE GENUINE DISPUTES, STATED PLAINLY

Which Hunas? Older books say Hephthalites or the Huns of Toramana. On the dates, that is difficult: Toramana's people arrive later. Most current scholarship makes Skandagupta's enemy the **Kidarites**, the first wave. The inscription just says Huna and leaves us to argue.

Who were the Pushyamitras? Nobody knows. They are not otherwise recorded as a power. Some scholars have even proposed a different reading of the damaged text. A war we are certain about, against a people we cannot identify.

How decisive was it? The inscription is a praise-poem written for the winner. Read alone, it proves the fight happened and that Skandagupta was pleased with the result. The thirty-year gap that follows is the real evidence, and it is circumstantial.

WHY SKANDAGUPTA WON

- **He fought them before they were established.** He met the Hunas while they were still raiding from outside, not ruling from inside. Every later Indian ruler in this part has to fight them as an occupying power.
- **The Gupta army was still intact.** He inherited the fully funded military machine of a century of successful reigns, and he used it immediately.
- **He led from the front.** Three separate passages stress his personal presence in the fighting. For an army facing an unfamiliar and terrifying enemy, that is not decoration; it is the difference between a line that holds and a line that runs.
- **He dealt with the internal enemy first.** Pushyamitras, then Hunas. In order, not at once. This is the correct answer to a two-front problem and it is depressingly rare in this book.

WHY THE VICTORY DID NOT HOLD

- **He beat the army, not the source.** The steppe kept producing new confederations. Nothing Skandagupta could do in India addressed that.
- **The frontier was still nobody's job.** After the victory, no permanent north-western command was created, no fortress line built, no standing frontier force stationed. The next wave found the same open door.
- **The war broke the money.** Debased gold is the visible symptom of a state spending more than it has.
- **The succession collapsed.** After Skandagupta died the Gupta house fell into competing branches and rival claimants. **Within twenty-five years of the great victory, there was no longer a single Gupta empire to defend anything.**

He Went to Tell His Mother

The Bhitari pillar is a formal royal inscription in high Sanskrit, and most of it does what such things do: it lists ancestors, piles up compliments, and compares the king to gods.

Then, in the middle of it, comes one of the most unexpected passages in Indian epigraphy. Having beaten his enemies and restored his family's ruined fortunes, the new king — in the words carved for him —

cried "the victory has been achieved," and betook himself to his mother, whose eyes were full of tears from joy, just as Krishna, when he had slain his enemies, betook himself to his mother Devaki.

Bhitari pillar inscription of Skandagupta, in Fleet's translation

Consider what is being described. A man in his twenties or thirties, who has just inherited a crumbling empire in a contested succession, has fought a hard war on two fronts and won it. He has the resources of an empire to celebrate with.

What he does — or what he chose to have carved in stone for all future time, which tells you the same thing about what he valued — is go and find his mother and say: we are all right.

The Krishna comparison is not accidental. In the story, Devaki had spent years imprisoned and had lost child after child before Krishna came back and freed her. Whoever wrote this line was saying that this mother had also been through something.

Everything else on that pillar is about the throne. That one sentence is about a family that had been frightened.

Toramana Takes the Punjab

CERTAIN

For the first time since Alexander, a foreign conqueror did not stop at the five rivers. He kept going, and reached the middle of India.

WON BY

Toramana of the Alchon Huns — who ruled from the Salt Range to Madhya Pradesh

WHEN

Roughly **490–515 CE**. His first regnal year is recorded; the calendar it belongs to is not.

WHERE

Gandhara, the Salt Range, the whole Punjab plain, Kashmir, and on into Malwa and central India.

WHO

Toramana, king of the Alchon, against the fragmenting Gupta empire and everyone in between.

THE EVIDENCE

Two inscriptions in his own name — **one of them in Punjab** — plus copper plates and a large coinage.

Why it happened

Because there was nothing left to stop it. In the thirty years after Skandagupta's death the Gupta empire came apart into competing branches. The Punjab republics were long past their strength. The Kidarites had been broken in Bactria by Persia and the Hephthalites, which removed the only organised power between the Alchon and the passes.

Every barrier that had held from 455 to 480 was gone by 490. **Toramana did not defeat India's defences. He arrived after they had dissolved.**

What happened

1. **The Alchon establish themselves in Gandhara and Kabul** from around 460 onward under earlier kings, of whom the best-attested is Khingila. They mint heavily. Their coins carry a distinctive mark — a *tamga*, a clan symbol used like a brand — and the name Alchono in Bactrian script.
2. **Toramana comes down onto the plain** some time around 490. There is no account of the campaign. The evidence for it is that he ends up in charge.

3. **He is recorded ruling in the Punjab.** The **Kura inscription**, found at Kura in the Salt Range in the Jhelum district, is dated by the reign of the great king **Toramana Shahi Jauvla**. It is the single most important document of Hun rule in Punjab, and we will come back to what it actually records, because it is not what you would expect.
4. **He reaches central India.** The **Eran boar inscription**, cut at Eran in what is now Madhya Pradesh, opens by dating itself to the first year of *Maharajadhiraja* Toramana, ruling the earth in great splendour. *Maharajadhiraja* means great king over kings — the full imperial title, used without apology. Copper plates from Sanjeli in Gujarat also record his overlordship.
5. **He is still being resisted in 510.** The Eran pillar inscription of that year records a great battle involving a Gupta prince named Bhanugupta and a warrior called Goparaja, who died in it. The inscription does not say who the enemy was. The date, the place and the context make the Huns the obvious candidate — obvious, but not stated.
6. **He dies around 515** and is succeeded by his son. That son is the reason this part exists.

THE ARCHAEOLOGY, WHICH IS GRIMMER THAN THE INSCRIPTIONS

At **Taxila**, the excavations of Sir John Marshall found the late city and its surrounding monasteries ending in destruction — burning, collapse, coin hoards buried and never recovered, and no meaningful rebuilding afterwards. Similar endings show up at monastic sites across Gandhara in roughly the same window.

Assigning that destruction to a specific king or year is beyond what the evidence supports, and honest archaeologists say so. What the evidence does support is blunt and terrible: **in the late fifth and early sixth centuries, the monastic civilisation of the north-west stopped, and it never restarted.** When the Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang came through a century later, he described monastery after monastery standing empty and ruined, with a handful of monks where there had been thousands.

WHY TORAMANA WON

- **He came into a vacuum.** No Gupta central authority, no republic strong enough, no frontier power left in Bactria. There was, for the first time in a century, nobody whose job it was to say no.
- **Mounted archers on open plains.** The Punjab doab country is close to ideal cavalry ground — flat, dry for much of the year, and cut only by rivers that a mobile army can choose when to cross.
- **Two generations of local knowledge.** The Alchon had been sitting in Gandhara since the 460s. They did not invade a country they had never seen; they annexed the one next door.
- **He governed rather than raided.** Dated regnal years, imperial titles, an issued coinage, land grants confirmed. Toramana set up a state. That is why his rule stuck and his son inherited an empire.

WHY INDIA LOST

- **The succession war did what no enemy could.** The Guptas spent the years 470 to 500 fighting each other. Toramana simply walked into the result.
- **No frontier institution ever existed.** Not under the Kushans, not under the Guptas, not under the republics. Two hundred years of warnings produced not one permanent garrison at the passes.
- **The rivers were not used.** Punjab's five rivers are the best defensive line in northern India, and in this war nobody held one.
- **Everyone defended their own ground.** Republics defended their fields, Gupta claimants defended their claims, cities defended their walls, monasteries defended nothing. Nobody defended the region.

The Monastery in the Salt Range

Here is the awkward document mentioned above, and it deserves to be awkward.

The one inscription we have from Punjab that names Toramana as its ruling king — the Kura record from the Salt Range — is not a war memorial. It is not a proclamation. It is a **dedication recording the building of a Buddhist monastery**, made by a local man, dated in the ordinary way by the reign of the ruling sovereign: the great king, king of kings, Toramana Shahi Jauvla.

Think about how that document came to exist. A subject of the Hun king, in Hun-ruled Punjab, spent his own money founding a Buddhist establishment, recorded it publicly on stone, and dated it by his king's name — exactly as he would have done under any Indian ruler. Nobody stopped him. The stone survived.

That does not cancel Taxila. The burnt monasteries are also real, and the wave that Toramana led is the wave under which Gandharan Buddhism died. Both things are in the record, and a book that tells you only one of them is selling you something.

The most likely truth is the ordinary, unsatisfying one that historians keep arriving at. **Conquest was catastrophic where armies passed and unremarkable a few valleys away.** In the Salt Range, life went on well enough that a man could plan a monastery and expect it to still be standing when he was old.

Remember that in the next war, because the next king is a monster, and it will be tempting to make his father one too. The evidence does not allow it.

Mihirakula of Sialkot — Three Years of War With Kashmir

LIKELY

Every source that mentions him hates him. That is unusual enough to be worth investigating.

WON BY

Mihirakula — at first, and everywhere

WHEN Roughly 515–528 CE for the height of his power.	WHERE Ruled from Sakala — Sialkot — over Punjab and Gandhara, campaigning into Kashmir and eastward.
WHO Mihirakula, son of Toramana, against Kashmir, the Buddhist establishments of the north-west, and eventually everyone.	THE EVIDENCE His own inscription at Gwalior; a Chinese envoy who was there; two later accounts that loathe him.

Who he was

Mihirakula inherited his father’s empire around 515 CE and ruled it from **Sakala** — the city we now call Sialkot. Readers of Part Three will recognise that address. Sakala was the capital of the Indo-Greek king Menander six centuries earlier, the setting of the *Milindapanha*, one of the great cosmopolitan cities of the ancient Punjab. **The same city, twice over: first the seat of a Greek king who is remembered for a philosophical dialogue with a monk, then the seat of a Hun king who is remembered for burning monasteries.**

His own inscription survives. At **Gwalior**, a record dated to the fifteenth year of Mihirakula commemorates the building of a sun temple by a man named Matricheta, and calls the king’s father Toramana a ruler of great fame. So we have him in his own words, or at least in his subjects’ words about him, doing perfectly normal royal things.

The eyewitness

Around 520 CE a Chinese envoy named **Song Yun** travelled through Gandhara on his way to fetch Buddhist texts, and wrote a report. He is the only person in this entire part who saw the Hun court in Punjab and left a description of it. What he says:

1. The country had been conquered by the Huns two generations earlier, and the current king was a hard, violent ruler with no interest in Buddhism, who preferred to worship demons.

2. The king had been **at war with Kashmir for three years** and had no intention of stopping, keeping his army permanently in the field.
3. He kept a great force of war elephants — Song Yun gives a figure of seven hundred, each carrying armed men, with blades fastened to the elephants' trunks.
4. The population was taxed heavily to pay for it, and the people were miserable.

ON THAT ELEPHANT FIGURE

Seven hundred war elephants is a very large number — comparable to the biggest elephant forces claimed anywhere in Indian history — and it comes from a foreign envoy who was shown what a king wanted him to see. **Treat it as “an impressive number of elephants, displayed deliberately to an ambassador.”**

The detail about swords on the trunks is repeated widely and may well be accurate; elephants were trained to use fitted blades. But note who is telling us: a visitor, being given a military parade. Every ruler in history has done this to every ambassador in history.

The three-year war

The Kashmir war Song Yun describes is one of the few concrete military facts we have about Mihirakula, and it fits everything else. Kashmir was the one neighbouring region that was hard to take: a valley behind mountains, reachable through a handful of passes that a defender can hold. It was also wealthy and it was on the flank of his Punjab territory.

The war lasted at least three years and was still going when Song Yun passed through. That, as much as any inscription, tells you what kind of ruler he was: the kind who commits an army to a mountain campaign for years, keeps it in the field through winters, and taxes his own country flat to pay for it.

It also tells you something about his empire's condition. Long wars in bad country are how large states exhaust themselves. Within a few years of Song Yun's visit, Mihirakula would lose everything.

WHY MIHIRAKULA WAS HARD TO BEAT

- **He inherited, not conquered.** The army, the treasury, the territory and the administration were handed to him intact. He started at full strength.
- **Combined arms.** Steppe cavalry from his own people plus Indian elephants and infantry from his subject territory. That is a genuinely dangerous combination, and it is what happens when invaders stay long enough to become local.
- **A central position.** From Sialkot he could reach Kashmir, Gandhara, the Punjab plain and the road east. It is one of the best strategic addresses in northern India.
- **Terror as policy.** Whether the stories are exaggerated or not, a reputation for atrocity makes cities open their gates. It works. It also, eventually, unites everyone against you.

THE WEAKNESSES THAT WOULD END HIM

- **He fought everyone at once.** Kashmir for three years, the Buddhist establishment at home, and expansion eastward, simultaneously.
- **He made enemies of his own subjects.** A king who persecutes the wealthiest institutions in his own territory has converted a tax base into an opposition.
- **He gave the Indian kingdoms a reason to combine.** The one thing this book shows to be nearly impossible was an Indian coalition. He achieved it, against himself.
- **His empire was one generation deep.** Loyalty in his territories was to a name, not an institution. When he was beaten once, it evaporated.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE CRUEL ONE

STORY

The Elephant at Hastivanj

This story comes from the *Rajatarangini*, the chronicle of the kings of Kashmir written by the poet **Kalhana** in about 1148 CE — six hundred years after the events. It is the most famous thing ever written about Mihirakula, and its label is *Story*, and it should stay that way.

Kalhana says that the king was known by the sound that travelled ahead of his army: not trumpets, but **the wailing of the women of the districts he was about to reach**. He calls him a man of violent deeds, and compares him to Death itself.

Then he tells this. Mihirakula was marching his army through the mountains when one of his elephants lost its footing on a steep path and fell into the gorge below. As it fell, it screamed.

The king found the sound delightful. He ordered a hundred more elephants driven over the edge so that he could hear it again.

Kalhana says the place kept the name — *Hastivanja*, the place of the elephants — and that people still pointed it out in his own day.

Now the honest part. Kalhana wrote six centuries later. He was a Kashmiri Brahmin writing about a foreign invader who had attacked Kashmir, which is not a neutral position. He was a poet, and this is a poet's image — the man who enjoys the scream. And in the very same chronicle he also records Mihirakula founding a shrine, establishing a town and granting villages to Brahmins, which is what he records of every king.

The story is almost certainly not true as told. It survived because it is the shortest possible way to say what an entire region remembered about being ruled by this man. That memory is the historical fact. The elephants are how it was carried.

Sondani — The Alliance That Broke Mihirakula

CERTAIN

The one time in this book that India’s kings combined in time, won, and then vanished.

WON BY

Yashodharman — a king who appears from nowhere and disappears within a decade

WHEN Around 528 CE. His related inscription at Mandsaur is dated to 532 CE.	WHERE Sondani, near Mandsaur in Malwa — a very long way from Punjab, which is the point.
WHO Yashodharman of Dashapura, probably in alliance with Gupta and other Indian forces, against Mihirakula.	THE EVIDENCE Two identical victory pillars raised on the spot by the winner, and still standing.

Why it happened here and not in Punjab

Because Mihirakula had pushed too far east and south. His empire already held Punjab and Gandhara; his expansion was aimed down the old road into Malwa and central India, the same corridor his father had reached at Eran.

That expansion did the one thing his enemies could never do for themselves. **It made him a threat to kingdoms that had no other reason to cooperate.** A Hun empire on the Ravi is a Punjabi problem. A Hun empire on the Chambal is everybody’s problem.

What we know, which is more than usual

- Yashodharman ruled at Dashapura** — Mandsaur, in western Madhya Pradesh. Before this war he is unrecorded. We do not know how he came to power or how he assembled the force he used.
- He beat Mihirakula in the field** and set up two matching stone pillars at Sondani to say so. Both survive.
- The pillars claim two specific things**, and their specificity is what makes them valuable. First, that he holds countries which **even the Guptas never held and which even the Hunas could not command**. Second, and far more pointedly, that **Mihirakula himself paid homage to him** — that the head which had never bowed to any human being was made to bow.

4. **He calls his own achievement out by name.** Naming your defeated enemy on a monument is not standard practice in Indian inscriptions, which usually prefer vague categories of vanquished foes. Yashodharman named him, twice, on two pillars, at the battlefield.
5. **And then he disappears.** Yashodharman is known from three inscriptions inside about five years. Then there is nothing. No successor, no dynasty, no later mention. **The empire that broke the Huns lasted less than a decade.**

WAS IT REALLY AN ALLIANCE?

The inscriptions credit Yashodharman alone, as victory inscriptions do. But a local ruler from Malwa defeating the emperor of the north-west is a very large step, and there are two other threads. The Chinese pilgrim **Xuanzang**, a century later, credits the defeat of Mihirakula to a king of Magadha he calls **Baladitya** — a name associated with the later Gupta king Narasimhagupta. And the Guptas, though weakened, were still in the field in this period.

The standard reconstruction — that Yashodharman won the decisive battle with Gupta and allied support, and took the whole credit on his own pillars — is plausible and unproven. **What is certain is that Mihirakula was beaten, and that after 528 he never again ruled an empire in India.**

WHY YASHODHARMAN WON

- **He fought at the end of the enemy's reach.** Mihirakula's power base was Punjab and Gandhara. At Sondani he was a very long way from his own country, in someone else's.
- **He fought a tired empire.** Three years of mountain war in Kashmir, a long eastward expansion, and a persecuted domestic population had already spent Mihirakula's strength.
- **He assembled a combination — probably.** Everything about the scale of the result suggests more than one kingdom's army in the field.
- **He understood the value of a monument.** He built the memory as deliberately as he built the victory, on the ground, in stone, with the loser named. It is why we know about him at all.

WHY MIHIRAKULA LOST

- **Overreach.** He was fighting Kashmir, holding Punjab and Gandhara, and campaigning into central India at the same time.
- **He had no friends anywhere.** No subject population with a reason to hold, no allied kingdom, no faction inside India that preferred him to the alternative.
- **Cavalry far from home.** Horse armies need remounts, grazing and space. Deep in central India, at the end of a supply line, they get none of the three.
- **He had made himself the point of the empire.** Once he was beaten in person, there was no institution underneath to keep the thing standing.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE IRONIC ONE

The Victory Pillar of a Man With No Kingdom

Go to Sondani today and the pillars are still there. What they say is one of the boldest claims any Indian inscription makes: **I rule lands the Guptas never ruled and the Hunas could not take, and the king whose head had never bowed to anyone bowed to me.**

Every word of that is very likely true. He did beat the most feared man in India. He did end an empire that had held the north-west for forty years. The Hun threat to India effectively stops here.

And within about five years, Yashodharman is gone. No coins of his are known. No son. No successor. No dynasty. Not one later inscription mentions him. The kingdom he claims on the pillar leaves no other trace anywhere in India, and the historians who reconstructed his existence had to do it almost entirely from the monuments he built for himself.

He is the only man in this book who beat the invader outright, took the credit in stone, and then vanished more completely than the enemy he defeated.

There is a hard lesson under the irony, and it runs through the whole of Punjab's history. Coalitions in this book form against a threat and dissolve with it. The alliance that broke Mihirakula did not become a state, an army or an institution. It won, and then it went home, and when the next invader came through the passes there was nothing there but the pillars.

Mihirakula's Revenge — Kashmir and the Killing of Gandhara

STORY

A defeated king with one army left, and nothing to lose, went and did the worst thing in this part of the book.

WON BY

Mihirakula — the most destructive victory in these four hundred years

WHEN

Roughly 528–535 CE, in the years after Sondani.

WHERE

Kashmir, and then Gandhara — Taxila, Peshawar and the monastery country.

WHO

Mihirakula, against the king who gave him shelter and then against the Buddhist establishment of the north-west.

THE EVIDENCE

Xuanzang, writing a century later, and Kalhana, six centuries later. No contemporary record at all.

What the sources say happened

This is the section of Part Four with the weakest evidence and the heaviest consequences, and both those facts need stating at the top.

1. **He is defeated and loses his empire.** Xuanzang's version has him captured by Baladitya of Magadha and released on the intervention of the victor's mother, which is a story shaped exactly like a moral lesson and should be read as one.
2. **He takes refuge in Kashmir.** The king of Kashmir gives shelter to the fallen conqueror.
3. **He kills his host and seizes the throne.** Both Xuanzang and Kalhana have some version of this. A man with a personal following, no territory and no future, taken in by a smaller kingdom, takes it over.
4. **Then he goes back down the mountains into Gandhara.** This is the part that matters. Xuanzang says he destroyed the royal house, overthrew stupas, wrecked monasteries, and killed on a scale he gives in the hundreds of thousands.
5. **And after that, nothing.** There is no reliable account of how or when he died. The coinage tails off. The Alchon fragment into small kingdoms in Kashmir, Gandhara and the Punjab hills, and never threaten India again.

INTERROGATING THE NUMBERS, AND THE SOURCE

Xuanzang's casualty figures are not usable. He was a Buddhist monk writing a century after the events about the destruction of Buddhist institutions, working from what monks in ruined monasteries told him. Hundreds of thousands killed is a number of the kind ancient and medieval writers reach for when they mean *beyond counting*. **Do not repeat the figure. It is a feeling, not a census.**

And yet. Xuanzang walked through Gandhara and Taxila in person around 630 CE and described what he saw with the calm detail of a man taking notes: monasteries deserted, stupas broken, foundations robbed, a handful of monks in buildings meant for hundreds. That part is not rhetoric — it is observation, and it is corroborated in the ground by excavation.

So: the number is worthless, and the devastation is real. Both statements are true at once, and holding both is the whole skill of reading a source like this.

WHY HE WAS ABLE TO DO IT

- **He still had an army when he had nothing else.** Steppe followings were loyal to a leader, not a state. Losing the empire did not dissolve the war-band.
- **Kashmir was a small kingdom with a big guest.** Taking in a defeated conqueror with his own troops is an act of charity that has almost never worked out in history.
- **Gandhara was undefended and wealthy.** The monasteries held gold, relics and reliquaries and had no military capacity whatsoever. As targets go, there was nothing safer.
- **Nobody came.** The Guptas were finished, Yashodharman had evaporated, the Punjab republics were long gone. The victors of Sondani never followed up.

WHY THE NORTH-WEST COULD NOT STOP HIM

- **It had already been ruled by his family for forty years.** Whatever independent power once existed there had been dismantled by his own father.
- **Its wealth was in buildings.** You cannot evacuate a stupa. Fixed, famous, valuable and unarmed is the worst possible combination.
- **Its protector had always been an outside empire.** Kushan, Persian, Kidarite, Alchon — Gandhara had not defended itself in centuries and no longer knew how.
- **Nobody outside considered it their responsibility.** That is the oldest pattern in this book, and here it costs an entire civilisation.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE THAT COSTS THE MOST

The City That Never Came Back

Taxila has been in every part of this book so far.

In Part Two it was the city of Ambhi, the king who invited Alexander in — already old, already famous, already the place people came to learn. In Part Three it revolted twice against the Mauryan empire, was governed by two future emperors, and grew into one of the great meeting points of the ancient world: Greek sculpture, Buddhist philosophy, Persian administration and Indian learning stacked in the same streets. It was one of the very few places on earth where all four of those things were in one place at one time.

And then, in the sixth century, it stops.

Not declines. Stops. The excavations show burning, collapse and abandonment. Money buried in panic and never dug up. Monasteries emptied and not reoccupied. No later great city on the site — no medieval Taxila, no Mughal Taxila. The road moved, the schools scattered east and north, and what had been a centre of the world became a set of mounds that farmers ploughed around for thirteen hundred years until archaeologists arrived to dig them up.

When Xuanzang passed through in about 630 CE, he was walking through the wreckage with a guidebook in his head. He knew every story attached to every ruin, because Buddhists in China had been reading about these places for centuries. He recorded what he had come to see and then recorded that it was gone.

This is the single largest loss in the whole of The Wars of Punjab, and unlike a battle it has no date. Nobody can tell you the day Gandhara ended. The most any honest account can say is that it was alive when Toramana came down the passes, and it was dead when the Arabs reached Multan in Part Five.

The War That Freed Punjab Was Fought a Thousand Miles Away

LIKELY

Two empires with no interest whatsoever in the five rivers destroyed the power that had been ruling them.

WON BY Sasanian Persia and the Turks — jointly, and briefly

WHEN	WHERE
Around 557–561 CE, with the long build-up starting in 484.	Bactria and Sogdia — the country around the Oxus, near Bukhara. Not India.
WHO	WHY IT IS IN THIS BOOK
Khosrow I of Persia and the Turk khagan Istami, against the Hephthalite empire.	Because it removed the last Central Asian power capable of feeding invasions into Punjab, and nobody in Punjab had anything to do with it.

The seventy years before it

To understand why this mattered, you need one earlier disaster.

In 484 CE, the Persian king **Peroz I** led a full imperial army east against the Hephthalites, who had been beating and humiliating him for years. The accounts differ in detail but agree on the shape of it: the Hephthalites let him come, drew his army into ground of their choosing, and destroyed it. Several versions describe a concealed trench dug across the line of the Persian advance and hidden, with the Hephthalite army waiting behind it.

Peroz died in that battle, and Persia paid tribute afterwards. A shah of Iran, at the head of the empire that had conquered Gandhara in War One of this part, was killed in the field by the same broad group of peoples who were about to take Punjab. It is the best single measure of how dangerous these confederations were, and it explains why nobody in India managed a permanent answer to them.

What happened in 557–561

1. **A new power appears behind the Hephthalites.** The Turks — the first empire in history to use that name for itself — came out of Mongolia in the 550s and expanded west across the steppe with extraordinary speed under a khagan named Istami.

2. **Persia had spent eighty years waiting for exactly this.** Khosrow I, one of the ablest rulers Persia ever had, made an alliance with the Turks against the enemy in between.
3. **The Hephthalites were crushed between them,** in fighting around Bukhara at the end of the 550s. Their empire ended.
4. **The victors then divided the corpse and immediately fell out.** The Oxus became the border: Persia south of it, the Turks north. Within a decade the two allies were enemies, which is what usually happens after a partition.
5. **And south of the mountains, the pressure stopped.** The Alchon in India had already been broken at Sondani. With the Hephthalite power in Bactria gone as well, there was no longer a reservoir behind the passes to send new waves down them. **The Huna period of Indian history ends here, in a war India did not fight.**

WHAT HAPPENED TO THE HUNS IN INDIA

They stayed. That is the short answer, and it is the one most often left out.

The Alchon and their descendants fragmented into small kingdoms in Kashmir, the Punjab hills, Gandhara and the Kabul valley, and their coins keep appearing for generations. The dynasties that will hold the north-western door in Part Five — the Shahi kings of Kabul and Gandhara — grew out of that wreckage.

Beyond the ruling families, there is a much larger and much more argued question: how far the Huna and related populations settled into the general population of north-western India, and which later clan and caste names carry their memory. **Some of the connections proposed in the nineteenth century were confident, colonial and evidence-free, and a lot of them are still repeated.** The careful version is this: the invaders of the fifth and sixth centuries did not evaporate, they merged, and the details are genuinely uncertain. Anyone who tells you exactly which modern community descends from whom is telling you about politics, not history.

WHY PERSIA AND THE TURKS WON

- **Two fronts, one enemy.** The Hephthalites were attacked from north and south at the same time — the exact situation that had destroyed the Kushans in War One.
- **Patience.** Khosrow waited eighty years and paid tribute in the meantime rather than repeat Peroz's mistake. Then he moved once, with an ally.
- **The Turks were faster and larger.** A steppe empire beaten by a bigger steppe empire, which is how most of them end.

WHY THE HEPHTHALITES LOST

- **Success made them the middle.** They had made enemies of everyone on both sides of them, which is fatal for a power that sits between two civilisations.
- **No depth.** Their strength was a confederation of war-bands. Beat the central army badly enough and there is nothing behind it.
- **Their Indian branch was already gone.** Sondani had taken away the wealth of the south a generation before the northern collapse.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Nobody in Punjab Was Consulted

Sit with this for a moment, because it is the most uncomfortable point in the whole part.

For roughly seventy years the people of the five rivers had lived under foreign rulers who came through the passes. They had been taxed for a three-year mountain war they had no interest in. Their cities had been burnt, their monasteries emptied and their most famous university town reduced to mounds.

And the thing that finally ended it was a battle near Bukhara, fought between a Persian emperor in Ctesiphon and a Turkish khagan from Mongolia, about who should control the silk trade across the Oxus.

Neither of them had ever been to Punjab. Neither of them was thinking about it. Punjab was not a party to the war, not a beneficiary anyone considered, and not informed of the outcome.

This is what it means to be a frontier rather than a power. Your fate is decided in rooms you are not in, by people arguing about something else, and the news reaches you afterwards as a change in who does not arrive at your gates.

It happens again in this book. It happens when the Mongols turn away from India because of a succession crisis in Karakorum. It happens when the fate of Punjab in the 1840s is settled by decisions taken in Calcutta and London. **Remember that the relief of 561 CE was not a victory. It was a vacancy.**

A Lion to the Huna Deer — The Vardhanas of Thanesar

LIKELY

The last Huna war in Indian history was won by a family from the Punjab plain, and it produced the last great empire before the Muslim conquests.

WON BY

Prabhakaravardhana and his sons — the house of Thanesar

WHEN

c. 580–648 CE. Prabhakaravardhana dies in 605; Harsha rules 606–647.

WHERE

From **Sthanvishvara — Thanesar**, in the Kurukshetra country of the eastern Punjab plain.

WHO

The Pushyabhuti or Vardhana family, against the Hunas, the ruler of Sindh, the Gurjaras, Malwa and Gandhara.

THE EVIDENCE

The *Harshacharita* of **Bana**, a court biography written for the family, and Xuanzang, who met Harsha in person.

Where they came from

Thanesar sits in the Kurukshetra plain, the country of the Mahabharata, at the eastern end of the Punjab plain on the great road between the Yamuna and the Sutlej. It is exactly where you would expect a defensive power to grow after two centuries of invasion: **far enough east to be safe from a first blow, close enough west to have to care.**

The Vardhanas were minor rulers who became major ones in one generation, under **Prabhakaravardhana**, who took the imperial title and spent his reign fighting his neighbours in every direction.

What Bana says about him

The *Harshacharita* is a court biography, written by the family's own poet, and it should be read with all the scepticism that implies. It is also the best piece of prose in this part and it contains the single most quoted description of a king in early medieval India. Prabhakaravardhana, it says, was:

a lion to the Huna deer, a burning fever to the king of the Indus land, a troubler of the sleep of Gurjara, a bilious plague to that scent-elephant the lord of Gandhara, a looter of the lawlessness of the Latas, an axe to the creeper of the glory of Malwa.

Bana, Harshacharita, on Prabhakaravardhana

Strip the poetry and it is a foreign policy summary. **Punjab's neighbours, listed in order, each with the injury done to them.** The Hunas are first, which tells you which one the family was proudest of.

What happened

1. **Prabhakaravardhana fights the Hunas repeatedly** and wins often enough for the boast to stick. These are no longer imperial Hunas; they are the fragments left after Sondani, holding the hills and the north-west. The threat is real but reduced.
2. **He sends his elder son Rajyavardhana north against them** in about 604 or 605, in what is the last recorded Huna campaign in Indian history. The prince is winning when a messenger reaches him: his father is dying.
3. **The family collapses in a single year.** Prabhakaravardhana dies. His queen, Yashomati, follows him into the fire, in the practice these sources record without comment and which this book will meet again. Rajyavardhana comes home to a funeral.
4. **Then it gets worse.** The king of Malwa attacks and kills the Vardhanas' ally; Rajyavardhana marches out, defeats him — and is then killed, Bana says by treachery, at the hands of **Shashanka**, the king of Gauda in Bengal, while apparently in negotiation.
5. **The younger brother inherits everything at about sixteen.** This is **Harsha**. He takes the throne in 606 CE, vows revenge, and then spends thirty years building the last great north Indian empire before the Muslim conquests — from the Punjab to Bengal, ruled from Kanauj.
6. **And in 647 he dies without an heir**, and it all comes apart within months. Northern India returns to being a collection of kingdoms, and stays that way for four hundred years.

WHAT PUNJAB LOOKED LIKE AT THE END OF THIS PART

We have an eyewitness, and he is unusually reliable. **Xuanzang** travelled through the Punjab in the 630s, and what he describes is a plain full of separate kingdoms rather than a province of anything: a large territory he calls the country of the **Takkas**, covering much of the plain, along with Jalandhara, Kashmir and others.

He also describes **Sakala** — **Sialkot**, and this is the detail worth keeping. He records the ruins of the old city, and remembers it as the seat of Mihirakula, who had ruled there a hundred years before. The Greek capital of Part Three, the Hun capital of Part Four, standing in pieces, being pointed out to a foreign traveller as the place where the cruel king used to live.

WHY THE VARDHANAS WON

- **They fought a broken enemy.** The Hunas of 600 CE were the wreckage of Sondani, not the empire of Toramana. Timing was most of the victory.
- **They were based in the right place.** Thanesar had depth behind it and the great road in front of it — a base you can defend and campaign from.
- **Three capable rulers in a row.** Father and two sons, all of them soldiers. In a hereditary system that is the whole game, and it is largely luck.
- **They campaigned in every direction and consolidated behind them.** Unlike Yashodharman, Harsha turned victory into an administration that lasted forty years.

WHY IT ENDED ANYWAY

- **One man, no heir.** Harsha's empire was a personal achievement with no institution underneath it. He died, and it stopped.
- **The centre had moved east for good.** Harsha ruled from Kanauj, not from Thanesar. Punjab was again a frontier province of somebody else's state — the pattern set in Part One and unbroken since.
- **Nothing was fixed at the passes.** For the fourth time in this part: the door was never garrisoned. Sixty years after Harsha, an Arab army walks through a different door into Sindh, and Part Five begins.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD ON THE HUNAS

The Deer That Was Once the Terror of the World

Read Bana's line again, and notice what it takes for granted.

A lion to the Huna deer. Deer. Not wolves, not tigers, not the storm out of the mountains — **deer**. Something you hunt for sport. Something that runs.

Two lifetimes before Bana wrote that sentence, the Hunas held everything from the Kabul valley to central India. They had killed a Persian emperor in the field, ended the Gupta empire's reach in the north-west, taxed the whole Punjab plain, and destroyed the greatest Buddhist civilisation in the world. Mihirakula ruled from Sialkot and marched wherever he liked.

And by 600 CE a court poet in Thanesar can use them as the small animal in a compliment, in a list, third from the top, without any need to explain the joke to his readers. **The most feared name in India had become a figure of speech.**

That is what the end of an era actually looks like from the inside. Not a treaty, not a final battle, not a date anybody records. Just a change in the way people talk — the moment a word that used to make a room go quiet turns into the sort of thing you put in a poem, because everyone in the room already knows it cannot hurt them any more.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

c. 230–270 CE	Sasanian Persia takes Gandhara and Peshawar. The Kushan empire ends in the north-west. No battle is recorded. Won by Persia.
c. 250–350 CE	The free century. The Yaudheyas, Madrakas, Kunindas, Audumbaras and Trigartas govern themselves and mint their own coins. Won by the republics of Punjab.
c. 350–375 CE	Samudragupta reaches the frontier. Nine peoples pay tribute and submit on paper; the Kushan and Saka rulers send embassies. Won by Samudragupta — on parchment.
c. 380–410 CE	The Mehrauli iron pillar. A king called Chandra crosses the seven mouths of the Sindhu and beats the Vahlikas. Won by Chandra — probably Chandragupta II.
c. 380–430 CE	Kidara crosses the great mountains. The first Huna wave takes Bactria, Gandhara and Kashmir. India learns a new word. Won by the Kidarites.
c. 455–460 CE	Skandagupta and the whirlpool. The Pushyamitras beaten, then the Hunas stopped for a generation. Won by Skandagupta.
484 CE	The Hephthalites destroy a Persian imperial army and kill the shah Peroz I. Won by the Hephthalites.
c. 490–515 CE	Toramana takes the Punjab and reaches central India. His name dates a monastery record in the Salt Range. Won by the Alchon Huns.
510 CE	The battle at Eran. Goparaja dies beside the Gupta prince Bhanugupta; his wife follows him into the fire, in the first dated record of the practice in India.
c. 515–528 CE	Mihirakula rules from Sialkot, fights Kashmir for three years, and persecutes the Buddhist establishment. Won by Mihirakula.
c. 528 CE	Sondani. Yashodharman breaks Mihirakula and raises two victory pillars naming him. Won by Yashodharman — who then vanishes.
c. 528–535 CE	Mihirakula's revenge. He seizes Kashmir and devastates Gandhara. Taxila does not recover. Won by Mihirakula — the costliest victory in this part.
c. 557–561 CE	Persia and the Turks destroy the Hephthalite empire near Bukhara. The pressure on the passes stops. Won by people who had never been to Punjab.
c. 580–605 CE	Prabhakaravardhana of Thanesar — “a lion to the Huna deer.” Won by the Vardhanas.
605–606 CE	The last Huna campaign. Rajyavardhana is recalled from it, and is murdered soon after by Shashanka of Gauda.

Five patterns to carry into Part Five

1. **Nobody ever garrisons the door.** This is the defining failure of Part Four and you should be angry about it by now. Four separate powers — Kushan, Gupta, republic, Vardhana — knew that every invasion of India for eight hundred years had come through the same three or four passes, and not one of them stationed a permanent army there. Punjab is invaded repeatedly not because it is weak but because **the entrance to it is always somebody else's problem**. Watch what Jayapala and the Shahis try to do about this in Part Five, and what it costs them.
2. **Conquering Punjab is easy; holding it is not — and this part adds a crueller version.** Toramana took the plain in a season. His son lost everything within thirteen years of inheriting it. The Alchon empire in India lasted about forty years in total. Every foreign power in this part rules Punjab quickly and briefly, and none of them build anything that outlives the man in charge.
3. **The coalition forms too late and dissolves too early.** Part One had ten kings who could not combine; Part Two had the Malavas and Kshudrakas who combined and then could not agree on a commander. Part Four finally produces a coalition that works — and it works only after the invader has ruled for forty years, and it disbands the moment it wins. **Yashodharman is the proof that India could beat these invaders whenever it chose to combine, and the proof that it almost never chose to.**
4. **The invader becomes the neighbour.** The Kushans became an Indian dynasty. The Alchon fragments became the hill kingdoms and the ancestors of the Shahis, who will spend Part Five defending India against the next wave from exactly the same passes they themselves came through. **In this book, today's invader is tomorrow's frontier guard.** It happens again with the Ghaznavids in Lahore, and again after that.
5. **Punjab's history in this period was written by everyone except Punjab.** A Persian cliff inscription, two Chinese travellers, victory pillars in Madhya Pradesh, a court poet in Thanesar and a Kashmiri writing six hundred years later. **Not one contemporary Punjabi account of any of these twelve wars exists.** The winner is whoever gets written about, and in Part Four almost nobody local was writing at all.

COMING NEXT — PART FIVE

Arabs, Hindu Shahis and Mahmud of Ghazni, 712–1030. Muhammad bin Qasim reaches Multan in 712 and stops. For nearly three hundred years the Shahi kings of Kabul and the Punjab hold the passes — the first dynasty in this book to actually try — and then the Ghaznavids come. Peshawar in 1001 and the self-immolation of Jayapala. Waihind in 1008, and the panicking elephant that lost a battle. The sack of Multan, Nandana in 1014, and the long end of Trilochanapala. And at the finish, something new: Lahore becomes the capital of a foreign empire, and Punjab acquires a Muslim ruling class that never leaves.

Words Used in This Part

Sasanian

The Persian imperial dynasty founded by Ardashir I in 224 CE and destroyed by the Arabs in 651. The last pre-Islamic Persian empire.

Kushanshah

“King of the Kushans.” The title used by Persian-appointed governors of the east after the Kushan collapse. Historians call them the Kushano-Sasanians.

Gana / gana-sangha

A republic — a state governed by an assembly of clan heads rather than a hereditary king. The Yaudheyas were one. The word survives in modern Indian usage for “republic”.

Prashasti

A formal praise-inscription. Always written by the winner’s own court. Essential evidence and never neutral.

Maharajadhiraja

“Great king over kings” — the full imperial title. Its use by Toramana is how we know he considered himself an emperor of India, not a raider.

Pratyanta

“Frontier.” In the Allahabad inscription, the *pratyanta* kings are the border rulers who submit without being annexed.

Huna

The Sanskrit word used for all the Central Asian invaders of this period, regardless of who they actually were. Related to the word behind “Hun”, but not the same people as Attila’s.

Kidarite

The first of the Huna groups to enter India, from around 380 CE. Named after their king Kidara.

Hephthalite

The “White Huns” of Byzantine writers. Dominated Bactria and Iran’s eastern frontier from about 450 to 560, mostly staying north of the mountains.

Alchon

The group of Toramana and Mihirakula, named from the word that appears on their coins in Bactrian script. These are the Hunas who actually ruled Punjab.

Tamga

A clan or dynastic symbol stamped on coins and seals, used across the steppe like a brand. The Alchon tamga is how numismatists identify their coinage at a glance.

Sakala

Ancient **Sialkot**. Capital of the Madrakas, then of the Indo-Greek king Menander in Part Three, then of Mihirakula in this part.

Sthanvishvara

Ancient **Thanesar**, in the Kurukshetra country. Capital of the Vardhana family.

Vihara

A Buddhist monastery. The Kura inscription in the Salt Range records the founding of one under Toramana's rule.

Stupa

A solid domed monument built over a relic. The characteristic religious building of Gandhara, and the main target of the destruction described in War Ten.

Gandhara

The country around Peshawar and Taxila. In this part it is a Buddhist civilisation of monasteries, sculpture and learning — and it does not survive the period.

Uttarapatha

"The northern road." The ancient trunk route from the Ganges plain through Punjab to the north-west. Every army in this part uses it.

Rajatarangini

"The river of kings." The chronicle of Kashmir written by Kalhana in about 1148 CE. The source of the Mihirakula elephant story, and the only sustained historical chronicle produced in early India.

Harshacharita

"The deeds of Harsha." A court biography of the Vardhana family by the poet Bana, written in the seventh century. Brilliant prose, entirely partisan.

Sources used for this part

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- The Mehrauli iron pillar inscription of Chandra; the Bhitari pillar and Junagadh rock inscriptions of Skandagupta; the Eran boar inscription and the Kura inscription of Toramana; the Gwalior inscription of Mihirakula; the Sondani and Mandsaur inscriptions of Yashodharman; the Eran pillar inscription of 510 CE — all in Fleet, *Corpus Inscriptionum Indicarum*, vol. III
- Xuanzang, *Records of the Western Regions* (Si-Yu-Ki), in Beal's translation
- Song Yun's account of his journey through Gandhara, c. 518–522 CE
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A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions in this part are unusually large. They include: how far east Sasanian authority ever reached; whether Samudragupta fought anything at all in the north-west; the identity of “Chandra” on the iron pillar and of the Vahlikas he defeated; whether Skandagupta’s Hunas were Kidarites or Alchon; who the Pushyamitras were; whether Yashodharman fought alone or as part of a coalition with the later Guptas; and how much of the destruction of Gandharan Buddhism can honestly be laid at Mihirakula’s door rather than spread across a century of disorder. Where scholars differ, this part follows the mainstream reading and says so on the page.

Quotations from inscriptions follow the standard published translations, chiefly Fleet’s. Those translations are more than a century old and bracket a good deal of wording that is not on the stone; where a reading is disputed, it is flagged in the text rather than smoothed over.

And the warning from Part Two applies twice as hard here. Every word we have about Punjab in these four hundred years was written somewhere else, by someone with an interest — a Persian king listing his possessions, a Gupta minister praising his employer, Chinese Buddhists describing the ruin of Buddhist places, a victorious rival naming his defeated enemy on a pillar, a Kashmiri poet six centuries later. Nobody who lived through Toramana’s conquest left an account of it. When you read that Mihirakula was a monster, remember that his own subjects’ only surviving word about him is a building record — and that we would think very differently about him if the people who hated him had not been the only ones taking notes.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART FIVE OF SIXTEEN

The Arabs, the Shahis and Mahmud

Three centuries in which one dynasty finally did what nobody in this book had ever done — stand at the passes and hold them — and what happened to the land of the five rivers on the day they failed.

712 CE — 1030 CE

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Door Finally Gets a Doorkeeper

Part Four ended with a complaint: in eight hundred years, nobody had ever put an army at the passes. In Part Five, somebody does. This is the story of how long they lasted.

If you read Part Four, you finished it annoyed, and you were meant to.

Wave after wave came through the same three or four mountain passes — Persians, Kidarites, Alchon Huns — and not one Indian power ever stationed a permanent force at the entrance. Everybody defended their own fields. Nobody defended the doorway.

Part Five is different, and that is why it matters more than its reputation suggests. **The Hindu Shahi kings of Kabul and the Indus spent about a hundred and fifty years doing exactly the job that nobody had ever taken on.** They held Kabul as long as they could. When they lost it, they pulled back to the Indus and held that. When they lost the Indus, they pulled back to the Salt Range and held that. They marched on Ghazni twice rather than wait to be attacked. They assembled the largest Indian coalition since Part Two. They lost anyway, one river at a time, over sixty years, and the last of them was killed by his own soldiers.

They are also the most under-remembered dynasty in this whole book, and the man who wrote their obituary was on the other side.

Four things that change permanently in this part

- **Islam arrives in Punjab, and it arrives twice.** First in 712, as an Arab army that takes Multan and then stops for three hundred years. Then again after 1000, as a Turkish dynasty from Afghanistan that does not stop. Those are two completely different events and this part keeps them apart.
- **Punjab stops being a target and becomes a base.** This is the biggest structural change since Part Two. From the 1020s, **Lahore is the seat of a foreign government** rather than a place foreign governments raid. Every part after this one is shaped by that.
- **The sources get much better and much more one-sided.** For the first time since Part Two we have detailed, dated, named battle accounts — written almost entirely by the court historians of the winning side, in Persian and Arabic, for patrons who paid them.
- **The frontier moves, and never moves back.** In 870 the defenders of India lose Kabul. Everything after that is fought on Indian ground.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a writer who was there or in the next room, or a coin or inscription cut at the time. **LIKELY** means good sources writing later, generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition, often written centuries afterwards.

Part Five has a particular problem worth naming at the start. Our best sources — **al-Utbi**, who was a Ghaznavid court secretary, and **Ferishta**, who wrote six hundred years later — were writing to praise. Their numbers are inflated as a matter of professional routine, and their explanations for why things happened are the explanations a court wanted to hear. **Every battle in this part is described by the winner's employee.** The only major writer of the period who is not doing that is al-Biruni, and he is the reason the Shahis have a reputation at all.

Multan, 712 — The Arabs Reach the Punjab

LIKELY

A seventeen-year-old general took the richest city in southern Punjab by cutting off its water, and then India did not see another Arab army for three hundred years.

WON BY

The Umayyad Caliphate — under a very young man with a very short career

WHEN 712 CE, at the end of a two-year campaign that began in Sindh.	WHERE Multan, on the lower rivers of southern Punjab — then, as now, the gateway between Sindh and the plain.
WHO Muhammad bin Qasim, aged about seventeen, against the ruler of Multan and the remnant of Raja Dahir’s kingdom.	THE EVIDENCE Arab historians writing later, and the <i>Chach Nama</i> — a Persian book of the 1200s claiming to translate a lost Arabic original.

Why it happened

The official reason is a piracy incident. Pirates operating out of Debal on the Sindh coast seized ships carrying goods and passengers belonging to the Caliphate. The governor of Iraq, **al-Hajjaj**, demanded compensation from Raja Dahir of Sindh, who replied — reasonably — that he did not control the pirates.

That is the stated cause and it may even be true. The real cause is the same one that produced every other war in this book: **a fast-expanding empire had run out of easy directions**. In the same handful of years, Arab armies took North Africa, crossed into Spain, and pushed into Central Asia. Sindh was one front out of three, and it was the smallest.

It is worth putting those dates side by side, because almost nobody does. **Tariq ibn Ziyad landed in Spain in 711. Muhammad bin Qasim landed in Sindh in the same year**. Two young commanders, one caliph, two ends of the known world, the same decade.

What happened

1. **Debal falls, 711**. The port is stormed after a siege. The campaign then moves up the Indus.
2. **Raja Dahir is killed** in battle at Rawar, fighting from an elephant. His kingdom breaks apart over the following months, city by city.

3. **Brahmanabad, then Aror.** The pattern in each case is a siege, a negotiated surrender by the merchants and priests inside, and terms: pay the tax, keep your temples, keep your law. This becomes the model for Arab rule in Sindh.
4. **Multan is besieged, 712.** The city held out — the accounts say for weeks, some say months. It was strongly walled and well supplied.
5. **The Arabs cut the water.** A deserter is said to have shown them the channel that fed the city. It was diverted, and Multan surrendered. **The oldest weapon in Punjab, used again.** In Part One the Bharatas broke a dyke on the Ravi to win the first recorded battle in Indian history. Two thousand years later, the answer is still water.
6. **And then it stops.** Muhammad bin Qasim was recalled almost immediately — the caliph who had appointed his patron died, the new regime had no use for him, and he was arrested and died in custody in his early twenties. Multan and Sindh became the far edge of the Arab world and stayed there.

ON THE CHACH NAMA, WHICH IS WHERE MOST OF THE GOOD STORIES COME FROM

Almost every vivid detail of this campaign — the speeches, the negotiations, the doomed princesses, the young general's fate — comes from the *Chach Nama*, written in Persian in the thirteenth century by Ali Kufi, who says he is translating a much older Arabic history.

Modern scholars are divided about how much of it is genuine early material and how much is thirteenth-century political writing dressed as history. **Treat its narrative shape as literature and its bare skeleton — dates, places, the sequence of cities — as broadly reliable**, because that skeleton is corroborated by earlier Arab historians.

WHY THE ARABS WON

- **They had a decade of unbroken practice.** This army came from a war machine that had taken Egypt, North Africa and Persia within living memory. It knew how to besiege a city.
- **They came up the river.** The Indus gave them supply, transport and a fixed line of advance. Every city they wanted was on it.
- **The terms were survivable.** Pay the tax and keep your temples and your law. Against a besieging army, a merchant community will take that deal, and repeatedly did.
- **They found the water.** Once you can drain a city, walls stop mattering.

WHY SINDH AND MULTAN LOST

- **Dahir fought alone.** No neighbouring Indian king sent help. Kanauj did not come, Kashmir did not come, the Punjab plain did not come.
- **He fought a decisive battle in person, on an elephant.** A visible king on a visible animal is the most conspicuous target on a battlefield. When he fell, the war effectively ended in an afternoon.
- **His kingdom was a recent conquest.** Dahir's family had taken Sindh only two generations earlier. Cities with no loyalty to a dynasty negotiate quickly.
- **Every city defended itself separately.** The oldest failure in this book, in its purest form: a chain of strong walled towns falling one at a time to the same army.

The Idol That Defended a City for Three Hundred Years

Multan had a temple, and the temple had an idol, and the idol became one of the strangest pieces of diplomacy in Indian history.

The temple was to the sun. It was ancient — old enough that Chinese pilgrims had described it before the Arabs arrived — and it was enormously rich, because pilgrims came to it from all over northern India and left offerings. Arab geographers who saw it in the ninth and tenth centuries described the idol in detail: a seated wooden figure, covered in red leather, with jewels for eyes. They also recorded the arithmetic. **A large share of the entire revenue of Multan came from pilgrims visiting that one building.**

Muhammad bin Qasim did not destroy it. He took the accumulated treasure — this is why Arab writers nicknamed Multan the *Frontier House of Gold* — and then left the temple standing and the pilgrimage running, and taxed it. A working shrine is an annual income. A destroyed shrine is a one-off.

What happened next is the part nobody expects. According to several Arab geographers, when a Hindu king marched on Multan to retake it, **the Muslim rulers of the city would bring the idol out onto the walls and threaten to destroy it — and the attacking army would withdraw.**

For roughly three centuries, the most effective defence of Muslim Multan was a Hindu god held hostage by its own custodians.

It is a story about how conquest actually worked in this period, and it is a useful corrective to hold on to for the rest of this part. **The men doing this were not confused about their religion. They were running a city, and the shrine was the treasury, the tourist trade and the anti-aircraft gun all at once.**

The Arab Advance Runs Out of Road

LIKELY

The same empire that took Spain got two hundred miles into India and stopped for three hundred years. Somebody stopped it.

WON BY

The Pratiharas, the Chalukyas — and by the sheer size of India

WHEN Roughly 724–740 CE, the period of the great raids out of Sindh.	WHERE Out of Multan and Sindh into Rajasthan, Malwa and Gujarat — and towards the Punjab plain and Kashmir.
WHO The Arab governors of Sindh, above all Junaid ibn Abd al-Rahman, against Nagabhata I of the Pratiharas and the Chalukya commander Pulakeshin.	THE EVIDENCE Arab chronicles for the raids; Indian inscriptions for the defence. The two barely mention each other.

Why it matters

This is one of the genuinely decisive turning points in Indian history, and it is almost unknown, because the sources for it are scattered and dull.

In the 720s and 730s the Arab governors of Sindh launched a series of large raids inland. They reached deep into Rajasthan, into Malwa, into Gujarat, and towards Ujjain. Arab writers list the places they burned. **Then the raids stop, and the frontier settles at the Indus and Multan, and it stays there for the next two hundred and eighty years.**

Something made that happen. Two Indian dynasties claim credit, on stone, in their own inscriptions.

What happened

- 1. Junaid raids inland from about 724.** The Arab lists are long and geographically wide. Whether these were conquests or plundering expeditions is exactly the question, and the answer is almost certainly the second.
- 2. Nagabhata I of the Pratiharas stops them,** somewhere in the Rajasthan–Malwa country. Pratihara inscriptions describe him as the destroyer of the armies of the *mlechchhas* — the foreigners — and it is the founding achievement of the dynasty, the thing they built their legitimacy on for two centuries afterwards.

3. **The Chalukya prince Pulakeshin stops another force in Gujarat**, around 738. His own inscription gives him a title that translates roughly as “the refuge of the western country”, awarded for repelling the Arab army.
4. **The Arabs consolidate instead of advancing.** New garrison cities are founded in Sindh; the province turns inward and, within a century, is effectively independent of the Caliphate anyway.
5. **And the Caliphate itself changes.** The Umayyads fall in 750 and the Abbasids move the centre of the Muslim world to Baghdad, whose interests were Mediterranean and Persian. Sindh became a distant, unprofitable outpost that nobody in the capital was thinking about.

HANDLE WITH CARE

Both Indian dynasties are describing their own victories on their own monuments, and neither names a specific battlefield in a way we can locate. The Arab sources record the raids and then simply stop recording them, without ever admitting a defeat — which is what court chronicles always do.

So the fact is solid and the details are not. The Arab advance into India was checked in the middle of the eighth century by Indian armies in the west, and the Pratiharas got a two-hundred-year reputation out of it. Where, exactly, and on what day, nobody can tell you.

WHY INDIA HELD HERE

- **The invader was at the end of a very long rope.** Sindh to Baghdad is an enormous distance. Reinforcements, money and attention all had to travel it.
- **They met organised states, not city walls.** The Pratiharas and Chalukyas were large, cavalry-equipped kingdoms with the resources to lose a battle and come back. Sindh had not been.
- **The desert did half the work.** An army coming out of Sindh towards the Ganges has to cross very bad country. Everything gets harder the further in you go.
- **The Caliphate had bigger arguments elsewhere.** Civil war, dynastic collapse, and a new capital pointed the other way.

WHY THE ARABS DID NOT PUSH ON

- **Raiding paid better than conquering.** There was no revenue model for holding Rajasthan, and there was an obvious one for burning it periodically.
- **Sindh was already hard to hold.** Governors were replaced constantly, and rebellions were routine. An unstable base cannot support an offensive.
- **They had no local partner.** In Spain, Arab armies found a broken kingdom and useful allies. In India they found kingdoms that were, for once, not interested in inviting anybody in.
- **Distance beats everybody eventually.** The same wall Alexander hit on the Beas, from the opposite direction.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE ABOUT ROADS NOT TAKEN

Two Landings, One Year, Two Different Worlds

In 711 an Arab army crossed a narrow strait into Spain. In the same year, another Arab army landed on the coast of Sindh. Both were small. Both were commanded by young men. Both were sent by the same caliph, from the same capital, in the same wave of expansion.

Within a few years, the Spanish force had taken almost the entire Iberian peninsula. What followed there lasted nearly eight hundred years and produced Cordoba, one of the great cities of the medieval world: libraries, translation from Greek, astronomy, agriculture, architecture that is still standing.

The Indian force took Sindh, reached Multan, ran into the Pratiharas and the Chalukyas and the Thar desert, and stopped. **Arab Sindh remained a strip of river valley — a province the Caliphate mostly forgot, ruled by dynasties that were effectively independent within a century.**

It is one of history's cleanest natural experiments. Same empire, same decade, same religion, same tactics. One direction opened into a civilisation. The other closed after two hundred miles.

And the reason it closed matters for everything that follows in this book. **India was not saved in 738 by unity, by faith or by heroism. It was saved by distance, by desert, by two dynasties who happened to be strong at the right moment, and by a change of government in Baghdad.**

Three hundred years later, the next invader would come from three hundred miles away instead of three thousand — and none of those defences would apply.

Lalitaditya Comes Down From Kashmir

STORY

For once the army came from the mountains to the north instead of the passes to the west — and Punjab was conquered by a king its own chronicler could not stop exaggerating.

WON BY Lalitaditya Muktapida of Kashmir — to an extent nobody can measure

WHEN Roughly 724–760 CE. Kashmiri dates for this period are approximate.	WHERE The Punjab plain, the hill states, and — if you believe the source — most of northern India and a good deal of Central Asia.
WHO Lalitaditya of the Karkota dynasty of Kashmir, against Yashovarman of Kanauj, the Turk Shahis, the Tibetans and others.	THE EVIDENCE Kalhana's <i>Rajatarangini</i>, written about four hundred years later, plus Chinese and Tibetan records that confirm he existed and mattered.

Why Kashmir was suddenly a great power

Because of where it sat. In the eighth century, three expanding empires met in the mountains north of Punjab: the Arabs coming from the west, the Tang Chinese pushing across Central Asia, and the Tibetan empire — which in this century was one of the strongest military powers in Asia, and would later occupy the Chinese capital itself.

Kashmir was in the middle of that, and it was rich and defensible. Under the Karkota kings it turned that position into an empire. **Lalitaditya sent embassies to the Tang court asking for joint action against the Tibetans; the Chinese records confirm it.** That is a Kashmiri king conducting foreign policy at continental scale, and it is the single strongest evidence that the boasts about him are not entirely invented.

What Kalhana says, and what we can keep

- 1. He conquers the Punjab plain and the hill country.** This is the part that concerns us, and it is the most plausible part of the whole account. Kashmir's natural expansion is straight down into Punjab, and it happened repeatedly in later centuries too.
- 2. He defeats Yashovarman of Kanauj,** the most powerful king in northern India at the time. This is widely accepted, and Yashovarman's own decline supports it.

3. **He fights the Turks and the Tibetans in the north.** Also plausible and corroborated in outline by the Chinese material.
4. **He then conquers, in Kalhana's telling, essentially everywhere** — the Deccan, Bengal, the coast, the far north — in a world tour of victory that is standard for this kind of writing and should be read as praise rather than geography.
5. **He builds enormously**, above all the great sun temple at Martand in Kashmir, whose ruins still stand. The building programme is real and is the best physical proof that somebody in Kashmir had a lot of money in this period.

WHY THIS ONE IS LABELLED STORY

Kalhana is the best historian early India produced and he is still writing four centuries after the events, from Kashmiri court tradition, about the greatest king in his own country's history. The *digvijaya* — the conquest of all directions — is a literary form, not a campaign log.

What survives sober assessment is this: **an unusually capable Kashmiri king, in a century when Kashmir was genuinely strong, campaigned successfully into the Punjab plain and beat the leading power of the Ganges.** That is enough to put him in this book. The rest is decoration.

WHY KASHMIR WON

- **He could come down whenever he liked and could not easily be followed up.** The valley is a fortress with doors that open outwards.
- **He was fighting a divided plain.** Post-Harsha northern India was a set of competing kingdoms with no combination, exactly as it had been left at the end of Part Four.
- **He had cavalry and money.** Kashmir sat on the trade routes between India and Central Asia and taxed them.
- **He played the great powers off against each other**, corresponding with China against Tibet. Very few Indian rulers in this book ever conduct diplomacy at that range.

WHY IT DID NOT LAST A GENERATION

- **It was a personal empire.** Same disease as Harsha in Part Four. Held together by one man's ability, with no institution beneath it.
- **Kashmir was too small to garrison the plain.** A valley kingdom can raid and dominate the Punjab. It cannot administer it.
- **His successors fought each other.** The Karkota dynasty after him dissolves into exactly the kind of succession chaos that ends every empire in this book.
- **And the plain was left weaker.** Which is the part that matters. When the Shahis had to hold the north-west a century later, the Punjab behind them had just been worked over by Kashmir.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE COLD ONE

The Advice He Left Behind

Kalhana records that before the end of his life, Lalitaditya sent a set of instructions to his ministers and successors on how to keep the kingdom. It is one of the most chilling passages in Indian literature, and it is chilling precisely because it is so practical.

The advice, in substance, is this. **The villagers must never be allowed to accumulate more grain than they need for a single year, or more oxen than they need to work their fields.** If they hold more than that, they will become strong, they will stop obeying, and no king will be able to control them. The frontier peoples in particular must be kept poor, because a prosperous frontier is a rebellious one.

Read it twice. This is not a tyrant raging. It is a successful king, at the end of a long reign, calmly explaining the mechanism of his own rule to the men who will inherit it: *keep them one harvest away from hunger and they will never be able to afford a rebellion.*

Kalhana reports it without much comment, as a piece of statecraft. He may have made it up, or shaped it, or found it in an older text. But it survived in the Kashmiri tradition for four hundred years because somebody thought it was worth writing down as wisdom.

Keep it in mind for the rest of this book, because the question it raises never goes away. **Every conqueror in these sixteen parts is remembered for the battles. Almost none of them are remembered for what they did on the ordinary Tuesdays in between — and that is the part that the people of Punjab actually lived through.**

870 — The Year India Lost Kabul

LIKELY

A coppersmith from a desert town took the city that had guarded the road into India for a thousand years, and it never came back.

WON BY

Ya'qub ibn Layth al-Saffar — a bandit chief who became a king

WHEN 870 CE, with the fighting running on either side of it for a decade.	WHERE Kabul and the country around it — the last Indian-ruled territory west of the mountains.
WHO Ya'qub the Coppersmith of the Saffarid dynasty, against the Turk Shahi king of Kabul.	THE EVIDENCE Arab and Persian chronicles. Al-Biruni, writing 150 years later, for the dynastic background.

Who was holding the door

Two dynasties, one after the other, and their relationship is one of the most striking things in this book.

The first were the **Turk Shahis**, who ruled Kabul and Gandhara from roughly the middle of the seventh century. Their name gives away where they came from: they were Turkish, descended from exactly the sort of Central Asian people who had spent Part Four invading India. **The wreckage of the Hun and post-Hun period had settled down, become local, and turned into the frontier guard.** Part Four ended by predicting this. Here it is.

For two hundred years, the Turk Shahis held Kabul against repeated Arab attacks. They were beaten several times, agreed to pay tribute several times, and stopped paying every time the pressure lifted. It was not glorious. It worked.

The second dynasty is the one this part is about. Al-Biruni records that the last Turk Shahi king was displaced by his own Brahmin minister, whose name he gives as Kallar, and that this man founded a new line — the **Hindu Shahis**. The date is uncertain and the story of the takeover is thin. What is not in doubt is that from the later ninth century the frontier is held by a Hindu dynasty ruling from the Kabul valley and the Indus.

What happened

1. **The Caliphate's grip on eastern Iran collapses**, and local strongmen take over. The most successful is Ya'qub ibn Layth, from Sistan, who genuinely had been a coppersmith — *saffar* — and who began his career

leading armed bands before turning them into an army and himself into a ruler.

2. **He takes Kabul in 870.** The Shahi king is defeated. Reports of the plunder sent back west include images of Indian gods, forwarded to Baghdad as proof of the victory.
3. **The Shahis fall back to the Indus.** Their capital becomes **Udabhandapura** — Waihind to Muslim writers, Hund today — on the right bank of the Indus above Attock. They hold the river line and the Peshawar valley for the next century.
4. **They rebuild, and they do it well.** Under kings like Lalliya and later Bhima, the Shahi state recovers enough to be treated as a serious power by everyone around it. Kashmiri sources treat Shahi kings as significant allies and relatives; one Shahi princess, Didda, becomes the ruling queen of Kashmir.
5. **But Kabul is gone.** That is the sentence that matters. Every subsequent war in this part is fought on the Indian side of the mountains.

WHY LOSING KABUL WAS WORSE THAN LOSING A BATTLE

Look at the geography honestly. A power holding the Kabul valley controls the western ends of the passes. It gets warning, it has depth, and it fights its wars in Afghanistan rather than in the Punjab.

A power holding only the Indus has none of that. **It finds out an army is coming when the army appears at the top of the pass, three or four marches from Peshawar.** Every Shahi defeat after 870 has this shape: a frontier force meeting an invasion that is already through the mountains.

And this is permanent. From 870 until the twentieth century, no Indian power holds Kabul except in brief episodes. The door that Part Four complained about being unguarded is, from now on, guarded — but from the other side.

WHY THE SAFFARIDS WON

- **They were a new, hungry, professional army.** Ya'qub's men fought constantly for a decade and were led by a man who had risen from nothing on results.
- **They came from the near side.** Sistan to Kabul is a short campaign. This is the beginning of the change that decides the whole period: **the threat is now regional, not imperial.**
- **The Shahis were fighting a two-front problem in the mountains,** with hostile powers on several sides and no depth behind Kabul.

WHY THE SHAHIS LOST KABUL

- **They had been on the defensive for two centuries.** A line that is attacked every generation eventually breaks on one of the attempts.
- **Nobody in India helped, ever.** Not the Pratiharas, not Kashmir except by marriage, not the Punjab kingdoms behind them. The dynasty holding the frontier was fighting for the subcontinent with the resources of a border province.
- **Their own change of dynasty came at the worst time.** A takeover at the top, then a major invasion within a generation.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Kindest Thing Ever Written About an Enemy

Around 1030 CE, a scholar named **al-Biruni** finished a book about India. He was Central Asian, he wrote in Arabic, he had learned Sanskrit, and he had come to India in the baggage train of Mahmud of Ghazni — the man who destroyed the Shahis. He was, in the most literal sense, on the other side.

He was also one of the finest minds of the medieval world: an astronomer, a mathematician, a geographer, and a man with an almost modern instinct for checking what he was told. His book on India is by a distance the best thing anybody wrote about the country in a thousand years, and it is full of complaints about how badly Indians and Muslims understood each other.

When he came to the Shahis, he wrote their obituary. He recorded that the dynasty was extinct, that not the slightest remnant of the house remained — and then, having no reason at all to say it, added that **in all their grandeur they never slackened in the desire to do what was good and right, and that they were men of noble sentiment and noble bearing.**

That is a scholar attached to the winning court, writing about the family his patron had just wiped out, and going out of his way to say that they were decent people.

Almost everything we know about the Shahis comes from men who were paid to celebrate their destruction. **Al-Biruni is the reason they have a reputation at all — and the reason we can be reasonably sure it is deserved.** Remember him when you read the battle accounts that follow, because he is the control sample. He shows you what an honest writer from that court sounded like, which lets you hear what the others are doing.

Ghazna, 962–988 — Jayapala Attacks First

LIKELY

The Shahis did the one thing no defender in this book ever does. They marched on the enemy’s capital, twice, before he could march on theirs.

WON BY

Ghazna — after losing the first round and nearly the second

WHEN

962 for the founding of Ghazna; the Shahi wars run c. 986–988.

WHERE

Ghazni and the Lamghan valley in Afghanistan, and the country west of the Indus.

WHO

Sabuktigin of Ghazna against Jayapala, king of the Hindu Shahis.

THE EVIDENCE

Al-Utbi’s *Tarikh-i Yamini*, written by a Ghaznavid court secretary within living memory, and later Persian historians.

Where Ghazna came from

This is worth understanding properly, because the institution that produced Mahmud is one of the most consequential things in Indian history.

The Turkish dynasties of Central Asia bought slaves — *ghulams* — trained them as soldiers, and promoted the best of them into command. It was a rational system: a slave officer had no clan, no land and no family faction, so his loyalty ran to the ruler alone. It also had an obvious failure mode. **If you spend a century putting your best soldiers in charge of your armies, one of them will eventually notice that he is the one holding the weapons.**

In 962 a Turkish slave-general named **Alptigin** fell out with his masters and seized the mountain town of **Ghazna**, south of Kabul, for himself. His own former slave and son-in-law, **Sabuktigin**, eventually took over and turned the place into a state.

Ghazna sat about three hundred miles from Peshawar. That is the whole story of the next seventy years. **For the first time, a strong, aggressive, professional military power had its capital next door to India rather than at the far end of Asia.**

What happened

1. **The Shahis try to take Ghazna back early.** The records for the 960s are thin, and the tradition that a Shahi king named Bhima campaigned against Alptigin cannot be checked properly. What is clear is that the Shahis recognised the threat at once and did not wait.
2. **Jayapala invades Afghanistan, around 986.** He marched a large army towards Ghazni. This is remarkable and almost unique in this book: **an Indian king going west through the passes to attack the invader's base before the invasion happened.**
3. **The campaign fails in the mountains.** Fighting near Ghazni went badly, and then the weather turned. Jayapala sued for peace, offering money, elephants and territory.
4. **He then repudiates the treaty.** Back on his own ground, Jayapala refused to pay and imprisoned the envoys sent to collect. Al-Utbi presents this as treachery; it can equally be read as a king refusing to fund the enemy who was about to attack him.
5. **Sabuktigin invades in return, around 988,** and this time wins decisively in the Lamghan country. Jayapala loses the territory west of the Indus — everything the dynasty still held on the Afghan side.
6. **The frontier is now the river.** Peshawar and the Indus crossings become the front line, and Sabuktigin's son inherits a war that is already half won.

INTERROGATING A FAMOUS STORY

Al-Utbi explains Jayapala's defeat in the mountains with a miracle. There was a spring near the battlefield which the Indians held sacred, and which was believed to produce a terrible storm if anything unclean were thrown into it. Sabuktigin, the story goes, deliberately defiled it — and a fearful storm duly broke over the Indian army and destroyed it.

Consider what is actually being described: **an army from the Punjab plain, campaigning in the Afghan highlands, caught by a snowstorm.** That does not need a miracle. It needs a calendar. Armies from warm plains have been wrecked by mountain weather in every century of recorded history.

What the anecdote really tells us is about the writer. Al-Utbi has a defeated Hindu army, a devout Muslim patron, and a storm; the story assembles itself. **The weather is the fact. The sacrilege is the sermon.**

WHY GHAZNA WON

- **They were fighting at home.** Mountain country, their own supply lines, their own winter.
- **A professional standing army.** Ghaznavid forces were paid, permanent and drilled, built around Turkish mounted archers. Indian armies of this period were assembled from contingents.
- **Horses.** Central Asia bred them, India largely imported them. This single logistical fact runs under every battle in the next four hundred years of this book.
- **They had a reason to keep coming.** Ghazna was a poor mountain state whose economy increasingly depended on what it could take from India. Peace was not affordable for them.

WHY JAYAPALA LOST

- **He attacked into the worst possible terrain in the worst possible season.** The instinct was right; the execution was fatal.
- **Elephants in the mountains.** The Indian battle-winning arm was close to useless on Afghan slopes, and it had to be fed the whole way there.
- **He broke a treaty he could not defend.** Refusing to pay was defensible; imprisoning the envoys handed Sabuktigin the justification for a full invasion.
- **Still, nobody came.** Say it again, because it will be true every time: no other Indian kingdom sent a soldier.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Only Man Who Went Looking For Them

Go back through this book and count how many Indian rulers took an army west through the passes to attack the threat before it arrived.

In four parts covering two and a half thousand years, the answer is very close to none. Punjab's rulers defend. They fight at the river, at the fort, at the city, in their own fields. They fight after the invasion has started, on ground the invader has chosen, at a moment the invader picked.

Jayapala did not. Some time around 986 he took a Punjabi army out of the Peshawar valley, up through the passes, into the Afghan mountains in the cold season, and went to burn the enemy's capital before the enemy could burn his.

He was wrong about almost every practical detail and completely right about the strategic problem. He had grasped what nobody in this book had grasped since Part Two: that a power sitting at Ghazna with a professional cavalry army was not a raiding nuisance but an existential problem, and that waiting for it on the Indus meant losing slowly.

It cost him the war, and eventually his kingdom, and eventually his life. But it is why he is in this book with a story of his own, and it is why the next war is the one people remember.

He is one of the very few figures in these sixteen parts who lost every major battle he fought and still deserves the space. **Being right too early and too poorly equipped is its own category of failure, and Punjab produces it more than most places.**

Peshawar, 27 November 1001

CERTAIN

The first battle in this book with a day, a month and a year attached — and it ends with a king walking into a fire he lit himself.

WON BY

Mahmud of Ghazni — the first of seventeen invasions

WHEN

27 November 1001 CE. From here on, this book has real dates.

WHERE

Near **Peshawar**, on the plain east of the pass, with the Indus behind the Shahi army.

WHO

Mahmud of Ghazni, three years into his reign, against **Jayapala**, at the end of his.

THE NUMBERS CLAIMED

12,000 horse, 30,000 foot and 300 elephants on the Shahi side, with 15,000 killed. **All from the winner’s historian.**

Why it happened

Sabuktigin died in 997. His son **Mahmud** took Ghazna after a short fight with his brother and was in full control by 998. He was twenty-seven, he had inherited a professional army and a treasury that needed refilling, and he had also inherited a half-finished war with a neighbour who had already been beaten twice.

Mahmud’s method, over the next thirty years, would be seventeen campaigns into India. It is worth being clear about the logic at the start, because it explains everything that follows. **Ghazna was a mountain capital in poor country supporting an expensive standing army. India was the richest region within reach, and its wealth was concentrated in temples, treasuries and cities that could be reached and returned from in a single campaigning season.** The Shahis stood between the two.

What happened

1. **Mahmud comes through the passes in the autumn of 1001** and takes position near Peshawar.
2. **Jayapala meets him in the open**, with the Indus at his back — a choice that would decide the day.
3. **The armies face each other for some days** before the fighting starts, with Mahmud waiting for reinforcements to come up.
4. **The Ghaznavid cavalry breaks the Shahi line.** The detailed tactical account is thin even in Utbi. What is consistent is that mounted archers wore down a larger, slower army and then broke it.

5. **The rout is catastrophic because of the river.** An army that breaks with a great river behind it cannot disperse. This is the same trap that will destroy the Sikh army at Sobraon eight hundred and forty-five years later, in Part Fourteen, on the Sutlej.
6. **Jayapala is captured alive**, along with a large number of his family and officers. Utbi makes much of the necklaces taken from him — one of them, he says, worth a fortune by itself.
7. **He is paraded, and then ransomed and released.** Mahmud took a payment, took territory, and let the old king go home. That was not mercy; a released king who has been publicly humiliated is more useful than a dead one.

NUMBERS GET INTERROGATED, NOT PRINTED

Utbi's figures — 12,000 horse, 30,000 foot, 300 elephants, 15,000 dead — are the numbers a court historian produces to make a victory sound like a victory. Elephant counts in the low hundreds are routinely inflated across all medieval Indian sources. A dead count that lands on a round 15,000 is a literary number.

What we can safely keep: the Shahi army was large, it was beaten decisively in open battle, its casualties were heavy, and its king and much of his family were taken alive. That much is confirmed by what happens next, which is that the Shahi state never fights on equal terms again.

WHY MAHMUD WON

- **Mounted archery against a standing line.** Ghaznavid cavalry could shoot, withdraw, and repeat. An infantry-and-elephant army has no answer except to close, and it cannot catch them.
- **A single command.** Mahmud's army obeyed one man who had trained it. The Shahi force was a royal army plus feudal contingents.
- **He chose when to fight.** He arrived, waited for his reinforcements, and engaged when he was ready.
- **He knew the ground.** His father had fought over the same country twice. This was a familiar battlefield for Ghazna and an emergency for the Shahis.

WHY JAYAPALA LOST

- **He fought with a river at his back.** The single worst decision available. It turned a defeat into a catastrophe.
- **He fought in the open against better cavalry.** The Shahi advantage was fortresses and hill country. He gave it away.
- **Elephants against horse archers on flat ground.** Slow, enormous targets that panic. You will see this fail again at Waihind in seven years' time.
- **He was out of options.** He had already lost the west, could not out-wait an invader who lived three hundred miles away, and had no allies. Fighting was a bad plan with no better one behind it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE HARDEST ONE IN THIS PART

The King Who Judged Himself

Jayapala came home. He had been captured, displayed to the enemy army, valued in public by the jewellery taken off his neck, and then released for money — the money of the kingdom he had failed to defend.

What he did next is recorded consistently by the Muslim historians who had no reason to invent it and every reason to find it strange.

He called an assembly. He announced that a king who had been defeated twice and taken prisoner had forfeited the right to rule, and that his misfortunes were his own responsibility and no one else's. He placed his son **Anandapala** on the throne in his place.

And then he had a pyre built, and he burned himself on it.

The Persian sources report this with an odd, careful tone — as something foreign and shocking and not entirely without dignity. They understood exactly what it meant. This was not despair and it was not a religious act in any simple sense. **It was a verdict, and he was both the judge and the accused.**

You can argue about whether it was brave or a waste. What it was, unmistakably, is a statement about what a Shahi king believed his job to be. He had one duty — to hold the gate — and he had failed it twice, and in his own judgement that carried a price which someone had to pay.

His son inherited the throne, the war, and that standard. Anandapala would fight Mahmud within a decade, at the head of the largest Indian alliance assembled in eight hundred years, and lose it to a frightened elephant.

Multan Again, 1006–1010 — A Muslim Army Marches on a Muslim City

LIKELY

A Hindu king blocked the road, a Muslim king was the target, and the Shahi prince in the middle changed religion twice. This is the war that ruins the simple version of this period.

WON BY Mahmud — against everybody in turn

WHEN	WHERE
1006 for the first campaign, with a revolt in 1007–08 and a final settlement around 1010.	Multan, and the road to it across the Punjab plain.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Mahmud against Abu'l Fath Daud, the Ismaili ruler of Multan; and against Anandapala, who refused him passage; and against his own appointed governor.	Al-Utbi and later Persian historians, all of them keen to explain why this was a holy war.

Why it happened

Multan by the year 1000 was ruled by a dynasty belonging to the **Ismaili** branch of Shia Islam — often called Qarmatians by their enemies, which is roughly as neutral as calling someone a heretic. They were connected to the Fatimid caliphate in Egypt, which was the great rival of the Sunni Abbasid caliphate in Baghdad.

Mahmud's entire legitimacy rested on being the sword of the Baghdad caliph. He collected titles from the caliph the way other rulers collected provinces. **An Ismaili state on his flank, allied to Baghdad's enemy, was a political problem long before it was a religious one.**

And Multan was rich, which never hurt.

What happened, and why it is so tangled

1. **Mahmud marches for Multan in 1006** and asks Anandapala for passage across Shahi territory.
2. **Anandapala refuses.** Think about that for a moment. The Hindu Shahi king blocked a Sunni army from attacking a Shia Muslim city. He was not defending Islam or Hinduism; he was defending a frontier, and he was not going to let an enemy army walk across his kingdom for any reason at all.

3. **Mahmud beats him and marches on anyway**, pushing Anandapala aside and reaching Multan, which submits and is fined heavily.
4. **Mahmud appoints a Shahi prince as governor**. This is **Sukhpal**, a grandson of Jayapala, who had been captured as a boy — probably at Peshawar — had converted to Islam, and had taken the name Nawasa Shah. Mahmud installed him to run the Punjab frontier.
5. **Sukhpal rebels in 1007–08**. With Mahmud occupied elsewhere, he renounced Islam, returned to his family's religion and declared himself independent.
6. **Mahmud comes back, crushes him, and imprisons him for life**, taking a vast sum from him. Multan is dealt with again around 1010 and this time absorbed properly.

WHAT THIS WAR DOES TO THE STANDARD STORY

This period is usually told as Islam versus India, and it is very often told that way for reasons that have to do with the twentieth century rather than the eleventh. This particular war does not fit the frame at any point, and it is not an exception — it is a fair sample.

In it you have **a Muslim army attacking a Muslim city** over a dispute between rival caliphates; **a Hindu king intervening to stop it** for reasons of frontier security; **a converted Hindu prince governing for the invader**, then converting back and rebelling for reasons that look entirely political.

None of that means religion was irrelevant — it plainly mattered enormously to the people involved, and Mahmud's campaigns against temples were real and were described in explicitly religious language by his own historians. **It means religion was one force among several, and in this particular decade it was not usually the one deciding who fought whom.** A book that cannot hold both those statements at once is not describing the eleventh century.

WHY MAHMUD WON

- **He fought his enemies one at a time**, and his enemies obligingly stayed separate. Multan and the Shahis never once combined against him even when they were both his targets.
- **He could return**. Ghazna was near. A rebellion in Punjab meant a campaign next season, not a lost province.
- **Religious framing bought him political cover**. Attacking a Shia state as a Sunni champion earned him titles and legitimacy in Baghdad, whatever the underlying motive was.
- **He used local rulers and discarded them**. Installing a Shahi prince was cheap government. When it failed, the cost was one campaign.

WHY THE PUNJAB KEPT LOSING

- **Multan and the Shahis were natural allies who behaved as rivals**. Both were destroyed within a decade by the same man.
- **Anandapala spent his strength on a war he was not the target of**. He fought a battle in 1006 to protect a city that would not have helped him.
- **The frontier had no depth left**. With Kabul and the west gone, every campaign now happened inside Punjab.
- **Collaboration was rational for individuals and fatal collectively**. Sukhpal made a sensible personal choice at every step, and the result was another Ghaznavid campaign.

The Grandson

Follow one life through this war, because it contains the whole period.

A boy is born into the Shahi royal family, the dynasty that has held India's frontier for a hundred and thirty years. His grandfather is Jayapala. His childhood is spent in a kingdom permanently at war.

Then he is captured — most likely as a child at Peshawar, in the same battle that ended his grandfather. He is taken to Ghazna, raised there, converts to Islam and is given a new name, **Nawasa Shah**. He is educated, trusted, and eventually sent back to the Punjab as the governor of the very frontier his family used to rule.

He lasts about two years. Then he renounces the religion, drops the name, and declares himself an independent king in his grandfather's country.

Mahmud came back with an army, took everything he had, and put him in a fortress. He was, so far as the record shows, still there when he died.

Nobody has ever known what to do with him. Muslim historians treat him as an apostate and a traitor. Later Hindu accounts have no place for a convert. He is a footnote in both traditions and a hero in neither.

But he is the most honest character in this part, because he is what conquest actually does to people. He was not a villain or a martyr. He was a captured child who was raised by the men who destroyed his family, given power by them, and then threw it away to try to be what he had been born as — and failed at that too.

There is a version of him in every part of this book from here on. Most of them do not get a name.

Waihind, 1008 — The Battle Lost by One Elephant

LIKELY

India assembled its largest alliance in eight hundred years, brought it to the field, was winning — and then an animal got frightened.

WON BY Mahmud — by about ten minutes, and not by his own doing

WHEN 1008 CE, sometimes dated to 1008–09. Also called the battle of Chach.	WHERE Near Waihind — Hund, on the Indus — the Shahi capital, in the plain between the river and the hills.
WHO Anandapala at the head of a confederacy of Indian kingdoms, against Mahmud.	THE EVIDENCE Al-Utbi, close to the events; Ferishta, six hundred years later, for the famous details.

The alliance

After 1006 Anandapala did what no ruler in this book had managed since the Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two. He wrote to the other kings of northern India and told them that this was not a border dispute.

Ferishta gives a list of who came: rulers and contingents from Ujjain, Gwalior, Kalinjar, Kanauj, Delhi and Ajmer. The list is late and should be treated with suspicion in its details — Ferishta was writing in about 1600 — but the underlying fact is supported by the earlier sources, which describe an unusually large Indian army with contingents from far beyond the frontier. **For once, India came.**

Ferishta also records something else, and it is either the best story in this part or an invention, and possibly both. He says the war was funded by public subscription: **that the women of the country sold their jewellery and sent the proceeds to the army, and that those who had no jewellery spun thread and sold that.**

What happened

- 1. The two armies face each other for weeks.** Mahmud, unusually, would not attack. He entrenched and waited, which tells you what he thought of the odds.
- 2. The Khokhars charge.** The **Khokhars** — a fierce people of the Salt Range and the Jhelum country, who will appear again in Parts Six and Seven — attacked the Ghaznavid line on foot, reportedly bare-headed and with no armour, and broke into it.

3. **They very nearly win it in minutes.** The accounts describe several thousand Ghaznavid casualties in a very short time, and the line bending. This is the closest Mahmud came to destruction in thirty years of campaigning in India.
4. **Then Anandapala's elephant bolts.** The sources say it was hit — by burning naphtha, or arrows, or both — and it panicked and carried the king off the field.
5. **The army breaks instantly.** Not because the battle was lost, but because everyone could see the royal elephant going the wrong way. **An alliance held together by one man's presence collapses the moment that man appears to be leaving.**
6. **The pursuit is long and murderous,** and the confederacy dissolves. It is never assembled again.

ON THE ELEPHANT, AND ON HOW BATTLES ARE ACTUALLY LOST

Some historians treat the fleeing elephant as a face-saving story, invented to explain a defeat that was really about better cavalry. It is a fair suspicion, and the detail comes mainly from the later sources.

But it is also entirely believable, because it is not a story about an animal. **It is a story about a command system with a single point of failure.** In a coalition army with no unified structure, the only thing everybody can see and everybody trusts is the king on the big animal. Remove that one visual signal and there is no chain of command left to hold the line.

You have seen this before in this book and you will see it again. At the Hydaspes in Part Two, elephants turned on their own side. At Panipat in Part Twelve and in the Anglo-Sikh wars in Part Fourteen, armies that were winning dissolved because of what the men in the ranks believed about their commanders. **The elephant is a symptom. The disease is a coalition with no second-in-command.**

WHY MAHMUD WON

- **He refused to be hurried.** Facing a bigger army, he dug in and waited for weeks, giving the coalition time to get bored, hungry and quarrelsome.
- **His army had one owner.** Every man in it was paid by, trained by and answerable to Mahmud. No contingent could decide to go home.
- **Naphtha and archery against elephants.** He had a specific technical answer to India's battle-winning arm, and he used it on the highest-value target on the field.
- **He held on through the worst of it.** The Khokhar charge should have broken him. Professional troops absorbing a shock they were not expecting is what the whole slave-soldier system was built to produce.

WHY THE ALLIANCE LOST

- **Its command was one man on one animal.** No deputy, no second line of authority, no plan for what to do if the king went out of sight.
- **Contingents fight for their own king.** When the host king vanished, the visiting armies had no reason to stay and every reason to save themselves.
- **It fought on flat ground of the enemy's choosing.** The Shahi advantage was hills and forts. For the second time in seven years, they gave it up.
- **It came too late.** This alliance in 986, when Jayapala went to Ghazni, might have ended the Ghaznavid threat. In 1008, after Kabul, after Peshawar, after Multan, it was a last stand pretending to be a strategy.

The Men With No Armour

The Khokhar charge deserves its own paragraph, because it is one of the great forgotten moments of Punjabi military history.

The Khokhars were hill and river people from the Salt Range and the Jhelum country — the same broken landscape that produced Nandana, where this war would end six years later. They were not a kingdom. They had no cavalry to speak of and, by every account, very little equipment. They were the sort of people that court historians on both sides describe as savage, which usually means poor and unmanageable.

At Waihind they went in on foot, uphill against the professional army of Ghazna, into a fortified line held by the best mounted archers in Asia. Ferishta describes them as bare-headed, with their arms and feet bare, cutting their way into the Ghaznavid ranks and killing several thousand men before the line could re-form.

For a few minutes on that day, a rabble of unarmoured hillmen from the Jhelum was beating the man who would raid India seventeen times.

Then a king's elephant panicked half a mile away, and none of it counted.

Remember them. They come back. It is the Khokhars who will kill Muhammad of Ghor on the bank of the Jhelum in Part Six, and Khokhar rebellions that will bleed the Delhi Sultanate for a century in Part Seven.

The kingdoms of Punjab lose in this book with grim regularity. Its unmanageable people are much harder to finish.

Nagarkot, 1009 — The Fort Full of Money LIKELY

The year after Waihind, Mahmud went straight to the Kangra hills and opened the biggest safe in northern India.

WON BY

Mahmud — the most profitable few days of his career so far

WHEN 1009 CE, immediately after the victory at Waihind.	WHERE Nagarkot — the fort at Kangra, in the hills above the Punjab plain.
WHO Mahmud against the garrison and the temple establishment of Bhimnagar.	THE EVIDENCE Al-Utbi, with an inventory. The inventory is the point.

Why he went there

Because that is where the money was, and because Waihind had just removed the only army that could have stopped him going.

Nagarkot was a hill fort with an ancient and extremely wealthy temple, and it had been used for generations as the place where the rulers and rich families of the plain deposited their valuables. It was defensible, it was holy, and it was a very long way from any frontier. **It was the safest place in northern India, which is exactly why it was worth more than anywhere else.**

What happened

1. **He marched straight from the battlefield into the hills**, giving the region no time to move anything.
2. **The fort was invested and surrendered within days.** Accounts vary from three days to a few weeks. There was no relieving army; there was nobody left to send one.
3. **The treasure was inventoried by his own secretary**, and the list is one of the most-quoted passages in the history of medieval India: coined gold and silver, ingots, plate, gemstones, and a collapsible silver house said to be big enough to hold a crowd.
4. **It took a long baggage train to carry it back**, and Mahmud displayed it at Ghazna to ambassadors as proof of what India was worth.

INTERROGATE THE INVENTORY

Utbi's figures for Nagarkot are enormous, and they are the reason this raid is famous. Two things to hold at once.

First, **the specific numbers should not be trusted**. They come from a man employed to describe his master's success, and displaying loot to foreign ambassadors was itself a form of propaganda. Weights of gold in medieval chronicles are advertising.

Second, **the order of magnitude probably is right**, and this is the important part. Wealthy Indian temples genuinely did function as treasuries. Kings deposited there, merchants deposited there, and generations of offerings accumulated in a building nobody expected to be robbed. The raid worked because the analysis behind it was correct.

That is the uncomfortable finding of this whole part, and it is worth stating without flinching. Mahmud's campaigns were not the blind fury of a fanatic. They were extremely well-informed. He knew which buildings held the money, how to get there, and how to be back over the passes before the season closed.

WHY THE RAID WORKED

- **Perfect timing.** He arrived one year after destroying the only coalition that could have opposed him, when nobody could react.
- **Excellent intelligence.** He went directly to the single richest deposit in the region rather than raiding at random.
- **Speed over occupation.** He did not garrison Kangra. He emptied it and left, which meant no cost and no exposure.
- **The wealth was portable.** Coin, bullion and gems are the ideal plunder: no transport problem worth mentioning, no spoilage, and instantly convertible into more soldiers.

WHY IT WAS THERE TO BE TAKEN

- **Everyone had put their savings in one building.** The concentration that made it safe from thieves made it irresistible to an army.
- **The defence was geography, and geography had stopped working.** Hill forts deter raiders. They do not deter a state army with siege experience and no opposition in the field.
- **Nobody expected the frontier to fail this completely.** The deposits had been accumulating on the assumption that armies from Afghanistan stopped at the Indus. That assumption had just died at Waihind.
- **And it happened again.** Nagarkot was plundered repeatedly over the following centuries by different invaders, for exactly the same reasons. Kangra returns in Part Thirteen, when Ranjit Singh takes it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE ABOUT HOW IT WORKED

Why a Temple Was a Bank

To understand this part of the book you have to stop thinking of these buildings only as places of worship, because that is not what made them targets.

A great Indian temple in this period was the largest financial institution for a hundred miles in any direction. It received endowments of land and villages. It took offerings from pilgrims by the thousand. It lent money. It employed hundreds of people, ran kitchens and schools, and held gold that had been accumulating for centuries because there was no safer place to put it and no religious reason to spend it.

It was, in short, a bank with a roof that could not be moved, guarded by the belief that nobody would dare.

Mahmud's campaigns were described by his own historians in the language of religion, and there is no point pretending otherwise: his court presented him as a destroyer of idols, and he collected titles from Baghdad on that basis. Modern historians have argued for decades about how much of that was belief and how much was the eleventh-century equivalent of a press release. That argument is not settled and this book will not pretend to settle it.

What is not in dispute is the pattern of the map. Seventeen campaigns, and the great ones go to Nagarkot, Thanesar, Mathura, Kanauj and Somnath. Rich, famous, well-connected by road, and reachable and returnable within a single dry season.

Whatever was in his heart, his route was chosen by an accountant.

Nandana, 1014 — The Last Fortress in the Salt Range

LIKELY

Driven off the plain, the Shahis moved their capital into the hills and tried to fight the war they should have fought from the beginning.

WON BY Mahmud — after the hardest fighting of any of his Indian campaigns

WHEN 1014 CE, six years after Waihind.	WHERE Nandana, a fortress commanding a pass through the Salt Range in northern Punjab.
WHO Trilochanapala, son of Anandapala, defending the last Shahi capital.	THE EVIDENCE Al-Utbi, who takes this one seriously enough to describe the terrain.

Why they moved to the hills

Because the plain had killed them twice. Peshawar in 1001 and Waihind in 1008 were both fought on open ground where Ghaznavid cavalry could do what it did best. After 1008 the Shahis abandoned the Indus and moved their seat of government to **Nandana**, in the Salt Range — the broken, rocky ridge country between the Jhelum and the Indus.

This was the right decision, made about thirty years too late. **Cavalry armies hate this country.** Steep approaches, narrow tracks, no room to manoeuvre, no forage, and a fort at the top of a pass that has to be taken frontally. It is the single best defensive terrain in Punjab, and readers of Part Four will recognise the address — this is the same Salt Range where Toramana’s name was carved on a monastery record five hundred years earlier.

What happened

1. **Mahmud advances into the Salt Range in 1014.** The march itself is difficult; Utbi describes hard country and a difficult approach in a way he does not bother with elsewhere.
2. **The Shahis hold the pass in front of the fort** and fight, which is what the position was for.
3. **The Ghaznavids force it with archery.** The pattern in the account is arrows in volume, a defensive line pushed back off the high ground, and then an assault.

4. **Nandana falls.** The fort is taken and garrisoned — Mahmud kept this one rather than emptying it, which tells you he regarded it as strategically valuable rather than merely rich.
5. **Trilochanapala escapes into the hills** and keeps fighting from the Siwaliks and Kashmir's borderlands for another seven years.

THE TWO FAILURES NOBODY MENTIONS

Mahmud of Ghazni is usually described as never having lost. He lost twice, in the same place, and it is worth putting on the record.

In **1015 and again in 1021** he tried to take **Lohkot**, a fortress guarding the approach to the Kashmir valley. Both times he failed. The accounts blame the weather and the terrain, which is exactly what accounts always blame. He never went back.

Kashmir is the only region within his reach that he attacked and did not take. That is not because Kashmiri soldiers were better than Punjabi ones. It is because a fort in a mountain gap, defended by people who intend to stay there, held against the best army in Asia — twice.

Hold that next to Nandana, and next to every open-field battle in this part, and the lesson of the whole Shahi war becomes hard to avoid. **Where Punjab fought in its hills and forts, it held. Where it fought on its plains against cavalry, it was destroyed.** The Shahis worked this out at Nandana. By then they had one fortress left.

WHY MAHMUD WON

- **He was willing to fight in bad country.** Most raiders are not. He brought his army into terrain that removed his main advantage because he had decided the target was worth it.
- **Archery beat position.** A defensive line holding a pass can be shot off it if the attacker has enough archers and enough patience.
- **He kept the prize.** Garrisoning Nandana meant the Salt Range road stayed open for every future campaign.
- **His enemy had nothing left to lose behind him.** No reserve, no second army, no allies since 1008.

WHY THE SHAHIS LOST

- **They came to the right strategy far too late.** Hill warfare in 986 might have worked. In 1014 it was the last resort of a state that had already lost its army, its capital and its revenue.
- **A fortress needs a field army behind it.** Forts do not win wars alone; they buy time for someone else to arrive. Nobody was coming.
- **They had no money left.** Three defeats, a lost capital and a lost plain meant no revenue with which to hire troops.
- **And still nobody came.** The last time in this part it will be said: the confederacy of 1008 had dissolved and not one of its members sent help in 1014.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Measured the Earth From the Salt Range

There is a strange and rather beautiful footnote to the fall of Nandana, and it belongs to the other side.

Al-Biruni — the scholar who wrote the Shahis' obituary — travelled in India with the Ghaznavid court, and at some point after the conquest he was at Nandana. Standing at the fort, with a plain stretching away below him and a clear horizon, he realised he could use the place to do something that had previously required a survey team and a desert.

He measured the height of the hill. Then he measured the angle down to the horizon. And from those two numbers, with trigonometry, **he calculated the size of the Earth.**

His result was remarkably close to the true figure — the exact error depends on which value of his units you accept, which historians of science still argue about, but by any reckoning it was one of the best measurements made anywhere in the world before modern instruments.

So the same rock in the Salt Range holds two things at once. It is where the last Indian dynasty to hold the north-western frontier lost its final capital. And it is where a man attached to the conquering army stood in the aftermath, looked at the horizon, and worked out how big the planet was.

Both of those happened at Nandana within a few years of each other, and the second one is the reason the first one is remembered at all — because it was this same man, in the same decade, who wrote down that the family who had lost the fort were people of noble sentiment and noble bearing.

The End of the Shahis, 1019–1026

LIKELY

A hundred and fifty years of holding the gate ended with a king being murdered by his own soldiers over money.

WON BY

Nobody — the dynasty simply runs out

WHEN 1019 for the last pitched battle; 1021–22 for Trilochanapala’s death; 1026 for the last king.	WHERE The Siwalik hills, the upper Ganges country, and the edges of Kashmir.
WHO Trilochanapala, then his son Bhimapala, against Mahmud and against their own troops.	THE EVIDENCE Ghaznavid historians for the campaigns; al-Biruni for the epitaph; Kashmiri tradition for the fugitive years.

What happened

1. **Trilochanapala keeps fighting from the hills** after Nandana, based in the Siwalik country and the borders of Kashmir. He is a king without a capital running an insurgency.
2. **He allies with the Ganges kingdoms — finally.** In 1019 he joins forces with the rulers of the upper Ganges plain and fights Mahmud at a river crossing on the Ramganga.
3. **He loses.** The last pitched battle the Shahi dynasty ever fought.
4. **He is murdered by his own mutinous soldiers** in about 1021 or 1022. The sources are vague on the details and consistent on the cause: unpaid troops. **A dynasty that had defended the frontier for a hundred and fifty years ended in a pay dispute.**
5. **His son Bhimapala survives him by a few years**, called in one tradition “the fearless”, and dies around 1026.
6. **Al-Biruni writes the obituary** a few years later: the house is extinct, and of the whole family there is not the slightest remnant left.

WHAT WAS ACTUALLY LOST

It is easy to read this as one more dynasty falling. It was more than that. From about 870 to 1026, the Hindu Shahis were **the only Indian power that treated the north-western frontier as a permanent, full-time job**. They held Kabul until they could not. They held the Indus until they could not. They held the Salt Range until they could not. They attacked Ghazni pre-emptively. They built the one great coalition of the age.

They also did it, from beginning to end, essentially alone. In a hundred and fifty years of fighting, the great kingdoms of the Ganges plain sent help exactly twice — once in 1008, once in 1019 — and both times after the situation was already unrecoverable.

When they were gone, **nobody replaced them**. No Indian power took over the job of watching the passes. The next invader, in Part Six, walks in through an unguarded door and takes Delhi.

WHAT GHAZNA DID RIGHT, OVER SIXTY YEARS

- **It never stopped.** Four rulers of Ghazna across three generations pursued the same enemy with the same method. Very few states in this book sustain a policy that long.
- **It fought a war of attrition it could afford.** Every campaign paid for itself in plunder. The Shahis paid for theirs out of shrinking revenue.
- **It took the frontier in stages.** Kabul, then the Indus, then the Salt Range, then the plain. Each victory made the next one easier.
- **It hired the defeated.** Ghaznavid armies came to include large Hindu contingents under their own commanders — one of Mahmud's most trusted generals was a Hindu named Tilak. Absorbing your enemy's soldiers is cheaper than killing them.

WHY THE SHAHIS FAILED

- **They were a frontier province fighting a state.** One border kingdom's revenue against a whole military economy.
- **India never treated their war as its own.** The single most consequential fact in this part.
- **They lost their fortresses one at a time,** and each loss cost them the revenue needed to hold the next.
- **Soldiers need paying.** The most ordinary reason in the world, and it is what actually killed the last effective king.

Not the Slightest Remnant

Al-Biruni's sentence about the Shahis is short, and it is worth reading slowly, because of who wrote it and when. He wrote it in Arabic, within a few years of the events, while attached to the court of the man responsible. He records that the dynasty is extinct and that of the whole house not the slightest remnant remains. And then, with nothing to gain, he adds the assessment: that in all their grandeur they never slackened in the desire to do what was good and right, and that they were men of noble sentiment and noble bearing.

Set that against everything else we have. Utbi counts their dead and prices their necklaces. Ferishta, six centuries later, turns them into a moral. The Indian tradition barely mentions them at all — no Sanskrit epic of the Shahis, no chronicle, no cycle of poems. **The dynasty that spent a hundred and fifty years defending India was not commemorated by India.** Its memory survived because a Central Asian mathematician in the invader's baggage train thought they had behaved well and said so in one sentence.

That is the sixth pattern of this book in its purest form. **The winner is whoever gets written about** — and the closest thing the Shahis have to a monument is a line of Arabic prose written by a man who arrived with the army that destroyed them.

Lahore Becomes a Capital — And a War on the Indus

LIKELY

The permanent change. Punjab stops being the place armies pass through and becomes the place they rule from.

WON BY

Ghazna — and this one does not get reversed

WHEN 1021–1022 for the annexation; 1027 for the river war; 1030 for Mahmud’s death.	WHERE Lahore and the central Punjab; and the Indus, for the last campaign.
WHO Mahmud, his governors, and finally the Jats of the Indus country.	WHAT CHANGES Punjab becomes a governed province of a Muslim state, permanently.

The annexation

For twenty years Mahmud had raided and gone home. Around 1021–22 the policy changed, and Punjab was formally annexed and given a governor. **Lahore became the seat of Ghaznavid government in India.**

Why the change? The simplest explanation is the best one. He now held the Salt Range, the Indus crossings and the plain, and there was no Shahi state left to contest them. A province that can be held cheaply is worth more as a tax base than as a target, and Punjab was also the corridor to everything further east.

The consequences run through the whole of the rest of this book:

- **A permanent Muslim ruling class arrives in Punjab** — soldiers, administrators, judges, scholars, merchants — and does not leave. Lahore begins its career as one of the great cities of the Islamic east.
- **Punjab becomes a base for invasions rather than a victim of them.** Every campaign into the Ganges plain from now until the eighteenth century is mounted from or through here.
- **And when Ghazna itself falls to the Ghurids in Part Six, Lahore becomes the Ghaznavid capital outright** — the last refuge of the dynasty that took it.

The last campaign — a naval battle on the Indus

The final war of Mahmud's life was fought against the **Jats** of the Indus country, in 1027, and it is one of the strangest engagements in this book.

1. **The provocation.** Returning from the Somnath expedition in 1026, Mahmud's army was harassed by Jat bands as it crossed the lower Indus country — an army loaded with plunder and tired from a desert march is a natural target.
2. **The problem.** The Jats lived in the riverine country of marsh, island and creek. Cavalry could not reach them. They simply took to their boats.
3. **The answer.** Mahmud built a fleet at Multan. The sources say fourteen hundred boats, each carrying archers and naphtha, **with iron spikes projecting from the bows to hole enemy craft on impact.**
4. **The battle.** The Jat fleet came out to meet it and was destroyed on the water.
5. **Mahmud died in 1030**, three years later, at Ghazna.

HANDLE THE NUMBERS, KEEP THE IDEA

Fourteen hundred boats is a chronicler's number and should be treated as one. But the operation itself is well attested and it is genuinely revealing about the man.

Faced with an enemy his army physically could not reach, **he built a completely different kind of force from nothing, in a season, and adapted it to the specific problem — ramming spikes for river craft.** That is not the behaviour of a raider. It is the behaviour of a state with engineers, money and administrative reach.

It is also the last thing in this part, and a good note to leave Punjab on. The invaders have stopped visiting. They now build fleets here.

WHY GHAZNA COULD HOLD PUNJAB WHEN NOBODY COULD HOLD IT AGAINST THEM

- **They held the passes from the far side.** For the first time in this book, the power ruling Punjab also controlled the doorway into it. That combination is what makes the occupation stick.
- **They governed instead of extracting.** Governors, tax administration, a mint, garrisons. Toramana in Part Four had done the same thing and it had worked until his son wrecked it.
- **They recruited locally.** Hindu troops and commanders served in Ghaznavid armies in large numbers, including at the highest level.
- **There was no alternative government left.** The Shahis were extinct, Multan was absorbed, and the Ganges kingdoms had shown for sixty years that they would not come.

WHAT PUNJAB LOST, IN ORDER

- **Kabul in 870.** The warning time.
- **The Indus in 1008.** The field army.
- **The Salt Range in 1014.** The last defensible ground.
- **The plain in 1021.** Everything else — and with it, self-government, which does not return in any form for seven hundred years.

The Hindu General of Ghazni

Here is a fact that sits badly in almost every account of this period, which is a good reason to end the part with it.

One of the most trusted commanders in the Ghaznavid army was a Hindu named **Tilak**. He had risen from a modest background as an interpreter and clerk, and under Mahmud's son he ended up leading Ghaznavid troops in the field and being sent to put down a rebellion by a Turkish general. **A Hindu officer, commanding a Muslim army, hunting a rebel Muslim commander, on behalf of the sultan of Ghazna.**

He was not alone. Hindu contingents served in Ghaznavid armies in numbers large enough that they had their own quarter in Ghazna, their own commanders, and their own place in the order of battle. Some of them were the descendants of men beaten at Peshawar and Waihind.

This does not soften anything. Mahmud sacked temples, killed at scale, and carried off wealth on a level that permanently damaged the regions he raided, and his own historians described all of it in the language of holy war. Those are the facts and they do not get an asterisk.

But an eleventh-century empire ran on soldiers, and soldiers were recruited wherever competent ones could be found, and by the 1020s the best available recruiting ground was the province he had just conquered. **Within a generation of the last Shahi king being murdered by his own men, Punjabi soldiers were the muscle of the state that had destroyed him.**

That is what conquest actually looks like from the inside, and it is the note Part Five ends on. Not a wall coming down between two civilisations. A payroll.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

711–712 CE	Muhammad bin Qasim takes Sindh and then Multan , cutting the city's water supply. The sun temple is taxed, not destroyed. Won by the Umayyad Caliphate.
c. 724–740 CE	The Arab advance inland is stopped by Nagabhata I of the Pratiharas and the Chalukya Pulakeshin. The frontier freezes at Multan for 280 years. Won by the Indian kingdoms.
c. 724–760 CE	Lalitaditya of Kashmir comes down into the Punjab plain and beats Kanauj. Won by Kashmir — briefly.
870 CE	Ya'qub the Coppersmith takes Kabul. The Shahis fall back to the Indus and India never holds the far side of the passes again. Won by the Saffarids.
962 CE	The Turkish slave-general Alptigin seizes Ghazna — three hundred miles from Peshawar.
c. 986–988 CE	Jayapala invades Afghanistan and is wrecked by mountain weather; Sabuktigin invades in return and takes everything west of the Indus. Won by Ghazna.
27 Nov 1001	The Battle of Peshawar. Jayapala is captured with a river at his back, ransomed, and burns himself on a pyre. Won by Mahmud.
1006–1010	The Multan campaigns. A Sunni army attacks a Shia city; a Hindu king blocks the road; a converted Shahi prince rebels. Won by Mahmud.
1008	Waihind. The largest Indian coalition in eight centuries. The Khokhars nearly break the Ghaznavid line, then Anandapala's elephant bolts. Won by Mahmud.
1009	Nagarkot. The treasure fort at Kangra is emptied in days. Won by Mahmud.
1014	Nandana. The last Shahi capital, in the Salt Range, is stormed. Won by Mahmud.
1015 and 1021	Lohkot. Mahmud fails to take the fortress guarding Kashmir — twice. Won by Kashmir.
1019	The Ramganga. Trilochanapala's last pitched battle, fought with Ganges allies who came ten years late. Won by Mahmud.
c. 1021–1026	The Shahi dynasty ends. Trilochanapala is murdered by his own unpaid soldiers; his son Bhimapala is the last. Won by nobody.
1021–1022	Punjab is annexed and Lahore becomes a capital. Won by Ghazna — permanently.
1027	The war on the Indus. Mahmud builds a spiked fleet at Multan and destroys the Jat boats. Won by Mahmud.
1030	Mahmud dies at Ghazna after seventeen campaigns into India.

Five patterns to carry into Part Six

1. **The frontier is only ever held by the people who live on it.** Part Four complained that nobody guarded the door. Part Five answers: one dynasty did, for a hundred and fifty years, and the rest of India left them to it and then inherited the consequences. **The Shahis were not defeated by Ghazna so much as abandoned by India.** Watch for the same arithmetic at Tarain in Part Six.
2. **Punjab wins in its hills and loses on its plains.** Nandana was hard, Lohkot was impossible, and the Khokhars in the Salt Range were never finished at all. Peshawar, Waihind and the Ramganga were fought on flat ground against cavalry and all three were catastrophes. Every ruler in this book who forgets this loses, and several of them are still to come.
3. **The coalition arrives one war too late.** Part Two's alliance could not agree on a commander; Part Four's alliance disbanded the moment it won. Part Five's came together in 1008, twenty years after it was needed, and dissolved after one bad afternoon. **Anandapala proved India could combine. He also proved it only combined when it was already losing.**
4. **Whoever holds the passes holds Punjab — and now that is a foreign power.** This is the permanent structural change of the part. From 1021 onwards, the state ruling Punjab is based on the far side of the mountains, and it controls both the province and the doorway into it. That situation persists, in one form or another, until Ranjit Singh takes Peshawar in Part Thirteen.
5. **Somebody always ends up on the payroll.** Ambhi hired Alexander in Part Two. Sukhpal governed for Mahmud. Tilak commanded his armies. Within a generation of every conquest in this book, the conquered are fighting in the conqueror's ranks — and in Part Six, it is the descendants of these very arrangements who decide Tarain.

COMING NEXT — PART SIX

Ghurids, Prithviraj and Mongols, 1175–1320. A new dynasty out of the Afghan hills takes Multan, Uch and then Lahore, ending the Ghaznavids in India. **Tarain in 1191 — won by Prithviraj Chauhan**, one of the very few Indian victories in this whole sequence. Tarain again in 1192, which is not. Then Ghori is assassinated on the bank of the Jhelum in 1206 by Khokhars, and the Delhi Sultanate is born out of his slave officers. And then something worse arrives: in 1221 Genghis Khan reaches the Indus, and for the next hundred years the Mongols come down into Punjab again and again — Jaran-Manjur, Kili, Amroha, the Ravi — while Punjab becomes the shield the Sultanate holds up and bleeds behind.

Words Used in This Part

Caliph / Caliphate

The head of the Muslim community and the state he ruled. The Umayyads (Damascus) were replaced by the Abbasids (Baghdad) in 750, which is one reason the Indian frontier went quiet.

Umayyad

The first great Muslim dynasty, ruling from Damascus 661–750. The conquest of Sindh happens under them.

Chach Nama

A Persian history of the Arab conquest of Sindh, written in the 1200s and claiming to translate a lost Arabic original. The source of nearly all the vivid detail — and of most of the arguments.

Ismaili / Qarmatian

A branch of Shia Islam. The rulers of Multan around 1000 CE belonged to it, which made them enemies of Sunni Baghdad and therefore targets for Mahmud.

Ghulam / mamluk

A slave-soldier, bought young and trained for military service. Because he had no clan or land, his loyalty ran to the ruler alone. This system produced Alptigin, Sabuktigin and eventually the Delhi Sultanate.

Ghaznavid

The dynasty founded at Ghazna in 962, at its height under Mahmud (998–1030). The first Muslim state to rule Punjab.

Turk Shahi

The Turkish dynasty that held Kabul and Gandhara from the seventh century — descendants of earlier Central Asian invaders who had become the frontier's defenders.

Hindu Shahi

The dynasty that replaced them, ruling Kabul and then the Indus from the later ninth century until 1026. The main Indian actors of this part.

Udabhandapura / Waihind

The Shahi capital on the Indus above Attock, modern **Hund**. The site of the great battle of 1008.

Nandana

The Shahi fortress commanding a pass through the Salt Range, taken in 1014. Later the site of al-Biruni's measurement of the Earth.

Nagarkot

The great hill fort and temple treasury at **Kangra**, emptied by Mahmud in 1009 and repeatedly plundered afterwards.

Salt Range

The broken ridge country between the Jhelum and the Indus in northern Punjab. Bad ground for cavalry, which is the whole reason it matters militarily.

Khokhars

A people of the Salt Range and Jhelum country. They nearly broke Mahmud's line at Waihind, and they return to kill Muhammad of Ghor in Part Six.

Naphtha

An incendiary — burning liquid thrown in pots or fired from tubes. Used against elephants, and probably what panicked Anandapala's.

Tarikh-i Yamini

Al-Utbi's history of Sabuktigin and Mahmud, written by a Ghaznavid court secretary. The closest source to the events and entirely partisan.

Ferishta

Muhammad Qasim Ferishta, a historian writing in the Deccan around 1600. The source of the best stories in this part — the jewellery, the Khokhar charge — and six hundred years late.

Al-Biruni

Abu Rayhan al-Biruni (973–1048), scholar, astronomer and the author of the *Kitab al-Hind*. Travelled with the Ghaznavid court, learned Sanskrit, and wrote the only even-handed account of India produced in this period.

Jats

An agricultural and pastoral people of the Indus and Punjab plains, appearing here as river fighters. They become one of the central communities of the rest of this book.

Sources used for this part

- Al-Utbi, *Tarikh-i Yamini* (Kitab-i-Yamini), on Sabuktigin and Mahmud — the closest contemporary narrative
- Al-Biruni, *Kitab al-Hind* (Alberuni's India), in Sachau's translation — for the Shahi dynasty, the epitaph, and the measurement at Nandana
- Gardizi, *Zayn al-Akhbar*, and Baihaqi, for the Ghaznavid state and its Hindu contingents
- Ferishta, *Tarikh-i Ferishta*, in Briggs's translation — for Waihind and the later tradition
- The *Chach Nama* of Ali Kufi, and the early Arab historians al-Baladhuri and al-Tabari, for the conquest of Sindh and Multan
- The Arab geographers — al-Istakhri, al-Masudi, al-Muqaddasi — on Multan, its sun temple and its revenues
- Kalhana, *Rajatarangini*, Book IV, in Stein's translation, for Lalitaditya
- Pratihara and Chalukya inscriptions on the repulse of the Arab raids
- Elliot and Dowson, *The History of India as Told by Its Own Historians*, for the translated Persian and Arabic material
- Modern scholarship on Mahmud's campaigns and their motives, including the long-running debate over the balance of plunder, politics and religion in the temple raids
- Standard reference accounts of the Hindu Shahis, the Ghaznavid state, and the Arab conquest of Sindh

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: how much of the *Chach Nama* preserves genuine eighth-century material; where exactly the Arab advance was checked and by whom; how much of Kalhana's *Lalitaditya* is real; the true scale of every army and every treasure in this part; whether Anandapala's elephant story is fact or face-saving; and above all the balance of motives behind Mahmud's campaigns.

That last one is a live political argument as well as a historical one, and it is worth saying plainly how this part has handled it. Mahmud's own historians described his Indian campaigns in explicitly religious terms and celebrated the destruction of temples; that is in the sources and it is not softened here. Historians have also pointed out that his targets were consistently the wealthiest and most accessible sites, that he attacked Muslim states as readily as Hindu ones, that he employed Hindu troops and commanders, and that plunder funded his entire state. Both sets of facts are real. **Anyone who presents you with only one half of that file, in either direction, is arguing about the present.**

And the warning that has run through every part of this book applies here more than anywhere. **Every battle in Part Five is described for us by the winner's employees.** No account written by a Shahi survives. No Punjabi wrote down what 1008 or 1014 looked like from inside. When you read a number, remember who counted it — and remember that the one writer of the age who had no reason to flatter anybody used his sentence about this war to say that the losers had been good men.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART SIX OF SIXTEEN

Ghurids, Prithviraj and the Mongols

A hundred and fifty years in which Punjab is the wall that northern India shelters behind — and the men who command the wall keep ending up on the throne in Delhi.

1175 — 1320

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Century Punjab Spent Being a Wall

Part Five ended with Punjab becoming a province of a foreign state. Part Six is about what that province was then used for — and the answer is: it was used as a shield, and shields get hit.

There are two halves to this part and they are completely different in character.

The first half, from 1175 to about 1210, is the conquest of northern India. A new dynasty out of the Afghan hills takes Multan, Uch and Lahore, destroys the Ghaznavids, loses a battle to Prithviraj Chauhan at Tarain, comes back the following year and wins it — and out of that victory comes the **Delhi Sultanate**, the state that will govern most of northern India for three hundred years.

The second half is about survival. From 1221 to 1306, the **Mongols** — the most successful military system in human history, the people who destroyed Baghdad and China and Persia and reached Hungary — come down into the Punjab again and again and again. They sack Lahore. They besiege Delhi. They are stopped, eventually, on the Ravi.

India is one of the very few settled civilisations the Mongols attacked repeatedly and did not conquer. That is a genuinely remarkable fact, and it is a Punjab fact, because the reason it happened is in this part.

Four things to hold on to

- **Punjab becomes a military zone rather than a province.** Under the Sultanate, the country between the Indus and the Sutlej is not really governed — it is garrisoned. Forts, marcher lords, cavalry, and a population that lives with raids the way other places live with weather.
- **Whoever commands the Punjab frontier ends up ruling Delhi.** This is the structural rule of the whole part, and you should watch for it. It happens in 1320 at the end of this chapter, and it keeps happening for four hundred years afterwards.
- **The slave-soldier system from Part Five produces a state.** Muhammad of Ghor bought and trained Turkish slave officers exactly as the Ghaznavids had. When he died, those slaves inherited his Indian empire and fought each other for it. **The Delhi Sultanate is a slave dynasty, literally and by name.**
- **The sources improve enormously and stay one-sided.** From here on we have detailed, dated, named Persian chronicles — Juzjani writing in the 1260s, Barani in the 1350s, and the poet Amir Khusrau, who was present at several of these events. All of them worked for the Sultanate. There is one contemporary Indian account of Tarain and it breaks off before the battle that mattered.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a writer who was present or in the next room, an inscription, a coin.

LIKELY means good sources writing later, generally accepted.

STORY means tradition, often written

centuries afterwards.

Part Six has a specific hazard that you should be warned about at the start. **The most famous story in this entire chapter — Prithviraj Chauhan blinded, taken to Ghazni, and killing Muhammad of Ghor with an arrow aimed by sound — is not true.** It comes from a poem written roughly four hundred years later, and it is contradicted by a date. This part will show you exactly how that story works, because it is the clearest example in the whole book of how national memory gets made.

The Ghurids Take Multan — And Lose to a Queen

LIKELY

The man who would conquer northern India began by taking two cities easily and then walking into the worst defeat of his life, inflicted by a regent ruling for a small boy.

WON BY

Ghor at Multan and Uch — and by Gujarat at Kayadara

WHEN

1175 Multan; 1176 Uch; 1178 the Gujarat disaster.

WHERE

Southern Punjab and Sindh, then across the Thar desert into Gujarat.

WHO

Mu‘izz al-Din Muhammad of Ghor — “Muhammad of Ghor” — against the Ismaili rulers of Multan and then the Chaulukyas of Gujarat.

THE EVIDENCE

Persian chronicles, above all Juzjani, writing within living memory; and Gujarati inscriptions and chronicles for the defeat.

Who the Ghurids were

Ghor is a mountainous district in central Afghanistan. Its rulers had been minor vassals of the Ghaznavids for generations — the same Ghaznavids you watched conquer Punjab in Part Five. In the twelfth century they turned on their overlords with startling violence.

In 1151 a Ghurid ruler named Ala al-Din Husayn took Ghazna and burned it for seven days. **He is known to history by the nickname he earned there: Jahan-suz, the World-Burner.** The Ghaznavid dynasty survived the destruction of its own capital by retreating to the province it had conquered a century earlier — **and so Lahore, from 1163, became the last capital of the Ghaznavid empire.**

By the 1170s two Ghurid brothers ruled between them: Ghiyath al-Din at Firuzkuh, and his younger brother **Mu‘izz al-Din Muhammad** at Ghazna. The elder took the west. The younger was given India.

What happened

1. **Multan, 1175.** Ghor took the city from its Ismaili rulers. This is the same Multan of Part Five — the sun-temple city, the Frontier House of Gold — and it changes hands here for the third time in this book.
2. **Uch, 1176.** The fortress town at the confluence of the Chenab and the Sutlej, taken the following year. With Multan and Uch, Ghor held the southern Punjab and the road into Sindh.

3. **Then, in 1178, he tried something ambitious and got it badly wrong.** Rather than go north into the Punjab plain, he marched south-east across the **Thar desert** towards Gujarat, one of the wealthiest regions in India.
4. **He was met at Kayadara, near Mount Abu, and destroyed.** The Chaulukya kingdom was at that moment ruled by a child, **Mularaja II**, with his mother **Naikidevi** as regent. Gujarati tradition has her riding out with her son and commanding in person.
5. **The retreat across the desert was worse than the battle.** An army that has been beaten in the field and then has to recross the Thar to get home does not arrive intact.

WHY THIS DEFEAT MATTERS MORE THAN IT LOOKS

Ghor never tried Gujarat again. After 1178 every campaign he launched went the other way — **north into the Punjab plain, along the road through Lahore and Sirhind towards Delhi.**

That is the road that runs through Tarain. **A queen regent in Gujarat, defending for a child, redirected the conquest of northern India onto the route it actually took.** If Kayadara had gone the other way, the great confrontation of this part might have been fought somewhere in Rajasthan against a completely different opponent.

It is also worth noticing what the Persian chroniclers do with this defeat, which is: as little as possible. Juzjani records it briefly. It is the Indian sources that remember who beat him.

WHY GUJARAT WON AT KAYADARA

- **The desert did half of it.** An army that crosses the Thar arrives thirsty, strung out and short of horses. The Chaulukyas fought it at the moment of maximum weakness.
- **They chose the ground.** Broken country near the hills at Mount Abu, not open plain — the standard answer to cavalry, and one Punjab keeps forgetting.
- **They were a functioning state.** Gujarat was rich, unified and had a real army, unlike the divided north-west.
- **They did not wait to be invaded.** They met him at the edge rather than letting him into the country.

WHY GHOR LOST

- **He picked the hardest possible approach.** Attacking the richest kingdom in western India across a desert, from a base he had held for two years.
- **He had no local ally and no local knowledge.** Multan and Uch gave him a foothold, not intelligence about Gujarat.
- **He underestimated a child's regency.** A kingdom with a boy on the throne looks weak from outside and often is not, because the nobility closes ranks around the child.
- **And he learned from it,** which is the genuinely dangerous part. Every later campaign in this part shows a man who does not repeat mistakes.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Only Ever Lost Twice

Muhammad of Ghor is one of the most consequential figures in Indian history and one of the least romantic. He was not a brilliant tactician. He was not, by the accounts of people who worked for him, especially charismatic. He had no son and no dynasty to leave anything to.

What he had was an almost inhuman refusal to treat a defeat as final.

He lost at Kayadara in 1178, and it ended his ambitions in western India permanently. He would lose again at Tarain in 1191, and that one nearly killed him. Both times, the pattern is identical: he is beaten, he goes home, he works out precisely what went wrong, and he comes back having fixed it.

Compare that with the men he fought. **Prithviraj Chauhan beat him at Tarain and did not follow up. Jayachandra of Kanauj watched Prithviraj fall and did not act. The Ghaznavids at Lahore lost Peshawar and Sialkot and did nothing but wait for Lahore.** Everybody in this war except Ghor treated each battle as an event. He treated the whole thing as a project.

And he was not even the one who profited. He died childless in 1206 on a riverbank in the Punjab, and within two years his Indian conquests belonged to a man he had bought as a slave.

The most successful invader of India in five hundred years was a stubborn, unlucky, unloved administrator from a mountain district in Afghanistan whose whole method was to keep coming back. Remember that when you read the next three wars, because the temptation is to explain them with brilliance or destiny, and the honest explanation is persistence.

Lahore, 1186 — The End of the Ghaznavids

LIKELY

The dynasty that conquered Punjab in Part Five was finished off in Punjab, by a former vassal, in a city that had become its last home.

WON BY

Muhammad of Ghor — by treaty, and then by breaking it

WHEN	WHERE
1179 Peshawar; 1185 Sialkot; 1186 Lahore.	The whole northern Punjab, ending at Lahore .
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Ghor against Khusrau Malik , the last Ghaznavid ruler.	Juzjani and the Persian tradition. No Ghaznavid account of their own end survives.

Why it took seven years

Because Ghor did it the slow, correct way — the way almost nobody in this book does it.

1. **Peshawar, 1179.** Take the pass first. The doorway that Part Five spent forty pages on.
2. **Raids into the plain, through the early 1180s,** wearing down the Ghaznavid position without committing to a siege.
3. **Sialkot, 1185.** He built or seized a fort at Sialkot and garrisoned it. **This is the decisive move and it is not a battle.** Sialkot sits north-east of Lahore; a garrison there cuts the Ghaznavid capital off from the hills and sits permanently on its flank.
4. **Khusrau Malik counter-attacked Sialkot and could not take it** — and here is the detail that belongs in this book: he attacked it with **Khokhar allies**. The Salt Range people from Part Five are back, and this time they are fighting on the Ghaznavid side.
5. **Lahore, 1186.** Ghor came in force, and rather than storm the city he negotiated. Khusrau Malik was induced to come out on terms — sources differ on exactly what was promised. He was seized, sent into captivity, and later killed with his family.

WHAT ENDED IN THAT ROOM

The dynasty that Khusrau Malik ended was founded by a Turkish slave who seized a mountain town called Ghazna in 962. That is War Five of Part Five, two hundred and twenty-four years earlier.

In between, the Ghaznavids had destroyed the Hindu Shahis, annexed the Punjab, made Lahore a capital, ruled from Iran to the Ganges, and then been driven out of Ghazna itself by the World-Burner in 1151 — **surviving for a further thirty-five years only because they still held the province they had conquered.**

There is a hard symmetry in it. **Punjab was the first thing the Ghaznavids took and the last thing they had.** They came into this book as invaders and they went out of it as a local dynasty being removed by a bigger one.

WHY GHOR WON

- **He took the passes before the plain.** Peshawar in 1179, seven years before Lahore. Nobody in this book does this and it works every time it is tried.
- **He built a fort instead of fighting a battle.** Sialkot did more to end the Ghaznavid state than any engagement.
- **He was patient.** Seven years for one city, from a man who had lost a whole army in a desert eight years earlier.
- **He negotiated rather than stormed.** Cheaper, faster, and it delivered the enemy king alive.

WHY THE GHAZNAVIDS ENDED

- **They had already lost their homeland.** A dynasty ruling its last province from a city it once treated as a colony has no depth left.
- **They defended the capital and nothing else.** Peshawar went, Sialkot went, and the response each time was to hold Lahore.
- **Their allies were not enough.** The Khokhars came, and a hill people's war-band cannot substitute for a field army.
- **And they trusted a negotiation.** Which was, on the evidence of what happened to Khusrau Malik, a mistake.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Fort That Beat a Kingdom

There is no famous battle for Lahore in 1186. There is no siege worth painting, no last stand, no defiant speech recorded by anybody. The Ghaznavid empire ended in a negotiation and a journey into captivity.

The thing that actually killed it was a fort at Sialkot, built or taken the year before, and garrisoned.

This is worth sitting with, because it is the least dramatic lesson in the entire book and one of the most reliable. **Wars in Punjab are usually decided by who is sitting on which piece of ground when the campaigning season opens, not by what happens on the day two armies meet.**

Sialkot cut Lahore off from the hill country and the Chenab. It gave Ghor a base inside Punjab that he did not have to march to from Ghazna every year. It meant the next campaign started three days from the enemy capital instead of three weeks. And when Khusrau Malik attacked it with everything he had, including his Khokhar allies, he could not take it back — which told everybody watching, including his own nobles, exactly how the war was going to end.

You will see this again immediately. The war that follows this one is fought at Tarain, and Tarain is where it is fought because of a fort at Bhatinda — and the man who wins the first battle there will then spend thirteen months besieging that fort instead of finishing his enemy.

Tarain, 1191 — Won by Prithviraj

LIKELY

An Indian army beat Muhammad of Ghor in open battle, and the man who won it made one decision afterwards that cost him everything.

WON BY

Prithviraj Chauhan — completely, and for one year

WHEN 1191 CE.	WHERE Tarain — Taraori, near Thanesar, on the plain north of Delhi. The Kurukshetra country.
WHO Prithviraj III Chauhan of Ajmer and Delhi, against Muhammad of Ghor.	THE EVIDENCE Persian chronicles for the battle; the Sanskrit <i>Prithviraja Vijaya</i>, written at Prithviraj’s own court, for the Indian side.

Why it happened where it did

Ghor took the fort of **Tabarhindah** — usually identified with Bhatinda — which sits on the road between the Punjab plain and the Chauhan territories. That was a direct threat to Prithviraj’s frontier, and he marched.

The two armies met at **Tarain**, on the flat country near Thanesar. **This is the invasion corridor.** Every army coming down the Punjab road towards Delhi passes through here, and the ground around Panipat and Thanesar will host decisive battles in Parts Seven, Eight and Twelve. You are looking at the most fought-over patch of farmland in India.

What happened

1. **The Indian army was larger and better suited to the ground.** Rajput heavy cavalry and elephants against a Ghurid force built around mounted archers.
2. **The Ghurid wings broke.** The Persian accounts do not dwell on it, which is itself informative.
3. **Ghor charged the centre in person** and fought **Govind Rai**, Prithviraj’s brother and the ruler of Delhi. The accounts describe Ghor striking him in the mouth with a lance and knocking out his teeth — and Govind Rai, in return, driving a javelin into Ghor’s arm.
4. **Ghor was carried off the field.** Wounded and slipping from the saddle, he was rescued by a young horseman of his own army, who held him on his horse and got him clear. The chroniclers do not agree on the man’s name;

they agree that the campaign ended in that moment.

5. **The Ghurid army broke and ran**, and was pursued for a considerable distance.

6. **And then Prithviraj stopped**. He did not pursue into the Punjab. He turned back and laid siege to Tabarhindah — **which held out for thirteen months**.

THE ONE CONTEMPORARY INDIAN SOURCE, AND WHERE IT STOPS

There is a Sanskrit epic called the *Prithviraja Vijaya*, written by a court poet named **Jayanaka** at Prithviraj's own court, while he was alive. It is the only substantial contemporary Indian account of any of this, and it survives in a single damaged birch-bark manuscript found in Kashmir.

It celebrates the defeat of the Ghurid invader — this battle, the victory of 1191.

And then it breaks off. The manuscript does not cover what happened the following year.

That is not a conspiracy; it is a damaged manuscript and a court poem that had no reason to continue after its patron died. But the effect on the historical record is total. **The only Indian voice we have from inside this war is describing a victory, and it falls silent before the defeat**. Everything you will read about Tarain in 1192 was written by the winners.

WHY PRITHVIRAJ WON

- **Numbers and weight**. A larger army with heavy cavalry and elephants, on ground where it could close with the enemy.
- **He came to the enemy**. He did not wait for Ghor to consolidate around Bhatinda; he marched immediately.
- **He broke the wings first**. Mounted archers are only dangerous while they have room. Crowd them off the flanks and they cannot work.
- **He nearly killed the enemy commander**. In an army built around one man, that is the whole battle — and Govind Rai, at the cost of his own teeth, very nearly did it.

WHY THE VICTORY WAS WASTED

- **He did not pursue**. A beaten army that gets home is next year's army. This is the single most expensive decision in the chapter.
- **He spent thirteen months on a fort**. Thirteen months is enough time to raise, equip and train an entirely new invasion — and that is exactly what it was used for.
- **He did not use the year to build a coalition**. The alliance he brought to Tarain the second time was assembled in an emergency, not during the year he had.
- **He treated it as a border war**. Ghor treated it as a project. That difference is the whole of the next section.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Year That Was Available

Between the first battle of Tarain and the second, there is a gap of about a year. Both men had it. Look at what each did with it.

Muhammad of Ghor went back to Ghazna. According to the Persian tradition he disgraced the officers whose contingents had broken — one account has them made to eat from nosebags in public. He raised a new army on a different principle: overwhelmingly mounted archers, drilled to work as separate mobile divisions rather than one mass. He spent the winter preparing. He came back in the campaigning season with a force built specifically to beat the army that had beaten him.

Prithviraj Chauhan besieged a fort.

That is not a joke at his expense, and it is worth being fair about it. Tabarhindah was a real strategic problem: a hostile garrison sitting on his frontier road. Reducing it was a legitimate objective, and medieval sieges were slow. He was also fighting other wars — the Chauhans had been in conflict with the Chandelas and were on bad terms with Kanauj — and a king does not get to fight only the enemy that history says was important.

But the arithmetic is brutal and it does not care about fairness. **Thirteen months went into a fort. The man he had beaten used the same months to redesign an army.**

This is the third pattern of the whole book appearing in its purest form. Punjab and its neighbours produce, again and again, commanders who win the battle and lose the war — because a victory that is not followed up is a delay, and the invader in this book always, always comes back.

Tarain, 1192 — The Battle That Made India Muslim-Ruled

LIKELY

The same ground, the same two men, one year later — and one of them had spent the year thinking.

WON BY

Muhammad of Ghor — the most consequential victory in this book

WHEN 1192 CE.	WHERE Tarain again — the same plain near Thanesar.
WHO Ghor against Prithviraj at the head of a large confederacy of Rajput rulers.	THE NUMBERS CLAIMED Ferishta gives Ghor 120,000 horse and the Indian side several hundred thousand. Both are advertising.

What Ghor did differently

1. **He built an army of one type.** The new force was overwhelmingly **mounted archers** — light, fast, and capable of shooting from the saddle at a distance no Indian formation could answer.
2. **He divided it.** Juzjani describes four divisions of ten thousand horse each, sent to harass the Indian army from all four sides, with a reserve of about twelve thousand heavy cavalry kept back under his own hand.
3. **He lied about wanting peace.** Prithviraj sent a demand that he withdraw. Ghor replied that he was only a brother and a general and must await instructions from Ghiyath al-Din — implying a truce was being considered. **It was a delaying message and it worked.**
4. **He attacked at dawn.** The Indian army, expecting negotiation and following the ordinary routine of a camp — morning washing, morning prayers, horses not yet saddled — was struck before it was formed up.
5. **Then he refused to close all day.** The four divisions rode in, shot, and withdrew. Any Indian charge found nothing to hit. This went on for hours, in armour, in the heat, with casualties accumulating and nothing to strike back at.
6. **In the evening he sent in the reserve.** Twelve thousand fresh heavy horse against an army that had been standing, sweating and dying since dawn. It broke.

7. **Govind Rai was killed. Prithviraj was captured.** Both certainties. What happened to him afterwards is the subject of the story below.

INTERROGATING THE NUMBERS, AND THE ALLIANCE

Ferishta's figures — 120,000 Ghurid horse, and Indian totals running to three hundred thousand men and thousands of elephants — are from 1600 and are not usable. Feeding 120,000 horses on a single plain is not possible.

What is solid: the Indian army was substantially larger; it was a confederacy of many rulers rather than one king's force; and the Ghurid army was smaller, homogeneous and under a single command. Those three facts explain the result without needing any number at all.

And note the shape of it, because you have seen it four times already. **A coalition of many kings against a single command.** Ten kings on the Ravi in Part One. The Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two. Yashodharman's alliance that dissolved on winning in Part Four. Anandapala's confederacy at Waihind in Part Five. **It is the most reliable losing formation in Indian military history and it will lose again at Panipat, twice.**

WHY GHOR WON

- **He refused the battle his enemy wanted.** The whole Indian system depended on closing with the enemy. He spent a day making sure that never happened.
- **Mobility beat weight.** Horse archers in loose divisions against heavy cavalry and elephants on an open plain is a solved problem, and he had solved it over the winter.
- **He used deception without embarrassment.** The false negotiation bought him the dawn, and the dawn bought him the battle.
- **He kept a reserve and used it late.** The commonest failure in this book is committing everything at once. He committed twelve thousand men after ten hours.

WHY PRITHVIRAJ LOST

- **He believed a message.** A commander facing an enemy who has already been beaten once has no business relaxing his camp routine on the strength of a letter.
- **His army could not be commanded as one thing.** Dozens of rulers, each with his own contingent, own honour and own opinion, and no mechanism for a single decision under pressure.
- **His equipment was wrong for the fight he got.** Heavy armour and elephants are decisive at contact and a liability across ten hours of being shot at.
- **He had given the enemy a year.** Everything above is downstream of that.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE FAMOUS ONE, AND IT IS FALSE

STORY

The Arrow Aimed at a Sound

Here is the version almost every Indian schoolchild knows.

Prithviraj is captured and taken to Ghazni, where he is blinded. His loyal court poet **Chand Bardai** comes to him in captivity, and together they plan a revenge. Chand Bardai persuades Muhammad of Ghor that the blind king can still shoot an arrow guided by sound alone. A demonstration is arranged. At the moment of the shot, the poet recites a couplet that tells Prithviraj — in verse, without the court understanding — exactly where the sultan is sitting. Prithviraj looses the arrow at the sound and kills him. The two friends then kill each other rather than be taken.

It is a magnificent story. It comes from the *Prithviraj Raso*, a Braj-language epic whose surviving form dates from roughly the sixteenth century — **about four hundred years after the events**.

And it is contradicted by a date. **Muhammad of Ghor died in 1206, fourteen years after Tarain, on a riverbank in the Punjab, and that is the subject of the very next war in this book.** Whatever happened to Prithviraj, he did not shoot the man who beat him.

So what did happen? The Persian sources say he was executed. There is also a striking piece of physical evidence: **coins survive carrying Prithviraj's name on one side and Muhammad of Ghor's on the other**, which suggests he was kept alive for a short time as a tributary ruler at Ajmer before being put to death — the standard account being that he was executed for conspiring against his new overlords.

Now the part that matters, and it is not really about Prithviraj at all.

The Raso is not history and it was never trying to be. It is what a defeated tradition does with an unbearable memory: it gives the loss a meaning, gives the dead king a last act, and lets the villain die by the hero's hand. Every culture in this book does this. The Greeks did it to Cyrus in Part Two. Kashmir did it to Mihirakula in Part Four.

You are allowed to love the story. You are not allowed to teach it as fact — and the reason is in the next four pages, where Ghor is still alive, still campaigning, and about to be killed in a much less satisfying way by people nobody has written a poem about.

Damyak, 1206 — The Khokhars Kill a Sultan

LIKELY

The conqueror of northern India was killed in a tent on the bank of the Jhelum by people from the Salt Range whose names nobody wrote down.

WON BY Ghor in the field — and by his assassins two weeks later

WHEN The rising in 1204–05; the assassination on 15 March 1206.	WHERE The Salt Range and the Jhelum; the killing at Damyak, near Sohawa in Jhelum district.
WHO Muhammad of Ghor against the Khokhars, with Qutb al-Din Aibak coming up from Lahore.	THE EVIDENCE Juzjani and the Persian chroniclers, who disagree with each other about who did the killing.

Why the Khokhars rose

Because Ghor lost a battle two thousand kilometres away, and news travels.

In **1204**, at **Andkhud** in what is now northern Afghanistan, Muhammad of Ghor was defeated by the Khwarezmian empire and its allies. It was a serious defeat, and a rumour ran ahead of the truth: **that the sultan was dead**.

The Punjab took the rumour at face value and rose. The rising was led by the **Khokhars**, the people of the Salt Range and the Jhelum country whom you met in Part Five, charging bare-headed into the Ghaznavid line at Waihind in 1008 and nearly breaking it. They cut the road between Lahore and Ghazna — which meant that the Ghurid empire in India was severed from the Ghurid empire in Afghanistan.

What happened

- 1. Ghor came back in person, in 1205–06.** He would not delegate this one, which tells you how dangerous he thought it was.
- 2. A hard campaign in the Jhelum country.** The accounts describe heavy fighting and heavy losses, in the broken salt-and-ravine country that Part Five described as the best defensive ground in Punjab.

3. **Aibak came up from Lahore** and caught the Khokhars between two forces. The rising was crushed with considerable slaughter.
4. **Ghor turned for home**, having reopened the road, and camped on the Jhelum at Damyak.
5. **On the night of 15 March 1206, assassins entered his tent and killed him.** He was about sixty-two and had no son.

WHO ACTUALLY KILLED HIM — A REAL DISAGREEMENT

The Persian sources do not agree, and it is worth setting the options out honestly rather than picking the exciting one.

Version one: Khokhars. Survivors of the campaign he had just finished, taking revenge in the obvious way, on their own ground, two weeks after he had massacred them. This is the version most commonly repeated and it has the merit of motive and geography.

Version two: Ismaili assassins. The *fidais* of the Nizari Ismailis, whose speciality was exactly this — infiltrating a camp and killing a ruler in his tent. Ghor had made himself a target: he had taken Multan from an Ismaili dynasty in 1175, and Ismaili communities had been persecuted under his rule.

Version three: his own people. A minority reading points at the court, since a childless sultan whose empire had just been cut in half is a problem with an obvious solution.

This book cannot tell you which. What it can tell you is that the Khokhar version is the one that stuck, and that it stuck partly because it makes narrative sense — the wronged hill people avenging themselves on the tyrant. Be a little suspicious of a story that satisfying, even when it is probably true.

WHY GHOR WON THE CAMPAIGN

- **He came himself, immediately.** A revolt that cuts your empire in half is not a job for a governor.
- **Two armies from two directions.** Ghazna and Lahore closing on the same country is a trap that a regional rising cannot escape.
- **He had a lieutenant he could trust.** Aibak had been running India for thirteen years and did exactly what was needed.

WHY THE KHOKHARS ROSE AND LOST — AND WON ANYWAY

- **They acted on a rumour.** The sultan was not dead, and rising on bad intelligence is how a rebellion becomes a massacre.
- **They were a people, not a state.** No fortress line, no field army, no ally, no way to hold ground against two converging armies.
- **But they could not be finished.** This is the point. He beat them, and two weeks later he was dead in his tent, and Khokhar rebellions go on troubling Delhi for another two hundred years.
- **And they had already cost him the empire.** The road he came to reopen closed again the moment he died.

The Tomb by the Road to Sohawa

Muhammad of Ghor conquered more of India than anybody since the Mauryas. He ended the Ghaznavid dynasty, destroyed the Chauhans, took Delhi, Ajmer, Kanauj and Benares, and founded — indirectly, by dying without an heir — the state that would govern northern India for three centuries.

He is buried in a small, plain tomb beside a road in Jhelum district, in the Pakistani Punjab, a few kilometres from where he was killed.

It is not a monument on the scale of what he did. It is a modest building in a village, and for most of its existence it was in poor repair, known mainly to the people who lived around it.

Think about the geography of that for a moment. **The man who took Delhi lies in the Salt Range, in the country of the people who probably killed him, on the bank of the river where Alexander fought Porus in Part Two and where Ranjit Singh's empire will be built in Part Thirteen.** Everything in this book keeps happening on the same forty kilometres of ground.

And there is one more thing about that grave, which is the real point of this war. **Ghor lost every important thing he had at the moment he died.** No son. No dynasty. His empire split in three within two years. His Indian conquests went to a man he had bought in a slave market.

The Delhi Sultanate — the thing that actually came out of Tarain — was not founded by the conqueror. It was founded by his property.

The War of the Slaves, 1206–1228

LIKELY

Three men who had all been bought as boys fought each other for twenty years over the Punjab, and the winner founded a dynasty called, without embarrassment, the Slave Dynasty.

WON BY

Iltutmish — a slave who had been sold by his own brothers

WHEN 1206–1228, from Ghor’s death to the drowning of the last rival.	WHERE The whole Punjab — Lahore, Multan, Uch, Sirhind, and Tarain again .
WHO Qutb al-Din Aibak, then Iltutmish at Delhi; Taj al-Din Yildiz at Ghazna; Nasir al-Din Qabacha at Multan.	THE EVIDENCE Juzjani, who served this dynasty and knew several of these men personally.

What a slave dynasty actually means

Part Five explained the system and this is where it produces a country. Turkish boys were bought from the steppe, trained as soldiers, educated, converted, and promoted on ability. A slave officer had no clan, no lands and no family faction, so his loyalty ran to his master alone. It made him the ideal instrument — and, on his master’s death, the only person holding the weapons.

Muhammad of Ghor was asked, according to a story the chroniclers liked, whether it grieved him to have no sons. **He is said to have replied that other kings had one son or two, and that he had thousands — meaning his Turkish slaves, who would inherit his empire and keep his name in the Friday prayers.** Treat it as a good line rather than a transcript. It is also, as it turns out, exactly what happened.

What happened

- The empire splits three ways.** Aibak takes Delhi and Lahore; Yildiz takes Ghazna and claims to be the senior heir; Qabacha takes Multan, Uch and the Sindh country. All three were Ghor’s slaves. All three now had to fight.
- Aibak is enthroned at Lahore in 1206.** Note the address. **The Delhi Sultanate begins in Punjab.**
- Aibak dies in 1210 falling from a horse while playing chaugan** — polo — at Lahore. He is buried there, and his tomb is still in the city.

4. **Iltutmish takes over.** He had been Aibak's own slave, then his son-in-law: a Turk of good family sold into slavery by jealous brothers, bought in Bukhara, bought again in Delhi, and now sultan. He spent the next twenty-five years turning a war-band into a state.
5. **Tarain, 1216.** Iltutmish met Yildiz on the same plain that had already decided this book twice in twenty-five years, beat him, and had him executed. **Three battles at Tarain in one generation.**
6. **Qabacha holds out at Multan until 1228,** and then Iltutmish came for him. Driven from Uch and cornered on the Indus at Bhakkar, Qabacha drowned in the river — whether by accident while fleeing or by his own choice, the sources are not sure.
7. **And by 1229 Iltutmish held it all,** with formal recognition from the caliph in Baghdad, which mattered enormously at the time.

THE MOST IMPORTANT THING ILTUTMISH EVER DID WAS REFUSE A REQUEST

In 1221 a fugitive prince came to him asking for help. That prince was **Jalal al-Din Mingburnu**, the last Khwarezmian ruler, and the army chasing him belonged to **Genghis Khan**.

Iltutmish said no. Politely, at length, and with a plausible excuse — the sources have him replying that the climate of the region he could offer would not suit an honoured guest. It was a refusal dressed as hospitality, and it may have saved the Sultanate.

Sheltering Jalal al-Din would have made Delhi a Mongol target at a moment when the Mongols were destroying every state that annoyed them. Iltutmish had been sultan for barely a decade, his rivals were still alive in Multan and Ghazna, and his army had never faced anything like the force sitting on the Indus.

It is one of the coldest and most correct decisions in this book, and it is the reason the next war is a Mongol campaign in the Punjab rather than the end of the Delhi Sultanate.

WHY ILTUTMISH WON

- **He held the middle.** Delhi and the upper Punjab sat between Ghazna and Multan. He could fight either rival without both at once, and he did exactly that — Yildiz in 1216, Qabacha in 1228.
- **He built institutions, not just an army.** A coinage, a land-assignment system, a corps of loyal officers, and recognition from the caliph. His rivals ran military governments; he ran a state.
- **He knew which wars not to fight.** The refusal to Jalal al-Din is the clearest example, and there are others.
- **He outlived them.** Twenty-six years on the throne, in an age when most claimants got five.

WHY THE OTHER TWO LOST

- **Yildiz was facing the wrong way.** Based at Ghazna, he claimed India while the Khwarezmians and then the Mongols came at him from behind. He lost Ghazna and arrived at Tarain as a refugee with a claim.
- **Qabacha ruled the poorest share.** Multan and Sindh could not out-produce the Ganges plain, and twenty years of holding on is not the same as winning.
- **Neither of them combined.** Two rivals who both faced the same stronger enemy and never allied. The oldest failure in this book, now being committed by the conquerors.
- **And the Mongols were behind them both,** which meant they were fighting for the Punjab with an axe hanging over their heads.

Sold by His Brothers, Buried a King

Iltutmish was born into a Turkish family of the Ilbari tribe on the steppe, and by the account he told his own chroniclers, he was a boy of striking looks and ability whose **brothers were jealous enough to take him to a horse fair and sell him.**

He passed through several owners, was bought in Bukhara, and eventually reached Delhi, where Qutb al-Din Aibak — himself a slave, himself bought as a boy — purchased him. He rose through the ranks, married Aibak's daughter, was made governor of Badaun, and in 1211 took the throne.

He then ruled for twenty-six years, defeated two rival sultans, refused Genghis Khan's enemy, obtained recognition from the caliph in Baghdad, issued the silver *tanka* that became the standard coin of northern India for centuries, finished the Qutb Minar, and died in his bed in 1236 having handed on a functioning state.

And then he did one more thing that almost nobody in this book does. **He named his daughter as his successor.** Passing over his surviving sons, he designated **Raziyya**, on the grounds — as Juzjani reports the argument — that she was more capable than any of them. She ruled Delhi for three and a half years before the Turkish nobility destroyed her.

Put the whole life in one line and it stops sounding like medieval history and starts sounding like an argument. **A boy sold by his own family became the founder of the most durable state in medieval India, and used his last political act to try to hand it to a woman.**

The system that produced him was slavery. That is not a contradiction to be smoothed over — it is the actual mechanism. **The Delhi Sultanate promoted purely on ability, because it had removed birth from the equation by buying its ruling class as children.** It is one of the strangest facts in Indian history and it is why this dynasty, and not Ghor's, is what Tarain really produced.

The Indus, 1221 — Genghis Khan Looks at India

CERTAIN

The most dangerous man in the world stood on the bank of the Indus, watched an enemy escape by jumping a horse into the river, and then decided not to come any further.

WON BY Genghis Khan — everywhere except the one man he wanted

WHEN 24 November 1221 for the battle, with Mongol operations in the region continuing into 1223.	WHERE The Indus, somewhere in the Attock–Kalabagh country, and then the western Punjab and Sindh.
WHO Genghis Khan against Jalal al-Din Mingburnu, the last Khwarezmian prince.	THE EVIDENCE Juvayni and Rashid al-Din on the Mongol side; Nasawi, Jalal al-Din’s own secretary, on the other. Unusually good.

How the Mongols got here

In 1218 the Khwarezmian empire — which ruled Iran and Central Asia — massacred a Mongol trade caravan and then executed Genghis Khan’s envoys. What followed is one of the most complete destructions of a state in history. Bukhara, Samarkand, Merv, Nishapur, Herat: taken and, in several cases, effectively erased.

The Khwarezmian shah fled and died on an island in the Caspian. His son **Jalal al-Din** did not run. He raised what troops he could in Afghanistan and, at **Parwan**, beat a Mongol army in the field — one of very few commanders anywhere to manage it.

Genghis Khan came after him personally. He caught him on the Indus in November 1221.

What happened

- 1. Jalal al-Din was pinned against the river** with no boats — the trap this book has described at Peshawar in 1001 and will describe again at Sobraon in Part Fourteen.
- 2. He fought well anyway.** The accounts describe him breaking the Mongol centre before being enveloped. Genghis extended his wings and closed them.
- 3. And then he jumped.** With the battle lost, Jalal al-Din turned his horse, rode to the bank — which the sources describe as a high one — and put the animal over the edge into the water. He swam the Indus with his sword

and shield, and came out on the far side, in the Punjab.

4. **Genghis Khan watched him do it.** Juvayni reports the Khan putting his hand to his mouth in astonishment and telling his sons that **a father should be fortunate to have such a son.**
5. **He then ordered the pursuit.** Mongol detachments crossed into the Punjab and Sindh and hunted Jalal al-Din for months, raiding Multan and the surrounding country.
6. **Jalal al-Din survived,** asked Iluttmish for shelter, was politely refused, and eventually left India westward. He was killed years later in Anatolia.
7. **And Genghis Khan turned around.**

WHY HE DID NOT INVADE INDIA — THE HONEST ANSWER

Genghis Khan spent months on the Indus with an intact army and northern India in front of him, weakly held by a new sultanate with unresolved civil wars. He considered marching through India and returning to Mongolia the long way round. Then he went back the way he came.

The reasons given in the sources are a mixture of the practical and the marvellous. **Heat and disease** — Mongol armies and Mongol horses did badly in the Indian climate, and this is the explanation most historians find sufficient on its own. **Bad water and bad going** in the country ahead. And **an omen**: a famous story in which a strange beast appears to the army at the river and speaks, and the Khan's Khitan adviser Yelü Chucai interprets it as heaven's warning to turn back.

The omen story is **STORY** and is usually read as a wise minister dressing up practical advice in a form a warlord would accept. **The climate is almost certainly the real answer, and it is worth stating plainly what it means: northern India was saved in 1222 by its own weather.**

WHY THE MONGOLS WERE SO HARD TO BEAT

- **Every man was mounted, and had spare horses.** An army that moves at that speed chooses every engagement it fights.
- **Discipline by unit, not by heroics.** Decimal organisation, signal flags, drilled feigned retreats. It was the most professional army in the world by a distance.
- **They enveloped rather than charged.** Exactly what happened to Jalal al-Din: hold the centre, extend the wings, close.
- **They fought a war of extermination and advertised it,** so that most cities surrendered before the army arrived.

WHY INDIA WAS NOT CONQUERED

- **Climate.** The plains of India in summer are hostile to a horse-based army from the steppe in a way no defender could have arranged.
- **It was a pursuit, not an invasion.** Genghis came here chasing one man, not to take a country. Objectives matter.
- **Iluttmish refused to give him a reason.** The single best decision made by anyone on the Indian side in this century.
- **And the empire turned east.** Genghis died in 1227 and Mongol strategic attention went to China and the west. India was a flank.

The Compliment

There is something worth pausing on in that scene at the river, and it is not the jump.

Genghis Khan had spent three years destroying Jalal al-Din's family, his cities and his empire with a thoroughness that is still visible in the archaeology of Central Asia. He had come to the Indus specifically to kill this man. He had him surrounded, beaten and against a river.

And when the man escaped by doing something spectacular, the Khan reportedly stopped, watched, and told his own sons to look at him — **because that was what a son should be.**

The remark is preserved by Juvayni, a Persian historian writing for the Mongol administration a generation later, whose own family had suffered in the conquest and who is not, as a rule, generous about his employers.

It is worth keeping for two reasons. The first is that it is a rare, credible glimpse of a man who is otherwise a statistic in most people's heads — a commander who could admire the enemy he had just failed to kill.

The second is the geography, and this book keeps insisting on geography. **On one bank stands the man who conquered more of the world than anyone before or since. On the other bank, dripping and alive, stands a prince who has just crossed into the Punjab.**

Whatever else Punjab is in these sixteen parts — corridor, prize, battlefield, shield — on that November afternoon it was the far bank. The place you get to if you are lucky. **For the next eighty-five years, its job is to be the bank the Mongols do not cross.**

The Sack of Lahore, 1241

LIKELY

The great city of Punjab was stormed and emptied in a single winter, and the Sultanate that was supposed to defend it effectively wrote it off.

WON BY The Mongols — and Lahore does not recover for a century

WHEN December 1241.	WHERE Lahore — capital of the Ghaznavids in Part Five, and of Aibak in War Six.
WHO A Mongol army under a commander the sources call Tair, against the Sultanate garrison.	THE EVIDENCE Juzjani, who was in Delhi at the time and had every reason to know.

What happened

1. **The Sultanate was in chaos.** Iltutmish had died in 1236. Raziyya had been overthrown and killed in 1240. Delhi was on its fourth ruler in five years and the Turkish nobility was fighting over the throne.
2. **The Mongols came down through the passes in strength** and invested Lahore in December.
3. **The governor fled.** Malik Ikhtiyar al-Din Qaraqash abandoned the city and made for Delhi. Juzjani, who does not usually editorialise, is clear about what this meant.
4. **The citizens fought on without him,** and the walls were breached.
5. **The city was sacked.** The population was slaughtered or enslaved on a scale that the chroniclers do not attempt to quantify.
6. **Delhi did not come.** No relief force was sent. This is the fact that shapes the next sixty years.

1241, FROM A DISTANCE

Look at what the Mongol empire was doing in the same twelve months, because it puts Lahore in a frame that Indian accounts rarely provide.

In **April 1241**, Mongol armies destroyed a Polish and German force at **Legnica** and, two days later, annihilated the Hungarian army at **Mohi**. Central Europe lay open. In **December 1241** they stormed Lahore. And in that same December the Great Khan Ögedei died in Mongolia, and the armies in Europe turned around and went home to attend to the succession.

In one year, the same empire was sacking a city on the Ravi and a city on the Danube. Nothing in this book gives a better sense of the scale of what Punjab was up against — or of how little the people of Lahore could possibly have known about why it was happening to them.

WHY THE MONGOLS TOOK IT

- **They came at the perfect moment.** Five years of succession chaos in Delhi, and a frontier province with a governor who did not want the job.
- **Lahore was exposed.** It sits close to the Ravi and to the road from the passes, with no natural defence in front of it.
- **They had siegecraft.** The Mongols had absorbed Chinese and Persian engineers and were, by this date, the best besiegers in the world.
- **And nobody relieved it.** A city can hold if it believes an army is coming. Lahore knew none was.

WHY THE SULTANATE LET IT HAPPEN

- **It was fighting itself.** The nobility that had destroyed Raziyya was busy consuming the next several sultans.
- **It had made a strategic judgement, and it was brutal.** Delhi decided it could not hold the far Punjab against the Mongols and would defend the Sutlej line instead.
- **Its governors had no incentive to die there.** A frontier command with no relief promised is a posting to survive, not a duty to hold.
- **And it worked, from Delhi's point of view.** That is the uncomfortable part of the story below.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE NOBODY SAYS OUT LOUD

The Province That Was Spent

Here is the strategy the Delhi Sultanate adopted after 1241, stated as plainly as the chroniclers never quite state it.

Punjab would be defended as far as was cheap, and no further. The Sultanate held the line of the Beas and Sutlej with forts and garrisons, kept its field army for the doab, and treated the country between the Indus and the Ravi as a buffer — a zone where Mongol armies could be allowed to arrive, spend a season, exhaust their supplies and go home, without ever threatening the taxable heartland around Delhi.

Judged as policy it was rational and it succeeded. The Delhi Sultanate is one of the very few states in Eurasia that faced repeated Mongol invasion and was still standing at the end of it. The Ganges plain was never systematically devastated. The revenue kept coming. The dynasty survived.

Judged from Lahore it looks different. **For roughly sixty years, the great city of the Punjab was a place the empire had decided not to defend** — raided, occupied at intervals, its trade broken, its population reduced, and its governor a man whose realistic options were flight or death.

This is what it means to be a frontier rather than a heartland, and it is the same lesson as the Shahis in Part Five with the polarity reversed. There, Punjab fought alone because nobody would come. Here, Punjab bleeds because a rational government in Delhi has done the arithmetic and concluded that it is cheaper to let it.

Every part of this book so far has asked why nobody defends Punjab. This is the first part where the answer is a policy rather than a failure.

Balban’s Iron Frontier, 1266–1287

LIKELY

A sultan who had also been bought as a slave decided that Punjab would be turned into a fortified military district — and it cost him his son.

WON BY Delhi — narrowly, expensively, and by never leaving home

WHEN 1266–1287, Balban’s reign as sultan; he had effectively run the state for twenty years before that.	WHERE The line of forts from Bhatinda and Sunam to Samana and Dipalpur, and the Multan frontier.
WHO Ghiyath al-Din Balban against the Mongols of the Chagatai realm, and against everybody else.	THE EVIDENCE Barani, writing seventy years later, and the poet Amir Khusrau, who was there and was captured.

What he did

Balban is not a likeable figure and this book will not pretend he is. He came to power over the bodies of rivals, ruled by terror, executed on suspicion, and invented an elaborate court ceremonial designed to make himself seem more than human. He also, more than any other individual, is the reason the Delhi Sultanate survived the thirteenth century.

1. **He refused to campaign anywhere else.** No southern adventures, no eastern conquests. For twenty years the field army stayed within reach of the frontier. Given what every other ruler in this book does with an army, that restraint is remarkable.
2. **He rebuilt and garrisoned a fort line.** Bhatinda, Bhatnair, Sunam, Samana and the forward posts around Dipalpur and Lahore were repaired, stocked and manned as a permanent system rather than as individual strongpoints.
3. **He cleared the forests of the doab** and settled soldiers along the roads, because the raiders were not only Mongol — the country between Delhi and the Punjab had become unsafe on its own account.
4. **He put his own family on the frontier.** His eldest son **Muhammad**, the heir, was made governor at Multan and Lahore. This is the crucial decision and it is the one that destroys him.

5. **And he mostly did not fight pitched battles.** The system was designed to absorb raids, deny supplies, and make a Mongol campaign into the Punjab unprofitable rather than impossible.

THE DEATH OF PRINCE MUHAMMAD, 1285

In 1285 a Mongol force came down into the Multan country. Prince Muhammad — called *Khan-i-Shahid*, the martyr prince, afterwards — went out to meet it and was killed, apparently caught by a detachment while his own force was dispersed.

The poet **Amir Khusrau** was in his service and was taken prisoner in the same action. He later wrote about it, and his account of the prince's death and of his own captivity is one of the very few pieces of first-hand testimony about the Mongol wars written by somebody who was actually caught in one.

Barani says Balban never recovered. He was already an old man; he had built a system, held a frontier for twenty years, and lost his heir to the thing he had built it against. **He died in 1287, and within three years his dynasty was gone.**

WHY THE FRONTIER HELD

- **Depth instead of a wall.** Not one line but a belt of forts, so a raid that got past the first post was still inside a defended zone with nothing to eat.
- **Permanent garrisons, permanently paid.** The most boring and most decisive item on this list. Part Five's Shahis lost their last king because his troops were not paid.
- **Strategic patience.** Balban did not chase glory. Twenty years of not invading anybody is what made the frontier affordable.
- **He accepted the loss of the far Punjab.** Ugly, and it worked.

WHAT IT COST

- **The heir.** A frontier command is a real command, and real commands kill people.
- **The dynasty.** With Muhammad dead and Balban old, the succession collapsed and the Khalji faction took the throne in 1290.
- **The far Punjab.** Lahore stayed a damaged, half-held city throughout.
- **And it did not stop the Mongols coming.** It made them unprofitable, which is a different thing — as the next three wars show.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Poet in the Baggage Train

Almost every voice in this part belongs to a chronicler writing in a library in Delhi years afterwards. **Amir Khusrau is different: he was on the field, he was captured, and he came back and wrote.**

He is one of the great figures of Indian culture — a poet in Persian and, by tradition, in the early Hindavi that stands behind modern Hindi and Urdu; a musician credited by tradition with instruments and forms still played today; a man who served seven sultans and outlived nearly all of them. He is buried next to his teacher, the Sufi saint Nizamuddin Auliya, in Delhi.

And in 1285 he was a court poet attached to a prince on the Multan frontier, and the Mongols came, and his patron was killed, and he was taken.

What he wrote afterwards is not a battle report. It is grief, and it is a description of what the enemy looked like from close up — faces, smell, the sound of the language, the ordinary terror of being a captive in a moving camp. He got away and made it home.

Every other war in this part is described by men who heard about it. Juzjani in Delhi. Barani seventy years later. Ferishta from another century entirely. Khusrau is the one who was there, and the thing he chose to record is not the manoeuvre or the casualty count but what it was like.

That is worth more than a dozen numbers, and it is the closest this book gets, in the whole medieval section, to a Punjabi war seen from inside it.

Jaran-Manjur, 1298 — The Frontier Fights Back LIKELY

For seventy years the policy had been to absorb the raids. Then Delhi got a sultan who decided to meet them at the river and destroy them.

WON BY

Delhi — the first outright Mongol defeat in the Punjab

WHEN 1298 CE.	WHERE Jaran-Manjur, on the Sutlej.
WHO Ulugh Khan and Zafar Khan, generals of Alauddin Khalji, against a Mongol force under Kadar.	THE EVIDENCE Barani and Amir Khusrau. Khusrau was writing for this court and celebrating these victories.

What had changed in Delhi

Alauddin Khalji took the throne in 1296 by murdering his uncle, and proceeded to run the most aggressively organised government medieval India had seen. Price controls in the markets, a standing army paid in cash rather than land, a systematic revenue assessment, a network of informers, and a habit of executing anybody who looked like a rival.

Almost all of it was built to pay for one thing. **He needed a large, permanent, cash-paid army, and he needed it because the Mongols were coming every other year.** The famous price controls in Delhi’s markets exist so that a soldier’s fixed salary would keep buying the same amount of grain.

Balban had absorbed the raids. Alauddin decided to fight them.

What happened

1. **A Mongol army under Kadar crossed into the Punjab in 1297–98** and raided down towards the Sutlej.
2. **Alauddin sent his brother Ulugh Khan and his best field commander Zafar Khan** to intercept — not to shadow, not to contain, but to bring it to battle.
3. **They caught it at Jaran-Manjur on the Sutlej.** A raiding army encumbered with plunder and captives, on the wrong side of a river, is a very different proposition from a Mongol army manoeuvring freely.

4. **It was destroyed.** Barani gives the prisoners as around twenty thousand. Treat the figure as a court number and the outcome as real.
5. **The prisoners were taken to Delhi and killed.** Alauddin made a public spectacle of it. This is deliberate policy, and it is discussed below.

ON THE KILLINGS, AND ON SAYING SO PLAINLY

Alauddin's treatment of captured Mongols was systematic and it was appalling. Prisoners were executed in large numbers at Delhi; the sources describe them being trampled by elephants and their heads built into towers. In 1298 he also had the settled Mongol converts living near Delhi — the so-called New Muslims — massacred after a mutiny, along with, by Barani's account, their families.

This book is not going to launder that by calling it deterrence and moving on. **It was mass killing of prisoners and of a resident community, and Barani, who admired Alauddin, records it without much discomfort.**

It is also true that it was a policy with an objective, and that the objective was achieved: **after 1306, Mongol invasions of India essentially stop for twenty years.** Both those statements belong in the same paragraph. A history that gives you only the second one is propaganda, and one that gives you only the first is not explaining why it happened.

WHY DELHI WON

- **They caught a loaded army.** Raiders carrying plunder and driving captives cannot manoeuvre, and will not abandon the loot.
- **A river at the enemy's back.** The oldest trick in this book, used for once by the Indian side.
- **A standing, paid, professional army.** Alauddin could send a field force at short notice because he had one sitting ready.
- **Intelligence.** The informer network that made Alauddin hated at home also meant he generally knew where a Mongol column was.

WHY THE MONGOLS LOST

- **They were raiding, not campaigning.** The objective was plunder, and plunder is heavy.
- **They had grown used to a passive enemy.** Seventy years of Balban-style absorption had taught them that nobody came out to fight.
- **They crossed a river with a hostile field army in range.** A mistake they had not needed to worry about before.
- **And the Chagatai realm was divided,** sending forces on the initiative of individual princes rather than as a single strategy.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Price of Grain in Delhi

Here is a chain of cause and effect that almost nobody puts together, and it is the most interesting thing about this reign.

A Mongol army is riding towards the Sutlej. To stop it, Delhi needs a large cavalry force that exists all the time — not a feudal levy summoned when trouble appears, but professional soldiers on a permanent payroll.

Paying them in land grants does not work, because a soldier with land becomes a landholder with opinions. So Alauddin paid them in **cash**, at a fixed salary.

But a fixed salary is only as good as what it buys. If the price of grain rises, the soldier is effectively taking a pay cut, and either the salary must rise — which the treasury cannot afford at that scale — or the army starts to dissolve.

So Alauddin fixed the prices. **Grain, cloth, horses, cattle, slaves — all set by decree, with state granaries to break hoarding, licensed dealers, registered merchants, inspectors in the markets and savage punishments for short weight.** It is the most thorough system of state price control in the medieval world, and Barani describes it in obsessive detail.

It was not economic theory and it was not benevolence. **It was a war measure, and the war was on the Sutlej.**

Keep this in mind for the rest of the book, because it is one of the quiet themes. **What happens on the Punjab frontier reaches into the price of bread five hundred kilometres away.** A raid on the Sutlej changes what a weaver in Delhi pays for grain, because of a decision made by a frightened government about how to keep enough horsemen in the field.

Kili, 1299 — The Year the Mongols Reached Delhi

LIKELY

This one was not a raid. It was an invasion aimed at taking the country, and it got to the outskirts of the capital.

WON BY Delhi — at the cost of its best general, who may have been left to die

WHEN 1299 CE.	WHERE Kili, near Delhi — after the Mongols had marched the length of the Punjab without stopping to plunder.
WHO Qutlugh Khwaja, son of the Chagatai ruler Duwa, against Alauddin Khalji in person.	THE EVIDENCE Barani, and Amir Khusrau writing close to the event.

Why this one was different

Every Mongol force in this part so far had come to take things and leave. **Qutlugh Khwaja came to conquer.** Barani is explicit about the change in intent, and the behaviour of the army confirms it: it came down through the Punjab *without stopping to plunder*, which for a Mongol raiding force is close to unnatural, and made straight for the capital.

Barani gives the size as two hundred thousand. That is not a usable number. What is usable is the reaction in Delhi, which the sources describe as close to panic: refugees crowding into the city, the roads cut, and a serious argument in the sultan’s council about whether to fight at all.

Alauddin was advised not to give battle. He was told to hold the fortifications and wait. He refused, and marched out to Kili with everything he had.

What happened

1. **The armies met at Kili.** Alauddin took the centre himself.
2. **Zafar Khan, on the right, charged** — and broke the Mongol wing in front of him.
3. **Then he kept going.** He pursued the fleeing Mongols far beyond the field, which is exactly what a feigned retreat is designed to produce.

4. **He was surrounded and cut off.** The accounts describe his force fighting until it was destroyed, and Zafar Khan being killed with it.
5. **Alauddin did not move to support him.** This is where Barani becomes interesting, and it is the subject of the story below.
6. **The main armies never fully engaged.** Qutlugh Khwaja had been wounded, his losses in the fighting with Zafar Khan were heavy, and he withdrew during the night.
7. **He died on the way home.** The invasion collapsed with him.

THE MOST FOUGHT-OVER SENTENCE IN BARANI

Barani hints — without stating it outright, in the way of a chronicler who knows what he is doing — that **Alauddin was not sorry to see Zafar Khan destroyed**, and that the reinforcement which could have saved him was deliberately withheld.

The motive suggested is jealousy. Zafar Khan was the most admired soldier in India, the victor of Jaran-Manjur, and a man whose reputation was becoming its own power base. Alauddin had taken the throne by murdering his own uncle and spent his reign eliminating anyone who might do the same to him.

It cannot be proved and it cannot be dismissed. Barani wrote seventy years later, admired Alauddin's governance, and had no obvious reason to invent this. Against that, a commander who over-pursues into an envelopment is beyond saving by the time anyone realises, and "he could have been supported" is the easiest accusation in military history to make and the hardest to test.

Keep both readings. **The nastier one is not required to explain the battle, and this reign gives you no grounds to rule it out.**

WHY DELHI SURVIVED

- **Alauddin came out and fought.** Against advice. A capital that shuts its gates against a Mongol army invites a siege it may not survive.
- **Zafar Khan's charge cost them dearly.** Whatever happened afterwards, the fight that killed him inflicted losses the invaders had not budgeted for.
- **Their commander was wounded.** A Mongol army built around one prince has the same single point of failure as everyone else's.
- **Delhi had a real army in being.** Ten years earlier there would have been nothing to march out with.

WHY THE MONGOLS FAILED

- **They had come too far to be reinforced.** The length of the Punjab lay between them and home, and it was now hostile.
- **Conquest needs sieges.** Taking a fortified capital is slow, and slow is the one thing this army could not be.
- **They lost their prince.** Wounded at Kili, dead on the retreat.
- **And they never tried it this way again.** Later invasions in this part go back to raiding.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Name That Frightened Horses

Barani tells a story about the aftermath of Kili that is one of the strangest compliments ever paid to a dead man.

For years afterwards, he says, when Mongol horsemen watered their horses and an animal shied or refused to drink, the riders would ask it mockingly whether it had **seen Zafar Khan**.

It became a saying — a thing you said to a nervous horse. The man who had broken their wing at Kili and then died surrounded, still being invoked on the steppe as the standard explanation for why an animal was afraid of something it could not see.

Take it as folklore rather than reportage; Barani is writing seventy years later and it is exactly the kind of detail a chronicler polishes. But it is a real thing to have been remembered for.

And notice the shape of it. **Zafar Khan is the best soldier in this part of the book. He wins the first Mongol defeat in Punjab in seventy years. He then dies in a trap, possibly abandoned by the sultan he served.** He gets no monument, no dynasty, no chapter in the chronicles under his own name.

What he gets is a joke that Mongol cavalrymen told each other about their horses, written down by a Persian historian in Delhi two generations later.

The winner is whoever gets written about — and sometimes the only person who writes you down is the enemy, laughing, at a watering place a thousand kilometres away.

Targhi at the Gates, 1303

LIKELY

The closest Delhi ever came to falling to the Mongols — and it happened because the sultan was five hundred kilometres away besieging a fort in Rajasthan.

WON BY Nobody — the Mongols went home after two months and Delhi never forgot it

WHEN	WHERE
1303 CE, for about two months.	Outside Delhi , with the Sultanate’s field army shut inside the unfinished fortress of Siri .
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
The Mongol commander Targhi against Alauddin Khalji.	Barani, who treats it as the most frightening episode of the reign.

How it happened

1. **Alauddin was at Chittor.** He had spent months besieging the great Rajput fortress and had taken it in August 1303, at heavy cost, with his army worn down.
2. **Targhi came down the Punjab road fast and light** — no siege train, no baggage worth the name, moving at the speed a Mongol column could actually move.
3. **He arrived before Alauddin could reassemble.** The sultan got back to Delhi with a tired army and shut himself inside **Siri**, the new fortified camp he was building, which was not finished.
4. **The Mongols blockaded the city for about two months.** They cut the roads, stopped the grain coming in, and camped on the Jumna. Barani describes prices in Delhi going through the roof and the population in real distress.
5. **Alauddin would not come out.** Having marched out and won at Kili four years earlier, he now did the opposite — because this time his army was not fit to fight.
6. **And then Targhi left.** No storm, no assault, no battle. He had no way to take a fortified position, his supplies ran down, and he went home.

WHAT ALAUDDIN DID ABOUT IT AFTERWARDS

He treated 1303 as a system failure and rebuilt the system, and the measures are worth listing because they are the reason the last two invasions in this part fail.

- **He finished Siri** and made it his capital and garrison.
- **He repaired every fort on the road from the Punjab to Delhi** and stocked them with grain, weapons and permanent garrisons.
- **He put a proper commander on the frontier** — **Ghazi Malik**, at Dipalpur, with orders to keep the marches and a free hand to do it.
- **He raised more cavalry**, which is what the price controls were paying for.
- **And he stopped leaving**. No more long personal campaigns to distant fortresses while the north was open.

Every one of those is a lesson taken from two frightening months, and together they close the Punjab corridor. It is the most competent response to a near-disaster by any ruler in this book.

WHY TARGHI GOT SO CLOSE

- **He moved when the army was elsewhere.** Chittor had taken months and had left the field force exhausted and far away.
- **He travelled light and fast.** No plunder, no siege train, nothing to slow him. The mistake of Jaran-Manjur, corrected.
- **He went for the capital, not the countryside.** Blockading Delhi threatened the whole state at once.
- **The forts on the road were not yet what they became.** He was not stopped anywhere between the Sutlej and the Jumna.

WHY HE COULD NOT FINISH IT

- **Light and fast means no siege capability.** The same choice that got him there stopped him taking anything.
- **Alauddin refused the battle.** Correctly. A commander who knows his army is unfit and sits behind walls anyway is doing the hard thing.
- **A blockade eats the besieger too.** Two months camped outside a large city in a country that has been stripped is not sustainable.
- **And there was no second army coming.** The Chagatai princes did not coordinate; there was no follow-up force to turn a blockade into a siege.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Two Months of Grain Prices

Barani was a courtier and a moralist and he mostly writes about sultans. In his account of 1303 he does something he rarely does: **he writes about the city.**

He describes the roads to Delhi cut, so that nothing came in from the country. He describes grain becoming scarce and then unaffordable. He describes people who had fled the Punjab ahead of the Mongols crowded into a capital that could not feed them. He describes the sultan and his army inside a half-built fortress, visible to everyone, and not coming out.

No battle is fought. Nobody is a hero. The whole episode consists of two months of hunger and fear, ended by an enemy who got bored.

This is what almost every war in this book actually looked like to the people it happened to, and it is nearly always the part that the chronicles leave out. Tarain gets a poem. Kili gets a joke about horses. The two months in 1303 when Delhi went hungry get a few sour paragraphs from a writer who happened to think grain prices were worth mentioning.

Remember it in Part Seven, when Timur comes down this same road in 1398 and does to Delhi what Targhi could not. **The difference between a frightening season and a catastrophe is, very often, only whether the besieger brought engineers.**

Amroha and the Ravi, 1305–1306 — The Last Invasions

LIKELY

Two campaigns in two years, both destroyed — and then the Mongols stop coming, and nobody at the time could have known it was over.

WON BY

Delhi — completely, and this time permanently

WHEN 1305 Amroha; 1306 the Ravi.	WHERE Amroha in the Ganges doab; then the crossings of the Ravi in the Punjab.
WHO Ali Beg and Tartaq in 1305; Kebek in 1306. Against Malik Nayak, and then Malik Kafur and Ghazi Malik.	THE EVIDENCE Barani and Amir Khusrau, both writing for the winning court.

Amroha, 1305

1. Ali Beg and Tartaq came down into the doab and, instead of going for Delhi, spread out to plunder the country east of the capital.
2. Alauddin did not defend the villages. He sent a field force under Malik Nayak to find the raiding columns and destroy them.
3. They were caught near Amroha, dispersed, loaded and out of position.
4. The Mongol commanders were taken alive and brought to Delhi, where they were killed — trampled by elephants, according to the accounts.

The Ravi, 1306

1. A larger force under Kebek came the following year, aiming at the Punjab and the country beyond.
2. This time Delhi did not wait for them to arrive. The frontier command under Ghazi Malik at Dipalpur, with Malik Kafur commanding the field army, moved to intercept in the Punjab itself.
3. They were caught at the Ravi. The accounts describe the Mongol force being broken at the river crossings — the worst possible place to be attacked, and by now the Sultanate’s standard method.

4. **The slaughter and the prisoner-taking were on a very large scale**, and the executions at Delhi that followed were the largest yet.
5. **And that is the end.** There is no serious Mongol invasion of India for the next twenty years.

WHY THEY STOPPED — AND IT IS NOT ONLY DELHI'S DOING

It is tempting to give Alauddin the whole credit, and he deserves a great deal of it. The fort line was real, the standing army was real, the frontier command at Dipalpur was real, and four invasions in nine years were beaten.

But the other half of the answer is in Central Asia. The Chagatai realm — the Mongol successor state that these invasions came from — was falling into internal conflict. Duwa, who had launched most of them, died around 1306. What followed was a long period of succession disputes and civil war, and a state fighting itself does not launch expeditions across the Hindu Kush.

So: India stopped being worth invading at roughly the same moment that the invaders stopped being able to invade. Both are true and the second one was not arranged in Delhi.

You have seen this exact pairing before. Part Five ended with Punjab being freed from the Huns by a battle near Bukhara that had nothing to do with India. **The frontier is never entirely in charge of its own fate.**

WHY DELHI WON THESE TWO

- **It fought them in Punjab, not in the doab.** The 1306 interception is the whole change: the war was moved back onto the frontier.
- **Rivers, again.** Both battles caught an enemy at a crossing or dispersed with plunder. The Sultanate had learned exactly one trick and it kept working.
- **A permanent frontier command.** Ghazi Malik at Dipalpur was not waiting for orders from Delhi; he was there, with troops, all the time.
- **Terror as declared policy.** Ugly, effective, and honestly recorded by the people who did it.

WHY THE MONGOLS FAILED

- **They were still raiding a country that had stopped behaving like a victim.** The tactics that worked in 1241 were suicidal by 1306.
- **Plunder slows an army and it will not drop it.** Both defeats turn on this.
- **They had no base this side of the mountains.** Every campaign started from Afghanistan and had to get home.
- **And their own state was coming apart behind them.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Eighty-Five Years

Count it out, because the number is the story.

From Genghis Khan on the Indus in **1221** to the Ravi in **1306** is eighty-five years. In that time the Mongols destroyed the Khwarezmian empire, the Abbasid Caliphate and the city of Baghdad, the Song dynasty of China, the Kievan Rus, the Assassins of Alamut, and the armies of Poland and Hungary. They ruled from Korea to the Danube. It is the largest contiguous land empire in history.

They came into the Punjab repeatedly across those eighty-five years, and they took Lahore, and they blockaded Delhi, and **they did not take India.**

The reasons in this part are unglamorous and they are all here: the climate; the distance from their base; the fact that most of these were raids rather than conquests; a Chagatai realm that fought itself; and — genuinely, substantially — a fortified Punjab frontier, a paid standing army, and two sultans, one cruel and one crueller, who understood exactly what they were dealing with.

And the cost was paid in one place. **Lahore sacked. Multan raided. The whole country between the Indus and the Sutlej treated for sixty years as a zone that Delhi would not defend, and then for another forty as a garrison.** The Ganges plain, the treasury, the capital, the dynasty, the culture that produced Amir Khusrau — all of it went on, protected.

This is the plainest possible statement of what Punjab is in this book, and Part Six is where it is truest. **India survived the Mongols. Punjab absorbed them.**

From Dipalpur to Delhi, 1320

LIKELY

The man who had spent fifteen years holding the Punjab frontier marched down the road he had been defending and took the throne. It becomes a habit.

WON BY

Ghazi Malik — warden of the marches, and now Sultan Ghiyath al-Din Tughluq

WHEN 1320 CE.	WHERE From Dipalpur in the Punjab to Delhi, along the invasion road in reverse.
WHO Ghazi Malik and his son against Khusrau Khan, who had seized the throne months earlier.	THE EVIDENCE Barani, and Amir Khusrau — who, characteristically, was in Delhi for it.

What happened

1. **Alauddin died in 1316** and the Khalji dynasty collapsed into murder within four years — a favourite, then a coup, then another coup.
2. **Khusrau Khan took the throne in 1320**, having killed the last Khalji sultan. His legitimacy was thin and his support was narrow.
3. **Ghazi Malik was at Dipalpur**, where he had been warden of the marches since 1305 — the man Alauddin had installed after the fright of 1303, and by tradition the veteran of a very large number of engagements against the Mongols.
4. **He refused to recognise the new sultan**, raised the frontier troops, and marched on Delhi.
5. **He won, and Khusrau Khan was executed.** Ghazi Malik took the throne as **Ghiyath al-Din Tughluq**, founding the dynasty that governs Part Seven.

THE RULE THIS ESTABLISHES

Watch the mechanism, because it now repeats for four hundred years.

The Punjab frontier command is the only place in the empire where a general has a large, permanent, battle-hardened army under his personal control, far from the capital, with a legitimate reason to have it. Every other force in the state is either small, or dispersed, or under the sultan's eye.

So when Delhi becomes weak, the army that takes it comes from Punjab. It happens here with the Tughluqs in 1320. It happens in Part Seven, when **Bahlul Lodi** comes down from Sirhind and takes Delhi in 1451. It happens in Part Seven again, when **Babur** takes Lahore first and Delhi second. It happens in Part Eight with the Suris, and in Part Twelve the same road is used by the Marathas and the Afghans.

Punjab in this book is almost never the prize. It is the springboard. And the reason is not glory or spirit or martial character — it is that this is where the empire keeps its soldiers, because this is where the enemy comes from.

WHY THE FRONTIER COMMAND WINS

- **It has the only real army.** Fifteen years of continuous Mongol warfare produces troops that a palace coup cannot match.
- **It has a legitimate grievance.** A usurper in Delhi lets a frontier general march as a defender of order rather than as a rebel.
- **It knows the road.** The Punjab-to-Delhi corridor is the ground it has spent its career on.
- **And its commander has a reputation.** Men follow a man who has beaten the Mongols.

WHY DELHI KEEPS FALLING TO IT

- **Palace power is not military power.** A throne taken by assassination is held by a faction, not an army.
- **The capital is downstream of the frontier.** Geography does the rest.
- **The Sultanate never solved its succession.** Not once, in three hundred years, does the throne pass peacefully more than a few times running.
- **And the system was built this way on purpose.** A strong frontier army was the answer to the Mongols. It was also, permanently, the answer to whoever was sitting in Delhi.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Pavilion at Afghanistanpur

Ghiyath al-Din Tughluq ruled for five years, and the way he died is one of the great unresolved arguments of Indian history — so it belongs here, at the end of the part, as a warning about what the next one contains.

In 1325 he was returning to Delhi from a campaign in Bengal. His son **Muhammad** had a wooden reception pavilion built for him at **Afghanistanpur**, near Delhi. The sultan entered it with his younger son and his retinue. The structure collapsed and killed him.

Ibn Battuta, the Moroccan traveller, who arrived in India a few years later and served the son as a judge, reports the version that was circulating in Delhi: that the pavilion had been designed to fall, that the elephants were made to strike a particular pillar, and that the son arranged it. He also reports that the rescue was oddly slow.

Modern historians are split, and reasonably so. Ibn Battuta was writing years later from court gossip in a city that had many reasons to hate Muhammad bin Tughluq. Wooden buildings do collapse. And a man who wanted his father dead had easier methods available.

This book cannot tell you which it was, and it is not going to pretend. What it can tell you is what came next, because that is Part Seven: Muhammad bin Tughluq, who moved the capital of India from Delhi to the Deccan and marched the population there and then marched them back; who issued a token currency that the country forged into worthlessness; and under whom the Khokhars of the Salt Range — the people who have been in every part of this book since 1008 — rose again.

The frontier general who took the throne in 1320 founded a dynasty that would nearly destroy the state it inherited. And in 1398, down the same Punjab road, comes Timur.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1175–1176	Muhammad of Ghor takes Multan and Uch. Won by the Ghurids.
1178	Kayadara. Ghor crosses the Thar into Gujarat and is destroyed by the regent queen Naikidevi , ruling for a child. He never goes that way again. Won by Gujarat.
1179–1186	Peshawar; then Sialkot, then Lahore. Khusrau Malik, the last Ghaznavid, is taken and later killed. The dynasty of Part Five ends. Won by Ghor.
1191	Tarain I. Ghor is wounded in single combat with Govind Rai and carried from the field. Won by Prithviraj Chauhan — who then spends thirteen months besieging a fort.
1192	Tarain II. A false truce, a dawn attack, four divisions of horse archers all day and a fresh reserve at dusk. Prithviraj captured; Govind Rai killed. Won by Ghor.
1193–1194	Aibak takes Delhi and Ajmer; Jayachandra of Kanauj is defeated at Chandawar. Northern India passes to the Ghurids.
1204–1205	Ghor is beaten at Andkhud in Afghanistan; a rumour of his death reaches Punjab and the Khokhars rise and cut the Lahore–Ghazna road.
15 March 1206	Damyak. Ghor crushes the Khokhars and is then assassinated in his tent on the Jhelum. Won by his killers, whoever they were.
1206	Aibak is enthroned at Lahore. The Delhi Sultanate begins in Punjab. He dies in 1210 falling from a horse at polo.
1216	Tarain, a third time. Iltutmish defeats Taj al-Din Yildiz. Won by Iltutmish.
24 Nov 1221	The Indus. Genghis Khan destroys Jalal al-Din, who escapes by putting his horse off the bank into the river. The Khan turns back from India. Won by the Mongols.
1228	Qabacha drowns in the Indus and Iltutmish holds the whole Punjab. Won by Iltutmish.
Dec 1241	The sack of Lahore. The governor flees, the city is stormed, and Delhi sends nobody. Won by the Mongols.
1266–1287	Balban fortifies the frontier and refuses to campaign anywhere else. In 1285 his heir Prince Muhammad is killed near Multan and Amir Khusrau is taken prisoner.
1298	Jaran-Manjur. Zafar Khan and Ulugh Khan destroy a Mongol army on the Sutlej — the first outright Mongol defeat in the Punjab in seventy years. Won by Delhi.
1299	Kili. Qutlugh Khwaja comes to conquer and reaches Delhi. Zafar Khan breaks a wing, overpursues and is killed. The Mongols withdraw. Won by Delhi.

1303	Targhi blockades Delhi for two months while Alauddin is returning from Chittor. No battle. The city goes hungry. Won by nobody.
1305	Amroha. Ali Beg and Tartaq are caught dispersed in the doab and taken to Delhi to be killed. Won by Delhi.
1306	The Ravi. Kebek's army is destroyed at the river crossings by Malik Kafur and Ghazi Malik. Won by Delhi — and the invasions stop.
1320	Ghazi Malik marches from Dipalpur and takes Delhi, founding the Tughluq dynasty. <i>Part Seven begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Seven

1. **Whoever commands the Punjab frontier eventually rules Delhi.** This is the new rule of the book and it starts here. The frontier is where the empire keeps its real army, because the frontier is where the enemy is — which means it is also, permanently, the place from which the capital can be taken. Ghazi Malik in 1320 is the first. **Bahlul Lodi in 1451 and Babur in 1526 are both in Part Seven.**
2. **Punjab is spent so that the doab can be saved.** After 1241 this is explicit policy, not failure. Delhi decided the far Punjab could not be held and defended the Sutlej instead. It worked, the Sultanate survived the Mongols, and the bill was paid entirely by one province. **Watch who pays in 1398, when Timur comes down the same road.**
3. **The victory that is not followed up is only a delay.** Prithviraj beat Muhammad of Ghor and then besieged a fort for thirteen months while his enemy redesigned an army. It is the same failure as Yashodharman's alliance in Part Four dissolving on the day it won. **In this book, the invader always comes back, and the defender almost never does.**
4. **A coalition of kings loses to a single command.** Ten kings on the Ravi in Part One; the Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two; Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five; Prithviraj's confederacy at Tarain here. **Six for six. It will be seven at Panipat in Part Seven and eight at Panipat again in Part Eight.**
5. **The men who could not be finished were never a kingdom.** The Khokhars have now been in three parts of this book. They nearly broke Mahmud's line in 1008, they killed a sultan on the Jhelum in 1206, and they rise again under the Tughluqs. They have no capital, no dynasty, no chronicle and no monument — and no empire in this book manages to remove them. **The states of Punjab lose with grim regularity; its unmanageable people do not.**

COMING NEXT — PART SEVEN

Tughlaqs, Timur, Khokhars and Lodis, 1320–1526. The dynasty founded on the Punjab frontier nearly destroys the state it inherited. The Khokhars rise again under Jasrat, who fights the Sayyids of Delhi to a standstill for twenty years from the Salt Range. Multan becomes an independent sultanate under the Langahs. And in **1398 Timur comes down the Punjab road** and does to Delhi what Targhi could not, leaving northern India in ruins behind him. Out of that wreckage comes **Bahlul Lodi**, an Afghan chief from Sirhind who takes the throne in 1451 — and, at the end of it all, five raids out of Kabul, the capture of Lahore in 1524, and **the First Battle of Panipat in 1526.**

Words Used in This Part

Ghurid

The dynasty from Ghor in central Afghanistan that destroyed the Ghaznavids and conquered northern India between 1175 and 1206.

Mu'izz al-Din Muhammad

"Muhammad of Ghor." Also called Shihab al-Din in some sources, which causes endless confusion. The conqueror of Tarain.

Ghulam / mamluk

A slave-soldier, bought young and trained for service. Because he had no clan or land, his loyalty ran to his master alone. This system produces the Delhi Sultanate.

Slave Dynasty / Mamluk Sultanate

The first dynasty of the Delhi Sultanate (1206–1290), so called because Aibak, Iltutmish and Balban had all been slaves.

Tarain

Taraori, near Thanesar in Haryana. Three battles were fought here in twenty-five years — 1191, 1192 and 1216. It sits on the road every invader uses.

Chauhan / Chahamana

The Rajput dynasty of Ajmer and Delhi. Prithviraj III was its last significant ruler.

Khokhars

A people of the Salt Range and the Jhelum country. They fought at Waihind in 1008 in Part Five, killed Muhammad of Ghor in 1206, and rebel again in Part Seven.

Chagatai khanate

The Mongol successor state in Central Asia. Almost every Mongol invasion in this part comes from it.

Noyan

A Mongol commander of high rank — roughly, a general or a lord.

Iqta

An assignment of land revenue given to an officer in return for military service. The Sultanate's basic method of paying an army — which is exactly what Alauddin Khalji moved away from.

Tanka

The silver coin introduced by Iltutmish, the standard currency of northern India for centuries. The ancestor of the modern word *taka*.

Chaugan

Polo. Qutb al-Din Aibak died playing it at Lahore in 1210.

Warden of the marches

The frontier commander — the officer holding the Punjab against the Mongols from a base such as Dipalpur. In this part the post produces a dynasty.

Dipalpur

A town in the Punjab, south-west of Lahore, used as the Sultanate's forward frontier command under Alauddin Khalji.

Siri

The fortified new city Alauddin Khalji built at Delhi, unfinished when Targhi blockaded it in 1303 and completed immediately afterwards.

Tabaqat-i-Nasiri

Juzjani's history, completed around 1260. The nearest thing to a contemporary account of the conquest and the early Sultanate.

Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi

Barani's history, written around 1357. Our main source for the Khalji Mongol wars — vivid, moralising, and seventy years after the events.

Prithviraja Vijaya

A Sanskrit epic written at Prithviraj's own court by Jayanaka. The only contemporary Indian account, surviving in one damaged manuscript, and it breaks off before 1192.

Prithviraj Raso

A Braj epic of roughly the sixteenth century. The source of the blinding-and-arrow legend. Magnificent literature and not history.

Sources used for this part

- Minhaj-i-Siraj Juzjani, *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*, in Raverty's translation — for the Ghurid conquest, the slave sultans and the sack of Lahore
- Ziauddin Barani, *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi* — for Balban, Alauddin Khalji and the Mongol wars
- Amir Khusrau, *Khaza'in ul-Futuh* and his other works — contemporary, and the only participant's voice in this part
- Hasan Nizami, *Taj-ul-Maasir*, for the immediate aftermath of Tarain
- Ferishta, *Tarikh-i Ferishta*, in Briggs's translation — late, and the source of the largest numbers
- Ibn Battuta, *Rihla*, for the death of Ghiyath al-Din Tughluq at Afghanpur
- Juvayni, *Tarikh-i Jahangusha*; Rashid al-Din, *Jami al-Tawarikh*; and Nasawi's life of Jalal al-Din Mingburnu — for the Indus in 1221
- Jayanaka, *Prithviraja Vijaya*; the *Prithviraj Raso*; and the *Hammira Mahakavya* — for the Indian tradition and its later reshaping
- Chaulukya inscriptions and Gujarati chronicles for the defeat at Kayadara
- Coins of Prithviraja and Muhammad bin Sam, for the period between the battle and the execution
- Elliot and Dowson, *The History of India as Told by Its Own Historians*, for the translated Persian material
- Standard modern accounts of the Delhi Sultanate, the Ghurid conquest and the Mongol invasions of India

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: who actually killed Muhammad of Ghor at Damyak; what happened to Prithviraj after his capture, and how long he survived; whether Alauddin Khalji deliberately allowed Zafar Khan to be destroyed at Kili; whether Muhammad bin Tughluq engineered the collapse at Afghanpur; and every army size and casualty figure in the part without exception.

One caution deserves to be repeated from the front of this part. The most famous story here — Prithviraj blinded, taken to Ghazni, and killing Muhammad of Ghor with an arrow aimed by sound — is from a poem written roughly four hundred years later and is contradicted by the date of Ghor's death. It is treated in this part as literature, because that is what it is, and because how a defeated tradition rebuilds its own memory is genuinely more interesting than the legend itself.

And the standing warning applies with full force. Every battle in Part Six is described by a Persian chronicler working for the Delhi Sultanate. Juzjani served it, Barani's family served it, Amir Khusrau was its court poet. There is one contemporary Indian account of any of this, and it is a court epic celebrating a victory, in a single damaged manuscript, which stops before the defeat. Nobody in the Punjab — not the Khokhars who killed a sultan, not the people of Lahore in 1241, not the villagers of the Sutlej country who lived through eighty-five years of it — left a word.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART SEVEN OF SIXTEEN

Tughlaqs, Timur and the Lodis

Two centuries in which Punjab belongs to Delhi on paper and to nobody in practice — held in turn by a chief from the Salt Range, a dynasty in Multan, and finally by a governor of Lahore who hands the whole country to a stranger from Kabul.

1320 — 1526

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



Two Hundred Years of Nobody in Charge

And at the very end of it, for the first time in seven parts and three thousand years, somebody who actually lived in Punjab writes down what a war looked like.

Part Six ended with a frontier general marching from Dipalpur and taking the throne of Delhi. Part Seven is what his dynasty did with it, and the short answer is: they lost the country.

Not to an invader — not at first. They lost it the ordinary way, through overreach, bad money, savage taxation and a spectacular run of ideas that did not work. By the middle of the fourteenth century the Delhi Sultanate had shrunk from an empire to a large kingdom, and the Punjab had become a place where the writ of Delhi was a suggestion.

Then, in 1398, **Timur** came down the Punjab road and destroyed what was left.

What follows the destruction is the most unusual stretch in this book. For roughly a century, **Punjab is not ruled by anybody in particular**. A Khokhar chief from the Salt Range holds the northern plain for twenty years and fights Delhi to a standstill. Multan becomes an independent sultanate under its own dynasty. Lahore, Sirhind, Dipalpur and Jammu are effectively separate powers. And the men who eventually take Delhi are, in both cases, Punjab frontier commanders coming down the same road as Ghazi Malik.

Four things to hold on to

- **The pattern from Part Six now runs twice more.** Khizr Khan, governor of Multan and Lahore, takes Delhi in 1414. Bahlul Lodi, governor of Sirhind, takes Delhi in 1451. Then Babur takes Lahore in 1524 and Delhi in 1526. **Three times in this part alone, the road runs from Punjab to the throne.**
- **Punjab produces its own rulers for the first time since the Shahis.** Jasrat Khokhar and the Langahs of Multan are not governors appointed from elsewhere. They are local powers, running local states, on their own account.
- **Somebody opens the door — explicitly, in writing.** The governor of Lahore invites Babur into India. This is the Ambhi problem from Part Two, four hundred years after the Shahis, and it decides everything.
- **And then Punjab finds its voice.** In about 1520, a man from a village near Lahore watches an army sack a town and writes about it — in Punjabi, in verse, as a moral accusation against God and the conqueror both. **It is the first surviving account of a war in this book written by somebody from the country the war happened in.** That is where this part ends.

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a writer who was present, an inscription, a document made at the time. **LIKELY** means good sources writing later, generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition, often written centuries afterwards.

Part Seven has an unusual problem: **for some of it we have too much source, and the source is the killer.** Timur's campaign is described in memoirs presented as his own and in an official history written for his family. The invasion of 1526 is described by Babur in a diary he kept himself. These are extraordinary documents and they are also self-portraits by men explaining their own conquests. **When a conqueror tells you how many people he killed, he is not confessing. He is reporting a result.**

Tarmashirin, 1327 — The Last Mongol Invasion

LIKELY

Twenty years after the Ravi, the Mongols came back one final time — and this time Delhi paid them to go away.

WON BY The Mongols — by being bought off, which is its own kind of victory

WHEN Around 1327–1329. The dating is loose and the sources disagree.	WHERE Down through the Punjab — Lahore, Multan — and towards Delhi.
WHO Ala al-Din Tarmashirin, khan of the Chagatai Mongols, against Muhammad bin Tughluq.	THE EVIDENCE Ibn Battuta, who was in India shortly afterwards and later met Tarmashirin in person; and the Persian tradition.

What happened

1. **The Chagatai realm pulled itself together.** The civil wars that had ended the invasions after 1306 produced, eventually, a strong khan. Tarmashirin was that khan.
2. **He came down the old road** and plundered the Punjab — Lahore and the Multan country — before pushing towards the capital.
3. **He got a long way in.** The sources describe him reaching the neighbourhood of Delhi itself, and the country around Meerut being ravaged.
4. **And then Delhi paid.** Muhammad bin Tughluq bought him off with a very large sum and he withdrew.
5. **He never came back**, and neither did anybody else. This is the last Mongol invasion of India in this book.

HANDLE WITH CARE

This war is less well documented than the ones in Part Six and the accounts do not agree. Some sources have Tarmashirin reaching Delhi's outskirts; others describe a campaign that got as far as the Punjab and the upper doab and was then bought off. A few modern historians are sceptical that he came near Delhi at all.

What is not in doubt: a substantial Mongol force came down through the Punjab in the late 1320s, did serious damage, and left with a payment rather than after a defeat. That is a real change from 1306, and the explanation is in the state of the Sultanate rather than the strength of the Mongols.

There is also a footnote of the kind this book enjoys. **Ibn Battuta later met Tarmashirin in Central Asia** and describes him as a hospitable and pious host. The Moroccan traveller who served as a judge in Delhi sat down to dinner with the man who had marched on it.

WHY DELHI PAID INSTEAD OF FIGHTING

- **The frontier system had been let go.** Alauddin Khalji's fort line and permanent frontier command depended on constant funding and attention, and it got neither after 1316.
- **The army was committed elsewhere.** Muhammad bin Tughluq had ambitions in the Deccan and beyond, and the field force was rarely where the threat was.
- **Paying is cheaper than losing.** The same arithmetic the republics used against Samudragupta in Part Four. It works, once.
- **And the sultan had bigger plans.** That is the problem, and it is the next war.

WHAT PUNJAB LOST

- **The deterrent.** Alauddin's whole policy had been to make invading India unprofitable. A payout advertises the opposite.
- **Lahore and Multan again.** Two cities that had barely recovered from the thirteenth century.
- **Confidence in Delhi.** A frontier province watches how the capital responds, and this response was noted.
- **And within a decade, control.** The revolts start almost immediately.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Difference Twenty Years Makes

Put 1306 and 1327 side by side, because they are the same country meeting the same enemy with two completely different states behind it.

In 1306, a Mongol army under Kebek crossed into the Punjab. It was intercepted in the Punjab by a permanent frontier command based at Dipalpur, caught at the crossings of the Ravi, and destroyed. The survivors were taken to Delhi and killed in public. The message was unmistakable and it worked for twenty years.

In 1327, a Mongol army came down the same road, plundered the same cities, marched much further in, and was handed a bag of money.

Nothing about the Mongols had improved. What had changed was on the Indian side, and it was not military in origin. Alauddin Khalji's system — the paid standing army, the price controls that made a fixed salary worth having, the stocked forts on the Punjab road, the frontier warden with a free hand — was expensive, unpopular and required a ruler willing to spend on defence rather than on anything else.

Within ten years of his death, most of it had been dismantled or allowed to decay, because that is what happens to expensive systems that solve a problem which has stopped happening.

Hold on to this, because it is one of the quiet laws of this book. **The frontier is always defended by the last generation's fear.** When the fear fades, the funding goes; and by the time the next army comes down the road, the thing that stopped the last one is a line in the accounts.

The Revolts of Muhammad bin Tughluq, 1327–1351

LIKELY

The most educated ruler in medieval India spent twenty-five years having brilliant ideas, and his empire came apart underneath him.

WON BY Nobody — this is a state dismantling itself

WHEN 1325–1351, the reign.	WHERE Everywhere at once — but for this book, the Punjab, the Salt Range and Sindh.
WHO Muhammad bin Tughluq against his own provinces, his own nobility, and eventually his own army.	THE EVIDENCE Barani, who loathed him; Ibn Battuta, who served him as a judge for seven years and was terrified of him.

The man

He was, by every account including hostile ones, formidably intelligent. Ibn Battuta describes a ruler who debated philosophy and medicine, wrote elegant Persian, and gave away money on a scale that astonished a man who had seen most of the Islamic world. The same passages describe him executing people almost casually, and a court that lived in permanent fear of him.

What ruined him was not stupidity. It was a habit of implementing enormous ideas at full scale without testing them.

- 1. He moved the capital.** In 1327 he transferred the administration — and, by the accounts, a large part of Delhi’s population — a thousand miles south to **Daulatabad** in the Deccan, to govern the empire from its centre. The logic was sound. The execution killed people on the road, and within a few years the whole thing was reversed and everyone marched back.
- 2. He reinvented the currency.** Facing a shortage of silver, he issued **token coins of brass and copper** to circulate at the value of silver. It is an idea that modern economies run on. It requires a state that can prevent forgery, and his could not. **The country forged them by the cartload** — Barani says every householder became a mint — and the treasury eventually had to redeem the lot in real metal.
- 3. He planned an invasion of Khurasan.** An enormous army was raised and paid for a year, and then the project was abandoned and the army disbanded, having achieved nothing but its own wages.

4. **He sent an army into the Himalayas.** The **Qarachil** expedition of the late 1330s went up into the mountains north of the doab and was destroyed by weather, terrain and hill fighters. Very few came back.
5. **And he taxed the doab during a famine.** The revenue demand was increased in the richest agricultural region of the empire at exactly the wrong moment, and the peasantry abandoned the land and took to the forests.

WHAT THIS DID TO PUNJAB

An empire that is executing its nobles, wrecking its own currency, marching armies to no purpose and driving its farmers off the land does not hold its frontier provinces.

Revolt after revolt broke out — Bengal, the Deccan, Gujarat, Sindh — and in the north-west, **the Khokhars rose again**. The Salt Range and the Jhelum country, which had killed a sultan in Part Six and nearly broken Mahmud's line in Part Five, went back to doing what it does whenever Delhi is weak.

By the end of the reign, the effective authority of the Delhi Sultanate over the Punjab beyond the Sutlej had become nominal. **The province was not conquered by anybody. It simply stopped being governed.**

And the sultan died chasing a rebel. In 1351, pursuing a Sindhi insurgent named Taghi through the country near Thatta, Muhammad bin Tughluq fell ill and died in camp. Barani's verdict, endlessly quoted, is that the king was freed from his people and they from their king.

WHY THE PROVINCES BROKE AWAY

- **The centre stopped paying.** A currency crisis and a disbanded army mean garrisons that go unpaid, and unpaid garrisons make their own arrangements.
- **Terror does not travel well.** Fear of a sultan works within a day's ride of him. At a thousand miles it is just a rumour.
- **The nobility had been thinned by executions,** which meant the men who might have held provinces loyally were dead or afraid.
- **And the Khokhars had never needed permission.** They had no state to lose and nothing to be taken away.

WHY THE SULTAN FAILED

- **He scaled every idea straight to national size.** No pilot, no province-sized trial, no way back if it went wrong.
- **He mistook the plan for the problem.** The token currency was correct in theory and required an anti-forgery capacity he did not have. That is not a small detail; that was the policy.
- **He punished failure so hard that nobody would report it.** A ruler who executes bearers of bad news gets no bad news, and therefore no warning.
- **And he was never in one place.** Twenty-five years of moving between crises meant no crisis was ever finished.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Coins Everybody Could Make

Of all the things in this reign, the token currency is the one worth understanding properly, because it is not the joke that popular accounts make of it.

Muhammad bin Tughluq faced a genuine shortage of silver. His answer was to issue coins of brass and copper and declare them legal tender at the value of a silver coin — **money whose worth came from the state's word rather than from its metal**. Every note in your pocket today works on exactly that principle. He was, by several centuries, early.

The catch is the one every currency has ever had. A token is worth what it says only if nobody else can make one. A silver coin is hard to counterfeit because silver is hard to get. **A brass coin is not, and fourteenth-century India was full of skilled metalworkers.**

Barani says the houses of the Hindus became mints, and that the countryside produced the sultan's money by the cartload — using it to pay taxes, to buy horses and weapons, and to settle debts in coin the state had promised to honour.

When the scale of it became clear, the government did the only thing it could and offered to redeem the tokens in real silver and gold. **The country brought them in. The treasury paid out.** The chronicles describe heaps of worthless metal piling up outside the palace at Tughlaqabad, where they were reportedly still lying years later.

The lesson is not that the idea was mad. **The lesson is that a policy is only as good as the state's ability to enforce it — and by the 1330s the Delhi Sultanate could not enforce anything, which is exactly why it was also losing the Punjab.** The forged coins and the Khokhar revolt are the same fact wearing different clothes.

Firoz Shah in Sindh, 1362–1367

— The Army That Got Lost

LIKELY

A sultan took an army into the desert country of the lower Indus and disappeared for six months, and half of India thought he was dead.

WON BY Delhi eventually — after the worst logistical disaster in the Sultanate’s history

WHEN 1362 the first campaign; 1365–1367 the second.	WHERE Sindh and the Rann of Kutch, launched from Multan and the southern Punjab.
WHO Firoz Shah Tughluq against the Sammas of Thatta.	THE EVIDENCE The Persian chroniclers, and Firoz Shah’s own inscription-cum-memoir, the <i>Futuhāt-i Firoz Shahi</i>.

What happened

1. **The campaign was launched from the Punjab** — the army assembled and supplied through Multan, which is why it is in this book.
2. **It went wrong immediately.** Disease broke out among the horses; the accounts describe the cavalry losing a large proportion of its mounts, which for a medieval army is close to a death sentence.
3. **The supply system failed.** The country was hostile, the grain did not arrive, and the boats on the Indus that were supposed to feed the army were unreliable.
4. **The retreat became the disaster.** Withdrawing towards Gujarat, the army entered the **Rann of Kutch** — a salt marsh that floods, dries, and looks identical in every direction — and the guides either failed or misled them.
5. **They were lost for months.** The accounts describe an army wandering in the Rann with no communication reaching Delhi at all. **For about six months, the capital did not know whether its sultan was alive.**
6. **He came out, went back, and did it properly.** The second campaign, with better preparation, forced Thatta to submit in 1367.

THE OTHER THING FIROZ SHAH DID, WHICH MATTERS MORE

Firoz Shah ruled for thirty-seven years and fought remarkably few wars. What he did instead was build, and a great deal of it was in the Punjab and the country immediately east of it.

He built the largest canal network in medieval India. Channels were cut from the Sutlej, from the Ghaggar and from the Yamuna, carrying water into dry country that had never been farmed. He founded **Hisar** — Hisar-Firoza — as a city in the middle of it, along with Fatehabad, Firozpur and Jaunpur, and repaired the reservoirs and forts of his predecessors.

This is the only sustained programme of construction anywhere in this book's medieval section, and it changed the map. Land that had been scrub became cultivable. Towns appeared where there had been nothing. Several of those canals were still being used, in improved form, under later governments.

He was also a harsher ruler than the building programme suggests — his religious policy was narrower than that of the sultans before him, he extended the *jizya* tax to groups that had previously been exempt, and he was capable of considerable cruelty. Both things belong in the same paragraph. **The man who dug the canals is the same man, and this book is not going to hand you only the half you prefer.**

WHY THE SECOND CAMPAIGN WORKED

- **He had learned the ground.** The first expedition was an education paid for in horses and men.
- **Supply was organised in advance** through Multan and the river, rather than assumed.
- **He was patient.** Two years between attempts, which is exactly what Muhammad bin Tughluq never allowed himself.

WHY THE FIRST ONE COLLAPSED

- **Horses, not enemies.** Disease in the cavalry lines did more damage than the Sammas ever did.
- **He fought in country he did not understand.** The Rann is not desert and not sea and behaves like neither.
- **He trusted local guides in hostile country.** An old mistake with a very long history.
- **And nobody could reach him.** An army out of communication for six months is an army that cannot be reinforced, redirected or rescued.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Sultan Who Collected Pillars

Here is a thing Firoz Shah Tughluq did that has almost nothing to do with war and everything to do with this book.

In the 1350s he found two ancient stone columns in the countryside north of Delhi — one near Topra in the Ambala district, in the eastern Punjab, and one near Meerut. They were enormously old, beautifully polished, covered in writing nobody could read, and lying in fields.

He had them moved to Delhi. The operation is described in detail in the chronicles: the pillar wrapped in silk cotton and reeds, lowered onto a bed of raw cotton, loaded on a forty-two-wheeled carriage, hauled by thousands of men to the Yamuna, floated downriver on boats lashed together, and then raised again on a purpose-built structure at his new city.

He also had scholars brought in to read the inscription. **None of them could.** The script was Brahmi, it had been dead for something like a thousand years, and it was not deciphered until James Prinsep worked it out in 1837 — nearly five hundred years later.

The columns were Ashoka's. The writing on them was the edicts you met in Part Three — the pillar edicts about restraint, about care for living things, about what a ruler owes the ruled.

So a fourteenth-century sultan hauled a third-century-BCE emperor's plea against cruelty across a hundred and sixty kilometres, at enormous expense, purely because it was beautiful and old — and could not read a word of it.

You met this pillar's cousin in Part Three, at Allahabad, where Samudragupta's minister carved a war record over Ashoka's edicts and Jahangir later carved over both. Here the same thing happens with the opposite motive: not contempt, but a kind of blank, expensive reverence for something whose meaning had been completely lost.

The pillar is still standing in Delhi. It says what it always said.

Multan, 1397–1398 — Six Months in the Rain

LIKELY

Timur’s grandson opened the invasion of India by sitting outside Multan for half a year, and the weather nearly beat him before the city did.

WON BY

Pir Muhammad — at a cost that should have been a warning

WHEN

Siege from **1397**; the city falls in **1398**, before Timur himself crosses the Indus.

WHERE

Multan, and the Uch country.

WHO

Pir Muhammad, Timur’s grandson, against Sarang Khan, the governor for Delhi.

THE EVIDENCE

Sharaf al-Din Yazdi’s Zafarnama, the official Timurid history, and the memoirs presented as Timur’s own.

Why Multan first

Because it is the door, and it always has been. Muhammad bin Qasim took it in 712 in Part Five. Mahmud fought over it in Part Five. Muhammad of Ghor took it in 1175 in Part Six. **Every invader who comes from the west and does not want to fight through the northern passes comes at Multan.**

Timur’s plan was a pincer. His grandson Pir Muhammad would come up through Sindh and take Multan and the southern Punjab; Timur himself would cross the Indus in the north and come down the road through Lahore. They would join in the middle and go to Delhi together.

What happened

1. **Pir Muhammad invested Multan in 1397.** The city was well walled and the governor, Sarang Khan, held it.
2. **The siege lasted about six months** and went into the rainy season, which is the detail that matters.
3. **The rains destroyed his cavalry.** The Timurid accounts describe the horses dying in large numbers in the wet — from disease, from foundering, from lack of dry fodder. **A Central Asian army in the Punjab monsoon stops being a Central Asian army.**
4. **Multan fell anyway**, in the early part of 1398, and Sarang Khan was taken.

5. **But Pir Muhammad's force was wrecked.** When Timur came down to join him, he had to re-horse and reinforce his grandson's army before it was fit to fight.

A NOTE ON THE SOURCES FOR EVERYTHING THAT FOLLOWS

Almost everything in the next four wars comes from two texts, and you should know what they are before you read a single number.

The *Zafarnama* of Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi, completed in the 1420s, is the official history of Timur written for his descendants. It is detailed, well-informed and entirely committed to presenting its subject as an instrument of divine will.

The *Malfuzat-i Timuri* — also called the *Tuzuk-i Timuri* — is a Persian text presented as a translation of Timur's own memoirs, made in the seventeenth century by Abu Talib Husaini, who said he had found the original Chagatai manuscript in Yemen. **Many scholars doubt that story and regard the text as later work built on genuine material.** It is the source of the most quoted passages about the Indian campaign, including some of the worst.

So: **when this part quotes a figure or a motive from "Timur", it means a text that claims to be Timur.** The events are corroborated. The self-justifications should be read as what a Timurid court wanted posterity to believe.

WHY MULTAN FELL

- **No relief came.** Delhi in 1397 was in the middle of a succession war between rival princes and could not have sent an army if it had wanted to.
- **Timurid siegecraft was excellent,** inherited from the Mongol tradition and improved.
- **Six months is a long time.** Walled cities fall to patience more often than to assault.

WHAT IT COST THE ATTACKER

- **The horses.** The single most expensive item in a steppe army, and the campaign started by losing most of them to weather.
- **The timetable.** Six months for the first city meant the main invasion had to be fitted into one dry season.
- **And it proved the point Genghis Khan had made.** Part Six ended with the Mongols turning back from India partly because of the climate. Seventy-five years later, Timur's advance guard learned the same lesson in the same country.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Reason Nobody Stays

Here is a question this book has been circling since Part Four, and Multan in 1397 is the clearest place to answer it. **Why do invaders from Central Asia raid India rather than settle it — and why, when they do settle, do they change?**

Part of the answer is horses, and it is almost entirely unromantic.

A steppe army's whole advantage is mobility, and mobility is animals. A Mongol or Timurid horseman rode with several remounts, which is what let him cover ground nobody could match. Those animals needed grazing — dry, open, cool grazing of the kind that runs for thousands of kilometres across Central Asia.

The Punjab in the wet season is the opposite of that country in every particular. It is hot, it is humid, the ground turns to mud, the fodder rots, and horses that have never met these conditions get sick and die. Pir Muhammad lost his cavalry to a monsoon without a battle being fought.

This is why the campaigning season for every invasion in this book runs from autumn to spring, why armies from the north-west almost always leave before the rains, and why the ones who stay — the Kushans in Part Three, the Ghaznavids in Part Five, the Sultanate in Part Six — end up buying Indian elephants, recruiting Indian infantry and importing horses at ruinous expense from the very country they came from.

The four-hundred-year habit that Part Three described — invaders becoming Indian within two generations — starts with the weather. You cannot keep being a steppe army in a place that kills steppe horses. You either leave, or you become something else.

Timur Crosses the Indus, 1398

LIKELY

The march from the Indus to Delhi took three months and destroyed every town on the road, and the man doing it wrote down why.

WON BY

Timur — against a country with no government left to fight him

WHEN

Crossed the Indus **24 September 1398**; reached Delhi in December.

WHERE

Attock, the Jhelum, the Salt Range, Talamba, Bhatnair, Sirsa, Kaithal, Panipat.

WHO

Timur — Tamerlane — against the Khokhars, the local chiefs, and a Sultanate in civil war.

THE EVIDENCE

Yazdi and the memoirs attributed to Timur. Both written by the winning side.

Why he came

Timur was in his sixties and had already conquered Persia, Central Asia and the Caucasus. The reason he gave — in the texts written for his own court — was religious: that the rulers of Delhi were too tolerant of their Hindu subjects, and that the campaign was therefore a holy war.

Read that with the scepticism it deserves. His main victims were Muslim states: he had already sacked Baghdad's neighbours and would shortly destroy the Ottoman army and the Mamluk cities of Syria. India in 1398 was the richest and least defended target within reach of a man who financed his state through conquest.

And it was undefended in a very specific way. **The Delhi Sultanate had split into two rival courts.** Since 1394 there had been competing sultans, one at Delhi and one at Firozabad, with the nobility fighting between them. There was no functioning central army. Timur's intelligence would have told him this, and the speed of his march says he knew.

What happened

1. **He crossed the Indus on a bridge of boats near Attock, on 24 September 1398**, and moved fast.
2. **He fought his way across the Jhelum country.** The local ruler around Jhelum resisted and was defeated; the accounts describe him drowning in the river rather than being taken.

3. **The Khokhars fought him.** Under their chief **Shaikha**, the people of the Salt Range did what they had done to Mahmud in Part Five and to Ghor in Part Six. They lost, and Shaikha's son will be War Nine of this part.
4. **Talamba was sacked**, then the army swung south-east into the desert country.
5. **Bhatnair** — modern Hanumangarh — was stormed after a hard fight. The accounts describe a massacre and mass self-immolation inside the fort.
6. **Then Sirsa, Fatehabad, Kaithal, Panipat.** The chronicles describe town after town found empty, the population having fled, and burned anyway.
7. **And by mid-December he was on the Jumna, in front of Delhi.**

THE MASSACRE OF THE PRISONERS

On the march, Timur's army took captives in enormous numbers — the texts give a figure of about a hundred thousand, and as always the number is the winner's.

Before the battle for Delhi, the decision was taken to kill them. The reason given in the memoirs attributed to Timur is coldly practical: **the prisoners were in the camp, they had shown signs of joy at the approach of the Delhi army, and a battle would leave them behind the fighting line.** The order was that every man in the army should put his own captives to death, on pain of forfeiting his life.

This book is not going to soften that or bury it in a subordinate clause. It was the mass killing of unarmed prisoners as a matter of administrative convenience before a battle, ordered by the commander, and recorded by his own side without embarrassment because they did not think it required any.

The figure of a hundred thousand should be treated like every other figure in this part — as a court number rather than a count. **The order and the killing are not in dispute.** They are in the sources written to praise him.

WHY NOTHING STOPPED HIM

- **There was no field army in the Punjab.** Not a small one, not a beaten one — none. The frontier command of Part Six had ceased to exist.
- **Delhi was fighting itself.** Two sultans and a divided nobility, at the exact moment the largest army in Asia crossed the Indus.
- **He moved faster than news.** Three months from the Indus to Delhi, in a country where a message takes weeks.
- **And terror did the rest.** After Bhatnair, towns emptied before he arrived, which is precisely what the reputation was for.

WHY PUNJAB COULD NOT RESIST

- **Everything was local.** The Khokhars fought, the Jhelum chief fought, Bhatnair fought — each on its own, in sequence, exactly as the cities of Sindh did in 712.
- **The forts were not stocked.** Alauddin's grain-filled fort line on the Punjab road was a century gone.
- **The rivers were not held.** Five rivers, not one of them defended.
- **And there was nothing to rally to.** No legitimate government, no summons, no coalition — not even the doomed kind this book usually gets.

The Towns That Were Already Empty

There is a detail that repeats through the accounts of this march, and it is more revealing than any of the battles.

Again and again, Timur's army arrives at a town — Sirsa, Fatehabad, Kaithal, the villages along the road — and finds it deserted. The people have gone. They have taken what they could carry and left for the ravines, the jungle, the river islands, anywhere that a cavalry army will not follow.

The chroniclers record this with mild irritation, as a logistical inconvenience: fewer captives, less plunder, no supplies.

What it actually records is the only defence available to the people of the Punjab in 1398, and the fact that they knew exactly when to use it.

Nobody warned them officially. There was no government to issue a warning. What there was, was a road that had been carrying invasions for four hundred years, a population that had lived through the Mongol raids of Part Six within family memory, and a very old set of instincts about what the dust on the horizon means.

So they went. Not heroically — there is no last stand in an empty town, and this book is not going to invent one. They read the situation correctly, wrote nothing down, saved as many of their families as they could, and came back afterwards to rebuild on the same spot, which is what people in the Punjab have done after every war in these sixteen parts.

The chronicles call these towns abandoned. The better word is evacuated. It is the single most common act in the military history of this province and it has never once been called a strategy.

Delhi, 17 December 1398

LIKELY

The Sultanate put a hundred and twenty armoured elephants in the field, and lost to burning hay.

WON BY

Timur — and then the city was destroyed anyway

WHEN 17 December 1398; the sack begins within days and runs into January.	WHERE Outside Delhi, on the plain by the Jumna.
WHO Timur against Nasir al-Din Mahmud Shah and his commander Mallu Iqbal Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Yazdi, in detail, and the memoirs attributed to Timur.

The elephants

The Sultanate’s one real asset was its war elephants — the accounts say about a hundred and twenty, armoured, with blades fixed to their tusks, and in some versions poison on the blades. Timur’s army had never fought elephants and the sources are unusually frank about the fact that his men were frightened of them.

His answer was engineering, and it is worth setting out because it is a masterclass in beating a weapon you have never faced.

1. **He dug a trench** in front of his position and threw up defences.
2. **He scattered iron caltrops** — spikes designed to point upward however they land — across the ground the elephants would cross.
3. **He tied his baggage animals into a barrier.** Buffaloes and camels roped together in front of the line, so that a charge would hit an obstacle rather than a rank of men.
4. **And then he set them on fire.** The animals were loaded with dry grass and wood, and at the moment of the elephant charge the loads were lit and the animals driven forward.
5. **The elephants turned.** Burning, screaming animals coming towards them broke the charge, and the elephants went back through their own army.
6. **The Delhi army disintegrated,** and the battle was effectively over. Mahmud Shah and Mallu Iqbal fled the city that night.

ELEPHANTS, ONE MORE TIME

Count how often this animal has decided a battle in this book, and in which direction.

Part Two, the Hydaspes: Porus's elephants panic under Macedonian pikes and trample his own infantry. **Part Five, Waihind 1008:** Anandapala's elephant bolts and an entire Indian confederacy dissolves. **Part Six, Tarain 1192:** the elephant line is useless against horse archers who will not close. **Part Seven, Delhi 1398:** the elephants turn and go back through their own army.

Four battles, four defeats, one animal. **The war elephant is the most consistently catastrophic weapon system in Indian military history**, and the reason is not that it was weak — it was terrifying and it worked, when it worked. The reason is that it is a living creature with its own opinions about fire, noise and pain, positioned at the centre of an army that has no plan for what to do when it changes its mind.

And it kept being used, for two thousand years, because when it did work it was decisive, and because a king on an elephant is visible to his whole army. That visibility was the point, and it was also the flaw.

WHY TIMUR WON

- **He studied the weapon and built a counter.** Trench, caltrops, animal barrier, fire. Four separate answers to one problem, prepared before the battle.
- **He fought from a prepared position.** Almost nobody in this book digs in, and the ones who do tend to win.
- **His army had no other job.** Professional, unified, campaigning for years under one commander.
- **And his enemy had already lost the country.** A sultan whose writ ended at his own city walls was not going to win a battle outside them.

WHY DELHI LOST

- **It had spent four years fighting itself.** Two rival courts, and the army that met Timur was what could be scraped together from one of them.
- **It committed its one advantage frontally.** Elephants driven straight at a prepared position with fire waiting for them.
- **It had no reserve and no second plan.** When the elephants turned, there was nothing behind them.
- **And its leaders left that night.** Which is the beginning of the next paragraph, and the worst part of this war.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE ONE THIS PART IS BUILT AROUND

The City That Surrendered

Here is what makes the destruction of Delhi different from every other sack in this book, and it is not the scale.

Delhi surrendered. The sultan and his commander had fled in the night. The remaining notables of the city — the religious leaders, the merchants, the officials — came out, submitted formally, and were granted quarter. Timur's own account is clear that terms were given and that he intended the city to be spared, and Yazdi says the same.

Then a levy was imposed, and parties went into the city to collect it, and something went wrong. The accounts describe resistance in the streets over the collection, then fighting, then more troops going in, then the whole thing coming apart.

For several days, one of the great cities of the world was destroyed. The population was killed or enslaved; the accounts describe the survivors being driven out in columns, and craftsmen — especially masons — being separated out and sent to Samarkand to build Timur's capital. The chroniclers describe towers built of heads. When it was over, Delhi was effectively empty, and it did not recover for generations.

Both surviving accounts present this as an accident that got out of hand — a sack that occurred despite the commander's intention.

You are entitled to disbelieve them, and you should at least notice what the excuse is doing. A commander who cannot control his army for three days is either not in command or is choosing not to be, and Timur was in command of that army for forty years. The claim of an accidental massacre is the standard defence of every general in history who wanted the result without the responsibility.

What is beyond argument is what it produced. **Northern India lost its capital, its administration, its treasury and its craftsmen in one month.** A famine and an epidemic followed. And the Delhi Sultanate — the state that had held off the Mongols for eighty-five years in Part Six — never functioned as an empire again.

Everything in the rest of this part happens in the hole that this left.

The Road Back, 1399

LIKELY

Having destroyed Delhi, Timur went home along the Himalayan foothills, fighting all the way — and left behind the man who would take the throne.

WON BY

Timur — and, indirectly, by his last appointment

WHEN Left Delhi 1 January 1399; recrossed the Indus in March 1399.	WHERE Meerut, Hardwar, then west along the Siwaliks through the Jammu country.
WHO Timur against the hill rajas, the Jammu country and the Khokhars again.	WHAT HE LEAVES Khizr Khan, installed over Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur.

What happened

1. **He stormed Meerut**, which had refused terms, and then moved north to the Ganges at Hardwar.
2. **He turned west along the foothills**. This is the route that keeps a large army in supply and out of the worst of the plains, and it took him straight through the hill states of the eastern Punjab and Jammu.
3. **He fought the whole way**. The hill rajas resisted in country that suited them, and the accounts describe repeated engagements rather than a march.
4. **The Raja of Jammu was defeated and captured**.
5. **He crossed the Indus in March 1399** and was gone. He never returned to India.
6. **And on the way out he made an appointment**, handing Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur to a local noble named **Khizr Khan** as his deputy.

WHAT WAS ACTUALLY LEFT BEHIND

It is worth being concrete about what a country looks like after this, because the chronicles move straight on to the next reign.

Delhi was empty. The administration was gone, the treasury was gone, and the skilled workforce had been marched to Samarkand. Famine and epidemic followed the sack, and the sources describe both.

The Punjab had been crossed twice — once going in and once coming back by a different route — with the towns on both roads destroyed or emptied. Multan had endured a six-month siege before any of it started.

And there was no government. Not a weak one. For a period after 1399 there is effectively no state authority between the Indus and the Ganges, and the country reorganises itself around whoever is locally strong: a Khokhar chief in the Salt Range, hill rajas in the Siwaliks, a governor in Multan, Afghan clans around Sirhind.

That reorganisation is the political history of the next hundred years, and every remaining war in this part comes out of it.

WHY HE LEFT

- **He had what he came for.** The plunder of Delhi, in a campaign that lasted six months from the Indus and back.
- **The season was ending.** The hot weather and then the rains were coming, and Part Four of this book explains what those do to a steppe army.
- **He had other wars.** The Ottomans and the Mamluks were next, and he beat both within four years.
- **And India was never the objective.** He wanted its wealth, not its administration — the Mahmud model from Part Five, at ten times the scale.

WHAT INDIA LOST

- **A functioning state.** The Sultanate survives in name for another century and never again rules an empire.
- **A generation of craftsmen.** Deported to Central Asia to build somebody else's capital.
- **The Punjab's towns, twice over.** On the way in and on the way out.
- **And the deterrent, permanently.** It had been demonstrated that India could be entered and its capital destroyed by an army that then simply went home.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Deputy Who Became a King

The most consequential thing Timur did in India was not the battle or the sack. It was a personnel decision made on his way out of the country.

Riding home in early 1399, he confirmed a local noble named **Khizr Khan** in charge of Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur — the southern and western Punjab — as his deputy. It was an administrative tidying-up, the sort of thing a departing conqueror does so that the ground behind him has a name attached to it.

Fifteen years later, in **1414**, that deputy marched on Delhi and took it, and founded the dynasty that ruled northern India for the next thirty-seven years.

And here is the detail that makes it worth a page. **Khizr Khan never called himself sultan.** He ruled Delhi without taking the royal title, had the Friday prayers read in the name of Timur's son Shah Rukh rather than his own, and continued to describe himself as a deputy — of a dynasty in Samarkand that had no ability whatever to enforce the claim and, so far as anyone can tell, very little interest in it.

Historians have argued about why: caution, genuine loyalty, a legitimacy he could borrow but not manufacture. Whatever the reason, the effect is one of the strangest sentences in Indian history. **For a generation after Timur destroyed Delhi, Delhi was governed in his family's name by a man from the Punjab who had been left in charge on the way out.**

Watch the mechanism, because it is the rule of Part Six repeating on schedule. **The frontier command takes the capital.** Ghazi Malik from Dipalpur in 1320. Khizr Khan from Multan and Lahore in 1414. Bahlul Lodi from Sirhind in 1451. Babur, by way of Lahore, in 1526.

Four times in two hundred years, and every one of them comes down the same road.

Khizr Khan Takes Delhi, 1414

LIKELY

The Punjab governor spent fifteen years grinding towards the capital, took it, and then spent the rest of his life collecting taxes at the head of an army because there was no other way to collect them.

WON BY

Khizr Khan — founding the Sayyid dynasty, which never quite admitted it was a dynasty

WHEN Delhi taken in 1414; he rules until 1421.	WHERE From Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur to Delhi, along the usual road.
WHO Khizr Khan against Daulat Khan Lodi, who was holding Delhi.	THE EVIDENCE Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi's <i>Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi</i>, written at this court — contemporary, and the best source for the fifteenth-century Punjab.

What happened

1. **He held on through fifteen years of chaos.** After Timur left, the Punjab was contested between Khizr Khan, rival nobles, and whatever Delhi could occasionally project. He lost Multan and Lahore at times and took them back.
2. **He built a base rather than raiding.** Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur were governed, taxed and garrisoned — which meant that when he moved, he moved with a revenue behind him.
3. **He took Delhi in 1414** from Daulat Khan Lodi, who had held it after the last Tughluq.
4. **And then he ruled without a crown.** No royal title, no coins in his own name, the Friday prayer read for Shah Rukh in Samarkand. His successors eventually took the title; he never did.
5. **He spent the rest of his reign on campaign,** not to conquer but to collect. The *Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi* reads, for these years, like an annual circuit: ride out, extract the revenue from a district by force, ride to the next one, repeat.

WHAT A STATE LOOKS LIKE AFTER TIMUR

The Sayyid “empire” is worth understanding because it is not really an empire at all, and the difference matters for everything that follows.

It had no administration to speak of. The revenue system that Alauddin Khalji had built and Firoz Shah had maintained was gone, along with the officials who ran it.

So taxation became a military operation. Instead of assessors and collectors, a field army rode out each season and took what it could from districts that would otherwise not have paid. This is not government; it is organised extraction with a throne attached.

And the territory was tiny. A contemporary jibe, quoted in several later histories, held that the sultan’s kingdom ran from Delhi to Palam — that is, about fifteen kilometres. It is a joke rather than a survey, and like most good jokes it is roughly the right shape.

This is why the Punjab in the fifteenth century belongs to local men. **There was nothing above them to belong to.**

WHY KHIZR KHAN WON

- **He had a province and everyone else had a faction.** Multan and Lahore produced revenue; Delhi’s claimants produced claims.
- **He waited fifteen years.** The same patience that got Muhammad of Ghor to Lahore in Part Six.
- **He borrowed a legitimacy he could not create.** Ruling in Shah Rukh’s name made him a deputy of the man who had destroyed Delhi, which was more authority than any local claimant could invent.
- **And he came from the frontier.** Where the soldiers were.

WHY IT DID NOT ADD UP TO MUCH

- **He inherited a ruin.** There was no functioning state to take over, only a city and a title.
- **Extraction is not administration.** A government that must send an army to collect its own taxes has already told every district what its real position is.
- **The Punjab did not come with him.** Taking Delhi meant leaving the province, and within a few years there was a Khokhar chief running most of it.
- **And the dynasty lasted thirty-seven years,** ending when another Punjab frontier lord walked in.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Kingdom From Delhi to Palam

There is a line about this period that has been repeated for six hundred years, in various forms, in various languages: **that the empire of the Sultan of Delhi extended from Delhi to Palam.**

Palam is now under an airport. It was then a village a short ride from the city gates.

The joke is aimed at the Sayyids, and it is unfair in the way jokes are — Khizr Khan and his successors did control considerably more than that, at least in the sense of being able to ride into it once a year with enough cavalry. But the reason it stuck is that it describes something true about the whole century, and the truth is not really about Delhi.

Between roughly 1400 and 1500, northern India had no centre. Not a weak centre or a contested one — no centre. The Punjab beyond the Sutlej was held by whoever held it. Multan went its own way entirely. Jaunpur in the east became a separate sultanate with its own splendid architecture, Malwa and Gujarat became independent kingdoms, and the hill states of the Siwaliks did as they pleased.

And here is the part that this book keeps having to insist on. **For most people in the Punjab, this was not a catastrophe.** A century without a distant capital demanding revenue is a century in which local arrangements govern, canals get maintained by the people who use them, and the harvest mostly stays where it was grown.

The chroniclers hate this period because they were employed by kings and it is a period without impressive kings. **Every source you have for the fifteenth-century Punjab was written by somebody who thought the absence of an empire was a disaster, and none of them asked the farmers.**

Jasrat Khokhar's Twenty Years, 1420–1442

LIKELY

A chief from the Salt Range came home from captivity, took the northern Punjab, and fought the Sultan of Delhi to a standstill for two decades.

WON BY Jasrat Khokhar — never decisively, and never beaten either

WHEN Released around 1420; active until his death around 1442.	WHERE The Salt Range, Sialkot, Lahore, Jalandhar and the Jammu country.
WHO Jasrat, son of Shaikha Khokhar, against Mubarak Shah of the Sayyid dynasty and the Raja of Jammu.	THE EVIDENCE The <i>Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi</i> — a contemporary Delhi chronicle that hated him and had to keep writing about him.

Who he was

His father **Shaikha** was the Khokhar chief who fought Timur in 1398 in War Five of this part. Jasrat himself was taken prisoner during the Timurid wars and spent years in captivity in Central Asia, and was released around 1420 by Timur's son Shah Rukh.

He came back to the Salt Range and found the Punjab with no government in it.

These are the same people you have been following since 1008. The Khokhars charged Mahmud's line at Waihind in Part Five. They killed Muhammad of Ghor on the Jhelum in Part Six. They rose under Muhammad bin Tughluq in War Two of this part, and fought Timur in War Five. **Now, for the first and only time in this book, they run the country.**

What happened

- 1. He beat Jammu first.** Defeating the hill raja gave him the northern flank and, by the accounts, a great deal of plunder and prestige.
- 2. He took Sialkot, then Lahore.** The two cities that anchor the northern Punjab, both of them in this book since Part Three.

3. **He fought Delhi for twenty years.** Mubarak Shah campaigned against him repeatedly through the 1420s and 1430s. The pattern is monotonous and it is the whole story: **the Delhi army comes, Jasrat withdraws into the Salt Range and the river country, the Delhi army cannot stay, and when it leaves he comes back.**
4. **He raided as far as the Sutlej,** and at times threatened the approaches to Delhi itself.
5. **He was never decisively defeated,** and he died — around 1442 — still in possession of a great deal of what he had taken.

WHY HE COULD NOT BE FINISHED

This is the fourth time in this book that a Punjabi people has proved unremovable, and by now the mechanism is clear enough to state as a rule.

He had no capital to take. A state can be destroyed by capturing its centre. Jasrat's power had no centre — he held Lahore when it suited him and left it when it did not.

He had ground that suited him. The Salt Range and the river country between the Jhelum and the Chenab is the terrain Part Five described at Nandana: broken, waterless in the wrong places, and hostile to a large cavalry army from the plains.

He did not need to win. Delhi had to conquer him; he only had to still be there. Every campaign that ended with the Sultanate's army going home for the season was a Khokhar victory by default.

And he had a population, not an army. The distinction is everything. Armies can be destroyed in an afternoon. A people that supports a chief has to be occupied, and occupation costs more than the Punjab was worth to a government that could barely tax Delhi.

WHY JASRAT HELD THE PUNJAB

- **He came back to a vacuum.** Timur had removed every institution capable of stopping him, and the Sayyids were extracting rather than governing.
- **Local legitimacy.** He was not a governor sent from elsewhere; he was a Khokhar chief in Khokhar country, which is a different kind of authority.
- **He fought a war of avoidance.** Never a pitched battle against the main Delhi army if it could be helped.
- **And he used the hills and the rivers.** The lesson Part Five spent a whole chapter on: Punjab wins in its broken country and loses on its plains.

WHY IT DID NOT BECOME A STATE

- **He never took a capital and kept it.** Holding Lahore permanently would have meant defending it, which was the one thing his method could not do.
- **No administration, no succession.** Personal authority over a set of clans does not survive the man.
- **He fought his neighbours as readily as Delhi.** Jammu, the local chiefs, rival factions — there was no coalition of Punjabi powers, only Jasrat and everybody else.
- **And when he died it dissolved.** Within a decade the Punjab belonged to the Afghan clans around Sirhind, and one of them took Delhi.

Four Hundred and Thirty Years of the Same People

Line up the appearances, because when you see them together they stop looking like footnotes.

1008, Waihind. Unarmoured hillmen charge on foot into the fortified line of the best army in Asia and kill several thousand of Mahmud of Ghazni's professionals before the line re-forms. An elephant panics half a mile away and none of it counts.

1206, Damyak. Muhammad of Ghor crushes a Khokhar rising on the Jhelum and is dead in his tent within a fortnight, probably at their hands.

1330s. They rise against Muhammad bin Tughluq while his empire falls apart around him.

1398. Shaikha Khokhar fights Timur — Timur, who had just come from destroying Persia and would shortly destroy the Ottoman army — and loses, and survives.

1420–1442. Shaikha's son takes Lahore and Sialkot and runs the northern Punjab for twenty years while the Sultan of Delhi tries and fails to remove him.

Four hundred and thirty years. Six empires. **And in all that time they never had a capital, never founded a dynasty, never built a monument, never minted a coin, and never — not once — produced a chronicle of their own.**

Everything we know about them comes from the people they fought, and those people were writing in Persian, in Delhi, in irritation.

This is the same shape as the Yaudheyas at the end of Part Three, who outlasted five empires and left one word stamped on copper. **The states of the Punjab lose in this book with terrible regularity. The peoples of the Punjab are never finished, and are almost never written down.**

The Langahs of Multan, 1445–1526

LIKELY

Southern Punjab spent eighty years as an independent country, and it is the closest thing to a native Punjabi state between the Shahis and Ranjit Singh.

WON BY

The Langah dynasty — and then, in the end, by the Arghuns of Sindh

WHEN

Independent from about **1445**; falls to the Arghuns in the **1520s**.

WHERE

Multan and the southern Punjab, from the Sutlej down towards Sindh.

WHO

The **Langahs**, against the governors of Delhi, the Lodis, and eventually Sindh.

THE EVIDENCE

Persian chronicles of the Lodis and of Sindh, and later Multani tradition. Thin, and mostly written by outsiders.

What happened

1. **Delhi lost its grip on Multan in the 1440s**, as it had lost its grip on everywhere else, and the local governor could not hold the city against the surrounding tribes.
2. **A Langah chief took it** — the accounts differ on the details, and a marriage into the previous governor’s family is part of most versions — and took the title of sultan.
3. **The dynasty ruled for about eighty years**. Its high point was under **Husain Langah** in the later fifteenth century, when Multan expanded north and east and became a serious regional power.
4. **It fought the Lodis**. Delhi under Bahlul and Sikandar Lodi tried repeatedly to bring Multan back, and did not manage it.
5. **And it fell to Sindh, not to Delhi**. In the 1520s the Arghuns — themselves refugees pushed out of Afghanistan by the same upheavals that produced Babur — came up the Indus and took Multan after a long siege, at exactly the moment Babur was taking Lahore.

WHO THE LANGAHS WERE, AND WHY IT IS WORTH ASKING

The origins of the Langaḥs are genuinely disputed and the dispute is old. Some accounts make them a Jat clan of the southern Punjab; others make them of Baloch or Afghan descent; the dynasty itself, once established, claimed a more prestigious foreign ancestry, which is what almost every dynasty in this book does the moment it gets a throne.

The argument matters less than the pattern. Whatever their origin, the Langaḥs were a local power that took a local city and ran it as an independent state for three generations, at a moment when there was no empire able to stop them.

And they were not alone. The same century produces the Khokḥars in the north, hill states in the Siwaliks, Baloch chiefs in the south-west, and Afghan clans around Sirhind. **Left without a capital for a hundred years, the Punjab did not collapse. It reorganised into its own components.** That is a fact about this province that almost never gets said, because the chronicles are written by the people whose empire had failed.

WHY MULTAN STAYED INDEPENDENT

- **Delhi could not reach it.** Multan is far from the capital, across country the Sultanate no longer controlled, and the Lodis had a war with Jaunpur on their hands for thirty years.
- **It was rich in its own right.** The city sat on the trade between Sindh, Khurasan and the Punjab, and paid for its own defence.
- **It had local support.** A dynasty rooted in the surrounding tribes is much harder to remove than an appointed governor.
- **And it had walls with a reputation.** Multan had held Pir Muhammad for six months in 1397 and would hold the Arghuns for a long siege in the 1520s.

WHY IT ENDED

- **Internal division.** The last phase of Langaḥ rule is a succession dispute, which is how the Arghuns got in.
- **It was caught by the same wave as everyone else.** The Uzbek conquest of Central Asia pushed the Arghuns into Sindh and Babur into India within the same twenty years.
- **Regional powers cannot survive a continental shift.** Multan was strong enough to defy Delhi and far too small to matter to what was coming.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The City That Keeps Being the Door

Multan has now appeared in five parts of this book, and it is worth putting the appearances in one place, because the repetition is the point.

712. Muhammad bin Qasim cuts the water supply and takes it; the sun temple becomes a taxable asset and, later, a hostage held on the walls to deter Hindu armies.

1006 and after. Mahmud of Ghazni fights over it; a Hindu king blocks his road to it; a converted Shahi prince governs it and then rebels.

1175. Muhammad of Ghor's Indian conquests begin here.

1397. Timur's grandson sits outside it for six months and loses his cavalry to the rain.

1445–1526. It becomes a country.

1520s. It falls to Sindh in the same season Babur takes Lahore. And in Part Fourteen, an Englishman will be murdered there and it will start a war that ends the Sikh empire.

The reason is entirely geographical and has not changed in thirteen hundred years. **Multan sits where the road from Sindh, the road from Khurasan and the road up the Punjab meet.** An army coming from the west that does not want to fight through the northern passes comes here. An army coming from Delhi that wants to control the Indus comes here.

It has been besieged more often than any other city in this book. It has never been strategically irrelevant for a single century of the period these sixteen parts cover.

And it is the only city in the Punjab that has been, at various times, the capital of an independent country — twice. Once under the Ismailis in Part Five, and once here.

Bahlul Lodi Comes Down From Sirhind, 1451

LIKELY

The third time in this book that a Punjab frontier lord took the throne of Delhi — and this one did it by being the man everybody trusted.

WON BY Bahlul Lodi — largely without a battle for the throne itself

WHEN	WHERE
1451; he reigns until 1489.	From Sirhind and the eastern Punjab to Delhi; then thirty years of war eastward against Jaunpur.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Bahlul Lodi, Afghan chief and governor of Sirhind, succeeding the last Sayyid, Alam Shah.	Persian histories of the Lodi period, most of them written under the Mughals afterwards.

Who the Lodis were

Afghans — specifically of the Lodi clan, part of the large Afghan population that had been settling in the Punjab and the Ganges plain for two centuries as soldiers, horse traders and holders of frontier commands. Bahlul’s family had held Sirhind and Dipalpur.

They were not Turks, and this matters more than it sounds. **Every previous dynasty of the Delhi Sultanate had been Turkish and had ruled on the Persianate model of an absolute sultan.** Afghan political culture was tribal and consultative: a chief was first among equals, his nobles were his kinsmen, and he was expected to behave like it.

What happened

1. **The last Sayyid gave up.** Alam Shah, sultan in name, withdrew to Badaun and left Delhi to be argued over — one of the very few voluntary abdications in this book.
2. **Bahlul took the city in 1451.** There was manoeuvring and there were rivals, but the throne was taken by the man with the army and the reputation rather than in a decisive battle.
3. **He then spent nearly thirty years fighting Jaunpur.** The Sharqi sultans of the east were the other serious power in northern India, and the war between them ran, on and off, from the 1450s to the 1470s. Bahlul eventually won it and absorbed Jaunpur.

4. **He held the Punjab through his family.** Sons and kinsmen were given Lahore, Multan's frontier, Sirhind and Dipalpur — the standard Afghan method, and the reason the province was quiet for the first time in a century.
5. **He died in 1489,** leaving a real kingdom to his son Sikandar, who moved the capital to Agra and ruled well.

THE AFGHAN PROBLEM, AND WHY IT DECIDES 1526

Bahlul Lodi ruled by consent among his own people. The accounts describe him refusing to sit on a raised throne in the presence of his nobles, sharing plunder rather than hoarding it, and treating the Afghan chiefs as partners.

That works beautifully, and it works exactly once. It made the Lodi state possible and it made the Lodi state fragile, because the nobility now expected to be consulted, and a consultative aristocracy is very hard to turn back into subjects.

His grandson **Ibrahim Lodi** tried to do exactly that. He insisted on the older Turkish model — the sultan as absolute master, the nobles as servants — and enforced it by humiliating, imprisoning and executing men whose grandfathers had put his own family on the throne.

The result is the whole of War Twelve. The Afghan nobility of the Punjab did not rebel in the ordinary way. They went looking for somebody else to be king.

WHY BAHUL SUCCEEDED

- **He came from the frontier with an army.** Sirhind, on the Punjab road. Fourth time in this book.
- **He was trusted by his own class.** The Afghan chiefs followed him because he behaved like one of them, and that got him more soldiers than a title would have.
- **He fought the war that mattered and finished it.** Thirty years against Jaunpur — slow, unglamorous, and it doubled his kingdom.
- **He held Punjab through kin.** A brother or son in each frontier command is not a modern system, but it worked for two generations.

WHY THE SAYYIDS ENDED

- **There was nothing left to defend.** A capital, a title and an annual tax-raid did not amount to a state worth fighting for.
- **Their legitimacy was borrowed.** Ruling as deputies of a Timurid in Samarkand meant never having a claim of their own.
- **The Punjab had gone.** Jasrat in the north, the Langahs in the south, the Afghans around Sirhind — the province that had produced Khizr Khan no longer belonged to his family.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The King Who Would Not Sit Higher

The stories told about Bahlul Lodi are all about the same thing, and they are told by later historians who found them either admirable or embarrassing depending on their politics.

He would not use a throne in front of his nobles, preferring to sit on a carpet with them. He divided plunder rather than taking the ruler's share. He addressed his chiefs as kinsmen, and when they disagreed with him in council he let them. One account has him, on being enthroned, telling the Afghan nobles that he was their equal and had merely been given a task.

Mughal historians writing a century later found this faintly ridiculous — the point of a king, in their world, was to be unlike everyone else — and modern accounts often repeat it as charming provincial simplicity.

It was neither. It was the constitution of an Afghan chiefdom being operated at the scale of a kingdom, and for one reign it worked better than anything Delhi had managed since Firoz Shah.

The trouble is what it does to the next generation. A system in which power is shared among kinsmen has no way of handling a ruler who wants it back. When Ibrahim Lodi tried to be an absolute sultan over men who had been promised partnership, there was no constitutional mechanism for the disagreement — only rebellion, or invitation.

And so the most consequential political decision in this part was made by a governor of Lahore who decided that if he could not have the king he had been promised, he would find a different king.

Daulat Khan Opens the Door, 1519–1525

CERTAIN

The governor of Lahore wrote to a king in Kabul and asked him to come. It is the clearest single decision in this book, and it is the one that ends it.

WON BY Babur — who did not do what he was invited to do

WHEN Five expeditions between 1519 and 1526; Lahore taken in 1524.	WHERE Bajaur, Bhera, Sialkot, Saidpur, Lahore, Dipalpur, Milwat.
WHO Babur, king of Kabul, invited by Daulat Khan Lodi, governor of Lahore, and by Ibrahim’s uncle Alam Khan.	THE EVIDENCE The Baburnama — Babur’s own diary, written in Chagatai Turkish. One of the great autobiographies of world literature.

Why the invitation was sent

Because Ibrahim Lodi was destroying his own nobility. He had imprisoned and executed Afghan chiefs, humiliated others, and made it clear that the partnership his grandfather had offered was over. **Daulat Khan Lodi, who held Lahore and the Punjab, had every reason to believe he was on the list.**

His plan was the standard one and it has never worked in this book. **Invite a foreign army to remove the king, then govern the Punjab yourself under a grateful and distant patron.** Ambhi tried it with Alexander in Part Two. It has the same result every time.

Babur, for his part, had a claim he genuinely believed in — he was descended from Timur, and Timur had ruled here for six months in 1398 — and, much more to the point, he had lost Samarkand three times and needed a country.

What happened

- 1519: Bajaur and Bhera.** Babur storms Bajaur, and his own diary describes the massacre of its garrison in flat, unembarrassed detail. He crosses the Indus for the first time.
- 1520–21: the Punjab raids.** Bhera, Sialkot, and **Saidpur** — modern Eminabad, near Gujranwala — which is stormed and sacked. This is the event at the centre of the story below.

3. **1524: Lahore.** Now formally invited, Babur comes in force, beats the Lodi army sent against him, and takes Lahore. His men burn the bazaar and much of the city.
4. **Then the arrangement collapses.** Daulat Khan had expected to be handed the Punjab. Babur gave him Jalandhar and Sultanpur and kept Lahore and Dipalpur for himself.
5. **Daulat Khan turned on him,** drove out the garrisons, and fought — old, by now, and out of options. He was besieged at Milwat, surrendered in 1526, and died on the road into custody.
6. **And Babur kept coming.** By the winter of 1525 he was across the Indus for the fifth time, with the Punjab behind him and Delhi in front.

THE PATTERN, STATED ONCE AND FOR ALL

This book has now watched it happen enough times to state it as a law rather than an observation.

Ambhi invites Alexander (Part Two) to settle a score with Porus, and loses his independence. **Jayapala's grandson governs for Mahmud (Part Five)** and ends his life in a fortress. **Daulat Khan invites Babur (here)** to remove Ibrahim Lodi, and dies a prisoner on a road while a foreign dynasty takes the country for three hundred and thirty-one years.

In every case the logic was locally sound. The invited power was genuinely stronger than the enemy at hand. The invitation genuinely did remove the enemy.

And in every case the man who opened the door was the second person through it, and got nothing.

The reason is not that these men were fools. It is arithmetic. A power strong enough to be worth inviting is strong enough to have its own plans, and the Punjab is not a prize that anybody who reaches it agrees to hand back.

WHY BABUR GOT IN

- **He was invited.** The single most important fact. He entered the Punjab with local guides, local supplies and a faction of the Lodi nobility on his side.
- **He came five times.** Not one invasion but a decade of raids, each one learning the country, the roads and the rivers.
- **He had gunpowder.** Field artillery and matchlocks, and — crucially — Ottoman-trained men who knew how to use them together with cavalry.
- **And he had nothing to go back to.** Kabul was small and Samarkand was lost. This was not an adventure; it was the only option he had.

WHY DAULAT KHAN LOST EVERYTHING

- **He mistook a king for a mercenary.** Babur was not a hired sword; he was a dynast with a Timurid claim to the very ground he was standing on.
- **He had no way to enforce the bargain.** Once the foreign army was inside the Punjab, the terms were whatever it said they were.
- **He turned too late.** Fighting Babur in 1525, after handing him Lahore in 1524, was the worst possible order in which to do those two things.
- **And his own side was split.** Some Punjabi Afghans went with Babur, some with Ibrahim, some with Daulat Khan. The oldest failure in this book, at the worst possible moment.

The Gap in the Diary

Babur kept a diary, and it is astonishing. The *Baburnama* is a real autobiography — self-critical, observant, funny, interested in fruit and gardens and birds and the taste of melons, honest about defeats and about being frightened. There is nothing else like it from the medieval world, and it is our main source for everything in this war.

It is also the account of a conqueror describing his own conquest, and he does not flinch from it. His account of Bajaur in 1519 records the storming and the killing of the garrison in the same steady voice he uses for the local flowers.

And it has holes. **The manuscript tradition of the *Baburnama* has gaps, and one of them falls across the early 1520s** — the years of the Punjab raids, of Saidpur, of the taking of Lahore.

So the most detailed first-person account of an invasion of India ever written thins out at exactly the point where it crosses the country this book is about.

That is almost certainly an accident of transmission. Manuscripts lose pages; this one lost several stretches. It is not a cover-up and this part is not going to suggest it was.

But the shape of the accident is worth noticing, because it is the shape of the whole book. Seven parts, three thousand years, and the record of every war in the Punjab has come to us through somebody else's manuscript, somebody else's language, somebody else's purpose — Greek, Chinese, Persian, Arabic, Sanskrit from another province — with the Punjabi part of the story either unwritten or lost.

Which is what makes the last page of this part what it is. **Because somebody else was at Saidpur in 1520, and he did write it down.**

Panipat, 21 April 1526

CERTAIN

Twelve thousand men beat a hundred thousand in about half a day, using carts, ditches and guns — and three hundred and thirty-one years of Mughal India began.

WON BY Babur — by engineering, not by weight

WHEN	WHERE
21 April 1526, and over by early afternoon.	Panipat, on the Punjab road north of Delhi — twenty miles from Tarain.
WHO	THE NUMBERS CLAIMED
Babur against Ibrahim Lodi, Sultan of Delhi.	Babur says he had about 12,000 and that Ibrahim had 100,000 and 1,000 elephants. Both are his figures.

What Babur built

He had a week before the battle and he spent it constructing a position, which is the entire explanation of what followed.

1. He anchored his right on the town of Panipat itself, so that flank could not be turned.
2. He dug a ditch on his left and filled the front of it with felled trees and branches — an obstacle that cavalry cannot cross at speed.
3. Across the centre he chained together carts — the *araba*, several hundred of them, roped with twisted hide, with gaps left between them.
4. Behind the gaps he put matchlockmen and field guns, under two Ottoman-trained specialists, Ustad Ali Quli and Mustafa Rumi. This is the crucial import. Guns had existed in India before; what Babur brought was the Ottoman method of using carts, firearms and cavalry as one system.
5. And he held back flanking parties — the *tulughma* — to swing wide around both wings and hit the enemy from behind once he was committed.

What happened

1. **Ibrahim attacked into the prepared front.** He had the numbers and he used them the way numbers had always been used.
2. **His army could not deploy.** The frontage between the town and the ditch was narrow, and an enormous army pushing into a narrow space compresses. Men in the rear could not get forward; men in the front could not withdraw.
3. **The guns and matchlocks fired into a stationary mass.** The casualties mattered less than the noise and the horses.
4. **The flanking parties closed behind him.** The tulughma detachments came around both wings and shot into the rear of an army that was already jammed.
5. **It was over by midday.** Babur says the fighting began in the morning and was finished around noon.
6. **Ibrahim Lodi was killed in the field** — the only Sultan of Delhi in three hundred and twenty years to die in a battle — and his body was found among the dead.

INTERROGATING THE NUMBERS, AND GIVING CREDIT CORRECTLY

Babur's figures are his own and are the classic shape of a victory account: very few of us, very many of them. Twelve thousand is probably close to the force he brought from Kabul, but by 1526 he had been in the Punjab for two years and had Afghan defectors with him, so his actual strength was larger. Ibrahim's hundred thousand and thousand elephants are not credible.

What decided it was not the ratio and it was not, mainly, the guns. Sixteenth-century field artillery was slow, inaccurate and fired a handful of times in a battle. It contributed, and the noise terrified elephants and horses that had never heard it.

The battle was won by the **position**. A narrow frontage that prevented a larger army from deploying; a fortified centre it had to attack head-on; and mobile detachments to envelop it once it was stuck. **Babur did to Ibrahim Lodi what Muhammad of Ghor did to Prithviraj at Tarain in Part Six — he made sure the battle his enemy was equipped to fight never happened.**

WHY BABUR WON

- **He chose and prepared the ground.** A week of digging beats a week of marching.
- **He turned the enemy's size into a liability.** A hundred thousand men who cannot deploy are worse than twenty thousand who can.
- **He integrated three arms.** Guns, matchlocks and cavalry working as one system, which nobody in India had.
- **And half the enemy did not want to be there.** The Afghan nobility had been alienated for a decade; contingents held back, and some had already changed sides.

WHY IBRAHIM LODI LOST

- **He attacked a fortified position frontally.** With no reconnaissance worth the name and no attempt to go round.
- **He had destroyed his own command.** Executing and humiliating the chiefs whose men he needed is why his army fought like a crowd.
- **He fought the last war.** Weight, elephants and a frontal advance — a system that had not won a major battle in this book since before Tarain.
- **And he had given Babur the Punjab already.** Two years of Babur holding Lahore and Dipalpur meant the invader arrived at Panipat rested, supplied and knowing the ground.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — AND THE REASON THIS PART EXISTS

The First Punjabi Voice in This Book

Six parts of this book have ended with the same complaint, and by now you should be tired of reading it. **Nobody in Punjab wrote anything down.**

Every war so far has reached us through somebody else's hand. Greeks writing centuries later about Alexander. A Chinese pilgrim describing the ruins of Taxila. Persian court historians in Delhi counting the dead of Waihind and Tarain. A Kashmiri poet six hundred years after Mihirakula. Inscriptions carved by winners in provinces a thousand kilometres away. In seven parts and three thousand years, not one surviving account of a war in the Punjab, written in the Punjab, by somebody it happened to.

That ends here.

Around 1520, Babur's army stormed **Saidpur** — Eminabad, near Gujranwala. And a man from a village on the Ravi, who had spent his life travelling and teaching and was then somewhere near fifty years old, saw what happened there and wrote about it.

Guru Nanak's four hymns on Babur's invasion — the *Babarvani* — are preserved in the Guru Granth Sahib. They are in Punjabi. They are contemporary. And they are not a chronicle at all: they are an accusation.

He describes the invasion as a wedding party of sin, come from Kabul demanding wealth as its dowry. He describes the killing, the women dragged from their homes, the destruction of a town that had done nothing. He says he speaks only what he is given to speak.

And then he does something that no court historian in this entire book has ever done, in any language. **He turns and asks God why it was allowed.** Having described the slaughter, he says the people cried out in agony — and asks whether God felt no compassion, whether the Creator felt no pain at what was done.

Read what that is, precisely. It is not a lament for a defeated king; there is no king in it. It is not a call to arms. **It is an eyewitness moral judgement on a conqueror, written in the language of the country he was conquering, by a man who had no army, no throne and no patron, and it was preserved by the community he founded and is still recited daily.**

Babur, who was there, has a gap in his diary across those years. The Persian chroniclers record the campaign as a stage in a successful conquest. **The only voice that records what Saidpur was actually like belongs to a Punjabi, in Punjabi, who was not interested in who won.**

Panipat begins the Mughal empire, and Part Eight will be full of emperors. But the thing that changes permanently in 1526 is not on the battlefield twenty miles from Tarain.

It is that from this point on, the Punjab has its own record of what is being done to it — and for the rest of this book, it never falls silent again.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

c. 1327–1329	Tarmashirin's Mongols come down through Lahore and Multan towards Delhi and are bought off with treasure. The last Mongol invasion of India. Won by the Mongols.
1327–1351	Muhammad bin Tughluq's reign. The capital moved to Daulatabad and back; a token currency forged into ruin; the Khurasan and Qarachil disasters; the Khokhars rise. Won by nobody.
1362–1367	Firoz Shah in Sindh. The army loses its horses, gets lost in the Rann of Kutch, and is out of contact for six months. The second attempt succeeds. Meanwhile he digs the largest canal network in medieval India across the Punjab.
1397–1398	Multan besieged for six months by Timur's grandson Pir Muhammad, whose cavalry is destroyed by the monsoon. Won by the Timurids.
24 Sept 1398	Timur crosses the Indus. The Jhelum country, the Khokhars under Shaikha, Talamba, Bhatnair, Sirsa, Kaithal, Panipat — and about a hundred thousand prisoners killed in camp before the battle.
17 Dec 1398	The Battle of Delhi. A hundred and twenty armoured elephants broken by burning camels and caltrops. The city surrenders and is destroyed anyway. Won by Timur.
Jan–Mar 1399	The road back through Meerut, Hardwar, the Siwaliks and Jammu — and Khizr Khan is left in charge of Multan, Lahore and Dipalpur.
1414	Khizr Khan takes Delhi and founds the Sayyid dynasty — ruling without ever calling himself sultan. Won by the Punjab frontier command, second time.
1420–1442	Jasrat Khokhar returns from captivity, beats Jammu, takes Sialkot and Lahore, and fights Delhi to a standstill for twenty years. Won by Jasrat — by never being caught.
c. 1445–1526	The Langahs make Multan an independent sultanate for eighty years, defying the Lodis throughout. Won by Multan — until Sindh takes it.
1451	Bahlul Lodi comes down from Sirhind and takes Delhi , then spends thirty years absorbing Jaunpur. Won by the Punjab frontier command, third time.
1519–1521	Babur's first raids. Bajaur, Bhera, Sialkot — and the sack of Saidpur , which Guru Nanak witnesses and writes about.
1524	Daulat Khan Lodi invites Babur in and Lahore falls. The bargain collapses at once; Daulat Khan turns on him, is besieged at Milwat, and dies in custody. Won by Babur.
21 April 1526	The First Battle of Panipat. Chained carts, a ditch, matchlocks, field guns and flanking columns. Ibrahim Lodi is killed — the only Delhi sultan to die on a battlefield. Won by Babur. Part Eight begins here.

Five patterns to carry into Part Eight

1. **The Punjab frontier command takes Delhi — now four times.** Ghazi Malik from Dipalpur in 1320, Khizr Khan from Multan and Lahore in 1414, Bahlul Lodi from Sirhind in 1451, and Babur by way of Lahore in 1526. **It is not coincidence and it is not martial spirit. It is that the empire keeps its army where the enemy is, and the enemy is always west of Delhi.** Watch for it again with Sher Shah Suri in Part Eight.
2. **Somebody always opens the door, and never profits by it.** Ambhi and Alexander in Part Two; Sukhpal and Mahmud in Part Five; Daulat Khan and Babur here. The invitation always works and the man who sends it always ends badly, because a power worth inviting is a power with its own plans.
3. **When the empire disappears, Punjab does not.** The century after Timur has no central authority at all, and the province reorganises into Khokhar, Langah, Afghan and hill-state power rather than collapsing. **The chroniclers call this anarchy because they worked for kings.** Remember that when Part Eleven describes the eighteenth century in the same words.
4. **Prepared ground beats numbers, every single time.** Ghor's four divisions and evening reserve at Tarain; Timur's trench, caltrops and burning camels at Delhi; Babur's carts, ditch and flanking columns at Panipat. Three of the four most decisive battles in the last two parts were won by the smaller army, and in every case it had spent days building something before the enemy arrived.
5. **And the silence ends.** Six parts of this book asked why nobody in Punjab wrote down what happened to them. From 1520 there is an answer, in Punjabi, in verse, in a scripture that is still recited. **Part Eight has both the Mughal chronicles and the Sikh Gurus writing at the same time about the same country — and for the first time, this book can quote both sides.**

COMING NEXT — PART EIGHT

Mughals, Suris and the Gurus, 1526–1605. Babur's victory nearly dies with him: Humayun loses India to **Sher Shah Suri**, an Afghan from Bihar who builds the best-run state medieval India ever had and rebuilds the Grand Trunk Road across the Punjab. Humayun comes back from Persian exile through Lahore in 1555. Then **the Second Battle of Panipat in 1556**, where a thirteen-year-old Akbar's regent beats Hemu on the same ground — the third decisive battle within twenty miles of Tarain. And running underneath all of it, in the villages between the Ravi and the Beas, the succession of the Sikh Gurus, the founding of Amritsar, and the compilation of a scripture that will make Punjab, for the first time in this book, a place with its own written voice.

Words Used in This Part

Tughluq

The dynasty founded by Ghazi Malik in 1320 and effectively ended by Timur in 1398. Also spelled Tughlaq.

Token currency

Coins whose value comes from the state's declaration rather than their metal. Muhammad bin Tughluq issued brass and copper tokens at silver value; the country forged them.

Qarachil

The Himalayan expedition of the late 1330s, destroyed by terrain and weather. One of several catastrophic projects of that reign.

Jizya

A tax levied on non-Muslim subjects. Firoz Shah Tughluq extended it to groups previously exempt.

Futuhāt-i Firoz Shahi

Firoz Shah's own account of his reign — part memoir, part public inscription. Unusual: a sultan describing his own policies in the first person.

Zafarnama

Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi's official history of Timur, completed in the 1420s. Detailed, well-informed and entirely committed to its subject.

Malfuzat-i Timuri

Also *Tuzuk-i Timuri*. A Persian text presented as Timur's own memoirs, produced in the seventeenth century. Its authenticity is doubted by many scholars; it is the source of the most quoted passages on India.

Caltrop

A four-spiked iron object that always lands with a point upward. Scattered by Timur in front of the elephant charge at Delhi.

Sayyid dynasty

The dynasty founded by Khizr Khan, ruling Delhi 1414–1451. Its first ruler never took the title of sultan.

Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi

Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi's chronicle, written at the Sayyid court. The best contemporary source for the fifteenth-century Punjab, and thoroughly hostile to Jasrat.

Khokhars

The people of the Salt Range and Jhelum country. In this book since 1008; here, under Jasrat, they run the northern Punjab for twenty years.

Langah

The dynasty that ruled Multan as an independent sultanate from about 1445 to the 1520s. Their origins are disputed.

Arghun

A dynasty of Central Asian origin pushed south into Sindh by the Uzbek conquests, who took Multan in the 1520s.

Lodi

The Afghan dynasty ruling Delhi 1451–1526. Bahlul, Sikandar and Ibrahim. The last dynasty of the Delhi Sultanate.

Araba

A cart. At Panipat, several hundred were chained together with twisted hide to form Babur's fortified centre, with gaps for matchlockmen.

Tulughma

The flanking manoeuvre in which detachments swing wide around both wings of an engaged enemy and attack its rear. The other half of how Panipat was won.

Matchlock

An early firearm fired by touching a burning cord to the powder. Slow and inaccurate, and terrifying to horses and elephants that had never heard one.

Baburnama

Babur's autobiography, written in Chagatai Turkish. Candid, observant and self-critical — and with gaps in the manuscript tradition, including across the early 1520s.

Babarvani

The four hymns of Guru Nanak on Babur's invasion, preserved in the Guru Granth Sahib. The first surviving Punjabi account of a war in the Punjab.

Sources used for this part

- Ziauddin Barani, *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi*, for Muhammad bin Tughluq and the token currency
- Ibn Battuta, *Rihla* — he served as a judge in Delhi for seven years and later met Tarmashirin in Central Asia
- Shams-i Siraj Afif, *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi*, and Firoz Shah's own *Futuh-i Firoz Shahi*, for the canals, the Sindh campaigns and the moving of the Ashokan pillars
- Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi, *Zafarnama*, and the *Malfuzat-i Timuri*, for Timur's campaign — both from the Timurid side, and the second of disputed authorship
- Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi, *Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi*, for Khizr Khan, Mubarak Shah and Jasrat Khokhar
- Persian histories of the Lodi period, including those compiled under the Mughals
- Babur, *Baburnama*, in Beveridge's and Thackston's translations
- The *Babarvani* hymns of Guru Nanak in the Guru Granth Sahib (Raags Asa and Tilang)
- Elliot and Dowson, *The History of India as Told by Its Own Historians*, for the translated Persian material
- Standard modern accounts of the Tughluq collapse, Timur's invasion, the Sayyid and Lodi periods, and the founding of the Mughal empire

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: how far Tarmashirin actually got in 1327; whether the *Malfuzat-i Timuri* preserves anything genuinely Timur's; every casualty figure and army size in the part, without exception; the origins of the Langah dynasty; the precise sequence and dating of Babur's Punjab raids; and how much of Ibrahim Lodi's army at Panipat had already decided not to fight.

One caution deserves particular weight. The most-quoted passages of Timur's Indian campaign — including the order to kill the prisoners and the explanation given for it — come from a text presented as his memoirs whose authenticity is disputed. This part has said so on the page rather than in a footnote. **The events are corroborated by the official Timurid history; the self-justifications should be read as a court's account of itself.**

And a note on the last war. **Guru Nanak's hymns are quoted here in paraphrase rather than as a translated text,** because they are scripture in daily liturgical use and translations differ meaningfully; anyone who wants the words should read them in the original or in a translation they trust. The historical claim being made in this part is narrow and, so far as this book can tell, solid: that they are contemporary with Babur's invasion, that they respond to it directly, and that they are the earliest surviving account of a war in the Punjab written in the Punjab by somebody who was there.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART EIGHT OF SIXTEEN

Mughals, Suris and the Gurus

Eighty years in which India is conquered, lost, and conquered again — Lahore becomes the capital of an empire for thirteen years — and in the villages between the Ravi and the Beas, Punjab acquires the one thing it has never had in this book: an institution of its own.

1526 — 1605

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Part Where Punjab Stops Only Being Fought Over

Two things happen in these eighty years that have never happened before in this book, and they happen at the same time and in the same province.

The first is that Punjab becomes the centre of an empire rather than its shield or its corridor.

For thirteen years, from 1585 to 1598, **Lahore is the capital of India**. Not a provincial seat, not a frontier command, not a governor's town — the actual working capital of the largest and richest state on earth, with the emperor in it, the treasury in it, and the armies that took Kashmir, Sindh and Kandahar setting out from it. This is the high-water mark for the Punjab in the whole of these sixteen parts, and it lasts thirteen years.

The second thing is quieter and matters more.

In villages along the Ravi and the Beas — Kartarpur, Khadur, Goindwal, and then a new town built round a tank that its founder called the Pool of Nectar — **a line of teachers is building something**. Not an army and not a kingdom: a community with a common kitchen, a script of its own, its own towns, and by 1604 its own book. **Part Seven ended with the first Punjabi voice in this entire history. Part Eight is where that voice acquires an institution to keep it.**

Four things to hold on to

- **The Mughal empire nearly does not happen.** Babur's son loses India completely and spends fifteen years in exile. The man who takes it from him builds the best-run state medieval India ever had, in five years, and then dies in an accident. Almost nothing in this part was inevitable.
- **Punjab is the road back.** Humayun returns to India through Lahore and wins the two battles that restore his dynasty at Machhiwara and Sirhind — both in the Punjab. Akbar is crowned in a field in Gurdaspur district. **The Mughal empire is re-founded on Punjabi soil.**
- **The Salt Range still cannot be subdued.** Sher Shah Suri spent five years and an enormous fortress trying, and the fortress is what survives.
- **And this part has, for the first time, two kinds of source at once.** Persian court chronicles written for emperors — and a scripture compiled in Punjabi in a Punjabi town, which is still recited. **For the first time in this book, we can hear both.**

THE HONESTY LABELS, AGAIN

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a writer who was present, a document made at the time, a building still standing. **LIKELY** means good sources writing later, generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition, often written down considerably afterwards.

Part Eight has a source problem that is the opposite of the earlier parts' problem. **We have almost too much, and most of it is official.** Abul Fazl's *Akbarnama* is a magnificent, enormous, meticulous work written by Akbar's closest friend to establish Akbar's greatness. Badauni, writing secretly at the same court, disliked almost everything about it. **Where those two disagree, this part will tell you, because the disagreement is usually the interesting part.**

There is also a category this book has not needed before: **religious tradition.** The accounts of the Gurus in this part come partly from later Sikh sources, and where a story is devotional tradition rather than documented history, it is labelled and treated as such — with respect, and without pretending.

The Brothers’ War — Kamran Takes the Punjab, 1530–1540

LIKELY

Babur had barely been buried before his second son took the Punjab off his first, and that single act is why the Mughal empire collapsed ten years later.

WON BY

Kamran Mirza — without a battle, and it cost his family India

WHEN 1530, immediately on Babur’s death; the arrangement lasts until 1540.	WHERE Lahore and the whole Punjab, added to Kabul and Kandahar.
WHO Kamran Mirza against his elder brother Humayun, the new emperor.	THE EVIDENCE The <i>Humayun-nama</i> of Gulbadan Begum — Babur’s daughter, sister to both men — and the Persian chronicles.

What happened

1. **Babur died in December 1530**, four and a half years after Panipat, leaving an empire that was really a conquest — a line of garrisons from Kabul to Bihar with almost no administration underneath it.
2. **Humayun succeeded him at Agra**. He was twenty-two.
3. **Kamran, who held Kabul and Kandahar, immediately marched on Lahore and took it**, along with the rest of the Punjab. He did not ask.
4. **And Humayun let him keep it**. Rather than fight his brother in the first months of a shaky reign, he confirmed the seizure.
5. **For the next ten years the Punjab was not part of the Mughal empire in any meaningful sense**. It was Kamran’s, governed from Lahore, with its own revenue and its own army, which was never available to the emperor.

WHY THIS DECISION IS THE HINGE OF THE WHOLE PART

Look at what Humayun gave away, in the terms this book has been using for eight parts.

He gave away the recruiting ground. Punjab is where the empire's cavalry came from and where the frontier troops were.

He gave away the road. Every reinforcement from Kabul to India comes through Lahore. With the Punjab in Kamran's hands, Humayun's line of retreat and resupply belonged to somebody with his own interests.

He gave away the frontier. The pattern established in Part Six and repeated four times in Part Seven — *whoever commands the Punjab frontier eventually rules Delhi* — was handed to a rival with a claim to the throne.

And when the crisis came in 1539 and 1540, all three consequences arrived at once. **Kamran had an army of Punjabi and Afghan troops at Lahore and did not use it to save his brother's empire.** He offered to help only on terms Humayun could not accept, and when Sher Shah came west, he went to Kabul and took the army with him.

WHY KAMRAN GOT AWAY WITH IT

- **He moved first.** Within weeks of the death, before the succession had settled.
- **He already held the far side.** Kabul and Kandahar behind him, Lahore in front — the position that has decided every contest in this book since Part Five.
- **Humayun could not afford a civil war.** Afghan resistance in the east, Gujarat in the south, and a treasury that was mostly plunder.
- **And Timurid practice was on his side.** The tradition Babur came from divided territory among sons rather than concentrating it. Kamran was doing what his family had always done.

WHY IT DESTROYED THEM BOTH

- **An empire cut in half at the waist.** India without the Punjab has no depth and no way home.
- **Two Timurid courts, one throne.** Every Afghan noble in northern India now had somewhere else to go.
- **Humayun set the precedent by conceding.** Having yielded once, he spent his reign negotiating with brothers instead of commanding them.
- **And Kamran never became emperor either.** He was blinded by Humayun's officers in 1553 and sent to Mecca, where he died. Nobody won this.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Woman Who Wrote It Down

Most of what we know about the inside of this family — the arguments, the arrangements, who said what to whom in which tent — comes from a book written by **Gulbadan Begum**, and she is one of the most remarkable authors in this entire history.

She was Babur's daughter, born about 1523, sister to Humayun and Kamran and Askari and Hindal. She was eight when her father died. She lived through the loss of India, the exile, the return, and Akbar's reign, and in her sixties her nephew — the emperor Akbar — asked the older members of the household to write down what they remembered of Humayun's time, so that Abul Fazl could use it.

She wrote the ***Humayun-nama***. It survives incomplete, in a single damaged manuscript, and it is unlike anything else from the period.

It is not a chronicle of battles. She writes about a family. She records the marriages and the quarrels, the moving of households, who was angry with whom and why, what the women of the court thought about decisions the histories present as strategy. **She writes about her brothers as brothers** — including Kamran, whose betrayals she does not excuse and does not pretend not to grieve over.

And she writes in plain, direct Persian, without the enormous rhetorical apparatus that Abul Fazl brings to everything. When Humayun is being foolish, she says so.

In eight parts and three thousand years, this is the first account of any events in this book written by a woman. There is no earlier one and there will not be many later. She was inside the room for the decisions that lost and regained India, she was asked to remember, and she did it honestly.

The official history of the reign runs to three enormous volumes and is one of the great works of Persian prose. **The truest thing we have about the same events is a partial manuscript by the emperor's aunt.**

Lahore, 1540 — The Emperor With Nowhere Left to Go

LIKELY

Two Mughal princes and their whole court sat in Lahore arguing, while the man who had taken their empire sent them a message from Sirhind telling them to leave.

WON BY Sher Shah Suri — who did not have to fight for the Punjab at all

WHEN	WHERE
Late 1540, after the defeats at Chausa (1539) and Kannauj (1540).	Lahore, and then the road out of it.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Humayun and his brothers, against Sher Shah Suri, who did not need to be present.	Gulbadan Begum, Jauhar the water-carrier's memoir, and the Persian histories.

How it got to this

1. **Sher Khan Sur** — an Afghan from Bihar, a former minor jagirdar who had risen by administration and patience — built a power base in the east while Humayun was distracted in Gujarat.
2. **Chausa, June 1539.** Humayun's army was destroyed on the Ganges. The emperor escaped by swimming the river; the tradition says he was kept afloat by a water-carrier named Nizam, whom he later rewarded in an extravagant and much-embroidered way.
3. **Kannauj, May 1540.** The second defeat, and this one was final. Sher Shah took Agra and Delhi.
4. **Humayun fell back to Lahore**, where Kamran was — with an army.
5. **And nothing was agreed.** The brothers argued for weeks. Kamran would not commit his troops to a war he thought was lost, or would commit them only if the terms made him something close to king.
6. **Then Sher Shah reached Sirhind** — a hundred and fifty miles away — and sent word. The message reported in the sources is one of the coldest sentences in this book: **that he had left them Kabul, and they should go there.**
7. **They went.** Kamran to Kabul with his army. Humayun south into Sindh, and then, eventually, into Persia — fifteen years of exile.

WHAT SHER SHAH'S MESSAGE ACTUALLY SAYS

Read it as a strategic document rather than an insult, because that is what it is.

He is telling them exactly where the border is. Kabul is theirs; India is not. He is not offering to negotiate and he is not threatening to pursue them beyond a certain line. He is drawing the frontier and inviting them to accept it.

And he is right about the geography, in the way everyone in this book who wins is right about the geography. **The line he is drawing runs through the Punjab** — and the first thing he does after they leave is start building the works that will hold it. That is the next two wars.

Notice also what is *not* in the message: any acknowledgement that these men had an army at Lahore, a Timurid claim, and the whole of the Punjab under their control. **He is treating an emperor with a province and a garrison as somebody to be moved along.** On the evidence, he had judged them correctly.

WHY SHER SHAH WON WITHOUT FIGHTING HERE

- **He had already won twice.** Chausa and Kannauj had destroyed the Mughal field army; what was at Lahore was a court, not a force.
- **He knew the brothers would not combine.** Ten years of visible division told him everything he needed.
- **He moved fast and stopped in the right place.** Sirhind is close enough to be a threat and far enough to leave them a road out. A cornered enemy fights.
- **And he wanted the country, not the men.** Chasing Humayun into Sindh would have cost a season he needed for governing.

WHY THE MUGHALS LOST THE PUNJAB

- **The army at Lahore had a different owner.** Ten years of Kamran holding the province meant those troops were his, not the empire's.
- **Nobody could give an order.** Two Timurid princes of near-equal standing, in one city, in a crisis, with no mechanism to decide anything.
- **Humayun had no local base.** He had been emperor for ten years and had never governed the Punjab.
- **And the Afghans of the Punjab preferred Sher Shah.** He was one of them; the Mughals were Turks from Kabul. That preference is worth more than a battle.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Fifteen Years

Follow Humayun out of Lahore, because what happens next is the most extraordinary reversal in this book and almost nobody outside India has heard of it.

He goes into Sindh and spends two and a half years trying to raise support. It fails. His brothers hunt him. In 1542, in the desert fort of **Umarkot**, while he is a fugitive with a few hundred men, his wife gives birth to a son. They name him **Akbar**. Within months the child has to be left behind in Kandahar, in the hands of an uncle who is technically an enemy.

Humayun crosses into Persia with about forty companions. The Shah receives him — and the price of hospitality includes political and religious concessions that the Persian and Mughal sources describe very differently, and that Humayun spent the rest of his life managing.

With Persian troops he takes Kandahar, then Kabul, then loses Kabul, then takes it again. He fights his brothers for a decade. Kamran changes sides so many times that even Gulbadan, who loved him, runs out of ways to explain it; in 1553 he is finally blinded and sent away.

And then, in 1555 — **fifteen years after being told to go to Kabul** — Humayun comes back down through the passes into the Punjab, wins two battles in the doabs, and takes Delhi.

Six months after that he falls down the stone stairs of his library in Delhi and dies.

The Victorian historian Stanley Lane-Poole wrote the line that has stuck to him ever since: **that he tumbled through life, and he tumbled out of it.** It is unfair and it is also hard to improve on.

But keep the fifteen years in view, because the man in this story is not a joke. **He lost an empire at thirty-two and took it back at forty-seven, from exile, with borrowed troops, having been betrayed by three brothers.** Almost nobody in this book who loses on that scale ever comes back at all.

Rohtas — The Fort Built to Hold Down the Salt Range

CERTAIN

The best administrator in medieval India spent five years and a fortune building a fortress against the people of the Jhelum country, and it did not work.

WON BY

The Gakkhars — who lost every battle and were still there afterwards

WHEN

Fort begun about **1541**, finished about **1548**; the campaigns run through **1543–1545**.

WHERE

Rohtas, on the Kahan river near Jhelum, in the **Salt Range**.

WHO

Sher Shah Suri against the **Gakkhars** under **Sarang Khan**.

THE EVIDENCE

Persian histories of the Sur period — and the fortress, which is still standing and is enormous.

Why he built it

Two reasons, and he stated both.

The first was Humayun. Sher Shah had told the Mughals to go to Kabul, and he expected them to try to come back. Everything comes back the same way: down the passes, across the Indus, through the Salt Range, onto the plain. A fortress there is a cork in the bottle.

The second was the Gakkhars. The people of the Salt Range and the Jhelum country had refused to submit, and they were in contact with the Mughals — which made them not merely disobedient but a standing invitation.

So he built a fort. Not a garrison post: **a circuit of walls something like four kilometres around, up to twelve or more metres thick in places, with a dozen gates, set on a ridge above a river gorge.** It is one of the largest fortifications of its century anywhere in the world, and it was built to hold down a district.

GAKKHARS, KHOKHARS, AND A GENUINE CONFUSION

You have been reading about the people of the Salt Range for four parts — the bare-headed charge at Waihind in 1008, the assassination on the Jhelum in 1206, Jasrat holding the northern Punjab for twenty years in the 1420s and 1430s. The Persian sources call them **Khokhar** in some places and **Gakkhar** in others, and the Sur-period sources for this war generally say Gakkhar.

Whether these are the same people is disputed and has been for a long time. Some historians treat the names as variants for one group; others hold that they are two distinct communities of the same region whom outside chroniclers, writing in Persian from Delhi, repeatedly confused.

This book cannot settle it, and it is worth saying why the confusion exists at all. **The people involved left no written record of their own.** Everything we have is a name written down by an enemy in a foreign language, and enemies are careless about the difference between one hill clan and another.

WHY THE GAKKHARS COULD NOT BE BROKEN

- **Same reasons as Jasrat in Part Seven.** No capital to take, no army to destroy, ground that punishes a large force, and no need to win — only to still be there.
- **They had an outside patron.** Contact with Humayun in Kabul meant that submitting to Sher Shah was not their only option.
- **The Salt Range is the best defensive country in the Punjab.** Part Five said this at Nandana in 1014 and it has not changed.
- **And Sher Shah ran out of time.** He died in 1545, four years into the problem.

WHAT THE FORT COULD AND COULD NOT DO

- **It could hold the road.** As a block on the route from the Indus to the plain it was well sited and well built.
- **It could not occupy a people.** A fortress controls the ground it can see. The Gakkhars lived in the country it could not.
- **It cost more than the problem.** Five years and a legendary amount of money to garrison a district that had never produced much revenue.
- **And it was surrendered without a fight.** Which is the story below.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

A Gold Coin For Every Stone

There is a story about the building of Rohtas that is repeated in the Persian histories and by everyone who has written about the fort since, and it is worth telling carefully because it says more than it means to.

The work was given to an officer named **Todar Mal Khatri** — a Punjabi administrator, and very probably the same man who would later build Akbar's revenue system, which would make him one of the most consequential officials in Indian history.

He could not get labour. **The local people would not work on it.** They understood perfectly well what the fort was for: it was being built on their land, out of their stone, to hold them down. So they stayed away.

Todar Mal raised the rate. They still would not come. He raised it again. The story ends with the rate reaching **a gold coin for every stone laid** — an absurd figure, quoted to convey scale rather than accountancy — before the work could go forward, and with Sher Shah, on being told what it was costing, telling him to pay it.

Now the part the story does not intend. **It is a record of a boycott.** The people of the Salt Range could not beat Sher Shah's army — nobody in India could, in 1541 — so they used the only leverage they had, which was their labour, and they made him pay a price that became proverbial.

And there is a final detail that finishes it. Rohtas was garrisoned by the Suris and held the road exactly as designed. When Humayun came back down through the passes in 1555, **the commander at Rohtas surrendered it without a fight**, and the Gakkhars, who had never submitted, came out for the returning Mughals.

The fort is still there, above the Kahan river, largely intact, a UNESCO World Heritage site. **It is the biggest monument any ruler in this book ever built to the problem of governing the Punjab, and it never fired a shot in anger.**

The Road, the Rupee and the Register, 1540–1545

CERTAIN

The only war in this book fought against distance — and it was won so thoroughly that you are still using the results.

WON BY Sher Shah Suri — in five years, and then he was killed by his own gunpowder

WHEN	WHERE
1540–1545. Five years, from taking Delhi to his death at Kalinjar.	From Bengal to the Indus — and the central section runs the length of the Punjab.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Sher Shah, against the ordinary condition of a fifteenth-century Indian state.	Persian histories, surviving coins, surviving sarais, and the road.

What he did

- The road.** He rebuilt and extended the great trunk route — the *Sadak-e-Azam* — from Bengal across the Ganges plain and the Punjab to the Indus. Trees along both sides for shade. Wells at intervals. **And sarais — walled rest-houses — spaced roughly a day’s travel apart, in numbers the sources put in the many hundreds,** each with lodging, water, a mosque, and food provided free to travellers.
- The post.** The sarais doubled as relay stations for a horse-borne courier service, so that a message could travel the length of the empire at the speed of a fresh horse rather than a tired one.
- The coinage.** He issued a standardised silver coin of about 178 grains and called it the *rupiya*, together with a copper *dam* and a gold piece, in fixed relation to each other. **That coin is the direct ancestor of the rupee** — the name and the standard both survive the Mughals, the East India Company and the Raj, and are in your pocket now if you are reading this in South Asia.
- The register.** Land was measured. The share due was fixed as a proportion of the actual crop rather than guessed at. **Every cultivator was given a written statement of what he held and what he owed** — a *patta* — and gave a written undertaking in return. Rates were adjusted for the quality of the soil.
- And the officials were watched.** Transfers were routine so that nobody built a local empire; the army was paid from the centre and the men were described in the muster rolls so that commanders could not invent soldiers.

WHY A ROAD COUNTS AS A WAR IN THIS BOOK

Because of what this whole history has been about.

Distance is the enemy that beat everybody in the previous seven parts. The Mauryas could not watch their officials at Taxila and lost the north-west. The Guptas never garrisoned the passes because the passes were too far from the Ganges. Delhi could not relieve Lahore in 1241 and wrote the province off. Alauddin Khalji's whole system was an attempt to move soldiers and information fast enough, and it decayed within ten years of his death. Muhammad bin Tughluq's empire dissolved because nothing he decided in the capital could be enforced at the edge.

Sher Shah attacked that problem directly and comprehensively, and it is why he is in this book despite being from Bihar. A road with rest-houses and a courier relay is a machine for shrinking a country. A standard coin means a soldier in Lahore and a merchant in Bengal can be paid in the same thing. A written revenue record means a peasant in the Punjab knows what he owes and can say so when an official asks for more.

He held India for five years. **Akbar's administration — the one that ran an empire for fifty years — was substantially Sher Shah's, refined by Todar Mal, who had learned it working for him.**

WHY IT WORKED

- **He had been a small landholder.** He had run a jagir himself, at ground level, and knew exactly how officials cheated because he had watched them do it.
- **He built the boring things first.** Roads, coins, records, muster rolls. No conqueror in this book had ever prioritised in that order.
- **He standardised.** One coin, one measure, one written form of agreement, across the whole empire.
- **And he spent his whole reign inside his own country.** Five years, no foreign adventures.

WHY IT DID NOT OUTLAST HIM

- **It was one man's system.** His son Islam Shah held it together; after that the Sur family fell into the usual succession war within a decade.
- **Five years is not long enough.** Institutions need a generation to become habits, and he got half of one.
- **The Afghan nobility was the same problem it had been under the Lodis** — a consultative aristocracy that would not be ruled absolutely, and was ruinous when it split.
- **And he died in an accident.** Besieging the fort of Kalinjar in 1545, he was killed by an explosion of his own gunpowder.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

You Have Driven On It

Here is the thing about Sher Shah Suri that makes him different from every other conqueror in these eight parts.

Timur is a name attached to a massacre. Mahmud is seventeen raids. Alexander turned back at a river. Most of the men in this book are remembered for the day they won something and forgotten immediately afterwards, and what they built — where they built anything — has to be dug out of the ground by archaeologists.

Sher Shah's road is still the road.

The route he rebuilt runs, in its modern form, from Bangladesh across northern India through Delhi and Amritsar, over the border at Wagah, through Lahore and Gujranwala and Jhelum and Rawalpindi to Peshawar. It carries lorries, buses, pilgrims, families and freight, every day, in enormous quantity. Sections of it are motorway now and sections of it are not, and the alignment is not identical to his — a road that old has been straightened and rerouted a hundred times.

But the line is his line, and some of his sarais are still standing beside it, in various conditions, doing various jobs. Some are ruins. Some became villages. Kipling called the road a river of life, which is the sort of thing that gets quoted too often and happens to be accurate.

And the reason it matters in a book about Punjab specifically: **its central third runs the whole length of this province,** because the province is what lies between the Ganges plain and the passes, and always has. Every army in Parts Five, Six and Seven walked that route before it was a road. Sher Shah made it a road. Every army in Parts Nine to Sixteen walks it as one.

He ruled India for five years, four hundred and eighty years ago. **If you have travelled between Delhi and Peshawar by land, you have used the thing he did with them.**

Machhiwara and Sirhind, 1555 — The Empire Comes Back

LIKELY

The Mughal empire was refounded in the Punjab doabs, in two battles, by an exiled emperor and a regent with a thirteen-year-old in the saddle.

WON BY Humayun and Bairam Khan — against a Suri army several times their size

WHEN	WHERE
May 1555 at Machhiwara; 22 June 1555 at Sirhind.	Machhiwara on the Sutlej near Ludhiana; Sirhind on the Delhi road. Both in the Punjab.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Bairam Khan, commanding for Humayun, against Sikandar Shah Suri.	Abul Fazl's Akbarnama, Jauhar's memoir, and the Persian histories of the Sur collapse.

Why the door was open

Because the Sur empire had done what every Afghan state in this book does. Sher Shah died in 1545; his able son Islam Shah died in 1554; and then the family tore itself apart. By 1555 there were three or four Suri claimants fighting each other across northern India, and the Punjab belonged to **Sikandar Shah Suri**, who was one of them.

Humayun had spent fifteen years waiting for exactly this. He came down through the passes with a Persian-equipped army, took Rohtas without a fight, took Lahore, and moved down the Punjab road.

What happened

1. **Machhiwara, May 1555.** A Suri force was beaten near the Sutlej. The Mughals were outnumbered and won by fighting at a moment and place of their choosing.
2. **Sikandar Shah came out in strength.** The numbers in the sources are the usual sort — thirty thousand against eighty thousand is the figure most often repeated, and like all such figures it is the winner's arithmetic.
3. **Sirhind, 22 June 1555.** Bairam Khan commanded. **The nominal commander was Akbar, aged twelve.** It was his first battle and he was there to be seen at it, which is exactly what a regent does with a boy who has to be made into an emperor.

4. **Bairam Khan entrenched.** Rather than meet a larger army in the open, he built a fortified camp, made the Suris attack it, and broke them when they had spent themselves — **the same answer Babur used at Panipat in Part Seven and Ghor used at Tarain in Part Six.**
5. **The Suri army disintegrated.** Sikandar fled into the Siwalik hills, which is War Seven of this part.
6. **Delhi and Agra fell within weeks,** and in July 1555 Humayun sat on the throne he had lost in 1540.
7. **And in January 1556 he fell down his library stairs and died.** He had ruled his recovered empire for about six months.

WHERE THE MUGHAL EMPIRE WAS ACTUALLY FOUNDED

It is worth being blunt about this, because the textbooks are not.

The Mughal empire is usually dated from Panipat in 1526. But that empire lasted fourteen years and was completely lost. **The empire that ruled India until 1857 — the one of Akbar and Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb, the one that built the Taj Mahal and governed a hundred million people — begins in the summer of 1555, in the Punjab.**

Its founding battles were fought at Machhiwara on the Sutlej and at Sirhind on the Grand Trunk Road. Its first sovereign act after the victory was performed at Lahore. And when Humayun died six months later, **his successor was crowned in a field in Gurdaspur district**, which is the next war.

Punjab has been the corridor, the shield, the buffer and the springboard in every part of this book so far. **In 1555 and 1556 it is the birthplace.**

WHY THE MUGHALS WON

- **They came back into a civil war.** Fifteen years of patience, and then arriving in the one year the Suris were fighting each other.
- **Bairam Khan.** A first-rate professional soldier with total authority — the thing Humayun had never had in the 1530s.
- **They fought from prepared positions.** Twice, against larger armies, in a book where the smaller army with a ditch nearly always wins.
- **And the Punjab did not resist them.** Rohtas surrendered, the Gakkhars came out for them, and Lahore opened. Fifteen years of Sur rule had not produced loyalty.

WHY THE SURIS LOST

- **Four claimants, one throne.** Sikandar was fighting Mughals in the Punjab while other Suris held Delhi, Agra and Bengal against him.
- **The system had lost its author.** Sher Shah's administration needed somebody to run it and instead had somebody to fight over.
- **They attacked entrenchments frontally,** with numbers, which by 1555 had failed in this book at Tarain, at Delhi and at Panipat.
- **And they had no depth.** Beaten at Sirhind, there was nowhere to fall back to that was not held by another Suri.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Boy at Sirhind

At the battle of Sirhind on 22 June 1555, the army of the restored Mughal empire was formally commanded by a twelve-year-old boy who had been born in a desert fort while his father was a fugitive, and who had spent most of his childhood as a hostage in the households of uncles who were trying to kill his father.

He had been left behind at Kandahar as an infant. He had been passed between Kamran and Askari. At one point in the fighting around Kabul, the sources describe him being placed on a wall as a human shield by an uncle, in the hope that his father's guns would stop firing.

He could not read. Whether he was dyslexic or simply never taught properly is argued about, and he remained unable to read for the whole of his life. **He had books read aloud to him instead, in enormous quantity, for forty years, and built one of the great libraries of the world.**

Bairam Khan put him at the head of the army at Sirhind because a claimant who has never been seen with an army is not a claimant. It was a piece of political theatre, and the boy was almost certainly nowhere near the fighting.

Eight months later his father was dead and he was proclaimed emperor at the age of thirteen, standing on a brick platform in a field in the Punjab. Nobody present had much reason to think he would last a year. The dynasty had already lost India once, the Suris were still in the field, and the empire consisted of Delhi, Agra and whatever Bairam Khan's army was standing on.

He ruled for forty-nine years.

Panipat, 5 November 1556 — Decided by One Arrow

LIKELY

Hemu was winning. Then something hit him in the eye, and an empire changed hands because one man went quiet.

WON BY

Akbar and Bairam Khan — by an accident, and they knew it

WHEN

5 November 1556.

WHERE

Panipat again — thirty years after Babur, twenty miles from Tarain.

WHO

Hemu — Hemchandra Vikramaditya — against the army of the thirteen-year-old Akbar under **Bairam Khan**.

THE EVIDENCE

Abul Fazl, Badauni, and the Persian histories.
No account from Hemu's side survives.

Who Hemu was

This is worth getting right, because he is one of the most unusual figures in Indian history and he is usually reduced to a footnote in somebody else's victory.

He came from a modest background in the Rewari country — the sources describe him starting as a trader, in one tradition a dealer in saltpetre. He rose through the Suri administration by ability: superintendent of markets, then a revenue official, then a commander. **By 1556 he was the effective ruler of the eastern Suri realm and had won a long run of engagements against rivals and rebels.**

When Humayun died, Hemu moved. He took Agra, then marched on Delhi and beat the Mughal governor Tardi Beg outside the city in October 1556.

And then he did something that had not happened in northern India for three hundred and fifty years. **He had himself crowned at Delhi, taking the title Vikramaditya** — an ancient Indian royal name — ruling in his own right rather than as anybody's deputy.

What happened

1. **The Mughal council wanted to retreat to Kabul.** Delhi and Agra were gone, the emperor was thirteen, and the enemy had just beaten a Mughal army in the field. Most of Akbar's officers argued for withdrawing to the

safety of the passes.

2. **Bairam Khan refused**, and marched for Panipat. This is the single decision the Mughal empire rests on.
3. **Hemu came out with a large army and a great many war elephants**. The figures given run to fifteen hundred elephants, which should be read the way this book has read every elephant count since Part Two.
4. **And he was winning**. Both Mughal wings were pushed back. The accounts on the Mughal side do not disguise it.
5. **Then an arrow hit him in the eye**. He was on his elephant, in armour, in the centre — visible, as a commander of that kind of army has to be.
6. **He went down, and the army broke**. Not because it had lost, but because the one man holding it together had stopped being visible on his elephant. **Nobody knew what to do next, so they went**.
7. **He was captured unconscious and brought before Akbar**. The accounts differ about what happened then — some have Bairam Khan urging the boy to strike the killing blow and Akbar refusing or merely touching him with the sword; others have him striking. **Hemu was beheaded**. His head was sent to Kabul and his body displayed at Delhi.

THE SINGLE POINT OF FAILURE, FOR THE FIFTH TIME

Count them, because by now this is not a coincidence, it is the central military fact of pre-modern India.

Part Two, the Hydaspes: Porus's elephants turn and trample his own line. **Part Five, Waihind 1008:** Anandapala's elephant bolts and the largest Indian coalition in eight centuries dissolves in minutes. **Part Six, Tarain 1191:** Muhammad of Ghor is wounded and carried off, and his entire army runs. **Part Six, Kili 1299:** Qutlugh Khwaja is wounded and a full invasion is abandoned. **Part Eight, Panipat 1556:** Hemu takes an arrow in the eye while winning, and loses.

The mechanism is always identical. An army assembled from contingents, held together by the visible presence of one man on one large animal, with no second-in-command whom everybody would obey and no plan for what happens when he goes down. The commander must be visible to command — and being visible is what kills him.

The armies that do not do this in this book are Alexander's, Ghor's second army at Tarain, Timur's, Babur's and Bairam Khan's. **All of them are professional forces under a single owner, with subordinate officers who can fight the battle without the boss.** That difference decides more engagements in these sixteen parts than any weapon ever invented.

WHY THE MUGHALS WON

- **Bairam Khan refused to retreat.** Everything else follows from one man overruling a council.
- **Their command survived contact.** Both wings were pushed back and the army did not break, because it did not depend on any one person being visible.
- **Archery at the right target.** Whether the shot was aimed or lucky is unknowable, but Mughal tactics deliberately concentrated fire on the enemy's command elephant.
- **And they were lucky.** This book will say so plainly. On the balance of the fighting, Hemu should have won.

WHY HEMU LOST

- **He was the army.** Personal authority over a force with no institutional structure beneath it.
- **He fought from an elephant.** Visible, elevated, unmissable, and the highest-value target on the field.
- **His officers had no reason to hold.** Most were Suri men serving whoever was winning, and when he fell there was nothing to be loyal to.
- **And he had been in power for weeks.** A month-old regime has no reserves of loyalty to spend on a bad afternoon.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Field in Gurdaspur

Nine months before Panipat, on **14 February 1556**, a thirteen-year-old boy was proclaimed emperor of India in a garden at **Kalanaur**, in what is now Gurdaspur district in the Indian Punjab.

His father had died in Delhi three weeks earlier and the news had been kept quiet while a man was dressed up as the emperor and shown to the people from a balcony, so that the government would not collapse before the son could be crowned. The boy was in the Punjab with Bairam Khan, campaigning against the last Suris.

There was no palace and no time to reach one. **They built a platform of brick in the open air and put him on it**, and Bairam Khan read out what needed reading, and that was the accession of the emperor Akbar.

The platform is still there. It is a low brick structure in a field, with a small enclosure round it, on the road between Gurdaspur and Kalanaur, and if you did not know what it was you would walk past it.

Consider what this book has been describing for eight parts. Punjab as the road other people's armies use. Punjab as the province that gets spent so that the doab can be saved. Punjab as the shield, the corridor, the buffer, the springboard — always the ground somebody else's history happens on.

And then, on a February morning in a Gurdaspur field, the greatest of the Mughal emperors is crowned on a heap of bricks because there was nowhere better and no time to find one.

Forty-nine years later he would rule from the Indus to the Godavari, and Lahore would be his capital for thirteen of those years. It starts in a field, in the Punjab, with a boy nobody expected to survive the summer.

Mankot, 1557 — The Last Afghan in the Hills

LIKELY

The Afghan century that began with Bahlul Lodi in 1451 ended in a hill fort above the Punjab, after a six-month siege that nobody remembers.

WON BY Akbar — by sitting outside a fort until the food ran out

WHEN Besieged from late 1556; surrendered May 1557.	WHERE Mankot, a hill fort in the Siwaliks on the edge of the Jammu country.
WHO Sikandar Shah Suri, the last Suri with an army, against Akbar and Bairam Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Abul Fazl, who covers it briefly, and the Persian histories.

What happened

1. **Sikandar Shah had lost the Punjab at Sirhind** in June 1555 and had gone north into the hills, which is what every beaten commander in this book does when the Siwaliks are available.
2. **He kept a force in being for eighteen months** in the broken country along the edge of the mountains, raiding and recruiting.
3. **Akbar came for him after Panipat**. With Hemu dead and Delhi secure, the last Suri army was the only organised opposition left in northern India.
4. **The siege lasted about six months**. There was no assault worth recording. Mankot was blockaded until it could not feed itself.
5. **He surrendered in May 1557** and was pardoned — given a jagir in Bihar, where he died a couple of years later.

WHAT ENDED HERE

It is worth pausing over how long this had run.

Afghan power in northern India begins in 1451, when Bahlul Lodi comes down from Sirhind and takes Delhi — War Eleven of Part Seven. It survives Babur's conquest, because the Lodis' Afghan nobility simply becomes the Afghan nobility of the Sur empire. It produces **Sher Shah Suri**, the best administrator any medieval Indian state ever had, and it drives the Mughals out of India entirely for fifteen years.

It ends in a hill fort in May 1557, with a blockade and a pardon.

A hundred and six years, two dynasties, an empire lost and regained, and it finishes with a garrison running out of grain in the Siwaliks. There is no last stand, no famous speech, and nobody has ever painted it.

That is what the end of an era actually looks like most of the time, and this book has now shown it three times: the Ghaznavids negotiated out of Lahore in 1186, the Shahis ending in a pay dispute in Part Five, and now the Afghans starved out of Mankot.

WHY AKBAR WON

- **He did not attack.** Storming a hill fort is expensive; waiting is not, if you can afford to wait.
- **He had the plain and the revenue.** The besieger was eating from the Punjab; the besieged were eating from a fort.
- **He offered terms worth taking.** A pardon and a jagir is a better outcome than starvation, and both sides knew it.
- **And there was nothing left to hold out for.** No other Suri army existed by 1557.

WHY SIKANDAR COULD NOT CONTINUE

- **The hills preserve; they do not supply.** Broken country is excellent for surviving and hopeless for feeding an army.
- **His allies had gone.** The Afghan nobility of the Punjab had made its peace with the Mughals over the previous two years.
- **He held a fort instead of a country.** The mistake the Shahis made at Nandana in Part Five, five hundred and forty years earlier.
- **And a fortress needs a field army behind it.** There was not one.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Hills That Always Take Them In

Look at where beaten men go in this book, because it is always the same place.

Mihirakula, broken at Sondani in Part Four, goes north into Kashmir and comes back down. **Trilochanapala**, the last effective Shahi, fights on from the Siwaliks for seven years after losing Nandana in Part Five. **Jasrat Khokhar** runs the northern Punjab for twenty years in Part Seven by retreating into the Salt Range every time a Delhi army appears. **Sikandar Shah Suri** holds out here for eighteen months. And in Part Nine, when the Mughal empire turns on the Sikh Gurus, the fighting will be in exactly this country — the Siwalik foothills between the Sutlej and the Beas, at Anandpur and Bhangani and Chamkaur.

The reason is geography and it does not change. **The hills that fringe the Punjab on the north and east are the province's only defensible terrain, and everybody in this book eventually finds out.** A cavalry army from the plains cannot deploy there. Supply is a nightmare. Every valley has to be taken separately, and the people who live in them know the ground.

And the limitation is just as constant. **You can survive in those hills indefinitely and you cannot rule from them.** There is no revenue, no manpower to speak of, and no way to threaten anybody on the plain. Every figure listed above ends the same way — preserved by the hills, and finished by them.

Punjab loses on its plains and survives in its hills. Eight parts, and the rule has not been broken once.

The Regent's Revolt, 1560

LIKELY

The man who had saved the dynasty twice was dismissed at eighteen, rebelled in the Punjab, was beaten, forgiven, and murdered on his way to Mecca.

WON BY Akbar — the first act of his actual reign

WHEN Dismissed March 1560; defeated later that year; murdered January 1561.	WHERE The Punjab — the fighting at Gunachur, near Jalandhar.
WHO Bairam Khan against the emperor he had made.	THE EVIDENCE Abul Fazl, whose account is careful, and Badauni, whose account is not.

What happened

1. **Bairam Khan had run the empire for four years** as regent, and had run it well — Panipat, Mankot, Gwalior, Jaunpur, and an administration that functioned.
2. **Akbar turned seventeen and then eighteen**, and the court around him — the harem faction, his foster-mother Maham Anga, and nobles who resented the regent's authority — pressed for the end of the regency.
3. **In March 1560 Akbar dismissed him**, by a manoeuvre rather than a confrontation: he left for Delhi, then sent word that he had taken the government into his own hands and that Bairam Khan should go on pilgrimage to Mecca.
4. **Bairam Khan accepted, and then did not**. Humiliated on the road by officials sent to hurry him along, he turned back and raised troops in the Punjab.
5. **He was beaten near Jalandhar**, at a place the sources call Gunachur, by a Mughal force sent against him.
6. **And Akbar pardoned him**. Completely — he was received at court with honour and offered a governorship or the pilgrimage. He chose the pilgrimage.
7. **He never got there**. At Patan in Gujarat, in January 1561, he was stabbed to death by an Afghan whose father had been killed fighting him at Machhiwara five years earlier.

THE PARDON, AND WHAT IT TELLS YOU ABOUT AKBAR

This is the first serious decision Akbar made on his own, and it set the pattern for a fifty-year reign.

He could have executed him. A defeated rebel who had been regent, who had a following in the army and a claim on the loyalty of half the nobility, is the most dangerous man alive. Every ruler in this book kills him. Alauddin Khalji would have killed him. Sher Shah would have killed him.

Akbar received him, embraced him, and offered him his choice of futures.

Whether that was mercy, calculation, or genuine feeling for the man who had raised him is unknowable, and Abul Fazl — writing to establish Akbar's greatness — is not a neutral witness. **But the policy was real and it was repeated for fifty years.** Akbar's method with defeated enemies was to absorb them: Rajput rulers married into the imperial family and given the highest commands, Afghan nobles kept in service, rebels forgiven.

And there is a coda that says more than the policy does. **Bairam Khan's widow and his four-year-old son were brought to court and taken into the imperial household.** That son, **Abdul Rahim**, grew up to be commander-in-chief of the Mughal army, and one of the finest poets in Hindi — his verses are still learned by schoolchildren in northern India.

The emperor raised the son of the man who had rebelled against him, and the boy became a poet in the language of the country rather than the language of the court.

WHY AKBAR WON

- **He moved before the confrontation.** Leaving for Delhi and announcing the change from a position of safety, rather than arguing about it in a camp Bairam Khan controlled.
- **The nobility went with the throne.** Most of the army preferred a legitimate emperor to a regent with a grievance.
- **He offered an exit.** The pilgrimage was a face-saving retirement, and it very nearly worked.
- **And then he forgave.** Which removed any reason for the rest of Bairam Khan's faction to keep fighting.

WHY BAIRAM KHAN LOST

- **He had no cause.** Rebelling against a Timurid emperor in the name of nothing but his own dignity gave nobody a reason to join him.
- **He was a servant of the dynasty, and everyone knew it.** His whole reputation rested on loyalty; the moment he rebelled he had spent it.
- **Punjab was not his.** He raised troops there but had no base of his own — the mistake that ended Daulat Khan Lodi in Part Seven.
- **And he was fifty and tired.** He submitted quickly, which suggests he knew.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Made the Empire and Got Nothing

Bairam Khan is the most consequential person in this part of the book and he has no monument, no dynasty and no chapter with his name on it.

He was a Turkoman from Badakhshan who attached himself to Humayun in the bad years and stayed through all of them — the flight into Sindh, the exile in Persia, the wars against the brothers. He commanded at **Machhiwara** and **Sirhind**, the two battles that gave the Mughals India back. When Humayun died, he held the empire together for a thirteen-year-old.

And at **Panipat in 1556**, with the boy's entire council urging retreat to Kabul, he refused, marched, and fought a battle he was losing until an arrow decided it. **If Bairam Khan had agreed with the council on that day, there is no Mughal empire.** No Akbar's reign, no Jahangir, no Shah Jahan, no Taj Mahal, no Aurangzeb — and Part Nine of this book is about something else entirely.

He was dismissed four years later at the urging of a court faction, rebelled out of wounded pride, was beaten in the Punjab, forgiven, and stabbed to death by a private enemy on a pilgrimage road in Gujarat.

His tomb is at Patan. It is not a famous building.

The winner is whoever gets written about — and the man who won the battle that founded the Mughal empire is remembered mainly as the regent Akbar had to get rid of before he could be great.

Mirza Hakim Comes Down From Kabul, 1581

LIKELY

Akbar's half-brother invaded the Punjab, half the Mughal nobility had already declared for him, and the empire came closer to breaking than at any point in fifty years.

WON BY Akbar — by marching so fast the rebellion did not have time to become one

WHEN 1580–1581; Akbar takes Kabul in August 1581.	WHERE The Punjab, up to the walls of Lahore; then Kabul.
WHO Mirza Muhammad Hakim, Akbar's half-brother and ruler of Kabul, against the empire.	THE EVIDENCE Abul Fazl, and Badauni, who was hostile to Akbar and is therefore useful here.

Why it was dangerous

Because it was not simply an invasion. It was an invasion that a large part of the Mughal establishment wanted to succeed.

Akbar's religious policy had by 1580 gone a long way from where his nobility expected it to be. He had abolished the pilgrim tax and the *jizya*. He had married Rajput princesses and given their families the highest commands in the army. He held debates in a hall at Fatehpur Sikri where Muslim theologians argued with Hindus, Jains, Zoroastrians and Jesuit priests, and the orthodox found the results alarming. In 1579 he issued a decree that made his own judgement final in disputed religious questions.

Badauni, who was at that court and hated all of it, records the anger in detail. He is a difficult and prejudiced witness and he is also the only one who tells us what the opposition sounded like.

So when a serious revolt broke out in Bengal and Bihar in 1580, the rebels proclaimed **Mirza Hakim** — Akbar's half-brother, who ruled Kabul, and who was a conventional Muslim prince — as the rightful emperor. Fatwas were obtained. And in early 1581 Hakim crossed into the Punjab.

What happened

1. **Hakim invaded with a substantial force** and moved on Lahore, which was the key to the whole province.

2. **Lahore held.** It was defended by **Man Singh** and **Bhagwant Das** — Rajput commanders of the Amber house, whose promotion was one of the things the rebels were objecting to. **The city that saved Akbar's empire from the orthodox reaction was held for him by Hindu generals.**
3. **Akbar marched.** He assembled an enormous army and came north up the Grand Trunk Road at speed.
4. **Hakim did not wait.** He withdrew from the Punjab without a general engagement.
5. **Akbar followed him to Kabul and took it** in August 1581.
6. **And then he gave it back.** He handed the government of Kabul to his half-sister, Bakht-un-Nissa Begum, with Hakim left in place under her, and went home. **He had taken his brother's capital and declined to keep it.**
7. **Hakim died in 1585,** of drink by most accounts, and Kabul was then annexed without a fight.

WHY HE GAVE KABUL BACK

The obvious answer is that it was cheap generosity towards a brother, and Abul Fazl presents it that way.

The strategic answer is better. **Kabul as a hostile power is a permanent threat to the Punjab; Kabul as a family appanage is a buffer.** Akbar had just demonstrated that he could take it whenever he liked, which was the actual point of the campaign. Occupying it would have committed a garrison and an army to a country that had eaten armies for a thousand years — as Part Five's Ghaznavids and Part Six's Mongols could both have told him.

And there is a third reason, which is the one this book keeps coming back to. **Whoever holds Kabul holds the door into the Punjab.** Akbar had spent 1581 discovering exactly how fast an army from Kabul could reach Lahore, and the answer had frightened him enough that four years later he moved his entire court to Lahore and kept it there for thirteen years.

WHY AKBAR WON

- **Speed.** He reached the Punjab before the rebellion in the east could combine with the invasion in the west.
- **Lahore held.** One city, competently defended, denied Hakim the base he needed.
- **His Rajput commanders were loyal,** which was precisely the arrangement his enemies were rebelling against. The policy defended itself.
- **And he took the war to Kabul.** Ending it at the source rather than defending the frontier — the thing Jayapala tried in Part Five and could not manage.

WHY HAKIM FAILED

- **He was a figurehead, not a leader.** The rebels wanted a name; he supplied one and very little else.
- **He could not take Lahore.** Without it there was no Punjab, and without the Punjab there was no march on Delhi.
- **The two revolts never joined.** Bengal in the east and Kabul in the west, a continent apart, with Akbar in the middle.
- **And he was outmatched by an enormous margin,** in troops, money and ability.

The Rajputs on the Walls of Lahore

Hold the picture of 1581 in your head, because it is one of the strangest arrangements in this book and it is entirely real.

A Muslim Timurid prince invades the Punjab from Kabul, backed by fatwas declaring that the reigning emperor has departed from the faith and that the invader is the rightful sovereign. A substantial part of the Muslim nobility of the empire agrees with him.

The city he has to take is Lahore. **Lahore is held against him by Man Singh and Bhagwant Das of Amber — Rajputs, Hindus, whose sister and aunt had married into the imperial family, and whose rapid promotion is one of the specific grievances the rebels have listed.**

They hold it. The emperor arrives. The rebellion collapses.

Man Singh went on to become one of the greatest commanders of the age — governor of Kabul, then of Bengal, then of the Deccan, with the highest rank in the imperial service. He fought at Haldighati against Rana Pratap, which is why his reputation in later Rajput tradition is complicated and remains so.

What this book takes from 1581 is narrower and harder to argue with. Akbar's policy of absorbing his enemies rather than destroying them — Rajputs married in and promoted, Afghans kept in service, rebels pardoned — was attacked as a betrayal by people who thought it was weakness.

And when the attack came, **the policy was what held the walls.**

The Karakar Pass, 1586 — The Worst Day of Akbar’s Reign

LIKELY

Eight thousand men were lost in a defile in the hills north-west of the Punjab, and the emperor is said to have refused food for two days.

WON BY The Yusufzai — completely, and it was never avenged

WHEN February 1586.	WHERE The Karakar Pass in the Swat–Buner country, north-west of the Indus.
WHO Raja Birbal, Zain Khan Koka and Hakim Abul Fath, against the Yusufzai tribes.	THE EVIDENCE Abul Fazl, who was Akbar’s friend and does not disguise the scale of it; Badauni, who enjoyed it.

Why the frontier was on fire

Because of a religious movement that the empire could not negotiate with. The **Roshaniyya** — the followers of Bayazid Ansari, called Pir Roshan, and after him his son Jalaluddin — had spread through the Pashtun tribes of the north-west frontier, and had turned the ordinary friction of the hill country into an organised refusal to submit.

The **Yusufzai** tribes of Swat and Buner were the core of it, and their country sits directly above the road from Kabul to the Punjab. **An empire that had just moved its capital to Lahore could not have an unsubdued and hostile frontier three days’ march to the north-west.**

What happened

1. **Zain Khan Koka was sent against the Yusufzai in 1585** and made slow progress in extremely difficult country.
2. **Reinforcements were sent in early 1586** under **Raja Birbal** and Hakim Abul Fath.
3. **The commanders did not agree.** This is the central fact and every source says it. Three men of roughly equal standing, no clear chain of command, and a disagreement about whether to press on or withdraw.

4. **They decided to withdraw**, and did it through a defile — the Karakar Pass — with the tribes on the heights above them.
5. **The column was destroyed**. An army strung out in single file on a mountain track, attacked from above along its whole length, cannot form, cannot deploy and cannot fight back. **The figure in the sources is about eight thousand dead**.
6. **Birbal was killed**. His body was never recovered.
7. **Akbar took it very badly**. Abul Fazl records that he was inconsolable and would not eat for two days.
8. **The frontier was pacified slowly afterwards** — Todar Mal, then Man Singh — by roads, forts and payments rather than by a decisive battle. Nobody ever avenged the pass.

WHO BIRBAL WAS, AND WHY THE LOSS LANDED SO HARD

Raja Birbal — born Mahesh Das, a Brahmin from a poor family — had come to Akbar's court as a poet and musician and had become one of the emperor's closest personal friends. He was one of the very small group Akbar genuinely relaxed with. He is also, in folk memory across northern India, the wit of a thousand stories: the clever courtier who solves impossible problems with a joke, in tales that are still told to children and have been filmed and televised endlessly.

Almost none of those stories are historical. They are a folk tradition that attached itself to a real man over four centuries.

The real man was a courtier and a poet with no significant military experience, sent to command in the worst terrain on the subcontinent against the best light infantry in Asia — and it killed him and eight thousand others.

Badauni, who despised Birbal as a Hindu favourite with too much influence, records the disaster with something close to satisfaction. **His hostility is exactly why he is worth reading:** Abul Fazl would have found a way to soften it, and Badauni would not.

WHY THE YUSUFZAI WON

- **They chose the ground.** A defile with heights on both sides is the one place a regular army cannot use its advantages.
- **They attacked a retreat.** The most vulnerable moment in any campaign, and they waited for it.
- **They knew the country and the Mughals did not.** Every path, every spur, every place a column has to string out.
- **And they had nothing to defend.** No city, no capital, no army to be destroyed — the same reason the Salt Range people could never be finished.

WHY THE MUGHALS WERE DESTROYED

- **Divided command.** Three commanders, no authority, a quarrel in the field. This is the whole disaster in two words.
- **A political appointment to a military job.** Birbal was sent because he was trusted, not because he could do it.
- **They took heavy cavalry into mountains.** The arm the Mughal army was built around was useless on those tracks.
- **And they retreated through a defile without securing the heights,** which is the first thing anyone fighting in hills is supposed to know.

The Same Pass, Forever

The Karakar Pass in 1586 is not an isolated catastrophe. It is one instance of the single most repeated event in the military history of this region, and the list is worth setting out because it does not stop at 1586.

A regular army from the plains enters the hills north-west of the Punjab. It is strung out in a defile. It is attacked from above. It is destroyed.

It happened to Alexander's detachments in the Swat valley in Part Two, which is why he had to storm Aornos. It happened to the Mughals here, in 1586, costing eight thousand men and the emperor's closest friend. It happened to Akbar's successors repeatedly in the same country. **It happened to a British army retreating from Kabul in January 1842, when roughly sixteen thousand people entered the passes and, by the most famous account, one exhausted surgeon reached Jalalabad.** It happened to the British again in the frontier campaigns of the 1890s. Armies have been learning it and forgetting it for two thousand three hundred years.

And the reason is always the same, and it has nothing to do with the courage of anybody involved. **The advantages that make a plains army powerful — numbers, cavalry, artillery, supply trains, formation — all become liabilities on a mountain track.** Numbers mean a longer column. Cavalry means animals that cannot manoeuvre. Supply means a baggage train that cannot be defended. Formation means nothing at all when you are in single file.

Against that, a few hundred men on the heights with time to prepare are worth more than a division.

This is the country that has funnelled every invasion in this book down onto the Punjab plain. **It has never been conquered by anybody, in any century, and it has ruined the reputation of every empire that has tried.**

Lahore, Capital of India, 1585–1598

CERTAIN

For thirteen years the largest empire on earth was governed from the Punjab, and Kashmir, Sindh and Kandahar were taken from there.

WON BY Akbar — the high-water mark of the Punjab in this whole book

WHEN The court moves to Lahore in 1585 and returns to Agra in 1598.	WHERE Lahore — and the campaigns launched from it into Kashmir, Sindh, Baluchistan and Kandahar.
WHO Akbar, against the Uzbeks he never had to fight, and everybody he did.	THE EVIDENCE Abul Fazl’s <i>Akbarnama</i> and <i>Ain-i-Akbari</i>, the buildings, and European travellers who saw it.

Why he moved

Three things happened in a single year and together they emptied the north-west of everything that had been holding it steady.

1. **Mirza Hakim died in 1585**, which meant Kabul had no ruler.
2. **Abdullah Khan Uzbek was conquering Central Asia**. He had taken Balkh and Badakhshan and was the most dangerous man north of the Hindu Kush. **An Uzbek advance on Kabul was a real prospect, and Kabul is the door into the Punjab.**
3. **The frontier tribes were in revolt**, and in February 1586 they destroyed an imperial army in the Karakar Pass.

Akbar’s answer was to move the entire apparatus of government — court, treasury, harem, records, army headquarters — **to Lahore**, and run the empire from there until the problem was solved. He stayed thirteen years.

What was done from Lahore

1. **Kabul annexed**, 1585, on Hakim’s death.
2. **Kashmir conquered**, 1586. Akbar visited it three times afterwards and it became the summer resort of the Mughal empire, which it remained for a century and a half.

3. **Sindh conquered**, 1591, by Abdul Rahim Khan-i-Khanan — Bairam Khan's son, the boy from War Eight, now commander-in-chief.
4. **Baluchistan and the Makran coast** brought in, 1595.
5. **Kandahar taken**, 1595, without a battle, when its Safavid governors handed it over.
6. **And the Uzbek war never happened**. Abdullah Khan, faced with an emperor sitting at Lahore with a field army, negotiated instead. **The most successful campaign of the thirteen years was the one that was deterred.**

WHAT LAHORE BECAME

A capital city is not just an address. For thirteen years, everything that flows to a capital flowed to Lahore.

The fort was rebuilt in brick and stone — the great Mughal Lahore Fort essentially begins with Akbar's reconstruction, and his successors added to it for a century. The city walls were rebuilt. Gardens, mosques, tombs, markets and the enormous apparatus of an imperial court all arrived at once.

The painters, calligraphers, poets and craftsmen of the imperial workshops came with the court. Some of the finest Mughal manuscript painting was produced at Lahore in these years.

And the trade followed. Lahore sat where the routes from Kabul, Kashmir, Multan and Delhi met, and with the court there it became one of the great commercial cities of Asia. European travellers reaching it in this period described it in the same breath as the largest cities they knew.

Then in 1598 the court went back to Agra, because the Deccan wars needed the emperor at the other end of the empire, and Lahore became a provincial capital again — a very great one, but not the centre.

Thirteen years, in a book that covers about five thousand. It is the only period in these sixteen parts when the Punjab is where the decisions are made, and it happens because an emperor was frightened of the Uzbeks.

WHY IT WORKED

- **He put the government where the problem was.** Obvious, and almost nobody in this book ever does it — Part Four spent a chapter complaining that nobody garrisons the door.
- **Presence deterred the war.** The Uzbeks did not attack an emperor who was three weeks away instead of three months.
- **The frontier was pacified with money and roads, not battles.** After the Karakar Pass, the policy shifted to subsidy, fortification and negotiation, which is slower and worked.
- **And the administration travelled.** Sher Shah's road and Todar Mal's revenue system meant an empire could be run from a different city without breaking.

WHAT IT DID NOT FIX

- **The hill tribes were never subdued.** Contained, subsidised, and left alone.
- **Kandahar did not stay.** It changed hands repeatedly between Mughals and Safavids for the next seventy years.
- **And the capital left.** Thirteen years, and then the centre of gravity went back east for good.

The Book That Counted Everything

While the court was at Lahore, Abul Fazl was finishing a project that is unlike anything else produced in the sixteenth century anywhere in the world.

The *Ain-i-Akbari* — the Institutes of Akbar — is the administrative volume of his history, and it is essentially a description of an empire by measurement. **It lists the provinces and their subdivisions, the revenue assessed on each, the crops grown, the prices of goods in the markets, the wages of workmen, the ranks and pay of officers, the organisation of the imperial kitchen, the stables, the workshops, the mint.** It records the castes and communities of each region, the rivers, the roads, and the distances between places.

For the Punjab it gives, district by district, what the land was worth and what it grew.

Nothing like it exists for any earlier period of Indian history, and that absence is why this book has spent eight parts saying “the figure is a court number.” For Waihind in 1008 we have a chronicler’s guess. For Panipat in 1526 we have Babur’s estimate of his own enemy. For the *Ain*, we have a government’s own working papers.

It is not neutral — Abul Fazl was writing to demonstrate that Akbar’s empire was the best-ordered state on earth, and he chose what to count. But you cannot fake a revenue table across hundreds of districts, and historians have been using his numbers for two hundred years because there is nothing else of the kind.

Set it beside the other book being finished in the Punjab in the same decade, twenty-five miles from Lahore. **One is an empire counting its provinces. The other is a community writing down its hymns.** Both are being completed within a few years of each other, in the same province, and the second one is the subject of the next war.

The War That Was Not Fought — Goindwal, Amritsar and the Book, 1539–1604

LIKELY

While everything else in this part was being decided by cavalry, the most consequential thing in it was happening in three villages on the rivers, and nobody fought anybody at all.

WON BY Nobody — and it changes Punjab permanently

WHEN 1539–1604, from Guru Nanak’s death to the installation of the Adi Granth.	WHERE Khadur, Goindwal, Ramdaspur — Amritsar — and Tarn Taran, between the Ravi and the Beas.
WHO Guru Angad, Guru Amar Das, Guru Ram Das and Guru Arjan.	THE EVIDENCE The Adi Granth itself; Mughal records; and later Sikh tradition, which is labelled as such.

What was actually built

Part Seven ended with Guru Nanak watching Babur’s army sack Saidpur and writing about it in Punjabi. He died in 1539. What his four successors did over the next sixty-five years was turn a teaching into an institution, and each step is concrete.

1. **A script.** Guru Angad established **Gurmukhi** in the form it has today — a script for writing Punjabi, standardised so that the hymns could be recorded and taught accurately. **A language with its own script is a language that can keep its own records.** Eight parts of this book have complained that Punjab wrote nothing down. This is the tool that ends that.
2. **A common kitchen.** The *langar* — free food, cooked and eaten together — was made central by Guru Amar Das, who required that anyone coming to see him must first sit and eat in the same row as everyone else, whatever their caste or rank. In sixteenth-century India that is not hospitality. It is an argument, made with food, every day.
3. **Towns.** Goindwal on the Beas, with its great step-well; then **Ramdaspur**, founded by Guru Ram Das around a tank he called the *Amritsar*, the pool of nectar — the town that took its name from the water; then Tarn Taran, Kartarpur in the Jalandhar doab, and Hargobindpur.

4. **An organisation.** Guru Amar Das divided the community into districts, each with an appointed representative, so that a scattered following became something that could be administered.
5. **A building.** The **Harmandir Sahib** was completed at Amritsar under Guru Arjan by about 1589 — set below the level of the surrounding ground, so that a visitor walks down to it, with entrances on all four sides.
6. **And a book.** In 1604, Guru Arjan compiled the **Adi Granth** and installed it in the Harmandir Sahib.

AKBAR AND THE GURUS — WHAT CAN AND CANNOT BE SAID

Sikh tradition records that Akbar visited Guru Amar Das at Goindwal, and that before he could meet the Guru he had to sit on the floor in the langar and eat with everybody else, which he did. Tradition also holds that he offered a revenue grant and that it was declined, and that at the Guru's request he remitted revenue during a hard year.

The visit is plausible and widely accepted; the details of what was said are tradition rather than documented history, and this book will not present them as more than that.

What can be said from the record is narrower and still striking. **Akbar's government did not persecute this community.** A movement that rejected caste, fed everyone from one kitchen, and was growing fast among the peasantry of the Punjab could easily have been treated as a threat by a less unusual emperor. It was not. It was allowed to build towns, dig tanks, raise a central shrine and compile a scripture, twenty-five miles from the imperial capital, during the years when that capital was Lahore.

The land on which Amritsar was founded is another disputed point: **some traditions say Akbar granted it, others that it was bought from the villagers of Tung.** The honest answer is that the evidence does not settle it.

And it does not last. Akbar died in October 1605. Within eight months his successor had executed Guru Arjan at Lahore, and Part Nine begins.

WHY IT TOOK ROOT

- **It was built, not preached.** Wells, kitchens, towns, a script, districts, a book — physical things that outlast the person who made them.
- **It was in Punjabi.** Not Persian, not Sanskrit — the language the farmers of the doabs actually spoke.
- **The succession was planned.** Each Guru chose his successor and installed him in his lifetime, which is more than almost any dynasty in this book managed.
- **And the political weather was favourable for exactly the right sixty years.** Which was luck, and it ran out.

WHAT IT WAS ABOUT TO FACE

- **A different emperor.** Jahangir's own memoirs discuss Guru Arjan in terms Akbar never used about anybody in the Punjab.
- **Proximity to a succession war.** Jahangir's rebel son Khusrau passed through the Punjab in 1606, and the Guru's contact with him became the stated pretext.
- **Success itself.** A community with towns, a treasury of offerings and a central shrine is visible in a way a wandering teacher is not.
- **And there was no answer available yet.** In 1606 this was a community with a book and no means of defending itself. That changes in Part Nine, and it changes because of what happens in 1606.

What They Put In the Book

In 1604 Guru Arjan finished compiling the **Adi Granth** and had it installed in the Harmandir Sahib at Amritsar, with Baba Buddha as its first attendant.

It contains the hymns of the Gurus. It also contains something else, and this is the part worth stopping on.

It contains the hymns of people who were not Sikhs at all. Kabir, the weaver of Benares. Namdev, the calico-printer from Maharashtra. Ravidas, a leather-worker — a caste treated as untouchable. Sheikh Farid, a Muslim Sufi of the Punjab from the thirteenth century. Bhikhan, Sain, Dhanna, and others: Hindus and Muslims, from several centuries and several provinces, many of them from the lowest social ranks in India.

They were included as scripture, on the same footing, in the same volume, and they are recited as scripture today.

Consider what that decision is, made in the Punjab in 1604 by a man whose father founded the town and whose great-great-predecessor had watched Babur's army sack Saidpur. **It is a deliberate statement that truth is not the property of one community** — assembled, written down in a Punjabi script, and given a permanent physical home so that it could not be lost the way everything else in this book has been lost.

And now the thing this history has been building towards for eight parts.

Guru Arjan included Guru Nanak's hymns on Babur's invasion. The *Babarvani* — the eyewitness account of the sack of Saidpur, the accusation against the conqueror, the question put to God about why it was permitted — went into the book in 1604 and has been recited ever since.

Read what that means against the previous seven parts. The wars of Punjab have reached us through Greeks writing centuries later, Chinese pilgrims describing ruins, Persian court historians counting the dead for their employers, a Kashmiri poet six hundred years after the event, and victory inscriptions carved by winners in provinces a thousand miles away. Not one word from inside, kept by the people it happened to.

In 1604, in a town on the Punjab plain, that ends. The province acquires a book of its own, in its own language, in its own script, containing its own account of what was done to it — and an institution whose entire purpose is to make sure the book survives.

Everything in Part Nine follows from that. So does everything in Parts Ten, Eleven, Twelve and Thirteen. **From here on, when somebody comes down the road, Punjab writes it down.**

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1530	Kamran Mirza seizes the Punjab on Babur's death and Humayun concedes it. The empire is cut in half at the waist. Won by Kamran.
1539–1540	Chausa and Kannauj. Sher Shah Suri destroys the Mughal army twice and takes Agra and Delhi.
1540	Lahore. The brothers argue for weeks; Sher Shah reaches Sirhind and sends word that he has left them Kabul and they should go there. They go. Won by Sher Shah, without a battle.
1540–1545	The road, the rupee and the register. The Grand Trunk Road rebuilt with sarais and a courier relay; the silver <i>rupiya</i> issued; land measured and every cultivator given a written record. Won by Sher Shah — permanently.
1541–1548	Rohtas. An enormous fortress built in the Salt Range against the Gakkhars and against Humayun's return. The local people boycott the work until the rate reaches a gold coin a stone. Won by the Gakkhars — who were never subdued.
1545	Sher Shah is killed at Kalinjar by an explosion of his own gunpowder. The Sur empire begins to come apart.
May 1555	Machhiwara, on the Sutlej near Ludhiana. The returning Mughals beat a Suri force. Won by Bairam Khan.
22 June 1555	Sirhind. Bairam Khan entrenches against a much larger Suri army and breaks it, with the twelve-year-old Akbar as nominal commander. Delhi falls within weeks. Won by the Mughals — the empire is refounded in the Punjab.
Jan 1556	Humayun dies falling down his library stairs, six months after regaining his throne.
14 Feb 1556	Kalanaur. Akbar, aged thirteen, is proclaimed emperor on a brick platform in a field in Gurdaspur district. The platform is still there.
5 Nov 1556	The Second Battle of Panipat. Hemu is winning until an arrow hits him in the eye and his army dissolves. Won by Bairam Khan — by an accident.
May 1557	Mankot. Sikandar Shah Suri is blockaded in the Siwaliks for six months and surrenders. Won by Akbar — and Afghan power in northern India ends.
1560–1561	Bairam Khan is dismissed, rebels in the Punjab, is beaten near Jalandhar and pardoned — then murdered at Patan on his way to Mecca. His four-year-old son is raised at court and becomes one of India's great poets. Won by Akbar.
1581	Mirza Hakim invades the Punjab from Kabul, backed by fatwas against Akbar. Lahore is held for the emperor by his Rajput generals. Akbar takes Kabul and gives it back. Won by Akbar.

Feb 1586	The Karakar Pass. A Mughal column is destroyed in a defile by the Yusufzai; about eight thousand die, including Raja Birbal. Won by the Yusufzai — and never avenged.
1585–1598	Lahore is the capital of India. Kabul annexed, Kashmir taken in 1586 , Sindh in 1591, Baluchistan and Kandahar in 1595 — and the Uzbek war is deterred without being fought.
1577–1589	Ramdaspur is founded around the Amritsar tank and the Harmandir Sahib is completed.
1604	Guru Arjan compiles the Adi Granth and installs it at Amritsar — including Guru Nanak's eyewitness hymns on Babur's invasion, and the verses of Hindu and Muslim saints alongside the Gurus.
Oct 1605	Akbar dies. <i>Part Nine begins here — and within eight months Guru Arjan is dead at Lahore.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Nine

- 1. Punjab is where the empire is refounded, not where it is defended.** Machhiwara, Sirhind, Kalanaur — the Mughal state that ruled India until 1857 begins in the Punjab doabs in 1555 and 1556. And for thirteen years from 1585 it is governed from Lahore. **This is the highest point Punjab reaches in the entire book, and it happens because an emperor was afraid of the Uzbeks.**
- 2. The army that fights as a machine beats the army that fights as a man.** Hemu at Panipat is the fifth commander in this book to be winning and then lose because he personally went down — after Porus, Anandapala, Muhammad of Ghor and Qutlugh Khwaja. **The armies that survive their commander's fall are professional forces with subordinate officers. That single organisational fact decides more battles in these sixteen parts than any weapon.**
- 3. The hills preserve and the hills imprison.** Sikandar Shah in the Siwaliks, the Gakkhars in the Salt Range, the Yusufzai above the Karakar Pass. You cannot be finished there and you cannot rule from there. **Watch this become the central military fact of Part Nine, when the fighting moves to Anandpur and Chamkaur.**
- 4. Distance is the enemy, and Sher Shah is the only ruler in this book who attacked it directly.** A road, a courier relay, one coin and a written record for every cultivator. He held India for five years and his system outlived him by three centuries. **The Mughal empire that Part Nine describes is running, substantially, on his machinery.**
- 5. And Punjab now keeps its own record.** After eight parts of hearing about the Punjab only from Greeks, Chinese, Persians and Kashmiris, the province has a script, a book, a shrine and an organisation to maintain them. **Part Nine is the first part of this history where the losing side's account survives — and it survives because of what was built between 1539 and 1604.**

COMING NEXT — PART NINE

The Gurus and the Mughals, 1605–1708. Within a year of Akbar's death, Guru Arjan is executed at Lahore — and his son responds by putting on two swords and building a fort. Part Nine is the century in which the community of Part Eight becomes a military power: the battles around Amritsar and Kartarpur under Guru Hargobind; the founding of Anandpur in the Siwalik hills; the execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur at Delhi in 1675; and then Guru Gobind Singh — Bhangani, Nadaun, the founding of the **Khalsa** at Anandpur in 1699, the long sieges, the retreat from Anandpur, **Chamkaur** and **Muktsar** in the winter of 1704 and 1705. It ends with Aurangzeb dead in 1707 and a Punjab that has, for the first time since the Shahis, an army of its own.

Words Used in This Part

Mirza

A Timurid prince. Kamran Mirza and Mirza Muhammad Hakim were both sons of emperors with territories of their own.

Sur / Suri

The Afghan dynasty founded by Sher Shah, ruling India 1540–1555. Its collapse into rival claimants is what let the Mughals back in.

Sarai

A walled rest-house on a road, with lodging, water and a mosque. Sher Shah built them a day's travel apart along the Grand Trunk Road, and they doubled as courier relay stations.

Sadak-e-Azam

"The great road." Sher Shah's trunk route from Bengal to the Indus — the Grand Trunk Road, whose central third runs the length of the Punjab.

Rupiya

The standardised silver coin issued by Sher Shah, of about 178 grains. The direct ancestor of the rupee.

Patta

The written statement given to a cultivator recording what he held and what he owed. Half of Sher Shah's revenue reform; the cultivator's written undertaking in return was the other half.

Jagir

An assignment of land revenue in return for service. The standard way of paying an officer in both the Sur and Mughal systems.

Gakkhars

The people of the Salt Range and Jhelum country in the Sur-period sources. Whether they are the same as the Khokhars of Parts Five to Seven is disputed.

Akbarnama / Ain-i-Akbari

Abul Fazl's history of Akbar's reign and its administrative volume. The *Ain* lists revenues, prices, wages and crops province by province — the first Indian source of its kind.

Badauni

Abd al-Qadir Badauni, a scholar at Akbar's court who wrote a secret history hostile to almost everything the emperor did. Prejudiced, and indispensable.

Humayun-nama

Gulbadan Begum's memoir of her brother's reign, written at Akbar's request. The only account of these events by a woman, and the frankest.

Roshaniyya

The religious and political movement among the Pashtun tribes founded by Bayazid Ansari, which turned the north-west frontier into a war zone in the 1580s.

Yusufzai

The Pashtun tribes of Swat and Buner who destroyed the Mughal column in the Karakar Pass in 1586.

Gurmukhi

The script established in its present form by Guru Angad for writing Punjabi. The tool that lets the province keep its own records.

Langar

The free community kitchen, where everyone eats together in the same row regardless of caste or rank. Made central by Guru Amar Das.

Harmandir Sahib

The central shrine at Amritsar, completed under Guru Arjan by about 1589, set below the surrounding ground with entrances on all four sides.

Adi Granth

The scripture compiled by Guru Arjan and installed at Amritsar in 1604. It includes hymns by Hindu and Muslim saints alongside those of the Gurus.

Amritsar

“The pool of nectar” — the name of the tank dug by Guru Ram Das, which the town founded around it eventually took as its own.

Sources used for this part

- Abul Fazl, *Akbarnama* and *Ain-i-Akbari*, in Beveridge’s and Blochmann’s translations — official, magnificent and partisan
- Abd al-Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* — written secretly at the same court and hostile throughout
- Gulbadan Begum, *Humayun-nama*, in Annette Beveridge’s translation
- Jauhar Aftabchi, *Tazkirat-ul-Waqiat* — the memoir of Humayun’s water-bearer, who was with him in exile
- Abbas Khan Sarwani, *Tarikh-i-Sher Shahi*, and the other Persian histories of the Sur period
- Ferishta, *Tarikh-i Ferishta*, in Briggs’s translation
- The *Adi Granth* (Guru Granth Sahib) as a primary document of the period, and standard scholarly histories of the early Sikh community
- The surviving fabric of Rohtas Fort, Lahore Fort, and the sarais of the Grand Trunk Road
- Coins of Sher Shah and Akbar, for the currency reform
- Elliot and Dowson, *The History of India as Told by Its Own Historians*, for the translated Persian material
- Standard modern accounts of Humayun’s exile and return, the Sur administration, Akbar’s reign, and the north-west frontier campaigns

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: how far the water-carrier story at Chausa has been embroidered; the true size of the armies at Sirhind and at Panipat in 1556; whether Akbar struck Hemu or refused to; the exact number of Sher Shah's sarais; whether the Gakkhars and Khokhars are one people or two; the precise casualty figure at the Karakar Pass; and whether Akbar granted the land at Amritsar or it was purchased.

Two cautions in particular. First, Abul Fazl is the main source for most of Akbar's reign and he was writing to establish his friend's greatness. Where this part has relied on him for something flattering — the pardon of Bairam Khan, the grief over Birbal, the handing back of Kabul — it has said so. Badauni is the corrective, and he is prejudiced in the opposite direction.

Second, and more important: **the section on the Gurus draws on later Sikh tradition as well as on contemporary record, and the two have been kept apart on the page.** The building of Goindwal and Amritsar, the compilation of the Adi Granth in 1604 and its contents are documented. Akbar's visit to Goindwal is widely accepted; what was said there is tradition. This book treats devotional tradition with respect and does not present it as documentary evidence, and it will hold to that in Part Nine, where the stakes are considerably higher.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART NINE OF SIXTEEN

The Gurus and the Mughals

A hundred years in which the community of Part Eight acquires an army — and then does the one thing no power in this entire book has ever managed: it builds something that does not die when its leader does.

1605 — 1708

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Century Punjab Learns to Fight for Itself

Every part of this book so far has described somebody else's army fighting on Punjabi ground. This one is different, and it is different in a way that changes the rest of the series.

Part Eight ended in 1604 with a book being installed in a shrine at Amritsar, and with an emperor at Lahore who left the people who put it there alone.

He died in October 1605. Within eight months his successor had executed the man who compiled that book.

What follows is a century of intermittent, escalating conflict between the Mughal state and the Sikh community, running through five Gurus, three emperors and a great many other things that had nothing to do with either. **It ends in 1708 with the Punjab possessing something it has not had since the Shahis in Part Five: an army raised from its own population, fighting for its own reasons.**

Four things to hold on to

- **This is not the only war in the part, and this book is not going to pretend it is.** The Mughal empire in these years also lost armies in Central Asia and Afghanistan, failed three times at Kandahar, fought a savage war of succession, and was humiliated repeatedly on the north-west frontier — **all of it staged through the Punjab and paid for out of Punjabi revenue.** Those wars are in here too.
- **The fighting moves into the hills, and stays there.** Part Eight's rule — the hills preserve you and the hills imprison you — becomes the central military fact of this part. Anandpur, Bhangani, Nadaun and Chamkaur are all in the Siwalik foothills, and so is almost everything that matters.
- **The most important thing here is not a battle.** It is what happens at Anandpur in 1699, and then what happens at Chamkaur in 1704 and at Nanded in 1708 — three moments in which authority is deliberately moved out of one man and into an institution. **Nothing in the previous eight parts does this.** Every army in this book so far has dissolved when its commander went down.
- **And for the first time we can hear the other side.** Jahangir wrote about Guru Arjan in his own memoir. Guru Gobind Singh wrote about his own battles, and wrote a letter to Aurangzeb that survives. **This part has both emperors and their opponents describing the same events in the first person, and that has not been true anywhere in this book before.**

HOW THIS PART HANDLES A DIFFICULT SUBJECT

The conflict in these pages is between a Muslim empire and a religious community that was not Muslim, and it is used today, by people on several sides, to argue about things that have nothing to do with the seventeenth century. This book is going to try to be useful rather than comfortable, and that means three commitments.

The rule about sources applies evenly. Jahangir's memoir is a ruler explaining himself and is read as such. The Sikh devotional literature of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries is written to edify and is read as such. Where a claim rests on one and not the other, this part says so.

The empire is not treated as one thing. Akbar left this community alone; Jahangir executed a Guru and later travelled with the next one; Shah Jahan's officers fought four battles against a Guru and then left him in peace for a decade; Aurangzeb's policy was different again. **Four emperors, four different postures.** A story that flattens them into a single hostile block is not describing this century.

And the labels are used honestly. **CERTAIN**, **LIKELY**, **STORY** — including where a beloved tradition falls into the third category. That is not disrespect. It is the same standard applied to Alexander in Part Two and to Timur in Part Seven.

Lahore, 1606 — The Execution of Guru Arjan

CERTAIN

The emperor wrote down what he had done and why, in his own memoir, and the reasons he gives are the beginning of everything in this part.

WON BY Jahangir — and it produced the exact opposite of what he intended

WHEN May or June 1606, a few months into the new reign.	WHERE Lahore, in custody.
WHO Guru Arjan, fifth Guru, compiler of the Adi Granth, on the orders of the emperor Jahangir.	THE EVIDENCE Jahangir's own <i>Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri</i>; a Jesuit letter written from Lahore the same year; and Sikh tradition.

What Jahangir says

This is one of the very few events in this book where the man who ordered a killing explains it himself, in writing, without being asked. His memoir is unusually frank, and the passage on Guru Arjan is worth reading closely because everything about it is revealing.

He describes a Hindu at Goindwal on the Beas named Arjun, living in the manner of a religious teacher, who had built up a following over three or four generations. **He complains that too many people believed in him — and specifically that Muslims as well as Hindus were among them.** He calls it a shop of falsehood and says he had long intended either to end it or to bring the man into Islam.

Then he gives the immediate occasion. His son **Khusrau** had rebelled and fled towards the Punjab, and on the way had met the Guru, who — Jahangir says — treated him with favour and made a mark on his forehead.

He orders the Guru brought in, his property confiscated, and his execution.

THREE THINGS ABOUT THAT PASSAGE

First, it is a confession, not an accusation by enemies. This is not a hostile chronicler or a later tradition. It is the emperor's own account, and it is why the fact of the execution is labelled **CERTAIN** rather than argued about.

Second, the reasons he gives are mixed, and the mixture is the point. He names the Guru's growing following — including Muslim followers — as a standing grievance he had held for some time. He also names the meeting with the rebel prince as the trigger. **Historians have argued for a century about which mattered more**, and the honest answer is that Jahangir presents both and does not rank them.

Some historians add a third factor: a wealthy community with towns, a central shrine and an income from offerings is a fiscal and political fact as well as a religious one, and new emperors take an interest in such things.

Third, there is independent corroboration. A Jesuit priest at Lahore, **Jerome Xavier**, wrote a letter in 1606 describing the death of a Hindu holy man in the city under the new emperor. **A European clergyman with no stake in the argument, writing from the same city in the same year, is about as good as seventeenth-century evidence gets.**

The detailed traditions about the manner of the death, and about the role of a Lahore official named Chandu Shah, come from later Sikh sources and are not in the contemporary record. This book reports the fact and does not dwell on the details, which are contested and which no purpose is served by rehearsing.

WHY JAHANGIR DID IT

- **A new reign needs to look decisive.** He had been emperor for months, his son had just rebelled, and severity was the standard answer.
- **The rebel connection made it defensible.** Whatever happened between the Guru and Khusrau, it gave the order a political justification rather than a purely religious one.
- **He had inherited a grievance.** His own words say he had wanted to act for some time and had not.
- **And Akbar was dead.** The policy of leaving this community alone was Akbar's personal policy, and personal policies do not survive their author. Part Seven's lesson, in a new setting.

WHY IT WAS A CATASTROPHIC MISCALCULATION

- **It made the succession the point.** The community did not scatter. It installed an eleven-year-old and kept going.
- **It converted a religious movement into a political one.** Before 1606 this community had no reason to arm. Afterwards it had a very specific one.
- **It created a category that did not exist before.** The concept of martyrdom in defence of the faith becomes central to Sikh identity from this moment, and it is the emperor who supplies it.
- **And it did not remove anything.** The book was already compiled and installed. The shrine was built. The organisation was in place. **He killed the man and left the institution standing** — which is exactly the mistake this book has watched empires make since Part Three.

The Instruction Left for a Boy

Sikh tradition records that before his arrest, Guru Arjan sent word to his son about how the succession was to be conducted — and that the instruction was that he should sit fully armed upon the throne, and maintain an army to the best of his ability.

The wording comes from later Sikh sources rather than from any contemporary document, and this book labels it accordingly: **STORY**. Whether those words were said in 1606 cannot be established.

What can be established is that this is precisely what happened.

Guru Hargobind was eleven years old. At his installation he did not take up only the items his predecessors had used. **He put on two swords**, and gave them names — *miri* and *piri*, the temporal and the spiritual — and the meaning was not subtle and was not meant to be. He began keeping horses. He accepted weapons and riders as offerings where his predecessors had accepted money. Within a few years there was a fort at Amritsar and a building facing the Harmandir Sahib from which secular decisions would be taken.

So the tradition may be a later community explaining its own turning point to itself in the form of a dying instruction. Traditions often are. **But the turn is real, it is dated, and its cause is not in dispute: it is a direct response to what happened at Lahore in 1606.**

Jahangir's memoir records the removal of a religious teacher who had attracted too many followers.

What the order actually produced was an eleven-year-old with two swords and a hundred and two more years of this.

The Two Swords — Guru Hargobind Builds an Army, 1606–1620s

LIKELY

A shrine had been built to be walked down into. Facing it, they now built a platform to be sat upon — and the difference between those two buildings is the whole of this part.

WON BY

Nobody — this is a decade of preparation, and one long imprisonment

WHEN

1606 onwards; the imprisonment at Gwalior falls somewhere between about 1609 and 1619.

WHERE

Amritsar, and the fortress of Gwalior.

WHO

Guru Hargobind, sixth Guru, installed at eleven.

THE EVIDENCE

The buildings, later Sikh sources, and the fact that Mughal officers were fighting his men by the 1620s or 1630s.

What was built

1. **The Akal Takht.** Facing the Harmandir Sahib across the tank, a raised platform and building was constructed — the *Akal Takht*, the Throne of the Timeless One. **The architecture is an argument.** The shrine is set below ground level so that you walk down to it, in humility. The Akal Takht is raised, so that authority is exercised from it. Worship in one; decisions in the other.
2. **The two swords.** *Miri* and *piri* — worldly authority and spiritual authority, worn together. The doctrine that the two cannot be separated dates from here, and it is the theological foundation for everything that follows in this part.
3. **A fort. Lohgarh** — the iron fort — was built at Amritsar. A religious centre with a fortification is a different kind of place.
4. **Horses and men.** Followers were asked for horses and weapons rather than only for money, and a body of mounted retainers was maintained. The numbers in later sources should be treated with caution; the existence of the force should not.
5. **And the drums.** A war-drum was installed and beaten at the Akal Takht — a public announcement in the most literal available form.

Gwalior

At some point in Jahangir's reign — the dating is genuinely uncertain and the sources disagree by as much as a decade — **Guru Hargobind was imprisoned in the fortress of Gwalior**, which the Mughals used for political detainees.

He was released. Sikh tradition holds that he refused to leave unless the rajas imprisoned with him were freed too, that a condition was set allowing out only those who could hold on to his cloak, and that a garment with many tails was made so that all of them could. **The number given is fifty-two.** The release is commemorated as *Bandi Chhor Divas*, the day of the release of prisoners, and coincides with Diwali.

HANDLE WITH CARE — AND NOTICE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The cloak story is **STORY**. It appears in later Sikh sources, not in contemporary record, and the number fifty-two has the shape of a remembered figure rather than a counted one.

The imprisonment itself is accepted; the reason for it is not recorded anywhere reliable. Suggestions range from unpaid fines levied on his father's estate to official unease about the fort and the armed following. Nobody knows.

And here is the part that complicates every simple version of this century. **After the release, the relationship between Jahangir and Guru Hargobind was not hostile.** The sources describe them on reasonable terms, with the Guru accompanying the emperor on travels including to Kashmir. There were no battles in Jahangir's reign after the release.

The same emperor executed the fifth Guru and travelled with the sixth. **Any account of this century that cannot hold both those facts is selling you something.**

WHY THE COMMUNITY COULD ARM AT ALL

- **It had an organisation already.** Part Eight built the districts, the representatives and the system of offerings. Turning offerings into horses is an administrative change, not a revolution.
- **It had a defensible location.** Amritsar was its own town, built by the community, not a quarter of somebody else's city.
- **Its population were farmers.** The Jat peasantry of the doabs joining the community in growing numbers brought with them exactly the horses, the physical hardiness and the tradition of local self-defence that an army needs.
- **And the state was distracted.** Jahangir's reign was consumed by the Deccan, by Kandahar and by his own succession.

WHAT ARMING COST

- **It made the community a military question.** A religious movement can be ignored; a fort cannot.
- **It divided opinion inside the community.** Not everyone thought the two swords followed from Guru Nanak, and rival claimants to the succession made exactly that argument.
- **It put them on a collision course with the local administration,** which is War Three.
- **And it could not match the empire.** A few thousand horsemen against the largest army in the world is not a strategy. It is a way of surviving until the hills.

Two Buildings, Fifty Yards Apart

Stand at Amritsar and look at what was built there in eighty years, because the whole argument of this part is visible in the stonework.

The Harmandir Sahib was completed under Guru Arjan by about 1589. It sits in the middle of a tank, and it is built *below* the level of the surrounding ground, so that a visitor descends to reach it. It has doors on all four sides. Both features are deliberate and both are statements: you come down to it rather than climbing up, and it is open from every direction.

The Akal Takht was built facing it from about 1606, and it is raised. It is a throne — the word is in the name. From it, decisions binding on the community are announced. A war-drum was beaten there.

Fifty yards apart, across water: a building you go down into, and a building you look up at.

That is the doctrine of the two swords rendered in brick, and it was put up within a couple of years of the execution at Lahore. It says that a community which will not defend itself will not survive to worship, and that the people who make the second decision must be the same people who make the first.

Every ruler in the previous eight parts of this book combined temporal and spiritual authority as a matter of course — Ashoka carving moral instruction on pillars, Mahmud collecting titles from the caliph, Akbar making himself the final arbiter in religious disputes. **What is new here is not the combination. It is that the combination is being asserted by people with no state, no throne and no army worth the name, against an empire that had both.**

Within thirty years, Mughal detachments were fighting them. Within a hundred, the Punjab had an army of its own.

The Four Battles of Guru Hargobind, 1628–1635

LIKELY

Four engagements over about seven years, all of them small, all of them won — and then the Guru moved into the hills and the fighting stopped for sixty years.

WON BY Guru Hargobind — in every one, and it changed nothing strategically

WHEN Between about 1628 and 1635. The dates are disputed and some sources place the first as early as 1628 and others as late as 1634.	WHERE Amritsar; Lahira near Mehraj in the Malwa country; Kartarpur in the Jalandhar doab; and Palahi near Phagwara.
WHO Guru Hargobind against local Mughal commanders under Shah Jahan.	THE EVIDENCE Later Sikh sources, chiefly. Contemporary Mughal records say very little, which is itself informative.

What happened

1. **Amritsar**. The traditional account has the fighting begin over a hunting hawk — a bird belonging to an imperial hunting party seized by the Guru’s men, or the reverse, depending on the version. A force under a commander the sources name as Mukhlis Khan was sent and was beaten.
2. **Lahira, near Mehraj**. The occasion in the tradition is horses: two fine animals bound for the imperial stables, taken and then recovered by a follower named **Bidhi Chand**, whose exploits are among the best-loved stories in the community. A Mughal force under Lalla Beg was defeated in the Malwa country south of the Sutlej.
3. **Kartarpur**. Fought against a force that included **Painde Khan** — a Pathan who had been raised in the Guru’s own household and had gone over to the other side. He was killed in the fighting, and the traditional accounts of his death are notably not triumphant.
4. **Palahi, near Phagwara**. The last of them, fought on the withdrawal.
5. **And then he left**. Guru Hargobind moved north-east to **Kiratpur**, in the Siwalik foothills, in territory belonging to a hill raja rather than to the empire. There were no further battles in his lifetime, and none for the next sixty years.

WHY THESE BATTLES ARE LABELLED LIKELY AND NOT CERTAIN

Almost everything we know about them comes from Sikh sources written considerably later — the *Gurbilas* literature and the nineteenth-century compilations — which are devotional works composed to inspire. They give the hawk and the horses, the named commanders, the numbers and the heroics.

Contemporary Mughal chronicles barely mention any of it. That silence is not evidence that nothing happened. Court histories record what an emperor's officials wanted recorded, and a local commander beaten by a religious leader's retainers in a Punjab village is not a thing anybody writes to Delhi about with enthusiasm. The Punjab produced dozens of such affrays a decade and almost none of them are in the imperial record.

So the honest position is this. **That armed clashes took place between Guru Hargobind's followers and Mughal detachments in this period is accepted by historians and is consistent with everything else we know** — the fort, the horsemen, the move to the hills afterwards. **The details, the causes and the dates come from a tradition rather than from a record**, and they are held here at arm's length in exactly the way this book has held Kalhana in Part Four and the *Prithviraj Raso* in Part Six.

WHY THE GURU'S MEN WON

- **These were small engagements against local forces.** A provincial commander with a few hundred men, not an imperial army.
- **They fought on their own ground.** Their own town, their own villages, their own countryside, with the population on their side.
- **Motivation is not evenly distributed.** Troops sent to deal with an irritant fight differently from men defending their own place.
- **And they had cavalry.** The Jat peasantry of the doabs supplied horses and riders who did not need training in how to sit on one.

WHY WINNING DID NOT HELP

- **The empire could always send more.** Four victories against local detachments do not change the arithmetic against a state with a million men under arms.
- **Amritsar could not be held.** A town on an open plain, forty miles from Lahore. The oldest lesson in this book.
- **So he went to the hills.** Kiratpur was outside the imperial administration, in a raja's territory, in country that cavalry cannot operate in — which bought sixty years.
- **And the hills imprison as well as preserve.** Part Eight's rule. From Kiratpur you are safe and you are also irrelevant, and everything that happens for the next two generations happens because of that trade.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Was Raised in the House

Of the four battles, the one that the tradition dwells on is Kartarpur, and it is not because of the tactics.

Painde Khan was a Pathan. By the accounts, he had been brought up in Guru Hargobind's own household, trained there, treated as family, and had fought on the Guru's side in earlier engagements. He was, in the versions that survive, an enormous and formidable man of whom the Guru was fond.

He quarrelled, left, and came back at the head of the other side's troops.

The tradition has them meet in the fighting. Painde Khan is killed. And then — this is the part that has kept the story alive for four hundred years — **the Guru is described as shading the dying man's face from the sun with his shield, and speaking to him.**

Take the scene as devotional literature, because that is what it is; nobody was taking notes.

But notice what a community chooses to remember about its own victories, because that is a historical fact even when the scene is not. Of four battles won, the one preserved in most detail is the one where the enemy was somebody they had loved, and the remembered image is not the killing blow but the shield held up against the sun.

This book has spent eight parts reading victory literature — Persian court histories counting the dead, Sanskrit inscriptions cataloguing subdued kings, Timur's memoirs explaining a massacre as administration. **The genre is not usually like this.**

Balkh and Kandahar, 1646–1653 — The Wars the Punjab Paid For

LIKELY

Shah Jahan spent seven years and an enormous fortune trying to take countries beyond the passes, and got none of them. Every rupee and every soldier went through the Punjab.

WON BY The Uzbeks and the Persians — without ever fighting a major battle

WHEN 1646–1647 Balkh and Badakhshan; 1649, 1652 and 1653 the three sieges of Kandahar.	WHERE Beyond the Hindu Kush, and at Kandahar — staged from Lahore and Kabul the whole way.
WHO Shah Jahan, with his sons Murad, Aurangzeb and Dara Shukoh commanding in turn.	THE EVIDENCE The Mughal court histories, which record the expenditure with painful precision.

Why they went

Because the Mughals never stopped thinking of themselves as a Central Asian family in exile. **Babur had lost Samarkand three times and taken India as second best** — Part Seven made the point, and it did not go away. Shah Jahan’s ancestral homeland was Transoxiana, and when Uzbek politics fell into disorder in the 1640s the chance to recover it looked real.

Kandahar was a different matter and a more practical one. It sits on the road between Persia and India and had changed hands between Mughals and Safavids repeatedly. It was lost in 1649 and Shah Jahan wanted it back.

What happened

1. **Balkh and Badakhshan were taken in 1646** with relatively little difficulty, and Aurangzeb was installed at Balkh.
2. **And then it became clear that they could not be held.** The country was hostile, the Uzbeks would not fight a decisive battle and would not stop raiding, and supplying an army across the Hindu Kush from India is a proposition that has defeated everybody who has attempted it.
3. **The withdrawal in 1647 was the disaster.** The army came back over the passes late in the season and was caught by winter in the mountains. The accounts describe men and animals dying in the snow in large

numbers. **Everything gained was abandoned within about two years, and the cost is recorded in the court histories in figures that made contemporaries wince.**

4. **Kandahar was besieged three times** — in 1649 under Aurangzeb, in 1652 under Aurangzeb again, and in 1653 under Dara Shukoh with an even larger army and a siege train.
5. **All three failed.** The fortress was strong, the Persians were competent, and Mughal siege artillery could not reduce it before the supply situation forced a withdrawal.

WHY THIS IS IN A BOOK ABOUT THE PUNJAB

Because of what an army is, logistically, before it is anything else.

Every one of these expeditions was assembled, supplied and paid for through the Punjab. The troops concentrated at Lahore. The grain came from the Punjab doabs. The transport animals were bought here. The revenue that funded seven years of failure was drawn substantially from these districts, because the Punjab was one of the wealthiest and best-assessed provinces the Mughals had — Part Eight's *Ain-i-Akbari* tables show exactly how much.

And when armies came back broken, they came back through here.

This is the cost that never appears in a battle account. A province that stages an empire's wars pays for them in requisitioned grain, in commandeered carts and bullocks, in men taken for the transport train, and in the ordinary inflation that follows a large army sitting in your district for a season.

Nobody wrote it down, because nobody has ever written that down. But when Part Ten describes a Punjab that collapses with startling speed in the eighteenth century, the answer starts here — **with seventy years of an empire spending this province on wars in the Deccan, in Central Asia and at Kandahar, and getting nothing back.**

WHY THE MUGHALS FAILED BEYOND THE PASSES

- **Supply across the Hindu Kush is close to impossible.** Every army in this book that has tried it has been destroyed by geography rather than by an enemy.
- **The Uzbeks refused a decisive battle.** There was nothing to defeat, only country to occupy — the problem the Salt Range people posed to Sher Shah in Part Eight, at national scale.
- **Kandahar was too strong for the artillery of the day,** and sieges have a clock: the food runs out before the walls come down.
- **And they were fighting for sentiment.** Balkh was an ancestral homeland, not a strategic necessity. Wars fought for feelings tend to be expensive.

WHAT IT COST

- **The treasury.** Contemporaries and modern historians agree the sums were enormous and that nothing was gained.
- **The army's reputation.** Three failures at one fortress in five years is noticed by everybody on the frontier, and remembered.
- **The frontier settlement.** The Pashtun tribes drew their own conclusions about Mughal invincibility, and War Six is what came of it.
- **And the succession.** Dara Shukoh's failure at Kandahar in 1653 damaged him badly at court, and Aurangzeb made sure it was remembered.

The Return Over the Passes

The Balkh campaign is barely known outside specialist history and it deserves better, because it is the clearest demonstration in this book of a thing this whole series keeps circling.

In 1646 a Mughal army crossed the Hindu Kush and took Balkh — the ancient Bactria of Part Three, the country the Kushans came from, the province Seleucus signed away in 303 BCE. Aurangzeb, then a prince in his late twenties, was installed as its governor. On paper, the family had recovered its homeland.

He was there for a few months, and what he learned in them shaped a fifty-year reign. The revenue did not cover the garrison. The Uzbeks would not fight and would not leave. The country was not conquered so much as stood upon.

By late 1647 the decision was taken to withdraw, and the withdrawal was made too late in the year.

The army came back over the passes in winter. The court histories, which had every reason to minimise it, describe men and horses lost in the snow and the survivors arriving at Kabul in a condition nobody wanted to record in detail.

Now put it beside the other returns over those passes in this book. **Genghis Khan turned back from India in Part Six partly because of the climate. Timur's grandson lost his cavalry to the Punjab monsoon in Part Seven. A British army retreating from Kabul in 1842 will be destroyed in the same country.**

The mountains between the Punjab and Central Asia have killed more soldiers than any general in these sixteen parts. They funnel every invasion of India down one road, and they destroy every army that tries to go back up it at the wrong time of year. Nobody has ever solved them, and the empires that keep trying keep paying for it out of the province at their foot.

The War of Succession, 1657–1659

— Dara Shukoh’s Last Road

LIKELY

The heir to the Mughal empire lost it in two battles and then spent a year running through the Punjab and Sindh, and the road he took is the road every fugitive in this book takes.

WON BY

Aurangzeb — the last Mughal succession decided cleanly, and the most destructive

WHEN Shah Jahan falls ill in September 1657 ; Dara Shukoh is executed in August 1659 .	WHERE Samugarh and Deorai — and then Lahore, Multan, Bhakkar and the road to the Bolan.
WHO Dara Shukoh , the eldest son and designated heir, against his brother Aurangzeb .	THE EVIDENCE Mughal chronicles, and the account of François Bernier , a French physician who was in India and travelled with Dara’s camp.

What happened

1. **Shah Jahan fell ill in 1657** and the four brothers — Dara, Shuja, Aurangzeb and Murad — went to war before anybody knew whether he would live. He did, and watched the rest of it from confinement.
2. **Samugarh, 1658.** Aurangzeb and Murad destroyed Dara’s army near Agra. Dara fled.
3. **He came to the Punjab.** Lahore was his province and its revenue and troops were his best remaining asset. He held it briefly, raised what he could, and could not hold it — Aurangzeb’s forces came up the Grand Trunk Road.
4. **Then Multan, then Sindh.** Down the same road that every beaten claimant in this book has taken since Humayun in Part Eight: Lahore, Multan, the Indus, and then out.
5. **He tried Gujarat and Rajasthan,** raised another army, and was beaten again at **Deorai** near Ajmer in 1659.
6. **And then he was betrayed.** Fleeing towards Persia through the Bolan country, exhausted and with his family, he was taken in by an Afghan chief named Malik Jiwan whose life he had once saved, and who handed him over.

7. **He was paraded through Delhi on a filthy elephant** — Bernier describes the crowds and their reaction — condemned on a charge of apostasy, and executed in August 1659.

WHO DARA SHUKOH WAS, AND WHY THE PUNJAB REMEMBERS HIM

He was a scholar as much as a prince. He studied Hindu philosophy seriously, associated with Sufis and with the Hindu ascetics of Benares, and **commissioned and worked on a Persian translation of the Upanishads** which he called *Sirr-i-Akbar*, the Greatest Secret. He wrote a book arguing that Hindu and Muslim mystical traditions were describing the same reality, and gave it a title that means *the meeting-place of the two oceans*.

That translation had a strange afterlife. It reached Europe in the eighteenth century by way of a Latin version, and was read by German philosophers who had no other access to the Upanishads at all.

The charge on which he was condemned was apostasy, and the intellectual work was cited against him.

Sikh tradition also records a connection: that when Dara was ill, **Guru Har Rai** — the seventh Guru, at Kiratpur — supplied a rare medicine from his stores. Whether it happened is not documented outside the tradition. What is documented is that Aurangzeb afterwards summoned the Guru to account for himself, and that the Guru sent his elder son **Ram Rai** instead — who altered a line of scripture to make it inoffensive to the emperor, and was disowned by his father for it.

That disinheritance matters more than it looks. It established, at the highest possible cost, that the words in the book were not negotiable to please a ruler — and the rival line it created would trouble the community for a century.

WHY AURANGZEB WON

- **He was the better soldier by a wide margin.** Years of command in the Deccan and at Kandahar against Dara's court career.
- **He made alliances and discarded them.** Murad was used to win Samugarh and imprisoned afterwards.
- **He moved fast and did not stop.** Two years from his father's illness to his brother's execution.
- **And he had a simpler case.** Orthodoxy against a prince who had translated the Upanishads was an argument that wrote itself at court.

WHY DARA LOST

- **He had never commanded successfully.** Kandahar in 1653 was his one great independent command and it failed publicly.
- **He kept the throne and lost the army.** Being at court with his father meant patronage; it did not mean loyal regiments.
- **He fled instead of consolidating.** After Samugarh he had Lahore, a province, a treasury and troops — and left rather than fight for it.
- **And he trusted the wrong man at the end,** which is how nearly every fugitive in this book finishes.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Road That Only Goes One Way

Trace the route of a defeated claimant in this book and it is always, without exception, the same route.

Humayun in 1540 loses at Kannauj, falls back on Lahore, argues with his brothers, and goes down through Multan into Sindh and out. **Dara Shukoh in 1658** loses at Samugarh, falls back on Lahore, cannot hold it, and goes down through Multan into Sindh and out. A hundred and eighteen years apart, the same four place-names in the same order.

And it is older than either of them. **Khusrau Malik, the last Ghaznavid, was cornered at Lahore in Part Six. Daulat Khan Lodi was run down in the Punjab in Part Seven. Sikandar Shah Suri went into the Siwaliks in Part Eight.**

The reason is geography and it is completely mechanical. **If you lose in the Ganges plain, the Punjab is the only direction with a road, a friendly province and a way out of India at the end of it.** So everyone goes there. And the Punjab, which had nothing to do with the quarrel, gets the losing army, the pursuing army, and the requisitions of both.

Only one man in this book ever comes back up that road: Humayun, after fifteen years, and it takes a Persian army to do it.

For everyone else, the road through Lahore and Multan is where their story ends — and the province spends four centuries being the corridor along which other people's defeats are conducted.

The Khapash Pass, 1672 — The Frontier Burns Again

LIKELY

A Mughal army was destroyed in a defile north-west of the Punjab for the second time in a century, and the emperor came to Hasan Abdal and spent a year and a half trying to fix it.

WON BY The Afridis — and the tribes were never subdued, only paid

WHEN 1672, with the Yusufzai revolt of 1667 before it and Aurangzeb at Hasan Abdal in 1674–1675.	WHERE The Khyber country and the passes — and the imperial headquarters at Hasan Abdal in the Punjab.
WHO The Afridi and allied tribes against Mughal armies under Muhammad Amin Khan and others.	THE EVIDENCE Mughal court histories, which do not enjoy this subject.

What happened

1. **The frontier had been simmering since the 1660s.** The Yusufzai rose in 1667 and were put down with difficulty.
2. **In 1672 the Afridis rose,** under a leader the sources call Akmal Khan, and closed the Khyber.
3. **A large Mughal force under the governor of Kabul went in to clear it** — and was caught in a defile the sources call the Khapash Pass, with the tribes above it.
4. **It was destroyed.** The figures given run to many thousands killed and enormous numbers of prisoners and animals taken. The governor escaped with a fraction of his men.
5. **A second force met a similar fate the following year.**
6. **So the emperor came in person.** In 1674 Aurangzeb moved to **Hasan Abdal**, in the Punjab north-west of Rawalpindi, and stayed about a year and a half directing the campaign.
7. **And what worked was not a battle.** It was roads, forts, garrisons, negotiation and, above all, **subsidies** — payments to tribal leaders to keep the passes open. The frontier was quieted by being bought.

THE SAME PASS, STILL FOREVER

Part Eight described the destruction of Raja Birbal's column in the Karakar Pass in 1586 and said that the same thing happens to every regular army that enters this country. Eighty-six years later, it happened again, to a bigger army, in the same way, for the same reasons.

A column strung out on a mountain track. Tribes on the heights. No way to form, deploy or manoeuvre. Destruction along the whole length of the line.

Akbar's answer after 1586 had been roads, forts and payments. Aurangzeb's answer after 1672 was roads, forts and payments. **The British answer after their own disasters in the same passes would be roads, forts and payments.**

Three empires, three centuries, one conclusion, arrived at independently each time after losing an army to learn it.

And notice where the emperor sat while he worked it out. **Hasan Abdal is in the Punjab.** For a year and a half in the 1670s, the Mughal empire was again being run from this province, for exactly the same reason it had been run from Lahore in the 1580s: because the frontier was on fire and the only way to manage it was to be near it.

WHY THE TRIBES COULD NOT BE BEATEN

- **They chose the ground every time.** A defile removes every advantage a regular army has.
- **There was nothing to capture.** No capital, no army, no treasury — the same problem the Gakkhars posed to Sher Shah and the Khokhars posed to everybody.
- **They only had to close the passes.** The empire had to keep them open, which is far harder.
- **And they could be bought, which is not the same as being beaten.**

WHAT IT COST THE EMPIRE

- **Two armies and several years.** At a moment when the Deccan war was already consuming everything.
- **The emperor's presence.** Eighteen months at Hasan Abdal is eighteen months not spent anywhere else, and the Deccan and the Punjab both drifted while he was there.
- **A permanent subsidy.** The payments to the tribes became a standing charge that no later government has ever managed to stop paying.
- **And it emptied the north.** With the field army committed to the frontier and then to the Deccan, the Punjab's own policing was left to provincial officers — which matters a great deal for everything after 1699.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Where the Emperor Was Standing

In 1674 and 1675, Aurangzeb was at Hasan Abdal in the Punjab, running a frontier war that had already eaten two armies.

He was not a young man; he had been on the throne for sixteen years. He had a rebellion in the north-west, an unfinished war in the Deccan that would eventually consume the last twenty-five years of his life, and an empire that on paper was the richest state on earth and in practice was being spent faster than it could be collected.

And in November 1675, while he was still dealing with the aftermath, **a religious teacher from the Punjab hills was executed at Delhi on his orders.**

That is War Seven, and the point of putting them side by side is this. **From inside the imperial administration, the second event was very much smaller than the first.** The frontier had destroyed armies. The Deccan was a war without end. A Guru in Delhi was a provincial matter, disposed of in a paragraph, if that.

Three hundred and fifty years later, almost nobody outside specialist history has heard of the Khapash Pass. **The execution at Delhi is commemorated by a gurdwara at the site, by another where the body was cremated, and by millions of people every year.**

This book has said it in every part and it is never truer than here: **the winner is whoever gets written about** — but the corollary is that the winner does not get to decide which of his own decisions turns out to have been the important one.

Delhi, 1675 — The Execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur

LIKELY

The ninth Guru was executed in a public square in Delhi, and the reason recorded in the Sikh tradition is one that has almost no parallel anywhere in this book.

WON BY Aurangzeb — and it produced a ten-year-old with a great deal of resolve

WHEN November 1675.	WHERE Chandni Chowk, Delhi. The Guru had come from Anandpur in the Punjab hills.
WHO Guru Tegh Bahadur, ninth Guru, and three companions executed with him.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, chiefly — including the <i>Bachittar Natak</i>, attributed to his son and written within a generation.

What the Sikh account says

Guru Tegh Bahadur had founded a town in the Siwalik foothills in 1665 on land bought from the raja of the local hill state. He called it **Chak Nanaki**, after his mother; it became **Anandpur**, and it is the centre of everything for the rest of this part.

The account preserved in the tradition is this. A delegation of **Kashmiri Brahmins** came to him at Anandpur, reporting forced conversions under the governor of Kashmir, and asked for help. He undertook their cause — and did so on the specific ground that people are entitled to their own faith, including a faith that was not his own.

He was arrested, taken to Delhi, and after some months given the choice of conversion or death. **Three companions — Bhai Mati Das, Bhai Sati Das and Bhai Dyala — were executed before him.** He was beheaded in Chandni Chowk.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SUPPORTS, STATED CAREFULLY

The execution is not in doubt. Two gurdwaras in Delhi mark the place of the death and the place of the cremation, and the event is fixed in Sikh memory with a precision that leaves no room for invention about whether it happened.

The cause is where the sources thin out. Mughal court chronicles of Aurangzeb's later reign are sparse on the whole subject — he had restricted official history-writing — and what survives says very little.

The nearest thing to a contemporary Sikh statement is the *Bachittar Natak*, a composition attributed to Guru Gobind Singh and written within a generation. It describes his father's death explicitly as a sacrifice made for the sake of others' right to their own religious marks and observances, and says that he gave his head and not his resolve. **That is a near-contemporary source from the closest possible witness, and it is why the Kashmiri Pandit account is accepted by most historians.**

Some historians add political factors — the size of the following at Anandpur, its revenue, official unease about a fortified centre in the hills, the rival claims of the disowned Ram Rai. Those may all have contributed. **They do not displace what the closest source says the reason was.**

What can be said without qualification is the shape of the thing, and the shape is genuinely unusual. **A religious leader of one community was executed after taking up the cause of a different community's right to practise its own faith.** This book has covered five thousand years and it does not have another case quite like it.

WHY THE STATE ACTED

- **Aurangzeb's religious policy had hardened.** The *jizya* was reimposed in 1679; temple demolitions were ordered in several provinces; the direction of travel was clear well before that.
- **A fortified centre with a following is a political fact.** Anandpur was in hill territory outside direct administration, and its growth was noticed.
- **The empire was overstretched and nervous.** A frontier war just finished, a Deccan war beginning, and revolts elsewhere.
- **And a public execution is meant to be seen.** Chandni Chowk is the busiest place in Delhi. That was the point.

WHY IT FAILED AS POLICY

- **The succession held again.** A nine-year-old was installed at Anandpur, exactly as an eleven-year-old had been installed in 1606.
- **It confirmed the argument.** The doctrine of the two swords holds that spiritual life cannot be maintained without the power to defend it. This was the demonstration.
- **It made the cause bigger than the community.** A death on behalf of another religion's freedom is not a sectarian grievance and cannot be dismissed as one.
- **And it produced Guru Gobind Singh,** who was nine years old when his father's head was brought back to the hills.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Argument in the Verse

There is a line of reasoning in the *Bachittar Natak* about this death which is worth setting out plainly, because it is the intellectual foundation of everything in the rest of this part and it is usually skipped over in favour of the drama.

The composition describes Guru Tegh Bahadur as having acted for the sake of people's right to their own religious observances — the sacred thread and the forehead mark, both specifically Hindu practices that had nothing to do with his own community's beliefs. **He is described as breaking his own body rather than his resolve, and giving his head without a sound of complaint.**

Read what that claims. It is not that his own faith was under attack, though it was. It is that **the right of anybody to practise their own religion is worth dying for, including when it is not your religion.**

Now measure that against the previous eight parts of this book.

Ashoka in Part Three renounced conquest and asked his descendants not to make war — the closest earlier parallel, and it is an emperor legislating from a position of total power. Akbar in Part Eight held debates between faiths and abolished the tax on non-Muslims — also an emperor, also from strength, and his policy died with him within months.

This is not that. This is a man with a small following in a hill town, with no army capable of anything, no state, no leverage and no protection, going to Delhi on behalf of people who were not his own and who could do nothing for him.

Whether every detail of the tradition is exact cannot be established. **What is established is that the closest source to the event, written within a generation by the man who had the most reason to know, says that was the reason — and that a community which could have chosen any explanation chose that one and has never chosen another.**

Bhangani, 1688 — The First Battle

LIKELY

The tenth Guru’s first battle was fought at twenty-one against a coalition of Hindu hill rajas, and it was a Muslim holy man from Sadhaura who came to fight on his side.

WON BY

Guru Gobind Rai — and he wrote the account himself

WHEN

September 1688.

WHERE

Bhangani, near Paonta on the Yamuna, in the Sirmur hills.

WHO

Guru Gobind Rai — later **Guru Gobind Singh** — against a coalition of hill rajas under **Fateh Shah of Garhwal**.

THE EVIDENCE

The *Bachittar Natak*, a first-person account attributed to the Guru himself. **Unusually good for this book.**

Why the hill rajas fought him

This is the fact that most retellings of this century get wrong, and it needs saying at the start. **Guru Gobind Singh’s first two decades of fighting were mostly not against the Mughal empire. They were against the Hindu rajas of the Siwalik hill states.**

The reasons were about power, not religion, and they were entirely ordinary. Anandpur and Paonta were growing. The Guru’s following was large, armed and expanding into country the rajas regarded as theirs. He accepted followers from every caste, which was corrosive to the social order the hill states were built on. And his presence disturbed the delicate arrangement by which those rajas paid tribute to the empire and were otherwise left alone.

He had moved to **Paonta**, on the Yamuna, under the protection of the Raja of Sirmur — who was in dispute with his neighbour of Garhwal. That neighbour assembled a coalition.

What happened

1. **A confederacy of hill rajas marched on Paonta**, led by Fateh Shah of Garhwal and joined by others including Bhim Chand of Kahlur, in whose territory Anandpur stood.
2. **Part of the Guru’s force deserted.** A body of Pathan mercenaries in his pay went over to the other side before the battle — the *Bachittar Natak* names them and does not soften it.

3. **And a Muslim holy man came to fight for him.** Pir **Buddhu Shah of Sadhaura** arrived with his sons and his followers and fought on the Guru's side. **Two of his sons were killed.**
4. **The battle was fought at Bhangani** and the coalition was broken.
5. **And the Guru wrote it down.** The *Bachittar Natak* gives a first-person account — who fought, who ran, who died, and the confusion of it — in verse.

WHY THE BACHITTAR NATAK MATTERS SO MUCH TO THIS BOOK

Stop and consider what this document is, against everything that has come before it in these nine parts.

It is a commander's own written account of his own battle, composed within his lifetime, in a language of the region, which survives.

Now count the alternatives this book has had to work with. Alexander's battles reached us through Greeks writing four hundred years later. Tarain was described by a Persian court historian in Delhi. Waihind was counted by al-Utbi for his employer. Timur's campaign comes through a text that may not be his. Mihirakula was written up by a Kashmiri poet six centuries afterwards. **In eight parts, the only comparable first-person military document is the *Baburnama* — and Babur was the invader.**

Here the man writing is defending his own ground, and he is writing in the Punjab about the Punjab.

It is not neutral — it is a devotional and autobiographical composition, in verse, by a religious leader, and its purpose is not the purpose of a modern battle report. **But it names the men who deserted him. It records that mercenaries in his pay changed sides. It does not pretend the fight was easy.** Court histories do not usually do those things.

WHY HE WON

- **He was defending, on ground he knew.** The hill country around Paonta, with the river behind the rajas' approach.
- **His people had a reason to fight.** A coalition of rajas assembling to remove a community is a clarifying event for that community.
- **The coalition was a coalition.** Several rajas, several agendas, no single command — the losing formation this book has now documented seven times.
- **And he had unexpected help.** Pir Buddhu Shah's men arrived when the Pathans left, and the arithmetic changed.

WHY THE RAJAS LOST

- **They were fighting a movement, not a rival.** Beating a raja settles a border; beating a community settles nothing.
- **They underestimated a twenty-one-year-old.** He had been Guru since the age of nine and had spent the intervening years preparing for exactly this.
- **Their own subjects were joining him.** Which is why they attacked, and also why they could not win.
- **And they would try again.** Repeatedly, for sixteen years, with the same result until they got the empire to do it for them.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Pir of Sadhaura

Of everything at Bhangani, the detail that deserves to be better known is who turned up.

Pir Buddhu Shah was a Muslim divine of Sadhaura, a town in the plains below the hills, with a following of his own. He had no obligation to the Guru, no shared religion, and nothing to gain. When the Pathan mercenaries deserted, he came with his sons, his brother and his followers, and fought.

Two of his sons were killed in the battle.

The tradition records that afterwards, when the Guru asked what he might give him, the Pir asked for a comb from the Guru's hair with some hairs still in it, and for his turban. That part is devotional tradition and this book marks it as such.

The rest is not in dispute, and it sits awkwardly across every simplified version of this century that anybody wants to tell.

At the first battle of the tenth Sikh Guru, the enemy was a coalition of Hindu rajas, the deserters were Muslim mercenaries in his own pay, and the ally who came unasked and lost two sons was a Muslim holy man.

Hold on to that when Part Ten and Part Eleven get bloodier, because it stops being obvious. The wars in this book divide along lines of power, land, revenue and fear far more often than along lines of faith — and when they do divide along faith, it is usually because somebody in authority found it useful.

Pir Buddhu Shah's own end is recorded as unhappy: the tradition holds that he was killed some years later on the orders of the local Mughal administration, for having helped the Guru.

Nadaun, 1691 — Fighting on the Rajas’ Side

LIKELY

Three years after the hill rajas tried to destroy him, the Guru fought a Mughal army alongside them — and then they went back to being his enemies.

WON BY

The hill rajas and the Guru together — and the alliance lasted about as long as the battle

WHEN 1691.	WHERE Nadaun, on the Beas in the Kangra hills.
WHO Guru Gobind Rai and Bhim Chand of Kahlur, against a Mughal force under Alif Khan.	THE EVIDENCE The <i>Bachittar Natak</i> again — the Guru’s own account.

What happened

1. **The hill rajas stopped paying tribute.** The Mughal governor of Jammu sent a commander named Alif Khan to collect it.
2. **Bhim Chand of Kahlur asked the Guru for help** — the same Bhim Chand who had marched against him at Bhangani three years earlier.
3. **And the Guru came.** He fought at Nadaun on the Beas alongside the rajas, and the *Bachittar Natak* describes the action, including his own part in it, in detail.
4. **The Mughal force was defeated** and withdrew.
5. **Then the rajas made terms with the empire anyway** and resumed paying, which is what hill states do.
6. **And within a few years they were his enemies again**, and would be for the rest of his life.

THE SHIFTING SIDES, AND WHY THEY SHIFTED

Nadaun is the clearest evidence in this part that the wars of the 1680s and 1690s in these hills were not a religious conflict, and it is worth setting out the ledger.

1688 at Bhangani: Hindu rajas attack the Guru; Muslim mercenaries desert him; a Muslim pir fights for him and loses two sons.

1691 at Nadaun: the Guru fights alongside the same Hindu rajas against a Mughal army.

1700 onwards at Anandpur: the same rajas besiege him, then ask the empire for troops, and Mughal and hill-state forces attack him together.

Three configurations in twelve years, involving the same handful of people.

What actually drove it was land, tribute, precedence and fear — the ordinary business of small states with a large neighbour and an inconvenient new power in the middle of them. Religion is present throughout, it matters to everyone involved, and it is not what determines who is on which side in any given year.

That is not a comfortable finding for anyone's preferred version, which is precisely why it belongs on the page.

WHY THE ALLIES WON

- **Hill country against a plains force**, for the fourth time in this book. Nadaun sits on a river in broken ground.
- **A tribute-collecting expedition is not a war.** Alif Khan came to enforce a payment, not to conquer, and such forces withdraw when the cost rises.
- **The Guru's men were the best troops on the field.** Trained, motivated and by now experienced.

WHY IT ACHIEVED NOTHING

- **The rajas settled immediately afterwards.** They wanted better terms, not independence, and a victory improved their bargaining position.
- **The Guru gained a reputation he could not use.** Being the best soldier in the hills made him more dangerous to his neighbours, not less.
- **And it put him in the imperial record.** A religious leader who beats a Mughal detachment in the field becomes an administrative problem with a name.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Twenty-Two Hill States and Not One Alliance

The Siwalik foothills between the Sutlej and the Ravi held a scatter of small kingdoms — Kahlur, Sirmur, Garhwal, Guler, Nurpur, Mandi, Kangra, Bilaspur and a dozen more. They had existed for centuries, they had their own dynasties, their own hill forts and some of the finest miniature painting produced anywhere in India.

And in this part they do nothing but change sides.

They fight the Guru, then fight beside him, then besiege him, then call in the empire, then break their own guarantees. They pay tribute to Delhi, stop paying, are made to pay again. Not one of them ever combines with the others into anything that could resist either the empire or the community growing in the middle of them.

This is the oldest failure in this entire book and it is now in its ninth appearance. Ten kings on the Ravi in Part One. The Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two, who combined and then could not agree on a commander. Nine republics submitting separately to Samudragupta in Part Four. Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five, which dissolved when one elephant bolted. Prithviraj's coalition at Tarain in Part Six. The Punjab powers of Part Seven — Khokhars, Langahs, Afghans — who never once made common cause.

Small states in this region do not federate. They bargain individually with whoever is strongest, and are eaten in sequence.

The hill states were absorbed by Ranjit Singh in Part Thirteen, one at a time, without much difficulty. By then they had been failing to combine for a very long time.

Anandpur, 1699 — The Khalsa

CERTAIN

Not a battle. The most consequential thing in this part, and one of the most consequential in the whole book.

WHAT CHANGED

Punjab acquires an army that is not a dynasty, a clan or a mercenary force

WHEN Vaisakhi, 1699.	WHERE Anandpur, in the Siwalik foothills above the Sutlej.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh and the community summoned to the town.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the observable fact that everything afterwards is different.

What was done

The Guru called the community to Anandpur for the spring festival and, before the assembly, asked for a head.

The account is that he asked for someone willing to give his life, took the man who came forward into a tent, and returned with a bloodied sword. He asked again. Five times in all, five men came forward, and after the fifth he brought all five out alive.

These five were the **Panj Pyare**, the Five Beloved. What they had in common was that they had volunteered. What they did not have in common is the point: **they came from different castes and different parts of India, including from groups that Indian society at the time treated as low.**

He then administered an initiation — *amrit*, prepared with water and sugar and stirred with a double-edged sword, with recitation — and established the order:

- The initiated took the name Singh, and women Kaur.** One name for everybody, replacing the surname that announced your caste. **This is not a symbolic gesture; a shared name in a caste society is a demolition.**
- They kept the five articles of faith** — uncut hair, comb, steel bracelet, prescribed undergarment and a blade — worn by everyone, which makes the member of the order visible and impossible to hide.
- They were bound by a code of conduct** that applied to all equally.

4. **And then the Guru asked the five to initiate him.** He received the rite from the men he had just created, on the same terms as anybody else.

WHAT IS DOCUMENTED AND WHAT IS TRADITION

The founding of the Khalsa in 1699 at Anandpur, the initiation, the names, the articles of faith and the code are established beyond dispute — they are the constitution of a community that has existed continuously since, and its practice is the evidence.

The dramatic details of the day — the tent, the sword, the five calls — come from Sikh sources rather than from any external record, and this book flags that in the same way it has flagged everything else. Nobody outside the community was writing it down.

What can be checked from outside is the effect. **Within a year, Mughal and hill-state forces were treating Anandpur as a military problem of a different order.** Within eleven years, an army raised from this order had taken Sirhind and was administering territory. Within a century it ruled the Punjab.

Something happened at Anandpur in 1699 that turned a religious community into a standing military force. **The mechanism is documented in its own constitution, and the results are visible in everybody else's records.**

WHY IT WORKED, MILITARILY

- **It removed caste from recruitment.** Every other Indian army in this book drew its fighting men from restricted groups. This one could recruit from the entire population, and did — overwhelmingly from the Jat peasantry, but formally from anybody.
- **Initiation is a commitment mechanism.** A man who has taken a rite, changed his name and put on visible articles he cannot remove has burned his boats. Deserting is not possible in the ordinary way.
- **It is voluntary.** Nobody is conscripted, levied or bought. Part Five's Ghaznavids ran on slave-soldiers; Part Seven's sultans on assignments of land revenue. **This runs on people who chose.**
- **And authority was distributed.** The Guru taking initiation from the five he created put the order above the man — which is the whole of War Twelve.

WHAT IT COST

- **Visibility.** The articles of faith make a member identifiable at a glance, which is an asset in a battle and a death sentence in a persecution. Part Ten is about that.
- **It split opinion inside the community.** Not everybody accepted the new order, and the divisions of the eighteenth century begin here.
- **It alarmed everybody outside it.** The hill rajas and the imperial administration both read it correctly as the creation of an army.
- **And the war started within a year.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Took the Oath From His Own Men

Go back through the previous nine parts and look for a founder who subordinated himself to the thing he founded.

Chandragupta built an empire and made it his family's. Ashoka carved his conscience on pillars and it died with him. Every Greek king in Part Three, every sultan in Parts Six and Seven, every Mughal in Part Eight — the state was the man, and the man was the state, and when he died it was fought over by his sons. **Part Eight counted five commanders who were winning a battle and lost it because they personally went down.** That is what happens when authority lives in one body.

At Anandpur in 1699, the Guru created an order, and then **knelt and received initiation into it from five men who had been ordinary members of the community that morning.**

Whatever else it was, that is a deliberate act of constitutional engineering. It says that the order is not his property. It says that its authority does not descend from him but is held collectively. And it establishes that the five, acting together, can bind him.

Five years later at Chamkaur, that provision was used, and it saved his life against his own wishes. Nine years later at Nanded he took it to its conclusion and ended personal Guruship altogether, vesting it in the book compiled in Part Eight.

This book has watched states, dynasties, empires and armies dissolve on the death of one man for three thousand years — the Nandas, Menander's kingdom, Harsha's empire, Yashodharman's alliance, Hemu's army, Jasrat's Punjab. It is the single most reliable failure mode in these sixteen parts.

In 1699, in a hill town on the Sutlej, somebody finally solved it.

The Sieges of Anandpur, 1700–1704

LIKELY

Four years of intermittent siege ended with a guarantee of safe passage, given on oath, and broken within hours.

WON BY The besiegers — by starvation and a promise they did not keep

WHEN Fighting from 1700; the final siege and evacuation in December 1704.	WHERE Anandpur and its ring of small forts in the Siwaliks.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh against the hill rajas and imperial forces under the faujdar of Sirhind.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources; some Mughal administrative record; the Zafarnama, the Guru’s own letter to Aurangzeb.

What happened

1. The hill rajas attacked first, from 1700, and were repeatedly beaten in the engagements around Anandpur and Nirmohgarh.
2. So they asked the empire in. Unable to remove him themselves, the rajas petitioned for imperial troops, and the governors of Sirhind and Lahore supplied them.
3. The final siege closed in 1704. Anandpur was invested by a combined force and cut off from supply. It lasted months.
4. Conditions inside became desperate. The accounts describe the food gone and the animals eaten. A number of the Guru’s followers left, and some formally renounced him in writing — a document called a bedava. Remember them; they come back in War Thirteen.
5. Terms were offered. The besiegers guaranteed safe passage if the town were evacuated — and, according to the Sikh accounts and to the Guru’s own later letter, swore to it on the Quran.
6. The evacuation began on a December night in rain, with the community strung out on the road.
7. And the guarantee was broken almost at once. The column was attacked on the march.
8. At the Sarsa river, in flood, the family was separated in the dark. The Guru and his two elder sons went one way with a small party. His mother and his two younger sons went another. Nothing after that is recoverable.

ON THE BROKEN OATH — AND ON THE ONE SOURCE THAT ANSWERS BACK

The breaking of the safe-conduct is central to how these events are remembered, and it is not only a later tradition. **The Guru wrote to Aurangzeb about it himself.**

The *Zafarnama* — a letter in Persian verse, sent about a year later and discussed in full in War Thirteen — accuses the emperor directly of an oath sworn on the Quran and broken, and asks what a man's word is worth if his sacred oath is not.

That is not a chronicler's accusation. It is a letter from the injured party to the person he holds responsible, and it survives.

Whether Aurangzeb personally authorised the guarantee, or whether it was given by commanders in the field who exceeded or ignored their orders, is genuinely disputed and cannot be settled here. Imperial armies in this period were commanded by provincial officers with wide discretion, and the emperor was two thousand kilometres away in the Deccan.

What is not disputed is that a guarantee was given, that the column was attacked on the road, and that the man it was given to wrote to the emperor and said so.

WHY THE BESIEGERS FINALLY SUCCEEDED

- **They stopped fighting and started waiting.** Four years of failed assaults, and then a blockade — the same lesson Akbar learned at Mankot in Part Eight.
- **They combined.** Hill rajas plus imperial troops, for once acting together, which the rajas alone had never managed.
- **A fort needs a field army behind it.** Part Five said this at Nandana in 1014 and it has not stopped being true. There was no relief and there was never going to be.
- **And the promise did the last of it.** A garrison that will not surrender to force may leave on terms — which is exactly why the terms were offered.

WHY HOLDING ANANDPUR WAS IMPOSSIBLE

- **It was a town, not a fortress.** A religious centre with defences, holding a civilian population including families.
- **The hills feed nobody.** Part Eight's rule again — you cannot be finished there and you cannot supply an army there.
- **No allies, anywhere.** The rajas were the besiegers and the empire was behind them.
- **And the community inside was not an army.** It was a population, and populations starve first.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Crossing of the Sarsa

The Sarsa is not a large river. In December, in an ordinary year, it is not much of an obstacle at all.

On the night the evacuation reached it, it was in flood, it was raining, it was dark, and there was a Mughal force behind them on the road.

What happened at that crossing is the hinge of the whole part, and it happened in about an hour, in confusion, with nobody in control of it.

The community was cut into pieces at the water. Some got across, some did not, some drowned. Baggage was lost — including, by the accounts, manuscripts. The Guru crossed with a small party and his two elder sons, **Ajit Singh**, seventeen, and **Jujhar Singh**, fourteen. His mother, **Mata Gujri**, crossed separately with the two younger boys, **Zorawar Singh** and **Fateh Singh**, who were about nine and six.

Neither group knew where the other had gone.

Within a week, everything that happens in Wars Twelve and Thirteen had happened, and by the end of December 1704 **all four of his sons and his mother were dead.**

This book has described a great many disasters. What makes this one different is that it was not a battle and nobody planned it. **A river came up, in the dark, at the worst possible moment, and separated a family that would never be in the same place again.**

Every account of these events — devotional, scholarly, hostile — agrees on this much. And it is the reason the winter of 1704 occupies the place it does in the memory of the Punjab: not because of the tactics, but because of what an ordinary flooded stream did to a group of people who were already walking away from everything they had.

Chamkaur, December 1704

LIKELY

Forty men in a mud house against an army — and the most important thing that happened there was an order the Guru did not want to obey.

WON BY The imperial force — which took the house and lost the person it came for

WHEN December 1704, within days of the Sarsa crossing.	WHERE Chamkaur, on the plain below the hills, near the Sutlej.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh and about forty Sikhs, against a pursuing imperial force.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the <i>Zafarnama</i>, which describes it in the Guru’s own words.

What happened

1. **They took shelter in a mud-walled house** — a *garhi*, a fortified compound of the ordinary Punjabi kind, belonging to a local family. It was not a fortress. It had walls and a gate.
2. **The pursuing force surrounded it.** The numbers in the sources are very large and are the usual sort; what is not in question is that the disproportion was extreme.
3. **The Sikhs went out in small parties to fight.** A few at a time, out of the gate, into the surrounding force. This is what you do when you cannot hold and cannot escape: you make the taking of the place expensive.
4. **Ajit Singh, seventeen, went out and was killed.**
5. **Jujhar Singh, fourteen, asked to go, and went, and was killed.**
6. **And then the surviving Sikhs ordered the Guru to leave.**
7. **He went.** With two or three companions, at night, through the encircling force, and escaped into the country to the west.

THE ORDER — AND WHY IT IS THE MOST IMPORTANT MOMENT IN THIS PART

Read carefully what the accounts describe, because it is easy to skim past as a devotional detail and it is not one.

Five of the surviving Sikhs constituted themselves as the Panj Pyare — the five, acting collectively, in the form established at Anandpur in 1699 — **and issued a command to the Guru to leave the position.**

He did not want to go. The accounts are consistent about that. He went because, under the constitution he had himself created five years earlier, **the five acting together could bind him, and he had accepted initiation from them on those terms.**

Now put that beside the previous nine parts of this book.

Porus's elephants turn and his army is destroyed. Anandapala's elephant bolts and eight centuries of Indian coalition-building dissolve in ten minutes. Muhammad of Ghor is wounded at Tarain and his army runs. Qutlugh Khwaja is hit at Kili and a full invasion goes home. Hemu takes an arrow at Panipat while winning, and loses.

Five commanders, five armies, one failure mode: *authority lived in one man's body and could not survive it.*

At Chamkaur, in a mud house, with his two elder sons dead outside the gate, **the machinery built to solve that problem was operated — and it worked.** The institution overruled the leader, the leader complied, and both the institution and the leader survived the night.

It is the single most consequential thing that happens in these hundred years, and it happens in a farmyard.

WHY THE IMPERIAL FORCE TOOK THE POSITION

- **Numbers, against a mud wall.** There was never any doubt about the outcome of the siege itself.
- **They had the pursuit right.** Catching a scattered party days after the Sarsa was competent soldiering.
- **And there was no relief.** Nobody in the Punjab was coming.

WHY IT WAS NOT THE VICTORY THEY NEEDED

- **They came for one man and did not get him.** Everything else was incidental to that objective, and it failed.
- **They gave the community its founding memory.** Forty against an army, in a mud house, is the kind of thing that gets remembered for three hundred years — and has been.
- **The order survived the battle.** The Khalsa was not at Chamkaur. It was scattered across the Punjab, and it still existed on the morning of the 23rd.
- **And within six years an army raised from it took Sirhind.** Which is Part Ten.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Ghani Khan and Nabi Khan

After Chamkaur the Guru was alone in open country in December, hunted, with an imperial administration searching every road.

The tradition records that he was sheltered near **Machhiwara** — a name you have seen already in this book, because Bairam Khan won a battle there in 1555 that refounded the Mughal empire — and that he was then moved out of the district by two Pathan brothers, **Ghani Khan and Nabi Khan**, horse traders who had known him.

They put him in a litter, dressed as a Muslim holy man, and carried him openly along the roads, telling anyone who asked that they were escorting the *Uch da Pir* — the holy man of Uch. The accounts have them stopped and questioned, and a local man vouching for them under oath.

The details are Sikh tradition and this book labels them so. What is not tradition is the shape of the thing, which is corroborated by everything else about this year.

The Guru survived the winter of 1704 because Punjabi Muslims hid him from a Muslim emperor's officers.

Set it beside the rest of the ledger this part has been keeping. At Bhangani a Muslim pir fought for him and lost two sons, while Muslim mercenaries in his pay deserted. At Nadaun he fought a Mughal army beside Hindu rajas who had tried to kill him three years earlier and would try again. At Anandpur those same Hindu rajas called in the imperial troops. And in the worst week of his life, two Pathan horse dealers carried him out of a search cordon.

Nothing in this century sorts cleanly by religion, and the people who lived through it knew that better than anybody arguing about it now.

Sirhind, Muktsar and the Letter, 1704–1708

LIKELY

Two children died at Sirhind, forty deserters came back and died at a pool in the desert, and the man who had lost everything wrote a letter to the emperor telling him he had lost.

WON BY Nobody — and everything in Part Ten comes out of it

WHEN December 1704 at Sirhind; December 1705 at Khidrana; the letter written about 1705–06.	WHERE Sirhind on the Delhi road; Khidrana — now Muktsar — in the dry Malwa country.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh; the faujdar of Sirhind, Wazir Khan; and forty Sikhs who had left him.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the <i>Zafarnama</i> in the Guru’s own hand.

Sirhind

The party separated at the Sarsa — Mata Gujri and the two younger boys — was betrayed by a servant and handed over to the authorities at Sirhind.

Zorawar Singh was about nine. Fateh Singh was about six.

They were held at Sirhind, brought before the faujdar Wazir Khan, and required to convert. They refused. **They were put to death in the last week of December 1704.** Their grandmother died at Sirhind at the same time.

This book is not going to describe it further. The manner of the execution is recorded in the Sikh tradition and is commemorated every December, and nothing is gained by setting it out here beyond what has been said. **Two children were killed by a provincial official because they would not change their religion, and the memory of it is one of the load-bearing facts of Punjabi history.**

WHAT SIRHIND BECAME

It is worth stating plainly what these deaths did, because the consequences run through the next hundred years of this book.

Sirhind stopped being a town and became a name. Six years later, in 1710, an army raised from the Khalsa under Banda Singh Bahadur stormed it and destroyed it. Wazir Khan was killed, and the site was left in ruins so deliberately that it was said to be under a curse. That is Part Ten, and it is the reason Part Ten opens the way it does.

And notice which of these events the empire recorded. Aurangzeb's later reign restricted official history-writing, and the Mughal record of the winter of 1704 is thin to the point of silence. A provincial faujdar disposing of the family of a hill-country religious leader was, administratively, nothing at all.

It is the other side that wrote this one down, and that is possible because of what was built in Part Eight and formalised in 1699. **For the first time in this book, the losing side's account is the one that survives in full.**

Khidrana, December 1705

1. **The forty who had left Anandpur during the siege** — the ones who had signed the *bedava* renouncing him — were shamed at home, according to the tradition, by the women of their villages.
2. **A woman named Mai Bhago** — Mata Bhag Kaur — is remembered as having rallied them and led them back.
3. **They found him at a pool at Khidrana** in the dry country of the Malwa, with an imperial force in pursuit.
4. **They fought there and nearly all of them died**, holding the ground long enough for the pursuit to be broken. Mai Bhago survived, badly wounded.
5. **And the Guru is said to have torn up the document.** The forty are remembered as the *Chali Mukte* — the forty liberated — and the place was renamed **Muktsar**, the pool of liberation.

WHY THE STATE COULD NOT FINISH IT

- **It kept killing individuals and missing the institution.** Guru Arjan in 1606, Guru Tegh Bahadur in 1675, four sons and a mother in 1704 — and the Khalsa was still there in 1708.
- **The empire was two thousand kilometres away.** Aurangzeb spent the last twenty-five years of his life in the Deccan, and the Punjab was run by provincial officers with local priorities.
- **Persecution recruits.** Sirhind is the clearest demonstration in this book: the killing of two children produced an army six years later.
- **And the country was with them.** A man hunted through the Punjab in 1704 and 1705 was fed, hidden and moved by ordinary people, including people of the emperor's own religion.

WHAT IT COST

- **Anandpur, and everything in it.** The town, the library, the accumulated work of forty years.
- **Four sons and a mother, inside one month.**
- **The community scattered.** The organisation built over a century was broken up and had to be reassembled from nothing.
- **And a century of what follows.** Part Ten and Part Eleven are the bill.

The Letter

Some time in 1705 or 1706, in the Malwa country, having lost his town, his library, his four sons and his mother inside a single winter, **Guru Gobind Singh wrote a letter to the Emperor Aurangzeb.**

It is in Persian, in verse, and it is called the **Zafarnama** — the Epistle of Victory.

It is not a plea and it is not a lament. It is an indictment, written by a man with nothing left, addressed to the most powerful person in the world, and its argument runs roughly like this.

You swore on your Quran and you broke the oath. He returns to this again and again — not as an insult but as a legal and religious point. A ruler whose sacred oath means nothing has forfeited the thing that makes him a ruler.

Your commanders did not defeat me. He describes Chamkaur: a handful of men, an army against them, and what it cost to take a mud house.

Killing my children changes nothing. One of the most quoted lines in Punjabi memory is his — that what does it matter if four have been extinguished, when the coiled one still remains.

And there was no other way left. The most famous couplet in the letter states the principle plainly: when all other means have been exhausted, it is lawful to take up the sword.

Now consider this document against the nine parts before it. This history has been assembled from Greeks writing four centuries late, Chinese pilgrims describing ruins, Persian court secretaries counting the dead for the men who paid them, victory pillars carved by winners, and a Kashmiri poet writing six hundred years afterwards. In Part Seven a Punjabi finally wrote down what an invasion looked like. In Part Eight it was put in a book.

Here, a Punjabi who has just lost everything writes directly to the emperor who took it, in the emperor's own literary language, and tells him he has lost.

Aurangzeb died in the Deccan in 1707. The Guru died at Nanded in October 1708, stabbed by an assassin, having done two last things: he sent a follower north to the Punjab with authority to act — and he ended personal Guruship for ever, declaring that after him the Guru would be **the book**.

The follower was **Banda Singh Bahadur**, and Part Ten begins with him on the road to Sirhind.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1606	Guru Arjan is executed at Lahore on Jahangir's orders, recorded in the emperor's own memoir: Won by Jahangir — and it produces the opposite of what he intended.
1606 onwards	Guru Hargobind takes up two swords , builds the Akal Takht facing the Harmandir Sahib, raises the fort of Lohgarh and begins keeping horsemen.
c. 1609–1619	The Guru is imprisoned at Gwalior and released — commemorated as Bandi Chhor Divas. Relations with Jahangir afterwards are cordial.
c. 1628–1635	Four battles — Amritsar, Lahira near Mehraj, Kartarpur and Palahi. All won. Then the Guru moves to Kiratpur in the hills and the fighting stops for sixty years. Won by Guru Hargobind.
1646–1647	Balkh and Badakhshan are taken and abandoned; the army is caught by winter recrossing the Hindu Kush. Won by the Uzbeks, without a battle.
1649, 1652, 1653	Three failed sieges of Kandahar , all staged and paid for through the Punjab. Won by Persia.
1657–1659	The war of succession. Dara Shukoh is beaten at Samugarh, loses Lahore, runs through Multan and Sindh, is betrayed in the Bolan country and executed. Won by Aurangzeb.
1665	Guru Tegh Bahadur founds Chak Nanaki — Anandpur — in the Siwalik foothills.
1672	The Khapash Pass. A Mughal army is destroyed in a defile by the Afridis; Aurangzeb comes to Hasan Abdal in the Punjab for eighteen months and quiets the frontier with roads, forts and subsidies. Won by the tribes.
Nov 1675	Guru Tegh Bahadur is executed at Chandni Chowk, Delhi , after taking up the cause of the Kashmiri Pandits. His son, aged nine, succeeds him. Won by Aurangzeb.
Sept 1688	Bhangani. A coalition of hill rajas is defeated; Pathan mercenaries desert the Guru and Pir Buddhu Shah fights for him and loses two sons. Won by Guru Gobind Rai — who wrote the account himself.
1691	Nadaun. The Guru fights a Mughal tribute force alongside the same hill rajas who attacked him three years earlier. Won by the allies — who then settled with the empire.
Vaisakhi 1699	The Khalsa is founded at Anandpur. The Panj Pyare, the initiation, one name for everybody, the five articles — and the Guru takes the rite from the five he has just created.
1700–1704	The sieges of Anandpur. The hill rajas fail, call in imperial troops, and blockade the town until it starves. Safe passage is guaranteed on oath. Won by the besiegers — and the guarantee is broken on the road.
Dec 1704	The Sarsa in flood at night. The family is separated in the dark and never reassembled.

Dec 1704	Chamkaur. Forty Sikhs in a mud compound; Ajit Singh and Jujhar Singh die; and the surviving Sikhs, acting as the Five, order the Guru to leave — and he obeys. Won by the imperial force, which did not get what it came for.
Dec 1704	Sirhind. Zorawar Singh and Fateh Singh, about nine and six, are put to death for refusing to convert. Mata Gujri dies at the same time.
Dec 1705	Khidrana. The forty who had renounced the Guru return, rallied by Mai Bhago , and die holding off the pursuit. The place becomes Muktsar . Won by the forty.
1705–06	The Zafarnama — the Guru’s letter in Persian verse to Aurangzeb, accusing him of a broken oath and asserting that he has lost.
1707–1708	Aurangzeb dies in the Deccan. Guru Gobind Singh is assassinated at Nanded in October 1708, having sent Banda Singh Bahadur north and vested the Guruship in the book. <i>Part Ten begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Ten

1. **The institution that outlives the man — finally.** Nine parts of this book have watched states collapse when one person died: the Nandas, Menander’s kingdom, Harsha’s empire, Yashodharman’s alliance, Jasrat’s Punjab, Hemu’s army. Five commanders lost battles they were winning because they personally went down. **At Anandpur in 1699 the problem was deliberately solved, at Chamkaur in 1704 the solution was used, and at Nanded in 1708 it was made permanent.** Part Ten is the first part of this book where the leadership can be killed without the movement ending — and it is tested immediately.
2. **Killing the man leaves the machinery standing.** Jahangir executed a Guru and got an eleven-year-old with two swords. Aurangzeb executed a Guru and got a nine-year-old who founded the Khalsa. A provincial officer killed two children at Sirhind and got an army at his gates in six years. **This book has watched empires make this error since Part Three; here it is made three times in a century by people who should have learned.**
3. **The hills preserve and the hills imprison.** Kiratpur, Paonta, Anandpur, Bhangani, Nadaun — everything in this part happens in the Siwaliks, for the reasons Part Eight set out. You cannot be finished there and you cannot win from there, and Anandpur in 1704 is what the trade eventually costs.
4. **Nothing sorts cleanly by religion, and the people involved knew it.** Hindu rajas besieged the Guru and fought beside him. A Muslim pir lost two sons for him and Muslim mercenaries deserted him. Muslim horse traders hid him from a Muslim emperor’s officers. A Guru died for the Hindu right to a sacred thread. **The wars in this part divide by land, tribute, power and fear — and when they divide by faith it is usually because someone in authority found it useful.**
5. **And the record is now ours.** The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama* are first-person Punjabi accounts of Punjabi wars, written by the man who fought them. **For the first time in nine parts, the losing side’s version survives in full — and from here to the end of this book, it never stops.**

COMING NEXT — PART TEN

Banda Singh Bahadur and the Years of Persecution, 1708–1748. A follower sent north from Nanded with a letter of authority raises an army in the Malwa within a year. **Samana in 1709; Sirhind in May 1710**, where Wazir Khan is killed and the town destroyed; the first Sikh administration, its own coinage struck in the Gurus' name, and a land settlement that abolishes the landlords. Then the empire's full weight: Lohgarh, the retreat to the hills, the long siege of **Gurdas Nangal** in 1715, and the executions at Delhi in 1716. What follows is thirty years in which the community is hunted through the Punjab with a price on every head, survives in the forests and the deserts and across the Sutlej — and comes out of it organised into fighting bands. And at the end, in 1739, **Nadir Shah** comes down the road from Kabul, and the Mughal Punjab ends for good.

Words Used in This Part

Miri and Piri

Temporal and spiritual authority. The two swords taken up by Guru Hargobind in 1606, and the doctrine that the two cannot be separated.

Akal Takht

“Throne of the Timeless One.” The raised building facing the Harmandir Sahib at Amritsar, from which decisions binding on the community are taken.

Lohgarh

“Iron fort.” The fortification built at Amritsar under Guru Hargobind; the name is used again later for Banda Singh Bahadur’s stronghold.

Bandi Chhor Divas

“The day of the release of prisoners” — commemorating Guru Hargobind’s release from Gwalior, and coinciding with Diwali.

Bachittar Natak

A composition attributed to Guru Gobind Singh containing a first-person account of his early life and battles, including Bhangani and Nadaun. Near-contemporary and unusually valuable.

Zafarnama

“Epistle of Victory.” The Guru’s letter in Persian verse to Aurangzeb, written after Chamkaur, accusing him of breaking an oath sworn on the Quran.

Khalsa

The order founded at Anandpur on Vaisakhi 1699 — initiated, bound by a common code, taking the names Singh and Kaur, and open to anyone regardless of caste.

Panj Pyare

“The Five Beloved” — the five who came forward at Anandpur in 1699. Also the standing institution of five initiated Sikhs acting collectively, whose decision can bind even the Guru.

Amrit

The initiation rite of the Khalsa, prepared with water and sugar and stirred with a double-edged blade.

Faujdar

A Mughal district military commander. Wazir Khan, the faujdar of Sirhind, is the official responsible for the events of December 1704.

Garhi

A small mud-walled fortified compound of the ordinary Punjabi kind. The one at Chamkaur was not a fortress.

Bedava

The written renunciation signed by the forty who left Anandpur during the siege — and torn up by the Guru after Khidrana.

Chali Mukte

“The forty liberated” — the men who returned and died at Khidrana, which was renamed Muktsar, the pool of liberation.

Sahibzade

The term used for Guru Gobind Singh's four sons, all of whom died in December 1704.

Anandpur

Founded as Chak Nanaki in 1665 by Guru Tegh Bahadur in the Siwalik foothills. The centre of everything in the second half of this part.

Gurbilas

A genre of later Sikh narrative literature about the lives of the Gurus. Devotional in purpose, and the source of most of the detail about the battles of Guru Hargobind.

Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri

Jahangir's own memoir, in which he records and explains his order for the execution of Guru Arjan.

Sirr-i-Akbar

"The Greatest Secret" — Dara Shukoh's Persian translation of the Upanishads, cited against him at his trial for apostasy.

Sources used for this part

- Jahangir, *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri*, in Rogers and Beveridge's translation — for the execution of Guru Arjan in the emperor's own words
- The letter of the Jesuit **Jerome Xavier** from Lahore, 1606 — independent contemporary corroboration
- The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama*, attributed to Guru Gobind Singh — first-person accounts from the Punjab
- The *Gurbilas* literature and later Sikh narrative sources for the battles of Guru Hargobind and the events of 1704–05, treated as devotional tradition and labelled as such
- Mughal court histories of Shah Jahan's reign for Balkh, Badakhshan and Kandahar
- **François Bernier**, *Travels in the Mogul Empire*, for the war of succession and the fate of Dara Shukoh
- Mughal records of the north-west frontier campaigns of 1667–1675
- The buildings at Amritsar and Anandpur, and the gurdwaras marking the sites in Delhi, Sirhind, Chamkaur and Muktsar
- Standard scholarly histories of the later Mughal empire and of the Sikh community in the seventeenth century

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the relative weight of the political and religious motives in the execution of Guru Arjan; the dating of the Gwalior imprisonment, which the sources place anywhere across a decade; the dates and details of Guru Hargobind's four battles, which rest on later Sikh sources and are barely mentioned in Mughal records; the specific reasons for the execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur, where Mughal record is nearly silent; whether Aurangzeb personally authorised the safe-conduct broken at Anandpur or whether it was given by commanders in the field; and every troop figure in the part.

On method, three things should be said plainly.

First, **this part applies the same test to Sikh sources that earlier parts applied to Persian, Greek and Sanskrit ones.** The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama* are near-contemporary and are treated as strong evidence; the *Gurbilas* literature is later and devotional and is treated as tradition. That is not scepticism about the community's memory. It is the same standard used on Kalhana in Part Four, the *Prithviraj Raso* in Part Six and the *Malfuzat-i Timuri* in Part Seven.

Second, **the Mughal side is not treated as one thing.** Akbar left this community alone; Jahangir executed one Guru and later travelled with his successor; Shah Jahan's officers fought four small battles and then let the matter drop for a decade; Aurangzeb's policy was harder again, and much of what was done in the Punjab in 1704 was done by provincial officers while the emperor was two thousand kilometres away. Four emperors, four postures.

Third, **this part has deliberately not described the manner of the deaths at Lahore in 1606 or at Sirhind in 1704.** Both are recorded in the tradition, both are commemorated, and neither requires elaboration here. The historical facts are stated. Anything beyond that would be for effect, and these particular events do not need any.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART TEN OF SIXTEEN

Banda Singh and the Hunted Years

Forty years in which a movement with no ruler, no capital and a price on every head takes a province from the largest empire on earth, loses it, is hunted almost out of existence — and comes out of the forests organised into an army.

1708 — 1748

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Test

Part Nine ended with a claim: that somebody had finally built a movement which would not die with its leader. This part is where that claim is tested to destruction, twice, and holds.

In October 1708 Guru Gobind Singh died at Nanded, two thousand kilometres from the Punjab, having ended personal Guruship for ever.

By every precedent in the previous nine parts of this book, that should have been the end of it. **The Nandas, Menander's kingdom, Harsha's empire, Yashodharman's alliance, Jasrat's Punjab, Hemu's army — all of them died with one man.** This community had just lost its Guru, its town, its founder's four sons, and the war.

Fourteen months later it took Sirhind.

What follows is the strangest forty years in this book. A follower sent north with a letter raises an army out of nothing, destroys a Mughal provincial capital, sets up a government, strikes his own coinage, abolishes the landlords — **and is captured, paraded through Delhi and executed within six years.**

And then the movement does not end again. It goes into the forests and the deserts, is hunted for thirty years with a bounty on every head, loses thousands of people in a single campaign in 1746, and emerges in 1748 organised into a standing confederate army that will rule the Punjab within twenty years.

Four things to hold on to

- **This is a peasant movement as much as a religious one.** Banda's land settlement is the most radical act of government in this entire book, and it explains why he could raise armies faster than the empire could destroy them.
- **The persecutors are provincial, and they are not all Muslim.** The men who ran the hunt were the governors of Lahore — and the campaign of 1746, the worst of them, was driven by a Hindu Khatri official avenging his brother. **This part will name people rather than communities.**
- **The Mughal empire collapses in the middle of it.** Nadir Shah sacks Delhi in 1739 and takes the treasury with him. After that there is no imperial power in northern India, only provincial governors and whoever comes down the road from Kabul — and everything in Parts Eleven and Twelve follows.
- **And for the first time this book can triangulate.** We have hostile Persian chronicles, Sikh tradition, and **an English eyewitness** — the East India Company's envoys in Delhi in 1716, who watched the procession and wrote home about it.

HOW THIS PART HANDLES IT

Same commitments as Part Nine, and they matter more here because the violence is worse on both sides.

The sources are read against their authors. Khafi Khan and the other Persian chroniclers of this period detest Banda and record his campaigns as atrocity; Sikh tradition records them as justice. **Both are describing a real war in which real towns were sacked.** This part does not launder either side.

The executions are stated, not described. The methods used at Lahore and Delhi in these decades are recorded in detail in several traditions. The facts are given here; the details are not, for the same reason as in Part Nine.

And the labels are used honestly. **CERTAIN** for contemporary documents — including the coins, which survive, and the Company letter. **LIKELY** for well-attested events reported later. **STORY** where a tradition is doing the work.

Samana, 1709 — The First Blow

LIKELY

A man arrived in the Punjab with five companions and a letter, and within a year he had stormed a wealthy imperial town.

WON BY

Banda Singh Bahadur — with an army that had not existed twelve months earlier

WHEN November 1709.	WHERE Samana, in the country between the Ghaggar and the Sutlej, in the Punjab plain.
WHO Banda Singh Bahadur, sent north from Nanded, against the imperial administration of the Sirhind province.	THE EVIDENCE Persian chroniclers hostile to him, chiefly Khafi Khan and the <i>Ibratnama</i>; and Sikh tradition.

Who he was

He was born in the Jammu hills around 1670, became a wandering ascetic, and by 1708 was living at Nanded in the Deccan as the head of a small establishment. He had no connection with the Punjab wars and no military record.

Guru Gobind Singh met him at Nanded in 1708. What passed between them is recorded in tradition rather than in any document. **What is not disputed is what he left with:** a new name, a letter of authority — a *hukamnama* — addressed to the Sikhs of the Punjab, a small escort of five experienced Sikhs, and instructions.

He went north. **He had no army, no money, no fortress and no standing.** What he had was a piece of paper from the Guru and the fact that the community was, at that moment, extremely angry.

What happened

1. **He raised men in the Malwa country** south of the Sutlej, working out of villages in the Sonapat and Kharkhauda region. The *hukamnama* was circulated and the response was immediate.
2. **The first recruits were mostly peasants.** The Persian sources are contemptuous about this — they describe the followers as cultivators and men of low occupation. **The contempt is the most useful thing in the account,** because it tells you exactly where the manpower came from.

3. **He took some small places first** to arm and pay the force.
4. **Then, in November 1709, he stormed Samana.** It was a wealthy town, an imperial administrative centre, and it was taken and thoroughly sacked.
5. **Then Ghuram, Thaska, Shahabad, Kapuri and Sadhaura** in quick succession, working north-west across the province.
6. **And by the spring of 1710 he was standing in front of Sirhind.**

WHY SAMANA, AND WHY THE SACK WAS WHAT IT WAS

Samana was not chosen at random, and the Sikh tradition is explicit about why.

It was the home town of the men who had carried out the executions. The executioner of Guru Tegh Bahadur at Delhi in 1675 came from Samana; so, by the tradition, did the men who put the two children to death at Sirhind in December 1704. Sadhaura, taken shortly afterwards, was the town where the official responsible for the death of **Pir Buddhu Shah** — the Muslim divine who had fought for Guru Gobind Singh at Bhangani and lost two sons — had his seat.

The campaign was a reprisal and it was conducted as one. The Persian sources describe the sack of Samana in terms of general massacre. Sikh tradition describes retribution against the guilty. **Both accounts are describing a town being stormed by an army raised out of grievance, and towns stormed in the eighteenth century did not distinguish carefully.**

This book is not going to pretend otherwise. The rage was earned. What it did to Samana was still what an army does to a town.

WHY BANDA COULD RAISE AN ARMY SO FAST

- **The authority was already established.** The *hukamnama* worked because there was a community, an organisation and a habit of obedience to a written order from the Guru — all of it built in Parts Eight and Nine.
- **The grievance was five years old and universal.** Anandpur, the Sarsa, Chamkaur and Sirhind had happened to everybody in that country, not to a court.
- **The Khalsa had already removed the barrier to recruitment.** Caste did not disqualify anybody. **His army came from the whole population, and no other army in this book could do that.**
- **And the empire was elsewhere.** Aurangzeb had died in 1707; his sons were fighting over the throne; the field army was in the Deccan.

WHY THE PROVINCE COULD NOT STOP HIM

- **Garrison troops, not a field army.** Provincial faujdars had enough men to police a district and not enough to fight a campaign.
- **The towns were rich and unwallled in any serious sense.** Prosperity without defence is the oldest invitation in this book.
- **The countryside was against them.** A revenue administration is only as strong as the cultivators' willingness to keep paying it.
- **And nobody believed it was serious until Sirhind.**

The Letter That Raised an Army

Think about the mechanism here, because it is genuinely without precedent in this book.

A man nobody in the Punjab had heard of arrived from the Deccan with five companions. He had no lineage anybody cared about, no lands, no fortress, no treasury and no reputation as a soldier. He was not a Guru and did not claim to be — the Guruship had been vested in the book at Nanded, and everybody knew it.

What he carried was a letter.

And on the strength of that letter, in a province under imperial administration with a functioning revenue system and garrisons in every town, thousands of men left their fields and came to him.

That only works because of what was built before he arrived. **Part Eight created a script, a book, a network of local congregations and a habit of receiving written instructions from a central authority. Part Nine created an order that anybody could join and that bound its members visibly and permanently.** Banda did not build any of it. He inherited a working institution and used it.

Compare it with every other rising in these ten parts. The Yaudheyas needed generations of tribal organisation. Jasrat Khokhar needed to be a chief's son in his own clan's country. Every rebellion against Delhi in Parts Six and Seven needed a noble with troops already on his payroll.

Here the qualification for command was a piece of paper, and the qualification for enlistment was willingness.

The empire never understood this, which is why for the next forty years it kept killing individuals and being surprised that it had not worked.

Chappar Chiri and Sirhind, May 1710

LIKELY

Five and a half years after the winter of 1704, the town came down.

WON BY

Banda Singh Bahadur — the most complete reversal in this book

WHEN 12 May 1710 the battle; the town taken two days later.	WHERE Chappar Chiri, a village on the plain a few miles from Sirhind.
WHO Banda’s army against Wazir Khan, faujdar of Sirhind — the official responsible for December 1704.	THE EVIDENCE Persian chronicles and Sikh tradition, which agree on the outcome and on very little else.

What happened

1. **Wazir Khan came out to fight** rather than stand a siege, with the provincial troops and artillery and a body of allied contingents.
2. **The armies met at Chappar Chiri.** The Sikh force was larger in numbers and much worse equipped — the accounts describe men with whatever weapons they had brought from their villages.
3. **The Sikh left was broken by artillery** and the line came close to collapsing.
4. **Then the centre held and pushed.** The tradition describes a general assault delivered against the guns.
5. **Wazir Khan was killed on the field.**
6. **The army broke and the town was entered two days later.** Sirhind was taken and destroyed. The Persian accounts describe general slaughter and the burning of the town; the Sikh accounts describe the same events as retribution.
7. **The treasury of the province went with it,** and it was very large.

WHAT WAS ACTUALLY DESTROYED

Sirhind was one of the wealthiest towns in northern India. It sat on the Grand Trunk Road at the point where the Punjab meets the road to Delhi — the same crossroads that made it the place where Sher Shah sent his message to Humayun in Part Eight, and where Bairam Khan refounded the Mughal empire in 1555.

It had gardens, sarais, mosques, tombs and a mint. It was the administrative capital of a rich province.

After May 1710 it was a ruin, and it was left as one. There was a deliberate refusal to rebuild, and the destruction of Sirhind entered Punjabi memory as a completed act rather than an incident.

And it is worth saying clearly what that means, because this book has spent nine parts describing sacked towns. **This one was sacked by Punjabis, on Punjabi ground, against a Punjabi administration.** It is not an invasion. It is the first time in this entire history that the destruction on this soil is entirely home-grown — and the people doing it had reasons that anybody reading Part Nine will understand and that do not make the burning of a town anything other than what it was.

WHY BANDA WON

- **Wazir Khan came out.** Sirhind's walls and guns were worth more than its field army, and he gave that away.
- **Numbers and motivation.** A badly armed force that will keep coming forward beats a well-armed one that will not.
- **The commander was killed.** For the sixth time in this book, a provincial army dissolved when the man holding it together went down — and this time the army with the institutional command structure was the peasant one.
- **And the countryside supplied him.** Food, intelligence, remounts and recruits, all locally, none of it available to the other side.

WHY THE PROVINCE FELL IN A SEASON

- **There was no imperial army within reach.** Bahadur Shah was in the Deccan dealing with the aftermath of his own succession war.
- **Provincial forces are for policing.** They are not designed to fight a popular rising and never have been.
- **The revenue apparatus collapsed with the capital.** Kill the treasury and the district officers stop being paid.
- **And nobody local would fight for it.** That is the whole of it, and the next war explains why.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Five and a Half Years

Set the two Decembers against each other, because the distance between them is the point.

December 1704. A town in the hills has been starved out. A river comes up in the dark and cuts a family in half. Two boys of seventeen and fourteen die outside a mud wall at Chamkaur. Two more, aged about nine and six, are put to death at Sirhind on the orders of the faujdar, along with their grandmother. The man who has lost all of them is moving through the Punjab in disguise, hidden by horse traders, with nothing.

May 1710. An army raised from the villages of that same country is standing on the field at Chappar Chiri. The faujdar is dead on it. Two days later the town is burning.

Five and a half years.

Nothing in the previous nine parts of this book turns round that fast, and it is worth being precise about why it could. **It was not revenge alone; revenge is common in these pages and almost never accomplishes anything.** The Shahis wanted revenge and were extinct. Prithviraj's kinsmen wanted revenge and got nothing. Wanting it has never once been sufficient.

What made the difference is that this time there was **an organisation still standing when the leader was gone** — congregations that could be written to, an order anybody could join, a shared identity that made a man from one village recognise a man from another as bound to him.

The empire had spent a century removing individuals: a Guru in 1606, a Guru in 1675, four sons and a mother in 1704. **Every one of those removals worked perfectly and none of them worked at all.**

The State at Lohgarh, 1710–1711

CERTAIN

Not a battle. For about eighteen months there was a government in the Punjab that struck its own coins, dated its own era, and abolished the landlords — and its coins survive.

WHAT HAPPENED

Punjab has an independent government for the first time since the Shahis

WHEN

1710–1711, and in fragments for several years after.

WHERE

The Sirhind province, from the Sutlej towards the Yamuna, governed from **Lohgarh** in the Siwaliks.

WHO

Banda Singh Bahadur and the officers he appointed.

THE EVIDENCE

The coins and the seal, which survive, plus hostile Persian description of the land settlement.

What was actually done

1. **A capital.** He fortified **Lohgarh** in the Siwalik foothills — the hills again, for the reasons Parts Eight and Nine set out — and governed from there.
2. **A coinage.** Coins were struck bearing a Persian couplet crediting the sword, the cooking-pot, victory and ready patronage to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. **The name on the coin is not his own.** The reverse names the mint in the formulae of imperial coinage.
3. **A seal.** Official orders went out under a seal carrying the same couplet — again, not in Banda’s name.
4. **A calendar.** A new era was dated from the taking of Sirhind.
5. **Officers.** Governors and administrators were appointed to the districts, several of them men who had come with him from Nanded.
6. **And the land settlement.** This is the one that matters most and is least discussed. **The zamindari system was abolished in the territory he held, and the cultivators were made proprietors of the land they worked.**

THE LAND SETTLEMENT — WHY IT IS THE MOST RADICAL ACT IN THIS BOOK

For five thousand years and nine parts, every state in this history has run on the same arrangement. **The cultivator works. An intermediary — zamindar, jagirdar, chaudhri, whatever the word is that century — collects from him and passes a share upward. The state protects the intermediary because the intermediary delivers the revenue.** That is the machinery of Ashoka, of the Guptas, of the Sultanate, of Sher Shah and of the Mughals alike.

Banda dissolved it. In the districts he controlled, the men who held the land as intermediaries lost it, and the men who ploughed it were declared its owners.

The Persian sources record this with genuine horror, and their horror is the best evidence that it happened. They describe men of no standing being set over their betters and the natural order overturned. What they are describing, in the language available to them, is a peasant revolution.

It also explains the military problem the empire could not solve. **An army of cultivators who have just been given their fields does not go home when it is beaten.** It goes back to the fields, and comes out again next season, and there is no aristocracy left in that country to raise a counter-force. This is why the fighting in the Sirhind province went on for years after Banda himself was gone.

WHY IT WORKED AT ALL

- **It was popular in the most literal sense.** The land settlement bought loyalty that no amount of money could have.
- **The authority was borrowed and therefore unassailable.** Ruling in the Gurus' name, not his own, made the government hard to delegitimise from inside.
- **The base was in the hills.** Lohgarh could not be rushed.
- **And the empire was busy.** Bahadur Shah had a Deccan war, a Rajput problem and his own brothers.

THE WEAKNESSES THAT WOULD KILL IT

- **It made every landholder in northern India an enemy.** Not only Muslim officials — Hindu zamindars and hill rajas too. The coalition that eventually formed against Banda was broader than religion.
- **Territory means you can be found.** A movement in the forests cannot be besieged. A government at Lohgarh can.
- **It divided the community.** Banda's innovations — his own practices, his authority, the honours paid to him — were disputed by Sikhs who held that nothing could be added after 1708. **That split hardened and lasted.**
- **And it was eighteen months old when the empire came.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Name That Is Not on the Coin

Pick up one of Banda's coins — they survive, in museums and collections, and they are the hardest evidence in this entire part.

A coin is the loudest statement a government can make. This book has been reading them since Part Three: the Yaudheya copper saying *victory to the nation*; the Indo-Greek silver with a king's face wearing an elephant's scalp; Sher Shah's rupiya; Kanishka's gold with the Buddha on it. **What a ruler puts on his money is what he wants everybody to know.**

Banda ruled a province, commanded an army, appointed governors and levied revenue. He had a mint.

And he did not put his own name on the coin.

The couplet credits everything — the sword, the pot that feeds people, victory, protection — to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. The seal on his official orders says the same. In a century when every ruler in Asia announced himself in metal, the man who had taken Sirhind struck coins in the names of two men who were dead.

You can read that as piety, and it was. **You can also read it as the most sophisticated political act in this part.** It said that the government belonged to the community and not to him — which made it very difficult for anyone to accuse him of setting himself up, and which meant that when he was captured and killed six years later, **the authority he had exercised did not die with him, because it had never been his.**

Part Nine described a Guru taking initiation from five men he had just created, so that the order would outlive him. This is the same idea, in silver:

And it worked. Banda was executed in 1716. The Punjab was ruled by the Khalsa within fifty years.

Lohgarh, December 1710 — The Empire Answers

LIKELY

The emperor came north in person with the imperial army, issued an order for extermination, took the capital — and the man he came for walked out of it.

WON BY

Bahadur Shah — on the map, and not in any way that mattered

WHEN

December 1710; the imperial order issued the same month.

WHERE

Lohgarh, in the Siwalik foothills near Sadhaura.

WHO

The emperor **Bahadur Shah I** with the imperial field army, against Banda Singh Bahadur.

THE EVIDENCE

Mughal records, including **the firman itself**, and the Persian chroniclers.

What happened

1. **The emperor abandoned the Deccan and came north.** That is the measure of how seriously it was taken: a Mughal emperor turning the imperial army around and marching it fifteen hundred kilometres.
2. **A firman was issued in December 1710** ordering the provincial officers to hunt down and kill the followers of Nanak wherever they were found. **This is a document, not a tradition.** It is the beginning of the thirty years described in War Seven.
3. **The imperial army invested Lohgarh.** Sadhaura fell; the outworks were carried; the fort was surrounded in force.
4. **And Banda escaped.** The accounts describe a night breakout through the encircling army. One tradition has a follower dressed in his clothes remaining behind to be taken in his place; the Persian sources simply record, with irritation, that he was not among the captured.
5. **He went into the hills** — into the country north of the Sutlej, in the Jammu direction — and the imperial army could not follow him into it in winter.
6. **Bahadur Shah died in February 1712**, and the empire fell into another succession war. **Within a year Banda was back in the plains, retaking towns.**

THE FIRMAN, AND WHAT AN ORDER LIKE THAT DOES

The December 1710 order is worth pausing on because it changes the character of everything after it.

Up to this point the conflict had a shape this book has seen many times: a state putting down a rebellion in a province. **The firman turned it into something else.** It made membership of a religious community, by itself, a capital matter — and because the Khalsa's articles of faith are worn and visible, it made that membership impossible to conceal.

Part Nine noted this as the cost of the 1699 settlement: uncut hair and a steel bracelet are an asset in a battle and a death sentence in a persecution. Here is the persecution.

The practical consequence over the following decades is described in War Eight. A great many people cut their hair and stopped being identifiable. A great many did not, and went into the forests. **And the ones who did not are the ones who are still there in 1748 with an army.**

It is also worth noting what the order could not do. **It required provincial officers to find people, and provincial officers in the Punjab were about to lose the ability to find anybody at all,** because the empire that paid them was three decades from collapse.

WHY THE EMPIRE TOOK LOHGARH

- **It brought the field army.** Nothing in the Punjab could stand against a full Mughal army with siege guns, and nothing did.
- **The emperor came himself.** Which meant the provincial governors and the hill rajas all cooperated, for once.
- **A fixed capital can be attacked.** The oldest trade in this book: territory buys legitimacy and costs you the ability to disappear.

WHY IT SETTLED NOTHING

- **They took a fort and not a movement.** The army was dispersed, not destroyed, and the districts stayed hostile.
- **The imperial army could not stay.** A field army in the Siwaliks in winter is a wasting asset, and the Deccan war was still running.
- **The emperor died fourteen months later,** and his sons fought over the succession for the next two years.
- **And the land settlement had already happened.** Retaking a province does not un-give the fields.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Fifteen Hundred Kilometres

Here is the fact that puts this whole part in proportion, and it comes from the empire's own behaviour rather than from anything anybody claimed.

In 1710 the Mughal empire was fighting a war in the Deccan that had already consumed twenty-five years, the last part of Aurangzeb's life and an incalculable amount of money. It was the single strategic obsession of the dynasty.

And Bahadur Shah left it, and marched the imperial army fifteen hundred kilometres north, because of what was happening in one province of the Punjab.

Consider who he was going to fight. A wandering ascetic from the Jammu hills, in the country for two years, commanding an army of cultivators with village weapons, holding a hill fort in the Siwaliks. No dynasty. No foreign backer. No cavalry tradition. No siege train. On paper, a provincial disturbance.

The emperor of India came in person.

Governments are honest in their logistics if nowhere else. You can discount every claim in every chronicle and still read the seriousness of a threat off the map, by looking at what the state moved and how far. In this case it moved everything, across the width of the subcontinent, in the middle of a different war.

And having done that, and having taken the fort, and having issued an order for the extermination of a religious community — **the empire had achieved, by the spring of 1712, precisely nothing.** Banda was in the plains again. The province was in arms again. And Bahadur Shah was dead.

Gurdas Nangal, 1715 — Eight Months in a Farmhouse

LIKELY

The empire finally caught him by doing the only thing that has ever worked in this book: it stopped attacking and sat down.

WON BY

Abdus Samad Khan — by starvation, over eight months

WHEN Besieged from about April 1715; surrendered December 1715.	WHERE Gurdas Nangal, near Gurdaspur — the fortified house of a landholder named Duni Chand.
WHO Abdus Samad Khan, governor of Lahore, against Banda Singh Bahadur and a few hundred followers.	THE EVIDENCE Persian chroniclers, who describe the conditions inside in detail because they were told by survivors.

What happened

- The new emperor, Farrukhsiyar, made it a priority.** A competent and determined governor, Abdus Samad Khan, was appointed to Lahore with orders to finish it, and given the resources to do it.
- Banda was pushed out of the plains** and, in the spring of 1715, was cornered at Gurdas Nangal — **an ordinary fortified farmhouse**, not a fortress, with a mud wall and a ditch.
- Abdus Samad Khan did not assault it.** He built a line of circumvallation around it — a wall of his own — and sat down.
- The siege lasted about eight months.** The Persian accounts of conditions inside are among the grimmest passages in this book: the food gone, then the animals, then the bark of trees and grass, and men dying of hunger where they stood.
- Some got out.** Small parties broke through at various points and escaped into the country.
- In December 1715 the survivors were taken.** Banda was captured alive with several hundred others.

THE ONE METHOD THAT ALWAYS WORKS

Look at how sieges resolve across these ten parts, because Gurdas Nangal is the clearest possible statement of the rule.

Assaults on determined defenders usually fail. Mahmud failed twice at Lohkot in Part Five. The hill rajas failed for four years at Anandpur in Part Nine. Timur's grandson lost his cavalry outside Multan in Part Seven.

Blockades almost always succeed. Multan surrendered when its water was cut in 712. Akbar starved Sikandar Shah Suri out of Mankot in six months in Part Eight. Anandpur fell to a blockade after the assaults had failed. And here, an ordinary farmhouse held out for eight months against the governor of Lahore and then surrendered because there was nothing left to eat.

The reason is arithmetic, not courage. A besieger eats from a province. A besieged man eats from a store. The store always runs out first, and the only variable is how long the defenders are prepared to make it take.

Which is why the note in Part Five is worth repeating here in its harshest form: **a fortress without a field army behind it is not a defence. It is a place to die slowly.** Nobody was coming to Gurdas Nangal, and everybody inside knew it by about the third month.

WHY ABDUS SAMAD KHAN SUCCEEDED WHERE THREE OTHERS HAD FAILED

- **He was patient.** Eight months of doing nothing, in a career where impatience had destroyed his predecessors.
- **He built a wall round the wall.** Circumvallation prevents both escape and relief, and it converts a siege into an accounting exercise.
- **He had continuity of command.** One governor, one objective, from 1713 to 1715, at a moment when Delhi changed emperors three times.
- **And Banda was cornered outside his own country.** Gurdaspur is not the Malwa; the local population was not the one that had risen in 1709.

WHY BANDA WAS CAUGHT

- **He had become findable.** Six years of holding territory, striking coins and appointing governors made him an address rather than a rumour.
- **The community was divided.** The dispute over his innovations and his authority had hardened, and not everybody came when he called.
- **He took shelter instead of dispersing.** The one mistake. The method that had worked in 1710 was to break up and vanish; in 1715 he went into a building.
- **And there was no relief because there was no second army.** Everything was in that farmhouse.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Ones Who Got Out

The Persian accounts of Gurdas Nangal are written by men who wanted Banda destroyed, and they record the eight months in detail because the detail was the point: this was what came of rebellion.

They describe the grain gone, the horses and oxen eaten, then the leaves and the bark stripped, then men eating what could not be eaten and dying of it. They describe the survivors at the surrender as barely able to stand.

And they record, without meaning to, the thing that mattered most. Over those eight months, in small parties, at night, men got out through the lines and away into the country.

They were not deserting in any useful sense — there was nowhere to desert to, with a price on their heads and the Punjab under a standing order for their extermination. They went out into a province where being recognised meant death, and they survived in it.

Some of those men were still alive in the 1720s and 1730s. Some of them were still alive in 1748.

The empire counted the prisoners at Gurdas Nangal, executed them, and considered the account closed. Khafi Khan's tone at the end of it is one of a problem finally solved.

What it had actually done was take a movement that held territory — findable, besiegeable, defeatable — and convert it back into a movement that held nothing at all. **Which turned out to be very much harder to kill, and is the whole of the next thirty years.**

Delhi, 1716 — The Procession

CERTAIN

The empire staged the most elaborate public demonstration it could devise — and the two Englishmen watching wrote down the one thing it did not want recorded.

WON BY Farrukhsiyar — and it is remembered for the opposite of what it was for

WHEN The procession in late February 1716; the executions through the spring; Banda executed in June 1716.	WHERE Delhi — the road into the city, and then the place of execution near Mehrauli.
WHO Banda Singh Bahadur and roughly seven hundred prisoners.	THE EVIDENCE Persian chronicles, and a letter written from Delhi in March 1716 by John Surman and Edward Stephenson of the East India Company.

What was staged

1. **The prisoners were brought from the Punjab to Delhi** and paraded into the city in a procession designed to be seen by the whole population.
2. **Banda was carried in an iron cage on an elephant**, dressed in an embroidered robe and a mock headdress, with a guard behind him.
3. **Ahead of the cage went cartloads of heads on poles** — the accounts give a figure in the thousands — and behind it the surviving prisoners, roped, on camels.
4. **The executions began at once** and continued daily for about a week at the kotwali in the centre of the city, in public.
5. **Banda was kept alive for three months** and then put to death in June 1716, near Mehrauli. **His young son was killed in front of him first.** This book will not go further than that sentence.

THE LETTER — AND WHY IT IS THE MOST VALUABLE DOCUMENT IN THIS PART

The East India Company had an embassy in Delhi at exactly this moment, negotiating trading rights with Farrukhsiyar. Two of its members, **John Surman and Edward Stephenson**, watched the procession and reported it in a letter home in March 1716.

Their account is dry, commercial and completely uninterested in the theology of any of it. They describe the cage, the elephant, the heads, the numbers. They are foreigners with no stake in the quarrel, writing to a company that wanted news of the court's mood, not a moral verdict.

And in the middle of the report they record something that neither the Persian chroniclers nor the Sikh tradition could have made them say. **They note how the prisoners went to their deaths — with a composure that struck the writers as remarkable — and record that not one of them, to the last, renounced his religion to save himself.**

Think about what kind of evidence that is. **Sikh tradition says the same thing, and Sikh tradition would say it either way.** Persian chroniclers hostile to Banda have every reason to describe rebels dying badly. The only genuinely neutral witnesses in Delhi in the spring of 1716 were two English merchants keeping their principals informed — and they wrote it down because they found it worth mentioning.

That is the whole reason this book keeps insisting on asking who is writing. Nine parts of triangulating between partisan sources, and here, at last, is a witness with nothing to gain.

WHAT THE STATE WAS TRYING TO DO

- **Make it public.** The whole event was theatre, staged in the busiest streets of the capital, for an audience.
- **Make it total.** Seven hundred prisoners and cartloads of heads is not a punishment; it is an attempt to demonstrate that a thing has ceased to exist.
- **Make it humiliating.** The cage, the robe, the mock crown — the point was to show a man who had struck coins in the Gurus' names being displayed as a curiosity.
- **And it was a new emperor's demonstration.** Farrukhsiyar had taken the throne in a civil war and needed a victory the capital could see.

WHY IT FAILED COMPLETELY

- **Public death makes witnesses.** Delhi watched seven hundred people refuse to save themselves, and Delhi talked about it.
- **It confirmed the story the community told about itself.** Everything the Khalsa had been founded on in 1699 was demonstrated in the street, at the empire's expense and on the empire's initiative.
- **It killed the leadership and not the institution.** For the third time in this book, and by now it is not an excuse: 1606, 1675, 1716.
- **And the empire had three decades left.** Farrukhsiyar was strangled by his own ministers in 1719. Nadir Shah was in Delhi in twenty-three years.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What the Merchants Noticed

There is a particular kind of historical evidence that this book has been hunting since Part One, and it has almost never been available.

Everything in these ten parts has come from someone with a reason. Greek writers glorifying Alexander. Court poets cataloguing their patron's conquests. Persian secretaries counting the dead for the man who paid them. Devotional literature written to edify. Victory inscriptions. Chronicles commissioned by the winner.

Ask who is writing, and the answer has always been: somebody who needed you to believe something.

In March 1716, two employees of a trading company sat in Delhi writing a routine business letter. They were there to secure customs concessions. They had no view about the Khalsa, no knowledge of Anandpur or Sirhind, no stake in Mughal legitimacy and no idea that anybody would ever read their letter for this. **They mentioned the procession because it was the news of the week.**

And what struck them enough to put in a commercial dispatch was not the cage or the heads or the emperor's power. **It was the behaviour of the prisoners.**

That is why the letter matters more than a hundred pages of chronicle. It is not a better source because Englishmen wrote it — it is a better source because **nothing about their situation gave them a reason to say it.**

The empire spent a fortune staging a spectacle in the streets of its capital to prove that a movement had been extinguished.

The only genuinely disinterested people who saw it came away describing the people in the ropes.

The Price on the Head, 1716–1745

LIKELY

For a generation, being recognisable in the Punjab was worth money to whoever turned you in.

WON BY

The governors of Lahore — for thirty years, and then not at all

WHEN 1716–1745, with the policy hardest under Zakariya Khan after 1726.	WHERE The whole Punjab, administered from Lahore.
WHO Abdus Samad Khan (governor 1713–1726) and his son Zakariya Khan (1726–1745).	THE EVIDENCE Persian administrative record, Sikh tradition, and the physical sites in Lahore.

What the policy was

1. **The 1710 firman remained in force.** Provincial officers were required to find and kill members of the community wherever they were.
2. **A bounty was placed on heads.** Payment for a captured Sikh, more for a killed one — a standing rate, administered through the district officers, which turned the hunt into an economy.
3. **Executions were public and centralised.** A platform at the horse market in Lahore — the *Nakhas* — became the standing place of execution. The site is now known as **Shahidganj**, the place of martyrs.
4. **Access to Amritsar was cut.** The Harmandir Sahib was occupied and closed to the community at intervals, and gatherings there were treated as an offence in themselves.
5. **And the identity itself was the offence.** Because the Khalsa’s articles of faith are worn, a man could be identified on the road. **The policy did not require evidence of anything; it required a look.**

THREE NAMES, STATED AND NOT ELABORATED

The executions of these decades are recorded in detail in the Sikh tradition, and the details are commemorated annually. This book states the facts and stops there, for the same reason it stopped in Part Nine.

Bhai Mani Singh was a scholar, a custodian of the Harmandir Sahib and one of the most learned men in the community — he had worked on the scripture. He obtained permission to hold a gathering at Amritsar on payment of a fee; troops were then sent to the gathering; the fee could not be paid. **He was executed at Lahore, by dismemberment, in about 1738.** The date is given variously in the sources.

Bhai Taru Singh was a young farmer from a village near Amritsar who had been feeding fugitives. He was arrested, offered his life if he would cut his hair, and refused. **He was executed at Lahore in about 1745.**

Massa Rangar was the local official put in charge of the occupied Harmandir Sahib, who used it for entertainments. In 1740 two Sikhs, Mehtab Singh and Sukha Singh, rode into Amritsar disguised as revenue collectors, killed him inside the building, and rode out.

These three names carry more weight in Punjabi memory than most of the battles in this book, and the reason is worth naming. A battle is a contest. What these decades produced instead was a long, administered, ordinary business of hunting people — and the memory of it is not about heroism in the field but about individuals who were given a way out and did not take it.

WHY THE POLICY WORKED AS LONG AS IT DID

- **It was administrative, not military.** No campaign to lose. District officers, a rate of payment, and a network of informers.
- **The identity was visible.** The single most effective feature of the policy, and it came free.
- **It paid.** Bounties recruit collaborators from the general population without any loyalty being involved.
- **And Zakariya Khan was competent.** Nineteen years in the same post, with a consistent policy — more continuity than the empire in Delhi managed in the same period.

WHY IT DID NOT FINISH ANYTHING

- **It could not reach the forests and the deserts.** Which is War Eight.
- **It gave nobody a way back.** A policy that offers only death produces people with nothing to lose, and there is no worse enemy.
- **Public executions of people who refuse to recant are recruitment,** as Delhi had already demonstrated in 1716 and learned nothing from.
- **And the state ran out of time.** Zakariya Khan died in 1745. Nadir Shah had already gutted the empire in 1739. Within three years there was a Sikh army with a formal command structure.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Toll on the Grand Trunk Road

In about 1739, according to the tradition, two men decided that the official position — that the Sikhs no longer existed in the Punjab — needed correcting.

Bota Singh and Garja Singh came out of hiding, walked to a sarai on the **Grand Trunk Road** near Tarn Taran, and set up a toll post. Two men, with sticks, on Sher Shah Suri's highway, collecting a fixed charge from carts and pack animals in the name of the Khalsa.

Travellers paid, because two armed men on a road are two armed men on a road, and went on their way.

Nothing happened. Nobody reported it. And **that was the problem** — because the entire point was to be noticed.

So Bota Singh wrote a letter to Zakariya Khan, the governor of Lahore, announcing what he was doing. The verse attributed to him is doggerel and is famous precisely because it is: **a note stating the rate for a cart and the rate for a donkey, and telling the governor's household, by name, that this is Bota Singh speaking.**

A detachment was sent. The two of them were killed on the road.

The story is **STORY** — it comes from the Sikh tradition and no Persian source records it, which is what you would expect of an incident the administration would rather not have on file.

But the logic of it is the most revealing thing in this whole part. Two men, hunted, with a price on their heads, in a province where being seen was fatal, deliberately made themselves visible on the busiest road in India and then wrote to the government to make sure it knew.

They were not trying to hold a road or raise money. **They were trying to be on the record.** The official line was that the community had been exterminated in 1716, and two men in a ditch on the Grand Trunk Road decided that the line needed a public contradiction, and paid for it with their lives.

Ten parts of this book have been about who gets written down. This is the only entry in it where somebody died specifically to be.

The Forest Years — How They Survived

LIKELY

Not a battle. The military method that came out of these decades is the reason the Punjab is Sikh-ruled by 1765, and it was invented by people with nothing.

WHAT HAPPENED A hunted population turned itself into cavalry

WHEN Roughly 1716–1745.	WHERE The Lakhi Jungle of the Malwa; the desert country towards Bikaner; the Siwaliks; and across the Sutlej.
WHO Bands — <i>jathas</i> — of a few dozen to a few hundred, under their own leaders.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh tradition, and the frustration visible in the Persian administrative record.

The method

1. **No fixed ground.** Banda had held territory and been besieged in it twice. The lesson was learned completely: **after 1716 the community held nothing that could be attacked.**
2. **Everything on horseback.** A band that can move eighty kilometres in a night cannot be caught by a district officer with foot police. Horses became the central economic fact of the movement — bought, taken, bred, and valued above everything else.
3. **Refuge terrain, chosen deliberately.** The Lakhi Jungle — a great belt of scrub and forest in the Malwa — the desert margins, the hill country, and the far side of the Sutlej, where Lahore’s writ ran thin. **Part Eight’s rule, applied as policy: the hills and the waste preserve you.**
4. **Living off the country, and then formalising it.** Bands took what they needed, and over time this hardened into a system — *rakhi*, protection: a village paid a fixed share of its harvest to a band, and in return that band kept other bands and the revenue officials off it. **This is a government forming out of a protection racket, and it is how most governments in history have started.**
5. **Assembling twice a year.** The scattered bands gathered at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali where they could — the *Sarbat Khalsa*, the whole community in assembly, which took binding decisions by resolution.

WHERE THE VILLAGES STOOD

A guerrilla movement lives or dies on one question, and it is not tactical. **Will the countryside feed it and lie to the government about it?**

In the Punjab between 1716 and 1745, in large parts of the Majha and the Malwa, the answer was yes — and it is worth being clear about why, because piety is only part of it.

These were the same villages. The men in the Lakhi Jungle were the sons and brothers of the men still ploughing. The community was not a foreign body hiding in the countryside; it was the countryside, with a portion of it living rough.

The alternative was worse. Revenue officials, faujdars and bounty hunters were not popular, and a village that paid *rakhi* to a band got a real service in return.

And Banda's land settlement had happened. Its formal reversal did not undo the memory of it. In a province where a movement had once given the fields to the men who worked them, that movement had a standing claim on those men that no governor could match.

The Persian sources notice the effect without ever quite naming the cause. **They complain, repeatedly, that the rebels vanish; that information is unobtainable; that detachments arrive to find nothing.** That is not a description of clever fugitives. It is a description of an entire province declining to cooperate.

WHY THEY COULD NOT BE CAUGHT

- **Nothing to besiege.** The single most important adaptation, learned at Gurdas Nangal.
- **Mobility over everything.** Cavalry bands with no baggage, no artillery and no families in the column.
- **Distributed leadership.** Dozens of *jathas* under their own leaders. Kill one and you have removed one.
- **And an assembly that could still make decisions.** The Sarbat Khalsa meant the movement could act as a whole without ever concentrating as a whole.

WHAT IT COST

- **Everything except survival.** No towns, no revenue, no schools, no building — thirty years of a community's ordinary life simply not happening.
- **The visible identity was a death sentence.** Many cut their hair and went back to their villages. The split between those who did and those who did not is a real and painful part of this period.
- **Discipline was hard to hold.** Bands living off the country are bands living off the country, and not all of them behaved well.
- **And when they were caught in the open, in 1746, it was a massacre.** That is War Eleven.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Same Answer, Every Time

Stop and notice what this method is, because you have read it before in this book. Repeatedly.

Part Five, 1008: the Khokhars of the Salt Range charge Mahmud's line at Waihind and are never subdued.

Part Six, 1206: Muhammad of Ghor crushes them on the Jhelum and is dead in his tent within a fortnight.

Part Seven, 1420–1442: Jasrat Khokhar holds the northern Punjab for twenty years by withdrawing into the Salt Range every time a Delhi army appears and coming back when it leaves. **Part Eight, 1541:** Sher Shah Suri builds the largest fortress of his century to hold down the same people, and it does not work. **Part Nine, 1586 and 1672:** the frontier tribes destroy two Mughal armies in defiles and are eventually paid rather than beaten.

Every one of them wins by the same means: **no capital, no field army, terrain the enemy cannot use, a population that will not inform, and no need to win — only the need to still be there next season.**

What is different after 1716 is that this method is being used, for the first time, by a movement with **a written scripture, a formal initiation, a standing assembly and a doctrine.**

The Khokhars had none of those and so their victories were always local and always temporary — four hundred years of being unremovable and never once turning it into a state.

Here, the same military method is attached to an institution. The bands in the Lakhi Jungle could assemble at Amritsar and pass a binding resolution. They could distribute territory among themselves and be held to it. They could hand a title to a man by common consent, which is War Nine.

Guerrilla survival plus an institution equals a government. **That combination appears in the Punjab in these decades for the first time in five thousand years, and it takes Lahore within twenty of them.**

The Nawabship, 1733 — A Title Given From Below

LIKELY

The governor of Lahore offered a peace, a jagir and a title. The way the community decided who should take it is the most interesting thing in this part.

WON BY

Nobody — a truce that lasted about two years and left behind an army

WHEN The offer in 1733; the organisation formalised soon afterwards; the peace broken within a couple of years.	WHERE Amritsar, in assembly.
WHO Zakariya Khan making the offer; the Sarbat Khalsa deciding what to do with it.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh tradition, and the fact that the organisation it produced is documented from 1748 onwards.

What happened

- The policy of extermination had failed and Zakariya Khan knew it.** Seventeen years of bounties and executions had produced a province he could not govern outside the towns.
- So he changed approach.** He offered a grant of land — a jagir around Dipalpur, Kanganpur and Jhabal — and the title of **Nawab**, to whoever the community named as its head.
- The Sarbat Khalsa met at Amritsar to consider it.** The offer was contentious: accepting a title from the government that had been hunting them was not an obvious step.
- They took it, and chose the recipient.** The tradition records that the title was conferred on **Kapur Singh**, a man of no particular rank, who was at that moment performing the ordinary service of fanning the assembly.
- And then they reorganised.** The scattered bands were formalised into two divisions — the **Buddha Dal**, the army of the elders, and the **Taruna Dal**, the army of the young, itself subdivided into five bodies each with its own leader, banner and drum.
- The peace broke down within about two years** and the hunt resumed. **The organisation did not break down.**

WHY THE MANNER OF THE APPOINTMENT MATTERS

Compare this with every other transfer of authority in these ten parts.

In Part Five a sultan's slave takes the throne because he holds the army. In Part Six the Punjab frontier command marches on Delhi. In Part Seven a governor left in charge by Timur makes himself the government. In Part Eight a thirteen-year-old is crowned on a brick platform because he is his father's son. **Every single one is either inheritance or force.**

Here, a title offered by a hostile government to "the head of the Sikhs" was received by an assembly, debated, and **conferred by that assembly on a man it selected.** The tradition's insistence that he was fanning the gathering at the time is doing exactly the work you would expect — it says that the office was given, not taken, and that the qualification was service.

Whether the detail is literal is **STORY**. What the story is asserting is a constitutional principle, and the principle is visible in what happened next.

Fifteen years later the same assembly would create the Dal Khalsa and appoint its commander. Fifty years later the misls would be dividing conquered territory among themselves by resolution at Amritsar. **That is a political system, and this is where it is first visible in operation.**

WHY ZAKARIYA KHAN OFFERED TERMS

- **The policy had failed and was expensive.** Seventeen years of bounties with the province still ungovernable outside the walls.
- **A jagir converts an enemy into a stakeholder** — the standard Mughal method, used successfully on Rajputs and Afghans for two centuries.
- **He needed the countryside quiet.** Revenue was not coming in, and revenue was what a governor was judged on.

WHY IT BACKFIRED

- **It conceded that the community existed.** Seventeen years of official policy had been that it did not. An offer of terms is a recognition.
- **It gave them a base and a breathing space,** which they used to reorganise into a formal military structure.
- **It legitimised the assembly.** By addressing an offer to "the Sikhs" he made the Sarbat Khalsa the body that answered.
- **And when the peace collapsed, they were better organised than before it started.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man With the Fan

The image at the centre of this story has been repeated for nearly three hundred years, and it is worth taking seriously as a piece of political thinking rather than as a piece of piety.

An assembly is sitting at Amritsar. On the table is an offer from the government of Lahore: land, revenue and the title of Nawab, for whoever will be recognised as the head of the community. It is the first formal recognition the Khalsa has ever been offered, and it comes from the man who has spent seventeen years killing them.

They accept, and they have to decide who.

Every other assembly in this book would have chosen the most successful commander, or the man with the most horsemen, or somebody's son.

The tradition says they gave it to the man who was fanning them while they talked.

Kapur Singh went on to be one of the most effective leaders the community produced — he held the Dal together through the worst of the persecution, and he was the man who handed the command to Jassa Singh Ahluwalia in 1748. This was not a joke appointment, and the assembly clearly knew what it was doing.

But the point of the story is the framing, and the framing is deliberate. **In a culture where the langar had established a century earlier that everybody eats in the same row, the highest office available was handed to a man performing a menial service, in front of everyone, as an argument about what authority is for.**

Fifteen years later that same assembly divided the Punjab into commands and appointed a commander-in-chief. Within twenty it was a government.

Nine parts of this book have described power passing by birth, by murder, by inheritance or by conquest. This is the first time in five thousand years that it is handed to somebody by a show of hands.

Nadir Shah, 1739 — The Road From Kabul

CERTAIN

In four months a Persian army came down the Punjab road, destroyed the Mughal empire as a functioning power, and went home with the treasury.

WON BY Nadir Shah — and the vacuum he left is the whole of Parts Eleven and Twelve

WHEN Lahore in January 1739; Karnal on 24 February; Delhi in March; back across the Indus by summer.	WHERE Down the Grand Trunk Road through the whole Punjab, and back up it.
WHO Nadir Shah of Persia against the emperor Muhammad Shah.	THE EVIDENCE Abundant — Persian, Mughal and European accounts, and the objects, which are in Iran.

What happened

1. **He came through the passes in the winter of 1738–39**, having already taken Kandahar and Kabul, and moved down the Punjab road.
2. **Lahore did not fight.** Zakariya Khan — the same governor who had spent seventeen years hunting the Sikhs — submitted, paid, and was left in place.
3. **Karnal, 24 February 1739.** The Mughal army was destroyed in a few hours on the plain north of Delhi. It was very much larger and it was beaten by better artillery, better cavalry tactics and a commander who knew what he was doing.
4. **Delhi was occupied in March.** A rumour that Nadir was dead led to attacks on his troops in the streets; the response was a general massacre lasting several hours, ordered in retaliation and stopped when the emperor pleaded for it to end. The death toll is given in tens of thousands.
5. **The city was stripped.** The treasury, the jewels, the **Peacock Throne**, the **Koh-i-Noor**, and a figure in the hundreds of millions of rupees, along with craftsmen, elephants and horses.
6. **And then he went home**, back up the same road, in the summer of 1739.
7. **On the way back the Sikhs raided him.** Bands came out of the Lakhi Jungle and the river country and took what they could off the baggage columns and, by the tradition, freed prisoners being carried north.

WHAT 1739 ACTUALLY DESTROYED

The Mughal empire did not end in 1739 — it had an emperor in Delhi until 1857. **What ended in 1739 was the idea that it could protect anything.**

The consequences run through the rest of this book and they are worth listing plainly.

The treasury was gone. An empire that cannot pay cannot command, and the provinces stopped pretending within a decade.

The frontier was gone. Nadir took the territory west of the Indus formally, and after his assassination in 1747 it passed to **Ahmad Shah Abdali**, who founded the Afghan kingdom out of it. **Whoever holds Kabul holds the door into the Punjab** — this book's most reliable rule since Part Five — and from 1747 that door belongs to a new, aggressive power that will come through it nine times.

And the road had been demonstrated again. Everybody in Asia now knew that an army from Kabul could reach Delhi in six weeks and that nothing in between would stop it.

For the Punjab specifically, the arithmetic was simple and terrible. **It sat between a capital that could no longer defend it and a new military power that had every reason to keep coming through it.** Everything in Parts Eleven and Twelve is that sentence being paid out.

WHY NADIR SHAH WON SO EASILY

- **A professional army against a ceremonial one.** The Mughal army of 1739 was enormous, magnificent and had not fought a serious war in a generation.
- **Better artillery and mounted firepower.** His men used the *zamburak* — light swivel guns on camels — and his cavalry could shoot.
- **Command.** One commander who had risen by war, against a court where the emperor's generals were rivals.
- **And Karnal was fought in a few hours.** There was no second Mughal army.

WHY THE PUNJAB COULD NOT STOP HIM

- **Lahore submitted immediately.** The governor had troops and used them to hunt his own population rather than to hold the road.
- **Seventeen years of internal war had emptied the province of anybody willing to fight for the government.**
- **The passes were long gone.** Kandahar and Kabul had fallen before he ever reached India.
- **And nobody in Delhi believed it until Karnal.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Question on the Road Home

There is a story told about Nadir Shah's return march through the Punjab in the summer of 1739, and like all the best stories in this book it may not have happened and is exactly right anyway.

His columns, loaded with the wealth of Delhi, were being raided. Small mounted parties came out of the scrub at night, took what they could off the baggage, and were gone before anything could be organised against them. It was not war; it was attrition by people who could not be caught.

The tradition has him asking Zakariya Khan who these people were.

The governor's reply, in the version that has come down, is that they are a set of religious mendicants who live in the saddle, whose homes are their horses, and who sleep in the open.

And Nadir Shah is said to have looked at that and observed that **a people who live like that will one day take this country.**

Treat it as **STORY**. It is recorded in later Persian and Sikh sources and it has the shape of a prophecy assembled after the event, which is how prophecies usually get their accuracy.

But hold the actual scene, because that part is not in doubt. In 1739 the man who had just destroyed the Mughal empire in a single afternoon was riding home through the Punjab, and the only people in that province giving him any trouble at all were fugitives with a price on their heads, operating out of a jungle, from a movement the government had officially declared extinct twenty-three years earlier.

Zakariya Khan's own army did not fire a shot at Nadir Shah. **The people he had spent his career hunting did.**

The Chhota Ghallughara, 1746

LIKELY

The one time in these decades they were caught in the open, and it cost about seven thousand lives in a month.

WON BY

Lakhpatt Rai — the worst month the community had yet had

WHEN May and June 1746.	WHERE The Kahnuwan marshes near Gurdaspur, and the hills beyond towards Basohli.
WHO Lakhpatt Rai, diwan of Lahore, with provincial troops, against the Sikh bands caught in the open.	THE EVIDENCE Persian record and Sikh tradition, which agree on the shape and roughly on the scale.

What happened

1. **It began with a private quarrel.** Jaspat Rai, the faujdar of Eminabad, was killed in a skirmish with a Sikh band. **His brother Lakhpatt Rai was the diwan — the chief revenue officer — at Lahore**, and he took it as a personal matter.
2. **He mounted a systematic campaign**, with the backing of the governor, and pursued it with a thoroughness the province had not seen since 1716. Sikhs in Lahore itself were rounded up and killed.
3. **The bands were driven north-east** out of their usual country, towards the Ravi and the hills.
4. **They were caught at Kahnuwan**, in marsh and scrub country near Gurdaspur, with the pursuit behind them and the hill states in front refusing passage.
5. **The fighting was a running massacre.** They tried to break through into the hills; the hill rajas would not let them in; they were driven back into the marshes and cut up.
6. **The figures usually given are about seven thousand killed and three thousand taken.** The prisoners were brought to Lahore and executed.
7. **It is remembered as the Chhota Ghallughara** — the lesser holocaust — a name that only makes sense because of what happens in 1762, in Part Eleven.

NAMING PEOPLE RATHER THAN COMMUNITIES

This book said in its introduction that it would name individuals, and 1746 is where that matters most.

Lakhpat Rai was a Hindu Khatri. So was his brother Jaspat Rai, whose death started it. They were career officials of the Mughal provincial administration, and the campaign of 1746 was driven by a revenue officer avenging his brother, with the resources of the state behind him.

The hill rajas who closed the passes and would not let the fugitives through were Hindu rulers — the same hill states that had besieged Anandpur in Part Nine, doing the same thing for the same reasons.

And a few years later, another Hindu Khatri official at Lahore, **Diwan Kaura Mal**, took the opposite view entirely and became known for his sympathy towards the community, to the point of being called by an honorific in Sikh sources.

This is not an argument that religion did not matter in the eighteenth-century Punjab. It obviously did, enormously. It is an argument that if you try to read these decades as one community against another, you cannot explain a single one of the four people just named.

Officials acted as officials, with careers, family obligations and grudges. Hill rajas acted as hill rajas, protecting their borders. That is what the record shows.

WHY 1746 WORKED WHEN NOTHING ELSE HAD

- **Personal motivation at the top.** Lakhpat Rai pursued it with an energy that a salaried officer executing a policy never brings.
- **They were caught in the open.** Away from the Lakhi Jungle, away from the Malwa, in country that was neither refuge nor home.
- **The hills were closed to them.** The one escape route that had always worked was shut by the rajas.
- **And the marsh trapped them.** Cavalry cannot move in flooded scrub, which removed the movement's single greatest advantage.

WHY IT STILL DID NOT FINISH IT

- **Not everybody was there.** Bands in the Malwa and across the Sutlej were untouched.
- **The organisation survived.** The Dal structure of 1733 and the assembly at Amritsar were institutions, not people, and institutions are not in marshes.
- **The state was two years from collapse.** Zakariya Khan had died in 1745, his sons fought over the succession, and Abdali crossed the Indus in 1748.
- **And within two years the survivors formalised into a standing army.** Which is War Thirteen.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Word They Had to Invent

The events of 1746 are called the **Chhota Ghallughara**. *Ghallughara* is a Punjabi word meaning something close to holocaust or catastrophe — a killing on a scale that requires its own noun.

And the word *chhota* means lesser.

Think about what has to be true for a language to name an event that way. Seven thousand people killed in a month, three thousand more executed afterwards, out of a community that numbered — nobody knows exactly, but not in the millions.

It is called the lesser one because **sixteen years later there was a bigger one**. In February 1762, at Kup near Malerkotla, Ahmad Shah Abdali caught the Dal Khalsa moving its families and killed a number that the sources put much higher. That is the *Vadda Ghallughara*, the greater, and it is War Six of Part Eleven.

A community that has to distinguish between its catastrophes by size is telling you something about the century it was having.

And here is the thing that makes the eighteenth-century Punjab genuinely unlike the rest of this book. After 1746 they did not scatter for a generation and rebuild slowly. Within two years they held a general assembly at Amritsar and organised themselves into eleven standing commands with a commander-in-chief. Within nineteen years of Kahnuwan they held Lahore.

Ten parts of this history have described defeats that ended things — the Shahis, the Chauhans, the Lodis, Hemu, Banda. **This is the first community in these pages that takes losses on this scale and comes out of it better organised than it went in.**

Manupur, March 1748 — Abdali Comes

LIKELY

The Mughals won this one, which makes it the last time. What came through the passes in 1748 came back eight more times.

WON BY The Mughal army — the final victory of the empire in the Punjab

WHEN 11 March 1748.	WHERE Manupur, near Sirhind — the same crossroads as ever.
WHO Ahmad Shah Abdali against a Mughal army under the wazir Qamaruddin and his son Muin-ul-Mulk.	THE EVIDENCE Mughal and Afghan accounts; well documented on both sides.

Who Abdali was

He had been a commander in Nadir Shah’s army. When Nadir was assassinated by his own officers in 1747, the Afghan contingent elected Ahmad Khan of the Abdali tribe as their leader, and he took the territories east of Persia — Kandahar, Kabul, and the country up to the Indus — and made them a kingdom.

He was, from 1747, the ruler of everything on the far side of the passes. Part Five established the rule and every part since has confirmed it: *whoever holds Kabul holds the door into the Punjab*. He held it, and he had an army that needed paying, and the richest country within reach was on the other side of the mountains.

What happened

1. He crossed the Indus in January 1748 and took Lahore without much difficulty. The governor’s family was in the middle of a succession dispute and the province was not defended.
2. He moved down the road towards Delhi.
3. A Mughal army came out to meet him under the wazir Qamaruddin, with his son Muin-ul-Mulk and the imperial prince.
4. Qamaruddin was killed before the battle — by a stray shot, at prayer, in his tent — and the command passed to his son.

5. **At Manupur on 11 March the Afghan army was beaten.** The accounts describe hard fighting and an explosion in the Afghan camp that decided it.
6. **Abdali withdrew to Kabul, and Muin-ul-Mulk — known ever after as Mir Mannu — was made governor of Lahore** as the reward.
7. **And he came back the following year, and the year after that.** Nine invasions in twenty years.

WHY WINNING CHANGED NOTHING

Manupur is the last battle the Mughal empire wins in the Punjab, and it is worth understanding why the victory was worthless.

The empire had no money. Nadir Shah had taken the treasury nine years earlier. A province could be defended once by an army that turned up; it could not be garrisoned permanently.

The winner became the problem. Mir Mannu, rewarded with Lahore, found himself governing a province with an Afghan army on one side and the Dal Khalsa on the other, and within two years he was paying Abdali tribute out of the revenues of the Punjab. The province was ceded formally soon after.

And the invader had come to stay in the sense that mattered. Abdali did not need to hold the Punjab; he needed to be able to reach it. He came back in 1749, 1752, 1756, and repeatedly after that.

The pattern that Part Five described at Peshawar in 1001 is now running again, with a different dynasty and identical mechanics. **A military power based at Kabul, a rich and undefended plain three hundred miles away, and a central government that cannot reach either.** Everything in Part Eleven follows.

WHY THE MUGHALS WON AT MANUPUR

- **Abdali's first invasion was small.** A new king consolidating a new kingdom, testing the road.
- **They met him near their own base.** Sirhind is close to Delhi and far from Kabul.
- **Muin-ul-Mulk fought well** after taking over on the death of his father, which made his reputation.
- **And they had luck.** The explosion in the Afghan camp is in every account.

WHY IT WAS THE LAST TIME

- **No treasury.** The single fact underneath everything after 1739.
- **No frontier.** The passes and the Indus country belonged to the invader before he set out.
- **No province.** The Punjab had been fought over internally for thirty years and would not fight for Delhi.
- **And a third party was now in the field.** Three weeks after Manupur, the Khalsa organised itself into a standing army — and neither Delhi nor Kabul had factored it in.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Same Crossroads, Again

Manupur is a few miles from **Sirhind**, and it is worth stopping to count what has happened at that crossroads in this book.

1540: Sher Shah Suri reaches Sirhind and sends the message that drives Humayun out of India. **1555:** Bairam Khan wins the battle of Sirhind and the Mughal empire is refounded. **1704:** two children are put to death at Sirhind by the faujdar. **1710:** the town is stormed and destroyed by an army raised in the villages around it. **1748:** the last Mughal victory in the Punjab is won a few miles away.

And it is not finished. **1761:** Ahmad Shah Abdali and the Marathas will decide the fate of northern India at Panipat, sixty miles down the same road. **1764:** the Sikhs will take Sirhind and it will change hands for the last time.

The reason is the reason it has always been. **Sirhind sits where the Punjab road meets the road to Delhi.** Everything coming from the passes and everything going to the capital passes through that gap, and has done since before anybody wrote it down.

Part Six made the same observation about Tarain, twenty miles away, where three battles were fought in twenty-five years. Part Seven made it about Panipat, forty miles further on, where three more were fought over two hundred and thirty-five.

There is a stretch of the Grand Trunk Road, perhaps a hundred and twenty kilometres long, on which the government of northern India has been decided at least ten times in a thousand years. It is ordinary wheat country with a motorway through it now, and there is nothing to look at.

Vaisakhi 1748 — The Dal Khalsa

LIKELY

Eighteen days after Manupur, the assembly at Amritsar turned sixty-five fighting bands into one army with a commander — and this book’s oldest failure was finally solved.

WHAT HAPPENED

Punjab acquires a confederate army with an agreed command

WHEN Vaisakhi, 29 March 1748.	WHERE Amritsar, at the Akal Takht.
WHO The Sarbat Khalsa, with Nawab Kapur Singh presiding and Jassa Singh Ahluwalia appointed to command.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources; the structure it created is documented in operation from this point onwards by everybody, including the British.

What was decided

1. **The scattered bands were consolidated.** The many *jathas* that had survived the persecution were reorganised into **eleven divisions** — later twelve — each under a named leader, each with its own banner and drum.
2. **These are the *misl*s.** The word means, roughly, an equal or a file — and the equality is the point. **Each *misl* was autonomous, kept its own territory and revenue, and none was subordinate to another.**
3. **A commander-in-chief was appointed** for the whole force in the field: **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia**, who had been raised in Kapur Singh’s household.
4. **The whole was called the *Dal Khalsa*** — the army of the Khalsa.
5. **A fort was built at Amritsar — Ram Rauni** — giving the community, for the first time since Lohgarh, a defensible place of its own.
6. **And the assembly retained authority over all of it.** The Sarbat Khalsa met at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali, passed binding resolutions — *gurmata*s — and allocated territory and tasks among the *misl*s.

WHY THIS IS THE ANSWER TO THE OLDEST PROBLEM IN THIS BOOK

Count the coalitions that have failed in these ten parts, because the list is now very long and completely consistent.

Ten kings on the Ravi in Part One. The Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two, who combined and could not agree on a commander. Nine republics submitting separately in Part Four. Yashodharman's alliance, which dissolved on the day it won. **Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five, destroyed in ten minutes when one elephant bolted.** Prithviraj's coalition at Tarain in Part Six. The Khokhars, Langahs and Afghans of Part Seven, who never once made common cause. The hill rajas of Part Nine, changing sides every three years.

Every single one failed for the same reason: several leaders of equal standing, no agreed command, and no mechanism for making a decision that everybody would obey.

The Dal Khalsa is that problem solved, and the solution has three parts. **The misls are formally equal**, so nobody is being subordinated to a rival. **The command in the field is appointed by the assembly**, not seized or inherited, so it is legitimate. **And the assembly itself is a standing body with a fixed calendar and a religious sanction**, so its resolutions bind.

It is not a perfect system and this book will not pretend it is — the misls fought each other repeatedly, and by the 1790s the confederacy was tearing itself apart, which is how Ranjit Singh becomes possible in Part Twelve.

But between 1748 and 1767 it does what no Indian coalition in five thousand years has managed: it holds together long enough to beat a superior invader, repeatedly, and then takes the country.

WHY IT WORKED

- **It formalised what already existed.** The bands, the leaders and the assembly were all thirty years old. This gave them a constitution rather than inventing one.
- **Equality removed the reason to defect.** No misl had to accept another's overlordship.
- **The command was temporary and functional.** Jassa Singh commanded in the field; he did not rule anybody.
- **And the timing was perfect.** The empire had just spent its last victory, the Afghans had just been introduced, and the province was open.

THE WEAKNESS BUILT INTO IT

- **Equality also means nobody can compel.** A misl that decided not to come to a muster could not easily be made to.
- **Territory divided is territory to argue about,** and by the 1780s they were arguing with cavalry.
- **The assembly worked under pressure and decayed without it.** Once the Afghans stopped coming, the gurmatas stopped binding.
- **And it took a war to hold it together.** Part Eleven is that war, and it is the worst one yet.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

Thirty-Two Years

Put the two dates side by side, because the distance between them is the whole argument of this part.

June 1716. Delhi. Seven hundred prisoners are executed in public over several days at the kotwali. Cartloads of heads have been paraded through the streets. The man who took Sirhind is put to death near Mehrauli after three months in captivity. The imperial order for the extermination of the community has been in force for five years and is being enforced. Two English merchants write home describing the spectacle, and note that not one of the condemned took the offer of life. **The state's position is that the matter is closed.**

March 1748. Amritsar. An assembly of the same community meets at the Akal Takht, consolidates sixty-five surviving bands into eleven standing divisions, appoints a commander-in-chief by common consent, builds a fort, and allocates the districts of the Punjab among its commanders.

Thirty-two years. One generation.

In between: a firman, a bounty on every head, a standing place of execution at Lahore, the loss of Amritsar, the executions of Mani Singh and Taru Singh, thirty years in the Lakhi Jungle, and seven thousand dead in the marshes at Kahnuwan.

And they came out with a constitution.

Nine parts of this book described a province that things were done to — invaded, garrisoned, taxed, spent, written about by other people in other languages. Part Nine gave it a book and an order. Part Ten is where those two things are tested by a state that set out deliberately to end them, and do not end.

Within seventeen years of this assembly, the Dal Khalsa took Lahore and struck coins there.

Which means the Punjab was governed by Punjabis for the first time since the Hindu Shahis lost Kabul in 870 — a gap of eight hundred and ninety-five years.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

Oct 1708	Guru Gobind Singh dies at Nanded, having sent Banda Singh Bahadur north with a letter of authority and five companions, and vested the Guruship in the book.
Nov 1709	Samana is stormed — the home town of the men who carried out the executions of 1675 and 1704 — followed by Sadhaura and half a dozen other places. Won by Banda.
12 May 1710	Chappar Chiri. Wazir Khan, the faujdar of Sirhind, is killed on the field; the town is stormed two days later and destroyed. Won by Banda.
1710–1711	A government at Lohgarh. Coins and a seal struck in the names of Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh, a new era dated from Sirhind — and the zamindari system abolished, with the land given to the cultivators.
Dec 1710	Bahadur Shah brings the imperial army north from the Deccan, takes Lohgarh — and Banda escapes. An imperial order is issued for the killing of the followers of Nanak wherever found.
1712–1713	Bahadur Shah dies and the empire falls into a succession war. Banda returns to the plains and retakes territory.
Apr–Dec 1715	Gurdas Nangal. Abdus Samad Khan walls in a farmhouse near Gurdaspur and waits eight months. Won by starvation.
Feb–Jun 1716	Delhi. Some seven hundred prisoners paraded and executed in public; Banda put to death in June. Two East India Company envoys write home that not one of the condemned recanted.
1716–1745	The price on the head. A bounty, a standing place of execution at Lahore, and Amritsar closed. Bhai Mani Singh executed c. 1738; Bhai Taru Singh c. 1745; Massa Rangar killed inside the Harmandir Sahib in 1740.
1716–1745	The forest years. No fixed ground, everything on horseback, refuge in the Lakhi Jungle and the deserts, the <i>rakhi</i> protection system, and the assembly meeting at Amritsar twice a year.
c. 1739	Bota Singh and Garja Singh set up a toll post on the Grand Trunk Road and write to the governor of Lahore to announce it. A detachment kills them.
1733	Zakariya Khan offers a jagir and the title of Nawab. The assembly accepts and confers it on Kapur Singh ; the bands are organised into the Buddha Dal and Taruna Dal . The peace lasts about two years; the organisation does not break.
Feb–Mar 1739	Nadir Shah. Lahore submits; the Mughal army is destroyed at Karnal ; Delhi is sacked and stripped of the treasury, the Peacock Throne and the Koh-i-Noor. Sikh bands raid his baggage on the road home. Won by Nadir Shah — and the empire never recovers.

May–Jun 1746	The Chhota Ghallughara. Lakhpat Rai, diwan of Lahore, avenges his brother; the bands are trapped in the Kahnuwan marshes with the hills closed against them. About seven thousand killed. Won by Lakhpat Rai.
1747	Nadir Shah is assassinated. Ahmad Shah Abdali takes Kandahar, Kabul and the country to the Indus, and founds the Afghan kingdom.
11 Mar 1748	Manupur , near Sirhind. Abdali's first invasion is beaten; the wazir Qamaruddin is killed before the battle and his son Mir Mannu becomes governor of Lahore. Won by the Mughals — for the last time.
29 Mar 1748	The Dal Khalsa is formed at Amritsar. Eleven misls, a commander-in-chief in Jassa Singh Ahluwalia, and the fort of Ram Rauni. <i>Part Eleven begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Eleven

1. **Killing the leader is now demonstrably useless.** 1606, 1675, 1704, 1716 — four decapitations by three governments, every one of them successful and none of them effective. **Part Nine claimed that an institution had been built which would outlive its leaders; Part Ten is the proof, delivered by the state's own repeated attempts to disprove it.**
2. **The coalition problem is solved.** Ten parts of failed alliances — the Ravi, the Malavas, Anandapala's confederacy, Tarain, the hill rajas — every one destroyed by having several leaders and no agreed command. **The Dal Khalsa of 1748 fixes it with formal equality between misls, a commander appointed by assembly, and a standing body that can pass binding resolutions.** Watch it hold for twenty years and then decay in Part Twelve.
3. **Territory is a liability until you can defend it.** Banda held ground and was besieged out of it twice. After 1716 the movement held nothing and could not be caught. **The moment it takes Lahore in Part Eleven, it becomes findable again — and that changes everything about how it has to fight.**
4. **Whoever holds Kabul holds the door.** Part Five's rule, now running for the eighth time. Nadir Shah took the frontier in 1739; Abdali inherited it in 1747; and from 1748 there is an aggressive military power on the far side of the passes with a standing reason to come through them. **Nine invasions in twenty years is what that sentence costs.**
5. **And the empire is gone.** After 1739 there is no power in Delhi capable of defending or governing the Punjab. What fills that vacuum — Afghans from the west, Marathas from the south, and the misls from inside — is the entire subject of the next two parts.

COMING NEXT — PART ELEVEN

The Afghans and the Ghallugharas, 1748–1767. Nine invasions in twenty years. Mir Mannu's governorship and the persecution of the early 1750s; the Punjab ceded to Kabul; **the Marathas take Lahore and reach Attock in 1758** — the furthest north an Indian power has reached since the Mughals — and are annihilated at **Panipat in January 1761**, the largest battle fought in India in a century. Then the worst day in Sikh history: the **Vadda Ghallughara** at Kup in February 1762, and the destruction of the Harmandir Sahib. And then the turn — Sialkot, Sirhind in 1764, and in **1765 the Dal Khalsa takes Lahore and strikes coin there**, in the names of the Gurus, on the same legend Banda used fifty-five years earlier.

Words Used in This Part

Hukamnama

A written order or command letter issued under the authority of the Guru. The document Banda Singh Bahadur carried north from Nanded in 1708.

Faujdar

A Mughal district military commander. Wazir Khan of Sirhind held the post; so did Jaspat Rai at Eminabad.

Zamindari

The system of intermediary landholders who collected revenue from cultivators and passed a share to the state. Abolished by Banda in the territory he held.

Firman

An imperial order. The firman of December 1710 required provincial officers to hunt and kill the followers of Nanak wherever found.

Jatha

A band — the basic unit of the movement during the persecution, from a few dozen to a few hundred, under its own leader.

Lakhi Jungle

The great belt of scrub and forest in the Malwa country south of the Sutlej, the principal refuge of the 1720s and 1730s.

Rakhi

“Protection.” A fixed share of the harvest paid by a village to a band, in return for being kept clear of other bands and of revenue officers. The beginning of Sikh territorial administration.

Sarbat Khalsa

The general assembly of the whole community, meeting at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali, whose resolutions bound everybody.

Gurmata

A binding resolution passed by the Sarbat Khalsa.

Buddha Dal / Taruna Dal

The army of the elders and the army of the young — the two divisions into which the bands were organised in the 1730s.

Dal Khalsa

The army of the Khalsa, formed at Amritsar on Vaisakhi 1748 out of the surviving bands.

Misl

One of the eleven — later twelve — autonomous divisions of the Dal Khalsa, each with its own leader, banner and territory, and none subordinate to another.

Ghallughara

A Punjabi word for a catastrophe or holocaust. The *Chhota* — lesser — is 1746; the *Vadda* — greater — is 1762, in Part Eleven.

Shahidganj

“The place of martyrs” — the site at Lahore, at the old horse market, used as the standing place of execution during the persecution.

Nakhas

The horse market at Lahore where the execution platform stood.

Zamburak

A light swivel gun mounted on a camel. Part of why Nadir Shah's army destroyed a much larger Mughal one at Karnal in a few hours.

Abdali / Durrani

Ahmad Shah, elected leader of the Afghan contingent after Nadir Shah's assassination in 1747, founder of the Afghan kingdom, and the central figure of Part Eleven.

Sources used for this part

- **Khafi Khan**, *Muntakhab-ul-Lubab*, and the *Ibratnama* of Mirza Muhammad Harisi — contemporary Persian accounts, both strongly hostile to Banda
- **The letter of John Surman and Edward Stephenson**, East India Company envoys at Delhi, March 1716 — the disinterested eyewitness account of the procession and executions
- Mughal administrative records, including the firman of December 1710
- **The coins and seal of Banda Singh Bahadur**, which survive
- Sikh sources of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries — *Prachin Panth Prakash* and related works — for the persecution, the martyrdoms and the internal organisation, treated as tradition and labelled as such
- Persian and European accounts of Nadir Shah's invasion of 1739
- Afghan and Mughal accounts of Ahmad Shah Abdali's first invasion and the battle of Manupur
- Ganda Singh's documentary work on Banda Singh Bahadur and on the eighteenth-century Punjab, and Hari Ram Gupta's history of the Sikhs
- The sites — Chappar Chiri, Gurdas Nangal, Shahidganj at Lahore, and the Akal Takht at Amritsar

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: what actually passed between Guru Gobind Singh and Banda at Nanded, and the exact nature of the authority conferred; the scale of the killing at Samana and Sirhind, where hostile Persian sources and Sikh tradition give irreconcilable accounts of the same events; the dates of the executions of Bhai Mani Singh, which the sources place variously across several years; the casualty figure for the Chhota Ghallughara; and the extent to which the 1733 nawabship story reflects what was actually decided.

Three things about method.

First, **this part does not launder Banda's campaigns**. Samana and Sirhind were stormed and sacked, with the killing that implies, by an army raised out of a real and terrible grievance. The Persian sources exaggerate and the Sikh sources justify, and underneath both there is a burned town. That has been said on the page rather than in a footnote.

Second, **the persecution is described by naming officials rather than communities**, because that is what the record supports. Abdus Samad Khan, Zakariya Khan, Yahiya Khan and Lakhpai Rai were individuals with careers, orders and grudges — and Lakhpai Rai, who ran the worst campaign of the period, was a Hindu Khatri avenging his brother, while another Hindu Khatri official at Lahore a few years later was remembered by the community with respect.

Third, **this part states the executions and does not describe them**, for the reasons given in Part Nine. The methods used at Lahore and Delhi in these decades are recorded in the tradition and are commemorated annually. Nothing is added here by rehearsing them.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART ELEVEN OF SIXTEEN

The Afghans and the Ghallugharas

Nine invasions in twenty years by a man who never lost a battle in the Punjab and never managed to keep it — and a community that lost perhaps half its people in one morning and took Lahore three years later.

1748 — 1767

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

Nine Times Down the Same Road

Twenty years, three contenders and one province. At the end of it the Punjab is governed by people born in it, for the first time since 870.

This is the most violent twenty years in this book, and it is also the shortest span any part has covered.

Three powers wanted the Punjab. **Ahmad Shah Abdali** came down from Kabul nine times between 1748 and 1767, won every significant battle he fought here, sacked Delhi, destroyed the largest army India had put in the field for a century, and blew up the Harmandir Sahib twice. **The Marathas** came up from the Deccan, took Sirhind, took Lahore, and put a flag on the Indus at Attock — the furthest north any power from peninsular India had ever reached — and were annihilated within three years. **And the Dal Khalsa**, which had eleven divisions and no capital, lost perhaps half its fighting strength in a single morning in 1762 and held Lahore by 1765.

The winner is the one that could not be caught.

Four things to hold on to

- **Abdali is undefeated and irrelevant.** He wins at Lahore, at Delhi, at Panipat and at Kup, and by 1767 he goes home for the last time with nothing. **This part is a demonstration of the difference between winning battles and holding a country**, and there is no clearer case anywhere in these sixteen parts.
- **Panipat in 1761 is the largest battle fought in India in the eighteenth century** and it did not decide who ruled India. It decided who did not.
- **The two Ghallugharas define the period.** The lesser in 1746, in Part Ten; the greater on one February morning in 1762. What happens eight months after the second one is the most remarkable thing in this part.
- **And we have a hostile eyewitness.** A qazi riding with Abdali's army in 1764 wrote a campaign account that calls the Sikhs dogs on every page and describes their conduct in terms that read like praise. **After Part Ten's English merchants, this is the second genuinely valuable outside witness in this book.**

THE HONESTY LABELS, AND A WARNING ABOUT NUMBERS

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a participant, a document, a coin. **LIKELY** means well-attested and generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition.

The casualty figures in this part are the worst in the book and the least reliable. Panipat and the Vadda Ghallughara both produced numbers that vary by a factor of three between sources, and the reason is not carelessness — it is that both events killed large numbers of non-combatants in circumstances where nobody was counting. **Where this part gives a figure it gives a range and says whose it is.**

And one more thing, since this part contains two attacks on a place of worship. **The desecrations of the Harmandir Sahib in 1757 and 1762 are documented and are stated here plainly.** They were acts of policy, aimed at a building because the building was the centre of a community that could not be caught in the field.

Mir Mannu's Punjab, 1748–1753 LIKELY

The governor who beat Abdali at Manupur spent five years hunting his own province, and the Punjabi couplet about him is the best thing anybody wrote in this century.

WON BY

Nobody — five years of a governor fighting on two fronts and losing both

WHEN

1748–1753, from Manupur to his death.

WHERE

Lahore and the whole province.

WHO

Muin-ul-Mulk — Mir Mannu — governor of Lahore, against the Dal Khalsa and against Abdali at the same time.

THE EVIDENCE

Persian record, Sikh tradition, and one couplet that has outlived every document.

The impossible job

Mir Mannu was given Lahore in 1748 as the reward for winning at Manupur, and it was a poisoned gift. He had:

1. **An empire behind him that could not pay him.** Nadir Shah had taken the treasury nine years earlier. Delhi could give him a title and nothing else.
2. **Abdali in front of him.** The Afghan king came back in 1748–49 and again in 1751–52, and each time the answer was to concede more.
3. **And the Dal Khalsa inside the province**, newly organised as of March 1748 and expanding into every district the government could not garrison.

His response to the third problem was the policy of Part Ten, intensified. **Movable columns were sent through the districts with orders to kill; the bounty system was reinstated; families were seized at Lahore.** The Sikh sources for these years are among the grimmest in the tradition, and they concern women and children held in the city.

RAM RAUNI, 1748 — AND HOW A MISL GOT ITS NAME

The first serious action came almost immediately. In late 1748 a Sikh force was besieged in **Ram Rauni**, the new mud fort at Amritsar, by provincial troops under **Adina Beg Khan**, the faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab.

The siege lasted months and the position was close to hopeless. It was lifted through the intervention of **Diwan Kaura Mal**, Mir Mannu's Hindu Khatri revenue minister, who argued that the Sikhs were more useful as allies against a rival than as corpses — and who was known in Sikh sources by an affectionate nickname that turned his own name, which means bitter, into its opposite.

And during that siege, a commander in the government's own service named **Jassa Singh** changed sides and went into the fort. He afterwards rebuilt it and renamed it **Ramgarh**, and took his own name from it: **Jassa Singh Ramgarhia**, whose misl becomes one of the great powers of Part Twelve.

Two things in that paragraph are worth holding. A Hindu official saved the Sikhs at Amritsar in 1748; a Sikh officer of the Mughal government defected to them in the middle of a siege. **Part Ten said this book would name people rather than communities. Here is why.**

WHY MIR MANNU COULD NOT WIN

- **Two enemies, one army.** Every soldier used against the Sikhs was a soldier not on the Afghan frontier, and the reverse.
- **No money.** He was paying tribute to Kabul out of a province he could not fully tax.
- **The countryside was not his.** The *rakhi* system of Part Ten meant villages were already paying somebody else for protection, and getting it.
- **And there was nothing to besiege.** After Ram Rauni the Dal Khalsa went back to holding nothing.

WHAT HIS POLICY PRODUCED

- **Recruits.** The same mechanism as 1716 and 1746, and by now the state had run the experiment three times.
- **A hardened organisation.** Five years of pressure with a functioning assembly at Amritsar is five years of practice.
- **An exhausted province.** When Abdali came in 1752, Lahore could not hold him.
- **And his own death solved nothing.** He fell from his horse in November 1753 and the province fell apart faster without him.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Mannu Is Our Sickle

Of everything produced in the Punjab in the middle of the eighteenth century — the chronicles, the letters, the administrative records — the thing that has survived best is four lines of doggerel that nobody signed.

It is in Punjabi, it rhymes, and it says roughly this: **Mannu is our sickle and we are his crop; the more he cuts us down, the more we grow.**

It was said in villages, by people with a price on their heads, about the man who was hunting them, and it has been repeated for two hundred and seventy years.

Take it seriously as an argument, because it is one. **It is an accurate strategic assessment delivered as a joke.** A crop that is mowed grows back thicker; a policy of killing a community faster than it reproduces only works if you can actually find everybody, and Mir Mannu could not. He knew he could not. The couplet is telling him so.

And notice what it does not contain. There is no god in it, no revenge in it, no self-pity in it, and no threat. **It is contempt, expressed as agricultural observation, by farmers.**

This book has spent ten parts looking for the voice of the ordinary population of the Punjab and finding almost nothing — a coin legend in Part Three, a hymn in Part Seven, a letter to an emperor in Part Nine. Every one of those was produced by somebody exceptional.

This one is anonymous, it is funny, and it turned out to be right. Mir Mannu was dead within five years and the crop took Lahore twelve years after that.

Lahore, 1752 — The Province Is Signed Away

LIKELY

After a four-month siege, the Mughal emperor formally ceded the Punjab and Multan to the king of Afghanistan. On paper it settled everything. It settled nothing at all.

WON BY

Ahmad Shah Abdali — who acquired a province he could not administer

WHEN The siege through the winter of 1751–52; the cession in April 1752.	WHERE Lahore.
WHO Abdali’s third invasion, against Mir Mannu.	THE EVIDENCE Mughal and Afghan records; the cession is a documented transfer.

What happened

1. **Abdali came back in late 1751** — his third crossing in four years — and invested Lahore.
2. **Mir Mannu held out for about four months.** The defence was real; this was not a city that opened its gates.
3. **Diwan Kaura Mal was killed** in the fighting outside the city — the man who had saved the Sikhs at Ram Rauni three years earlier, dying in the defence of Lahore against the Afghans.
4. **Mir Mannu was defeated and submitted.** And Abdali, in one of the shrewdest decisions in this part, **reappointed him as governor** — now holding Lahore for Kabul rather than for Delhi.
5. **In April 1752 the emperor in Delhi formally ceded the Punjab and Multan** to Ahmad Shah Abdali.

WHAT A CESSION IS WORTH

Look at what that document actually transferred.

Delhi gave away a province it did not control. The Mughal government had not been able to collect revenue across most of the Punjab for a decade, could not protect it, and had not sent an army into it since Manupur.

Kabul received a province it could not hold. Abdali's method was the campaign, not the garrison: he came, won, took what he could carry, appointed somebody, and went home before the hot weather. **An Afghan king ruling Lahore from Kandahar is exactly the arrangement the Ghaznavids had in Part Five and the Ghurids in Part Six, and it worked for them because they had no third party in the field.**

And the third party is the whole difference. **Between the departing empire and the arriving one there was, in 1752, an organised military confederacy of Punjabis with an assembly, a command structure and a protection-revenue system already running in the villages.**

Neither signatory to the cession mentioned them. Within thirteen years they had Lahore.

WHY ABDALI TOOK IT

- **He held the passes.** Part Five's rule, ninth appearance. Kandahar, Kabul and the Indus country had been his since 1747.
- **He could come back every year.** Three hundred miles from Peshawar to Lahore, in a good season, with cavalry.
- **Delhi could not respond.** No treasury, no field army, and a succession crisis of its own.
- **And he was patient about form.** Leaving Mir Mannu in place cost nothing and gave the transfer a legality it would otherwise have lacked.

WHY POSSESSION MEANT NOTHING

- **He never stayed.** Nine invasions and not one winter spent governing.
- **His governors were caught between two fires,** exactly as Mir Mannu had been — Afghan tribute above, Sikh *rakhi* below.
- **The revenue never arrived.** A province where villages pay somebody else for protection is not a taxable province.
- **And the more often he came, the more the Punjab organised against him.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Was Called Sweet

Diwan Kaura Mal was a Hindu Khatri from the Multan country who rose through the Mughal revenue service to become the diwan — the chief financial officer — of the Punjab under Mir Mannu.

He is remembered in Sikh tradition with an affection that is almost unique for a government official of that century, and the reason is a pun. His name, *Kaura*, means bitter. The Sikhs called him **Mitha Mal** — sweet.

What he did to earn it was practical rather than sentimental. In 1748 he argued Mir Mannu into lifting the siege of Ram Rauni. He consistently advocated accommodation rather than extermination. He is credited with securing the community's access to Amritsar at points when the policy was to deny it, and with using his position to moderate what the columns did in the districts.

He was not a sympathiser in any modern sense. **He was a senior official of the government doing the hunting, who thought the hunting was bad policy, and who had enough standing to say so.**

He was killed in 1752 outside Lahore, fighting the Afghans, in the service of the Mughal governor.

Set him beside **Lakhpai Rai** from Part Ten — the other Hindu Khatri diwan of Lahore, who ran the worst massacre of the 1740s to avenge his brother. Same community, same office, same city, fifteen years apart, and opposite conduct.

That is what the eighteenth-century Punjab actually looked like from inside, and it is why this book keeps refusing to write sentences that begin with the name of a religion and end with a verb.

Delhi, Mathura and Amritsar, 1757

LIKELY

The fourth invasion took the capital of India, sacked two pilgrimage cities, and on the way home destroyed a building.

WON BY

Abdali — everywhere he went, and it changed nothing structurally

WHEN January to April 1757.	WHERE Delhi, Mathura and Vrindavan, and then Amritsar on the return.
WHO Abdali's fourth invasion; the Amritsar operation under his general Jahan Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Persian and Afghan accounts, Maratha correspondence, and Sikh tradition.

What happened

1. **He entered Delhi in January 1757** and held it for about a month. The city was systematically stripped — the second such stripping in eighteen years, and there was much less left to take than Nadir Shah had found.
2. **Then Mathura and Vrindavan.** The sack of these two Hindu pilgrimage cities in the spring of 1757 was accompanied by a massacre that the sources on all sides describe in similar terms.
3. **An epidemic — described as cholera — broke out in his army** and forced the withdrawal earlier than planned.
4. **On the way home he dealt with Amritsar.** In April 1757, Jahan Khan's troops **demolished the Harmandir Sahib and filled the sacred tank with debris and the carcasses of slaughtered animals.**
5. **He left his son Timur Shah as viceroy at Lahore** with Jahan Khan to run the province.

WHY THE BUILDING

It is worth being precise about the military logic here, because it is not mysterious and it is not incidental.

The Dal Khalsa could not be brought to battle. Ten parts of this book have established what that means: no capital, no field army to destroy, nothing to besiege, a population that will not inform. Abdali had the finest cavalry in Asia and there was nothing to point it at.

But the community had one fixed point, and everybody knew where it was. The assembly met at Amritsar twice a year. The Harmandir Sahib was the one address the Khalsa could not abandon.

So the building was attacked, twice — in 1757 and again in 1762 — as the only available substitute for an enemy that would not stand still. **It is the same reasoning that produced the destruction of Sirhind in 1710, in the opposite direction: when you cannot reach the people, you go for the place.**

It did not work either time, and the reason is the subject of War Ten. **The community rebuilt the tank and came back to it within months on both occasions,** and the second desecration produced the largest assembly at Amritsar in twenty years.

WHY NOTHING COULD STOP HIM

- **Nobody in northern India had a field army.** Delhi had no treasury; the Punjab's governor was his own appointee; the Marathas were not yet in position.
- **Speed.** He crossed the Indus in the cold weather and was back before the heat every single time.
- **He came for plunder, not for territory.** An objective you can carry away is an objective you always achieve.
- **And he had allies in the doab.** The Rohilla Afghans of the Ganges country welcomed him and would be decisive at Panipat four years later.

WHAT HE COULD NOT ACHIEVE

- **A settled province.** Timur Shah lasted just over a year at Lahore before being thrown out by the Marathas.
- **An end to the Dal Khalsa.** Which is why he came back five more times.
- **Any revenue worth the name.** Plunder is one-off; taxation requires a government.
- **And the destruction at Amritsar bought him an enemy that would never negotiate.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Tank That Kept Being Refilled

The pool at Amritsar was dug in the 1570s by Guru Ram Das, and the town took its name from it — *Amritsar*, the pool of nectar. Part Eight described its founding. The shrine in the middle of it was completed under Guru Arjan by about 1589.

In this part it is destroyed twice — in 1757 and again in 1762 — and on both occasions the tank itself was deliberately fouled: filled with rubble and with the carcasses of cattle, which in that context is not vandalism but a message, and everybody involved understood it as one.

Both times it was cleared and refilled.

That is the whole of it, and it is worth pausing on because it is the most literal illustration in this book of the difference between a place and an institution.

You can demolish a building in a day. What you cannot demolish is the fact that several thousand armed men, scattered across a province, have agreed to be in the same field twice a year on two fixed dates. The dates are in a calendar; the calendar is in a book; the book is in every congregation in the Punjab. **The tank is where they meet, not why.**

Part Nine described a Guru taking initiation from five men he had just created so that the order would outlive him. Part Ten described a movement that survived thirty years by owning nothing that could be taken. **Here is the same principle again, and the enemy testing it directly with gunpowder.**

The Harmandir Sahib standing today is a later building. The tank is the same water in the same place, and it has been cleared out and refilled more than once by people who were being hunted at the time.

Gohalwar, November 1757 — The Old Man

LIKELY

A seventy-five-year-old scholar left his desk, raised a force, and died within sight of the town.

WON BY

The Afghan garrison — and the man who lost is the one everybody remembers

WHEN

November 1757, about seven months after the demolition.

WHERE

Gohalwar, a few miles from Amritsar.

WHO

Baba Deep Singh and a volunteer force, against the Afghan troops holding Amritsar.

THE EVIDENCE

Sikh tradition. The core is accepted; the most famous element is not history.

What happened

1. **Baba Deep Singh was a scholar** — one of the leading figures in the copying and transmission of the scripture, based at Damdama Sahib in the Malwa, and by 1757 he was about seventy-five.
2. **News of the demolition reached him** and he undertook to go and reclaim the site.
3. **A force gathered as he moved north.** The tradition describes numbers accumulating from village to village on the road to Amritsar.
4. **They were intercepted at Gohalwar**, a few miles short, by the Afghan troops from the city.
5. **The fighting was severe and Baba Deep Singh was killed.** The Sikh force did not take Amritsar.

THE FAMOUS PART, AND WHAT TO DO WITH IT

The image everybody knows — **the old man fighting on after being mortally struck, carrying his own severed head in one hand and his weapon in the other, until he reaches the edge of the sacred tank** — is **STORY**. It is one of the most reproduced images in Sikh devotional art and it is not something that happened.

This book has said the same about the elephant at Hastivanj in Part Four, about Prithviraj's arrow in Part Six, and about the fifty-two rajas' cloak in Part Nine. **The rule does not bend for anybody.**

But look at what the historical core actually is, because it does not need decorating. **A man of seventy-five, whose life had been spent copying and teaching a text, put it down, raised a force out of the villages, marched on a garrisoned town, and was killed a few miles short of it.**

He knew the odds. Everybody who went with him knew the odds. They went anyway, seven months after the thing they were going to reclaim had been blown up, at a moment when the community was officially supposed to have been suppressed for the fourth time in fifty years.

The legend exists because the fact needed a shape. A story about a man who would not stop is what you get when a community tries to explain to itself why an old scholar walked to Amritsar.

WHY THE ATTEMPT FAILED

- **A volunteer force against regular troops.** Men gathered on the road, without artillery, against an Afghan garrison in position.
- **They were intercepted short of the objective,** in the open, which is the one place the Dal Khalsa never chose to fight.
- **It was not a Dal Khalsa operation.** This was a march undertaken on its own account, not a campaign agreed by the assembly.

WHY IT MATTERED ANYWAY

- **It answered the demolition within the year.** Which is what the demolition had been designed to make impossible.
- **It came out of the Malwa.** The community south of the Sutlej mobilising for Amritsar showed the assembly was still binding people three hundred kilometres apart.
- **And it gave the century one of its two or three central images.** Which, for a movement that survives on what its people are willing to do, is not a small military asset.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Scribe

The thing usually left out of the story of Baba Deep Singh is what he did for the fifty years before it.

He was a scribe. He worked on copies of the scripture — the painstaking, unglamorous business of reproducing a large text by hand, accurately, so that congregations across the Punjab could have one. He was associated with the establishment at **Damdama Sahib**, in the Malwa country, which is where the definitive recension of the Guru Granth Sahib is traditionally held to have been prepared under Guru Gobind Singh, and he is remembered as having been part of that work.

In a community being hunted with a price on every head, in a province where owning the book could be fatal, **somebody had to keep making copies.**

Ten parts of this history have been about the loss of records. Taxila's libraries burned in Part Four. Anandpur's manuscripts went into the Sarsa in the dark in Part Nine. **The single greatest complaint of this entire book is that the Punjab's own account of itself keeps not surviving.**

It survives from the eighteenth century, through the worst persecution in the province's history, because men like this one sat and copied it out while the columns were in the districts.

And then, at seventy-five, he put the pen down and went to Amritsar.

The warrior is what the paintings show. The scribe is why there is anything to paint.

Attock, 1758 — The Marathas Reach the Indus LIKELY

An army from the Deccan took Sirhind, took Lahore, drove the Afghan viceroy out of the Punjab, and planted a flag on the Indus. It is the furthest north a power from peninsular India had ever come, and it lasted four months.

WON BY

The Marathas — and it is the high point and the beginning of the end

WHEN March to May 1758.	WHERE Sirhind, then Lahore, then Attock on the Indus.
WHO Raghunath Rao and Malharrao Holkar, with Adina Beg Khan and Sikh contingents, against Timur Shah and Jahan Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Maratha correspondence, which is abundant and excellent; Persian accounts; Sikh tradition.

How the Marathas got there

They had been expanding north for a generation. From a base in the Deccan they had made themselves the effective power behind the Mughal throne — protecting Delhi, collecting tribute across northern India, and by the 1750s holding a claim to defend the empire that the empire itself could not enforce.

In 1757, after Abdali sacked Delhi and Mathura and went home leaving his son at Lahore, the Marathas were invited north to deal with it — and **Adina Beg Khan**, the endlessly resourceful faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab, brokered it. He had spent his career playing Mughals, Afghans, Marathas and Sikhs against each other, and this was his masterpiece.

What happened

1. **Sirhind fell in March 1758** to a combined force of Marathas, Adina Beg’s troops and Sikhs.
2. **Lahore fell in April.** Timur Shah and Jahan Khan were driven out of the Punjab entirely.
3. **The pursuit went to the Indus.** Maratha detachments took **Attock** in May 1758 and raided towards Peshawar.

4. **Adina Beg was installed as governor** on a very large annual tribute to Pune — and died in September, five months later.
5. **And the alliance came apart.** Maratha troops in the Punjab behaved as armies of occupation do; the Sikhs, who had helped take both Sirhind and Lahore, got nothing they regarded as their share; and the relationship curdled.
6. **The Maratha hold lasted until Abdali came back at the end of 1759.**

WHY THE SIKHS SAT OUT PANIPAT

This is one of the most argued-over questions in eighteenth-century Indian history and the answer is mostly in 1758.

The Sikhs had been useful allies and were treated as auxiliaries. They provided troops and local knowledge for the campaigns that took Sirhind and Lahore, and the settlement afterwards gave the province to Adina Beg and the revenue to Pune.

The Marathas were an occupying army, not a liberating one. Their method across northern India was *chauth* — a demand for a quarter of the revenue, enforced by cavalry. To a Punjabi village it was not obviously different from what Lahore had been doing.

And the Maratha commanders did not think they needed them. The army that marched to Panipat was the largest and best-equipped force in India and its leadership was confident.

So when the decisive campaign came in 1760, the Dal Khalsa was not in it. **What they did instead was watch the Afghans go past, and then attack them on the way home** — which is War Seven, and which is the strategy of a power that has learned exactly what it is good at.

Whether a Sikh alliance would have changed Panipat is unanswerable and endlessly asserted. What can be said is narrower: **the two forces that could have fought Abdali together in 1761 had fallen out in 1758 over the division of the Punjab.**

WHY THE MARATHAS GOT TO ATTOCK

- **Abdali had gone home.** They fought Timur Shah, not his father, and the difference was decisive.
- **They had local partners.** Adina Beg's intelligence and the Sikh contingents made the campaign possible.
- **Excellent light cavalry.** The Maratha army moved fast and lived off the country as well as anybody in Asia.
- **And nobody defended the Punjab for Kabul.** The province had no reason to.

WHY THEY COULD NOT HOLD IT

- **Two thousand kilometres from Pune.** The oldest problem in this book, and the Marathas had no Grand Trunk Road equivalent running south.
- **They governed by extraction.** *Chauth* is a revenue demand, not an administration, and it makes no friends.
- **Adina Beg died.** The one man who could actually run the province lasted five months.
- **And they had alienated the only local force that mattered,** which cost them nothing in 1758 and everything in 1761.

The Flag on the Indus

In May 1758, Maratha troops stood on the bank of the Indus at Attock — the crossing where Timur bridged the river in 1398 and where Akbar built the fort in the 1580s.

They had come from Pune. It is roughly two thousand kilometres in a straight line and considerably more by road.

No power based in peninsular India had ever reached that point. Not the Satavahanas, not the Chalukyas, not Vijayanagara, not the Bahmanis. The Mauryas and the Guptas and the Mughals had all held the Indus, but they were northern powers reaching west. **This was the Deccan reaching the Afghan frontier, and it had never happened before and has not happened since.**

It lasted about eighteen months in the Punjab as a whole and four months at Attock.

Two and a half years later, on 14 January 1761, the army that had done it was destroyed sixty miles from Delhi and the Maratha empire never recovered its ambitions in the north.

There is a lesson here that this book has been repeating since Part Three and that gets forgotten every time. **The furthest extent of an empire is almost always the moment before its collapse, and for exactly the same reason: the reach that produced it is the overreach that ends it.**

Chandragupta II's inscription boasts of crossing the seven mouths of the Sindhu. Muhammad bin Tughluq's empire reached its greatest extent about four years before it dissolved. The Maratha flag at Attock in May 1758 is the same phenomenon, dated to the month.

Panipat, 14 January 1761

CERTAIN

The largest battle fought in India in a century, on the same ground as 1526 and 1556 — and it decided who would not rule India rather than who would.

WON BY Ahmad Shah Abdali — who went home and never governed a square mile of it

WHEN 14 January 1761, from morning to mid-afternoon.	WHERE Panipat, on the Grand Trunk Road north of Delhi — the third decisive battle on that field in 235 years.
WHO Sadashivrao Bhau for the Marathas, against Abdali and his Indian allies.	THE NUMBERS Perhaps 45,000–60,000 Maratha fighting troops, with a camp of civilians several times that. Abdali’s coalition of similar fighting strength, with better cavalry and artillery.

How they came to be there

1. **Abdali came back at the end of 1759** to recover what the Marathas had taken, and made alliances the Marathas could not match — the Rohilla Afghans of the Ganges doab under **Najib-ud-Daula**, and the Nawab of Awadh, **Shuja-ud-Daula**.
2. **The Marathas sent a great army north** under Sadashivrao Bhau, with the Peshwa’s son Vishwasrao, and with **Ibrahim Khan Gardi** commanding European-trained infantry and artillery.
3. **They took Delhi in August 1760**, and then Kunjpura in October — where the Afghan garrison was massacred, which hardened everything that followed.
4. **Then Abdali crossed the Yamuna behind them** and cut them off from Delhi and from the south.
5. **And the two armies sat facing each other for about two months.** This is the part that decided it. **The Maratha camp contained tens of thousands of non-combatants — pilgrims, families, camp followers — and it slowly starved.**
6. **On 14 January the Marathas attacked**, because they had to.

What happened on the day

1. **The Maratha centre and left did well in the morning.** Ibrahim Khan Gardi's infantry and guns pushed the Afghan right back, and Bhau's centre broke into the enemy line.
2. **Abdali held his reserve.** Several thousand of his best troops were kept out of the fighting for hours, and he committed them in the afternoon — **the same answer Muhammad of Ghor used at Tarain in Part Six and Babur used at Panipat in Part Seven.**
3. **Vishwasrao was killed** — shot, in the middle of the fighting, in full view of the army.
4. **Bhau went in after him and disappeared.** His body was identified afterwards.
5. **And the army broke.** Not gradually. The accounts describe a line that was holding and then, within a short time of the two men going down, was not there.
6. **The pursuit and the aftermath were worse than the battle.** Tens of thousands were killed in the rout; a very large number of prisoners were killed the following day; and the civilians in the camp were caught in all of it.

THE SINGLE POINT OF FAILURE, FOR THE SEVENTH TIME

This book has been counting, and Panipat is the clearest case yet.

Porus's elephants in Part Two. Anandapala's elephant at Waihind in Part Five. Muhammad of Ghor wounded at Tarain in Part Six. Qutlugh Khwaja hit at Kili. Hemu's arrow at Panipat in Part Eight. Wazir Khan killed at Chappar Chiri in Part Ten. And now Vishwasrao shot and Bhau gone, and one of the finest armies in Asia disintegrating within an hour of it.

The mechanism never varies. **An army held together by the visible presence of its commanders, with no institutional structure that can fight the battle without them.**

And it is worth noting who does not suffer from it. Abdali kept a reserve and directed the battle from outside it. His army was a professional force under a single owner with subordinate commanders who could act.

So was the Dal Khalsa, which was not on that field — eleven misls, each under its own leader, any of whom could be killed without the others stopping. That is not a coincidence and it is the reason the last war of this part goes the way it does.

WHY ABDALI WON

- **He cut them off and waited.** Two months of blockade did more than the battle. **Blockades always work; Part Ten made the point at Gurdas Nangal and here it is at national scale.**
- **He had allies and they had none.** The Rohillas and Awadh gave him numbers, supplies and local knowledge in a country the Marathas were operating in as strangers.
- **Better cavalry and mounted firepower.** Afghan horse and camel-mounted swivel guns against an army built around infantry and heavy artillery.
- **And he held a reserve until the afternoon.** The oldest winning move in this book.

WHY THE MARATHAS LOST

- **They fought at the end of a two-thousand-kilometre line** with no secure supply and no friendly province behind them.
- **They brought a civilian camp to a war.** Tens of thousands of non-combatants meant they could not manoeuvre, could not disperse, and starved faster.
- **They had made enemies of everyone in the north.** Rohillas, Awadh, Rajputs and Sikhs all had reasons to prefer them beaten.
- **And they attacked because they were starving,** which is the worst reason to attack anybody.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Two Pearls Dissolved

The news had to be sent to Pune, two thousand kilometres away, and the letter that carried it is one of the most famous sentences in Indian history.

It reports the disaster in code, in the language of a jeweller taking stock. **Two pearls have been dissolved. Twenty-seven gold coins have been lost. And of the silver and the copper, the total cannot be cast up.**

The two pearls were Vishwasrao, the Peshwa's son and heir, and Sadashivrao Bhau, his cousin and the commander. The gold coins were the senior commanders. The silver and copper were everybody else.

Of the silver and the copper, the total cannot be cast up.

Modern estimates of the dead run from forty thousand upward for the battle itself, with a comparable number of prisoners killed afterwards and an unknown but very large number of the civilians who had come north with the army. **Almost every substantial family in Maharashtra lost somebody at Panipat**, and the phrase is still used in Marathi to mean a catastrophe.

The Peshwa, Balaji Baji Rao, received the news and died in June, five months later.

And here is the part that makes it a Punjab story rather than a Maratha one. **Abdali had just destroyed the largest army in India and had northern India lying open in front of him. He did not take it.** His own troops were owed pay and wanted to go home; his supply position was bad; and he had no administration capable of governing anything east of the Indus.

So he went back up the Grand Trunk Road, through the Punjab, with his columns strung out and loaded — **and that is War Seven.**

The Road Home, 1761

LIKELY

The Sikhs did not fight at Panipat. They fought the winner on his way back, took what he was carrying, and then walked into Lahore.

WON BY

The Dal Khalsa — by attacking the one thing Abdali could not defend

WHEN	WHERE
February–March 1761 on the road; November 1761 at Lahore.	The Grand Trunk Road through the Punjab, and then Lahore .
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
The misls under Jassa Singh Ahluwalia , against Abdali’s returning columns.	Sikh tradition and Persian accounts, which agree on the raiding if not on the numbers.

What happened

1. **Abdali withdrew north in February 1761**, with the plunder of a campaign and a very large number of prisoners taken at and after Panipat — mostly women and children being carried to Afghanistan.
2. **The misls attacked the columns repeatedly**. Not a battle: a series of raids on the flanks and the rear of a strung-out army moving through country the raiders knew and the army did not.
3. **Prisoners were taken off the columns and freed**. The tradition records this in detail and gives figures in the low thousands; Persian sources acknowledge the losses without the arithmetic. **The freed captives were escorted back to their homes across northern India**.
4. **Abdali got home**, having lost baggage and prisoners and gained nothing he could keep.
5. **And in November 1761 the Dal Khalsa took Lahore**. The Afghan governor could not hold it. **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was proclaimed Sultan-ul-Qaum — king of the nation — and a coin was struck**.
6. **They did not try to hold it**. When Abdali came back in strength at the end of the year, they left the city and dispersed, which is the method that had kept them alive for forty years.

HANDLE WITH CARE

The rescue of the Panipat captives is one of the best-known episodes in Sikh tradition, and the numbers given for it vary. The figure most often quoted is in the region of two thousand two hundred; other accounts give more.

What is solid: Abdali's return march through the Punjab in early 1761 was harassed continuously; his columns lost baggage and prisoners; and captives taken at Panipat were freed by Sikh bands and sent home. Persian sources hostile to the Sikhs record the harassment and the losses without disputing what caused them.

What is not solid: any specific total.

And the second event needs its own caution. **Whether a coin was actually struck at Lahore in November 1761, or whether the striking belongs to the occupation of 1765, is disputed among numismatists.** The proclamation of Jassa Singh Ahluwalia as *Sultan-ul-Qaum* is well attested; the metal is argued about.

WHY THE RAIDING WORKED

- **A loaded army cannot manoeuvre.** Part Six made this exact point about the Mongols at Jaran-Manjur in 1298 — plunder is heavy and nobody will abandon it.
- **They chose the moment.** Not before Panipat, not during it, but on the return, when the winner was tired, strung out and going away.
- **They knew the ground.** Four hundred kilometres of road through their own country.
- **And they were not trying to beat him.** The objective was the baggage and the captives, and both were achievable.

WHY THEY GAVE LAHORE UP AGAIN

- **They could not hold a city against Abdali in the field.** They had known this since 1748 and it did not change until 1765.
- **A garrison is a target.** The lesson of Banda at Lohgarh and Gurdas Nangal, learned permanently.
- **The misls were a raiding confederacy, not yet a state.** Holding a capital requires an administration nobody had built.
- **And Abdali was coming.** Within three months he was back, and War Eight is what happened.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What They Did With the Winner

Stand back from January and February of 1761 and look at the whole shape of it, because it is the clearest strategic lesson in this part.

The Marathas fought Abdali properly. They brought the largest and best-equipped army in India, with European-trained infantry and a modern artillery train, met him on a chosen field, and were destroyed in an afternoon along with tens of thousands of their people.

The Sikhs did not fight him at all. They watched him go past, let him win, and then attacked his baggage on the road home.

Nine months later the Marathas were finished as a power in northern India, and the Dal Khalsa was in Lahore proclaiming a king.

It is worth being honest about how this looks. **There is no glory in it.** Nobody has painted the raids on the Grand Trunk Road in February 1761. The battle honours belong to Panipat, and Panipat was a catastrophe.

But look at what forty-five years of being hunted had taught. **Never fight the enemy's battle. Never hold what he can take. Attack what he cannot defend, when he is going away. Have no capital to lose and no army that dies with a commander.**

Part Ten described where that method came from — the Lakhi Jungle, the bounty years, Gurdas Nangal. This is what it was for.

And the thing it produced on that road was not only plunder. **Several thousand people who had been taken north as slaves were pulled off those columns and walked home,** to places all over northern India, by a confederacy that was itself under a standing order of extermination.

Of everything in this part, that is the paragraph to keep.

The Vadda Ghallughara, 5 February 1762

LIKELY

He marched two hundred kilometres in about two days and caught them with their families on the road. It is the worst morning in Sikh history.

WON BY

Ahmad Shah Abdali — the greatest single loss the community has ever taken

WHEN	WHERE
5 February 1762, in one day.	Near Kup and Rahira, close to Malerkotla, in the Malwa country south of the Sutlej.
WHO	THE NUMBERS
Abdali's sixth invasion, with the Sirhind and Malerkotla forces, against the whole Dal Khalsa and its <i>vahir</i> .	Killed: sources give between about ten thousand and thirty thousand . Sikh tradition puts it near the upper figure.

What made it possible

Everything the community had done for forty-five years depended on one thing: **being able to disperse**. Bands on horseback, nothing to defend, no fixed position, no baggage.

In February 1762 they were not dispersed and they were not unencumbered. **They were moving the *vahir*** — the whole non-combatant body of the community, women, children, the old and the sick, with their possessions — south-west across the Malwa towards the safety of the desert country, because Abdali had come back into the Punjab and the villages were no longer safe.

An army escorting its own families cannot scatter. That is the entire explanation of what followed.

What happened

1. **Abdali force-marched from Lahore**. The accounts describe a distance of roughly two hundred kilometres covered in something close to forty-eight hours. It is a remarkable feat of movement and it is why the Sikhs were caught at all.
2. **He was joined by the Afghan forces of Sirhind and Malerkotla**, so the trap closed from more than one direction.

3. **The Dal Khalsa did the only thing available.** The fighting men formed a moving ring around the *vahir* and tried to keep marching south-west while fighting on all sides.
4. **The running battle went on for most of the day** over many kilometres of open country towards Barnala.
5. **The ring held and the losses were catastrophic.** Most of the dead were non-combatants. **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was carried off the field with wounds counted in the dozens.**
6. **A remnant reached the desert country and survived.**

ON THE NUMBER, AND ON WHAT “HALF” MEANS

The figures for the Vadda Ghallughara are the least reliable in this book, and the reason should be stated. **Most of the dead were civilians on a road, killed over many hours across a wide stretch of country, and nobody counted them.**

Sikh tradition gives figures around twenty-five to thirty thousand and holds that this was somewhere near half the community. Persian sources give lower numbers, as sources do when the killing includes non-combatants. Modern historians generally accept something in the range of ten to thirty thousand and decline to be more precise.

What is not in doubt is the character of it. This was not a defeat in the field. It was the destruction of a population that its own army was trying to shield while walking.

And the name records the judgement. Part Ten explained why 1746 is called the *Chhota* — lesser — Ghallughara. **It is called lesser because of this one.**

WHY ABDALI SUCCEEDED

- **Speed.** The march from Lahore is the whole battle. He arrived before anybody thought he could.
- **He caught them encumbered.** The one condition under which the Dal Khalsa could not use its only real advantage.
- **Open ground.** The Malwa plain in February — no forest, no marsh, no hills, nothing to break up cavalry.
- **And he had local allies closing the other side.**

WHY THEY COULD NOT AVOID IT

- **They would not abandon the *vahir*.** The fighting men could have dispersed and lived. They did not, and that decision is the reason for the casualty figure.
- **They were between refuges.** Caught in the open between the villages they had left and the desert they were making for.
- **They had no warning.** The march from Lahore outran the intelligence network that had protected them for forty years.
- **And there was nowhere to stand.** No fort, no hills, no river — only a ring of men walking.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Malerkotla

The battle was fought a few miles from the small state of **Malerkotla**, whose Afghan ruling family sent troops to join Abdali on that February morning.

And Malerkotla is the one place in the Punjab that Sikh armies afterwards did not touch.

The reason goes back to Part Nine, to Sirhind in December 1704. When the two younger sons of Guru Gobind Singh were brought before Wazir Khan and sentence was passed, the tradition records that **the Nawab of Malerkotla, Sher Muhammad Khan, spoke against it** — objecting that whatever quarrel there was with the father, it could not be visited on children. The protest is remembered as the *haah da naara*, the cry of protest, and it did not save them.

It saved Malerkotla. In the decades when Sikh power was sweeping the Malwa and every Afghan-held town in the plains was being taken and in several cases destroyed — Sirhind twice — **Malerkotla was spared, and the reason given was always the same one.**

It survived as a princely state into the twentieth century. And in 1947, when the Punjab was being partitioned and the killing on both sides of the new border was as bad as anything in this book, **Malerkotla is recorded as having come through it without the massacres that consumed the districts around it.** The explanation offered locally, then and since, was a protest made in a courtroom in 1704.

How much weight that single act can really bear across two hundred and forty years is a fair question and this book will not pretend to settle it.

What is certain is that a community which lost perhaps half its people a few miles from that town, partly to troops sent from it, chose to remember instead a Muslim nobleman who had objected to the killing of two children — and acted on that memory for two centuries.

Amritsar, April 1762 — The Second Demolition

LIKELY

Two months after Kup he went back to the tank and did it again, and this time something came off the building and hit him.

WON BY Abdali — for about six months

WHEN	WHERE
April 1762.	Amritsar.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Abdali, in person this time, rather than through a general.	Afghan, Persian and Sikh accounts, which agree.

What happened

1. He came to Amritsar after Kup, while the community was scattered and its army was in the desert country recovering.
2. The Harmandir Sahib — rebuilt after 1757 — was blown up with gunpowder.
3. The tank was filled again with rubble and the carcasses of slaughtered cattle.
4. And, according to widely repeated accounts, a fragment of the building struck him in the face, leaving a wound on the nose that never healed properly.
5. Then he went back to Lahore, and shortly afterwards home.

THE WOUND

The story that a piece of the demolished building hit Ahmad Shah Abdali in the face, and that the resulting wound became the illness that eventually killed him, is repeated in a great many accounts and deserves careful handling.

What is documented: Abdali suffered for years from a disease of the face and nose — the sources describe an ulcerating growth — which got progressively worse, was treated unsuccessfully, disfigured him, and contributed to his death in 1772.

What is tradition: that it began with a flying fragment at Amritsar in April 1762.

Medical opinion, to the extent anybody can offer one at this distance, generally reads the illness as a tumour rather than an infected wound. **The connection to Amritsar is** STORY, **and it is a story with an obvious appeal to the people telling it.**

But there is a reason it is worth including even when labelled. **The man who twice destroyed the Harmandir Sahib spent the last decade of his life with a disfiguring illness that made it hard for him to eat, and died of it at about fifty.** The tradition did not have to invent the ending, only the cause.

WHY HE DID IT AGAIN

- **It was the only fixed target he had.** Same reasoning as 1757, unchanged.
- **The moment was as good as it would get.** Two months after Kup, with the Dal Khalsa broken and dispersed.
- **And he had nothing else to show.** He had won at Panipat and at Kup and held nothing; the demolition was a result he could point to.

WHY IT WAS THE WORSE MISTAKE

- **It gave a shattered community a fixed date to reassemble on.** Which is exactly what happened in October.
- **It removed any possibility of a settlement.** Abdali made peace overtures within the year and they went nowhere, and this is why.
- **It confirmed that he could not find the enemy.** Blowing up a building is what you do when you cannot reach an army.
- **And they rebuilt it. Again.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Six Months

Count the interval, because it is the single most extraordinary fact in this part and it is easy to read past.

5 February 1762: the Dal Khalsa is caught in the open with its families and loses something between ten and thirty thousand people in a day. Its commander-in-chief is carried off the field with wounds beyond counting. The survivors are in the desert.

April 1762: their central shrine is blown up and their sacred tank filled with carcasses, for the second time in five years.

17 October 1762: they are back at Amritsar in force, for the Diwali assembly, and they fight Ahmad Shah Abdali to a standstill on that ground.

Eight months from the worst day in their history to standing on the same field as the man who caused it.

This book has described a great many recoveries and none of them are like this. **The Shahis took sixty years to lose in Part Five and never came back. The Marathas lost once at Panipat and never returned to the north. The Lodis, the Suris, Hemu, Banda — every defeat of this magnitude in these eleven parts ended something.**

The mechanism is the one Part Nine built and Part Ten tested. **There was no leader whose death would end it, no capital whose loss would end it, and no army whose destruction would end it** — only an assembly with two fixed dates in a calendar that every congregation in the Punjab possessed a copy of.

Abdali could kill people, and did, on a scale this book has rarely had to describe. **He could not make Diwali not happen.**

Amritsar, October 1762 — Diwali

LIKELY

They came back for the festival, he came out of Lahore to stop them, and at the end of the day neither side had moved. That was the turning point.

WON BY Nobody — and a drawn battle was worth more to the Sikhs than a victory

WHEN 17 October 1762.	WHERE Amritsar.
WHO The reassembled Dal Khalsa against Abdali, who marched from Lahore to prevent the gathering.	THE EVIDENCE Afghan and Sikh accounts, which agree that it was indecisive and disagree about everything else.

What happened

1. **The Sarbat Khalsa was called for Diwali** at Amritsar, as it had been every year that it was possible and several when it was not.
2. **They came.** From the Malwa, from the Doab, from the Majha — the misls converged on a town whose shrine had been rubble since April.
3. **Abdali marched from Lahore to break it up.** Roughly sixty kilometres, at speed, in the expectation of catching them assembled and unready as at Kup.
4. **This time they were not encumbered and they were ready.** The fighting lasted through the day.
5. **Neither side broke.** At nightfall Abdali withdrew towards Lahore, and the Sikhs held the ground.
6. **Within a short time he was making peace overtures** — offering terms, recognition, arrangements. They were not taken up.
7. **And in December he went home.**

WHY A DRAW WAS A VICTORY

Nothing was captured on 17 October and no army was destroyed. Here is why it is the hinge of the whole part.

Abdali's entire method depended on being able to catch them. Nine invasions in fourteen years had produced exactly one decisive engagement against the Sikhs — Kup — and that had required a forced march of two hundred kilometres and the accident of finding them escorting their families.

At Amritsar in October he knew exactly where they were, they were assembled in one place, they had been shattered eight months earlier, and he marched sixty kilometres to hit them. **And he could not do it.**

Everybody in the Punjab drew the conclusion at once. The peace overtures that followed were the strongest possible admission: **the king of Afghanistan, undefeated in India for fifteen years, offering terms to a confederacy with no capital eight months after nearly destroying it.**

Part Five made the point about Kashmir and Lohkot, which Mahmud attacked twice and failed twice. **The invader who cannot finish the job has already lost; he simply does not know it for a few more years.**

WHY THE SIKHS HELD

- **They were fighting unencumbered.** No *vahir*, no baggage, on ground of their own choosing, for the first time in that campaign.
- **Everybody was there.** The Diwali assembly concentrated the whole confederacy in one place — the one occasion each year when the misls fought as a single army.
- **Their command could take losses.** Eleven leaders, no single point of failure, and the man who had been carried off at Kup back in the field.
- **And they had nowhere else to be.** The site had already been destroyed twice; there was no version of retreating that meant anything.

WHY ABDALI COULD NOT FINISH IT

- **He had spent his one advantage.** Surprise had worked in February and could not work again.
- **His army wanted to go home.** Fifteen years of campaigning in India with pay in arrears and diminishing returns.
- **He had no base in the province.** Lahore was a garrison, not a government, and the countryside fed the other side.
- **And there was nothing left to destroy.** He had already blown up the only fixed thing they had, twice.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Calendar as a Weapon

Consider what the Sarbat Khalsa actually was, as a piece of military technology, because that is the right way to look at it.

It was two dates. **Vaisakhi in the spring and Diwali in the autumn, at Amritsar.** On those days, whoever could come, came, and what was decided bound everybody.

That is all. There was no permanent headquarters, no standing council, no records office, no capital and nothing to garrison. **The entire command apparatus of the Dal Khalsa consisted of an agreement about when to be in the same field.**

Now look at what it did between 1748 and 1765. It appointed a commander-in-chief. It divided the province among eleven misls and made the division stick. It allocated campaigns. It set the *rakhi* arrangements. It decided whether to accept an Afghan king's offer of terms — and decided not to.

And it could not be attacked. Abdali could burn Amritsar, and did, and the assembly met at Amritsar anyway, because the assembly was not the buildings.

Set this beside every other command system in these eleven parts. **Alexander's, which was Alexander. Prithviraj's coalition, which had no mechanism to decide anything. The Maratha army at Panipat, which dissolved when two men went down. Abdali's own, which was a king and his household troops and which ceased to exist when he died in 1772.**

The most durable political institution in this book is two dates and a rule about who has to obey the outcome — and it was built by people who could not afford a building.

Sirhind, January 1764

LIKELY

The town came down a second time, and this time it did not change hands again.

WON BY

The Dal Khalsa — and the Punjab east of the Sutlej became theirs

WHEN 14 January 1764.	WHERE Sirhind, on the Grand Trunk Road.
WHO The misls under Jassa Singh Ahluwalia, Charat Singh Sukerchakia, Hari Singh Bhangi and others, against Zain Khan, the Afghan governor.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and Persian accounts; the outcome is not disputed.

What happened

- The Sikhs had spent 1763 taking the province apart in pieces.** Charat Singh Sukerchakia beat an Afghan force near Sialkot; Kasur was taken; the Jalandhar Doab fell; and the *rakhi* system was extended over districts that had been paying Lahore.
- In January 1764 the whole confederacy came together for Sirhind.**
- Zain Khan came out and was killed on the field.**
- The town was taken and destroyed for the second time in fifty-four years.**
- And then it was divided.** The territory of the Sirhind province was allocated among the misls by agreement — the beginning of the Cis-Sutlej states that will still be on the map in Part Fourteen.

THE CROSSROADS, FOR THE LAST TIME

Part Ten counted what had happened at Sirhind. Here is the list finished.

1540: Sher Shah Suri reaches Sirhind and sends the message that drives Humayun out of India. **1555:** Bairam Khan wins there and the Mughal empire is refounded. **1704:** two children are put to death by the faujdar. **1710:** Banda Singh Bahadur destroys the town. **1748:** the last Mughal victory in the Punjab is won a few miles away at Manupur. **1758:** the Marathas take it. **1761:** Abdali's allies hold it. **1762:** its troops join him at Kup. **1764:** it is taken and destroyed again.

Nine times in two hundred and twenty-four years, on one crossroads.

And after January 1764 it stops appearing, because there is nothing left to take. The province was divided among the misls and the town was never rebuilt as what it had been. **The place where the Punjab road meets the road to Delhi finally ceased to matter because the same people now held both ends of it.**

WHY THEY TOOK IT THIS TIME

- **Abdali was not there.** Between invasions, the province belonged to whoever was in it, and that was now the misls.
- **They came as one army.** A gurmata at Amritsar concentrated the whole confederacy on one objective.
- **The countryside was already theirs.** A year of *rakhi* collection had made the districts around Sirhind more theirs than the governor's.
- **And the governor came out to fight**, which was the last mistake he made.

WHY THE AFGHAN POSITION COLLAPSED

- **Garrisons without a field army.** Abdali's governors held towns in a province whose villages paid somebody else.
- **Nobody was coming.** Kabul was two months away and only came in the cold weather.
- **The revenue had gone.** A governor who cannot pay troops has a title and not much else.
- **And Panipat had removed the alternative.** The Marathas were gone; there was no third party left to play off.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What They Did Next

The interesting part of January 1764 is not the battle. It is the meeting afterwards.

An entire Mughal province had just fallen to a confederacy of eleven autonomous divisions, none of which was subordinate to any other, all of which had been in the fighting, and all of which now wanted a share.

This book has watched exactly this moment go wrong for eleven parts. **Yashodharman's coalition dissolved on the day it won in Part Four. The Malavas and Kshudrakas could not agree on a commander in Part Two. Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five did not survive one afternoon.** Winning together and then dividing the proceeds is the point at which every alliance in this history has come apart.

The misls divided the Sirhind province among themselves, by agreement, and the division held.

It held well enough that the resulting territories — Patiala, Nabha, Jind, Kaithal, Kalsia and the rest — were still functioning states eighty years later. **They are on the map when the British arrive in Part Fourteen; some of them survived to 1947, and one of them gave its name to a district of modern Punjab.**

The mechanism was the one described in the last war. **The Sarbat Khalsa met, a gurmata was passed, and it bound everybody** — not because anybody could enforce it, but because the alternative was the thing that had destroyed every Indian coalition in these sixteen parts, and they had all read the same book about it.

Not perfectly. The misls fought each other repeatedly afterwards and the confederacy tore itself apart in the 1790s, which is how Part Twelve ends.

But in January 1764 they took a province together and split it without a war, and nothing in the previous eleven parts of this history had managed that.

The Akal Bunga, December 1764 — Thirty Men

LIKELY

The most valuable description of the Sikhs written in this century was written by a man riding with the army that came to destroy them.

WON BY Abdali — over thirty men who would not leave a building

WHEN December 1764, during Abdali’s seventh invasion.	WHERE Amritsar, at the Akal Bunga beside the tank.
WHO Bhai Gurbaksh Singh and about thirty companions, against Abdali’s army.	THE EVIDENCE Qazi Nur Muhammad’s <i>Jangnamah</i> — an eyewitness account by a member of the invading army.

What happened

1. **Abdali came back at the end of 1764**, for the seventh time, and found the province in Sikh hands and nobody willing to fight him for it.
2. **The misls dispersed as usual.** Fifteen years of practice; there was nothing to defend and no reason to lose men.
3. **He came to Amritsar** and found about thirty men at the Akal Bunga beside the tank, who had chosen not to go.
4. **They came out and fought and were killed**, all of them, in a short engagement against an army.
5. **And a qazi travelling with that army wrote it down.**

THE JANGNAMAH — THE MOST USEFUL BOOK IN THIS PART

Qazi Nur Muhammad accompanied Abdali's 1764–65 campaign in the train of an allied Baluch chief, and wrote a verse account of it. He was not neutral in any sense whatever. **He refers to the Sikhs throughout by a standard term of abuse and makes his religious contempt for them entirely explicit.**

And in the middle of that, describing an enemy he despises, he records a set of observations that a friendly witness could never have made credible.

He describes their **courage** in terms that go well beyond what his argument requires. He describes their **horsemanship** and the speed at which they move. He notes — and this is the passage most often quoted — that **they do not kill a fleeing enemy, and that they do not lay hands on women**, including the women of their enemies, and he states it as a rule they observe rather than an incident he witnessed.

He also, having spent the poem calling them dogs, concedes that in battle they behave like lions.

This is the second genuinely valuable outside witness in this book, after the East India Company letter of 1716 in Part Ten. And it works for the same reason: **nothing in the writer's position gave him any motive to say it.**

When a man who thinks you are vermin takes the trouble to record that you do not kill runaways or touch women, that is worth more than any amount of your own tradition.

WHY THIRTY MEN STAYED

- **The site had been destroyed twice already.** Somebody being at Amritsar when the army arrived was the point.
- **It was a choice, not a trap.** The rest of the confederacy had gone; these men elected to remain.
- **And it cost the Afghans nothing and gained them nothing**, which is the whole shape of that invasion.

WHY THE SEVENTH INVASION ACHIEVED NOTHING

- **There was no enemy to fight.** The misls dispersed and let him march about an empty province.
- **He could not stay.** Cold weather in, hot weather out, every time, for seventeen years.
- **He tried to appoint a governor and was ignored.** By this point Lahore's Sikh holders simply did not respond to offers from Kabul.
- **And his own army was finished with India.** He came twice more and neither invasion did anything at all.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Witness Who Called Them Dogs

This book has asked one question in every part for five thousand years: **who is writing, and what do they need you to believe?**

Almost every source in these eleven parts fails that test in an obvious direction. Greek writers glorifying Alexander. Harishena praising Samudragupta on a pillar. Al-Utbi counting the dead for Mahmud. Abul Fazl establishing Akbar's greatness. Sikh devotional literature edifying the community. Persian chroniclers describing Banda as a monster.

Every one of them is telling you something true, and every one of them is doing it for somebody.

The two most valuable documents in Parts Ten and Eleven are both by people who had no dog in the fight, or who had the wrong one.

In 1716, two East India Company merchants in Delhi wrote home about a procession of condemned prisoners and mentioned, because it struck them, that none of them recanted. They were negotiating customs duties. They did not care.

In 1765, a qazi riding with an Afghan army wrote a poem calling the enemy dogs on every page — and recorded that they would not strike a man who was running away and would not touch a woman.

Neither man was trying to help. The first was writing a business report. The second was writing propaganda and could not stop himself putting in what he had actually seen.

That is what evidence looks like when it is worth something. And it is why this book keeps labelling its sources instead of simply telling you what happened: **because the difference between a tradition and a fact is usually just the identity of the person who had no reason to lie.**

Lahore, 1765 — The Coin

CERTAIN

In April 1765 the Dal Khalsa took Lahore and struck money there — and the legend on it was the one Banda Singh Bahadur had used fifty-five years earlier.

WON BY The Dal Khalsa — and this time they kept it

WHEN April 1765; Abdali's last two invasions in 1766–67 change nothing.	WHERE Lahore.
WHO The Bhangi misl chiefs — Lehna Singh, Gujjar Singh and Sobha Singh — governing the city between them.	THE EVIDENCE The coins, which survive.

What happened

1. **Abdali went home in the spring of 1765** having achieved nothing in his seventh invasion.
2. **The misls took Lahore** and, this time, did not withdraw.
3. **Three chiefs divided the city between them** and governed it jointly — an arrangement that sounds unworkable and lasted about thirty years.
4. **They struck coin**, in the name of the Gurus, on the same Persian couplet Banda had used at Lohgarh in 1710.
5. **Abdali came twice more**, in 1766–67 and again afterwards. The misls dispersed, let him march about, and reoccupied everything the moment he left. **In 1767 he went back across the Indus for the last time.**
6. **He died in 1772**, of the disease of the face that had troubled him for a decade.

WHAT THE COIN SAYS, AND WHAT IT MEANS

The legend is the one from Part Ten: a Persian couplet crediting the cooking-pot, the sword, victory and ready protection to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. **No ruler's name appears on it.**

Banda struck it at Lohgarh in 1710 and was executed six years later. **Fifty-five years afterwards, the same couplet was struck at Lahore** — the capital of the province, the seat of every governor who had hunted them, the city where Guru Arjan died in 1606 and where the execution platform at the horse market had stood for thirty years.

And it stayed. The Sikh mints at Lahore and Amritsar used versions of that legend for the rest of the century, and Ranjit Singh continued the practice: **his coinage does not carry his own name either.** He ruled from 1799 to 1839 and never put himself on his money.

That is a constitutional statement made in silver, sustained for over a hundred and thirty years, by rulers who had every incentive to do the ordinary thing.

WHY 1765 HELD WHEN 1761 DID NOT

- **Abdali was finished.** Seventeen years, nine crossings, an army in arrears and an illness that was killing him.
- **The countryside was already administered.** *Rakhi* had turned into revenue collection across most of the province; taking the city was the last step, not the first.
- **The Marathas were gone.** Panipat had removed the only other claimant.
- **And Delhi was irrelevant.** The Mughal emperor of 1765 had just signed away the revenues of Bengal to the East India Company after Buxar. Northern India had no centre at all.

WHAT HOLDING A CAPITAL COSTS

- **They became findable.** The advantage that had kept them alive for fifty years was traded away deliberately, and it could not be traded back.
- **Territory divides people.** Eleven autonomous misls with fixed districts and revenues had, for the first time, something to fight each other over.
- **The assembly lost its purpose.** The Sarbat Khalsa worked under pressure; with the pressure gone, the gurmatas stopped binding.
- **And that is Part Twelve.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

Eight Hundred and Ninety-Five Years

In April 1765, Punjabis governed the Punjab.

Stop and count backwards, because this book has been building to that sentence for eleven parts and it is worth being exact about the arithmetic.

The last time the land of the five rivers was ruled by a power based in it, and drawing its soldiers and its legitimacy from its own population, was the Hindu Shahi dynasty — and they lost Kabul in 870 and the Punjab plain within a century and a half. Part Five described their end: the last effective king murdered by his own unpaid troops in about 1021, and al-Biruni writing that of the whole house not the slightest remnant remained.

Between then and 1765: Ghaznavids from Ghazna, Ghurids from Ghor, slave sultans from Delhi, Mongol raids, Tughlaqs, Timur, Sayyids, Lodis, Mughals, Suris, Mughals again, Persians, and Afghans.

Eight hundred and ninety-five years of the Punjab being administered from somewhere else.

And the people who ended it were not a dynasty. They had no royal family, no ancient claim and no foreign patron. They were, by origin, the peasantry of the doabs, organised by an institution founded in a hill town in 1699, which had survived a bounty on every head, thirty years in the forests, two ghallugharas and the demolition of its central shrine twice in five years.

They took the capital, and they put on the coins the names of two men who had been dead for a very long time, and left their own names off.

The next thirty-four years are what they did with it, and it is not a simple story. The misls fought each other, the assembly decayed, and by the 1790s the confederacy that had beaten Ahmad Shah Abdali was tearing itself apart over districts.

And then, in 1799, a one-eyed nineteen-year-old from one of the smaller misls took Lahore.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1748–1753	Mir Mannu governs Lahore, fighting Abdali in front and the Dal Khalsa behind. The siege of Ram Rauni is lifted through Diwan Kaura Mal; Jassa Singh Ramgarhia changes sides. Won by nobody.
1751–52	Abdali besieges Lahore for four months. Kaura Mal is killed; Mir Mannu submits and is reappointed as Kabul's governor. In April 1752 Delhi formally cedes the Punjab and Multan to Afghanistan. Won by Abdali.
Jan–Apr 1757	Abdali's fourth invasion. Delhi stripped, Mathura and Vrindavan sacked — and on the way home the Harmandir Sahib is demolished and the tank filled. Timur Shah left as viceroy. Won by Abdali.
Nov 1757	Gohalwar. Baba Deep Singh, a scholar of seventy-five, marches on Amritsar with a volunteer force and is killed a few miles short. Won by the Afghan garrison.
Mar–May 1758	The Marathas take Sirhind and then Lahore, drive out Timur Shah, and reach Attock on the Indus — the furthest north any peninsular Indian power has ever come. Adina Beg is made governor and dies in September. Won by the Marathas.
14 Jan 1761	The Third Battle of Panipat. Two months of blockade, then an attack made out of starvation. Vishwasrao shot, Bhau killed, the army destroyed. Won by Abdali — who then went home.
Feb–Mar 1761	The road home. The misls raid Abdali's returning columns and free the Panipat captives, escorting them back across northern India. Won by the Dal Khalsa.
Nov 1761	The Sikhs take Lahore and Jassa Singh Ahluwalia is proclaimed <i>Sultan-ul-Qaum</i> . They withdraw when Abdali returns.
5 Feb 1762	The Vadda Ghallughara. Abdali force-marches from Lahore and catches the Dal Khalsa escorting its families near Kup. Between ten and thirty thousand killed, most of them non-combatants. Won by Abdali.
Apr 1762	The Harmandir Sahib is blown up a second time and the tank filled again.
17 Oct 1762	Diwali at Amritsar. Eight months after Kup, the whole confederacy assembles on the same ground and fights Abdali to a standstill. He withdraws and begins offering terms. Won by nobody — which is the turning point.
1763	Sialkot, Kasur and the Jalandhar Doab fall; the <i>rakhi</i> system spreads across the province.
14 Jan 1764	Sirhind. Zain Khan killed; the town destroyed for the second time in fifty-four years; the province divided among the misls by agreement. Won by the Dal Khalsa.

Dec 1764

The Akal Bunga. Thirty men choose not to leave Amritsar and are killed — and **Qazi Nur Muhammad, riding with the invaders, writes the best outside description of the Sikhs in this century.**

Apr 1765

The Dal Khalsa takes Lahore and strikes coin there on Banda's legend, in the names of the Gurus and nobody else. **Won by the Dal Khalsa — permanently.**

1766–1767

Abdali's last invasions achieve nothing. The misls disperse, let him march, and reoccupy behind him. He recrosses the Indus for the last time in 1767 and dies in 1772. *Part Twelve begins here.*

Five patterns to carry into Part Twelve

1. **Winning every battle is not the same as holding a country.** Abdali beat Mir Mannu, destroyed the Marathas at Panipat, caught the Dal Khalsa at Kup and demolished Amritsar twice — **and went home in 1767 with nothing.** No governor he appointed survived, no revenue reached Kabul, and the province he had been formally ceded in 1752 was ruled by his enemies within thirteen years. This is the clearest case in the whole book.
2. **The institution absorbed a catastrophe and the pressure was what held it together.** Eight months from the Vadda Ghallughara to standing on the same ground at Diwali. **No other power in these eleven parts recovers from a loss on that scale — because no other power had separated its command from its commanders.** Watch what happens in Part Twelve when the pressure comes off.
3. **The single point of failure claims its seventh army.** Vishwasrao shot and Bhau gone, and the finest force in India dissolving in an hour — after Porus, Anandapala, Ghor at Tarain, Qutlugh Khwaja, Hemu and Wazir Khan. **Every army in this book that dies with its commander is a personal army. Every one that does not is an institutional one.**
4. **Territory is the trade.** Nothing to defend kept them alive for fifty years; taking Lahore in 1765 gave that up on purpose. **From here on the Sikhs can be found, besieged and negotiated with — and they can also govern.** Part Twelve is what that costs and what it buys.
5. **And the outside witnesses are the ones to trust.** Two English merchants in 1716 and a hostile qazi in 1765 — **the two most valuable sources in these two parts are both by people with no reason to say anything kind.** When you read the rest of this book, that is the standard to hold everything else to.

COMING NEXT — PART TWELVE

The Misls, 1767–1799. Twelve autonomous states with no overlord, governing the Punjab between them — and the thirty years in which the system that beat Ahmad Shah Abdali comes apart because there is nobody left to fight. Multan taken in 1772; Jammu, Kangra and the hill states brought under tribute; the Sikhs at the gates of Delhi in 1783 and the agreement they made there. Then the internal wars: Bhangi against Sukerchakia, Ramgarhia against Kanhaiya, the assembly at Amritsar meeting less and binding nobody. Mahadji Scindia's Marathas pushing back into the north; George Thomas, an Irish sailor, carving out a kingdom in Haryana; and Zaman Shah coming down from Kabul three times in the 1790s to find a province with twelve governments and no army. And at the end of it, in July 1799, **a nineteen-year-old from the smallest of the great misls walks into Lahore** — and the Punjab has one ruler for the first time in eight hundred years.

Words Used in This Part

Abdali / Durrani

Ahmad Shah, founder of the Afghan kingdom in 1747 and its ruler until 1772. He invaded India nine times.

Vahir

The non-combatant body of the community on the move — families, the old, the sick, and their possessions. Escorting it is why the Dal Khalsa could not disperse at Kup in 1762.

Ghallughara

A catastrophe or holocaust. The *Chhota* — lesser — is 1746, in Part Ten; the *Vadda* — greater — is 5 February 1762.

Rakhi

“Protection.” A fixed share of the harvest paid by a village to a misl in return for security. By 1763 it had become the revenue system of most of the Punjab.

Misl

One of the eleven — later twelve — autonomous divisions of the Dal Khalsa. Formally equal, none subordinate to another.

Sarbat Khalsa

The general assembly at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali, whose resolutions bound the whole confederacy. Two dates and a rule — the most durable institution in this book.

Gurmata

A binding resolution of the Sarbat Khalsa.

Sultan-ul-Qaum

“King of the nation” — the title by which Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was proclaimed at Lahore in November 1761.

Chauth

The Maratha revenue demand — a quarter of the assessed revenue of a territory, enforced by cavalry. The reason Maratha expansion made few friends in the north.

Zamburak

A light swivel gun carried on a camel. Part of why Abdali’s cavalry outfought the Marathas at Panipat.

Jangnamah

“Book of war.” Qazi Nur Muhammad’s verse account of Abdali’s 1764–65 campaign, written from inside the invading army — hostile throughout and invaluable.

Akal Bunga

The building beside the tank at Amritsar, later the Akal Takht, where thirty Sikhs died in December 1764.

Ram Rauni / Ramgarh

The fort at Amritsar, besieged in 1748 and afterwards rebuilt and renamed — giving the Ramgarhia misl its name.

Adina Beg Khan

Faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab, who played Mughals, Afghans, Marathas and Sikhs against one another for two decades and was briefly governor of the Punjab in 1758.

Haah da naara

“The cry of protest” — the objection made by the Nawab of Malerkotla at Sirhind in 1704, and the reason Sikh armies afterwards spared his state.

Cis-Sutlej states

The territories south and east of the Sutlej divided among the misls after Sirhind in 1764 — Patiala, Nabha, Jind and the rest, still on the map when the British arrive.

Sources used for this part

- **Qazi Nur Muhammad**, *Jangnamah* (1765) — an eyewitness account of Abdali’s seventh invasion by a member of his army, in Ganda Singh’s edition
- Persian histories of the later Mughal period, including the *Siyar-ul-Mutakherin* of Ghulam Husain Khan
- Afghan accounts of Ahmad Shah Abdali’s campaigns
- Maratha correspondence and the Peshwa daftar records for the 1758 campaign and for Panipat — an unusually rich body of contemporary letters
- Sikh sources of the later eighteenth and nineteenth centuries — *Prachin Panth Prakash* and related works — for the Ghallugharas, Gohalwar and the internal organisation, treated as tradition and labelled as such
- **The coins of the Sikh mints at Lahore and Amritsar**, which carry the legend used by Banda Singh Bahadur in 1710
- Ganda Singh’s documentary work on Ahmad Shah Durrani and on the eighteenth-century Punjab; Hari Ram Gupta’s history of the Sikhs
- Standard modern accounts of the Third Battle of Panipat, the Maratha northern expansion, and the Afghan invasions

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the casualty figures at Panipat and at the Vadda Ghallughara, both of which vary by a factor of three between sources; the number of captives freed on the road in 1761; whether coin was struck at Lahore in 1761 as well as in 1765; whether a Sikh alliance would have changed the outcome at Panipat, which is unanswerable and endlessly asserted; and the origin of Abdali’s fatal illness.

Three things about method.

First, **the two desecrations of the Harmandir Sahib are stated as documented acts of policy** and are explained in military terms — a fixed target substituting for an army that could not be caught. That explanation is not a justification and is not offered as one.

Second, **this part has again named individuals rather than communities**. Diwan Kaura Mal, a Hindu Khatri, saved the Sikhs at Ram Rauni and died fighting Afghans for a Mughal governor. Adina Beg Khan changed sides four times in twenty years. The Nawab of Malerkotla’s protest in 1704 protected his state for two centuries while his successors’ troops fought at Kup. **None of these people can be explained by their religion, and the record does not support trying.**

Third, **the most important source in this part is hostile**. Qazi Nur Muhammad despised the people he was describing and said so on every page, and what he recorded about their conduct in war is worth more than any friendly account precisely because of it. Where this book has used him, it has said who he was.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART TWELVE OF SIXTEEN

The Misls

Twelve states, no overlord and one shared capital — the strangest political system in this book — and thirty years to discover that it only ever worked while somebody was trying to destroy it.

1767 — 1799

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



Twelve Governments and No Government

Part Eleven ended with the Punjab in its own hands for the first time in nearly nine centuries. This part is about what its owners did with it, and the honest answer is: they nearly lost it again.

In 1767 Ahmad Shah Abdali went back across the Indus for the last time, and the pressure came off.

What was left behind was a political arrangement with no parallel anywhere else in this book. **Twelve autonomous states — the *misls* — each with its own chief, its own army, its own territory and its own revenue, none of them subordinate to any other, sharing one capital that none of them owned.** There was no king, no council, no permanent government and no way to compel anybody.

It had beaten the finest army in Asia. And within twenty years of the last invasion it was fighting itself.

Four things to hold on to

- **The system was genuinely a system, not chaos.** The *misls* collected revenue, kept order, built, endowed, negotiated and made war by agreement. Foreign observers who came to look at it — and several did — described something they had not expected and did not have a word for.
- **It came apart because the enemy left.** The assembly at Amritsar had bound eleven chiefs together when Abdali was in the country. With nobody coming down the passes, its resolutions stopped mattering, and by the 1780s the *misls* were fighting each other with the armies they had raised against the Afghans.
- **The British are now in the frame.** Not in the Punjab — but a Company servant walked through it in disguise in 1783 and wrote the first English account of the Sikhs, an Irish deserter carved out a kingdom on its south-eastern edge, and by 1799 Calcutta was worried enough about Afghan invasions to be conducting diplomacy in Persia about it.
- **And it ends with an invitation.** In July 1799 the leading citizens of Lahore — Muslims and Hindus among them — wrote to a young chief from one of the smaller *misls* asking him to come and take the city off the men who were holding it. **He was eighteen.**

THE HONESTY LABELS, AND A CHANGE IN THE SOURCES

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence.

LIKELY means well-attested and generally accepted.

STORY

means tradition.

For the first time in this book, the outside evidence becomes plentiful. George Forster, a Company servant, travelled through the Punjab disguised as a Turkish merchant in 1783 and published an account of it. Major James Browne compiled a history of the Sikhs for Warren Hastings in the 1780s. Antoine Polier, a Swiss officer in Indian service, wrote a description for the learned societies of Calcutta. And George Thomas, an Irish sailor turned warlord, dictated a memoir of thirteen years spent fighting on the Punjab's edge.

None of these men were friendly, several were gathering intelligence, and all of them are useful for exactly that reason. Parts Ten and Eleven made the case: the witness with no motive is worth more than the witness with a good one.

The Twelve Republics, 1767–1799

CERTAIN

Not a battle. A description of the only government the Punjab has ever produced that had no ruler at all.

WHAT IT WAS

Twelve sovereign states with one capital and no head

WHEN

1767–1799, at its most effective in the 1760s and 1770s.

WHERE

The whole Punjab, from the Sutlej to the Indus and into the hills.

WHO

Twelve *misl*s — Bhangi, Ahluwalia, Kanhaiya, Ramgarhia, Sukerchakia, Nakai, Dallewalia, Nishanwalia, Shaheedan, Karorasinghia, Singhpuria, and the Phulkian houses south of the Sutlej.

THE EVIDENCE

Coins, revenue records, the buildings at Amritsar, and four separate European descriptions.

How it worked

1. **Each misl held its own territory outright.** Districts taken in the campaigns of 1763 and 1764 were divided by agreement, and what a misl held it governed — collecting revenue, appointing officials, administering justice and keeping troops.
2. **The chief was chosen, not born.** In principle a *sardar* led because his men followed him, and a follower could leave one misl for another. In practice leadership became hereditary within a generation, and that drift is a large part of what goes wrong in this part.
3. **Nobody was anybody’s superior.** The word *misl* means, roughly, an equal or a like — and the equality was real. Jassa Singh Ahluwalia commanded the Dal Khalsa in the field and had no authority whatever over the Bhangi chiefs at Lahore.
4. **The revenue system was *rakhi* grown up.** Part Ten described protection money paid by villages to bands. By the 1770s it had become an ordinary land revenue — assessed, collected, and generally lighter than what Lahore had charged.
5. **The common capital was Amritsar, and no one owned it.** Each misl built a *bunga* — a tower and residence — around the tank, so that its chief had a house there for the assemblies. **Dozens of them stood round the water: twelve governments with twelve embassies to a shrine.**

6. **And the assembly still met.** The Sarbat Khalsa at Vaisakhi and Diwali, passing *gurmata*s that bound everybody — for as long as everybody wanted to be bound.

WHAT THE FOREIGNERS MADE OF IT

Europeans who encountered this system had genuine trouble describing it, and their difficulty is informative.

George Forster, travelling in disguise in 1783, found a country with no capital, no sovereign and no court, run by chiefs who consulted at a religious site twice a year — and who nonetheless collected taxes and kept the roads reasonably safe. He reached for the vocabulary he had and settled on something like a commonwealth or a federal republic. **He also recorded a judgement that turned out to be extremely accurate: that if a leader of ability ever emerged among them, they would become a formidable power.** He wrote that sixteen years before Ranjit Singh took Lahore.

Antoine Polier and **Major James Browne** produced accounts in the 1780s for Calcutta audiences, and both circled the same problem — how do you report to a government on a state that has no government?

The honest answer is that the misl confederacy resembled nothing else in eighteenth-century Asia. **It was closest, of all the things in this book, to the armed republics of Part Three** — the Yaudheyas and their neighbours, who ran themselves by assembly, put *victory to the nation* on their coins, and outlasted five empires.

WHY IT WORKED

- **It had been forged under fire.** Every rule in it existed because something had gone wrong without it between 1716 and 1762.
- **Equality removed the reason to defect.** No chief had to accept another as overlord, which is what had destroyed every Indian coalition in eleven parts.
- **It was cheap and local.** Government by men who lived in the district, taking less than the empire had taken.
- **And it could not be decapitated.** Kill any one chief and eleven others carried on — the lesson of 1606, 1675, 1716 and 1762, built into the constitution.

WHY IT FAILED

- **Nobody could compel anybody.** A *gurmata* bound a chief who wished to be bound. Under pressure, everybody wished to be. Without it, nobody did.
- **Leadership became hereditary.** Within a generation the chiefs were sons of chiefs, and the misls were dynasties calling themselves republics.
- **Territory made rivals.** Fixed districts and fixed revenues gave twelve equal powers something to want from each other.
- **And there was no frontier policy at all.** Twelve governments cannot defend a pass, and Zaman Shah walked through it three times in the 1790s.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Towers Round the Water

If you want to see the misl system rather than read about it, look at what was built at Amritsar in these thirty years.

Around the tank, facing the rebuilt shrine, the chiefs put up *bungas* — a *bunga* being a tower with residential rooms, part guesthouse, part fortified lodging, part statement. There were eventually dozens of them, and every significant misl had one. **The Ramgarhia Bunga, with its two tall minarets, is still standing.**

Consider what that arrangement actually is. Twelve independent states, each maintaining a permanent establishment at a place that none of them governed, so that their heads of state would have somewhere to stay when they came for the assembly.

They are embassies. To a building.

And the building was not a palace, a fort or a treasury. It was the shrine that had been demolished by gunpowder twice in five years, and whose tank had been filled with carcasses twice, and which had been cleared out and refilled both times by people with a price on their heads.

Part Eleven made the point that the Sarbat Khalsa was two dates and a rule. This is the physical form of it: **a capital that consists of a pool of water with twelve guesthouses round it, belonging to a state that does not exist.**

It worked for about twenty years. Then the chiefs started using the bungalows to plot against each other, and by the 1790s the assemblies were being called and not attended.

Multan, 1772

LIKELY

The oldest door in this book changed hands again — and this time it was opened by people from the Punjab.

WON BY

The Bhangi misl — and lost again seven years later

WHEN Taken in 1772; recovered by the Afghans in 1779.	WHERE Multan, southern Punjab.
WHO Jhanda Singh and Ganda Singh of the Bhangi misl, against the Afghan governor.	THE EVIDENCE Persian and Sikh accounts; the Bhangi occupation is not disputed.

Why Multan again

Because it is the door, and it has been the door in every part of this book since 712. **Muhammad bin Qasim took it by cutting its water in Part Five. Mahmud fought over it. Muhammad of Ghor began his Indian conquests there in Part Six. Timur’s grandson sat outside it for six months in Part Seven. The Langahs made it an independent country for eighty years. The Arghuns took it from Sindh in the 1520s.**

It sits where the road from Sindh, the road from Khurasan and the road up the Punjab meet, and whoever holds it controls the southern approach to the province. In 1772 it was the last major Afghan possession east of the Indus.

What happened

- Ahmad Shah Abdali died in 1772**, and the Bhangi chiefs moved almost at once.
- Multan was taken** after a campaign in the southern Punjab, and the Bhangi misl held it and the country around it.
- It was the high-water mark of the confederacy’s expansion.** With Multan, the misls between them held from the Sutlej to the Indus, from the Sindh border to the hills.
- And in 1779 Timur Shah took it back.** Abdali’s son came down and recovered Multan, and the Afghans held it for another thirty-nine years.
- It does not return to Punjabi hands until 1818**, when Ranjit Singh takes it — which is Part Thirteen.

WHY THEY COULD TAKE IT AND NOT KEEP IT

This is the misl system's structural weakness in one example, and it is worth being precise.

Multan was taken by one misl and held by one misl. The Bhangis captured it, garrisoned it, and drew its revenue. It was their property.

So when Timur Shah came down in 1779 with an Afghan army, **defending Multan was a Bhangi problem, not a Punjabi one.** The Ahluwalia misl had no obligation to march; the Sukerchakias had their own frontier in the north; the Kanhaiyas were busy in the hills.

Compare it with 1764. When Sirhind was taken, the whole confederacy came, because the Sarbat Khalsa had passed a gurmata and everyone was bound. **By 1779, gurmata about somebody else's city were not being passed, and would not have been obeyed if they had been.**

Twelve equal states can conquer a province between them. They cannot defend a frontier post that belongs to only one of them — and every frontier post in the Punjab belonged to only one of them.

WHY THE BHANGIS TOOK IT

- **Abdali was dead.** The Afghan kingdom went into a succession dispute and the eastern provinces were left to themselves.
- **The Bhangis were the strongest misl.** They held Lahore, Gujrat and Amritsar's neighbourhood, and could put a real army in the field.
- **The countryside was already paying them.** *Rakhi* had spread down the Ravi and the Chenab well before the city fell.

WHY THEY LOST IT

- **They held it alone.** No other misl had a stake in it.
- **Timur Shah came with a state behind him.** A kingdom's army against one misl's establishment.
- **It is a very long way from the Bhangi heartland.** Two hundred and fifty miles from Lahore, at the end of a line nobody else was interested in holding.
- **And the Bhangi misl was already declining.** Jhanda Singh was assassinated in 1774 and the misl never recovered its leadership.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Eleven Hundred Years of the Same Gate

Multan has now appeared in seven parts of this book, and it is worth setting the whole sequence down in one place because the repetition stops being a coincidence and becomes a fact about geography.

712: an Arab army cuts the water supply and takes it; the sun temple becomes a taxable asset and later a hostage on the walls. **1006:** Mahmud of Ghazni fights over it, blocked on the road by a Hindu king. **1175:** Muhammad of Ghor's conquest of India begins here. **1397:** Timur's grandson besieges it for six months and loses his cavalry to the monsoon. **1445–1526:** it is an independent country under the Langahs. **1520s:** it falls to the Arghuns of Sindh in the same season Babur takes Lahore. **1772:** the Bhangi misl takes it. **1779:** Timur Shah takes it back. **1818:** Ranjit Singh takes it, in Part Thirteen. **1848:** the murder of two British officers there starts the war that ends the Sikh empire, in Part Fourteen.

Ten changes of hands in eleven hundred and thirty-six years, and not one of them for a reason that has anything to do with Multan itself.

It is always taken because of where it is. An army coming from the west that does not want to fight through the northern passes comes here. An army going down the Indus comes here. An army from Delhi that wants to control Sindh comes here.

Part Seven called it the city that keeps being the door. **Nothing in the seven centuries since has changed the sentence.**

The Hills — Jammu and Kangra, 1770–1786

LIKELY

The misls turned north into the hill states that had closed their passes against them in 1746 — and one of them killed a chief with his own gun.

WON BY

The misls — by tribute rather than annexation, mostly

WHEN 1770–1786.	WHERE Jammu, and the Kangra hills — the Siwalik states of Parts Eight and Nine.
WHO The Sukerchakia and Kanhaiya misls chiefly, against the hill rajas.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and hill-state accounts; the tribute arrangements are documented.

What happened

1. Charat Singh Sukerchakia was killed at Jammu in 1770 — not by the enemy. His own matchlock burst in his hands. He was Ranjit Singh’s grandfather, and one of the ablest commanders of the previous decade.
2. His son Mahan Singh took the misl and continued the northern campaigns, sacking Jammu in the 1780s and bringing back a very large amount of money — the plunder of Jammu is one of the things that funded the Sukerchakia rise.
3. The Kanhaiya misl went into the Kangra hills. Jai Singh Kanhaiya took the great fort of Kangra in 1783 — the fort that Mahmud of Ghazni emptied in 1009 in Part Five, which had been plundered repeatedly ever since.
4. And the hill rajas played the misls against each other, exactly as they had played the Mughals against the Gurus in Part Nine. Sansar Chand Katoch, the young raja of Kangra, allied with the Sukerchakias against the Kanhaiyas and recovered his fort in the mid-1780s.
5. Most of the hill states were not annexed. They paid tribute and kept their rajas — the standard arrangement, and it lasts until Ranjit Singh changes it in Part Thirteen.

THE SAME HILLS, THE FIFTH TIME

This country has been decisive in five separate parts of this book and it is worth naming the pattern before it changes.

Part Four: Mihirakula flees into Kashmir and comes back down. **Part Five:** Trilochanapala fights on from the Siwaliks for seven years after Nandana. **Part Eight:** Sikandar Shah Suri is starved out of Mankot. **Part Nine:** Anandpur, Paonta, Bhangani and Nadaun — the whole military history of the Gurus after 1635 happens in these foothills. **Part Ten:** Banda escapes into them from Lohgarh. **Part Eleven:** the hill rajas close the passes at Kahnawan in 1746 and thousands die because of it.

The rule has been constant: the hills preserve you and the hills imprison you. You cannot be finished there and you cannot rule from there.

What changes in this part is the direction. **For the first time, the power in the plains is strong enough to go up into the hills and impose terms** — not to hide there, not to be destroyed there, but to collect tribute from the rajas who had spent seven centuries being the refuge or the obstacle.

The hill states never recover from it. Ranjit Singh absorbs them outright between 1809 and 1820, and Sansar Chand — the ablest of them, and the one who outmanoeuvred the Kanhaiyas here — ends his life as a Sikh tributary.

WHY THE MISLS COULD GO NORTH

- **Nobody was invading from the west.** Between 1767 and 1795 the passes were quiet, and armies raised against the Afghans had nothing to do.
- **The hill states were small and divided.** The oldest failure in this book, now costing the rajas rather than the plains.
- **The plains had the revenue.** A misl drawing on the doabs could outspend a hill raja indefinitely.
- **And the hills were rich in a specific way.** Kangra and Jammu held accumulated temple and treasury wealth of exactly the kind Part Five described.

WHAT IT COST THE CONFEDERACY

- **It set the misls against each other.** Kanhaiya expansion into Kangra was a threat to the Sukerchakias, and both sought hill allies against the other.
- **The rajas learned to use the divisions.** Sansar Chand recovered his fort by picking a side, not by fighting.
- **It pointed the armies away from the frontier.** Every campaign in the hills was a campaign not spent watching the Khyber.
- **And it produced the war in the next section.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Gun That Killed Its Owner

Charat Singh Sukerchakia died at Jammu in 1770 because **his own matchlock burst when he fired it.**

It is a small death and an unglamorous one, and it is worth a page because of what it says about the armies of this period.

The misls were the best light cavalry in Asia. Qazi Nur Muhammad, watching them in 1765 from the other side, said so in a poem written to insult them. They could move faster than anybody, live off nothing, and appear where they were not expected.

What they could not do was make guns. Firearms in the eighteenth-century Punjab were bought, captured, or made by local smiths working without the metallurgy or the quality control of a state arsenal. A matchlock that burst in the hands of the head of a misl is a piece of equipment that nobody had tested, because there was nobody whose job that was.

Hold that fact, because it is the seed of Part Thirteen. **Ranjit Singh — this man's grandson — spent his reign fixing exactly this problem.** He hired European officers, built arsenals at Lahore, cast his own artillery, and turned the finest irregular cavalry in Asia into a regular army with infantry, guns and a foundry.

And he did it because he had watched what an army of horsemen could not do. **Twelve misls could take a province. They could not take a fortress, could not stand against artillery, and could not stop a European-officered brigade — which is what George Thomas demonstrated on their south-eastern border in the 1790s, and what the British demonstrated to everybody else in India in the same decade.**

The grandfather was killed by a bad gun in 1770. The grandson had two hundred pieces of his own artillery by the 1830s.

Delhi, March 1783

LIKELY

The Sikhs took the Red Fort, sat in the hall of audience, negotiated, built seven shrines, and went home. It is the strangest occupation in this book.

WON BY

The Sikhs — who wanted something nobody expected

WHEN March 1783; the withdrawal towards the end of the year.	WHERE Delhi — the Red Fort and the city.
WHO Baghel Singh Karorasinghia, Jassa Singh Ahluwalia and Jassa Singh Ramgarhia, against the government of Shah Alam II.	THE EVIDENCE Persian and Sikh accounts; and seven buildings that are still standing and in daily use.

What happened

1. **A very large Sikh force came down the Grand Trunk Road** in the early months of 1783 — the figures given run to tens of thousands of horse — and there was nothing between it and the capital.
2. **They entered Delhi in March** and occupied the Red Fort. The chiefs went into the **Diwan-i-Am**, the imperial hall of audience.
3. **And then they negotiated.** Shah Alam II, who was emperor of India in name and of very little in fact, opened talks — mediated, in the accounts, by **Begum Samru** of Sardhana, one of the most remarkable figures of the period, who had risen from a dancing girl to the ruler of a state with its own European-officered army.
4. **The terms were unlike any other in this book.** Baghel Singh was to remain in Delhi with a body of troops; he was to receive a share of the city’s customs revenue; **and he was to be permitted to build shrines at the sites associated with the Gurus.**
5. **He built seven**, over the following months — including **Sis Ganj** where Guru Tegh Bahadur was executed in 1675, **Rakab Ganj** where his body was cremated, and **Bangla Sahib** where Guru Har Krishan had died in 1664.
6. **And then he went home.** By the end of 1783 the Sikh force had left Delhi.

WHAT THEY DID NOT DO

It is worth listing what an eighteenth-century army in possession of Delhi would normally have done, because none of it happened.

They did not sack the city. Nadir Shah had in 1739 and Abdali had in 1757, both within living memory, and both had stripped it. **The city was assessed, not looted.**

They did not depose the emperor. Shah Alam II remained on the throne he was already only nominally occupying.

They did not annex anything. No territory changed hands; the arrangement was a revenue share and a building permit.

And they did not stay. The capital of India was in their hands and they left it within the year.

The reason is the reason this book has been circling since Part Ten. **The misls had no state-building project.** They were not a dynasty seeking a throne; they were twelve autonomous chiefs with territories in the Punjab, who had come down the road because they could. What Baghel Singh actually wanted was the sites — and having secured them, there was nothing else in Delhi worth the cost of holding it.

WHY THEY COULD TAKE DELHI

- **There was no government.** Shah Alam II had no treasury and no army; the Marathas who protected him were between commitments.
- **They had the road.** The Grand Trunk Road from the Punjab to Delhi was in Sikh hands the whole way after 1764.
- **They came as one force.** This was a gurmata operation with three of the great chiefs in it — one of the last times the confederacy acted together.
- **And nothing was defended.** The Red Fort was entered, not stormed.

WHY HOLDING IT WAS NEVER THE PLAN

- **Delhi is not in the Punjab.** Holding it means garrisoning a hostile capital two hundred miles from your own districts.
- **The Marathas would have come.** Mahadji Scindia was reasserting Maratha control over the emperor at exactly this period and would not have left it alone.
- **Twelve equal chiefs could not have divided it.** Who governs Delhi is not a question the misl system could answer.
- **And the objective had been achieved.** They came for the sites.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Throne and the Slab

Two things happened in the Red Fort in March 1783 that between them say everything about what the misls were.

The first is a refusal. Sikh tradition records that in the Diwan-i-Am, some of the sardars seated **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia** on the imperial throne and proclaimed him king — and that **Jassa Singh Ramgarhia objected**, on the ground that the Khalsa had no king and was not going to acquire one in somebody else's palace. The tradition has Ahluwalia stepping down.

Take the scene as **STORY** ; nobody was taking minutes. **But note that a community which could have remembered its greatest chief being crowned emperor of India chose instead to remember him being told to get off the chair.** That is a deliberate choice about what the thing was for, and it is the same choice as Banda leaving his name off the coin in Part Ten.

The second is a theft. Jassa Singh Ramgarhia — the man who had just objected to the throne — **had a large stone slab from the fort prised out and carried to Amritsar on carts.** It is said to be the slab on which Mughal emperors sat or were invested. It is in the Ramgarhia Bunga, beside the tank, and you can see it.

So the same man refused the throne and took the furniture.

That is not a contradiction. **It is exactly the point.** They would not have a king, and they would take the emperor's stone four hundred kilometres up the Grand Trunk Road and put it next to the pool at Amritsar, where anybody could stand on it.

Achal, 1782 — The Misls Turn on Each Other

LIKELY

A battle between two Sikh armies near Batala killed one man, and the widow’s response created the Sikh empire.

WON BY The Sukerchakias and Ramgarhias — and the loser’s family won everything

WHEN	WHERE
1782.	Achal, near Batala in the Majha country.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Mahan Singh Sukerchakia and Jassa Singh Ramgarhia, against Jai Singh Kanhaiya.	Sikh accounts; the marriage that followed is documented.

What happened

1. **The Kanhaiya misl had become the strongest in the Punjab.** Jai Singh Kanhaiya held a great swathe of the Majha and the Kangra hills, and had driven the Ramgarhias out of their territories altogether.
2. **So the others combined against him.** Mahan Singh Sukerchakia — Ranjit Singh’s father — allied with the exiled Jassa Singh Ramgarhia, and they brought Jai Singh to battle at Achal.
3. **Jai Singh’s only son, Gurbaksh Singh Kanhaiya, was killed in the fighting.**
4. **The Kanhaiya power was broken** — not destroyed, but permanently reduced, and the Ramgarhias got their lands back.
5. **And then Gurbaksh Singh’s widow did something nobody expected.**

SADA KAUR

The widow was **Sada Kaur**, and she is one of the most consequential people in the history of the Punjab. She is also, in most accounts of this period, a paragraph.

Her husband had been killed by Mahan Singh Sukerchakia. She had a young daughter, **Mehtab Kaur**, an ageing father-in-law, and a misl that had just lost its heir and half its standing.

She proposed a marriage. **Her daughter to Ranjit Singh, the son of the man responsible for her husband's death.**

The betrothal was agreed in the mid-1780s and the marriage took place in 1796. Jai Singh Kanhaiya, who had lost his son, accepted an alliance with the family that killed him — because the alternative was watching the Kanhaiya misl be dismantled by the Sukerchakias and the Ramgarhias over the following decade.

What Sada Kaur bought with that marriage was the survival of her misl. What she gave Ranjit Singh was the Kanhaiya army.

When he rode on Lahore in July 1799, aged eighteen, the troops behind him were substantially hers, and she was with them. She was his mother-in-law, his principal ally and, for the first decade of his rise, his indispensable partner.

He dispossessed her in 1821 and she died in confinement. This book will get to that in Part Thirteen, and it is not a story that reflects well on him.

WHY THE COALITION BEAT THE KANHAIYAS

- **Success creates a coalition against you.** The Kanhaiyas had grown too large for the other misls to tolerate, exactly as the misl system was designed to prevent.
- **The Ramgarhias had a grievance and nothing to lose.** Six years of exile makes a highly motivated ally.
- **And the death of one man decided it.** Gurbaksh Singh was the Kanhaiya heir and the misl's future, and it ended with him.

WHAT THE CONFEDERACY LOST

- **The principle.** Two Sikh armies fought each other in the Majha, sixteen years after they had beaten Ahmad Shah Abdali together.
- **The assembly's authority.** No gurmata could have stopped this and none was attempted.
- **The habit of combining.** After Achal, alliance between misls means an alliance against another misl.
- **And it made a super-misl inevitable.** If the strongest can be brought down by a coalition, the winner of the last coalition becomes the strongest — and in 1799 that was the Sukerchakias.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Marriage That Made a Kingdom

Look at the arithmetic of what Sada Kaur did, because it is one of the coldest and most successful political calculations in this book.

Her position in 1782: husband dead, no son, a father-in-law past his best, a misl that had just been beaten by two others and would be picked apart by them within a decade. In the ordinary course of eighteenth-century Punjab politics, the Kanhaiya territories would have been divided between the Sukerchakias and the Ramgarhias by about 1795.

Her move: offer her daughter to the killer's son. Convert the enemy into a family. Trade a claim for revenge — which was worth nothing, since she had no army to enforce it — for a permanent alliance with the rising power.

The result: the Kanhaiya misl survived. And when the moment came, the young man she had made her son-in-law had the horses and the men to take Lahore.

This book has spent twelve parts describing coalitions that failed because nobody could combine — the ten kings on the Ravi, the Malavas and Kshudrakas, Anandapala's confederacy, Prithviraj at Tarain, the hill rajas, the misls themselves. **The one alliance in this part that actually holds and produces something is arranged by a widow with no army, using the only instrument available to a woman in that society, against the man who had made her one.**

Marriage as statecraft is not new — Chandragupta and Seleucus in Part Three, Akbar and the Rajputs in Part Eight. **What is unusual here is who is doing it, and that she was operating from the losing side.**

She got twenty-two years out of it, and then he took her lands.

The Ramgarhia Exile, 1776–1783

LIKELY

One of the twelve misls was driven out of the Punjab entirely by the other eleven’s indifference, spent seven years in exile, and walked back in.

WON BY The Kanhaiyas — and then, seven years later, by nobody

WHEN Driven out around 1776 ; returned in 1783 .	WHERE Out of the Bari Doab into the Malwa and the country towards Hansi and the Jumna.
WHO Jassa Singh Ramgarhia , against the Kanhaiya and Ahluwalia misls.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh accounts; his return and restoration are well attested.

What happened

1. **The Ramgarhia misl was one of the strongest**, holding Batala and a large territory in the Bari Doab. Its chief had been a builder and a soldier for thirty years — the man of Part Eleven’s Ram Rauni siege, who took his name from the fort he rebuilt.
2. **Jai Singh Kanhaiya and Jassa Singh Ahluwalia combined against him** around 1776 and drove him out of his territories.
3. **The other misls did not intervene**. This is the point of the section: **a founding chief of the confederacy was expelled from the Punjab and nine other governments declined to have a view**.
4. **He spent seven years in the country south and east of the Sutlej**, taking service and making alliances with local powers — the same Malwa and Haryana country where George Thomas would later build a kingdom.
5. **Achal changed everything**. In 1782 Mahan Singh Sukerchakia allied with him against the Kanhaiyas, and after the battle he recovered his lands.
6. **And in 1783 he was in the Red Fort at Delhi**, objecting to a coronation and removing a slab.

WHAT AN EXILE PROVES

The expulsion of the Ramgarhias is the clearest single measure of what had happened to the confederacy between 1764 and 1776, and it is worth stating flatly.

In 1764 the misls took the Sirhind province together and divided it by agreement, and the division held. Part Eleven called that the moment the oldest failure in this book was solved.

Twelve years later, two misls drove a third out of the country and nobody stopped them.

There was no mechanism to stop them. That is the whole trouble. The Sarbat Khalsa could pass a resolution; it had no army of its own, no officers, no treasury and no way of enforcing anything against a chief who declined to comply. **Its authority had always rested on the fact that every chief needed every other chief, because Ahmad Shah Abdali was coming back in the autumn.**

Take that away and the assembly is a meeting.

This is the central finding of Part Twelve and it should be uncomfortable. The most successful political institution in these sixteen parts — the one that survived the bounty years, two ghallugharas and nine invasions — turned out to have been held together by the enemy.

WHY HE WAS DRIVEN OUT

- **He was strong and in the way.** Ramgarhia territory sat between Kanhaiya ambitions and the hills.
- **Two misls against one.** The arithmetic that the confederacy's equality was supposed to prevent, and could not.
- **And nobody's interest was engaged.** A quarrel in the Bari Doab was not a threat to a chief in the Malwa.

WHY HE CAME BACK

- **Because the winners fell out.** Kanhaiya success against the Ramgarhias frightened the Sukerchakias into an alliance with the exile.
- **He kept his following.** A misl is men, not land, and his men went with him into exile and came back with him.
- **He was useful.** Seven years of experience in the Malwa and Haryana made him valuable to anybody planning a campaign towards Delhi.
- **And the system had no way of making an expulsion permanent** any more than it had a way of preventing one.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Carpenter

Jassa Singh Ramgarhia was, by origin, a *tarkhan* — a carpenter, from a family of artisans. That is what the name of his misl records, indirectly: he took it from a fort he rebuilt, and rebuilding was his trade before it was his profession.

His career runs the length of Parts Ten to Twelve. He was in Mughal service as a young man; **he changed sides during the siege of Ram Rauni in 1748** and went into the fort; he rebuilt it afterwards and named it Ramgarh; he fought Abdali; he held a great territory in the Bari Doab; he was driven out of the Punjab by his own colleagues and spent seven years in exile; he came back, recovered everything, and in 1783 was standing in the Diwan-i-Am at Delhi telling the commander-in-chief of the Dal Khalsa that the Khalsa did not have kings.

He died in 1803, at about eighty, having outlived nearly everybody in this part.

Now the reason he belongs here. **Look at what the Khalsa system had made possible.** A carpenter's son commanded one of the twelve governments of the Punjab, on terms of formal equality with men from every other background, and nobody in the confederacy thought it was remarkable enough to comment on.

Part Nine described what was done at Anandpur in 1699 — one name for everybody, initiation open to anyone, caste removed from the qualification for command. **This is what that looked like eighty years later, in practice, as an ordinary fact about who was running the country.**

His bunga is still standing at Amritsar, with two minarets, and the Delhi slab inside it.

Mahadji Scindia and the Maratha Return, 1785–1794

LIKELY

Twenty-four years after Panipat the Marathas were back at Delhi — and this time they brought European officers and did not try to take the Punjab.

WON BY

Nobody — a standoff on the Jumna that both sides preferred to a war

WHEN

1785–1794, the period of Maratha dominance at Delhi.

WHERE

The country between the Jumna and the Sutlej — the Cis-Sutlej states and Haryana.

WHO

Mahadji Scindia, with the brigades of **Benoît de Boigne**, against the Cis-Sutlej misls.

THE EVIDENCE

Maratha correspondence, British reports, and Sikh accounts.

What had changed

The Maratha confederacy had been broken at Panipat in 1761 but not destroyed, and by the 1780s it had recovered enough to be the dominant power in northern India again. **Mahadji Scindia** — one of the survivors of Panipat — made himself the protector of the emperor at Delhi and effectively ran the Mughal court.

And he had learned the lesson of 1761. **His army was not the old Maratha light cavalry.** He hired a Savoyard officer, **Benoît de Boigne**, and raised brigades of regular infantry, drilled in European fashion, with disciplined artillery.

These formations were the most effective troops in India outside the Company's army, and they changed what was possible. Cavalry — even the finest in Asia — cannot break a square of trained infantry with guns. Everybody in northern India worked this out in the 1790s, and the ones who worked it out fastest are in Part Thirteen.

What happened

1. **Scindia's forces pushed north-west** into the country the Cis-Sutlej misls had taken after Sirhind in 1764.
2. **There were clashes and there were negotiations**, repeatedly, through the later 1780s. Neither side wanted a war of conquest.

3. **The Sikhs raided; the Marathas garrisoned.** A pattern familiar from every frontier in this book.
4. **And agreements were reached — several times — and did not hold long,** because the misls were twelve governments and no single signature bound them.
5. **Scindia died in 1794** and Maratha attention turned south, where a much larger problem was developing.

THE TWELVE-SIGNATURE PROBLEM

This is where the confederacy's structure stops being an internal inconvenience and becomes a foreign policy disaster.

A treaty requires somebody who can sign it. Scindia's agents, and later the British, faced the same difficulty every time: there was no Sikh government. There were twelve chiefs in the Punjab, another dozen smaller ones south of the Sutlej, and any agreement made with one of them bound one of them.

The Marathas dealt with it by making separate arrangements with individual chiefs, which meant playing them against each other — and that suited the Marathas perfectly well.

It suited the British even better, and they were watching. The Cis-Sutlej chiefs' habit of making individual arrangements with a stronger outside power is exactly how the Sutlej line gets drawn in 1809 in Part Thirteen, and how the Cis-Sutlej states end up under British protection while the Punjab proper stays independent.

Twelve equal governments is a magnificent way to survive an invasion and a catastrophic way to conduct diplomacy.

WHY THE MARATHAS CAME BACK

- **The emperor was worth having.** Legitimacy at Delhi was still worth something, and nobody else was providing it.
- **De Boigne's brigades.** Regular infantry and artillery gave them something the Punjab had no answer to.
- **And there was no opposing state.** The Punjab had twelve governments and the Ganges plain had none at all.

WHY NEITHER SIDE PUSHED

- **The Marathas had a bigger enemy.** The Company was expanding, and after 1798 the war with Tipu Sultan and then with the Marathas themselves consumed everything.
- **The Sikhs had nothing to gain.** Territory beyond the Jumna was not defensible and nobody's misl needed it.
- **Neither could deliver a knockout.** Cavalry cannot break brigades; brigades cannot catch cavalry.
- **And the Cis-Sutlej chiefs preferred ambiguity.** Being courted by two powers is more comfortable than belonging to one.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Europeans Arrive Sideways

There is something worth noticing about the 1780s and 1790s in northern India that is easy to miss because it happens gradually and in the wrong uniform.

The European officer becomes the decisive military commodity, and almost none of them are working for European governments.

Benoît de Boigne was a Savoyard who had served in the Russian army and was captured by the Turks, and he raised and trained the brigades that made Mahadji Scindia the master of northern India. **Begum Samru** of Sardhana — who mediated between the Sikhs and the emperor at Delhi in 1783 — ran a small state with a European-officered force of her own. **Pierre Cuillier-Perron**, a French sailor's son, ended up commanding Scindia's northern army. **George Thomas**, an Irish deserter, is War Eight.

They were mercenaries. They served whoever paid, they changed employers, and several of them ended up fighting the countrymen they had left.

What they carried was not a flag but a method: infantry drilled to fire in volleys and stand under fire, artillery served by trained crews, and pay delivered on time so that neither would go home.

That method was going to decide everything. It had already beaten the French in Bengal, it was about to beat Tipu Sultan at Seringapatam, and within twenty years it would beat the Marathas who had hired it.

And the ruler who understood it best was an eighteen-year-old in the Punjab who had not yet taken Lahore. By 1822 Ranjit Singh had French and Italian officers of Napoleon's armies training his infantry, and it is why Part Fourteen takes two wars and eight battles rather than one afternoon.

George Thomas, 1798–1801 — The Irish King of Haryana

LIKELY

A sailor from Tipperary who deserted his ship built a kingdom on the Punjab’s south-eastern border, cast his own cannon, minted his own coin, and announced that he intended to conquer the Punjab and give it to Britain.

WON BY

The French-officered Maratha brigades — and Thomas lost to Europeans, not to Sikhs

WHEN Independent from about 1798; destroyed in 1801–02.	WHERE Hansi and Hisar in the Haryana country, on the border of the Cis-Sutlej Sikh states.
WHO George Thomas, against the Sikh chiefs of the Malwa, and finally against Perron’s brigades.	THE EVIDENCE His own memoir, dictated to William Francklin — an outside account of the misls by a man who fought them.

Who he was

1. **He was an Irish sailor** who deserted the Royal Navy at Madras in the early 1780s and went inland to sell the only skill he had, which was gunnery.
2. **He served a succession of Indian employers** — southern chiefs, then **Begum Samru** at Sardhana, then a Maratha commander — rising each time.
3. **In 1798 he set up on his own account** in the arid Haryana country between the Jumna and the Sutlej, made **Hansi** his capital, and governed it.
4. **And he did it properly.** He restored the town, raised revenue, drilled infantry, **cast his own artillery in his own foundry, and struck his own coinage.**
5. **He fought the Sikhs repeatedly**, raiding into the Cis-Sutlej states and being raided in turn, with mixed results across several campaigns.
6. **He was destroyed by other Europeans.** Perron, commanding Scindia’s northern brigades, sent a French-officered force against him in 1801; he was besieged at Hansi and surrendered on terms at the beginning of 1802.

7. **He set out for Calcutta and died on the way**, at Berhampore, in August 1802 — and on the journey he dictated his story to a Company officer named William Francklin, who published it.

WHAT HIS MEMOIR SAYS ABOUT THE PUNJAB

Thomas is a useful witness for the same reason as Qazi Nur Muhammad in Part Eleven: **he fought the Sikhs, he did not like them, and he was describing them for a foreign government.**

What he reports is a country of many chiefs and no ruler; excellent cavalry available in very large numbers; almost no infantry worth the name; and artillery that was scarce, poorly served and inferior to anything a European-officered force could put in the field.

He also stated an intention that should be read carefully. He proposed — and told the Company so — that with British support he could conquer the Punjab, and that he intended to hoist British colours over Lahore.

It was the boast of a man looking for a patron and it came to nothing. **But it is the first time in this book that anybody proposes a British conquest of the Punjab, and it is 1799.**

Forty-seven years later, in Part Fourteen, it happens.

WHY ONE MAN COULD BUILD A STATE

- **There was no government in Haryana.** Between the Marathas at Delhi, the Sikh chiefs to the north and nothing to the west, the country was open.
- **He had the method.** Drilled infantry and his own guns against irregular cavalry, in country where cavalry had nowhere to hide.
- **He paid his men.** The one thing that separates an army from a band, and half the powers in this part could not manage it.
- **And he governed rather than raided.** Hansi was administered, which meant it produced revenue, which meant he could keep paying.

WHY IT LASTED FOUR YEARS

- **He had no state behind him.** No recruiting ground, no allies, no legitimacy, and nowhere to retreat to.
- **He made enemies on every side at once** — Sikhs, Marathas, and the Company's rivals among the French officers.
- **And he met his own method coming the other way.** Perron's brigades were what Thomas's brigade was, only larger.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Warning Nobody Read

George Thomas's kingdom is a curiosity, and his memoir is not.

Read what he actually reported to his English readers about the military situation in the Punjab in 1799, and read it as the misls should have read it.

The finest irregular cavalry in Asia, in enormous numbers, belonging to a dozen governments that would not combine. Almost no trained infantry. Artillery that was old, scarce and badly served. No arsenal, no foundry, no drill, and no fortress that could stand against a properly conducted siege.

And on the other side of the ledger: **one Irishman with a few battalions of drilled infantry and guns he had cast himself had made himself a king in country the Sikh chiefs regarded as theirs, and it had taken a French-officered army to remove him.**

That is not an insult to the misls. Their cavalry had beaten Ahmad Shah Abdali by refusing to fight him. It is a statement that the thing they were good at had stopped being the thing that decided wars, and that the change had happened within one generation.

The same demonstration was being given everywhere in India in the same decade. **De Boigne's brigades made Scindia master of the north. The Company's sepoy, drilled the same way, were about to take Seringapatam.**

Only one man in the Punjab acted on it. Within a few years of taking Lahore, Ranjit Singh was building an arsenal, hiring European officers, and turning horsemen into infantry — and he did it because he had grown up on the border of George Thomas's kingdom watching what a few battalions and some decent guns could do.

Zaman Shah, 1795–1799

LIKELY

Abdali’s grandson came down the road three times and found a province with twelve governments, no army and nobody to negotiate with. It should have been easy.

WON BY Events in Afghanistan — which is the only reason it was not a disaster

WHEN 1795, 1797 and 1798–99.	WHERE Down the Grand Trunk Road to Lahore , twice occupying it.
WHO Zaman Shah Durrani, grandson of Ahmad Shah Abdali.	THE EVIDENCE Afghan, Sikh and — significantly — British records.

What happened

1. He came in 1795 and reached the Punjab before turning back.
2. He came again at the start of 1797, took Lahore, and withdrew within weeks because of trouble at home.
3. He came a third time at the end of 1798, took Lahore again, and this time meant to stay.
4. And the misls did what they had always done. They dispersed, refused battle, harassed his communications, cut off his foraging parties, and waited. The method of Part Ten and Part Eleven, applied to a lesser man than Abdali.
5. Then his brother rebelled in Afghanistan and Persian pressure developed on his western frontier, and in January 1799 he abandoned the Punjab and went home fast.
6. His artillery got stuck. Crossing the Jhelum in flood, a number of his guns went into the river and had to be left.

WHY CALCUTTA WAS WATCHING

Zaman Shah's invasions matter for a reason that has nothing to do with the Punjab, and it is the first appearance in this book of a pattern that dominates the last four parts.

The British were frightened of him. An Afghan army marching on Delhi, at a moment when the Company was fighting Tipu Sultan in the south and worrying about French influence, looked like a serious threat to a position that was not yet secure.

So Calcutta acted at a distance. **In 1799 the Company sent Captain John Malcolm on a mission to Persia**, with the explicit object of encouraging the Persian court to threaten Zaman Shah's western frontier and keep him occupied at home.

It is a small episode and it is the shape of everything that follows. **The British did not fight Zaman Shah. They arranged for somebody else to distract him, from two thousand kilometres away, using diplomacy and money.**

Part Fourteen is full of this. The Company's method in the Punjab was never primarily military; it was treaties, subsidies, residents, boundary lines and the careful management of other people's succession disputes. **The first move in that long game was made in 1799, in Tehran, about a man who had just left Lahore.**

WHY THE MISLS SURVIVED HIM

- **The old method still worked.** Disperse, refuse battle, harass, wait for the season to end.
- **He was not his grandfather.** Zaman Shah had a divided kingdom behind him and could never stay a full campaigning season.
- **The country would not feed him.** Foraging parties in a hostile Punjab do not come back.
- **And Persia and his brother did the rest.**

WHAT HIS INVASIONS PROVED

- **The frontier was undefended.** He reached Lahore twice in two years without fighting a battle for it.
- **Twelve governments could not concentrate.** No gurmata was passed, no combined army took the field, and no chief could speak for the province.
- **Refusing battle is not a policy when you hold cities.** Lahore fell twice because dispersing means abandoning it.
- **And the Punjab was living on the invader's weakness.** A stronger Afghan king would have kept it, and everybody in the province knew it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Guns in the River

When Zaman Shah broke off his third invasion in January 1799 and went home, his army crossed the Jhelum in a hurry and in flood, and a number of his heavy guns were lost in the river.

The tradition — and it is well attested enough to be worth telling — is that a young Sukerchakia chief named **Ranjit Singh**, who had been harassing the Afghan columns, had the guns recovered from the riverbed and sent back to Zaman Shah.

And that in return, or at least soon afterwards, **Zaman Shah confirmed him as governor of Lahore** — a city the Afghan king did not hold, in a province he had just abandoned, in favour of a young man who had not yet taken it.

Treat the causal link as **STORY**. The recovery of the guns is reported; the exchange is a neat piece of tradition and the timing is convenient.

But look at the politics, because whether or not it happened exactly like that, the calculation behind it is real and it is very shrewd.

An eighteen-year-old chief of a middling misl wanted Lahore. Taking it by force was possible; **taking it with a piece of paper from the King of Afghanistan was better**, because it converted a raid into a succession and gave every other misl one fewer argument.

He got the guns out of a river and turned them into a title.

Part Thirteen is forty years of that.

Lahore, 7 July 1799

CERTAIN

The citizens of Lahore wrote to an eighteen-year-old and asked him to come and take the city off the men who were holding it. He came.

WON BY

Ranjit Singh — with his mother-in-law's army and a letter of invitation

WHEN

7 July 1799.

WHERE

Lahore.

WHO

Ranjit Singh of the Sukerchakia misl, with **Sada Kaur** and the Kanhaiya forces, against the three Bhangi sardars.

THE EVIDENCE

Persian, Sikh and later British accounts; the invitation is documented.

What happened

1. **Lahore had been held since 1765 by three Bhangi chiefs** governing it between them. By 1799 the arrangement had degenerated: the surviving sardars were unpopular, the city was badly administered, and Zaman Shah's two occupations had shown that nobody was defending it.
2. **The leading men of the city sent a petition.** The signatories named in the accounts include **Muslim notables and a Hindu** — merchants, officials and religious figures — asking Ranjit Singh to come and take over.
3. **He came with the Kanhaiya forces.** Sada Kaur — his mother-in-law, the widow from Achal in 1782 — brought her misl's troops and came with the army herself.
4. **A gate was opened for them.** The accounts differ on which; the point is that it was opened.
5. **The fort held out briefly and surrendered.** One of the Bhangi sardars gave it up on terms.
6. **He was eighteen years old**, blind in one eye from childhood smallpox, and could barely read.

THE INVITATION, INVERTED

This book has a pattern that it has stated as a law, in Part Seven and again in Part Five, and July 1799 is the one time it runs the other way.

Ambhi invited Alexander in Part Two to settle a score with Porus, and lost his independence. **Daulat Khan Lodi invited Babur in Part Seven** to remove Ibrahim Lodi, and died a prisoner while a foreign dynasty took the country for three centuries. **Every invitation in these twelve parts has been extended to an outsider, and every one of them has ended the same way.**

The petition of 1799 went to a man born in Gujranwala, forty miles away.

And notice who signed it. The men who asked a Sikh chief to come and govern Lahore included Muslim notables of the city — in a province that had spent the previous century in a religious war, thirty-four years after a Sikh confederacy had taken the city from an Afghan king.

They were not making a statement about religion. **They wanted the streets policed and the revenue collected by somebody competent**, and the three men in possession were not doing it.

That is worth holding on to for Part Thirteen, because the state Ranjit Singh built ran on exactly that principle — a Sikh maharaja with a Muslim foreign minister, a Hindu finance department, European generals and an army recruited from everybody — and it started with a petition from people who wanted the bins emptied.

WHY HE TOOK IT

- **He was asked.** Which converted an attack into an arrival.
- **He had Sada Kaur's army.** The marriage arranged in 1782 delivered exactly what it had been designed to deliver.
- **He had a colourable title.** Whatever passed between him and Zaman Shah, he could claim the Afghan king's confirmation, and nobody could easily contradict it.
- **And the Bhangis were finished.** The strongest misl of 1770 had been declining for twenty-five years and could not defend its own capital.

WHY THE CONFEDERACY DID NOT STOP HIM

- **No mechanism existed.** The Sarbat Khalsa had not bound anybody for a decade; there was no body that could have forbidden it and no army that could have enforced a prohibition.
- **Every other misl had its own quarrel.** The Ramgarhias, Kanhaiyas, Ahluwalias and Nakais were all pursuing their own interests, and several were his allies.
- **The Bhangis had no friends.** Twenty years of misl politics had left them with nobody willing to march for them.
- **And a great many people were tired.** After a century of war, a young man with an army who promised order was not an unattractive proposition.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Boy With One Eye

Consider the person who rode into Lahore on 7 July 1799, because on paper he is not an obvious candidate for anything.

He was **eighteen**. He had lost an eye to smallpox as a small child and his face was marked by it. **He could barely read** — his education had been neglected during a chaotic minority, and he remained functionally illiterate, having documents read to him for the rest of his life.

His father Mahan Singh had died when he was about ten, leaving him the chief of the **Sukerchakia misl** — **which was not one of the great ones**. The Bhangis were larger, the Kanhaiyas had been stronger, the Ahluwalias had the prestige, and the Ramgarhias had the reputation. His inheritance was a middling territory around Gujranwala.

What he had instead was an alliance made for him when he was a small boy by a woman whose husband his father had killed, and an instinct for the difference between force and legitimacy that most rulers in this book never develop at all.

He did not storm Lahore. He was invited, arrived with his mother-in-law's cavalry, accepted a surrender on terms, and could show a piece of paper from the King of Afghanistan. Every element of that was chosen.

Two years later, on Vaisakhi 1801, he had himself proclaimed **Maharaja** — a title no Sikh had ever taken, in a tradition that had made a constitutional principle out of not having kings, in the city where the Bhangis had governed by committee.

And on his coins, from first to last, he put the names of the Gurus and never his own.

He ruled for forty years. Part Thirteen is what he did with them.

The Assembly That Stopped Meeting

LIKELY

Not a battle. The failure of the most successful political institution in this book, and why it failed.

WHAT HAPPENED The confederacy dissolved because nothing was attacking it

WHEN Effective through the 1760s; decaying through the 1770s and 1780s; over by the 1790s.	WHERE Amritsar — or rather, increasingly, not at Amritsar.
WHO The Sarbat Khalsa, and the twelve chiefs who stopped attending it.	THE EVIDENCE The absence of recorded gurmata after the 1780s, and the wars in Wars Five and Six.

How it decayed

- 1748–1767: it works.** Gurmata allocate commands, divide conquered territory, decide whether to accept an Afghan king’s terms, and bind twelve equal chiefs — because Abdali is coming back and every chief needs every other chief.
- 1767: the pressure stops.** Abdali crosses the Indus for the last time.
- 1772: territory becomes property.** Multan is taken by one misl and is that misl’s business. The habit of common enterprise starts to look like an option rather than a necessity.
- 1776: a founding chief is expelled and nobody intervenes.** The assembly’s authority is tested and found not to exist.
- 1782: two Sikh armies fight a pitched battle at Achal.** No gurmata is passed against it because there is no point.
- 1783: the last great combined operation** — Delhi — and even that is three chiefs rather than twelve.
- 1790s: the assemblies are called and not attended.** Zaman Shah invades three times and no combined army takes the field.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE FINDING

Part Eleven claimed that the Sarbat Khalsa had solved the oldest problem in this book — the Indian coalition that cannot agree on a commander. Twelve parts of failures, from the ten kings on the Ravi to Prithviraj at Tarain, and here at last was a working federal system.

Part Twelve has to withdraw half of that claim.

The system did not solve the problem. **It suspended it, for as long as an external threat made cooperation cheaper than defection.** The gurmata bound a chief who wished to be bound, and between 1748 and 1767 every chief wished to be, because the alternative was Ahmad Shah Abdali.

Take the enemy away and the arithmetic reverses. A chief who complies gains nothing; a chief who defects gains a district. **And there is no army, no treasury, no court and no officer of the confederacy to make him pay for it.**

This is not a Punjabi failing and it is not unique to the misls. **It is the standing weakness of every confederacy in history that has no central coercive power,** and the same decades that saw the Sarbat Khalsa stop binding anybody saw thirteen states on the other side of the world discover the identical problem and write a constitution about it.

The misls did not write one. **What they got instead was a maharaja.**

WHAT ACTUALLY REPLACED IT

- **A single ruler with a standing army.** Which is what every other state in this book had always had, and which the Khalsa had deliberately refused for a century.
- **Coercion.** Ranjit Singh absorbed the misls one at a time — by marriage, by treaty, by purchase and by force — and by 1820 there was one government in the Punjab.
- **And it worked, militarily.** No confederacy could have built the army of Part Thirteen, and no confederacy could have held the Punjab for forty years.

AND WHAT WAS LOST WITH IT

- **The assembly.** Ranjit Singh did not convene the Sarbat Khalsa. The institution that had governed the Khalsa since 1748 simply stopped.
- **The principle of no king.** Held from 1699 to 1801, asserted in the Red Fort in 1783, and abandoned on a Vaisakhi in Lahore.
- **The distributed command.** One ruler is one point of failure — and Part Fourteen begins with his death.
- **The chiefs.** Sada Kaur, who made him, was dispossessed in 1821 and died in confinement.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What the Enemy Was Holding Together

Here is the argument of this part in one paragraph, and it should be read twice.

The Khalsa was at its most united when it was being hunted, at its most disciplined when it had nothing, and at its most effective when it was losing.

The bounty years produced the Dal Khalsa. The Ghallugharas produced the Diwali assembly of 1762. Nine Afghan invasions produced the conquest of the province. **Every institution described in Parts Ten and Eleven was built under a pressure that would have destroyed anything less well designed.**

Then in 1767 the pressure stopped, and within twenty years the same men were fighting each other over Batala.

This is not a story about the Punjab. **It is one of the most reliable findings in the whole of political history and it turns up in these sixteen parts again and again.** Yashodharman's coalition beat Mihirakula in Part Four and dissolved the moment it won. The Greek kingdoms of Part Three could not be beaten by anybody and spent sixty years destroying each other. The Afghan nobility of Part Seven was consultative and effective under Bahlul Lodi and tore itself apart the moment it had no enemy.

Solidarity is easiest to sustain against something. The misls had an unusually good system for it, and it worked for nineteen years, and then it did not have a job to do.

And the thing that came next held the Punjab for forty years, built the last independent army in India, and collapsed inside ten years of one man's death — which is Parts Thirteen and Fourteen, and which is the other half of the same lesson.

1799 — The Year the Map Changed

CERTAIN

Two months apart, the last independent power in the south was destroyed and the last independent power in the north was founded. Everything in the final four parts of this book is in that sentence.

WHAT HAPPENED

India acquired one dominant power and one remaining rival

WHEN 4 May 1799 at Seringapatam; 7 July 1799 at Lahore.	WHERE Mysore, and the Punjab — three thousand kilometres apart.
WHO The East India Company, and Ranjit Singh.	THE EVIDENCE Both events are documented in detail from several directions.

The two events

1. **On 4 May 1799, Seringapatam was stormed and Tipu Sultan was killed** in the breach. Mysore had been the most formidable Indian opponent the Company had faced — with a modern army, French officers, rocket artillery and a ruler who understood exactly what he was fighting. It took four wars and thirty years, and it ended in a morning.
2. **On 7 July 1799, Ranjit Singh entered Lahore.**
3. **With Mysore gone, the Company’s only serious rivals were the Marathas** — and the Marathas were destroyed in two wars over the following twenty years, at Assaye in 1803 and finally in 1818.
4. **Which left one independent power of any size in India,** and it was in the Punjab.

THE FRAME FOR THE REST OF THIS BOOK

It is worth setting out what the last four parts of this history are going to be about, because 1799 is where the shape of it is fixed.

Part Thirteen: forty years in which Ranjit Singh builds a state and an army from Peshawar to the Sutlej — the only power in India that the Company treats as an equal and signs a border treaty with rather than a subsidiary alliance.

Part Fourteen: what happens to that state ten years after he dies.

And Parts Fifteen and Sixteen: what a province does when it has been annexed.

The reason the Punjab is last is geography, and this book has been explaining it since Part One. **It is the furthest thing from Calcutta.** The Company came in by sea, took Bengal in the 1760s, worked up the Ganges, dealt with Mysore and the Marathas, and reached the Sutlej in 1809 — **by which time there was a real state on the other side of it.**

Forty years of independence, bought by one man's ability and by two thousand kilometres of distance.

WHY THE COMPANY WON EVERYWHERE ELSE

- **Drilled infantry and disciplined artillery,** paid on time out of the revenues of Bengal — the method Part Twelve has watched arrive with de Boigne, Perron and George Thomas.
- **Sea power and money.** Reinforcement, credit and supply that no Indian state could match.
- **One decision-making body.** Against a subcontinent of rulers who could not combine — the failure this book has documented in every part since the first.
- **And they made treaties as instruments of conquest.** Subsidiary alliances turned allies into dependants without a battle being fought.

WHY THE PUNJAB LASTED FIFTY MORE YEARS

- **Distance.** The single largest factor, and the least glamorous.
- **One ruler who understood the method and copied it.** Ranjit Singh built the only Indian army of the period that could stand against the Company's, and he did it deliberately.
- **And he never fought them.** Forty years of scrupulous treaty observance on the Sutlej line, which is the most underrated achievement in Part Thirteen.
- **Then he died,** and it took the British nine years.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

Sixty-Four Days

On 4 May 1799, a British storming party went through a breach at Seringapatam and Tipu Sultan died fighting in a gateway with his own troops. He had been the most dangerous enemy the Company had, and he was the last ruler in southern India with the capacity to be one.

Sixty-four days later, on 7 July, an eighteen-year-old rode into Lahore.

Neither man had heard of the other's day. News between Mysore and the Punjab took months and there was no reason for anybody to connect them.

But between those two dates the map of India was set for the next half-century. One power had removed its last southern rival; another had just been founded at the opposite corner of the subcontinent, and it would be the only thing left on the board.

And there is one more thing about 1799 worth ending on, because this book has been keeping track of it for twelve parts.

George Thomas, in Haryana that same year, was telling the Company that with a little support he could conquer the Punjab and hoist British colours over Lahore.

He was a deserter with four battalions and a foundry, and it was the boast of a man looking for a patron, and it came to nothing at all.

It was also, precisely, the plan. **It took forty-seven years, two wars, and a Punjabi army that fought better than anything the British met in India — and in 1849 the colours went up over Lahore.**

That is Part Fourteen. Part Thirteen is the forty years in between, and they are the best years this province has in the whole of this book.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1767	Ahmad Shah Abdali crosses the Indus for the last time. The pressure that held the confederacy together is removed.
1767–1799	The misl system. Twelve autonomous states, formally equal, sharing Amritsar as a capital none of them owns, each with a <i>bunga</i> beside the tank; <i>rakhi</i> grown into ordinary land revenue; the Sarbat Khalsa meeting twice a year.
1770	Charat Singh Sukerchakia is killed at Jammu when his own matchlock bursts — Ranjit Singh's grandfather.
1772	The Bhangi misl takes Multan. Abdali dies the same year. Won by the Bhangis.
1776	Jassa Singh Ramgarhia is driven out of the Punjab by the Kanhaiya and Ahluwalia misls, and the other nine do not intervene. Won by the Kanhaiyas — and the assembly's authority is shown not to exist.
1779	Timur Shah recovers Multan — a Bhangi problem that nobody else marched for. Won by the Afghans.
1782	Achal, near Batala. Mahan Singh Sukerchakia and Jassa Singh Ramgarhia break the Kanhaiya misl; Gurbaksh Singh Kanhaiya is killed — and his widow Sada Kaur offers her daughter to the killer's son. Won by the Sukerchakias — and by Sada Kaur.
1783	Delhi. Baghel Singh and the two Jassa Singhs occupy the Red Fort, negotiate a revenue share, build seven gurdwaras including Sis Ganj and Rakab Ganj , and go home. Jassa Singh Ramgarhia carries a stone slab back to Amritsar. Won by the Sikhs — who wanted the sites.
1783–1786	The hills. Jai Singh Kanhaiya takes Kangra fort; Sansar Chand Katoch allies with the Sukerchakias and recovers it. Mahan Singh sacks Jammu.
1785–1794	Mahadji Scindia dominates Delhi with de Boigne's European-officered brigades. Clashes and repeated agreements with the Cis-Sutlej chiefs — none of which bind anybody, because there is no Sikh government to sign.
1795, 1797, 1798–99	Zaman Shah invades three times and takes Lahore twice. The misls disperse and wait; his brother rebels and Persia threatens his frontier, and he goes home. Won by events in Afghanistan.
Jan 1799	Zaman Shah's guns are lost in the Jhelum. Ranjit Singh recovers and returns them, and is said to have received the governorship of Lahore in exchange.
1798–1802	George Thomas , an Irish deserter, rules Haryana from Hansi with his own guns and his own coin, fights the Cis-Sutlej Sikhs, and proposes to conquer the Punjab for Britain. Destroyed by French-officered Maratha brigades.

4 May 1799

Seringapatam falls and Tipu Sultan is killed. The Company's last southern rival is gone.

7 July 1799

Ranjit Singh enters Lahore — invited by the city's own notables, with Sada Kaur's Kanhaiya army behind him, aged eighteen. **Won by Ranjit Singh.** *Part Thirteen begins here.*

Five patterns to carry into Part Thirteen

1. **A confederacy without an enemy dissolves.** The Sarbat Khalsa bound twelve equal chiefs for nineteen years and stopped binding anybody within a decade of the last Afghan invasion. **Part Eleven credited the misls with solving the oldest failure in this book; Part Twelve has to withdraw half of that.** The problem was suspended, not solved — and what solved it in the end was a king.
2. **The invitation pattern is broken, once.** Ambhi invited Alexander; Daulat Khan invited Babur; both lost everything. **In 1799 the notables of Lahore invited a man born forty miles away, and it produced the only independent Punjabi state in eight hundred and ninety-five years.** The lesson is not about invitations. It is about whether the person you invite has somewhere else to go home to.
3. **The military commodity has changed and the Punjab has noticed late.** De Boigne's brigades, Perron's army and George Thomas's four battalions all demonstrated the same thing: drilled infantry with disciplined artillery beats any quantity of irregular cavalry. **Part Thirteen is the story of one ruler doing something about it, and Part Fourteen is what happens when it is nearly enough.**
4. **The women in this part are decisive and are usually a footnote.** Sada Kaur made the alliance that created the Sikh empire, brought the army that took Lahore, and was dispossessed by the man she made. Begum Samru mediated between the Sikhs and the emperor of India. **Watch for what happens to both of them, and to Jind Kaur in Part Fourteen.**
5. **And the last independent power in India is now the Punjab.** Mysore fell in May 1799; the Marathas fall in 1803 and 1818. **After that there is one thing left on the map, and everything in the final four parts of this book is about the fifty years it takes to remove it.**

COMING NEXT — PART THIRTEEN

Ranjit Singh, 1799–1839. Forty years, and the best of them in this whole book. Amritsar taken from the Bhangis in 1805 and the misls absorbed one by one; the **Treaty of Amritsar in 1809**, which fixes the Sutlej as the border with the British and holds for thirty years; **Kangra in 1809, Attock in 1813, Multan in 1818** — the door of Part Five's book finally shut from the Indian side — **Kashmir in 1819**, and **Peshawar**, which no Indian power had held since the Shahis lost it in 870. The Fauj-i-Khas drilled by Napoleon's veterans; Hari Singh Nalwa on the frontier; the Khalsa army that becomes the only force in Asia the Company privately admits it is not sure it can beat. And at the end, **Jamrud in 1837**, and a court that knows exactly what is coming when the Maharaja dies.

Words Used in This Part

Misl

One of the twelve autonomous divisions of the Dal Khalsa, each with its own chief, army, territory and revenue. The word means, roughly, an equal or a like.

Sardar

A chief. The head of a misl, in principle chosen by his followers and in practice hereditary within a generation.

Bunga

A tower and residence built by a misl beside the tank at Amritsar, so that its chief had a house there for the assemblies. Dozens stood around the water; the Ramgarhia Bunga survives.

Rakhi

“Protection” — the share of the harvest paid by a village to a misl. By the 1770s it had become ordinary land revenue.

Sarbat Khalsa

The general assembly at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali. Binding while the Afghans were coming; a meeting afterwards.

Gurmata

A binding resolution of the assembly. The last great one is the Delhi expedition of 1783.

Cis-Sutlej states

The Sikh territories south and east of the Sutlej — Patiala, Nabha, Jind and the rest — divided after Sirhind in 1764, courted by the Marathas and later placed under British protection.

Phulkian

The house from which the Cis-Sutlej states of Patiala, Nabha and Jind descend.

Diwan-i-Am

The hall of public audience at the Red Fort in Delhi, occupied by the Sikh chiefs in March 1783.

Begum Samru

Farzana, ruler of Sardhana — a woman who rose from a dancing girl to command a state with its own European-officered army, and who mediated between the Sikhs and Shah Alam II in 1783.

Subsidiary alliance

The Company’s principal instrument of expansion: a ruler accepts British troops, pays for them, and surrenders his foreign policy. Conquest by treaty.

Brigade (European-officered)

Regular infantry drilled in European fashion with disciplined artillery, raised for Indian rulers by foreign officers — de Boigne for Scindia, Perron after him. The decisive military development of this period.

Fauj-i-Khas

“The special army” — the regular corps Ranjit Singh built with European officers after 1822. It belongs to Part Thirteen and begins as an answer to the brigades in this one.

Sources used for this part

- **George Forster**, *A Journey from Bengal to England* — an eyewitness account of the Punjab in 1783 by a Company servant travelling in disguise, and the first substantial English description of the Sikhs
- **Major James Browne**, *India Tracts* (1788), containing the history of the Sikhs compiled for Warren Hastings
- **Antoine Polier**'s account of the Sikhs, written for Calcutta in the 1780s
- **William Francklin**, *Military Memoirs of Mr George Thomas* (1803) — dictated by Thomas himself
- Persian histories of the later eighteenth century, and Sikh accounts including the *Prachin Panth Prakash* tradition
- Maratha correspondence and Company records for Mahadji Scindia, de Boigne and Zaman Shah
- The coins of the Sikh mints at Lahore and Amritsar, and the bungas and the Delhi slab at Amritsar
- Hari Ram Gupta on the misl period; Ganda Singh's documentary collections; standard modern histories of the Sikh confederacy and of Ranjit Singh's rise

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the exact list of the twelve misls, which varies between authorities; the date and circumstances of Jassa Singh Ramgarhia's expulsion and return; the year Sansar Chand recovered Kangra fort; whether Zaman Shah actually conferred the governorship of Lahore on Ranjit Singh or whether the connection with the recovered guns is a later tidy-up; and the identity of the signatories to the Lahore petition of 1799, which different accounts give differently.

Two things about method.

First, **this part is harder on the misls than the previous two were.** Parts Ten and Eleven described an institution that survived what should have destroyed it. Part Twelve describes the same institution failing at the first period of peace it had ever known — a founding chief expelled with nobody objecting, two Sikh armies fighting a battle at Achal, and an Afghan king walking into Lahore twice while twelve governments watched. **That is what the evidence shows, and a history that only records a community's best decades is not a history.**

Second, **the European sources in this part were gathering intelligence.** Forster travelled in disguise; Browne wrote for Warren Hastings; Thomas was looking for a British patron and told his readers what he thought would interest them. They are valuable precisely because they were assessing the Punjab as a target, and their assessments — abundant cavalry, no infantry, poor artillery, no central government — were accurate, and were acted on in Part Fourteen.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART THIRTEEN OF SIXTEEN

Ranjit Singh

Forty years in which the Punjab is a country — with a border the British did not cross, an army that Europe took seriously, and one design flaw that destroyed all of it within a decade of the Maharaja's death.

1799 — 1839

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Forty Good Years

These are the best four decades the Punjab gets in this entire book, and the reason they end is written into how they began.

In July 1799 an eighteen-year-old with one eye rode into Lahore because the citizens had asked him to.

By 1839 he ruled from the **Sutlej to the Khyber** and from Multan to Ladakh: the Punjab, Multan, Kashmir, the Derajat, the hill states, Hazara and Peshawar. He had an army that European officers of Napoleon's campaigns had drilled and that British generals privately rated the most formidable in Asia. He had a treaty with the East India Company that fixed a border and held for thirty years without a shot. He was the only ruler in India the Company dealt with as an equal.

He was also the only thing holding it together, and he knew it.

Four things to hold on to

- **He copied the winning method deliberately.** Part Twelve watched de Boigne's brigades, Perron's army and an Irish deserter's four battalions demonstrate that drilled infantry with disciplined artillery beats any quantity of irregular cavalry. Ranjit Singh is the only Indian ruler who watched the same demonstration and rebuilt his army around it in time.
- **The state was not a Sikh state in the way people expect.** The Maharaja was Sikh; his foreign minister was Muslim, his finance minister and his best general were Hindu, his prime minister was a Dogra Rajput, and his infantry was drilled by Frenchmen and Italians. **The army recruited from everybody, including Muslims and Gurkhas and Purbias from the Ganges plain.**
- **The border with the British was the thing he never crossed.** Thirty years of scrupulous treaty observance on the Sutlej is the most underrated achievement in this part — and, read another way, the trap he walked into in 1809.
- **And there was no succession.** One ruler, no council, no assembly, no institution that could act without him. **Part Twelve described a confederacy that dissolved because it had no coercive centre. Part Thirteen describes a state that dissolved because it was nothing but one.**

THE HONESTY LABELS, AND A CHANGE IN THE EVIDENCE

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence.

LIKELY means well-attested and generally accepted.

STORY

means tradition.

For the first time in this book, most of the evidence is **CERTAIN.** The Lahore court kept records. The British Residency kept records. European officers in Sikh service wrote memoirs. Travellers — Burnes, Jacquemont, Osborne, von Hügel, Moorcroft — came and described what they saw. There are portraits, treaties, muster rolls and photographs of the men who fought in Part Fourteen.

Which creates the opposite problem to the one this book has had for twelve parts. Instead of too little, there is a great deal — and a large share of it was written by British officers assessing a potential enemy. Their descriptions of the Khalsa army are detailed, professional and, as Part Fourteen shows, largely accurate. They are also intelligence reports, and this part reads them as such.

Amritsar, 1802 — The Great Gun

LIKELY

Three years after Lahore he took the holy city, and with it the largest piece of artillery in the Punjab — a gun that had already changed hands six times.

WON BY

Ranjit Singh — without much of a fight, which was the pattern

WHEN 1802.	WHERE Amritsar — the Bhangi stronghold, and the common capital of Part Twelve.
WHO Ranjit Singh against Mai Sukhan, widow of the last effective Bhangi chief, holding the fort of Lohgarh.	THE EVIDENCE Court records, Sikh accounts — and the gun, which is still there.

What happened

1. **Amritsar was Bhangi property.** The misl that had held Lahore until 1799 still held the holy city, the fort beside it, and the great gun.
2. **Ranjit Singh came for it in 1802** with the Kanhaiya and Ahluwalia forces alongside his own — the same alliance that had taken Lahore.
3. **The resistance was brief.** Mai Sukhan held the fort for a short time and gave it up on terms.
4. **He took the *Zamzama*.** The largest gun in the Punjab, cast at Lahore in 1757, passed to him with the city.
5. **And then he did something no misl chief had ever done.** He became the patron of the Harmandir Sahib — **and over the following decades had it faced in marble and its upper storeys covered in gold plate.** The building the world now calls the Golden Temple looks the way it does because of him.

WHY AMRITSAR MATTERED MORE THAN LAHORE

Lahore was the capital, the fort, the treasury and the mint. It was where a ruler had to sit.

Amritsar was where legitimacy lived. The Sarbat Khalsa had met there since 1748. Every misl had a bunga beside the tank. The Akal Takht had been the seat of the community's collective authority since 1606. **Whoever held Lahore governed the Punjab; whoever was accepted at Amritsar governed the Khalsa.**

Ranjit Singh understood the difference completely and spent forty years working the second half of it. He endowed the shrine lavishly. He never convened the Sarbat Khalsa — but he never denied its authority either, and when it was invoked against him personally, he submitted, which is the story in War Eleven.

And he never put his own name on his coinage. From 1801 to 1839 the money of the Sikh state carried the legend Banda Singh Bahadur had used at Lohgarh in 1710, crediting everything to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. **He called the currency Nanakshahi and himself the servant of the Khalsa, and he ruled as an autocrat.** Both of those are true and he saw no contradiction in them.

WHY IT WAS EASY

- **The Bhangis were finished.** Thirty years of decline, and a misl held by a widow because there was nobody else.
- **He came with allies.** Kanhaiya and Ahluwalia troops made it look like a confederacy operation rather than a conquest.
- **And he offered terms.** Which he did every time. Almost nobody in this part is destroyed; nearly everybody is absorbed.

WHAT IT COST HIM LATER

- **Every misl now knew what he was.** Lahore could be explained as an invitation; Amritsar could not.
- **He had made the Khalsa's capital his property.** A ruler who owns the holy city has to be accepted by it, and that gave the Akalis leverage over him for the rest of his life.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Gun That Everybody Owned

The **Zamzama** is the single most travelled object in this book, and its ownership history is the history of the Punjab in miniature.

It was **cast at Lahore in 1757**, in bronze, for the wazir of Ahmad Shah Abdali. It went south with the Afghan army and was at **Panipat in 1761**. Then Abdali could not get it back over the passes and left it in the Punjab.

After that it changed hands repeatedly among the misls, which is how it acquired the name it is known by locally — **the Bhangian di Top, the Bhangis' gun** — and it was fought over so often that possessing it became a claim to seniority in itself. It was taken and retaken by chiefs, hill rajas and the Afghans across four decades.

Ranjit Singh got it in 1802 with Amritsar. He used it at **Multan in 1818**, where it breached the walls and where the barrel finally cracked. After that it was retired.

It sits outside the Lahore Museum now. **And in 1901 Rudyard Kipling opened *Kim* with a boy sitting astride it** — “the great green-bronze piece” — and called it, correctly, the fire-breathing dragon, and noted that whoever held Zamzama held the Punjab.

He was writing fiction and he had the politics exactly right. **Between 1757 and 1802 the gun passed from an Afghan wazir to the Marathas’ battlefield to a dozen Punjabi chiefs and finally to the man who unified them.** You could write the whole of Parts Eleven and Twelve as a list of the people who owned one piece of bronze.

Eating the Confederacy, 1801–1821

LIKELY

He absorbed eleven independent states in twenty years, and almost none of it was done by battle.

WON BY

Ranjit Singh — by marriage, purchase, inheritance law and, occasionally, force

WHEN

1801–1821, effectively complete by about 1820.

WHERE

The whole Punjab north and west of the Sutlej.

WHO

Ranjit Singh against the misls of Part Twelve — Bhangi, Nakai, Dallewalia, Faizullapuria, Ramgarhia, Kanhaiya, Ahluwalia and the rest.

THE EVIDENCE

Court records; the process is documented in detail.

The method

1. **He waited for chiefs to die.** When a sardar died without a competent heir, the Lahore government took the territory and gave the family a pension or a jagir. **This was the single most productive technique**, and it required nothing but patience.
2. **He married into them.** The Nakai misl came to him through marriage. The Kanhaiya connection was made for him as a child by Sada Kaur.
3. **He bought them.** Chiefs were offered jagirs, commands and rank in the new army in exchange for their independence, and a great many took the offer.
4. **He used the last one first.** Force was applied where the other three had failed — and it is remarkable how rarely it was needed.
5. **And the chiefs became his officers.** The men who had been heads of sovereign states in 1799 were, by 1820, generals, governors and courtiers of the Lahore durbar.

SADA KAUR

The story that has to be told here is the one that reflects worst on him.

Sada Kaur made Ranjit Singh. Part Twelve set it out: after her husband was killed at Achal in 1782 by his father, she offered her daughter in marriage to the killer's son, held the Kanhaiya misl together through his minority, and brought her army to Lahore in July 1799. For the first two decades of his rise she was his principal ally, his mother-in-law, and by several accounts the shrewdest political head in the Punjab.

In 1821 he took her territories. The dispute was over the inheritance of her Kanhaiya lands, and the substance of it is that they were valuable and she was in the way. **She was placed in confinement and died in it, around 1832.**

There is no version of this that is creditable, and the sources sympathetic to him do not really try. **It is the clearest single instance of what the absorption of the misls actually involved** — and of the fact that a state built on one man's judgement has no mechanism to tell him when he is being unjust.

His daughter-in-law's mother is not the only case. The Ahluwalia chief, his ally for twenty-five years, eventually fled across the Sutlej into British territory. The Ramgarhia lands went the same way as everybody else's.

WHY IT WORKED

- **He offered a soft landing.** A chief who gave up sovereignty got rank, revenue and a place at court. Very few had the strength to refuse and most had no wish to die for a principle.
- **The confederacy had already failed.** Part Twelve described the assembly ceasing to bind anybody by the 1790s. There was no body that could have coordinated resistance.
- **He was demonstrably better at the job.** One government, one army, one currency and a frontier that was actually defended — after fifty years of twelve.
- **And he never made it religious.** Absorbing a Sikh misl was presented as consolidating the Khalsa, not as conquering it.

WHAT WAS LOST

- **The Sarbat Khalsa.** He did not abolish it. He simply never called it, and an institution that is not convened ceases to exist.
- **Distributed command.** Twelve chiefs who could each act became one court where nobody could act without him.
- **The principle of no king,** held from 1699 and asserted in the Red Fort in 1783.
- **And the men who might have held it together after him** were, by 1839, courtiers rather than sovereigns.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Trade

It is worth stating plainly what the Punjab exchanged between 1799 and 1820, because both halves are real and the book has spent two parts setting them up.

What it gave up. Twelve autonomous states, each governed by a chief chosen in principle by his followers, in a system where nobody was anybody's subject and the highest authority was an assembly that met twice a year and bound everyone by resolution. The most unusual political arrangement in these sixteen parts, and the direct descendant of what was built at Anandpur in 1699.

What it got. A frontier that was defended. A currency. Roads that were policed. Multan, Kashmir, Peshawar and the hill states brought under one administration. Forty years without an invasion — **the first such stretch in this book since the Kushans in Part Three.** And an army that made the British think very hard for thirty years.

Part Twelve ended by saying that the misl confederacy failed because it had no coercive centre, and that what solved the problem in the end was a king.

This is the king, and this is the bill.

The honest verdict is that both systems worked and both failed, and they failed at opposite ends of the same problem. **The confederacy could not compel anybody and dissolved when the pressure came off. The monarchy could compel everybody and dissolved when one man stopped breathing.**

Nothing in the Punjab between 1699 and 1849 ever managed to be both durable and free, and Part Fourteen is what it cost.

The Sutlej Line, 1806–1809

CERTAIN

A twenty-three-year-old British diplomat came to Lahore, was attacked by religious warriors at Amritsar, and went home with a treaty that fixed the Punjab’s eastern border for thirty-six years.

WON BY

The East India Company — and Ranjit Singh knew it and signed anyway

WHEN

Missions and expeditions **1806–1808**; the **Treaty of Amritsar, 25 April 1809**.

WHERE

The **Sutlej**, and the Cis-Sutlej states beyond it.

WHO

Charles Metcalfe for the Company, against Ranjit Singh’s ambition to take the Malwa.

THE EVIDENCE

The treaty text, Company records, and Metcalfe’s own correspondence.

CERTAIN

What happened

1. **He wanted the Cis-Sutlej states.** Patiala, Nabha, Jind and the rest — Sikh territories east of the Sutlej, created by the division of Sirhind in 1764. He made three expeditions across the river between 1806 and 1808 and took tribute.
2. **The Cis-Sutlej chiefs appealed to the British.** Exactly as Part Twelve predicted they would: small states with a large neighbour, making individual arrangements with a stronger outside power.
3. **The Company sent Charles Metcalfe**, aged twenty-three, with an escort of sepoys, to negotiate.
4. **And at Amritsar in February 1809 something happened that changed the Punjab.** During Muharram, Metcalfe’s escort — Muslim sepoys of the Bengal army — was attacked by **Akalis**. The sepoys formed up, held their ground and drove them off with heavy losses. **About a hundred disciplined infantry beat several times their number of the most formidable irregular warriors in India.**
5. **Ranjit Singh saw the result** and drew the conclusion.
6. **The treaty was signed on 25 April 1809.** He accepted the Sutlej as his eastern boundary and gave up all claim beyond it; the Cis-Sutlej states passed under British protection.

TWO WAYS TO READ 1809

The first reading is that he lost. He had wanted a Punjab united from the Jumna to the Indus, and the treaty closed off half of it permanently. Patiala, Nabha and Jind were Sikh states, ruled by Sikh chiefs, and they went under British protection because they preferred a distant patron to a near one. He signed because the alternative was a war with the Company in 1809, which he was not going to win.

The second reading is that he bought thirty years. The treaty removed the one thing that could have destroyed him early — a British war — and left him free to spend the next three decades taking Multan, Kashmir, the Derajat and Peshawar, and building an army. **He turned east and was blocked; so he turned west, where nobody could block him, and doubled his kingdom.**

Both readings are correct and this book will not choose between them. **What is not in doubt is that he observed the treaty scrupulously for the rest of his life,** in circumstances where he was repeatedly provoked, and that the Sutlej frontier was quiet from 1809 until six years after he died.

And the third thing that came out of 1809 is in the next section: **he started building infantry.**

WHY THE COMPANY GOT WHAT IT WANTED

- **Timing.** They came in 1809, when he had held Lahore for ten years and had no regular infantry at all.
- **The Cis-Sutlej chiefs invited them.** Twelve equal governments, individually negotiable — Part Twelve's diagnosis, delivered on schedule.
- **They offered him something real.** Recognition, a fixed border, and no interference west of the river. For a ruler with enemies on three sides that was worth having.
- **And they were prepared to fight.** Troops were moved up to Ludhiana while the talks went on, which was the point of moving them.

WHAT RANJIT SINGH CONCEDED

- **Half the Sikh population.** The Cis-Sutlej states were never his, and in 1846 they were the base from which the British fought him.
- **A permanent frontier with a growing power.** Every year after 1809, the Company got relatively stronger.
- **A garrison at Ludhiana,** forty miles from his border, watching him for thirty years and reporting everything.
- **And the initiative.** After 1809 the eastern question was closed and could only be reopened by the other side, which is exactly what happened in 1845.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

A Hundred Sepoys in a Square

The incident at Amritsar in February 1809 lasted perhaps an hour and is the most consequential hour in this part.

Metcalf's escort was about a hundred sepoy of the Bengal Native Infantry — Muslims, observing Muharram, in the Sikh holy city, at a moment of considerable tension. **Akalis** — the Nihangs, the irregular religious warriors who were the most feared fighting men in the Punjab and answered to nobody — attacked them.

The sepoys did what they had been drilled to do. They formed up, they held, they fired by volley, and they drove off an enemy several times their number.

Ranjit Singh was told about it in detail, and he understood immediately what he had just been shown.

His own army at that moment was what every Punjabi army in this book had been since Part Ten: superb light cavalry, in very large numbers, with almost no infantry and poor artillery. It had beaten Ahmad Shah Abdali by refusing to fight him. **Against a hundred men who would stand in a square and shoot in volleys, the finest horsemen in Asia had just been beaten by the arithmetic.**

Part Twelve laid out the same lesson three times — de Boigne's brigades, Perron's army, George Thomas's four battalions and his own foundry. Everybody in northern India had the opportunity to learn it.

One man acted on it. Within a few years he was raising regular battalions; by 1822 he had Napoleonic officers drilling them; by 1839 he had roughly thirty thousand regular infantry and the best artillery in India outside the Company's.

And in Part Fourteen, at Ferozeshah and Chillianwala, British officers who had seen every army in Asia wrote home to say they had never been so nearly beaten.

It started with a hundred sepoys in a square, in a city where they should not have been, on a day when they were attacked for being there.

Kangra, 1809 — Stopping the Gurkhas

LIKELY

He relieved a siege, saved the hill raja who had asked for help, and kept the fortress. It is the template for everything he did in the hills.

WON BY

Ranjit Singh — and the man he rescued lost his fort

WHEN August 1809, four months after the Treaty of Amritsar.	WHERE Kangra fort, in the hills above the Beas.
WHO Ranjit Singh against Amar Singh Thapa's Gurkhas, on behalf of Sansar Chand Katoch.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh, hill-state and Gurkha accounts; the outcome is not disputed.

What happened

- The Gurkhas were expanding west.** The kingdom of Nepal had been pushing along the Himalaya for a generation, and by 1806 Amar Singh Thapa's forces were in the Kangra hills.
- Sansar Chand Katoch was beaten and besieged.** The ablest of the hill rajas — the man who had outmanoeuvred the Kanhaiyas in Part Twelve — was shut up in Kangra fort for something like four years while his country was occupied.
- He asked Lahore for help** and Ranjit Singh named his price: **the fort.**
- The relief campaign worked.** In August 1809 the Gurkhas were driven back east of the Sutlej and Kangra was relieved.
- And Ranjit Singh garrisoned the fort himself.** Sansar Chand got his country back, without his fortress, as a tributary.
- Gurkha expansion west of the Sutlej stopped permanently.** Five years later the British fought them for the same reason, and the war of 1814–16 fixed Nepal's western border where Ranjit Singh had already fixed it.

KANGRA, FOR THE THIRD TIME IN THIS BOOK

This fortress has now appeared in three widely separated parts, and always for the same reason.

Part Five, 1009: Mahmud of Ghazni marched straight from his victory at Waihind into the Kangra hills and emptied the temple treasury at Nagarkot — the richest single haul of his career, because generations of families across northern India had deposited their valuables in the safest place they knew.

Part Twelve, 1783: Jai Singh Kanhaiya took the fort, and Sansar Chand got it back by allying with the Sukerchakias against him.

Part Thirteen, 1809: Ranjit Singh takes it as the price of a rescue.

The reason is the same in every century. **Kangra sits at the mouth of the hill country above the Punjab plain — defensible, rich, and controlling the approach to a dozen small states behind it.** Whoever holds it holds the hills, and whoever holds the hills has a secure northern flank.

After 1809 it is Sikh, and it stays Sikh until 1846, when it goes to the British with everything else north of the Sutlej.

WHY IT WORKED

- **Somebody asked him.** Same as Lahore in 1799 — an invitation converts an annexation into a rescue.
- **He named the price in advance.** No pretence, no later dispute: the fort was the fee.
- **The Gurkhas were at the end of a very long line.** Nepal to Kangra is an enormous distance along a mountain chain.
- **And the hill states could not combine.** Twelve parts of this book and the rule has not once been broken.

WHY THE HILL STATES ENDED

- **They had been playing outsiders against each other for six centuries** — Mughals against Gurus, misl against misl — and the technique requires two comparable outsiders. After 1809 there was only one.
- **Sansar Chand paid the standard price of being rescued.** His fort in 1809, his independence over the following decade.
- **Their military value had gone.** Hill forts are formidable against cavalry and negotiable against siege artillery, and Lahore now had siege artillery.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Price of Being Rescued

Sansar Chand Katoch is one of the more interesting losers in this book and his career is a complete education in what happens to a small state between large ones.

He inherited Kangra as a boy with his ancestral fort in somebody else's hands. He got it back in the 1780s by **allying with the Sukerchakias against the Kanhaiyas** — playing two Sikh misls against each other, and winning. For twenty years afterwards he was the strongest ruler in the hills, patronised the finest school of miniature painting in India, and dominated his neighbours.

Then he overreached against the Gurkhas, was beaten, and spent four years besieged in the fort he had spent his life recovering.

So he did what had worked before: he called in a bigger neighbour. **And this time the bigger neighbour did not go home.**

He lived until 1823, a tributary of Lahore, with his country intact, his court intact, his painters still working — and his fortress garrisoned by somebody else's troops.

The technique that had saved him in 1785 destroyed him in 1809, and nothing about the technique had changed. What had changed is that the Punjab now had one government instead of twelve, so there was no second power to balance the first.

Every small state on the edge of this book learns the same lesson eventually. **Playing your neighbours off against each other is a strategy that works exactly as long as you have more than one neighbour.**

Attock, 1813 — The First Afghan Defeat

LIKELY

Eight hundred years of Afghan armies coming down that road, and this is the first time one of them was beaten in a pitched battle on the Indus.

WON BY

Diwan Mokham Chand — commanding for Lahore

WHEN 13 July 1813.	WHERE Haidru, near Attock on the Indus — the crossing Timur bridged in 1398 and Akbar fortified in the 1580s.
WHO Diwan Mokham Chand for Ranjit Singh, against Fateh Khan Barakzai and Dost Muhammad Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and Afghan accounts; the result is not disputed by either.

How it came about

1. **Ranjit Singh and the Afghan wazir agreed to take Kashmir together** in 1812–13, and to split it. It was a bad idea and both of them knew it.
2. **Fateh Khan double-crossed him**, took Kashmir and kept it.
3. **So Ranjit Singh took Attock instead** — the fort commanding the Indus crossing — by inducing its Afghan governor to hand it over.
4. **Fateh Khan came back to recover it** with an army, his brother Dost Muhammad Khan commanding the cavalry.
5. **They met at Haidru on 13 July 1813.** The Afghan attack came in hard and the Sikh line bent; Mokham Chand held his reserve and committed it at the right moment; the Afghans broke.
6. **Ranjit Singh was not present.** He had left the field command to his general and stayed back — a habit that separates him from almost every commander in this book.

WHY THIS BATTLE MATTERS MORE THAN ITS SIZE

Count what had happened on this frontier before it.

Part Five, 1001: Jayapala destroyed at Peshawar. **1008:** Anandapala's confederacy dissolved at Waihind. **1014:** Nandana stormed. **Part Six, 1191–1192:** Tarain. **Part Seven, 1398:** Timur crossing the Indus unopposed. **Part Ten and Eleven:** nine Afghan invasions in twenty years, in which the Punjab's answer was always to disperse and never to fight.

In eight hundred years, no army raised in the Punjab had beaten an army from beyond the passes in a pitched battle. The method had always been avoidance, and Part Eleven made the case that avoidance was correct.

At Haidru in July 1813 a Punjabi army stood in the open against an Afghan army and won.

It is not a large battle by the standards of this book. **What it demonstrates is that the arithmetic on this frontier had changed for the first time since the Shahis** — and it changed because of infantry, artillery and a commander who kept a reserve, which is exactly what the Punjab had lacked since 870.

Everything after this — Multan, Kashmir, Nowshera, Peshawar, Jamrud — follows from the discovery that they could now do this.

WHY THE SIKHS WON

- **Artillery.** Mokham Chand had guns, served properly, and the Afghans did not have an answer to them.
- **A reserve, held and committed late.** The move that has won battles in every part of this book since Tarain in 1192.
- **The commander was not the king.** Ranjit Singh's absence meant the army did not have its single point of failure on the field — and this book has counted seven armies destroyed by that mistake.
- **And they held the fort.** Attock in Sikh hands meant the Afghans had to attack, on ground of the defender's choosing.

WHY THE AFGHANS LOST

- **They attacked to recover a position rather than to fight a battle.** Which meant fighting when and where the other side preferred.
- **Their strength was cavalry.** Against guns and steady infantry, in open ground, that had stopped being enough — the lesson of the whole period.
- **The Barakzai brothers had a kingdom coming apart behind them.** Afghan politics after 1810 was a permanent succession crisis.
- **And they had underestimated him.** Everybody did, until about 1818.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Diamond

The same summer that Attock was won, Ranjit Singh acquired the most famous object in this book.

Shah Shuja Durrani — grandson of Ahmad Shah Abdali, the king who had been deposed in Kabul — turned up as a refugee in the Punjab in 1813 with his family and very little else. His wife, **Wafa Begum**, had already been at Lahore, and in exchange for the rescue of her husband she had promised Ranjit Singh the family's greatest possession.

It was the **Koh-i-Noor**.

The diamond's route to that room is the route of this whole book. It came out of the Deccan; it was in Mughal hands by the seventeenth century and set in the Peacock Throne; **Nadir Shah took it from Delhi in 1739** in Part Ten; it passed to Ahmad Shah Abdali in 1747 and down the Durrani line to Shuja.

Shuja did not want to give it up and there was a good deal of pressure applied before he did, in June 1813. The story that has attached itself to the handover has Ranjit Singh asking him what the stone was worth, and Shuja replying that its value is **good fortune, since whoever has held it has been superior to his enemies**. Treat the quotation as **STORY**; the extortion is documented.

Ranjit Singh wore it on his arm for the rest of his life. Visitors describe it. **Shah Shuja escaped to British territory, and twenty-six years later the Tripartite Treaty of 1838 put him back on the throne of Kabul with British and Sikh help** — where he was murdered in 1842.

And in 1849, in Part Fourteen, the diamond was taken from the Lahore treasury as part of the terms of annexation, and sent to London.

It has been in the possession of a Punjabi ruler for exactly thirty-six years out of the last five hundred, and those thirty-six are in this part.

Multan, 1818

LIKELY

The oldest door in this book was shut, from the Indian side, for the first time in eleven hundred years — and the man who lost it deserves better than he usually gets.

WON BY

Misr Diwan Chand — after a siege of several months

WHEN Besieged from the spring of 1818; the fort stormed on 2 June 1818.	WHERE Multan.
WHO Misr Diwan Chand commanding, with Kharak Singh nominally in charge, against Nawab Muzaffar Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and Persian accounts, which agree on the length and the defence.

What happened

1. **Multan had been attacked from Lahore repeatedly** since 1802 and had always bought its way out with tribute. In 1818 Ranjit Singh sent an army to finish it.
2. **Muzaffar Khan refused terms** and shut himself in the fort with his sons and his garrison.
3. **The siege lasted months.** The walls were massive and the defence was competent.
4. **The Zamzama broke the wall.** The great gun of War One was brought down from Lahore and used against the fortifications — and cracked doing it. **It never fired again.**
5. **The assault went in on 2 June 1818.** Akali Sadhu Singh led a storming party through the breach.
6. **Muzaffar Khan and several of his sons were killed fighting in the breach.** The accounts on the Sikh side describe his defence with respect, which is not always the case in this book.

THE DOOR, CLOSED

Multan has appeared in seven parts of this book and Part Twelve listed its changes of hands. Here is what 1818 actually means.

From 712 to 1818 — one thousand one hundred and six years — Multan was, with brief interruptions, held by powers coming from the west. Arabs, Ismailis, Ghaznavids, Ghurids, Timurids, the Langahs, the Arghuns of Sindh, the Mughals, the Afghans. The Bhangi misl held it for seven years in the 1770s and lost it again.

In June 1818 it passed to a government at Lahore, and it never went back.

Combined with Attock in 1813 and Kashmir the following year, it meant that for the first time since the Hindu Shahis, the whole of the Indus frontier — north, centre and south — was held by a power based in the Punjab.

That is what this part is for. Parts Five to Eleven are a single long story about a province that could not hold its own doors. Between 1813 and 1834, all of them are shut.

WHY THE FORT FELL

- **Siege artillery.** Multan's walls had defeated everybody for a thousand years and were built for a world before heavy guns were common.
- **Patience.** Months rather than a rush, which is the answer to every fortress in this book.
- **No relief was possible.** The Afghan kingdom was in a succession war and could not send an army.
- **And Lahore could afford it.** A siege is an accounting exercise, and one government with a revenue can sustain what twelve chiefs could not.

WHY MUZAFFAR KHAN IS WORTH NAMING

- **He held out for years before this.** Repeated attacks since 1802, paid off, negotiated, survived.
- **He refused terms at the end** when accepting them would have saved his life and his family.
- **He died in the breach with his sons.** The Sikh accounts say so without qualification.
- **And he is the last independent ruler of Multan in this book,** in a city that had been a country twice.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Last Shot of the Zamzama

There is a neatness to the fall of Multan that is worth pausing on, and it belongs to a gun.

The **Zamzama** was cast at Lahore in 1757 for the wazir of Ahmad Shah Abdali, went to Panipat in 1761 with the Afghan army that destroyed the Marathas, and was left behind in the Punjab because the Afghans could not get it home. It was fought over by the misls for forty years, and its possession became a claim to seniority among them. Ranjit Singh took it with Amritsar in 1802. In 1818 it was hauled two hundred and fifty miles south and turned on the walls of Multan — the last major Afghan possession east of the Indus. It breached the wall, and in doing so it cracked, and it never fired again.

A gun made for an Afghan king's minister, used to close the door that Afghan armies had been coming through for eleven hundred years, and destroyed by the effort. It is the kind of detail that would be too tidy in fiction. It is also true, and the gun is still there, cracked, on a traffic island in Lahore, with a boy sitting on it in the first paragraph of a famous novel.

Kashmir, 1819

LIKELY

The valley that Mahmud of Ghazni failed to take twice, and that had beaten every army sent at it for eight hundred years, was taken at the second attempt.

WON BY Misr Diwan Chand — again

WHEN A failed attempt in 1814; the conquest in July 1819.	WHERE The Kashmir valley; the decisive action at Shopian.
WHO Misr Diwan Chand and Kharak Singh, against the Afghan governor Jabbar Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh, Kashmiri and Afghan accounts; and European travellers who arrived shortly afterwards.

What happened

- The first attempt in 1814 failed badly.** Ranjit Singh went himself; the columns were divided; the rains came; disease and the passes did the rest. It was his worst military failure.
- He waited five years and did it properly.** A single strong column, a competent commander, and a start early enough in the season.
- The Afghan governor met them at Shopian** in July 1819 and was beaten.
- The valley was annexed.** It had been under Afghan rule since 1752 and Mughal rule before that.
- And it was not governed well.** This needs saying: Sikh administration in Kashmir was extractive, several of its governors were harsh, and the valley’s own accounts of the period are not favourable. **Some of the governors were good and some were not, and the record is mixed at best.**
- In 1846 it was sold.** The British, having beaten the Sikhs in Part Fourteen, transferred Kashmir to **Gulab Singh Dogra** — Ranjit Singh’s own vassal — for a cash payment, creating the state whose disputed status has outlived everything else in this book.

THE VALLEY THAT NOBODY COULD TAKE

Part Five made a point about Kashmir that is worth cashing in here. **Mahmud of Ghazni attacked the fortress of Lohkot twice, in 1015 and 1021, and failed both times.** He took Multan, Nagarkot, Nandana, Thanesar, Mathura, Kanauj and Somnath. Kashmir is the only place within his reach that he attacked and did not get.

The reason is the same reason Ranjit Singh's first attempt failed in 1814. **A valley behind mountains, reachable through a handful of passes, in a climate that ruins an army from the plains, at the end of a supply line that runs over the passes.**

What made 1819 different was not courage. It was **logistics and timing** — one column instead of three, moving early enough in the season, with the supply arrangements made in advance by a government that had a revenue department.

That is the whole difference between this part and the eleven before it. **Punjab in 1819 had a state, and a state can plan a campaign in a way that a confederacy cannot.**

WHY IT WORKED THE SECOND TIME

- **He learned from 1814.** Divided columns and a late start had failed; a single column starting early succeeded.
- **Delegated command.** He did not go himself the second time, which is a startling thing for a ruler of that period to do about a prize of that size.
- **The Afghans were weaker.** Kabul was in a succession crisis and the governor could not be reinforced.
- **And Attock and Multan had already been taken.** The approaches were secure before the campaign started.

WHAT IT COST

- **A province that was hard to hold and expensive to garrison.**
- **A reputation for extraction.** The Kashmiri record of Sikh rule is not a happy one, and this book is not going to pretend otherwise.
- **And it created the Dogra connection.** Gulab Singh's rise begins with Kashmir and ends with him buying it from the British over the ruins of the state that had employed him.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Bought and Sold

Twenty-seven years after Misr Diwan Chand took Kashmir for Lahore, it was sold.

In March 1846, in the settlement that followed the First Anglo-Sikh War, the British transferred the valley and the surrounding hill territory to **Gulab Singh**, Raja of Jammu, for a payment of seventy-five lakhs of rupees. He had been a soldier of Ranjit Singh's — a Dogra Rajput who rose in Sikh service, was made Raja of Jammu, and whose family became the most powerful faction at the Lahore court after the Maharaja's death.

His conduct during the war that produced the sale is one of the ugliest questions in Part Fourteen, and this book will deal with it there rather than here.

What belongs here is the shape of the transaction. **A province conquered by a Punjabi army in 1819 was transferred by a British government in 1846 to a servant of the state that had conquered it, for money, as part of the price of that state's defeat.**

The Dogra dynasty ruled Jammu and Kashmir from 1846 until 1947. What happened in October 1947, and every year since, descends directly from that transfer.

Of everything in these sixteen parts, this is the one whose consequences are still being paid. Taxila is a ruin, Sirhind is a mound, the Zamzama is on a traffic island — and the sale of Kashmir in 1846 is on the front page.

The Fauj-i-Khas — Napoleon’s Officers at Lahore, 1822–1839

CERTAIN

Not a battle. The army that came out of this is the reason Part Fourteen takes the British two wars and nine battles instead of one afternoon.

WHAT HAPPENED

The Punjab acquired the only Indian army the Company was genuinely unsure about

WHEN Regular battalions from about 1810; the European officers arrive in 1822.	WHERE Lahore — the cantonments, the arsenal and the gun foundry.
WHO Jean-Baptiste Ventura and Jean-François Allard, then Claude Auguste Court and Paolo Avitabile.	THE EVIDENCE Muster rolls, the officers’ own memoirs, and detailed British intelligence reports.

Who they were

1. **They were unemployed Napoleonic officers.** After Waterloo, Europe was full of professional soldiers with nothing to do. **Ventura** was Italian, **Allard** French, and both had served in the Grande Armée. They arrived at Lahore in 1822 by way of Persia and Afghanistan, looking for work.
2. **Ranjit Singh tested them for months** before employing them, and then set conditions: they were to grow beards, not eat beef, not smoke, and to serve the Punjab rather than any European power.
3. **Allard took the cavalry; Ventura took the infantry.** Together they raised the **Fauj-i-Khas** — the special army — a model corps with its own standards, drilled to French words of command.
4. **Court and Avitabile came in 1827.** Court, a French artilleryman, took the guns and the foundry; **Avitabile**, a Neapolitan, became a governor — of Wazirabad and later of Peshawar, where his methods restored order by means that made him notorious on both sides of the frontier.
5. **Others followed** — including an American and the adventurer Alexander Gardner, whose own account of himself is entertaining and unreliable.

What they built

1. **Regular infantry.** By the end of the reign, something in the region of **thirty thousand** drilled infantry in permanent battalions — a completely new thing in the Punjab.
2. **Artillery, and the means to make it.** A gun foundry at Lahore casting its own pieces, arsenals, and trained crews. **The Sikh artillery of 1845 was, by British admission, as good as anything they had.**
3. **Regular cavalry** alongside the old *Ghorchurra* horse, which was kept because it was still the best light cavalry in Asia.
4. **Pay, in cash, on time.** The single most boring item on this list and the one that made the rest possible.
5. **And it recruited from everybody.** Sikhs, Punjabi Muslims, Hindus, Gurkhas, and Purbias from the Ganges plain — including men who had served the Company.

INTERROGATING THE NUMBERS

Figures for the Khalsa army at Ranjit Singh's death vary considerably and should be handled with the usual caution.

The regular establishment is generally given as somewhere around **thirty thousand infantry**, several thousand regular cavalry, and an artillery arm with **at least a hundred and fifty guns** — some counts go much higher depending on whether garrison and light pieces are included.

Beyond that were the irregular *Ghorchurra* cavalry, the contingents of jagirdars, and the Akalis, none of which appear on a muster roll in any usable way. Totals of seventy thousand and upwards are commonly quoted and are estimates.

What matters is not the total but the composition. In 1799 the Punjab had perhaps fifty thousand irregular horsemen and almost nothing else. In 1839 it had a regular army with infantry, artillery, engineers, a foundry and a pay department.

British officers who inspected it — and several were shown it deliberately — reported home that it was the most formidable native army in India. **Sir Henry Fane, the Commander-in-Chief, saw it in 1837 and said so.** Six years later the Company doubled its garrisons on the Sutlej.

WHY IT WORKED

- **He hired for skill and controlled for loyalty.** European professionals, on Punjabi terms, with no European government behind them.
- **He kept what was already good.** The Ghorchurra cavalry was not abolished; it was supplemented.
- **He built the industry, not just the army.** A foundry and arsenals meant he was not dependent on anyone for guns — the lesson of his grandfather's bursting matchlock in Part Twelve.
- **And he paid.** An army paid in cash on time does not have to be coerced into existing.

THE FLAW NOBODY FIXED

- **It was loyal to him, not to a state.** There was no constitution, no council of regency, no war office — only a Maharaja and an army that obeyed him.
- **It was too good for the government it served.** After 1839 the army was the strongest institution in the Punjab and the court was the weakest, and the panchayats of the regiments began making political decisions.
- **The European officers mostly left.** Allard died in 1839; Ventura, Court and Avitabile went home in the years after, taking their fortunes and their expertise with them.
- **And it was built to fight the Afghans.** It ended up fighting the British, and the difference is Part Fourteen.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Only Ruler Who Was Paying Attention

Here is what makes Ranjit Singh unusual, and it is not conquest — this book is full of conquerors.

Between about 1780 and 1820 every ruler in India was given the same demonstration, repeatedly, in public. De Boigne's brigades made Mahadji Scindia master of northern India. The Company's sepoys took Seringapatam. George Thomas built a kingdom in Haryana with four battalions and a foundry. At Assaye in 1803 and again in 1818 the Marathas — who had hired the method — were destroyed by it in British hands.

The lesson was not subtle: **drilled infantry, disciplined artillery, and regular pay beat any quantity of irregular cavalry, every time, in the open.**

Nearly every Indian ruler saw it. Almost none of them acted on it in time. The Marathas hired European officers and then let their political system waste what those officers built. The Afghans never tried. The hill states could not afford it. The misls, as Part Twelve showed, were still fighting each other with horsemen while it happened.

One man watched a hundred sepoys form square at Amritsar in 1809 and spent the next thirty years rebuilding his army around what he had seen.

It nearly worked. At Ferozeshah in December 1845 the Governor-General of India spent a night on the field expecting to lose his army, and burned his papers in case he was captured. At Chillianwala in 1849 a British force was mauled badly enough that the news caused a political crisis in London.

The Khalsa army lost both wars — and it is the only army in India that ever gave the Company a serious fright twice. It was built by a man who could not read, on the basis of an incident he did not witness, thirty years before it was needed.

Nowshera, 1823 — The Akali’s Last Charge

LIKELY

The hardest battle of the reign, fought against the tribes of the frontier — and the man who won it had once had the Maharaja publicly flogged.

WON BY **Ranjit Singh — and it cost him Akali Phula Singh**

WHEN 14 March 1823.	WHERE Nowshera, on the Kabul river west of Attock — Yusufzai country.
WHO Ranjit Singh against Azim Khan Barakzai and the assembled frontier tribes.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and Afghan accounts; both describe it as unusually hard fighting.

What happened

1. **Azim Khan raised the frontier tribes.** The Yusufzai and their neighbours — the same confederations that had destroyed Raja Birbal’s column in Part Eight and a Mughal army in Part Nine — came out in very large numbers, and the campaign was declared a holy war.
2. **The Sikh army had to cross a river to reach them,** under fire, with the tribes holding the high ground at Pir Sabak beyond it.
3. **The first attacks failed.** The position was strong and the defenders were the best hill infantry in Asia.
4. **Akali Phula Singh took the Nihangs in.** The irregular religious warriors went up the hill and broke the position, and **Phula Singh was killed doing it.**
5. **The tribes were driven off and Azim Khan withdrew across the Kabul river** without committing his own regular troops, which ruined his standing; he died shortly afterwards.
6. **Peshawar became tributary to Lahore.**

THE FRONTIER, FOR THE FOURTH TIME IN THIS BOOK

Part Eight described the destruction of a Mughal column in the Karakar Pass in 1586 and said that the same thing happens to every regular army that goes into this country. Part Nine described it happening again in 1672.

Nowshera is the exception, and it is worth being clear about why.

It was not fought in a defile. It was fought on a hill above a river crossing, in country where an army could deploy, by a force with artillery and regular infantry as well as irregular cavalry. **The tribes' advantage is the ground, and at Nowshera they gave up part of it by standing to fight a battle rather than ambushing a column.**

The rule held everywhere else. **Ranjit Singh never conquered the tribal country and never tried.** He took Peshawar, held the valley, garrisoned the mouth of the Khyber, and paid, negotiated and fought with the tribes in the hills for the rest of his life without ever attempting to occupy them.

That is the same conclusion Akbar reached in 1586, Aurangzeb reached in 1675, and the British reached in the 1890s. **Four empires, four centuries, one answer: hold the mouth of the pass and do not go up it.**

WHY THE SIKHS WON

- **Combined arms.** Artillery to prepare, regular infantry to hold, and irregular shock troops to take the hill.
- **The Akalis.** Whatever else can be said about the Nihangs, they went in when nothing else would.
- **The Maharaja was present and visible,** which mattered on a day when the first attacks had failed.
- **And Azim Khan did not commit.** His regular troops watched from the far bank, which decided the battle as much as anything the Sikhs did.

WHAT IT COST

- **Heavy casualties** — by most accounts the worst of any battle in the reign.
- **Akali Phula Singh,** who was irreplaceable in a specific way described below.
- **And it settled nothing on the frontier.** Peshawar became tributary; it took eleven more years to annex it and it was never quiet.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Had the Maharaja Flogged

Akali Phula Singh was the head of the Nihangs — the irregular religious warriors of the Khalsa, who answered to no government, kept their own encampment at Amritsar, and regarded themselves as the conscience of the community.

He had fought for Ranjit Singh in most of the campaigns of the reign. He was also, on at least one famous occasion, his judge.

The Maharaja had married a Muslim dancing girl of Amritsar named **Moran** — a match that scandalised the orthodox, and which he compounded by having coins struck that carried her name. Whatever else Ranjit Singh was, he was not discreet.

Phula Singh summoned him to the Akal Takht.

The tradition is that the Maharaja came, on foot, and was sentenced to be tied to a tree and flogged; that he accepted the sentence and presented himself for it; and that the assembled congregation, seeing him submit, remitted the punishment to a fine.

Treat the details as **STORY**. **Treat the fact that he went as very well attested and completely extraordinary.**

Consider what is being described. **The absolute ruler of the Punjab — a man who had absorbed eleven states, imprisoned his own mother-in-law and taken the Koh-i-Noor by extortion — walked to a building at Amritsar and accepted a sentence from an institution with no army, no revenue and no power to compel him whatever.**

He did it because the Akal Takht's authority, established in 1606 in Part Nine and exercised by the Sarbat Khalsa through Parts Ten to Twelve, was the only thing in the Punjab that could still say no to him — and because a ruler who denied it would have stopped being the servant of the Khalsa and become simply a king, which was the one thing his legitimacy could not survive.

Phula Singh died at Nowshera in 1823, going up a hill first.

Nobody summoned Ranjit Singh to the Akal Takht again.

Peshawar and Jamrud, 1834–1837

LIKELY

The door that this book has been complaining about since Part Four was finally shut and bolted from the Indian side — and the man who bolted it was killed doing it.

WON BY Lahore — at the cost of the best soldier the Punjab produced in this century

WHEN 1834 Peshawar annexed; 30 April 1837 the battle at Jamrud.	WHERE Peshawar, and Jamrud at the mouth of the Khyber Pass.
WHO Hari Singh Nalwa, governor of Peshawar, against Dost Muhammad Khan's sons.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh, Afghan and British accounts; the fort at Jamrud still stands.

What happened

1. Peshawar had been tributary since 1823 and was annexed outright in 1834, with Hari Singh Nalwa as governor.
2. He fortified forward. Rather than sit in Peshawar, he pushed the frontier to the mouth of the Khyber and built a fort at Jamrud in 1836, at the point where the pass opens onto the plain.
3. The Afghans came to take it back. In April 1837, while Ranjit Singh and most of the court were at Lahore for the wedding of his grandson, Dost Muhammad Khan sent an army under his sons.
4. The battle at Jamrud was fought on 30 April 1837. The garrison was small; Nalwa came out to fight; he was mortally wounded.
5. His death was concealed. The accounts say the garrison was not told, so that the fort would hold — and it held until relief came up from Peshawar.
6. The Afghans withdrew. Peshawar and the Khyber mouth stayed with Lahore until 1849, when they went to the British with everything else.

THE DOOR, AT LAST

This book has made one complaint more often than any other, and it began in Part Four.

“Nobody ever garrisons the door.” Every invasion of India for two thousand years came through the same three or four passes, and no Indian power ever put a permanent force at the mouth of them. The Mauryas did not. The Guptas did not. The Delhi Sultanate did not. Part Five described the Hindu Shahis losing Kabul in 870 and everything after being fought on Indian ground.

In 1836 a fort was built at Jamrud, at the mouth of the Khyber, by a Punjabi government, and garrisoned.

That is the complaint answered — nine hundred and sixty-six years after the Shahis lost Kabul, and about two thousand one hundred years after the first invasion in this book came down that road.

It held for thirteen years. In 1849 it passed to the British, who kept a garrison there for the next century for exactly the same reason.

Whatever else Ranjit Singh’s reign was, it is the only period in this entire history in which the Punjab held its own doors.

WHY JAMRUD HELD

- **The fort was in the right place.** The mouth of a pass is the one point where a small garrison is worth an army.
- **Nalwa came out and fought** rather than being shut up, which bought the time the relief needed.
- **The death was concealed.** A garrison that does not know its commander is dead does not lose the battle he died in — the single point of failure, defeated by an administrative decision.
- **And Peshawar was close.** A relieving force could reach it, which is what a forward fortress is for.

WHAT IT COST

- **Hari Singh Nalwa.** The best field commander in the Sikh service, on the frontier that needed him most, two years before the Maharaja died.
- **The frontier was never pacified,** only held — and holding it consumed troops for the rest of the reign.
- **And the timing was terrible.** The court was at a wedding; the army was dispersed; and it demonstrated to everybody watching that the state could be surprised.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Name They Used to Frighten Children

Hari Singh Nalwa is the only Punjabi commander in this book whose reputation crossed the frontier and stayed there.

He rose from a modest family in Gujranwala, fought in most of the campaigns of the reign, and governed Kashmir, Hazara and finally Peshawar. He built forts, founded a town, minted coin as governor, and spent the last fifteen years of his life on the most difficult frontier in Asia.

There is a tradition — repeated on both sides of the Khyber, and repeated by British officers who served there afterwards — that **Pashtun mothers used his name to quiet children**. Whether that is literally true is unverifiable and it is the sort of thing that gets said about frontier commanders; it is also recorded early enough and widely enough to be worth mentioning.

What is not tradition is the strategic fact. **He was the man who moved the Punjab's western frontier from the Indus to the mouth of the Khyber and kept it there.**

And what is worth ending on is the manner of the last day. Mortally wounded at Jamrud, with a small garrison in a new fort and an Afghan army outside it, **the decision was taken not to announce that he was dead** — so that the men holding the walls would go on believing he was behind them.

Seven armies in this book have been destroyed because a commander went down in front of his men: Porus, Anandapala, Ghor at Tarain, Qutlugh Khwaja, Hemu, Wazir Khan, the Marathas at Panipat.

At Jamrud in 1837 somebody finally thought of simply not telling them.

The Court and the State

CERTAIN

Not a battle. How a Sikh maharaja governed a province where most of his subjects were Muslim, and what he got right and wrong doing it.

WHAT IT WAS

An autocracy that was, by the standards of its century, unusually broad

WHEN 1799–1839.	WHERE Lahore — the fort, the durbar and the revenue offices.
WHO Fakir Azizuddin, Diwan Dina Nath, Dhian Singh Dogra, Misr Diwan Chand and the rest of the durbar.	THE EVIDENCE Court records, revenue papers, and a dozen European travellers who described it in detail.

Who ran what

1. **Foreign affairs:** **Fakir Azizuddin**, a Muslim from a Lahore family of physicians, who conducted every important negotiation with the British and the Afghans for thirty years.
2. **Finance:** **Diwan Dina Nath**, a Hindu, who ran the revenue system.
3. **Chief minister:** **Dhian Singh Dogra**, a Hindu Rajput from Jammu, whose family became the most dangerous force at court after 1839.
4. **Field command:** Misr Diwan Chand and Mokham Chand, both Hindus; Hari Singh Nalwa and Sham Singh Attariwala, both Sikhs; Ventura, Allard, Court and Avitabile, all Europeans.
5. **And the army recruited from everybody**, including large numbers of Punjabi Muslims and men from outside the province.

THE HONEST LEDGER

The state's record on religion is usually described in one of two ways, and both are wrong.

What is genuinely to his credit. The *jizya* was not levied. Muslims held the highest offices, including the foreign ministry, for the whole reign. Muslim shrines received state endowments, and the Sunehri Masjid at Lahore — which had been taken over — was returned to Muslim use at Fakir Azizuddin's request. Executions for religious offences did not happen. There was no forced conversion. **By the standards of any state in this book, including the ones ruled by the tolerant emperors of Part Eight, this is a good record.**

What is not. Cow slaughter was banned, which was a real restriction on Muslim practice. The call to prayer was restricted in some places at some times. **And the Badshahi Mosque at Lahore — one of the great buildings of the Mughal empire — was used as a military store and its courtyard as a stable and parade ground.** That was a deliberate humiliation of a kind that this book has described being inflicted in the other direction in Parts Nine and Eleven, and it should be recorded in the same words.

The Kashmir administration, as War Seven said, was extractive and is not remembered kindly in the valley.

The fair summary is that it was a state which did not persecute and did not entirely refrain from humiliating, in a province that had spent the previous hundred and fifty years in a religious war. That is a considerable achievement and it is not a clean one.

WHY IT HELD TOGETHER

- **Competence was the qualification.** He hired the best available person for the job and did not much care what they were.
- **The revenue was lighter than the Afghans'** and it was collected regularly, which is what a cultivator actually notices.
- **He was personally accessible.** Every European visitor remarks on it — a ruler who rode about, asked endless questions, and held *darbar* in the open.
- **And he did not execute people.** Almost uniquely in this book. Rebels were fined, dispossessed or pensioned. Sada Kaur's confinement is the harshest thing in the reign, and she was not killed.

WHY IT COULD NOT SURVIVE HIM

- **There was no institution.** No council, no assembly, no law of succession, no body that could act in his absence. Everything ran through one man's judgement.
- **He never called the Sarbat Khalsa.** The one body that might have been able to arbitrate a succession had not met in his lifetime.
- **He built factions instead of ministries.** The Dogras, the Sindhanwalias, the army — each with a patron, and all of them balanced by him personally.
- **And his heirs were not up to it.** Which he knew.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Could Not Read

Every European who met Ranjit Singh wrote about him, and the descriptions are unusually consistent.

They describe a small, scarred, one-eyed man in plain white clothes with no jewellery except an armlet holding an enormous diamond, sitting cross-legged in a chair, in a court where everybody else was dressed magnificently. **Victor Jacquemont, a French naturalist, said he was the first inquisitive Indian he had met and complained that the Maharaja asked him a hundred thousand questions** — about Europe, about Bonaparte, about medicine, about how things worked.

He could not read. His education had been abandoned during a chaotic minority and he never repaired it. Documents were read aloud to him. Treaties were read aloud to him. He signed with a seal.

And this is the man who understood the significance of a hundred sepoy forming square, hired Napoleon's officers, built a gun foundry, kept a treaty for thirty years, and worked out that the East India Company was a different kind of thing from anything else on the subcontinent long before most literate rulers did.

There is a story — **STORY**, but a good one — that when a map of India was shown to him with the British possessions coloured red, he looked at how much of it was red and said “**sab lal ho jayega**”: it will all become red.

Whether he said it or not, he behaved for forty years as though he believed it. **He never fought the British, never gave them a pretext, honoured every clause of the treaty of 1809, and spent the entire time building an army and taking everything to the west that they could not object to.**

It was the correct strategy and it required only one thing to work, which was that it had to be continued after he died.

Ropar and the Tripartite Treaty, 1831–1838

CERTAIN

The two powers left in India met on a riverbank, spent a week impressing each other, and both went away knowing exactly what they had seen.

WON BY Nobody — a thirty-year draw on the Sutlej, and it was the best deal available

WHEN October 1831 at Ropar; the Tripartite Treaty in June 1838.	WHERE Ropar, on the Sutlej — the treaty line of 1809.
WHO Ranjit Singh and the Governor-General, Lord William Bentinck.	THE EVIDENCE Both governments' records, and several eyewitness accounts.

What happened at Ropar

1. **It was a state visit, staged by both sides to be looked at.** Camps facing each other across the river, troops paraded, gifts exchanged, and a week of ceremonial.
2. **The Sikhs displayed their army.** Deliberately. The regular battalions, the artillery and the Ghorchurra cavalry were all shown to the British.
3. **The British displayed theirs.** Equally deliberately.
4. **Both sides went home reassured and worried in roughly equal proportions,** and the reports each wrote about the other are the most useful documents of the decade.
5. **Nothing was signed of any substance,** which was the point. Ropar was about measurement.

And then Afghanistan

1. **In June 1838 the Tripartite Treaty was signed** — the British, Ranjit Singh, and Shah Shuja, the exiled Durrani king who had given up the Koh-i-Noor in 1813 — to put Shuja back on the throne at Kabul.
2. **The British wanted a friendly Afghanistan** because they were frightened of Russian influence in Persia, which is the beginning of the long game the nineteenth century called the Great Game.
3. **Ranjit Singh signed and gave nothing.** He agreed in principle, kept Peshawar, and **refused to let a British army march through the Punjab.**

4. **So they went the long way round**, through Sindh and the Bolan Pass — a route that added months and enormous cost, and contributed to the disaster that followed.
5. **The Army of the Indus reached Kabul in 1839 and Shah Shuja was restored.** Two and a half years later he was murdered, and a British army was destroyed retreating through the passes in January 1842.

THE REFUSAL THAT IS EASY TO MISS

The single most revealing thing Ranjit Singh ever did about the British is that **he would not let their troops cross his country**, even as their treaty partner, even in a cause he had signed up to.

He was seventy-nine years old and in poor health. The Company was the strongest power in Asia. He had every diplomatic reason to oblige them and no realistic prospect of ever fighting them.

He said no anyway, and they went round.

He understood that a British army inside the Punjab, with a legitimate reason to be there and a line of supply through it, would be very difficult to get out again. He had watched the subsidiary alliance system swallow half the states in India by exactly this route: an ally accepts troops, then pays for them, then finds they are a garrison.

Six years after he died, British troops crossed the Sutlej. Ten years after he died, they stayed.

WHY THE PEACE HELD FOR THIRTY YEARS

- **Neither side wanted the war.** The Company had the Marathas, Burma, Sindh and Afghanistan to deal with; he had Multan, Kashmir and the frontier.
- **He was scrupulous.** Thirty years without a single serious breach of the 1809 treaty, under repeated provocation.
- **The army was a deterrent.** That is what Ropar was for, and it worked.
- **And the British respected him personally,** which mattered more in that period than it should have.

WHY IT COULD ONLY LAST HIS LIFETIME

- **The relationship was personal, not institutional.** The Company had a system; the Punjab had a man.
- **The balance was moving.** Every year the Company got relatively stronger, and both sides could see the trend.
- **Sindh went in 1843**, which put British territory on a second side of the Punjab.
- **And the Afghan disaster of 1842 made the British more nervous, not less.** A humiliated power on your border is a dangerous neighbour.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Two Camps on a River

The meeting at Ropar in October 1831 is worth picturing, because it is the only time in this book that the Punjab meets the power that will eventually take it, on equal terms, with both sides trying to impress.

On one bank of the Sutlej: the Governor-General of India, with the Company's troops in review order — scarlet, drilled, silent, moving in perfect time.

On the other: the Maharaja of the Punjab, with the Fauj-i-Khas drilled by Napoleon's officers, an artillery train cast in his own foundry, and behind them several thousand Ghorchurra horsemen in the finest silks in Asia.

Both armies were being shown off for exactly the same reason, and both sets of officers understood exactly what they were being shown.

The British reports afterwards are respectful and slightly uneasy. **They had come expecting Indian irregulars and had been shown a European-style army with good artillery, held by a ruler who was not going to give them a pretext.**

Fourteen years later, at Ferozeshah, some of the men who had watched that parade fought each other.

And this is the thing worth ending the section on. **Ropar in 1831 was the high point of the Punjab's standing in the world since the Shahis** — an independent state, dealing as an equal with the greatest power in Asia, on a border it had agreed and both sides kept.

Eight years later the Maharaja was dead, and everything in the next section is about the fact that nobody had made any arrangements at all.

June 1839 — The Succession Nobody Solved

CERTAIN

He built everything and arranged nothing, and it took ten years to lose all of it.

WON BY

Nobody — and everything in Part Fourteen is in this section

WHEN 27 June 1839.	WHERE Lahore.
WHO Ranjit Singh, aged fifty-eight, and the court he left behind.	THE EVIDENCE Court records and British Residency reports. CERTAIN

What he left

1. **A kingdom** from the Sutlej to the Khyber and from Multan to Ladakh, with a full treasury.
2. **The best native army in India**, in the region of seventy thousand men with modern artillery.
3. **An heir who was not capable of governing.** Kharak Singh, his eldest son, was widely regarded — including by his father — as unequal to it.
4. **A grandson who might have been.** Nau Nihal Singh, Kharak Singh’s son, was able and popular.
5. **Three factions.** The **Dogras** under Dhian Singh and his brothers; the **Sindhanwalias**, the Maharaja’s own collaterals; and the army.
6. **And no mechanism whatever.** No council of regency, no succession law, no assembly, no arbitrating institution. **The Sarbat Khalsa had not met in forty years.**

THE SATI

One thing must be recorded about the funeral and not passed over.

Four of his queens and several women of the household were burned on his pyre. Sati was practised at the Lahore court and it was practised here, publicly, with the whole city present, and it is described by European eyewitnesses.

The same ruler who did not execute rebels, who employed Muslims as ministers, who submitted to the Akal Takht and who returned a mosque to its congregation, had women burned alive at his funeral because it was the custom of his court.

Sikh teaching had condemned the practice from the beginning — Guru Amar Das spoke against it in the sixteenth century, in Part Eight. It happened anyway.

This book has stated facts of this kind about every other ruler in it and it is not going to make an exception for this one.

WHY THE STATE FELL APART SO FAST

- **Everything ran through him personally.** Every faction was balanced by his judgement and nothing was balanced by a rule.
- **The army was the strongest institution left.** Within a few years the regimental *panchayats* — committees of soldiers — were making political decisions, because nothing else could.
- **The factions had armies of their own.** The Dogras held Jammu; the Sindhanwalias had followings; and both had reason to prefer a weak Maharaja.
- **And the British were watching every hour of it** from Ludhiana, forty miles away, with a Resident and a network of informants.

WHAT WAS ALREADY FIXED BY JUNE 1839

- **Kharak Singh died in 1840.** Nau Nihal Singh died the same day, in an accident at his father's funeral that almost nobody has ever believed was one.
- **Five years of court murders followed,** and by 1843 the Maharaja was a five-year-old boy, **Duleep Singh**, with his mother **Jind Kaur** as regent.
- **The army lost confidence in the court** and the court became afraid of the army — an arrangement that has only ever ended one way.
- **And in December 1845 that army crossed the Sutlej.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

The One Thing He Did Not Build

Set the two halves of this book's last two hundred years against each other, because they are the same lesson from opposite ends and the Punjab paid for both.

The Khalsa of 1699 was built specifically so that it would not die with a man. Part Nine described a Guru taking initiation from five men he had just created, so that the order would outrank its leader. Part Nine ended with him vesting the Guruship in a book. Part Ten described that design being tested by a state that hanged its leadership in public in 1716 and failing to kill it. Part Eleven described it absorbing the loss of half its people in a morning and reassembling eight months later.

Part Twelve described that system failing, because a confederacy with no coercive centre dissolves the moment nobody is attacking it.

And Part Thirteen is the correction — **and the correction went too far.**

Ranjit Singh built a treasury, an army, an arsenal, a frontier, a revenue system and a foreign policy. He did not build a council, a regency, a succession, or any body that could make a decision without him. **He restored the single point of failure that the Khalsa had spent a century engineering out of itself.**

Seven armies in this book were destroyed because one man went down in front of them. At Jamrud in 1837 his own governor solved that problem with an administrative decision — **they simply did not tell the garrison.**

Two years later the Maharaja died in his bed at Lahore and there was nobody to not tell.

Ten years after that, the Punjab was a British province.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1801	Proclaimed Maharaja on Vaisakhi at Lahore. The coinage carries the names of the Gurus and never his own.
1802	Amritsar taken from the Bhangis, with the great gun Zamzama . He becomes the patron of the Harmandir Sahib and later has it faced in marble and gold. Won by Ranjit Singh.
1801–1821	The misls are absorbed — by marriage, purchase, inheritance and occasionally force. Sada Kaur, who made him, is dispossessed in 1821 and dies in confinement.
Feb 1809	Metcalfe's escort of about a hundred sepoys forms square at Amritsar and drives off an Akali attack. Ranjit Singh draws the conclusion and starts building infantry.
25 Apr 1809	The Treaty of Amritsar. The Sutlej becomes his eastern border; the Cis-Sutlej states pass under British protection. Won by the Company — and it buys him thirty years.
Aug 1809	Kangra. The Gurkhas are driven back east of the Sutlej and Sansar Chand is relieved — and loses his fort as the fee. Won by Ranjit Singh.
Jun 1813	The Koh-i-Noor is obtained from the exiled Shah Shuja at Lahore.
13 Jul 1813	Haidru, near Attock. Diwan Mokham Chand beats Fateh Khan and Dost Muhammad. The first time in eight hundred years that a Punjabi army beat an Afghan army in a pitched battle.
1814	The first Kashmir expedition fails — divided columns, a late start, and the rains. His worst military failure.
2 Jun 1818	Multan. Months of siege; the Zamzama breaches the wall and cracks doing it; Nawab Muzaffar Khan dies in the breach with his sons. The door of Part Five is shut from the Indian side.
Jul 1819	Kashmir, taken at the second attempt after the action at Shopian. Sold to Gulab Singh Dogra by the British in 1846.
1822 onwards	Ventura and Allard arrive, then Court and Avitabile. The Fauj-i-Khas , the arsenals and the gun foundry — roughly thirty thousand regular infantry and modern artillery by 1839.
14 Mar 1823	Nowshera. The hardest battle of the reign, against the frontier tribes. Akali Phula Singh is killed taking the hill. Peshawar becomes tributary. Won by Ranjit Singh.
Oct 1831	Ropar. The Maharaja and the Governor-General meet on the Sutlej, show each other their armies, and both go home having taken the measure.
1834	Peshawar annexed, with Hari Singh Nalwa as governor.

1836–1837

The fort at **Jamrud** is built at the mouth of the Khyber. On **30 April 1837** the Afghans attack; **Hari Singh Nalwa is killed and his death is concealed** so the garrison will hold. It holds. **Won by Lahore — and the door is finally garrisoned.**

Jun 1838

The Tripartite Treaty. He signs to restore Shah Shuja at Kabul — and **refuses to let a British army cross the Punjab**, so it goes the long way through Sindh.

27 Jun 1839

Ranjit Singh dies at Lahore, aged fifty-eight, leaving a kingdom, a treasury, the best army in India — and no council, no regency and no succession. *Part Fourteen begins here.*

Five patterns to carry into Part Fourteen

1. **The door is finally shut — and it is shut for thirteen years.** Part Four opened with the complaint that nobody garrisons the passes, and every part since has repeated it. Attock in 1813, Multan in 1818, Kashmir in 1819, Peshawar in 1834, **Jamrud in 1836**. For the only time in this book, a Punjabi government holds every one of its own doors — and in 1849 all of them pass to somebody else in a single treaty.
2. **He copied the winning method and nobody else did.** Drilled infantry, disciplined artillery, a foundry and regular pay — the lesson of Part Twelve, acted on by one ruler out of a subcontinent. **It is the only reason Part Fourteen takes two wars.**
3. **The single point of failure, restored on purpose.** The Khalsa spent a century engineering itself so that no leader's death could end it — 1699, 1704, 1708, 1716, 1762. Ranjit Singh built a state with no institution that could act without him. **At Jamrud they solved the problem by not telling the garrison; in 1839 there was nobody to not tell.**
4. **The army outlives the state.** By 1843 the Khalsa army is the strongest institution in the Punjab and the court is the weakest, with regimental committees making political decisions because nothing else can. **Watch who actually decides to cross the Sutlej in 1845, and why.**
5. **And the treaty line was the trap and the shelter both.** The Sutlej border of 1809 kept the British out for thirty-six years and fixed the Punjab in place while the Company took Sindh, Gwalior, Awadh and everything else. **Distance had protected this province since Part One. In 1843 the distance ran out.**

COMING NEXT — PART FOURTEEN

The Anglo-Sikh Wars, 1839–1849. Six years of court murders — Kharak Singh, Nau Nihal Singh, Chand Kaur, Sher Singh, Dhian Singh — until the throne holds a five-year-old, **Duleep Singh**, and his mother **Jind Kaur** is regent over an army nobody controls. Then the First Sikh War: **Mudki** and **Ferozeshah** in December 1845, where a Governor-General burned his papers expecting to lose; **Aliwal**; and **Sobraon** in February 1846, where Sham Singh Attariwala died in the bridgehead. The Treaty of Lahore, the sale of Kashmir, and a British Resident in the fort. Then 1848: two officers murdered at **Multan**, the army rising again, **Chillianwala** — the worst day the British had in India in that century — and **Gujrat** in February 1849. The Khalsa army lays down its arms at Rawalpindi. **On 29 March 1849 the Punjab is annexed, the Koh-i-Noor is sent to London, and a ten-year-old signs away the last independent state in India.**

Words Used in This Part

Sarkar Khalsa

“The government of the Khalsa” — the name Ranjit Singh’s state used for itself. He ruled as an autocrat and never called himself more than its servant.

Nanakshahi

The currency of the Sikh state, carrying the couplet used by Banda Singh Bahadur in 1710 and crediting everything to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. It never bore the Maharaja’s name.

Zamzama

The great bronze gun cast at Lahore in 1757, present at Panipat in 1761, fought over by the misls, taken with Amritsar in 1802, and cracked breaching the walls of Multan in 1818. Kipling’s “Kim’s Gun.”

Fauj-i-Khas

“The special army” — the model corps of regular infantry, cavalry and artillery raised from 1822 under Ventura and Allard and drilled to French words of command.

Fauj-i-Ain

The regular army as a whole, as distinct from the irregulars and the feudal contingents.

Ghorchurra

The irregular cavalry — the descendants of the misl horsemen, kept on alongside the regular army because they were still the best light cavalry in Asia.

Akali / Nihang

The irregular religious warriors of the Khalsa, answering to no government. Akali Phula Singh led them at Nowshera and died there — and had earlier summoned the Maharaja before the Akal Takht.

Panchayat

A committee. In the army after 1839, the regimental panchayats became political bodies, because the court could no longer govern and nothing else could act.

Durbar

The court, and by extension the government of Lahore. British despatches use “the Lahore Durbar” to mean the Sikh state.

Jagir

An assignment of land revenue in return for service — the instrument by which misl chiefs were converted into courtiers.

Cis-Sutlej states

The Sikh states east of the Sutlej — Patiala, Nabha, Jind and the rest — placed under British protection by the treaty of 1809 and never part of Ranjit Singh’s kingdom.

Tripartite Treaty

The agreement of June 1838 between the British, Ranjit Singh and Shah Shuja to restore the latter at Kabul — the beginning of the First Anglo-Afghan War.

Koh-i-Noor

The diamond taken from Delhi by Nadir Shah in 1739, passed down the Durrani line, obtained from Shah Shuja at Lahore in 1813, and sent to London in 1849.

Sati

The burning of a widow on her husband's pyre. Condemned by the Gurus from the sixteenth century, and practised at Ranjit Singh's funeral in 1839.

Sources used for this part

- The records of the Lahore Durbar, and the British Residency and Ludhiana Agency correspondence
- The treaties themselves — Amritsar 1809 and the Tripartite Treaty 1838
- Memoirs and papers of the European officers in Sikh service — **Ventura, Allard, Court and Avitabile**, and the unreliable but vivid narrative of **Alexander Gardner**
- European travellers who saw the court: **Victor Jacquemont, Alexander Burnes, W. G. Osborne, Baron von Hügel** and **William Moorcroft**
- **Charles Metcalfe**'s mission correspondence, 1808–09
- Persian court chronicles of the Sikh period, including Sohan Lal Suri's *Umdat-ut-Tawarikh*, the official diary of the Lahore court
- Afghan accounts of the campaigns of 1813, 1823 and 1837
- Kashmiri accounts of the period of Sikh rule
- Standard modern biographies of Ranjit Singh and histories of the Sikh kingdom

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: whether the Amritsar incident of 1809 really caused the decision to raise regular infantry, or whether that has been tidied into a single cause after the event; the true size of the Khalsa army in 1839, where figures vary by tens of thousands depending on what is counted; the details of the Akal Takht episode; the exact terms under which the Koh-i-Noor was surrendered; and the reliability of Alexander Gardner, who is entertaining and should not be trusted alone on anything.

Three things about method.

First, **this part has stated the discreditable things**. Sada Kaur's dispossession and death in confinement; the Badshahi Mosque used as a magazine; the extractive administration of Kashmir; the sati at his funeral. A reign this successful attracts hagiography, and a history that only records the successes is a monument rather than a history.

Second, **most of the sources here are British and most of them were assessing a potential enemy**. The Residency reports, the intelligence summaries and the officers' accounts of the Khalsa army are detailed and — as Part Fourteen demonstrates — largely accurate. They are also written by the people who would shortly be fighting it, and that has been kept in view.

Third, **the closing argument of this part is a judgement, not a fact**. That Ranjit Singh's failure to build an institution capable of surviving him is what destroyed the state is the view of most historians and it is the view of this book, and it is stated as an argument rather than smuggled in as a description.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART FOURTEEN OF SIXTEEN

The Anglo-Sikh Wars

Ten years, nine battles and the hardest fighting the British ever met in India — lost by a state that murdered itself, and fought to the end by an army its own government had given up on.

1839 — 1849

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Ten Years

This is the part where the Punjab loses, and the way it loses is not the way this book has taught you to expect.

Ranjit Singh died in June 1839 leaving a full treasury, a secure frontier and the finest army in India.

Ten years later the Punjab was a British province, its Maharaja was a ten-year-old signing away his kingdom, and the Koh-i-Noor was on a ship to London.

What happened in between is two separate stories that are usually told as one. **The first is a court that destroyed itself** — five rulers in four years, every one of them murdered or dead in circumstances nobody believed, until the throne held a five-year-old and his mother. **The second is an army that went on fighting long after the state it belonged to had stopped functioning**, and that came within an afternoon of beating the British twice.

Four things to hold on to

- **The Khalsa army was not defeated in the way defeated armies usually are.** British officers who had fought Napoleon's veterans in Spain wrote home to say they had never met anything like it. At Ferozeshah the Governor-General of India burned his papers expecting to lose. At Chillianwala the news caused a political crisis in London. **Read the enemy's despatches in this part; they are the highest tribute anybody in these sixteen parts receives.**
- **The question of betrayal is real and it is not settled.** Two of the army's own commanders were in communication with the British before and during the first war. This book will set out what is established, what is inferred, and where the argument still runs.
- **The conquest was done as much by treaty as by battle.** Lahore in March 1846, Bhyrowal in December 1846, annexation in March 1849 — three documents in three years, each one narrowing what was left. **Part Twelve described this method arriving in India; here it is finished.**
- **And the army governed itself for four years.** The regimental committees — *panchayats* — that ran the Khalsa army between 1841 and 1845 are one of the strangest institutions in this book, and the court's fear of them is a large part of why the war happened at all.

HOW THIS PART HANDLES A DEFEAT

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence.

LIKELY means well-attested.

STORY means tradition.

Almost everything here is **CERTAIN** — there are despatches, muster rolls, treaty texts, regimental histories, casualty returns and eyewitness memoirs on both sides.

Which creates the reverse of Part One's problem. Most of the surviving narrative is British, written by professional soldiers for professional audiences. It is detailed and it is largely honest — these were men describing a war they had nearly lost, to colleagues who would check. But it is one side's account of the other side's destruction, and it is read here as such.

The Punjabi record of these years is thinner, because the state that would have kept it was disintegrating while the events happened. **That absence is itself a fact about 1839 to 1849 and this part says so rather than filling the gap with anything.**

The Court Murders, 1839–1843

CERTAIN

Five rulers in four years. By the end of it the throne of the Punjab held a boy of five, and every man capable of governing was dead.

WON BY

Nobody — this is the state killing itself

WHEN

June 1839 to September 1843.

WHERE

Lahore — the fort, the gardens outside it, and the road between them.

WHO

The **Dogras** under Dhian Singh; the **Sindhanwalias**, Ranjit Singh's own collaterals; and the army.

THE EVIDENCE

Court records and British Residency despatches, which report each killing within days.

What happened, in order

1. **Kharak Singh** succeeded his father in June 1839 and was deposed within months. His favourite was murdered in front of him; he was confined, and he died on **5 November 1840**. He had been ill for a long time and had been given something; the details are argued about and the direction is not.
2. **Nau Nihal Singh** — his son, nineteen, able, and the one man who might have held the state together — walked back from his father's cremation the same day. **An archway of the Roshnai Gate at Lahore Fort collapsed as he passed under it.** He was carried inside injured. Nobody was allowed to see him. His death was announced that evening.
3. **Chand Kaur**, Kharak Singh's widow and Nau Nihal's mother, claimed the regency and held it for a few months. She was pushed out in January 1841 and **murdered in June 1842** by her own maidservants, who were afterwards mutilated so that they could not testify.
4. **Sher Singh**, another of Ranjit Singh's sons, ruled from 1841. On **15 September 1843**, a Sindhanwalia sardar presented him with a new gun to inspect and shot him with it. His young son was killed the same day.
5. **Dhian Singh Dogra**, the chief minister who had arranged or benefited from most of the preceding, was murdered by the same faction within hours.
6. **And the Sindhanwalias were killed the next day** by Dhian Singh's son, who brought the army against them.
7. **Duleep Singh, aged five**, was proclaimed Maharaja, with his mother **Jind Kaur** as regent.

THE ARCHWAY

The death of Nau Nihal Singh on 5 November 1840 is the hinge of this whole part, and it deserves to be stated carefully.

What is documented: masonry from the gateway fell as the procession passed; a companion walking with him — a son of Gulab Singh Dogra — was killed outright; Nau Nihal was injured; Dhian Singh Dogra took charge of him; he was carried into the fort; access was refused; and his death was announced later that day. Witnesses who saw him carried in described his injuries as serious but not obviously fatal.

What is inferred: that he was finished off inside.

This book cannot prove it and neither can anybody else. What can be said is that almost nobody at the time believed it was an accident, that the British Resident's reports treat it as murder, and that the man who controlled the scene was the man with the most to gain.

And the consequence is not in doubt at all. **Nau Nihal Singh was nineteen, competent, and the last plausible ruler of the Sikh state.** After 5 November 1840 there was nobody left who could both command the army and govern the court, and the ten years in this part follow from that.

WHY IT HAPPENED

- **There was no succession law and no council.** Part Thirteen's closing argument, arriving on schedule. Nothing existed to arbitrate a disputed throne except violence.
- **Ranjit Singh had balanced factions personally** — Dogras, Sindhanwalias, the army — and when he stopped, nothing balanced them.
- **The prize was enormous.** A full treasury and the richest province in India, controlled by whoever held the child on the throne.
- **And each killing required the next.** A faction that has murdered a ruler cannot afford to lose the next round.

WHAT IT DESTROYED

- **Every capable leader.** In four years the Punjab lost two Maharajas, a regent, a chief minister, a prince and most of two noble houses.
- **The court's authority over the army.** Soldiers watching their government murder itself annually draw conclusions.
- **Any chance of a coherent policy towards the British,** at exactly the moment when one was needed.
- **And the loyalty of the Dogras,** who by 1845 were positioning for whatever came next — which is the ugliest thread in this part.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Forty Miles Away, Somebody Was Writing It All Down

Every one of these murders was reported to Ludhiana within days, and from Ludhiana to Calcutta.

The British had kept an Agency on the Sutlej since the treaty of 1809 — thirty years of watching, with informants at Lahore, a network of news-writers, and officers whose job was to report what the Durbar did. **The despatches from 1839 to 1845 are one of the best sources for this part, and they are also the record of a government studying a neighbour coming apart.**

They noted that Nau Nihal Singh was dead and that nobody believed the gateway. They noted the strength of the army and the weakness of the court. They noted the size of the treasury. They counted the guns.

And from 1843 they began moving troops up. **Sindh had been annexed that year, which put British territory on a second side of the Punjab.** Garrisons on the Sutlej were reinforced; a bridging train was moved to Ferozepur; boats were collected on the river.

From Lahore, all of that looked like exactly what it was.

This book has said since Part One that the Punjab's protection was distance — that everything came at it from the north-west because that was the only direction anything could come from, and that whatever ruled the Ganges plain was always too far away to finish the job.

By 1843 the East India Company had territory on the Sutlej and territory in Sindh, a road, a river fleet, and six years of detailed intelligence on a government that was murdering itself.

The distance had run out.

The Army That Became the Government, 1841–1845

CERTAIN

When the court stopped governing, the regiments elected committees and governed instead. It is one of the most extraordinary things in this book, and it terrified everybody.

WHAT HAPPENED

The Khalsa army became the sovereign institution of the Punjab

WHEN 1841–1845.	WHERE The cantonments around Lahore and across the province.
WHO The regimental <i>panchayats</i> — committees elected by the soldiers.	THE EVIDENCE Durbar records and British Residency reports, which describe the system in detail and with alarm.

What the panchayats were

1. **Each regiment elected a committee** — traditionally five men, hence the name — to represent it.
2. **The committees coordinated between regiments**, and a general body spoke for the army as a whole.
3. **They negotiated pay.** The army had been under-paid since 1839 and the panchayats extracted substantial increases from a court that could not refuse them.
4. **They removed officers.** Commanders judged incompetent or corrupt were dismissed, and in some cases killed.
5. **And they made political decisions.** By 1843 no wazir could hold office without the army’s acquiescence, and in September 1845 the panchayats had the regent’s own brother, the wazir **Jawahar Singh**, put to death in front of the boy Maharaja.

WHAT TO MAKE OF IT

It is easy to describe this as indiscipline and several British observers did. That is not quite what it was.

The Khalsa army in 1841 was the only institution in the Punjab that still worked. It was paid, organised, drilled and disciplined internally; it had a chain of command that functioned; and it had a strong sense of itself as the army of the Khalsa rather than of any particular ruler. Part Thirteen described what Ranjit Singh had built. This is that machine, still running, with nobody at the controls.

So the regiments did what soldiers have done in that situation elsewhere — **they elected representatives and started making decisions.** The closest parallel in European history is the Agitators of the New Model Army in the 1640s, and the resemblance is close enough that several historians have used it.

And the panchayats invoked the old vocabulary. They spoke of themselves as the Khalsa, took decisions in the name of the community, and appealed to a tradition of collective authority that ran back to the Sarbat Khalsa of Part Eleven and beyond that to 1699.

Whether that was sincere or convenient is unanswerable. **What is clear is that the institution Ranjit Singh had allowed to lapse reasserted itself, in uniform, forty years later — and that the court found it intolerable.**

WHY THE ARMY COULD TAKE OVER

- **It was the last thing standing.** The court was murdering itself; the army was not.
- **It had the money problem on its side.** An unpaid army with guns is a political actor whether it wants to be or not.
- **It had a tradition to appeal to.** The Khalsa's collective authority was a real inheritance, not an invention.
- **And nobody could replace it.** The Punjab's frontier needed defending and there was no second army.

WHY IT COULD NOT GOVERN

- **A committee of soldiers can veto and cannot administer.** They could remove a wazir and could not run a revenue department.
- **It had no foreign policy.** Against a government in Calcutta with a strategy, an army with grievances is not a match.
- **It frightened its own state into destroying it.** Which is War Three, and it is the darkest reading in this part.
- **And it grew.** By 1845 the army was substantially larger than Ranjit Singh had ever maintained, and correspondingly more expensive and less controllable.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Institution That Came Back

There is a thread running through the last six parts of this book that comes to the surface here in a form nobody expected.

Part Nine: the Khalsa is founded in 1699, with authority vested in the order rather than the man, and five ordinary members empowered to bind even the Guru. **Part Ten:** the Sarbat Khalsa emerges in the forests, meeting twice a year and binding twelve chiefs by resolution. **Part Eleven:** that assembly appoints commanders, divides provinces and refuses an Afghan king's terms. **Part Twelve:** it stops being convened, because the misls stop needing each other. **Part Thirteen:** Ranjit Singh never calls it once in forty years.

And then in 1841, with the state coming apart, **the soldiers of the Khalsa army elect committees, call themselves the Khalsa, and start passing resolutions.**

It is not the same institution. A regimental panchayat is not the Sarbat Khalsa and a demand for arrears of pay is not a gurmata. Several of the army's decisions were factional, some were murderous, and the men involved were pursuing their interests like everybody else in this part.

But the shape of the thing is unmistakable, and it did not come from nowhere. A hundred and forty years after Anandpur, in the collapse of a monarchy that had set the collective tradition aside, an army reached for it again — because it was the only model of legitimate collective authority the Punjab had.

It lasted four years, it could not govern, and its own government sent it across the Sutlej to be destroyed.

The Crossing, December 1845

LIKELY

The Khalsa army crossed the Sutlej, and the argument about why has been running for a hundred and eighty years.

WON BY

Nobody yet — but the war began on terms that suited only one side

WHEN	WHERE
11 December 1845.	The Sutlej , the treaty line of 1809.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
The Khalsa army, under Lal Singh as wazir and Tej Singh as commander-in-chief.	Both governments' records — and a set of intercepted communications that are the heart of the controversy.

Three explanations, all of them partly true

- 1. The British were preparing for war.** This is not a nationalist claim; it is in their own papers. **Sindh had been annexed in 1843**, putting British territory on a second side of the Punjab. Garrisons at Ferozepur, Ludhiana and Ambala were reinforced from 1843 onwards. **A bridging train was moved to Ferozepur** and boats were collected. By late 1845 there were tens of thousands of troops and a large artillery park on the Sutlej. **From Lahore this looked like an invasion being assembled, because in an important sense it was.**
- 2. The army wanted to go.** Confident, larger than ever, and contemptuous of a court that had murdered five rulers in four years. It had been told for six years that the British were coming, and it preferred to fight on ground of its choosing.
- 3. And the court wanted the army destroyed.** This is the reading most historians accept in some form. **A government that cannot control its own army, and whose ministers have watched the panchayats execute a wazir, has an obvious interest in that army being broken by somebody else.**

THE BETRAYAL QUESTION, STATED AS CAREFULLY AS IT CAN BE

This is the most serious accusation in this part and it needs to be handled precisely.

What is documented. Both **Lal Singh**, the wazir, and **Tej Singh**, the commander-in-chief, were in communication with British officers before and during the war. Correspondence exists. **Captain Peter Nicolson, the British agent at Ferozepur, was receiving information from Lal Singh.** After the war both men were retained in office by the British-backed settlement, and Lal Singh was later removed only for a separate offence.

What is inferred from conduct. At Ferozeshah, Tej Singh arrived on the morning of 22 December with a fresh army, against a British force that was exhausted and nearly out of ammunition — and withdrew without attacking. At Sobraon, he crossed the bridge to the rear early in the battle, and the bridge behind the Sikh army failed at the moment it was most needed. Lal Singh's handling at Mudki and Ferozeshah was, at best, extraordinarily poor.

What is contested. Whether this amounts to a coordinated plan to have the army annihilated, or to two frightened men hedging against a defeat they thought inevitable, or to some combination. **Historians differ, and the difference matters.**

This book's position is that the communications are established, the conduct at Ferozeshah and Sobraon requires an explanation, and that no innocent explanation has ever been offered that accounts for both. **That is not the same as a proven conspiracy, and it will not be described as one.**

WHY THE BRITISH WERE READY

- **Six years of intelligence** on a disintegrating neighbour, from an Agency forty miles away.
- **Sindh in 1843** gave them a second front and a river route.
- **They had prepared the ground** — troops, guns, boats and supplies were in place before a shot was fired.
- **And they had friends inside.** Whatever the extent of it, they were not fighting blind.

WHY THE SIKH POSITION WAS HOPELESS BEFORE IT STARTED

- **The army did not trust its commanders and was right not to.**
- **There was no government behind it.** No war policy, no reserves plan, no diplomacy, no ally.
- **It crossed a river with an enemy in front and nothing at its back.**
- **And it fought four battles in eight weeks,** which no army can sustain without a state.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Argument About Whose War It Was

British despatches of December 1845 describe an unprovoked invasion of Company territory by a barbarous soldiery, and the war was fought and justified on that basis.

It is worth being exact about what the crossing actually was. The Lahore Durbar held territory on both banks of the Sutlej — the treaty of 1809 fixed a boundary, not an exclusion. Sikh possessions on the left bank were long established. Crossing the river was therefore not, by itself, an act of war in the way the despatches presented it, and everybody involved knew that.

It is equally worth being exact about the other side of the ledger. **The army crossed in force, with artillery, and invested Ferozepur.** Whatever the legal position, that is a campaign, not a border dispute.

And the third thing is the one this book keeps returning to. **Both governments had spent two years preparing for a war they each said the other was going to start.** The Company moved troops and bridging equipment to the frontier; the Durbar increased an army it could not pay. Each buildup justified the next.

Wars that everybody has prepared for tend to happen, and the question of who technically began them is usually the least interesting thing about them.

What was genuinely one-sided was the aftermath. Within three years the Punjab had lost a province, its treasury, its army, its regent and its independence — **and the winner wrote the account of how it started.**

Mudki, 18 December 1845

CERTAIN

The first battle was fought in dust and failing light by two armies that could not see each other, and the British won it at a price that told them what the next one would cost.

WON BY

The British — narrowly, and it frightened them

WHEN

18 December 1845, from late afternoon into the night.

WHERE

Mudki, in the scrub country south of Ferozepur.

WHO

Sir Hugh Gough with about eleven thousand, against a Sikh force under Lal Singh.

THE EVIDENCE

British despatches, regimental records and casualty returns.

What happened

1. Gough’s army had force-marched from Ambala and arrived at Mudki exhausted and thirsty, and was attacked as it was settling.
2. The ground was low scrub and sand, and the fighting kicked up so much dust that in the failing December light neither side could see what it was doing. The battle is remembered in the British army as “Midnight Mudki.”
3. The Sikh guns were well served and did serious damage before the British cavalry got among them.
4. Lal Singh withdrew — early, and with much of his force intact.
5. British losses were about eight hundred and seventy. Among the dead were Sir Robert Sale, the defender of Jalalabad and one of the most famous soldiers in India, and Sir John McCaskill.

WHAT THE BRITISH LEARNED IN ONE EVENING

Gough had fought in Spain against Napoleon's armies and in China. Most of his officers had spent careers fighting Indian armies and had a settled view of what those were like: brave, badly led, and certain to break when pressed.

At Mudki the Sikh artillery outshot theirs, the infantry did not break, and the withdrawal was orderly. Two generals were killed. Eight hundred and seventy casualties for an evening's fighting against a force that had not been trying very hard was not the arithmetic anybody had expected.

The despatches after Mudki change tone noticeably. **Officers who had written about "the Sikhs" as a rabble started writing about them as an army.**

And there is a detail that recurs through every battle in this part and starts here: **the Sikh gunners stayed with their guns.** British accounts of Mudki, Ferozeshah, Aliwal and Sobraon all note the same thing, in the same words, with the same puzzled respect — that the artillerymen were killed at their pieces rather than abandoning them.

WHY THE BRITISH WON

- **Cavalry.** Their horse got round the flanks in the confusion and into the gun line, which the Sikh cavalry did not prevent.
- **Discipline in the dark.** Formed infantry that can keep its order in dust and darkness has an enormous advantage over one that cannot.
- **And the Sikh commander did not commit.** Lal Singh fought a portion of his force and took it away.

WHY IT WAS NOT A DEFEAT THAT MATTERED

- **The Sikh army was substantially intact** and three days later was entrenched at Ferozeshah with a hundred guns.
- **The ground was chosen by nobody** — a meeting engagement, not a battle either side had planned.
- **British losses were disproportionate** for the result, and they had a much harder fight coming.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Governor-General as Second-in-Command

There is an arrangement in this campaign that has no parallel in British military history and it says a good deal about how seriously the war was taken.

Sir Henry Hardinge was the Governor-General of India. He was also a Peninsular veteran who had lost a hand at Ligny two days before Waterloo, and he did not think much of Gough's tactics.

So he volunteered to serve **under** Gough as second-in-command.

Consider the position. The head of the government of British India — the man with civil authority over a hundred and fifty million people — placed himself in the field as the military subordinate of the Commander-in-Chief, in order to be present at the battles and to intervene if things went wrong. It was not vanity. **Hardinge had concluded that this war might be lost, and that if it was lost the Company's position in northern India would go with it.** His own private letters say so.

Three days after Mudki, at Ferozeshah, he told Gough that the attack should not go in that evening — and was overruled, because Gough was his commanding officer. **That night he sent his sword and his state papers to the rear at Ferozepur, with orders that they were to be destroyed if the battle was lost.** The sword was one Wellington had given him; it had belonged to Napoleon.

Ferozeshah, 21–22 December 1845

CERTAIN

The hardest-fought battle the British ever had in India, and the closest they came to losing one. It was decided by a general who arrived with a fresh army and did not attack.

WON BY **The British — and Hardinge wrote that another such victory would undo them**

WHEN 21–22 December 1845, over two days and a night.	WHERE Ferozeshah, a fortified camp in flat scrub country.
WHO Gough and Hardinge with about eighteen thousand, against roughly thirty-five thousand Sikhs with over a hundred guns under Lal Singh — and Tej Singh with a second army nearby.	THE EVIDENCE Extensive, from both sides, and unusually candid on the British side.

Day one

1. **The Sikh army was entrenched** in a defended camp with a large and well-served artillery park — the strongest position anybody had built against a British army in India.
2. **Gough waited most of the day** for Littler’s division to come up from Ferozepur, then attacked in the late afternoon. Hardinge argued against attacking so late and was overruled.
3. **The assault went in and partly succeeded.** British and Company infantry got into the entrenchments; some of the guns were taken; the fighting was hand to hand and extremely costly.
4. **Then the light went.**

The night

1. **The British army spent the night scattered among the Sikh entrenchments**, in the dark, in pieces, in and around the enemy’s own camp, with Sikh guns still firing into them at intervals.
2. **Units were lost.** Regiments did not know where their brigades were. Some formations had withdrawn; others were still in the camp; ammunition was low and there was no water.
3. **Hardinge sent his papers and his sword to the rear.**

4. **Officers who survived it wrote afterwards that India was won and lost several times during that night.**

Day two

1. **At first light the British re-formed and cleared the camp.** By mid-morning the position was theirs and the Sikh army had drawn off.
2. **And then Tej Singh arrived with a fresh army.**
3. **The British force in front of him was finished.** It had marched, fought two battles in four days, spent a night among enemy guns, was almost out of artillery ammunition, and had no reserve. Several accounts describe cavalry being sent away to look like a manoeuvre because there was nothing else left to do.
4. **Tej Singh made a demonstration and withdrew.**

THE MORNING OF 22 DECEMBER

Everything in this part turns on an hour on the morning of 22 December 1845, and it is worth stating what was actually available to each side.

The British: perhaps twelve thousand effective men, no fresh troops, artillery ammunition nearly exhausted, no water, casualties of well over two thousand, and the Governor-General of India on the field.

Tej Singh: a substantially intact army that had not fought, with its own artillery, arriving on the flank of an enemy in that condition.

He did not attack.

The explanations offered at the time and since: that he believed the British were manoeuvring to cut him off; that his own troops were unwilling; that he judged the position too strong. **The explanation most historians give:** that he did not want to win.

This book set out the evidence for that in War Three and will not repeat it. **What can be said without any inference at all is that the outcome of the First Anglo-Sikh War was decided by a Sikh commander declining to engage a beaten enemy, and that his own army never forgave him for it.**

WHY THE BRITISH SURVIVED

- **Discipline through a night that should have broken them.** Whatever else is said about the British army of 1845, it did not disintegrate at Ferozeshah, and it very nearly should have.
- **The Sikh command was divided and half of it was not trying.**
- **Two armies were never combined.** Lal Singh's and Tej Singh's forces fought the same battle on consecutive days rather than together on one.
- **And luck, which the survivors said so themselves.**

WHY THE SIKHS DID NOT WIN

- **Their commanders.** This is the whole answer and every other line is a detail of it.
- **No coordination between the two forces** — the oldest failure in this book, appearing for the last time.
- **They fought a defensive battle brilliantly and could not follow up.** Nobody ordered the counter-attack that was there to be made.
- **And they had no government to exploit a victory even if they had won one.**

What the Enemy Wrote Down

This book has spent thirteen parts asking who is writing and what they need you to believe, and it has usually had to work with victors describing people they had just destroyed.

Ferozeshah produced the opposite. The British accounts of this battle were written by professionals for professional readers who would check, about a fight they had nearly lost, and they are startlingly generous.

They describe artillery served better than their own. They describe infantry that stood in entrenchments and did not run. They describe gunners killed at their pieces. **They describe, repeatedly and with something close to bewilderment, that Sikh soldiers did not surrender.**

Hardinge — the Governor-General, who had fought the French — wrote privately that he had never seen troops fight like it, and that **another such victory would undo them.**

Gough said afterwards that policy prevented him from recording publicly what he thought of the gallantry of the men he had beaten.

Take that at exactly its face value and no more. These were officers of an army engaged in conquering the Punjab, and generosity about a defeated enemy is cheap and flatters the winner. But the purpose was not to praise Sikhs. **It was to explain to London why a victory had cost two and a half thousand casualties in four days, and the honest answer was that they had met the best army in Asia and had barely got past it.**

Part Ten found its most valuable witness in two English merchants with no reason to be kind. This is the same thing at a larger scale: **the highest tribute the Punjab receives in these sixteen parts is written in the reports of the men who were killing them.**

Aliwal, 28 January 1846

CERTAIN

The one battle in this war that the British fought properly, and the only one they are unreservedly proud of.

WON BY Sir Harry Smith — cleanly, which is why it is famous

WHEN 28 January 1846, after a check at Baddowal a week earlier.	WHERE Aliwal, on the Sutlej near Ludhiana.
WHO Sir Harry Smith against Ranjodh Singh Majithia.	THE EVIDENCE Detailed on both sides; the tactical accounts are unusually clear.

What happened

1. A Sikh force had crossed near Ludhiana to threaten the British communications and had checked Smith at Baddowal on 21 January.
2. Smith came back reinforced and found them drawn up with the river behind them.
3. He fought a methodical battle — artillery first, then a general advance, with his flanks secured and his cavalry used at the right moment.
4. The 16th Lancers charged Sikh infantry squares and broke them, in an action that became one of the most celebrated in British cavalry history.
5. The Sikh army was driven back into the fords and lost heavily crossing under fire. Sixty-seven guns were taken.
6. British casualties were under six hundred — by the standards of this campaign, almost nothing.

WHY ALIWAL IS THE ODD ONE OUT

British military writers have called Aliwal “the battle without a mistake,” and the phrase is worth unpacking, because what it praises is the absence of the thing that characterised the rest of the war.

Gough’s method was the frontal assault with the bayonet. It had worked in Spain and in China and it worked in the Punjab too, at Mudki, Ferozeshah, and later Chillianwala — at a cost that appalled his own government. He distrusted long bombardments and preferred to close.

Smith did the opposite. He used his guns first, kept his formations in hand, secured his flanks, and committed cavalry when the infantry had done its work.

The result was the only engagement of the First Sikh War in which the British lost fewer men than they might have expected.

And the lesson was not learned for three more years. Gough remained Commander-in-Chief; Chillianwala in January 1849 was fought his way and cost him twenty-three hundred casualties in an afternoon. Only at Gujrat, six weeks after that, and under enormous political pressure, did a British army in the Punjab finally fight the way Harry Smith had fought at Aliwal.

WHY SMITH WON SO CHEAPLY

- **Artillery preparation.** The guns did the work before the infantry went in.
- **The Sikhs had a river at their back.** A position with no line of retreat is a trap for whoever is standing in it.
- **He had time.** Unlike Gough at Ferozeshah, he was not fighting at the end of a forced march against a clock.
- **And this was a detached force,** not the main Khalsa army.

WHY THE SIKH POSITION WAS BAD

- **They stood with the Sutlej behind them** and no bridge worth the name.
- **They were on the wrong side of the river** for the strategic purpose, isolated from the main army.
- **Their infantry formed squares against cavalry** — correct doctrine, and useless without guns to break up the charge.
- **And sixty-seven guns lost is a catastrophe** for an army whose artillery was its greatest asset.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Guns

Count what the Khalsa army lost in artillery between December 1845 and February 1846.

Guns taken in the entrenchments at Ferozeshah. **Sixty-seven at Aliwal.** The whole of the artillery in the bridgehead at Sobraon two weeks later. And then, by the treaty of March 1846, thirty-six more surrendered as a condition of peace.

The gun park that Ranjit Singh spent twenty years building — the foundry at Lahore, the trained crews, the French artillery officer who organised it — was destroyed in eight weeks.

Part Twelve described the lesson that everybody in India was given between 1780 and 1820 and that only one ruler acted on: drilled infantry and disciplined artillery beat any quantity of irregular cavalry. Part Thirteen described him acting on it, deliberately, for thirty years, building the industry as well as the army.

The guns were the reason the British nearly lost at Ferozeshah. Every British account of that battle says so; the Sikh artillery outshot theirs and held them out of the entrenchments through an afternoon.

And an army's guns are the hardest part of it to replace. Men can be recruited; a foundry takes years and a trained gunner takes longer. **When the Khalsa army rose again in 1848 it fought two more full-scale battles — and at Gujrat it was outgunned three to one by an enemy that had learned, finally, to use artillery properly.**

What was lost in eight weeks in 1846 was not recovered, and could not have been.

Sobraon, 10 February 1846

CERTAIN

The army was destroyed in a bridgehead with a river behind it and a bridge that failed. It is the end of the Sikh state as a military power, and it produced the last great figure in this book.

WON BY

The British — decisively, and at a cost of two and a half thousand men

WHEN

10 February 1846, from dawn to early afternoon.

WHERE

Sobraon, on the east bank of the Sutlej.

WHO

Gough and Hardinge, against roughly **thirty thousand** Sikhs in prepared entrenchments.

THE EVIDENCE

Extensive and detailed on both sides.

CERTAIN

The position

The Sikh army had built a bridgehead on the **east** bank — a horseshoe of earthworks perhaps three kilometres long, well sited, with a heavy gun line, resting both flanks on the river.

Behind it was a single boat bridge. That is the whole battle. An army in a bridgehead with one crossing behind it is either winning or annihilated, and there is nothing in between.

What happened

1. **The British opened with a bombardment** of about two hours from a heavy battery brought up for the purpose — and ran short of ammunition without having broken the earthworks.
2. **So Gough attacked anyway.** His remark on being told the guns were running out is recorded in several versions and all of them amount to: then we will do it with the bayonet.
3. **The assault was extremely costly and it went in.** The entrenchments were carried after prolonged fighting at the parapet.
4. **And then the bridge went.** Whether it broke under the weight of retreating men, or was damaged by the river, or was cut, is disputed and is discussed below.
5. **The Sikh army was destroyed against the water.** Men went into the Sutlej under artillery fire at close range. **The dead are usually put between eight and ten thousand.**

6. British casualties were about two thousand four hundred.

7. Tej Singh had crossed to the far bank early in the action.

THE BRIDGE

The failure of the boat bridge behind the Sikh army is the most serious of all the allegations in this part, and it needs the same care as the others.

What is agreed: the bridge failed at the moment the army needed it, and the destruction of that army followed directly from it. The Sutlej was high; the bridge was under strain; and men and guns were crossing it under fire.

What is alleged: that Tej Singh, having crossed early, had it weakened or cut behind him. This is asserted in a great many accounts and it is entirely consistent with the rest of his conduct.

What can be established: not enough. A boat bridge under that load, in that river, with an army retreating over it, may well have failed on its own.

This book's position is the one it has taken since War Three. **The pattern of Tej Singh's conduct across the whole war requires an explanation and no innocent one has been offered that fits all of it.** Whether he personally destroyed the bridge at Sobraon cannot be proved and will not be asserted here.

What is beyond dispute is the result: the finest army in Asia was penned against a river it could not cross and killed there.

WHY THE BRITISH CARRIED IT

- **Weight of assault.** Gough's method was crude and at Sobraon it worked, because there was nowhere for the defenders to go.
- **The position was a trap for its own garrison.** A bridgehead is only as good as the bridge.
- **Their artillery finally had the range and the metal** for the second half of the battle, when it mattered most.
- **And the Sikh command was on the wrong side of the river.**

WHY THE POSITION WAS INDEFENSIBLE

- **One crossing.** The single decision that made the annihilation possible, and it was made by the men who chose the ground.
- **They could not be reinforced or withdrawn** once the action started.
- **The river was rising.**
- **And nobody was coming.** The rest of the Khalsa army was across the water and did not intervene.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Sham Singh Attariwala

He was about sixty. He had been a sardar under Ranjit Singh, had fought on the frontier, had been sent as an ambassador, and had spent the years after 1839 watching a court he despised murder itself.

He came to Sobraon knowing what it was.

The accounts — Sikh and British both — describe him dressed in white, having taken a vow not to leave the field alive, going through the entrenchments before the battle telling the men what was expected of them.

He fought in the earthworks and he was killed there, with the men who did not cross the bridge.

British officers who wrote about Sobraon afterwards singled him out, which they did not have to do. And the same accounts record the detail that runs through every battle in this part: **at Sobraon, with the position lost, the bridge gone and the river behind them, the Sikh army did not surrender.** Officers describe men walking into the Sutlej under fire rather than laying down arms, and gunners standing at their pieces until they were killed.

The tradition is that his body was recovered from the field and carried home to Attari, and that his wife performed sati.

This book has described a great many last stands — Porus at the Hydaspes, the Shahis on the Indus, forty men in a mud house at Chamkaur, thirty at the Akal Bunga in 1764.

Sham Singh Attariwala is the last one. **After Sobraon there is no independent Punjabi army left to make one, and the four remaining battles in this book are fought by an army that already knows how it ends.**

The Three Treaties, 1846

CERTAIN

The Punjab was not annexed after Sobraon. It was taken apart with paper over the following ten months, which was cheaper and worked better.

WON BY

The East India Company — without another shot being fired

WHEN 9 March 1846 (Lahore); 16 March 1846 (Amritsar); 16 December 1846 (Bhyrowal).	WHERE Lahore, and a village on the Beas.
WHO Sir Henry Hardinge for the Company; the boy Maharaja’s government for the Punjab.	THE EVIDENCE The treaty texts. CERTAIN .

What each one did

- The Treaty of Lahore, 9 March 1846.** The **Jalandhar Doab** — the whole country between the Beas and the Sutlej — was ceded outright. An indemnity of a crore and a half of rupees was imposed. **The Khalsa army was to be reduced to twenty thousand infantry and twelve thousand cavalry**, and thirty-six guns surrendered. A British Resident was installed at Lahore.
- The Treaty of Amritsar, 16 March 1846.** The Durbar could not pay the indemnity. So **Kashmir and the hill country were transferred to Gulab Singh Dogra for seventy-five lakhs** — a Sikh vassal buying a Sikh province from the British with the money the Sikh state owed them.
- The Treaty of Bhyrowal, 16 December 1846.** The one that mattered. **Jind Kaur was removed from the regency**. A Council of Regency of eight sardars was set up, **subject in everything to the British Resident**, who was given full authority over every department. British troops were to garrison Lahore. The arrangement was to last until Duleep Singh came of age in 1854, and the Durbar was to pay for it.

WHY THEY DID NOT ANNEX IN 1846

Hardinge could have taken the Punjab in March 1846 and chose not to. The reasons are entirely practical and worth setting out, because they explain the whole shape of this part.

It would have cost too much. Governing a province of that size, with a hostile population and an undefended Afghan frontier, was an expense the Company did not want.

It would have made them the frontier. A weak Sikh state as a buffer between British India and the Khyber was strategically preferable to a British border on the Indus.

And they could get the substance without the liability. Bhyrowal gave the Resident control of the revenue, the army, the appointments and the succession, while a Sikh government remained nominally responsible for everything that went wrong.

This is the subsidiary alliance system that Part Twelve watched arrive in India, applied to the last independent state on the subcontinent. It had swallowed Hyderabad, Awadh, Mysore and the Maratha houses by the same route: accept a Resident, accept troops, pay for them, and discover in a few years that you are a district.

It took two and a half years here rather than a decade, because in 1848 the Punjab rose.

WHY IT WORKED

- **There was nobody to say no.** The army was destroyed, the regent was being removed, and the Maharaja was eight.
- **The Council of Regency were beneficiaries.** Eight sardars given power they could not otherwise have held, on condition of obedience.
- **The indemnity was the lever.** A debt that cannot be paid converts into whatever the creditor wants.
- **And it looked like a protectorate rather than a conquest,** which mattered in London.

WHY IT PRODUCED A SECOND WAR

- **It humiliated without disarming the population.** Disbanded soldiers went home to villages, with their grievances intact.
- **It removed the one figure with real standing.** Jind Kaur's exile in 1847 was felt as an insult across the province.
- **British officers were now administering revenue districts,** which put them where they could be resented daily.
- **And the sale of Kashmir told everybody exactly what the Punjab was worth to its new managers.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Jind Kaur

She was the daughter of a kennel-keeper at Ranjit Singh's court, the last of his wives, and the mother of his youngest son. In September 1843 she became regent of the Punjab because everybody else was dead.

She was about twenty-six.

She held it for three years, in the worst circumstances any ruler in this book inherits — an army nobody controlled, a court that had murdered five rulers, and a British Agency across the river taking notes. She was not good at it and it is not clear that anybody could have been. Her brother was made wazir and was killed by the army in front of her and her son.

The British removed her from the regency at Bhyrowal in December 1846 and separated her from Duleep Singh in 1847, sending her first to Sheikhpura and then out of the Punjab entirely, to a fort near Benares, with a reduced pension.

The despatches describing her are worth reading for what they reveal about the writers. **She is “intriguing,” “dangerous,” “the only man in the Punjab” — and a good deal worse than that.** British officials of the 1840s had no vocabulary for a woman exercising political power except abuse, and they used all of it.

The abuse is also a measurement. **They took her away from her son at nine years old and moved her a thousand kilometres because they were afraid of what she could do from Lahore.**

In 1849 she escaped from Chunar disguised as a servant and reached Nepal, where she lived in exile for years. In 1861 she was allowed to join Duleep Singh in England — **and it was she who told him what he had signed away at ten years old, which he had never properly understood.** He spent the rest of his life trying to get it back.

She died in 1863. Her ashes were eventually brought home to the Punjab.

Multan, April 1848 — Two Officers at a Gate

CERTAIN

A handover of a governorship went wrong, two British officers were murdered, and the whole province rose. It is the last war in this book fought by Punjabis for the Punjab.

WON BY Nobody — and the British let it spread on purpose

WHEN 19–20 April 1848; Multan falls 22 January 1849.	WHERE Multan, and then Hazara and the Chenab.
WHO Diwan Mulraj, governor of Multan; then Chattar Singh and Sher Singh Attariwala.	THE EVIDENCE Company records, Edwardes’s own account, and the trial papers.

What happened

1. **Mulraj resigned the governorship of Multan** in a dispute over an increased revenue demand from the new administration at Lahore.
2. **A successor was sent, escorted by two young British officers — Patrick Vans Agnew and Lieutenant William Anderson.**
3. **On 19 April they were attacked** at the fort by Mulraj’s soldiers and wounded, and **they were killed the following day.** Whether Mulraj ordered it or was overtaken by his own troops is disputed; he took command of the revolt afterwards either way.
4. **The British did not move.** Gough argued that a campaign in the hot weather was impossible; the Governor-General, **Lord Dalhousie**, agreed to wait until the autumn.
5. **So a young political officer did it himself.** **Herbert Edwardes**, with locally raised forces and Pathan levies, beat Mulraj in the field and shut him up in Multan.
6. **And by then the province had risen.** **Chattar Singh Attariwala** rose in Hazara; his son **Sher Singh Attariwala**, sent to help besiege Multan, went over to the rebels in September and marched north to join his father.
7. **They offered Peshawar to the Afghans** in exchange for support, and **Dost Muhammad Khan sent cavalry.**

THE DELAY, AND WHAT DALHOUSIE WANTED

The five-month pause between the murders in April and the campaign in November is one of the most argued-over decisions of the period, and the argument is not really about the weather.

A quick, small operation in May could probably have contained Multan as a local mutiny. Edwardes, on the spot with improvised forces, very nearly did it alone.

What happened instead was that the revolt had five months to spread, and by November it was a national rising involving the Attariwalas, the disbanded soldiers of the old Khalsa army, and an Afghan alliance.

Dalhousie's own words are the reason historians suspect the delay was not purely logistical. On the outbreak he wrote that the Sikh nation had called for war, and that on his word they should have it — with a vengeance. **His declared intention was annexation, and a local mutiny could not be used to justify it. A national rebellion could.**

This book will not assert that he deliberately let it spread. **It will note that he wanted the outcome that the delay produced, said so in writing, and got it.**

WHY THE PROVINCE ROSE

- **Two years of resentment.** Disbanded soldiers, reduced sardars, a Resident running the government, and British officers in the districts.
- **Jind Kaur's removal and exile,** which was felt as a national humiliation.
- **The sale of Kashmir** to a man widely regarded as having sold the state in the first war.
- **And the army had gone home, not been destroyed.** The men of Ferozeshah and Sobraon were in their villages and came back.

WHY IT COULD NOT SUCCEED

- **No guns.** The artillery of 1845 was gone and could not be replaced.
- **No government.** A rising without a state has no money, no supply and no diplomacy.
- **The Cis-Sutlej states stayed out** — the consequence of the 1809 treaty, forty years later.
- **And the Afghan alliance cost more than it delivered.** Offering Peshawar to Kabul lost the rising support in the very districts that Hari Singh Nalwa had secured.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Multan, for the Last Time

This city has appeared in eight parts of this book and this is its final entry, so here is the whole sequence in one place.

712: an Arab army cuts its water supply and takes it. **1006:** Mahmud fights over it. **1175:** Muhammad of Ghor's conquest of India begins here. **1397:** Timur's grandson besieges it for six months. **1445–1526:** the Langahs make it an independent country. **1772:** the Bhangi misl takes it; **1779:** Timur Shah takes it back. **1818:** Ranjit Singh takes it and Muzaffar Khan dies in the breach. **1848:** two British officers are killed at its gate and a province rises. **1849:** it falls, and its guns free the siege train that wins the war.

Eleven hundred and thirty-seven years, and every single time for the same reason. It sits where the road from Sindh, the road from Khurasan and the road up the Punjab meet. Part Seven called it the city that keeps being the door; Part Twelve counted its owners.

Here it is one last time, and this time what comes through the door is a British siege train coming up from Sindh — from the south, which is the one direction nothing in this book has ever come from before. That is the whole strategic story of 1849 in a sentence. **For five thousand years the Punjab was invaded from the north-west, because that was the only way in.** In 1843 the Company annexed Sindh, and in 1848 they came up the Indus. **The door everybody had watched for fifty centuries was not the one that finally opened.**

Chillianwala, 13 January 1849

CERTAIN

The worst day the British army had in India in that century, fought a few miles from where Alexander crossed the Jhelum — and it nearly ended a Commander-in-Chief’s career and a government’s nerve.

WON BY Both sides claimed it; neither could hold the field; the British counted the cost

WHEN 13 January 1849, from mid-afternoon into darkness.	WHERE Chillianwala, in dense scrub jungle near the Jhelum.
WHO Gough with about twelve thousand, against Sher Singh Attariwala with perhaps thirty thousand.	THE EVIDENCE Very extensive on the British side, including the parliamentary row that followed.

What happened

1. **Gough found the Sikh army in thick scrub** where neither artillery nor cavalry could work properly, and where formations lost sight of each other after fifty yards.
2. **He intended to camp and attack in the morning.** Sikh guns opened on his position; he changed his mind and went in late in the afternoon.
3. **There was almost no artillery preparation.** The infantry went forward into the jungle against an entrenched enemy with guns.
4. **It became a confused, disconnected brawl.** Brigades lost direction; one regiment went in without its muskets loaded on an order it should never have been given; units were enfiladed by guns they could not see.
5. **The 24th Foot lost something near half its strength in minutes.** Four guns were lost. **Three regiments lost their colours** — which, in the British army of 1849, was a disgrace of a kind that did not happen.
6. **British casualties were about twenty-three hundred.**
7. **Both armies stayed on the ground for two days and then both withdrew.** Gough claimed a victory; Sher Singh claimed a victory; and neither claim was worth much.

WHAT CHILLIANWALA DID IN LONDON

The despatch reached England in February 1849 and caused something close to panic.

Twenty-three hundred casualties, lost guns and lost colours was not the news the British public expected from India. The Duke of Wellington was consulted. The government decided that Gough had to go, and **Sir Charles Napier — the conqueror of Sindh — was sent out to replace him.**

Napier arrived in May, by which time the war had been over for three months, and the replacement was never made.

The row afterwards was about Gough's tactics and it was justified. **His method was the frontal assault; he distrusted long bombardments; and he had now spent four years applying it against the best artillery in Asia.** Mudki, Ferozeshah, Sobraon and Chillianwala had cost him a number of casualties that a European army would have found difficult to explain.

The other half of the explanation is the one the row did not want to state. The reason those battles cost what they did is that the enemy was extremely good, and had been for four years, and had now been beaten twice and come back.

Six weeks after Chillianwala, at Gujrat, Gough fought a battle the way Harry Smith had fought Aliwal — **guns first, for three hours, and then the advance.** It cost him under a thousand men and won the war. He had known how to do it the whole time.

WHY THE SIKHS HELD

- **The ground.** Dense scrub is the worst possible terrain for a regular army and the best for a defender who knows it.
- **Their artillery was well sited** and could not be located from the front.
- **Sher Singh Attariwala was a real commander** — the first the Khalsa army had had since 1845 who was actually trying to win.
- **And they were fighting for their own country** in a war their government had not started.

WHY IT CHANGED NOTHING

- **They could not follow up.** No reserve, no supply and no second army.
- **Multan fell nine days later,** freeing a siege train and fifteen thousand men to join Gough.
- **The British could replace two thousand men.** The Sikhs could not replace anything.
- **And the Afghan cavalry was of no use in a jungle fight.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Same River

Chillianwala is fought a few miles from where this book's second part is set. **In 326 BCE, Alexander of Macedon crossed the Jhelum in a thunderstorm, upstream and at night, and beat Porus on the far bank** — the battle of the Hydaspes, and one of the most studied engagements in military history. Part Two described it: the elephants turning on their own line, the king fighting on after his army had gone, and the exchange afterwards about how he wished to be treated.

In January 1849, on the same stretch of river, a British army fought the last full-scale battle of the last independent Indian state.

Two thousand one hundred and seventy-five years apart. Both times an army from far away, with better organisation and a professional command structure, against a Punjabi army fighting on its own ground. Both times the Punjabi side fought well enough that the winner's own account is full of respect, and both times it made no difference to the outcome. And both times the fighting turned on the same thing, which this book has been counting since Part Two: **whether an army can go on functioning when the plan has come apart.**

There is a monument at Chillianwala with the names of the British dead on it. There is nothing on that ground for Porus, and nothing for the men of the Khalsa army killed there in 1849 either.

Two of the most consequential battles ever fought on Punjabi soil, on the same river, and the province they were fought over has one obelisk between them, put up by the people who won the second one.

Gujrat, 21 February 1849 — The Battle of the Guns

CERTAIN

Six weeks after the worst day of his career, Gough fought the way he should have fought all along, and it took an afternoon.

WON BY The British — decisively, and cheaply, and it ended the war

WHEN 21 February 1849.	WHERE Gujrat, on the plain between the Chenab and the Jhelum.
WHO Gough with about twenty-four thousand and ninety guns, against Sher Singh and Chattar Singh with perhaps fifty thousand and about sixty.	THE EVIDENCE Detailed British accounts; the tactical narrative is clear and undisputed.

What happened

1. **Multan had fallen on 22 January** and its besieging force — with the heavy siege train — had come north and joined Gough. For the first time in the war he had proper artillery superiority.
2. **He used it.** The battle opened with a bombardment of something close to three hours, methodically, before a man moved forward.
3. **The Sikh guns were silenced or destroyed** in the counter-battery work, which is what had never happened at Ferozeshah or Chillianwala.
4. **Then the infantry advanced** across open ground, in order, with the guns moving up in support.
5. **The Sikh army broke and was pursued** — properly, for the first time in either war, by fresh cavalry.
6. **Dost Muhammad Khan’s Afghan cavalry, on the Sikh side, was driven off** and pursued to the Khyber.
7. **British casualties were under a thousand.** The Sikh army ceased to exist as a fighting force.

THE LESSON, ARRIVING FOUR YEARS LATE

Set Gujrat beside the four battles that came before it, because the contrast is the whole argument.

Ferozeshah: attack late in the day with insufficient bombardment against entrenchments and guns. Two thousand four hundred casualties, and the war nearly lost in a night.

Sobraon: two hours of bombardment, ammunition exhausted, then the bayonet. Two thousand four hundred casualties.

Chillianwala: almost no bombardment at all, into scrub. Twenty-three hundred casualties, four guns and three colours lost.

Aliwal, and then Gujrat: guns first, thoroughly, then advance. Under six hundred and under a thousand respectively, and both decisive.

Gough had watched Harry Smith demonstrate it in January 1846 and did not adopt it until February 1849, after Parliament had decided to sack him.

And here is what that arithmetic actually measures. The reason the frontal assault was so expensive in this particular war, and had not been in China or Spain, is that the Khalsa army's artillery was the best any British force had faced in Asia. **Gough's tactics did not become correct at Gujrat; the Sikh guns became fewer.** Four years of attrition, and finally a three-to-one superiority in metal, is what changed.

WHY GUJRAT WAS DECISIVE

- **Artillery superiority, used properly.** Ninety guns against sixty, and three hours to work with.
- **Open ground.** The plain suited the side with more guns and better cavalry, and both were British.
- **The Multan siege train.** The delay of 1848 cost the British the autumn; the fall of Multan gave them the war.
- **And they pursued.** Which turned a defeat into a dissolution.

WHY THE SIKH ARMY COULD NOT SURVIVE IT

- **Its guns were gone,** destroyed at Ferozeshah and Sobraon and never replaced.
- **It had no base.** Lahore was in British hands and had been for three years.
- **It had no government, no treasury and no ally that mattered.**
- **And there was nowhere left to go.** Sindh in the south, the British in the east, and Afghans in the west who had come for Peshawar rather than for them.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Three Hours

There is a detail about Gujrat that deserves more than it usually gets, and it is about what the three hours of bombardment were actually doing.

The counter-battery work at Gujrat was aimed at the Sikh gun line, and it was thorough. British accounts describe the Sikh artillery being systematically located and destroyed piece by piece before a single infantry battalion moved.

And the same accounts record what the Sikh gunners did about it, which was nothing different from what they had done at Mudki and Ferozeshah and Sobraon. **They stayed with their guns.**

Four battles across four years, every British account, the same observation in almost the same words: **the gunners were killed at their pieces.**

By February 1849 those men knew everything. They knew the state had been sold twice over. They knew what Tej Singh had done at Ferozeshah and what had happened to the bridge at Sobraon. They knew the guns they were serving were outnumbered three to one and were being taken apart methodically by an enemy they could not reach.

They stayed anyway.

This book has looked for the voice of ordinary Punjabis for fourteen parts and found perhaps five instances of it — a coin legend, a hymn, a couplet about a sickle, two men who set up a toll post to prove they existed.

The last one is a set of casualty observations in the despatches of the men who killed them, repeated four times because the writers could not get over it, and it is the only record we have of what those gunners thought was worth doing.

Rawalpindi, March 1849 — The Surrender

CERTAIN

The Khalsa army laid down its arms, and one of the men doing it said the sentence that this whole part is about.

WON BY The British — the last army of an independent Punjab dissolves

WHEN	WHERE
12–14 March 1849.	Near Rawalpindi.
WHO	THE EVIDENCE
Chattar Singh and Sher Singh Attariwala, surrendering to Sir Walter Gilbert.	British eyewitness accounts, several of them by officers present.

What happened

1. Gilbert pursued the remains of the army north-west after Gujrat, allowing it no chance to reassemble.
2. The Attariwalas asked for terms and were given personal safety and nothing else.
3. The army came in and gave up its weapons over several days — perhaps twenty thousand men, with what artillery it had left.
4. The Afghan contingent was pursued to the Khyber and out of it, and Peshawar was retaken.
5. The men were disarmed and sent home.

THE SENTENCE

British officers who watched the surrender at Rawalpindi wrote about it, and several of them recorded the same detail.

The soldiers came forward, laid their weapons on the pile, and went. Many of them were veterans of Ranjit Singh's campaigns — men who had been at Multan in 1818 or Nowshera in 1823 or on the frontier with Hari Singh Nalwa. Some of them, according to the accounts, kissed their swords before putting them down. Some wept.

And one old soldier, laying down his arms, is recorded as saying: *Aj Ranjit Singh mar gaya.*

Today Ranjit Singh has died.

He had died ten years earlier, in his bed at Lahore, and the man saying it knew that perfectly well.

It is one of the great lines in this book and it belongs to somebody whose name nobody wrote down.

WHY THE SURRENDER WAS COMPLETE

- **There was nothing to fight for.** Lahore was British, the Maharaja was a child in British custody, and the government had been a British department for three years.
- **The guns were gone.**
- **The Afghans had left,** and had never been fighting for the Punjab.
- **And Gilbert did not give them time.** A pursuit that never stops prevents an army from becoming an army again.

WHAT WAS NOT DESTROYED

- **The men.** Twenty thousand trained soldiers went home to their villages, and eight years later the British recruited from exactly those villages for the fighting of 1857.
- **The reputation.** Every British officer who fought in these two wars carried the same opinion for the rest of his career, and it shaped Indian army recruitment for a century.
- **And the memory.** Which is Parts Fifteen and Sixteen.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What “Today” Meant

Take that sentence seriously as a piece of historical analysis, because it is one.

“Today Ranjit Singh has died.”

The man who said it was standing in a field near Rawalpindi in March 1849, putting a weapon on a pile. He was not confused about the date of the Maharaja’s funeral. What he was saying is that the thing Ranjit Singh had built — the state, the army, the independence, the forty years — ended at that moment and not in June 1839.

And he was right, and this book’s argument agrees with him.

Part Thirteen said that Ranjit Singh restored the single point of failure the Khalsa had spent a century engineering out of itself, and that everything followed from it. That was a judgement about institutions. This is the same judgement, made by somebody who was there, in six words.

But notice the other half of it, which is the more remarkable claim. **He is saying that for ten years after the Maharaja’s death, the thing was still alive** — through the court murders, the panchayats, the betrayal at Ferozeshah, the bridge at Sobraon, the treaties, the exile of the regent, and the rising of 1848.

Through all of that, as long as there was an army of the Khalsa in the field, something of it was still standing.

What ended at Rawalpindi was not a dynasty and not a battle. It was the last armed force in India that belonged to nobody but the country it came from.

After March 1849 there is not another one, anywhere on the subcontinent, until 1947.

29 March 1849 — A Ten-Year-Old Signs CERTAIN

In a room in Lahore Fort, a boy who had been Maharaja since he was five gave away a kingdom and a diamond, and did not understand what either of them was.

WON BY

The East India Company — the last independent state in India is annexed

WHEN 29 March 1849.	WHERE Lahore Fort.
WHO Duleep Singh, aged ten, and the Governor-General, Lord Dalhousie.	THE EVIDENCE The document itself. CERTAIN.

The terms

1. **The Maharaja renounced all claim to sovereignty** for himself and his heirs.
2. **All property of the state was confiscated** in settlement of the debt and the costs of the war.
3. **The Koh-i-Noor was to be surrendered to the Queen of England.** It is in the treaty, as a separate article, by name.
4. **He was to receive a pension** and to be treated with respect, on condition that he obeyed the British government and lived wherever it chose.
5. **And the Punjab became a British province**, administered by a Board under Henry and John Lawrence.

DULEEP SINGH

He was born in 1838, made Maharaja at five, separated from his mother at nine, and signed away his kingdom at ten.

He was then removed from the Punjab entirely. Placed in the care of a British doctor and his wife at Fatehgarh, hundreds of miles away, he was converted to Christianity at fifteen and sent to England at sixteen, where he became a favourite of Queen Victoria, was painted by Winterhalter, bought an estate in Suffolk and became one of the best game shots in England.

He did not properly understand what had been taken from him until **he was reunited with his mother in 1861** and she told him. He was twenty-three.

He spent the rest of his life trying to get it back — petitioning, litigating, reconvertng to Sikhism, and in 1886 attempting to return to India. He was stopped at Aden. He went to Russia to look for support and found none. He died in a hotel room in Paris in 1893, in debt, aged fifty-five.

This book is not going to sentimentalise him. He was not a leader in exile and he never seriously attempted to be one; much of his later life was spent on grievance and money. The Punjab did not rise for him and was never going to.

But the document he signed at ten years old is the legal instrument by which the last independent country on the subcontinent ceased to exist, **and the person who signed it could not have understood a single clause of it.**

WHY THE ANNEXATION HAPPENED

- **Dalhousie had decided on it before the second war started** and said so in writing.
- **The 1848 rising made it defensible.** A rebellion by a protected state is the standard justification, and a local mutiny would not have served.
- **There was nothing left to negotiate with.** No army, no treasury, no government, no adult ruler.
- **And nobody could object.** The Marathas were gone, Mysore was gone, and there was no other Indian power to be alarmed by it.

WHY THE PUNJAB COULD NOT HAVE AVOIDED IT

- **The state killed itself first.** Five rulers in four years; the war was fought by an army whose government had given up on it.
- **The Sutlej treaty of 1809 had fixed the border for thirty-six years** while the Company took everything else in India, and by 1845 there was no other power left to balance against.
- **Sindh in 1843 removed the last protection, which was distance.**
- **And the guns could not be replaced.** Everything after February 1846 was fought on borrowed time.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

The Diamond Goes to London

Follow the stone one last time, because it is the closest thing this book has to a single thread running through five thousand years.

It came out of the Deccan and was in Mughal hands by the seventeenth century, set into the Peacock Throne at Delhi. **Nadir Shah took it in 1739** — Part Ten — and carried it back up the Grand Trunk Road with the treasury of India, while Sikh bands raided his baggage in the dark. It went to **Ahmad Shah Abdali** in 1747 and down the Durrani line through nine invasions of the Punjab. **Ranjit Singh extorted it from Shah Shuja at Lahore in 1813** — Part Thirteen — and wore it on his arm for twenty-six years.

And in 1849 it was taken out of the Lahore treasury under Article III of a document signed by a ten-year-old, put on a ship, and given to Queen Victoria. It was recut in 1852, losing a large part of its weight, and set in a crown.

It is in the Tower of London.

Every owner of that stone in the last three hundred years acquired it by force from the previous one, and the argument about where it should be now is conducted between four countries with reasonable claims and one that has it.

This book is not going to resolve that. What it will say is this.

The Punjab in these sixteen parts has been invaded, garrisoned, taxed, spent, sacked, partitioned and written about by everybody except itself. **Its independence ran for thirty-six years out of the last thousand.** The one object that stands for all of it is a stone that has been in the possession of a Punjabi ruler for exactly that long, and which was taken away in the same document that took everything else.

What follows in Parts Fifteen and Sixteen is what happens to a country after it has stopped being one. There is a great deal of it, and some of the worst of it is still to come.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

Jun 1839	Ranjit Singh dies. Kharak Singh succeeds and is deposed within months.
5 Nov 1840	Kharak Singh dies — and the same day Nau Nihal Singh, nineteen and capable, is killed when an archway of the Roshnai Gate collapses . Almost nobody believed it.
1841–1842	Chand Kaur holds the regency, is pushed out, and is murdered by her own maidservants in June 1842. Sher Singh takes the throne.
15 Sep 1843	Sher Singh is shot with a gun handed to him for inspection ; his son is killed the same day; and Dhian Singh Dogra is murdered within hours. Duleep Singh, aged five , becomes Maharaja with Jind Kaur as regent.
1841–1845	The army governs . Regimental <i>panchayats</i> negotiate pay, remove officers and make political decisions — and in September 1845 have the wazir executed in front of the boy Maharaja.
1843	The British annex Sindh , putting their territory on a second side of the Punjab, and begin reinforcing the Sutlej frontier.
11 Dec 1845	The Khalsa army crosses the Sutlej under Lal Singh and Tej Singh — both of whom were in communication with the British.
18 Dec 1845	Mudki . A confused evening battle in dust and scrub. Two British generals killed and ~870 casualties. Won by the British — narrowly .
21–22 Dec 1845	Ferozeshah . The hardest battle the British ever fought in India. A night spent among the enemy's guns; Hardinge sends his sword and papers to the rear. On the morning of the 22nd Tej Singh arrives with a fresh army against a beaten enemy and withdraws without attacking . Won by the British — and Hardinge wrote that another such victory would undo them .
28 Jan 1846	Aliwal . Harry Smith fights the one clean battle of the war — guns first, then the advance — and takes sixty-seven Sikh guns. Won by the British .
10 Feb 1846	Sobraon . The Khalsa army is destroyed in a bridgehead when the bridge behind it fails. Sham Singh Attariwala dies in the entrenchments . Eight to ten thousand Sikh dead. Won by the British — decisively .
Mar 1846	The Treaty of Lahore — the Jalandhar Doab ceded, an indemnity imposed, the army cut to a third. The Treaty of Amritsar — Kashmir sold to Gulab Singh for seventy-five lakhs .
Dec 1846	The Treaty of Bhyrowal . Jind Kaur removed from the regency; a Council of Regency under the British Resident; British troops in Lahore. A protectorate in everything but name .
1847–1848	Jind Kaur is separated from her son and exiled — first to Sheikhpura, then out of the Punjab to Benares.

19–20 Apr 1848	Multan. Vans Agnew and Anderson are murdered at the fort; Diwan Mulraj takes over the revolt. Dalhousie waits five months, and the province rises.
13 Jan 1849	Chillianwala , a few miles from Alexander’s crossing of the Jhelum. Gough attacks into scrub without artillery preparation: ~2,300 casualties, four guns and three colours lost. Won by nobody — and it caused a political crisis in London.
22 Jan 1849	Multan falls , freeing the siege train to join Gough.
21 Feb 1849	Gujrat. Three hours of bombardment, then the advance. Under a thousand British casualties. Won by the British — and the war is over.
12–14 Mar 1849	Rawalpindi. The Khalsa army lays down its arms. An old soldier is recorded saying Aj Ranjit Singh mar gaya — today Ranjit Singh has died.
29 Mar 1849	The Punjab is annexed. Duleep Singh, aged ten, renounces sovereignty and surrenders the Koh-i-Noor by name in Article III. <i>Part Fifteen begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Fifteen

1. **The state died before the army did.** Five rulers murdered in four years, then a regency the British dismantled by treaty, then a rising fought by soldiers whose government had already been replaced. **Part Thirteen argued that Ranjit Singh built a state with no institution capable of surviving him. This is the receipt.**
2. **Conquest by treaty, not by battle.** Lahore in March 1846, Bhyrowal in December 1846, annexation in March 1849 — three documents in three years. **The Company had taken half of India this way before it reached the Sutlej, and Part Twelve watched the method arrive.**
3. **The direction changed.** For five thousand years everything came at the Punjab from the north-west, because that was the only way in. **In 1843 the British annexed Sindh, and in 1848 the siege train that won the war came up the Indus from the south.** The door everybody had watched for fifty centuries was not the one that opened.
4. **The enemy’s despatches are the tribute.** The most generous account any Punjabi army receives in these sixteen parts is written by the officers who destroyed it — because they were explaining to London why a victory had cost so much. **Watch what that reputation becomes after 1849, because it is the reason the British recruit from these villages for the next hundred years.**
5. **And twenty thousand trained soldiers went home.** Disarmed, not destroyed, into the same villages. **Eight years later the British were recruiting from those villages to retake Delhi — and Part Fifteen is what happens when a conquered province becomes the conqueror’s army.**

COMING NEXT — PART FIFTEEN

The Loyal Province, 1849–1919. Seventy years in which the Punjab is annexed, disarmed — and then becomes the most important military recruiting ground in the British Empire. **In 1857 the province that had been conquered eight years earlier holds for the British**, and Punjabi troops take Delhi; this book will ask, carefully, why. Then the machinery: the **canal colonies** that turned the western wastes into the greatest irrigated tract on earth and rearranged who lived where; the Land Alienation Act; the doctrine of the “martial races” and the Punjabization of the Indian Army. And then the reaction: the **Kuka** movement and the men blown from guns in 1872; the agitation of 1907 and Lala Lajpat Rai’s deportation; the **Ghadar** conspiracy carried home from California; the enormous Punjabi contribution to the First World War; and on **13 April 1919, in a walled garden in Amritsar**, the afternoon that ends any argument about what the arrangement had been.

Words Used in This Part

Panchayat

A committee, traditionally of five. In the Khalsa army after 1841, the elected regimental committees that negotiated pay, removed officers and made political decisions.

Durbar

The court, and by extension the government of Lahore. British despatches use “the Lahore Durbar” to mean the Sikh state.

Wazir

Chief minister. Between 1839 and 1845 the office was held by six men, of whom four were murdered.

Resident

The senior British political officer at an Indian court. After Bhyrowal in December 1846 the Resident at Lahore controlled every department of the Sikh government.

Subsidiary alliance

The Company’s principal instrument of expansion: a ruler accepts British troops, pays for them, and surrenders his foreign policy. Conquest by treaty.

Jalandhar Doab

The country between the Beas and the Sutlej, ceded outright by the Treaty of Lahore in March 1846.

Cis-Sutlej states

The Sikh states east of the Sutlej — Patiala, Nabha, Jind — under British protection since 1809, and which stayed out of both wars.

Bridgehead

A fortified position held on the enemy’s side of a river. The Sikh position at Sobraon was one, with a single boat bridge behind it.

Counter-battery

Artillery fire directed at the enemy’s guns rather than at his troops. Its absence explains Ferozeshah and Chillianwala; its presence explains Aliwal and Gujrat.

Colours

A regiment’s flags, carried into battle and defended absolutely. Three British regiments lost theirs at Chillianwala, which is why the news caused the crisis it did.

Ghorchurra

The irregular cavalry inherited from the misl period, still serving alongside the regular army in both wars.

Attariwala

The house of Attari, near Amritsar. Sham Singh died at Sobraon; Chattar Singh and his son Sher Singh led the rising of 1848.

Aj Ranjit Singh mar gaya

“Today Ranjit Singh has died” — recorded as said by an old soldier laying down his weapon at Rawalpindi in March 1849.

Sources used for this part

- British official despatches and campaign records of both wars, including Gough's and Hardinge's
- The treaty texts — Lahore and Amritsar (March 1846), Bhyrowal (December 1846), and the terms of annexation (March 1849)
- British Residency and Ludhiana Agency correspondence, 1839–1849
- Regimental histories and officers' memoirs, including eyewitness accounts of Ferozeshah, Sobraon, Chillianwala and the surrender at Rawalpindi
- **Herbert Edwardes**, *A Year on the Punjab Frontier*, for the Multan rising of 1848
- The *Umdat-ut-Tawarikh* of Sohan Lal Suri and other Persian court records of the Lahore Durbar for the succession crisis
- Papers relating to the removal and exile of Jind Kaur; and to Duleep Singh's later life
- Standard modern histories of the Anglo-Sikh wars and of the fall of the Sikh kingdom

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: whether Nau Nihal Singh was murdered inside the fort on 5 November 1840; the exact extent and intention of Lal Singh's and Tej Singh's dealings with the British; whether the bridge at Sobraon was cut or simply failed; whether Mulraj ordered the killings at Multan or was carried by his own troops; and the casualty figures at Sobraon, which range widely.

Three things about method.

First, **the betrayal question is handled by separating what is documented from what is inferred, and saying which is which.** The communications with British officers are established. The conduct at Ferozeshah and Sobraon requires an explanation. No innocent explanation has been offered that accounts for both. That is as far as the evidence goes and this part does not go further, because a charge of that gravity should not be asserted more confidently than it can be proved.

Second, **most of the narrative here is British and it is read as an enemy's account.** Its generosity about Sikh soldiers is genuine and it also served a purpose — explaining to London why victories cost what they did. Both things are true and the part says so on the page.

Third, **this is a defeat and it has been written as one.** The Punjab lost these wars, and it lost them partly because of British power and distance and Sindh and artillery, and partly because its own court murdered five rulers in four years and its own commanders would not fight. **A history that blames only the winner is a comfort, not an explanation.**

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART FIFTEEN OF SIXTEEN

The Loyal Province

Seventy years in which the Punjab is conquered, disarmed, irrigated and turned into the recruiting ground of an empire — and then, on a spring afternoon in a walled garden, told exactly what the arrangement had been worth.

1849 — 1919

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Part With No Battles

For fourteen parts this book has been about armies. This one has almost none, and it is the part where more happened to the Punjab than in any of them.

After March 1849 there is no Punjabi state, no Punjabi army and nobody left to fight anybody.

What replaces them is a different kind of history and it needs a different kind of chapter. **The events in this part are a land settlement, an irrigation scheme, a recruitment policy, a law about who may buy a field, a movement of a million people from the east of the province to the west — and, at the end, ten minutes of rifle fire in an enclosed garden.**

None of that is a war in the sense the previous fourteen parts have used the word. **All of it did more to determine what the Punjab is today than Tarain, Panipat or Sobraon.**

Four things to hold on to

- **The province that was conquered in 1849 was fighting for the conquerors by 1857.** Eight years. This book is going to explain why without either celebrating it or pretending it did not happen, because both are easier than the truth.
- **The Punjab became the empire's army.** By 1914 a province with about seven or eight per cent of India's population was supplying **somewhere around half the Indian Army**. That was a deliberate policy, it was justified by a theory that was nonsense, and it reshaped who owned land, who got pensions, and who thought of themselves as what.
- **The western Punjab was rebuilt from nothing.** The canal colonies turned scrub grazing into the largest irrigated tract on earth and moved hundreds of thousands of people west into it. **In 1947 every one of them had to move back, or die.**
- **And the categories were invented here.** "Agricultural tribes," "martial races," separate electorates — administrative boxes drawn between 1857 and 1919, which hardened into the identities that tore the province apart in Part Sixteen.

HOW THIS PART IS GOING TO TALK ABOUT 1857 AND 1919

Two events here are used as arguments by people who are not really interested in the seventeenth or the nineteenth century, and this book will handle both the same way it handled Parts Nine and Fourteen.

1857 is not a moral failure and it is not a triumph. The Punjab did not rise, and the reasons are specific, local and mostly obvious once stated. Some of them do the province credit and some do not, and the holding of the province involved a level of state terror that is usually left out. All of it is on the page.

Jallianwala Bagh will be stated and not dramatised. The facts are appalling enough without assistance, and **the single most damning source is the testimony the officer responsible gave in his own defence.** This part quotes him rather than describing the dead.

The labels work as before. **CERTAIN**, **LIKELY**, **STORY** — though in this part almost everything is **CERTAIN**, because there are census returns, revenue records, court transcripts, commissions of inquiry, newspapers and photographs.

The Board of Administration, 1849–1857

CERTAIN

The first thing they did was take away the weapons. The second was to build roads. Both were the same policy.

WHAT HAPPENED

A conquered province was administered better than it was governed

WHEN 1849–1857.	WHERE The whole province, run from Lahore.
WHO Henry Lawrence, John Lawrence and a small group of officers who became famous as the “Punjab School.”	THE EVIDENCE Revenue records, settlement reports and administration reports. CERTAIN throughout.

What they did

- 1. Disarmament.** The first and largest operation. Weapons were collected across the province in enormous quantities — the figures run well over a hundred thousand pieces in the first years — and possession was restricted. **A province that had been under arms for a century and a half was stripped of them in about three.**
- 2. The army was pensioned rather than persecuted.** Officers of the old Khalsa army were given allowances; some sardars kept estates; and **many soldiers were re-enlisted into new British-officered Punjabi regiments almost immediately.**
- 3. A land settlement.** Revenue was assessed district by district, generally at rates lower than the Durbar had demanded in its last years, and — crucially — **proprietary right was recorded in the names of the men who actually cultivated.**
- 4. Public works.** The Grand Trunk Road was metalled and bridged. The Bari Doab Canal was begun. The railway reached Lahore and then Multan.
- 5. And a style of government.** District officers with very wide personal discretion, riding their districts, settling disputes on the spot, keeping the paperwork minimal. It was called the non-regulation system, and its practitioners were proud of it.

THE TWO LAWRENCES, AND WHAT THEY WERE ARGUING ABOUT

The Board that ran the Punjab from 1849 contained two brothers who disagreed about everything that mattered, and the disagreement is worth understanding because both sides of it turn up again in Part Sixteen.

Henry Lawrence wanted to conciliate the old order. Keep the sardars, leave them their estates and their standing, and govern through them — on the view that a landed aristocracy is what holds a countryside quiet and that the men who had fought at Sobraon were worth having on your side.

John Lawrence wanted to govern the peasantry directly. Cut out the intermediaries, assess the cultivator, record his right, take his revenue, and let the sardars find their own level — on the view that a contented smallholder is worth more than a resentful nobleman and considerably cheaper.

John won. The Board was dissolved in 1853, Henry was sent to Rajputana, and John became Chief Commissioner. He was still there in 1857.

The consequence runs through the rest of this part. **The British in the Punjab dealt with the peasantry, and the peasantry is what they recruited, irrigated, protected by law and eventually depended on.** Everything from the Land Alienation Act to the martial-races doctrine to the recruitment machinery of 1914 follows from a decision taken about administrative method in 1853.

Henry Lawrence died at Lucknow in July 1857, in the Residency, under siege.

WHY IT WORKED AS ADMINISTRATION

- **It was cheap and light at the point of contact.** Fewer officials, less paper, quicker decisions.
- **The revenue demand was moderate** after a decade of a bankrupt Durbar squeezing the districts.
- **It recorded rights.** A cultivator with a document has something to lose and something to defend.
- **And it absorbed the old army** instead of leaving twenty thousand trained and hungry men in the villages.

WHAT IT WAS ACTUALLY FOR

- **Pacification.** Every item on the list is a security measure wearing the clothes of good government.
- **The paternalism was real and so was the arbitrariness.** A district officer with wide discretion is benevolent or not depending entirely on which officer you get.
- **It removed the province's capacity to resist** — that was the point of the disarmament, and it worked.
- **And within eight years the province was being used to reconquer India.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Weapons

Between 1849 and about 1852 the new government collected weapons across the Punjab, and the returns are among the most eloquent documents of the period.

Muskets, matchlocks, swords, spears, shields, pistols, and — from the fort at Lahore and the arsenals — the artillery. **The gun foundry that Ranjit Singh had built was closed. The pieces that had been cast in it were taken away.**

The totals run to well over a hundred thousand items, and that is only what was surrendered.

Now consider what this book has spent five parts describing. **The Punjab between 1710 and 1849 was the most heavily armed society in India** — a province where the peasantry rode, where a village kept its own weapons, where twelve independent governments maintained cavalry, and where a movement had survived thirty years of persecution because the men in the forests had horses and swords.

In three years all of it was on a pile.

And the second half of the policy is the part that makes it interesting rather than merely brutal. **The government that had disarmed the province immediately began re-arming a selected part of it, in uniform, under British officers, for its own purposes.** Punjabi regiments were being raised almost before the surrendered weapons had been counted.

That is the arrangement of the next seventy years in a sentence: no arms for the province, and a rifle for anybody willing to carry it for the empire.

Eight years later it was tested, and it held.

1857 — The Province That Held

CERTAIN

Eight years after being conquered, the Punjab supplied the troops that retook Delhi. The reasons are specific and some of them are ugly.

WON BY

The British — and the Punjab is why

WHEN May 1857 to September 1857.	WHERE The Punjab cantonments — Mian Mir, Ferozepur, Peshawar — and then Delhi.
WHO John Lawrence, Herbert Edwardes, John Nicholson, and roughly thirty-four thousand newly raised Punjabi troops.	THE EVIDENCE Extensive on both sides; the Punjab administration’s own records are unusually candid.

Why the Punjab did not rise — six reasons, all real

- The rebels were the men who had conquered the Punjab.** The Bengal Army sepoys who mutinied were largely Purbias — high-caste Hindus from Awadh and Bihar. **They were the infantry at Mudki, Ferozeshah and Sobraon eleven years earlier.** To a Punjabi village, they were not liberators; they were the occupying garrison.
- Delhi was not a symbol worth fighting for.** The rebellion made the Mughal emperor its figurehead. **This book has spent six parts describing what the Punjab’s relationship with Mughal Delhi had been,** and Part Twelve described Sikh armies occupying the Red Fort in 1783 and going home.
- The disarming was immediate and ruthless.** The Bengal regiments in the Punjab were disarmed within days — at Lahore on 13 May, at Ferozepur, at Peshawar on 22 May — before they could act.
- The Cis-Sutlej chiefs backed the British.** Patiala, Nabha, Jind and Kapurthala supplied troops and secured the Grand Trunk Road. They had been British protectorates since 1809 — Part Thirteen’s Treaty of Amritsar, paying out forty-eight years later.
- There was money in it.** Recruitment was open, immediate and paid, into a province with twenty thousand disbanded soldiers and no employment for them.
- And the province had been governed reasonably for eight years.** A moderate revenue settlement and a recorded title are not affection, but they are a reason not to gamble.

THE PART THAT IS USUALLY LEFT OUT

The Punjab was also held by terror, and the record of it is in the administration's own files.

Disarmed sepoys who tried to escape were hunted down and killed in large numbers. Villages that sheltered them were punished. Executions were public and were conducted by blowing men from the mouths of guns — a method chosen because of what it did to a watching crowd.

At Ajnala, near Amritsar, in the summer of 1857, a deputy commissioner named Frederic Cooper captured a body of some hundreds of sepoys of a disarmed regiment and had them killed without trial. A large number were shot in batches; others died of suffocation in the building where they had been confined overnight. The bodies were put down a dry well. **Cooper published his own account of it and was not ashamed of it,** and the figure he gives is two hundred and eighty-two.

The well was located and excavated in 2014 and the remains were recovered.

That is what “the Punjab remained quiet” means when you look underneath it, and any account of 1857 in this province that does not include it is not describing the same event.

WHAT THE PUNJAB SUPPLIED

- **Manpower.** Some thirty-four thousand new levies raised during 1857 — Sikhs, Punjabi Muslims, Pathans and Dogras.
- **The Movable Column** under John Nicholson, which policed the province and then marched on Delhi.
- **The siege train.** The heavy guns that finally breached Delhi came down from the Punjab in September.
- **And the Grand Trunk Road,** held open the whole way, which is the whole campaign.

WHAT IT COST THE PROVINCE

- **A reputation that became a cage.** After 1857 the Punjab was the loyal province, and everything that followed was built on that assumption.
- **The executions.** Ajnala is the worst-documented case and it was not the only one.
- **And Delhi.** The sack of the city in September 1857, the executions, the expulsion of the population — Punjabi troops were part of an operation that gutted the capital.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Eight Years

In February 1846, at Sobraon, the Bengal Native Infantry went into the Sikh entrenchments and killed several thousand men in a bridgehead against a river.

In September 1857, at Delhi, Punjabi troops raised in the villages of those dead men went up the breach beside British regiments to retake the capital from the Bengal Native Infantry.

Eleven years and seven months.

It is tempting to make this a story about betrayal and it is not one. The men who enlisted in 1857 were not betraying anybody, because there was nobody left to betray. The Sikh state had been dead for eight years, its Maharaja was a schoolboy in England, and the alternative on offer was a restored Mughal empire at Delhi run by the army that had conquered them.

What they were doing was what soldiers without a country have always done, in every part of this book. **Part Five described Hindu Shahi troops in the armies of Ghazni. Part Seven described Punjabi contingents in every Delhi army that came through. Part Nine described Pathan mercenaries in the pay of a Guru.**

An army is a livelihood before it is anything else, and a province that has just been disarmed and has twenty thousand unemployed veterans in it will sell that livelihood to whoever is buying.

What is worth noticing is what the British concluded from it — because they concluded the wrong thing, deliberately, and built seventy years of policy on it.

They did not conclude that the Punjab had made a calculation. **They concluded that Punjabis were naturally loyal and naturally martial, that this was a fact about their blood, and that the empire's armies should henceforth be recruited from here.**

That is War Six, and it is the most consequential mistake anybody makes in this part.

The Frontier, 1849–1898

CERTAIN

Fifty years, more than sixty punitive expeditions, two invasions of Afghanistan and one line drawn on a map that is still causing trouble.

WON BY Nobody — the same answer this book has given four times already

WHEN 1849–1898, continuously.	WHERE The hills west of the Indus — Swat, Buner, Tirah, the Khyber, Waziristan.
WHO The Punjab Frontier Force, largely recruited in the Punjab, against the Pashtun tribes.	THE EVIDENCE Campaign records and despatches for every one of them.

What happened, for fifty years

1. **A force was raised for the job.** The Punjab Frontier Force — known as the Piffers — was created in 1849, recruited heavily in the Punjab, and spent half a century on the same ground.
2. **The expeditions never stopped.** More than sixty punitive operations between 1849 and 1900: burn the villages, destroy the towers, take the hostages, extract the fine, withdraw before winter. **Then do it again.**
3. **Ambela, 1863,** was the worst of the early ones — a campaign that was supposed to take a fortnight and turned into two months of hard fighting for a rock outcrop that changed hands repeatedly.
4. **The Second Afghan War, 1878–1881,** was launched from the Punjab. It produced Maiwand, the march from Kabul to Kandahar, and — like the first — a British withdrawal from a country nobody could hold.
5. **The Durand Line, 1893.** A boundary was agreed between British India and the Amir of Afghanistan and drawn across the map. **It ran straight through the Pashtun tribal country, dividing it.**
6. **And in 1897 the whole frontier rose at once** — Malakand, the Khyber, Tirah — in the largest operation the British had yet mounted there, involving tens of thousands of troops.

THE FIFTH EMPIRE TO REACH THE SAME CONCLUSION

Set this beside what this book has already recorded about the same country.

Part Eight, 1586: a Mughal column is destroyed in the Karakar Pass and eight thousand die, including Akbar's closest friend. Akbar's answer afterwards is roads, forts and subsidies.

Part Nine, 1672: a Mughal army is destroyed in the Khapash Pass. Aurangzeb comes to Hasan Abdal for eighteen months. His answer is roads, forts and subsidies.

Part Thirteen, 1823–1837: Ranjit Singh takes Peshawar, garrisons the mouth of the Khyber at Jamrud, and never attempts to occupy the hills.

Part Fifteen, 1849–1898: the British spend fifty years, sixty expeditions and an unquantifiable amount of money, and arrive at roads, forts and subsidies.

Four empires. Three centuries. The same answer, reached independently each time after losing men to learn it.

And there is a fifth entry that this book will note and not elaborate on, because it is not history yet. **Two more great powers went into that country in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries and came out again, and the Durand Line drawn in 1893 is still disputed.**

WHY IT COULD NEVER BE FINISHED

- **The ground.** Defiles, no capital, no army to destroy, nothing to besiege — every reason this book has given since Part Five.
- **Punitive expeditions punish and do not govern.** Burning a village creates a grievance and removes nothing.
- **The Durand Line made it worse** by giving every tribe a border to cross and two governments to play off.
- **And the tribes only had to still be there,** which is the oldest rule in this book.

WHAT THE PUNJAB GOT OUT OF IT

- **Fifty years of employment.** The Frontier Force was a career, and it ran on Punjabi recruits.
- **A permanent military establishment** in the province, which is a large economy.
- **And a reputation, reinforced annually,** that fed directly into the martial-races policy of War Six.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Line

In November 1893, Sir Mortimer Durand and the Amir Abdur Rahman Khan signed an agreement at Kabul fixing the boundary between Afghanistan and British India.

The document is short. The line runs some two and a half thousand kilometres, from the Wakhan corridor to the Persian border, and **it was drawn to define spheres of influence rather than to divide a people.**

What it actually did was cut the Pashtun tribal country in half. Villages, valleys, clans and grazing grounds ended up on opposite sides of a boundary that meant nothing on the ground and a great deal on paper.

The British used it as an administrative convenience and never wholly controlled the territory on their own side of it. Afghanistan has never fully accepted it. **It is still the border between Pakistan and Afghanistan, it is still disputed, and it is still the reason for a large amount of what happens in that region.**

This book has spent fifteen parts on a province defined by a frontier it did not draw, and here is that process at its most literal. **Two men signed a paper in Kabul in 1893, and a hundred and thirty years later people are still being killed along the line they drew.**

The same thing is going to happen to the Punjab itself in Part Sixteen, in 1947, and the man who does it will have five weeks and a set of out-of-date census maps.

The Kukas, 1872

CERTAIN

The first organised resistance in the annexed Punjab was a religious reform movement that boycotted the government forty-five years before anybody called it non-cooperation — and it ended with sixty-six men blown from guns without a trial.

WON BY

The government — and the officer who did it was dismissed for it

WHEN

17–18 January 1872.

WHERE

Malerkotla, in the Malwa — and the movement's centre at **Bhaini Sahib** near Ludhiana.

WHO

The **Namdharis** or **Kukas**, followers of **Satguru Ram Singh**, and **L. Cowan**, Deputy Commissioner of Ludhiana.

THE EVIDENCE

Government records — including the inquiry that ended Cowan's career.

What the Namdharis were

1. **A reform movement inside the Sikh tradition**, led from 1857 by Ram Singh at Bhaini Sahib. The name Kuka comes from the cry raised in their worship.
2. **Their social programme was radical for 1860**. They rejected caste, opposed female infanticide, dowry and child marriage, promoted widow remarriage, and performed inter-caste marriages at a cost of a few paise — a direct attack on the marriage economy of the Punjabi village.
3. **And their political programme was a boycott**. They refused to use British courts, British schools, the British post, and imported cloth — **which is non-cooperation and swadeshi, complete, in the 1860s**. Gandhi launched the same programme in 1920.
4. **Cow protection was central to them**, and it is what produced the crisis.

What happened

1. **In 1871 Kukas killed butchers at Amritsar and Raikot** over cow slaughter. Those responsible were tried and hanged.

2. **In January 1872 a body of about a hundred and fifty Kukas attacked the fort at Malerkotla**, against Ram Singh's instructions. They were beaten off with losses on both sides and about sixty-eight were captured.
3. **Cowan, the Deputy Commissioner, did not wait for a trial, an order or a superior.** On 17 January he had **forty-nine of the prisoners blown from the mouths of guns** at Malerkotla, in public. **Sixteen more were killed the following day.**
4. **A boy among the prisoners, Bishan Singh, seized Cowan's beard** and was cut down where he stood.
5. **Ram Singh was arrested and deported to Rangoon**, where he remained until his death in 1885. The movement was placed under permanent surveillance.

COWAN WAS DISMISSED

The detail that makes this episode more interesting than a simple atrocity is what the government did afterwards.

Cowan was dismissed from the service. His superior, the Commissioner, was removed from his post. The Government of India took the view that the executions had been carried out without trial, without authority, and without any of the forms of law — and that this was unacceptable.

It was not squeamishness about the deaths. Blowing men from guns was an approved punishment and had been used extensively in 1857. What was unacceptable was that an officer had done it on his own initiative.

Hold that judgement, because the contrast at the end of this part is exact. **In 1872 an official who killed sixty-six people without trial was dismissed. In 1919 an officer who killed several hundred without warning was relieved of command, and a London newspaper raised a subscription of over twenty-six thousand pounds for him.**

Something changed in between, and the change is the subject of the last three sections.

WHY THE STATE REACTED SO VIOLENTLY

- **It was fifteen years after 1857** and any organised Sikh movement was read as a rising in embryo.
- **The boycott was more alarming than the violence.** A movement that tells people not to use the courts or the post is attacking the administration where it lives.
- **Ram Singh had a large following** in exactly the districts the army recruited from.
- **And Cowan panicked**, which is the honest explanation for the manner of it.

WHY THE KUKAS COULD NOT SUCCEED

- **They attacked a state with a monopoly of weapons.** The disarmament of War One had worked.
- **Their leader disowned the attack** and was punished for it anyway.
- **Cow protection narrowed them.** A cause that sets one community against another cannot become a national movement, and this one was already close to the fault line that opens in Part Sixteen.
- **And it was forty years early.** Everything the Kukas did in 1870 became mainstream Indian politics in 1920 and nobody in 1870 was ready for it.

Malerkotla, Again

Of all the places in the Punjab where sixty-six men could have been executed without trial in January 1872, it happened at Malerkotla.

Part Eleven told the story of that town. In December 1704 at Sirhind, when sentence was passed on the two younger sons of Guru Gobind Singh, **the Nawab of Malerkotla is recorded as having spoken against it** — the *haah da naara*, the cry of protest, made by a Muslim nobleman on behalf of two children who were not of his community.

It did not save them. It saved his town. For two centuries afterwards, while Sikh armies took and in some cases destroyed every Afghan-held place in the Malwa — Sirhind twice — **Malerkotla was spared, and the reason given was always the protest of 1704.**

And in 1872 that town was where a British deputy commissioner executed sixty-six Sikhs at the mouths of guns.

This book is not going to draw a lesson out of that, because there isn't a clean one. The Nawab of 1872 had nothing to do with the executions; the Kukas had attacked his fort; Cowan brought his guns to the nearest convenient place. It is a coincidence of geography and not a judgement on anybody.

But it is the kind of coincidence this book has learned to notice. **The Punjab is not a large place, and the same fifty or sixty towns keep appearing in it across five thousand years** — Sirhind nine times, Multan ten, Panipat three, Attock in five separate parts.

Malerkotla appears twice, a hundred and sixty-eight years apart, for opposite reasons. And in 1947, when the districts around it were consumed, it came through comparatively unharmed — **and the explanation offered locally was still a protest made in a courtroom in 1704.**

The Canal Colonies, 1885–1920

CERTAIN

The largest irrigation works in the world were built in the western Punjab, and several hundred thousand people were moved into them. In 1947 all of them had to move back.

WHAT HAPPENED

The physical and demographic remaking of half a province

WHEN Major works from 1885; the colonies settled through to the 1920s.	WHERE The bars — the high scrub plains between the western rivers: the Sandal Bar, the Ganji Bar, the Neeli Bar.
WHO The Punjab Irrigation Department, and colonists drawn from the crowded central districts.	THE EVIDENCE Settlement reports, canal records, census returns. CERTAIN and enormous.

What was built

1. **The Lower Chenab Canal**, from the 1890s, was the largest of them and created the **Chenab Colony** around a new town laid out in 1896 and named **Lyallpur** — now Faisalabad, and one of the biggest cities in Pakistan.
2. **The Lower Jhelum Canal** followed, then the **Lower Bari Doab**, and then the Triple Canals Project, which moved water between river basins on a scale nobody had attempted anywhere.
3. **By the 1920s something like fourteen million acres were under canal irrigation** — the largest contiguous irrigated tract on earth, and it still is.
4. **The population was moved deliberately.** Colonists were recruited from the congested central districts — Amritsar, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Gurdaspur, Sialkot — and given land in the new colonies.
5. **And the grants were categorised.** Peasant grants, yeoman grants, capitalist grants — **and, critically, horse-breeding grants and grants reserved for army pensioners and serving soldiers.**

WHO PAID FOR IT

Three groups paid, and only one of them is usually mentioned.

The people who already lived there. The bars were not empty. They were grazing country, used by pastoral communities — the Janglis — who had lived there for generations and who had no documented title of the kind the new administration recognised. **They were largely dispossessed, and where they were compensated it was on terms that assumed grazing land was waste.**

The rivers. The Indus system was re-engineered to a degree that changed the hydrology of the whole basin, and the consequences — waterlogging, salinity, the exhaustion of groundwater — arrived within decades and are still being managed.

And the colonists themselves, eventually. Every family that moved west between 1890 and 1920 was moving into what became, in August 1947, the wrong country. **The canal colonies are in Pakistan. The colonists were disproportionately Sikhs and Hindus from the eastern districts.**

That is not hindsight being unfair to the engineers. It is a plain statement of what the policy produced: **the most valuable agricultural land in the province, developed at enormous cost, settled by people who would be driven out of it inside fifty years.**

Part Sixteen is largely about those roads, going the other way.

WHY IT WAS DONE

- **Revenue.** Irrigated land pays several times what scrub pays, and the canal colonies became the most profitable investment the Government of India ever made.
- **Famine policy.** After the famines of the 1870s and 1890s, guaranteed irrigated production was a strategic necessity.
- **Relieving congestion** in the central districts, where holdings had been subdivided to the point of unviability.
- **And recruitment.** Land grants tied to military service bound the recruiting base to the government with something more durable than pay.

WHAT IT CHANGED PERMANENTLY

- **Where people lived.** Hundreds of thousands moved west, and the religious composition of whole districts changed with them.
- **Who owned land.** Allocation by category hardened the administrative distinctions of War Six into facts on the ground.
- **The relationship between land and the army,** which is the subject of the next section.
- **And it built the prize that made partition catastrophic in the west.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

A Town Laid Out on a Wheel

Lyallpur was founded in 1896 on empty scrub and named after a departing Lieutenant-Governor.

It was designed, not grown. The plan is a clock tower at the centre with **eight bazaars radiating from it**, laid out to represent the Union Jack — the whole town a diagram of who had built it, drawn on ground where there had been nothing but grazing five years earlier.

Within a generation it was one of the great agricultural markets of northern India: wheat, cotton, an agricultural college, a railway junction, and a population drawn from a hundred and fifty miles away to the east.

Today it is **Faisalabad**, the third-largest city in Pakistan, with several million people in it and a textile industry that clothes a good part of the world. **The clock tower is still there and the eight bazaars still radiate from it.**

Consider what that is, in a book that has spent fifteen parts describing this province.

Almost everything in these sixteen parts is about something being destroyed. Taxila is a ruin. Sirhind was levelled twice and never rebuilt. The Harmandir Sahib was blown up twice. Multan's walls came down. Delhi was sacked four times by armies that came down this road.

The canal colonies are the one thing in this entire history that was built rather than knocked down, and that is bigger now than when it was made.

They were built by a colonial government for its own purposes, on land taken from people who were not consulted, and they were settled by families who lost everything in 1947.

All of that is true at once, and the wheat is still growing.

The Martial Races and the Land Alienation Act

CERTAIN

A theory about blood that was not true, and a law about who could buy a field — and between them they drew the lines that the Punjab was cut along in 1947.

WHAT HAPPENED

Administrative categories became identities

WHEN The doctrine from the 1860s, at its height under Lord Roberts in the 1880s; the Act in 1900.	WHERE The recruiting districts of the central and western Punjab.
WHO The Indian Army, the Punjab administration, and the categories they invented.	THE EVIDENCE Recruiting handbooks, census reports and the text of the Act. CERTAIN

The doctrine

- After 1857 the Indian Army was rebuilt from the ground up.** The Bengal Army had mutinied and was largely dismantled. Recruitment shifted decisively north-west.
- The justification offered was racial.** Certain “races” — Sikhs, Punjabi Muslims, Pathans, Dogras, Gurkhas, some Rajput and Jat groups — were held to be inherently warlike. Others — Bengalis, Madrasis, Marathas — were held not to be. **Recruiting handbooks were published describing the physical and moral characteristics of each.**
- It was nonsense.** The Marathas had fought the British for fifty years. The Bengal Army had conquered the Punjab. The men who had beaten every European army sent against them in the eighteenth century were Marathas and Mysoreans. **The theory was constructed after the fact to justify recruiting from the province that had stayed quiet in 1857.**
- And it had a second purpose that was never stated in the handbooks.** Regiments were organised in class companies and class regiments — by caste and community — **so that the pan-Indian solidarity that produced 1857 could not form again.**
- By 1914 the Punjab supplied something close to half the Indian Army** from around seven or eight per cent of India’s population.

The Act

1. **The Punjab Land Alienation Act of 1900 prohibited the permanent transfer of agricultural land from members of “agricultural tribes” to anybody outside them.**
2. **The stated purpose was to protect the peasantry from the moneylender.** Debt was real, foreclosure was real, and land was passing from cultivators to urban creditors across the province.
3. **The unstated purpose was to protect the recruiting base.** A dispossessed peasantry does not enlist and does not stay loyal, and the government knew exactly which districts its soldiers came from.
4. **And it required the government to define who was an agricultural tribe.** Lists were drawn up, district by district, of which castes and communities qualified.

WHY A LAW ABOUT LAND IS IN A BOOK ABOUT WARS

Because of what the lists did.

Before 1900, “Jat” and “Arain” and “Khatri” and “Arora” were social facts — real, but fluid, local, and negotiable. Families moved between occupations. Categories blurred at the edges.

After 1900 they were legal categories with property rights attached. Whether you could buy a field depended on which box the government had put your community in. Every subsequent census, every land record, every recruiting return reinforced it.

And the boxes correlated with religion. **The “agricultural tribes” of the central and western Punjab were overwhelmingly Muslim and Sikh peasant communities. The excluded moneylending and trading communities were overwhelmingly Hindu.**

So a law intended to keep peasants on their land **put a legal boundary between rural Muslims and Sikhs on one side and urban Hindus on the other, and made it a matter of property.**

Add separate electorates from 1909 — communal rolls, communal seats — and the Punjab entered the twentieth century with its population sorted, counted, listed and legally distinguished by community in every department of government.

This book is not saying the British invented Hindu, Muslim and Sikh identity in the Punjab. It is saying that between 1857 and 1919 those identities were converted from things people were into boxes with rights attached — and that when the province was divided in 1947, the lines were already drawn and the lists already existed.

WHAT THE PROVINCE GAINED

- **Money, on a very large scale.** Army pay, pensions and remittances were the largest cash income in the rural Punjab for seventy years.
- **Land.** Grants in the canal colonies to soldiers and pensioners transferred serious wealth into the recruiting districts.
- **Protection from foreclosure**, which was a real and widespread danger and which the Act genuinely reduced.
- **And a political weight** that the province had not had since 1849, because the government could not afford to alienate it.

WHAT IT COST

- **The province became a garrison.** Its prosperity, its politics and its land tenure all ran through the recruiting office.
- **The categories hardened**, permanently, and were reinforced by every instrument of the state.
- **Communal arithmetic became the basis of politics** from 1909 onwards, which is where Part Sixteen begins.
- **And a theory about blood was taught to the people it was about**, some of whom believed it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Handbooks

The recruiting handbooks of the Indian Army are among the strangest documents produced by the British in India, and they are worth reading because of what they reveal about the people who wrote them.

Each one covers a community — *Sikhs, Punjabi Musalmans, Dogras, Pathans* — and each describes its subject's history, religion, customs, physique and character, with recommendations about which clans and districts produce the best recruits and which should be avoided.

They are careful, detailed, respectful in their way, and completely wrong about the thing they exist to establish. **There is no such thing as a martial race.** There are populations with military traditions, economies that make soldiering attractive, and governments that recruit where it suits them.

What makes the handbooks worth a page in this book is the second-order effect. **They were not only read by British officers. They were read by the communities they described.**

A theory that says your people are natural soldiers, published by the government, taught to your officers, and backed by land grants and pensions, is a flattering thing to be told — and it was told to the Punjab, in print, for sixty years.

This book has spent fifteen parts arguing that **the winner is whoever gets written about.** Here is a variation on it that is harder to see and worse in its effects.

The conqueror also gets to write down what the conquered are, and if he does it long enough and pays for it, they may start quoting it back to him.

1907 — Pagri Sambhal Jatta

CERTAIN

The colonists of the canal colonies discovered what their tenancies actually said, and for the first time since 1849 the government was frightened.

WON BY The agitation — the Viceroy vetoed the bill, which almost never happened

WHEN Spring 1907; the leaders deported in May and released in November.	WHERE The canal colonies, Lyallpur, Rawalpindi and Lahore.
WHO Lala Lajpat Rai and Sardar Ajit Singh, with the colonists and the urban press.	THE EVIDENCE Government records, newspapers, and the text of the bill that was withdrawn.

What caused it

1. **The Punjab Colonization of Land Bill, 1906.** It tightened the terms on which canal-colony land was held — restricting the colonists’ rights to sell, sublet or bequeath as they chose, imposing conditions and fees, and giving the government wide powers to resume grants.
2. **An increase in water rates** on the Bari Doab Canal at the same moment.
3. **And a rise in the land revenue assessment** in several districts.
4. **Together they told the colonists something they had not fully understood:** that after fifteen years of breaking scrub into wheat land, they were tenants of the government rather than proprietors, on terms the government could change.

What happened

1. **The colonies organised.** Meetings, petitions, refusal to pay, and an alliance between the rural colonists and the urban politicians of Lahore that had not existed before.
2. **Lala Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh led it.** Lajpat Rai was an Arya Samaj lawyer and one of the leading nationalists of the period; Ajit Singh was a young radical from Khatkar Kalan whose nephew, **Bhagat Singh**, was born in that year.
3. **There were riots at Rawalpindi** in April.

4. **Both men were deported without trial in May 1907** — to Mandalay, in Burma — under a regulation of 1818.
5. **And the government backed down.** The bill was **vetoed by the Viceroy**; the water rates were revisited; and the two men were released in November.

WHY THE GOVERNMENT BLINKED

The Government of India did not withdraw legislation because of petitions. It did here, and the reason is stated plainly in its own correspondence.

The agitation was in the recruiting districts, and 1907 was the fiftieth anniversary of 1857.

The colonies were full of army pensioners and serving soldiers' families — because War Five's grants had put them there deliberately. Meetings were being attended by men in uniform on leave. **Reports reached Simla that discontent was spreading into the regiments.**

And the whole structure of Indian military power since 1857 rested on the Punjab being reliable. **A province that supplied half the army and was also the centre of an agrarian agitation was an unacceptable combination, and the government paid whatever it cost to break the connection.**

The lesson everybody drew was correct and it shaped the next forty years. **The Punjab's leverage was the army, and the moment the countryside and the barracks started talking to each other, Delhi had to listen.**

It is also the reason the reaction in 1919 was as violent as it was. Michael O'Dwyer had been in the Punjab in 1907, and he had learned exactly the opposite lesson from it.

WHY IT SUCCEEDED

- **It was economic, specific and winnable.** Not a demand for independence — a demand about tenancy terms and water rates.
- **It united town and country,** which colonial administration in the Punjab had been designed to keep apart.
- **It touched the army.** The single fact that made the government move.
- **And the deportations backfired.** Removing two men without trial made them national figures and the case a cause.

WHAT IT DID NOT CHANGE

- **The colonies stayed government land** on government terms, with the worst clauses removed.
- **The recruiting machine was untouched** and seven years later delivered half a million men.
- **And it taught the administration to watch for exactly this** — which is why 1919 was met with maximum force.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Look After Your Turban

The agitation of 1907 produced a song, and the song outlived everything else about it.

It was written by **Banke Dayal**, the editor of a small paper at Jhang, and first sung at a meeting in Lyallpur. Its refrain is three words of Punjabi:

Pagri sambhal, jatta.

Look after your turban, farmer.

The turban is honour, standing and self-respect, and the phrase means: hold on to what you have, because they are taking it. It was aimed at a specific bill about specific tenancies in a specific set of districts, and it became the name of the whole movement.

It is still sung. It has been recorded by every generation of Punjabi singers since, it is used at farmers' demonstrations, and most of the people who know it could not tell you what the Punjab Colonization of Land Bill was.

This book has spent fifteen parts complaining that ordinary Punjabis left no record. The exceptions have been remarkably consistent in form: **a coin legend, a hymn about an invasion, a couplet comparing a governor to a sickle, a letter written to a governor by two men on a road.**

Nearly all of them are short, most of them rhyme, and every one was made by somebody who owned nothing.

The Punjab's own voice in this history is almost entirely in verse, and it is almost entirely about not being pushed off the land.

Ajit Singh went into exile in 1909 and spent thirty-eight years abroad. He came home in 1947 and **died on 15 August, the day India became independent.**

Ghadar, 1913–1915

CERTAIN

Punjabi labourers on the Pacific coast of North America founded a revolutionary party, sailed home to raise a rising, and were betrayed by one man before it began.

WON BY

The government — the rising never happened

WHEN

Party founded **1913**; the rising planned for **21 February 1915**.

WHERE

California and British Columbia, and then the central Punjab.

WHO

Sohan Singh Bhakna, Har Dayal, Kartar Singh Sarabha and several thousand returning emigrants.

THE EVIDENCE

The party's own newspaper, and the transcripts of the conspiracy trials. **CERTAIN**.

How it started

1. **Punjabis went to the Pacific coast for work** from about 1904 — sawmills in British Columbia, farms in California, railway construction. Most were Sikhs from the Doaba districts. By 1913 there were perhaps ten thousand.
2. **They met a wall of racial legislation.** Canada's "continuous journey" regulation of 1908 was designed to exclude Indians without saying so; there were riots against them in Washington state; and they could not vote, own property in some places, or bring their families.
3. **And they noticed the contradiction.** They were British subjects, from the province that supplied half the Indian Army, being treated as unwanted aliens in another part of the same empire.
4. **In 1913 they founded a party at Astoria** and named it after the word for mutiny or revolt: **Ghadar**. Its newspaper was printed in Urdu and Gurmukhi and mailed all over the Indian diaspora.
5. **Its programme was not reform.** It was armed rebellion, and it said so on the front page every week.

The Komagata Maru

1. **In 1914 a Sikh businessman, Gurdit Singh, chartered a Japanese steamer** and sailed from Hong Kong to Vancouver with three hundred and seventy-six passengers, specifically to test the continuous-journey rule.

2. **The ship was held in Vancouver harbour for two months** and the passengers were not allowed to land. Almost all were eventually forced back.
3. **It reached Budge Budge near Calcutta on 29 September 1914.** The authorities tried to put the passengers straight on a train to the Punjab; there was a confrontation; and about nineteen or twenty people were killed.
4. **The episode did more for the Ghadar party than anything it wrote.**

WHY IT FAILED

When war broke out in 1914 the party called its members home, and several thousand went — the estimates run to about eight thousand people returning to India in a few months, many of them intending to raise a rising.

The government knew they were coming. Ships were met at the ports; the Ingress into India Ordinance allowed internment on arrival; hundreds were detained and hundreds more restricted to their villages.

The rising itself was betrayed. A date was fixed for 21 February 1915 — regiments were to be suborned, arsenals seized, and the Punjab raised. An informer inside the conspiracy passed the plan to the police. The date was brought forward and it made no difference; the arrests began before anything started.

What followed were the **Lahore Conspiracy Case** trials, under special tribunals with no appeal. **Some two hundred and ninety-one people were tried; more than forty were sentenced to death and over a hundred transported for life.**

And the honest assessment has to include the other reason it failed. **The Punjab did not rise.** The countryside in 1915 was recruiting, drawing pay and pensions, and about to send half a million men to France and Mesopotamia. A few thousand returned emigrants with a newspaper could not move it.

WHY IT WAS CRUSHED SO EASILY

- **The government was ready.** Surveillance of the party had been running since 1913 through consulates and informers.
- **Wartime powers.** The Defence of India Act of 1915 removed the ordinary protections of trial and appeal.
- **They had no base in the villages.** Returning emigrants were outsiders to the political networks that mattered.
- **And the province was making money out of the war.**

WHY IT MATTERED ANYWAY

- **It was secular and explicitly so.** The party's membership was Sikh, Muslim and Hindu and its literature attacked communal division directly — which almost nothing else in the Punjab of 1913 did.
- **It was the first Punjabi movement to aim at independence rather than redress.**
- **It supplied the next generation with its heroes,** which is the story below.
- **And it convinced the government that the Punjab was dangerous,** which shaped everything about 1919.

Nineteen

Kartar Singh Sarabha was born in a village near Ludhiana and went to California at about fifteen to study. He was in Berkeley when the Ghadar party was founded, worked on its newspaper, learned to set type and to fly, and came home in 1914 to raise a rebellion.

He travelled the Punjab for months trying to suborn regiments and organise the rising. When it collapsed he was arrested, tried in the first Lahore Conspiracy Case, and refused to defend himself — telling the court that he had done what he had done and would do it again.

He was hanged at Lahore Central Jail on 16 November 1915. He was nineteen years old.

Twelve years later a schoolboy from a village forty miles away, whose uncle had been deported in 1907 and who was born in the year of that agitation, began carrying a photograph of Sarabha in his pocket.

His name was **Bhagat Singh**. He was hanged at the same jail in March 1931, aged twenty-three, and he is the most famous revolutionary in modern Indian history.

Follow the chain and it is remarkably short. **The canal colony agitation of 1907 produced Ajit Singh. Ajit Singh's deportation and exile produced a household in which his nephew grew up. The Ghadar trials of 1915 produced Sarabha, and Sarabha's photograph was in that nephew's pocket.**

Three movements, one district, twenty-four years.

This book has repeatedly observed that the Punjab is not a large place. **Its politics in the twentieth century came out of about four districts of the Doaba and the Majha, and a great many of the people involved were related to each other.**

The First World War, 1914–1918

CERTAIN

Half a million men went from one province to fight in France, Mesopotamia, Gallipoli and East Africa, and the province was promised something for it.

WON BY

The Allies — and the Punjab presented its bill in 1919

WHEN

1914–1918.

WHERE

Flanders, Gallipoli, Mesopotamia, Egypt, Palestine, East Africa — and the recruiting offices of every Punjabi district.

WHO

Roughly a **third to a half of all Indian combatants**, raised under **Sir Michael O'Dwyer**, Lieutenant-Governor from 1913.

THE EVIDENCE

Recruitment returns, casualty lists, war memorials.

CERTAIN

The numbers

1. **India sent well over a million men overseas.**
2. **The Punjab supplied somewhere in the region of three hundred and fifty thousand to nearly half a million combatants** — the figures vary with definitions, and every version of them puts the province at or near half the Indian total.
3. **Its share of India's population was around seven or eight per cent.**
4. **Indian troops were in France within months.** The Lahore and Meerut Divisions were in the line in the winter of 1914–15 — men from the Punjab plains in Flanders mud, in the first winter, in tropical uniforms.
5. **They fought at Neuve Chapelle, Ypres and Loos;** at Gallipoli; through the whole Mesopotamian campaign including the surrender at Kut; in Egypt, Palestine and East Africa.
6. **Indian dead across all theatres were around seventy-four thousand**, and the Punjab's share of that is proportionate to its share of the enlistment.

HOW THE MEN WERE ACTUALLY RAISED

The recruitment of the Punjab in the First World War is often described as volunteering, and for the first two years that is roughly what it was — a province with a military tradition, cash pay, land grants and pensions on offer.

By 1917 and 1918 it was something else.

Michael O'Dwyer ran recruitment as a quota system. **Districts were given targets, and the targets were passed down to the tehsildars, the zaildars and the village lambardars, whose own positions depended on meeting them.** Villages that fell short were pressed. Land grants, canal water, remissions and official favour were tied to compliance. There are well-documented cases of coercion, of families with several sons being made to produce another, and of quotas being met by methods nobody wrote down.

The province also supplied money, animals and grain — war loans raised under pressure, horses and mules requisitioned, wheat taken at controlled prices — during a period of rising costs and, in 1918, an influenza epidemic that killed a very large number of people across northern India.

So the picture is both things at once. **Hundreds of thousands of Punjabis enlisted willingly, fought extremely well, and were proud of it. And by the last two years the machinery producing them was closer to conscription than to recruitment, and the province knew it.**

What made 1919 explosive was not one of those facts. It was both of them together, plus what happened next.

WHY THE PUNJAB DELIVERED

- **Sixty years of policy.** Everything in War Six was designed to produce exactly this and it worked.
- **Land and pensions.** The canal colony grants tied service to property in a way pay alone never could.
- **A genuine military tradition** in families that had been soldiering for three generations.
- **And an administration that could reach every village** and apply pressure through people the village could not refuse.

WHAT THE PROVINCE EXPECTED IN RETURN

- **Political advance.** In August 1917 the British government publicly declared that its policy was the progressive realisation of responsible government in India. Everybody read it as a promise.
- **An end to wartime emergency powers,** which had been accepted as temporary.
- **Recognition.** A province that had supplied half an army expected to be treated as something other than a district.
- **And what it got in March 1919 was the Rowlatt Acts.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Winter of 1914

The Lahore and Meerut Divisions reached France in the autumn of 1914 and went into the line almost at once, in the first winter of the war.

Consider what that involved for a man from a village near Jalandhar or Rawalpindi. He had never seen Europe. He had never seen that kind of cold, or that kind of rain, or a landscape without sun in it for weeks. **The kit issued was for a different climate.** The trenches filled with water. The artillery was on a scale nothing in Asia had prepared anybody for.

They held sections of the line through that winter when the British Expeditionary Force had been shot to pieces and there was very little else available, and they attacked at Neuve Chapelle in March 1915.

Letters home were censored, and the censors' summaries survive, which is how we know some of what the men were saying. **They are among the very few first-person Punjabi voices in this entire book** — dictated by men who could not write, to scribes, read by censors, and preserved in a file because somebody was checking for morale problems.

They are mostly about the cold, the noise, and money for home.

There is a memorial at Neuve Chapelle to the Indian dead of that winter. There are Commonwealth war cemeteries in France, Belgium, Iraq, Turkey, Egypt and Tanzania with Punjabi names on the stones.

This province has been a corridor for other people's armies since Part One of this book. In 1914 it stopped being a corridor and became a source — and the men went to the other end of the world to fight in a war that had nothing to do with them, for a government that put the Rowlatt Acts on the statute book four months after the armistice.

The Rowlatt Acts and April 1919

CERTAIN

Four months after the armistice, the government made its wartime emergency powers permanent, and every elected Indian in the legislature voted against it.

WON BY Nobody — the government got its Act and lost the argument for ever

WHEN The Act passed March 1919; the arrests at Amritsar on 10 April.	WHERE Delhi, and then Amritsar.
WHO The Government of India; Gandhi; and at Amritsar, Dr Saifuddin Kitchlew and Dr Satyapal.	THE EVIDENCE Legislative records, the Hunter Committee evidence, and contemporary newspapers.

What the Act did

1. **It extended the wartime emergency powers into peacetime.** Trial of political offences without a jury; detention without trial; restricted appeal.
2. **Every elected Indian member of the Imperial Legislative Council voted against it.** It passed on the official bloc.
3. **That is the fact that mattered.** Not the content — the demonstration that Indian representation, such as it was, could be simply outvoted on a question of civil liberty, four months after the war those representatives’ constituents had fought.
4. **Gandhi called a satyagraha** — a nationwide suspension of business — for early April 1919. It was his first all-India campaign and it worked far better than anybody expected.

Amritsar, 10 April

1. **The two local leaders were popular and they were a Muslim and a Hindu working together,** which the administration found more alarming than either of them separately.
2. **On 10 April they were arrested and deported from the city without notice.**
3. **A crowd marched to the Civil Lines to petition for their release** and was fired on at a railway bridge. Numbers were killed.

4. **The city then rioted.** Banks were attacked and burned; **five Europeans were killed**; and a woman missionary, **Miss Marcella Sherwood**, was pulled from her bicycle and badly beaten in a narrow lane. She was rescued and hidden by Indian neighbours.
5. **By 11 April the civil authorities had lost control** and handed the city to the military.
6. **Brigadier-General Reginald Dyer arrived that night.**

STATING THE VIOLENCE ON BOTH SIDES

This book has been consistent about this for fifteen parts and will not stop now.

Five Europeans were murdered in Amritsar on 10 April 1919 — bank employees and a railway guard, killed by a mob. **Marcella Sherwood was assaulted in a lane and left for dead.** These were real crimes committed against people who had done nothing, and they are part of the record.

They are also the reason the city was placed under military control, and they are the justification that was offered afterwards for everything that followed.

What has to be held alongside them is proportion. The riot of 10 April was a day of mob violence in a city, following the firing on a peaceful procession, following the arrest without notice of two popular leaders, following an Act that every elected Indian had voted against.

What happened three days later, in response, was not policing and was not a riot.

The man responsible said in his own testimony that it was intended to produce an effect throughout the Punjab, and that is the whole difference.

WHY THE PUNJAB OF ALL PLACES

- **It had just supplied half an army** and the sense of a debt unpaid was strongest there.
- **Wartime recruitment had been coercive** in the last two years and the resentment was fresh.
- **The 1918 influenza epidemic and wartime inflation** had hit the province hard.
- **And it had a Lieutenant-Governor who had spent six years believing the province was permanently on the edge of revolt** and governing accordingly.

WHY THE RESPONSE WAS WHAT IT WAS

- **1857 was the reference point.** Every senior official in India read a disturbance in the recruiting province through that lens.
- **Ghadar was four years old** and the administration believed, wrongly, that it was still live.
- **O'Dwyer's doctrine was pre-emption.** He had said publicly and often that firmness at the outset prevented worse later.
- **And the city had been handed to a soldier** with instructions to restore order and no instructions about how.

The Promise and the Bill

In August 1917 the Secretary of State for India stood up in the House of Commons and announced that the policy of His Majesty's Government was **the increasing association of Indians in every branch of the administration, and the gradual development of self-governing institutions, with a view to the progressive realisation of responsible government in India.**

It was the most explicit commitment any British government had ever made, and it was made in the fourth year of a war in which India had supplied over a million men.

The Punjab had supplied around half the combatants.

The armistice was in November 1918. **In March 1919 the Rowlatt Act became law over the votes of every elected Indian in the legislature.**

Four months.

It is possible to explain the Act. The government was frightened of revolutionary violence, the wartime powers had been useful, the Rowlatt Committee had recommended it, and the officials who pushed it believed they were preventing bloodshed.

None of that mattered, and none of it was the point. The point was the sequence. A promise of self-government in 1917; a million men and seventy-four thousand dead; and then, before the war memorials were built, a law that let the government imprison people without trial.

Gandhi had spent the war recruiting for the British in Gujarat. **The Rowlatt Act is what turned him into the leader of a mass movement against them,** and what happened at Amritsar three weeks later is what made that movement unstoppable.

Jallianwala Bagh, 13 April 1919

CERTAIN

Ten minutes. One thousand six hundred and fifty rounds. No warning was given, and the officer who gave the order explained why in his own words, under oath, and was not ashamed of any of it.

WON BY

Nobody — and it ended the argument about British rule in India

WHEN

13 April 1919, about a quarter past five in the afternoon. It was **Baisakhi**.

WHERE

Jallianwala Bagh, Amritsar — a walled enclosure of about six or seven acres, a few minutes' walk from the Harmandir Sahib.

WHO

Brigadier-General Reginald Dyer, with fifty riflemen — Gurkhas and Baluchis — and two armoured cars.

THE EVIDENCE

Dyer's own sworn testimony to the Hunter Committee. CERTAIN.

What happened

1. **Dyer issued a proclamation that morning banning gatherings.** It was read out by drum in parts of the city. **It did not reach most of it**, and Amritsar was full of people who had come in from the villages for Baisakhi and for the horse fair, and who knew nothing about any of it.
2. **A meeting was called in the Bagh for the afternoon.** The Bagh was not a garden in any ordinary sense — it was a piece of enclosed waste ground, surrounded on all sides by the backs of buildings, with a handful of narrow exits and one main entrance down a lane.
3. **Somewhere between ten and twenty thousand people were in it.** Some had come for the meeting. A great many were there because it was a festival day and the Bagh was where people sat.
4. **Dyer marched in with fifty riflemen** and took up position on raised ground inside the entrance. **The two armoured cars with machine guns could not follow, because the lane was too narrow.**
5. **He gave no warning and no order to disperse.**
6. **He ordered his men to fire, and directed the fire** — including towards the exits where people were trying to get out.

7. **The firing lasted about ten minutes and stopped when the ammunition was nearly exhausted. One thousand six hundred and fifty rounds were expended.**
8. **He then marched his men out and did not arrange for the wounded.** A curfew was in force that night; the wounded lay where they were.

THE NUMBERS, AND WHY THEY ARE DISPUTED

The official figure, arrived at by the Hunter Committee, was three hundred and seventy-nine dead and something over a thousand wounded.

The Indian National Congress inquiry put the dead at over a thousand.

The gap exists for a specific and discreditable reason. **No count was made at the time.** The bodies were removed by families under curfew, over subsequent days, without any official process. The government's figure was assembled afterwards from claims submitted by relatives — which requires a family to come forward, to a government under martial law, and identify a dead man as having been at a banned meeting.

The true number is not knowable and it is almost certainly higher than the official one.

This book has interrogated casualty figures in every part since the first, usually to argue that a chronicler's number is too high. **This is the one case in sixteen parts where the official figure is the floor rather than the ceiling,** and where the reason it is too low is that nobody in authority wanted to count.

WHAT DYER SAID HE WAS DOING — IN HIS OWN TESTIMONY

- **He said he had made up his mind before he arrived** that if he found a crowd assembled he would fire on it.
- **He said he did not give a warning** because the crowd had defied his proclamation and warning would have been inconsistent with that.
- **He said his object was not to disperse the meeting but to produce a moral effect throughout the Punjab.**
- **And he was asked whether he would have used the machine guns had he been able to get the armoured cars in. He said he probably would have.**

WHAT THAT TESTIMONY ESTABLISHES

- **It was not crowd control.** He said so himself, twice, in terms.
- **It was not a decision taken under pressure in a moment.** He testified that he had decided in advance.
- **The target was the Punjab, not the Bagh.** The people in the enclosure were the means.
- **And he volunteered all of this,** to a committee of inquiry, believing it justified him.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Walls Are Still There

This book is not going to describe the afternoon of 13 April 1919 in any more detail than it already has. The facts are on the page and they do not need help.

What is worth saying is what the place is now.

Jallianwala Bagh is a memorial garden in the middle of Amritsar, a few minutes' walk from the Harmandir Sahib. The entrance is still the narrow lane. The walls of the surrounding houses are still standing, **and the bullet marks are still in them, and they are marked.** The well into which people jumped is still there and is enclosed.

Several million people visit every year. Most of them are Indian and many are Punjabi, and a great many of them walk in from the Golden Temple as part of the same visit, which is exactly the walk that a large number of the people in the Bagh had made that afternoon.

This book has spent fifteen parts complaining that the Punjab's history has been destroyed, built over, forgotten or written down by other people. **Taxila is a ruin. Sirhind is a mound. There is nothing on the ground at Chillianwala for anybody but the British dead. Nobody knows where Porus fought.**

Jallianwala Bagh is the exception. It was preserved deliberately, bought by public subscription within a few years, and it has been kept as it was on purpose — the lane, the walls, the marks.

Of everything that has happened on Punjabi soil in five thousand years, the one site that the province decided it would not allow to be smoothed over is a piece of enclosed waste ground where several hundred people were shot in ten minutes for being in it.

Martial Law, April–June 1919

CERTAIN

What followed in the rest of the province is less known than the Bagh and is in some ways more revealing, because it went on for weeks and was administered.

WON BY

The government — and it destroyed its own case doing it

WHEN 15 April to early June 1919.	WHERE Amritsar, Lahore, Gujranwala, Gujrat and Lyallpur districts.
WHO The military authorities, under the general direction of Sir Michael O'Dwyer.	THE EVIDENCE The Hunter Committee's own record. CERTAIN

What was done

1. **Martial law was proclaimed** across five districts and summary tribunals were set up, handing down death sentences and long terms of transportation.
2. **Public floggings** were carried out, in the street, including of people convicted of nothing by any court.
3. **Indians were required to salaam to European officers** and were punished for failing to.
4. **The crawling order.** In the lane where Marcella Sherwood had been assaulted, **Dyer ordered that any Indian passing along it must do so on his hands and knees.** It was enforced for several days on people who lived in the lane and had no other way to reach their own front doors.
5. **And at Gujranwala, on 14 and 15 April, aircraft bombed and machine-gunned crowds and villages from the air.** This is not a disputed allegation; it is in the official record.

THE CRAWLING ORDER, AND WHAT IT WAS FOR

Of everything done under martial law in the Punjab in 1919, the crawling order is the one that officials found hardest to defend, and it is worth being precise about why.

It had no security purpose whatever. It prevented nothing, protected nobody and gathered no intelligence. Dyer's own explanation was that the lane was sacred because an Englishwoman had been assaulted in it, and that Indians should approach it in a posture of humility.

The people it was actually applied to were the residents of that lane — including, on the record, elderly people and people carrying things, who had to crawl to get home past a picket that enforced it.

Miss Sherwood herself, when she recovered, is recorded as having been distressed by it, and she had been rescued and hidden by Indian neighbours in the first place.

The Hunter Committee could find no justification for it and said so. Dyer, giving evidence, did not really attempt one.

It belongs in this book because it is the clearest statement anybody made in 1919 of what the relationship was understood to be. The Bagh can be argued about as a catastrophic misjudgement under pressure. The crawling order was thought about, written down, ordered, posted and enforced by soldiers for several days, and its entire content was humiliation.

WHY IT WAS DONE

- **Deterrence, explicitly.** O'Dwyer's stated doctrine was that severity at the outset prevented worse later, and he applied it.
- **The 1857 reflex.** Every senior official read April 1919 as the beginning of a mutiny in the army's home province.
- **Fear.** The European community in the Punjab in April 1919 was frightened, and frightened administrations do this.
- **And nobody stopped it for six weeks.**

WHY IT DESTROYED THE CASE FOR THE RAJ

- **It was administered, not spontaneous.** Orders, proclamations, pickets and paperwork — which meant it could not be blamed on one man's panic.
- **It was documented by the government's own inquiry,** in public, with the officers testifying.
- **It humiliated in ways that could not be undone by compensation** or explained by military necessity.
- **And it happened in the loyal province,** to the families of the men who had just fought in France.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

From the Air

On 14 and 15 April 1919, at Gujranwala and the villages around it, **British aircraft bombed and machine-gunned crowds on the ground.**

It is one of the earliest uses of air power against a civilian population anywhere, and it happened in the Punjab, and it is barely remembered even here.

The aircraft were operating in support of the civil power against what were reported as mobs damaging railway property. They dropped small bombs and fired on groups of people in the open, including — according to evidence given to the inquiry — on a gathering at a village and on people in fields.

The casualties were small compared with the Bagh. **The significance is not the number.**

This book has described the introduction of a great many military technologies to this province across five thousand years. **The war chariot in Part One. The elephant in Part Two. The stirrup and the mounted archer in Part Five. The mangonel and the mine in Part Six. Gunpowder artillery at Panipat in Part Seven. Drilled infantry and the volley in Part Twelve.**

Every one of them arrived here from somewhere else, and every one of them was used on this ground before most people here had seen it.

In April 1919 the Punjab was added to the very short list of places that had been attacked from the sky, twenty-eight years before it had a government of its own.

The Reckoning, 1919–1920

CERTAIN

The inquiry censured him, the army removed him, the House of Lords defended him, and a London newspaper raised him a fortune. That combination is what made independence inevitable.

WON BY

Nobody in Britain — and everything after 1920 follows from how they handled it

WHEN The Hunter Committee sat October 1919 to March 1920; the Commons debate in July 1920.	WHERE Lahore, Delhi, and Westminster.
WHO The Disorders Inquiry Committee, Parliament, the British press, and Indian opinion.	THE EVIDENCE The committee's reports, Hansard, and the newspapers. CERTAIN.

What happened

1. **The Hunter Committee took evidence in public**, with Indian members on it, and Dyer testified at length. His testimony did more damage to the government's position than any evidence against him.
2. **The majority report censured him** — for firing without warning, for continuing after the crowd began to disperse, and for his stated intention to produce an effect beyond Amritsar.
3. **The Indian members went further** in a separate minority report and called it inhuman.
4. **Dyer was relieved of his command and resigned**. He was not prosecuted, not court-martialled, and lost no rank or pension.
5. **The House of Commons debated it in July 1920 and supported the government by a substantial majority**. Winston Churchill, as Secretary of State for War, spoke against Dyer and called the episode monstrous.
6. **The House of Lords passed a motion in Dyer's favour**.
7. **And the *Morning Post* opened a public subscription for him** which raised something over twenty-six thousand pounds — an enormous sum, contributed by thousands of ordinary people in Britain, and presented

to him as the man who had saved India.

WHY THE FUND MATTERED MORE THAN THE CENSURE

Indian opinion in 1920 was watching to see what Britain would do, and it received a completely unambiguous answer.

The censure was real. A committee of inquiry found against him, a Secretary of State denounced him in the Commons, and the government defeated a motion to restore him.

And the House of Lords voted for him, and the British public gave him a fortune.

Those two facts arrived in India together, and the second one destroyed the first. **It demonstrated that a large part of British society, including a chamber of its Parliament, regarded what had been done in the Punjab as defensible.**

Rabindranath Tagore renounced his knighthood in May 1919, in a letter that said he wished to stand beside his countrymen who were being shot at.

Gandhi, who had recruited for the British army during the war, launched Non-Cooperation in 1920. He said afterwards that the events in the Punjab and the response to them were what convinced him that cooperation with the government was impossible.

Constitutional reforms were enacted in 1919 giving Indians more of a share in provincial government than they had ever had. **Almost nobody in India cared, because of what had happened at Amritsar in April and what had been said about it in London in July.**

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT GAINED

- **Order in the Punjab** in the summer of 1919, which was what it wanted.
- **Nothing else at all.**

WHAT IT LOST

- **The argument.** After 1919 the case that British rule was benevolent could not be made in India by anybody who expected to be listened to.
- **The moderates.** Indians who had spent a generation working for reform within the system had their position destroyed underneath them.
- **Gandhi**, who had been a loyal subject and a recruiting sergeant, and who was thereafter the leader of a mass movement to end British rule.
- **And the loyal province.** The arrangement of seventy years — land, pensions, recruitment, obedience — was shown to be worth nothing, in the plainest way available.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

Caxton Hall, 1940

On 13 March 1940, at a meeting of the East India Association at Caxton Hall in Westminster, a man in the audience stood up and shot **Sir Michael O'Dwyer** dead.

O'Dwyer had been Lieutenant-Governor of the Punjab in 1919. He had approved of Dyer's action at the time, defended it for the rest of his life, sued a critic for libel and won, and was in that hall to hear a lecture about Afghanistan.

The man who shot him was **Udham Singh**, an orphan from Sunam who had been in Amritsar in 1919. He gave his name in court as Ram Mohammad Singh Azad — deliberately combining a Hindu, a Muslim and a Sikh name, with *azad*, free, on the end.

He was tried at the Old Bailey, convicted, and **hanged at Pentonville on 31 July 1940**. He was about forty. His remains were returned to India in 1974 and he was cremated at Sunam.

This book is not going to present a political assassination as a happy ending, and it is not one.

Udham Singh killed a retired official at a public meeting twenty-one years after the event, and O'Dwyer was not the man who gave the order at the Bagh.

What it is worth ending on is the name he gave the court.

In 1940 the Punjab was seven years from being cut in half along exactly the line that name refuses. Part Sixteen is about that, and about the fact that within a decade of Udham Singh standing up in an English courtroom and calling himself Hindu, Muslim and Sikh at once, **the province he came from killed several hundred thousand of its own people over the difference.**

Seventy years of loyalty, and the categories the loyalty was organised into, and the walled garden where the arrangement ended — all of it leads there.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1849–1853	The Board of Administration. The province is disarmed — over a hundred thousand weapons surrendered — the revenue is settled moderately, roads and canals are begun, and Punjabi regiments are raised almost immediately.
1857	The Punjab does not rise. The Bengal regiments are disarmed within days; the Cis-Sutlej chiefs back the British; ~34,000 Punjabi levies are raised; and the siege train that breaches Delhi comes down from Lahore. And at Ajnala, 282 disarmed sepoys are killed without trial and put down a well.
1849–1898	The frontier. Sixty-odd punitive expeditions, the Ambela campaign of 1863, the Second Afghan War, the rising of 1897 — and the Durand Line in 1893 , drawn through the Pashtun country and still disputed. Won by nobody.
Jan 1872	The Kukas. A reform movement that boycotted British courts, schools and cloth fifty years before Gandhi. After an attack on Malerkotla, Cowan has 49 men blown from guns without trial and 16 more the next day. He is dismissed for it — and Ram Singh is deported to Rangoon.
1885–1920	The canal colonies. The largest irrigated tract on earth; Lyallpur founded 1896 ; hundreds of thousands moved west from the crowded central districts; the pastoral communities of the bars dispossessed; and grants tied to army service.
1860s–1914	The martial races doctrine. A theory about blood, constructed after 1857, that made the Punjab the empire's recruiting ground — about half the Indian Army from seven or eight per cent of India's population.
1900	The Land Alienation Act bars transfer of land outside listed "agricultural tribes" — protecting the peasantry, protecting the recruiting base, and turning community into a legal category with property rights attached.
1907	Pagri Sambhal Jatta. The Colonization Bill and the water rates bring the canal colonies out; Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh are deported without trial ; and the Viceroy vetoes the bill — because the agitation had reached the recruiting districts. Won by the agitation.
1913–1915	Ghadar. Founded by Punjabi emigrants on the Pacific coast; the Komagata Maru turned back in 1914; thousands return to raise a rising; it is betrayed before it starts ; and Kartar Singh Sarabha is hanged at nineteen. Won by the government.
1914–1918	The First World War. Something near half a million Punjabi combatants — roughly half the Indian total — in France, Gallipoli, Mesopotamia and East Africa. By 1917 recruitment is running on district quotas and coercion.
Aug 1917	The British government publicly commits to responsible government in India.

Mar 1919	The Rowlatt Act makes wartime emergency powers permanent, over the votes of every elected Indian in the legislature. Gandhi calls a nationwide satyagraha.
10 Apr 1919	Amritsar. Kitchlew and Satyapal are deported without notice; a procession is fired on; the city riots; five Europeans are killed and Marcella Sherwood is assaulted. Dyer arrives that night.
13 Apr 1919	Jallianwala Bagh. On Baisakhi, in a walled enclosure with narrow exits, fifty riflemen fire 1,650 rounds in about ten minutes without warning. Official dead: 379. Congress inquiry: over a thousand. Dyer testifies that his object was to produce a moral effect throughout the Punjab.
Apr–Jun 1919	Martial law in five districts: summary tribunals, public floggings, forced salaaming, the crawling order , and aircraft bombing and machine-gunning crowds at Gujranwala.
1920	The Hunter Committee censures Dyer and he resigns — and the House of Lords votes in his favour and the <i>Morning Post</i> raises him over £26,000. Tagore renounces his knighthood; Gandhi launches Non-Cooperation. <i>Part Sixteen begins here.</i>
13 Mar 1940	Udham Singh shoots Michael O'Dwyer dead at Caxton Hall and gives his name in court as Ram Mohammad Singh Azad.

Five patterns to carry into Part Sixteen

1. **The categories were built here, and they are what the province is cut along.** “Agricultural tribes” in 1900, “martial races” from the 1860s, separate electorates from 1909 — administrative boxes, backed by property law, recruitment policy and the census, applied for sixty years. **This book is not saying the British invented Hindu, Muslim and Sikh. It is saying they turned them into legal categories with things attached, and that in 1947 the lists already existed.**
2. **The Punjab was made into an army and then shot by it.** Half the Indian Army from one province; land grants tied to service; a whole rural economy running through the recruiting office. **And in April 1919 the troops who fired in the Bagh were Gurkhas and Baluchis, and the man who ordered it said his target was the province.**
3. **The one thing that was built is in the wrong country.** The canal colonies are the only large constructive achievement in these sixteen parts — and they were settled from the east by people who had to run for their lives in 1947. **Part Sixteen is those roads, in reverse.**
4. **The province’s own voice is still almost entirely in verse.** A coin legend, a hymn about an invasion, a couplet about a sickle, a letter written on a road — and now a three-word refrain from a meeting at Lyallpur that is still sung at demonstrations. **Fifteen parts, and everything ordinary Punjabis left behind rhymes and is about not being pushed off the land.**
5. **And after 1919 the argument was over.** The censure and the subscription arrived in India together, and the second cancelled the first. **What follows is not a debate about whether the British should leave, but a fight about who gets what when they do** — and that fight is conducted in the categories described above.

COMING NEXT — PART SIXTEEN, THE LAST

The Line, 1919–1947. Non-cooperation and the **Akali** movement for the gurdwaras — Nankana Sahib in 1921, Guru ka Bagh, Jaito. **Bhagat Singh**, the Lahore Conspiracy Case and the gallows in March 1931. The Unionist Party and the twenty years in which Punjabi Muslims, Hindus and Sikhs governed the province together, and why it collapsed. The Lahore Resolution of 1940; the elections of 1946; Direct Action Day; and the **Rawalpindi massacres of March 1947**, which is where the killing in the Punjab actually starts. Then **Cyril Radcliffe**, who had never been to India, given five weeks and out-of-date census maps, drawing a line through the most integrated province in the subcontinent. **Between ten and fifteen million people moved. Nobody knows how many died; the estimates run from several hundred thousand to two million.** It is the largest forced migration in human history and it happened here, in about ten weeks. And then a short accounting of what came after — **1965, 1971, 1984, 1999** — because the wars did not stop, and because this book promised to cover every one of them.

Words Used in This Part

Non-regulation system

The style of administration used in the annexed Punjab — district officers with wide personal discretion and minimal paperwork. Its practitioners were known as the “Punjab School.”

Piffers

The Punjab Frontier Force, raised in 1849 and recruited largely in the Punjab, which policed the north-west frontier for half a century.

Durand Line

The boundary agreed at Kabul in 1893 between British India and Afghanistan, drawn through the Pashtun tribal country. Still the Afghanistan–Pakistan border and still disputed.

Namdhari / Kuka

The reform movement led by Satguru Ram Singh from 1857 — anti-caste, anti-dowry, and boycotting British courts, schools, posts and cloth decades before non-cooperation.

Bar

The high scrub plain between two rivers in the western Punjab — the Sandal Bar, the Ganji Bar, the Neeli Bar — grazing country before the canals, and the site of the colonies afterwards.

Canal colony

A tract of newly irrigated land settled with colonists brought from elsewhere in the province. The largest was the Chenab Colony around Lyallpur, now Faisalabad.

Martial races

The doctrine, constructed after 1857, that certain communities were inherently warlike and should supply the army. It was not true and it determined recruitment policy for eighty years.

Class regiment

A unit recruited from a single caste or community. Adopted deliberately after 1857 to prevent the pan-Indian solidarity that had produced the mutiny.

Agricultural tribe

A community listed under the Land Alienation Act of 1900 as entitled to buy agricultural land. The lists made community a legal category with property rights attached.

Pagri Sambhal Jatta

“Look after your turban, farmer” — the song written by Banke Dayal for the canal colony agitation of 1907, and still sung.

Ghadar

“Mutiny” or “revolt” — the party founded by Punjabi emigrants in California in 1913, and its newspaper.

Komagata Maru

The steamer chartered in 1914 to test Canada’s exclusion of Indian immigrants, turned back from Vancouver, and fired on at Budge Budge near Calcutta.

Rowlatt Act

The Anarchical and Revolutionary Crimes Act of March 1919, extending wartime powers of detention and trial without jury into peacetime, passed over the votes of every elected Indian member.

Satyagraha

Gandhi's method of mass non-violent resistance. The Rowlatt satyagraha of April 1919 was his first all-India campaign.

The crawling order

Dyer's order that any Indian passing along the lane where Marcella Sherwood was assaulted must do so on hands and knees. Enforced for several days; no security purpose was ever claimed for it.

Hunter Committee

The Disorders Inquiry Committee of 1919–20, which took Dyer's evidence in public and censured him. Its Indian members issued a separate and harsher minority report.

Sources used for this part

- Punjab administration reports, settlement reports and district gazetteers, 1849–1919
- Census of India returns for the Punjab, 1881 onwards
- The text of the **Punjab Land Alienation Act, 1900**, and of the Colonization of Land Bill, 1906
- Indian Army recruiting handbooks and regimental records
- **Frederic Cooper's** own published account of the Ajnala executions of 1857
- Government files on the Kuka movement and the dismissal of Cowan
- Ghadar party publications and the transcripts of the **Lahore Conspiracy Case** trials
- Censored extracts from Indian soldiers' letters from France, 1914–1918
- **The Report of the Disorders Inquiry Committee (Hunter Committee), 1920**, including Dyer's evidence, and the Indian National Congress inquiry report
- Hansard for the Commons and Lords debates of July 1920, and contemporary British newspapers including the *Morning Post*
- Standard modern histories of colonial Punjab, the canal colonies, the Indian Army and the events of 1919

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the true number of dead at Jallianwala Bagh, which cannot now be established and is almost certainly above the official 379; the exact number of Punjabi recruits in the First World War, which varies with whether non-combatants are counted; the scale of coercion in wartime recruitment, which by its nature was not documented; and the number killed at Ajnala in 1857, for which the main source is the man responsible.

Three things about method.

First, **1857 has been written without a verdict.** The Punjab did not rise, for reasons that are specific and mostly practical, and the province was also held down by executions that its administrators recorded and were not ashamed of. Both halves are here. A version that celebrates the loyalty and a version that condemns it are equally incomplete.

Second, **the account of Jallianwala Bagh rests on the perpetrator's own testimony rather than on description.**

Dyer told a public inquiry that he had decided to fire before he arrived, that he gave no warning deliberately, that his object was an effect throughout the Punjab, and that he would have used machine guns if he could have brought them in. Nothing this book could write would be more damning than that, and dwelling on the dead would add nothing.

Third, **the argument that colonial categories hardened into communal identity is an argument, not a fact,** and it is contested. It is stated here as this book's reading of the evidence rather than smuggled in as description — and Part Sixteen depends on it.

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART SIXTEEN OF SIXTEEN

The Line

The last part. A province governed across religion for twenty years, a border drawn in five weeks by a man who had never seen it, and about ten weeks in which the Punjab did to itself what nobody in the previous fifteen parts had managed.

1919 — TODAY

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

The Last Part

Fifteen parts of invasions, and the worst thing that ever happened to the Punjab was done by Punjabis, to each other, in about ten weeks.

This book has described armies coming down the same road for five thousand years.

Persians, Greeks, Kushans, Huns, Arabs, Turks, Mongols, Afghans, Mughals, Persians again, Afghans again, and finally an army that came up the Indus from the sea. Every one of them killed people here. **None of them killed as many as died in the Punjab between August and November 1947, and none of them had to be invited.**

That is the subject of this part, and it is why the last chapter of a book about wars is not about a battle.

Four things to hold on to

- **It was not inevitable.** For roughly twenty years the Punjab was governed by a cross-communal coalition of Muslims, Hindus and Sikhs, elected, functioning, and built on the interests of cultivators against townsmen. **Anybody who tells you the province was always going to tear itself apart has to explain the Unionist Party, and most accounts simply leave it out.**
- **The killing started before partition was announced.** The massacres in the Rawalpindi districts happened in March 1947 — three months before the plan, five before the border.
- **The border was drawn in five weeks by a man who had never been to India,** and it was published two days *after* independence, so that the government that drew it would not have to police the result.
- **And it did not end in 1947.** There were wars on this soil in 1965 and 1971, the province was divided again in 1966, and there was a decade of killing in the 1980s and 1990s. **This part covers those too, because the book promised every war and this is the last chance to keep the promise.**

HOW THIS PART WILL HANDLE 1947 — AND 1984

Two subjects here are inside living memory and are actively fought over in the politics of three countries. This book's method does not change for them, but it needs stating explicitly.

All three communities killed and all three were killed. There is no version of the Punjab in 1947 in which one group is only a victim, and this part will not write one. It will name specific events, specific places and — where they are known — specific people, and it will not attribute anything to a religion.

The violence will be stated and not described. The same rule this book used for 1606, 1704, 1762 and 1919 applies here with more force, not less, because there are people alive whose families are in it.

And on 1984 and after, this book will report and not adjudicate. Those events are recent, the facts are contested, inquiries are still argued about, and reasonable people who agree on the evidence disagree about the meaning. **This part sets out what is documented, notes where the figures and the interpretations diverge, and stops there.** A history written in 2020 has no business handing down a verdict on 1984.

The Akali Morchas, 1920–1925

CERTAIN

A five-year campaign to take the gurdwaras back from hereditary custodians — fought almost entirely by people refusing to hit anybody — and it won.

WON BY

The Akalis — by legislation, after about four hundred dead

WHEN

1920–1925.

WHERE

Nankana Sahib, Guru ka Bagh near Amritsar, and Jaito in Nabha state.

WHO

The Shiromani Gurdwara Prabandhak Committee and the Shiromani Akali Dal, both formed in late 1920.

THE EVIDENCE

Government records, court proceedings, contemporary press.

CERTAIN

What it was about

Over the nineteenth century, control of most major Sikh shrines had passed to hereditary managers — *mahants* — who held the endowments as personal property, and who were, in many cases, backed by the British administration because a compliant custodian was useful. **The campaign was to transfer the shrines to elected community control.**

What happened

1. **Nankana Sahib, 20 February 1921.** The birthplace of Guru Nanak. A body of reformers entered the shrine and **about a hundred and thirty of them were killed by men in the mahant’s employ, and their bodies burned.** The mahant was tried and convicted. **It is the event that turned the movement from a reform campaign into a political one.**
2. **Guru ka Bagh, 1922.** Akalis went in daily batches to cut wood on disputed land, having taken a vow not to resist. **The police beat them, batch after batch, for weeks.** Something like five thousand six hundred were arrested.
3. **Jaito, 1923–1925.** A prolonged campaign in the princely state of Nabha, in which a column of five hundred was fired on in February 1924 and around twenty were killed.

4. **And the government gave way.** The **Sikh Gurdwaras Act of 1925** transferred management of the shrines to an elected committee — the SGPC — which still holds them.

WHAT C. F. ANDREWS SAW

The Guru ka Bagh campaign was watched by **Charles Freer Andrews**, an English clergyman and friend of Gandhi and Tagore, and his account of it did more damage to the government's position than anything the Akalis said.

He described men walking forward in batches, in silence, to be beaten to the ground by police with staves, **and not raising a hand or a word** — and then the next batch walking forward.

He wrote that he had never seen anything like it, that he found it almost unbearable to watch, and that what he was looking at was **a new kind of heroism**.

The account was published, it was read in England, and the beatings stopped.

This matters for the whole shape of Part Sixteen. The Akali movement of the 1920s was the largest sustained non-violent campaign in India before Gandhi's salt march, it was run by a community with a considerable military tradition, and **it worked — by legislation, in five years, against the government that had ordered the firing at Jallianwala Bagh three years earlier.**

Some thirty thousand people went to prison. Around four hundred died. The gurdwaras changed hands.

WHY IT SUCCEEDED

- **The objective was specific and legal.** Control of named institutions under a statute — winnable, unlike a demand for independence.
- **Non-violence was tactically correct.** A community famous for fighting, declining to fight, was impossible to answer with force in public.
- **It was well organised.** The SGPC and the Akali Dal gave it a structure, a treasury and a leadership, which is what the morchas of previous centuries never had.
- **And 1919 had made the government cautious** about being seen to shoot Punjabis.

WHAT IT ALSO DID

- **It created a permanent religious-political machine.** The SGPC controls large endowments and an electorate; the Akali Dal became a party. **Punjabi politics after 1925 has a standing Sikh political institution in it, which it did not before.**
- **It sharpened the boundaries.** A campaign to define Sikh institutions required defining who counted as a Sikh, at a moment when every community in the province was being counted and listed.
- **And it aligned the Akalis with Congress**, which mattered enormously in 1947.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Ten Years, Two Methods

Put the two things the Punjab did in the 1920s side by side, because they happened in the same districts, among the same families, at the same time.

At Guru ka Bagh in 1922, thousands of men walked forward in batches to be beaten unconscious without raising a hand, on a vow, for months, until the government stopped.

At Lahore in 1928, three young men shot a police officer dead in the street in revenge for the death of a nationalist leader, and one of them was hanged at twenty-three and became the most famous revolutionary in modern India.

Both were reactions to the same thing. Both came out of the same province in the same decade. **Both worked, in their own terms** — the Akalis got the Gurdwaras Act, and Bhagat Singh's execution did more to radicalise Indian politics than any single event of the 1930s.

This book has watched the Punjab argue with itself about method for a very long time. **Part Nine described a community that spent a century refusing to arm and then armed. Part Eleven described a confederacy that survived by refusing battle. Part Twelve described one that could not stop fighting itself.**

The 1920s is the same argument, conducted between people who knew each other.

And it is worth noting which of the two the province chose to institutionalise. **The SGPC and the Akali Dal are still there. The Hindustan Socialist Republican Association lasted four years.**

Bhagat Singh, 1928–1931

CERTAIN

He was twenty-three, he was an atheist and a socialist, his organisation was deliberately non-communal — and in a province being pulled apart by religion he is the one figure everybody still claims.

WON BY The government — which hanged him and lost the argument permanently

WHEN 1928–1931.	WHERE Lahore, and the Central Legislative Assembly at Delhi.
WHO Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev Thapar, Shivaram Rajguru and the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association.	THE EVIDENCE Trial records, his own writings, contemporary press. CERTAIN

What happened

1. **He was born in 1907**, in the year of the canal colony agitation, into the family of Part Fifteen — his uncle **Ajit Singh** was deported to Mandalay that May.
2. **In October 1928 the Simon Commission came to Lahore** and was met by a protest. **Lala Lajpat Rai** — the other leader of 1907, by then the outstanding nationalist of northern India — was baton-charged and died a few weeks later.
3. **In December 1928 Bhagat Singh and Rajguru shot a police officer, John Saunders, in the street at Lahore.** They had intended to kill the superintendent who had ordered the charge and killed the wrong man.
4. **In April 1929 he and Batukeshwar Dutt threw two bombs into the Central Legislative Assembly at Delhi.** The bombs were designed not to hurt anybody and did not. **They stayed where they were, scattered leaflets and waited to be arrested** — because the object was a trial, and a platform.
5. **The leaflet carried the line the whole thing is remembered by:** that it takes a loud noise to make the deaf hear.
6. **In jail he led a hunger strike** for political-prisoner status. **Jatindranath Das died on the sixty-third day of it** in September 1929.

7. **He was tried by a special tribunal with no appeal and hanged at Lahore Central Jail on 23 March 1931,** with Rajguru and Sukhdev. He was twenty-three.

WHAT HE ACTUALLY THOUGHT — BECAUSE IT IS USUALLY LEFT OUT

Bhagat Singh is claimed today by a remarkable number of movements with incompatible programmes, and the simplest corrective is to read what he wrote, because he wrote a great deal in two years in a condemned cell.

He was a socialist. The organisation was renamed the Hindustan *Socialist* Republican Association deliberately. He argued that replacing British rulers with Indian ones would change nothing for a peasant or a millworker.

He was an atheist, and wrote an essay in 1930 called *Why I Am an Atheist* explaining it, in prison, awaiting execution, when a profession of faith would have been the easiest thing in the world.

And he attacked communalism directly. He wrote about communal riots with contempt for everybody involved, argued that religious leaders and politicians were manufacturing division for their own purposes, and held that the cure was economic and educational rather than a better bargain between communities.

He was writing that in the Punjab, in 1930, seventeen years before the province divided.

He was also twenty-three, and he had shot a policeman by mistake. This book is not going to sand that off. He believed political violence was justified and he acted on it, and the man he killed had done nothing.

Both things are in the record and both belong on the page.

WHY THE EXECUTION WAS A MISTAKE

- **He wanted the trial and they gave it to him.** The Assembly bomb was designed to produce a courtroom, and the special tribunal produced a martyr instead of a conviction.
- **The timing was catastrophic.** He was hanged days before the Karachi Congress, and the anger swamped everything else on the agenda.
- **He was young, articulate and photogenic** in a decade when Indian newspapers were reaching a mass readership for the first time.
- **And they hanged him in Lahore,** in the province that had already given the movement Jallianwala Bagh.

WHY HIS POLITICS DID NOT SURVIVE HIM

- **The HSRA was tiny** and was destroyed within a few years by arrests.
- **Individual violence has no theory of the next step.** He knew it; his prison writings say so.
- **And the province went the other way.** The politics that determined 1947 in the Punjab was communal arithmetic, and his was its explicit opposite.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Photograph in the Pocket

Part Fifteen ended one section with a nineteen-year-old hanged at Lahore Central Jail in November 1915 for the Ghadar conspiracy.

Kartar Singh Sarabha's photograph was in Bhagat Singh's pocket, and he is recorded as having carried it for years and as having named him as the person he most wanted to be like.

Sixteen years later Bhagat Singh was hanged in the same jail.

Now trace the whole line, because it is astonishingly short and it runs through about three districts.

1907: the canal colonies agitate; Ajit Singh is deported; his nephew is born. **1915:** Sarabha is hanged at nineteen. **1919:** Jallianwala Bagh; a boy from Sunam is in Amritsar. **1928:** Lajpat Rai, the other leader of 1907, dies after a baton charge. **1931:** Bhagat Singh is hanged at twenty-three. **1940:** the boy from Sunam shoots Michael O'Dwyer in London and gives his name as Ram Mohammad Singh Azad.

Thirty-three years. One province. **Several of the people involved knew each other or were related to each other.**

This book has said repeatedly that the Punjab is not a large place. **What it produced in those three decades was a political tradition that was young, secular, violent, extremely brave and almost entirely unsuccessful** — and which, sixteen years after Bhagat Singh's execution, could do nothing at all to stop what happened.

The Unionists — The Twenty Years That Worked, 1923–1942

CERTAIN

The most important thing in this part is a political party that most histories of partition do not mention, because it is inconvenient for every version of the story.

WHAT HAPPENED

The Punjab was governed across religion, by election, for about twenty years

WHEN Founded 1923 ; in office through the 1920s and 1930s; effectively finished by 1946 .	WHERE The Punjab Legislative Council and Assembly at Lahore .
WHO Mian Fazl-i-Husain, Chaudhry Chhotu Ram, Sir Sikandar Hayat Khan and Sir Khizar Hayat Tiwana.	THE EVIDENCE Assembly records, election returns, legislation. CERTAIN

What the Unionist Party was

- 1. It was a party of agriculturalists, and it cut straight across religion.** Its founders were a Muslim from Punjab, a Hindu Jat from Rohtak, and a Muslim from the Salt Range, and its base was the landholding and cultivating classes of every community.
- 2. Its enemy was the town.** The moneylender, the urban trader, the professional politician — and this is where it connects directly to Part Fifteen. **The Unionist Party is the political expression of the “agricultural tribes” of the Land Alienation Act of 1900.**
- 3. It legislated for its base.** Debt relief, restrictions on foreclosure, regulation of the grain markets, and reform of the moneylending laws — chiefly the work of **Chhotu Ram**, who is still remembered across the Haryana and eastern Punjab countryside for it.
- 4. And it governed.** It won the 1937 election under the new provincial constitution, and **Sikandar Hayat Khan ran a Punjab ministry containing Muslims, Hindus and Sikhs** for five years.

WHY THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT SECTION IN PART SIXTEEN

Because it destroys the central claim on which every simple account of 1947 rests: that Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs in the Punjab could not live together and were always going to divide.

For twenty years they governed together, by election, in the most communally mixed province in India.

They did it not because they loved each other but because **the Unionist coalition organised politics around a real interest that cut across religion** — land, debt, water and prices. A Muslim Rajput landholder in Jhelum and a Hindu Jat in Rohtak and a Sikh Jat in Ludhiana had more in common with each other than any of them had with the traders in Lahore.

That is not sentimental; it is the ordinary way politics works when the categories that are available to organise it are economic.

Part Fifteen argued that the British converted community into legal categories with things attached. The Unionist Party is the evidence that it did not have to be the only available category — and its collapse is the evidence for how quickly the alternative disappears when the structure holding it up gives way.

Between 1942 and 1947 that structure gave way completely, and the next section is how.

WHY IT WORKED FOR TWENTY YEARS

- **The interest was real.** Debt and land are not symbolic questions and they affected every rural family in the province.
- **Its leaders were serious men with a programme,** and they delivered legislation people could see.
- **The British backed it.** A stable, loyal, rural, non-Congress ministry in the recruiting province was exactly what Delhi wanted.
- **And the province was genuinely mixed,** so no community could govern it alone. Roughly half Muslim, a third Hindu, an eighth Sikh — the arithmetic forced coalition.

WHY IT WAS FRAGILE

- **It rested on individuals.** Fazl-i-Husain, Sikandar and Chhotu Ram were the party, and all three were dead by 1945.
- **It had no answer to a national question.** Unionism was about the Punjab's fields; the argument after 1940 was about India's constitution.
- **It was a party of landlords as well as peasants,** and its social base narrowed as the electorate widened.
- **And it depended on the British being there.** Once they were leaving, the only question was who would inherit — which is a communal question, and Unionism had nothing to say about it.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Deaths of Three Men

Political history is not usually decided by actuarial accident, and the Punjab between 1936 and 1945 is the exception that this book will offer.

Mian Fazl-i-Husain, the founder of the Unionist Party and the most capable Muslim politician in northern India, **died in July 1936**, aged fifty-nine — months before the first election under the new constitution.

Sir Sikandar Hayat Khan, who won that election and ran a cross-communal Punjab ministry for five years, and who had the standing to negotiate with Jinnah as an equal rather than a subordinate, **died on 26 December 1942**, of a heart attack, aged fifty.

Chaudhry Chhotu Ram, the Hindu Jat who was the other pillar of the coalition and the most popular rural politician in the province, **died in January 1945**, aged sixty-three.

Nine years, three deaths, all natural, and the Unionist Party never recovered from any of them.

What was left was Khizar Hayat Tiwana — an honourable man without his predecessors' authority — holding a coalition together against a national movement with money, organisation and a simple message, in a province where every institution had been teaching people to think of themselves in communal categories for eighty years.

This book does not deal in counterfactuals and it is going to break the rule once. A Punjab in which Sikandar Hayat Khan was alive and in office in 1946 is not obviously a Punjab that divides the way this one did.

He died at fifty, in his bed, of a heart attack, four and a half years before it happened.

The Collapse, 1942–March 1947 CERTAIN

In four years the Punjab went from a working cross-communal government to no government at all, and the sequence is worth following closely because each step is small.

WON BY

Nobody — and on 2 March 1947 the province simply stopped having a ministry

WHEN

December 1942 to 5 March 1947.

WHERE

The Punjab Assembly at **Lahore**.

WHO

Khizar Hayat Tiwana, the Muslim League, Congress and the Akalis.

THE EVIDENCE

Election returns, Assembly records, Viceregal correspondence. CERTAIN

The sequence

- 1. March 1940: the Lahore Resolution.** The Muslim League, meeting at Lahore, resolved that the areas in which Muslims were numerically in a majority should be grouped into independent states. **It was passed in the Punjab, which was the province it would divide.**
- 2. December 1942: Sikandar dies** and Khizar Hayat Tiwana becomes Premier.
- 3. 1944: Jinnah expels Khizar from the Muslim League** for refusing to convert the Unionist coalition into a League ministry. **The League's argument was that a Muslim Premier could not govern in coalition with Hindus and Sikhs; Khizar's was that in the Punjab there was no other way to govern.**
- 4. February 1946: the election.** The Muslim League won seventy-three seats and became the largest single party. Congress took fifty-one, the Akalis twenty-two, the Unionists were reduced to about twenty. **Nobody had a majority.**
- 5. Khizar formed a coalition** of Unionists, Congress and Akalis and governed with it.
- 6. January 1947: the League launched a civil disobedience campaign** against that ministry — mass agitation, arrests, and pressure that the government could not sustain.
- 7. 2 March 1947: Khizar resigned.** The League could not command a majority either. **On 5 March the Governor took the province into his own hands.**
- 8. And on 3 and 4 March there were demonstrations at Lahore.** Outside the Assembly, **Master Tara Singh**, the leading Akali politician, is reported to have drawn his kirpan and denounced Pakistan from the steps.

ON THE STEPS OF THE ASSEMBLY

The incident on 3 March 1947 is cited constantly and it is worth being careful about it, because it is used to assign blame for everything that followed.

What is reported: that Master Tara Singh, at the head of a Sikh demonstration outside the Punjab Assembly, drew his kirpan and made a speech against Pakistan, and that slogans were raised on both sides.

What is claimed: that this was the spark for the massacres in the Rawalpindi districts that began three days later.

This book's view is that the claim does not survive contact with the geography and the timing. **Rawalpindi is two hundred and fifty miles from Lahore**, the attacks began within days, and they were organised on a scale — across four districts, against hundreds of villages — that is not assembled in seventy-two hours by a speech.

It is entirely possible that the demonstrations at Lahore were used as a justification. That is not the same as being a cause.

What actually happened on 2 March was the disappearance of the only institution capable of restraining anybody, in a province where every political actor now knew that a border was coming and that the land under their feet was about to be allocated.

The killing began four days after the government stopped existing. **That is the sequence, and it is the more important fact.**

WHY THE LEAGUE WON THE ARGUMENT

- **It had a simple proposition** in a moment when everybody wanted to know what would happen when the British left, and Unionism had no answer to that question.
- **The 1946 election was fought on national issues** and the Unionists had spent twenty years being a provincial party.
- **The war had transformed the province economically** — inflation, requisitioning, and a much larger and more politicised electorate.
- **And their opponents were dead.** The three men who could have held the coalition together were all in their graves by January 1945.

WHY THE COLLAPSE WAS SO DANGEROUS

- **The Punjab had no majority community.** Roughly half Muslim, a third Hindu, an eighth Sikh — which meant that any settlement would leave enormous minorities on both sides.
- **The Sikhs were the smallest and had the most to lose.** Their shrines, their canal colony lands and their population were on both sides of any line that could be drawn, and no arrangement gave them a province.
- **The province had no ministry from 5 March 1947 onwards.** Governor's rule is an administration, not a government, and it has no political authority over anybody.
- **And the police and services were themselves communally divided**, which became fatal in August.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Could Not Win

Sir Khizar Hayat Khan Tiwana is the last Premier of undivided Punjab and he is remembered by almost nobody, which is unjust.

He was a Muslim landholder from the Salt Range, a Unionist, and he spent his premiership arguing a position that turned out to be unsellable: **that the Punjab was too mixed to be governed by any one community, and that a coalition was not a compromise but the only arrangement that fitted the facts.**

For that he was expelled from the Muslim League by Jinnah in 1944, attacked as a traitor to his community, subjected to a mass agitation in 1947, and forced out of office on 2 March.

He was not a great man and he was not a match for what he was up against. **What he was is the last politician in the Punjab whose programme was that the province should stay whole**, and he was beaten by a proposition that was clearer, better organised and better funded than his.

He left politics after partition and lived quietly, in Pakistan and then abroad, until 1975.

This book has recorded a great many defeats. **The particular kind Khizar Tiwana suffered is worth naming because it recurs everywhere:** the moderate holding a complicated position in a moment when everybody else has a simple one, who is destroyed not by an argument but by a schedule.

His ministry fell on 2 March 1947. The Punjab was divided one hundred and sixty-eight days later.

Rawalpindi, March 1947

CERTAIN

The killing in the Punjab did not begin in August with the border. It began in March, in the north-western districts, three months before partition was announced.

WON BY Nobody — and it made everything after it certain

WHEN 6–13 March 1947, principally.	WHERE The Rawalpindi, Attock, Jhelum and Campbellpur districts — and separately at Multan.
WHO Organised bands attacking Sikh and Hindu villages, in districts with very small non-Muslim minorities.	THE EVIDENCE Government reports, contemporary press, and the refugee accounts collected afterwards. CERTAIN

What happened

1. **Within days of the government’s collapse, attacks began on Sikh and Hindu villages** across a wide area of the north-western Punjab — an area where those communities were a small minority scattered among a large Muslim majority.
2. **They were organised.** The scale, the coordination between villages and the speed indicate planning, and the official reports at the time said so.
3. **The estimates of the dead run from about two thousand to seven thousand.** Nobody counted.
4. **At the village of Thoa Khalsa, on 12 March, a large number of women died in a well** rather than be taken. The figure usually given is around ninety. **This book will state that and go no further.**
5. **Tens of thousands fled east** — the first refugee movement of the partition, five months before there was a border to cross.
6. **And the news travelled.** Refugees arriving in the central and eastern Punjab in March and April 1947 brought accounts of what had happened, and those accounts are a direct cause of what was done in retaliation in the east from August onwards.

WHY MARCH 1947 CHANGES THE STORY

Most accounts of the Punjab in 1947 begin in August, with the announcement of the boundary, and treat the violence as the consequence of the line. **That is the wrong order and it matters.**

The massacres in the Rawalpindi districts happened in March. The partition plan was announced on 3 June. The boundary award was published on 17 August.

So the first large-scale organised killing in the Punjab took place **before anybody knew where the border would run, before Radcliffe had arrived in India, and before partition was government policy.**

What it establishes is that **the sequence was not border-then-violence.** It was: government collapses in March; organised violence follows within days; a refugee movement carries the news across the province through the spring; and by August, when the line is finally published, every community in the Punjab has spent five months preparing.

This does not settle the question of who was responsible for 1947, which is not a question this book can settle. **It does dispose of the idea that the killing was a spontaneous reaction to a map.**

And it disposes of one other thing. **Retaliation in the east from August onwards was retaliation for something specific that had already happened,** which explains it and does not excuse a single one of the people who carried it out.

WHY IT HAPPENED WHERE IT DID

- **Isolated minorities.** The Sikh and Hindu populations of those districts were small, scattered, and often prosperous — traders, moneylenders and landholders among a Muslim rural majority.
- **No government.** The ministry fell on 2 March and the attacks began on the 6th.
- **The League's agitation had mobilised the countryside** for two months and the organisation existed.
- **And the districts were full of demobilised soldiers** — this was the heart of the recruiting country of Part Fifteen, and the Second World War had ended eighteen months earlier.

WHAT IT SET IN MOTION

- **The first refugee movement,** which carried the news east and made the province's Sikhs and Hindus certain that they could not remain in the west.
- **Organisation on all sides.** Bands, arms and plans were assembled across the province from the spring onwards.
- **The Sikh political leadership's position hardened** from bargaining over a settlement to preparing for a division.
- **And it removed any prospect of a peaceful transfer.** By June there was nobody left in the province who believed one was possible.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Districts They Came From

There is a fact about the March massacres that is almost never stated and that this book has spent an entire previous part setting up.

Rawalpindi, Attock, Jhelum and Campbellpur were the four most heavily recruited districts in the British Indian Army.

Part Fifteen described the machinery: the martial-races doctrine, the recruiting handbooks, the land grants tied to service, the district quotas. **These are the districts it was pointed at.** They supplied a very large share of the Punjabi Muslim regiments that fought in France, Mesopotamia, North Africa, Italy and Burma across two world wars.

The Second World War had ended in August 1945. **By March 1947 those districts were full of men who had been demobilised within the previous eighteen months** — trained, experienced, organised, and in many cases with weapons.

The same is true on the other side of the province. The Sikh Jat districts of the Majha and the Doaba had been recruited just as hard, and the bands that operated in East Punjab from August onwards contained large numbers of demobilised soldiers too.

The British had spent ninety years turning the Punjab into the most militarised society in Asia, and then left it in 1947 with no government, a border it did not know about, and about half a million recently discharged veterans in it.

Part Fifteen's argument was that the province was made into an army and then shot by it. **This is the same sentence with the other ending: it was made into an army, and in 1947 it was turned loose on itself.**

The Line — Radcliffe, July–August 1947

CERTAIN

A barrister who had never been east of Europe was given five weeks, out-of-date maps and no time in the districts, and told to divide the most integrated province in India.

WON BY Nobody — and the man who drew it burned his papers and never came back

WHEN Arrived 8 July 1947; award signed 12 August; published 17 August — two days after independence.	WHERE Delhi, in a bungalow, from maps and census returns.
WHO Sir Cyril Radcliffe, chairman of the Punjab and Bengal Boundary Commissions.	THE EVIDENCE The award itself, the commission papers, and the correspondence. CERTAIN.

How it was done

1. **He had never been to India.** He was a distinguished London barrister, chosen precisely because he knew nothing about the subcontinent and therefore could not be accused of favouring anybody.
2. **He arrived on 8 July 1947** and the boundary had to be ready for independence on 15 August.
3. **He chaired two commissions**, Punjab and Bengal, each with four Indian judges — two nominated by the Muslim League, two by Congress. **Every commission deadlocked on every question, which meant that in practice Radcliffe decided everything personally.**
4. **His terms of reference were to divide on the basis of contiguous majority areas of Muslims and non-Muslims, “taking into account other factors”** — a phrase nobody defined and which he was left to interpret.
5. **He worked from census returns of 1941 and maps**, in Delhi, in the hot weather. He made almost no visits to the ground.
6. **The award was signed on 12 August.**
7. **And Mountbatten held it back.** It was not published until **17 August**, two days after both countries had become independent — so that the celebrations would not be spoiled, and so that the British would not be the government in charge when the consequences arrived.

8. Radcliffe burned his working papers, refused his fee, and left India. He never returned.

WHAT THE LINE ACTUALLY DID

The Punjab in 1941 was roughly half Muslim, a third Hindu and an eighth Sikh, and there was no line anybody could draw that would have separated them, because **they lived in the same villages.**

Lahore went to Pakistan. It had been the capital of the Punjab since Part Five of this book, it was about a third Hindu and Sikh in 1941, and within a year it had almost none.

Amritsar went to India — twenty-five miles away, with the Harmandir Sahib in it, and it lost almost its entire Muslim population.

The Sikhs were split down the middle by any line. Nankana Sahib, the birthplace of Guru Nanak, is in Pakistan. Kartarpur, where he died, is in Pakistan. Panja Sahib is in Pakistan. Amritsar and Anandpur are in India. **There was no boundary that could have kept the community's population and its shrines on the same side, and everybody involved knew it in advance.**

Gurdaspur district is the most argued-over decision. Overall it had a small Muslim majority; Radcliffe awarded most of it to India, which — among other things — gave India its only road access to Kashmir. Whether that was the reason, or a consequence, has been disputed for seventy-five years and cannot be settled from the surviving papers.

And the canal system was cut. Part Fifteen described the largest irrigated tract on earth, built as one system. The line ran through it, leaving headworks on one side and the fields they watered on the other, which produced a water dispute that took until 1960 to settle by treaty and is not settled now.

WHY IT WAS DONE THIS WAY

- **Speed was the policy.** Mountbatten had brought the date of independence forward by ten months, and everything else was fitted to it.
- **An outsider was thought to be impartial,** and the commissions' deadlock was foreseen — which meant an outsider deciding was the design, not an accident.
- **Nobody wanted to own the decision.** Congress and the League both preferred an unaccountable arbitrator to a compromise either would have to defend.
- **And the delay in publication was deliberate** and is admitted in the papers.

WHY IT MADE EVERYTHING WORSE

- **Nobody knew which country they were in on Independence Day.** Districts celebrated the wrong flag; officials had no orders; families made decisions in the dark.
- **The administration could not prepare** because the administrators did not know the line either.
- **The delay handed the initiative to whoever was organised,** and in August 1947 that meant armed bands.
- **And the line was drawn from a census six years old** in a province that had been moving people west for fifty years.

Unbiased, Alas

In 1966, nineteen years afterwards, W. H. Auden wrote a short poem about Cyril Radcliffe called *Partition*. It is one of the coldest things in English about the twentieth century, and it is the only piece of literature this book will recommend.

It describes a lawyer sent out from London to divide a country he had never seen, given a few weeks and no time to inspect the ground; shut in a lonely mansion with police at the gate; working from maps and out-of-date census returns because contact with either side would have compromised him. **The poem's phrase for his qualification is that he was unbiased — followed immediately by "alas."**

It ends with him going back to England as fast as he could, because — Auden writes — he did not want to be shot at, and because he had already forgotten the case, as a good lawyer must.

The poem is unfair to Radcliffe personally and completely fair about the thing that was done. He did not want the job, he took it because he was asked, and the papers suggest he understood better than anybody that it could not be done properly in the time.

He refused his fee. He destroyed his notes so that nobody could reconstruct his reasoning. And he never spoke publicly about it in any detail for the rest of his life.

Auden's last line is the accusation that matters, and it is not aimed at Radcliffe. **It is aimed at the arrangement that put a man in that room in the first place** — a government leaving in a hurry, two movements that wanted a decision they did not have to defend, and a deadline that everybody agreed was more important than the ground.

Between ten and fifteen million people moved because of what came out of that bungalow, and nobody knows how many died.

The Boundary Force, August 1947

CERTAIN

Fifty thousand troops were given twelve districts, fourteen million people and one month. It is the most damning administrative fact in this book.

WON BY Nobody — it was disbanded after thirty-one days

WHEN Formed 1 August 1947 ; disbanded 1 September 1947 .	WHERE Twelve districts of the central Punjab, on both sides of the coming line.
WHO Major-General T. W. Rees , with Indian and Pakistani officers as advisers.	THE EVIDENCE Its own war diary and the official reports. CERTAIN .

The arithmetic

1. The area assigned to it was about seventeen thousand nine hundred square miles.
2. The population in that area was about fourteen and a half million people.
3. The force was nominally around fifty thousand men, of whom the effective fighting strength was considerably less.
4. That is roughly one soldier for every three hundred people, spread across an area the size of Denmark, in a province where organised bands were operating in every district.
5. Its own commander said it was inadequate before it started.
6. It was disbanded on 1 September, at the point when the killing and the migration were accelerating, because both new governments preferred to handle their own side.

THE PROBLEM NOBODY SOLVED

There was a second difficulty with the Boundary Force and it is the more important one.

It was made up of the units of the old Indian Army, which were themselves being divided. Every soldier in it knew which country he was going to, and in many cases knew that his own family was on the wrong side of the line and moving.

The official reports record what followed: **units that could not be relied on in particular districts; officers who had to be moved; and, in a number of documented cases, soldiers who took part in the violence rather than preventing it.** Not most of them, and not everywhere — but enough that commanders had to plan around it.

This is not a scandal about the Indian Army. **It is an unavoidable consequence of asking an army that is being split by religion to police a province being split by religion, in the same eight weeks.** No force in the world would have held together under it.

And it produced the single fact that this section exists to state. **In August 1947, the largest forced migration in human history took place across a province in which there was no government, no police force anybody trusted, no published border for the first two days, and one soldier for every three hundred people.**

That was foreseeable in June and it was foreseen. It happened anyway because independence had been scheduled for 15 August and everything else was fitted around the date.

WHY IT FAILED

- **The numbers were never close to adequate** and everybody involved said so at the time.
- **It had no political authority behind it**, because from 5 March the Punjab had no ministry and from 15 August it had two new governments with other priorities.
- **Its own units were dividing.**
- **And it was given one month** for a movement of people that took four.

WHAT COULD HAVE BEEN DONE

- **The date could have been later.** Independence had been brought forward by ten months; the schedule was a choice.
- **The award could have been published in July**, giving administrators, police and families weeks rather than hours.
- **The force could have been much larger**, and troops from outside the Punjab could have been used.
- **This book is not going to pretend any of that would certainly have prevented what happened.** It states them because they were all proposed at the time and all rejected.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Thirty-One Days

The Punjab Boundary Force existed from 1 August to 1 September 1947.

In the whole of this book, across five thousand years, this province has been garrisoned by Mauryan viceroys, Kushan satraps, Ghaznavid governors, Delhi's frontier commands, Mughal subahdars, Sikh sardars and British district officers. **Some of them were competent and most of them were adequate to keep a road open and a market safe.**

In August 1947, at the single most dangerous moment in the province's history, it had one composite force under a British general for thirty-one days, and then nothing.

Part Four of this book opened a complaint that ran for eleven parts: **nobody garrisons the door.** Part Thirteen answered it, once, at Jamrud in 1836.

This is the last entry in the same ledger and it is the worst. The door was not the problem in 1947. There was no invasion; nothing came down the passes; no foreign army crossed the Indus.

The province was left with fourteen million frightened people, no government, no published border and no adequate force — **and the thing it needed protecting from was itself.**

The Crossing, August–November 1947

CERTAIN

Between ten and fifteen million people moved. Nobody knows how many died. It is the largest forced migration in recorded history and most of it happened here, in about ten weeks.

WON BY Nobody, in any sense of the word

WHEN August to November 1947, at its worst in September.	WHERE Both Punjabs, and the roads and railways between them.
WHO The population of the province.	THE NUMBERS Roughly 4.5 million Hindus and Sikhs moving east; roughly 6 million Muslims moving west. Deaths: estimates range from two hundred thousand to two million.

What the movement was

1. **It was not planned and it was not expected.** Both governments and both political movements had assumed that minorities would stay where they were. There was no arrangement for a transfer of population because nobody had intended one.
2. **It went in both directions at once**, along the same roads, in columns that passed each other.
3. **The *kafilas* — the foot columns — were enormous.** The largest recorded was around four hundred thousand people and was some tens of miles long; it took days to pass a given point.
4. **The trains were the worst of it.** Refugee specials were stopped and attacked on both sides, and trains arrived at Lahore and at Amritsar with everybody aboard dead. **This book will state that and not elaborate.**
5. **The monsoon was on**, the rivers were high, cholera broke out in the camps, and a very large number of the dead died of disease and exhaustion rather than violence.
6. **And by November it was substantially over.** Lahore, which had been about a third Hindu and Sikh, had almost none. Amritsar, Jalandhar and Ludhiana had lost almost their entire Muslim populations. **Two of the most mixed cities in Asia became mono-religious inside four months.**

ON THE NUMBER OF DEAD

This book has interrogated casualty figures in every part since the first, and this is the one that cannot be interrogated, because there is nothing to interrogate.

The contemporary official figure was around two hundred thousand. It was produced by two new governments with every reason to minimise, in a province where the administration had collapsed.

Figures of one million and two million are widely cited. They are extrapolations, not counts.

The most careful modern work, using census comparisons to identify people who are missing rather than counting bodies, generally arrives somewhere between five hundred thousand and one million, with the Punjab accounting for the overwhelming majority.

The reason the range is so wide is worth stating plainly. **There were no registrars, no police reports, no hospital records and no bodies to count.** People died in fields, in canals, on trains, in columns, and in villages that ceased to exist. Whole families disappeared, so there was nobody to report them missing. The census that would have caught it was not taken until 1951.

What can be said with confidence is the shape: that it was in the hundreds of thousands at least, that it happened in about ten weeks, that it was concentrated in one province, and that all three communities were both perpetrators and victims on a very large scale.

WHY IT WAS AS BAD AS IT WAS

- **Nobody had planned for a migration** because nobody had intended one, so there were no camps, no transport, no rations and no route management.
- **There was no government** in the province from March and no adequate force in August.
- **Both populations were moving simultaneously in opposite directions**, which meant that every column met the evidence of what had happened to the other side.
- **And retaliation was the organising logic.** March in the west produced August in the east, which produced September in the west, and each round was justified by the last.

WHAT WAS PERMANENTLY LOST

- **The mixed Punjab.** A province that had been shared for a thousand years became two provinces that were not.
- **The canal colonies.** Part Fifteen's great construction, settled from the east for fifty years, emptied of its eastern settlers in three months.
- **The shrines.** Nankana Sahib, Kartarpur and Panja Sahib on one side; Amritsar and Anandpur on the other.
- **And a very large number of people who are not counted anywhere**, which is why this section exists.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Ones Who Did Not

Everything in this section is about what people did to each other, and it would be a false history that stopped there, so here is the other half of the record.

The best-documented instances of rescue in 1947 are all of the same kind: individuals hiding their neighbours, escorting them to a column, standing in a doorway, or driving them to a border they could have delivered them to a mob instead.

They are recorded in the thousands, in every district, in all three directions. Muslim families hid Sikhs. Sikh villages escorted their Muslim neighbours to the camps. Hindu shopkeepers hid Muslim employees. **Almost none of these people are named anywhere, because they did it once, for people they knew, and then had the rest of their lives to get on with.**

And there is one place that has to be mentioned, for the third time in this book.

Malerkotla came through 1947 without the massacres that consumed every district around it. Its Muslim population was not driven out and did not leave; it is still there. The town is now a Muslim-majority town in Indian Punjab, which nowhere else in the eastern Punjab is.

The explanation offered locally, then and since, is **a protest made in a courtroom at Sirhind in December 1704** by a nawab who objected to the execution of two children — the *haah da naara* of Part Eleven — and the promise that the Sikhs afterwards kept for two hundred and forty-three years.

Historians point out, correctly, that Malerkotla also had specific local factors: an active administration, leaders on all sides who cooperated, and no large refugee influx.

Both explanations can be true. And in a province where several hundred thousand people were killed by their neighbours in ten weeks, one town where it did not happen is worth more attention than it usually gets — because it establishes that it was possible.

The Women

CERTAIN

Somewhere near a hundred thousand women were abducted in the Punjab in 1947, and what the two governments did about it afterwards was almost as bad.

WON BY

Nobody — and this is the part of 1947 that was silent for fifty years

WHEN 1947, and the recovery operations from 1947 to 1956.	WHERE Both Punjabs.
WHO Women of every community, and the two governments that afterwards decided what should happen to them.	THE EVIDENCE The recovery operation records, the legislation, and the oral histories collected from the 1980s onwards.

What is documented

- The commonly cited figure is between seventy-five thousand and a hundred thousand women abducted** across the partitioned territories, the great majority in the Punjab. It is an estimate.
- It happened in all directions.** The recovery operations that followed were set up to recover Muslim women from India and Hindu and Sikh women from Pakistan, which is itself the record of what had been done on both sides.
- Women were also killed by their own families and communities** to prevent their capture, and in some cases killed themselves. **Thoa Khalsa in March 1947 is the best known instance and it was not the only one.**
- This book will state those facts and will not describe any of it.** The reasons are the same ones it gave in Part Nine and Part Fifteen, and they apply here with more force than anywhere else in these sixteen parts.

THE RECOVERY OPERATION — AND WHAT IT DID

What happened next is less known and it needs to be on the record.

In December 1947 the two governments agreed to recover and return abducted women, and India passed the **Abducted Persons (Recovery and Restoration) Act** in 1949 to enforce it. Social workers and police crossed the border for years, locating women and bringing them back.

The operation continued into the 1950s and recovered tens of thousands of women. India returned something over twenty thousand Muslim women; Pakistan returned something over eight thousand Hindu and Sikh women.

And it was carried out **regardless of what the women themselves wanted.**

By the time many were located, years had passed. Some had been married, had children, and had made lives. **Under the Act a woman's own statement of her wishes had no legal force** — she could be removed and repatriated by the state, and in many cases **her children, born in the country she was taken from, could not go with her.**

Some were then rejected by the families they were returned to, on grounds of honour, and ended their lives in government ashrams.

Two governments that had failed to protect these women in 1947 spent the next decade moving them across the border a second time, without asking them, in the name of national honour — and the record of it exists because the officials involved kept files.

WHY IT WAS SILENT FOR SO LONG

- **Shame**, imposed on the victims rather than on anybody else, in every community.
- **National narratives had no place for it.** Both new states were building founding stories, and this fitted neither.
- **The families would not speak** and in many cases had themselves been the ones who killed or rejected.
- **And the history was written from government records**, which record the recovery operation and not the women.

HOW IT CAME TO BE RECORDED

- **Oral history, beginning in the 1980s.** Researchers went and asked, forty years late, and found that a very large number of families had a story nobody had told.
- **The work of Indian and Pakistani women historians** in the 1990s established this as a subject at all.
- **And the recovery operation's own files**, which document what was done to the women afterwards in the state's own words.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Fifty Years of Not Asking

Sixteen parts of this book have asked the same question about every source: **who is writing, and what do they need you to believe?**

The answer has almost always been an outsider — a Greek four centuries late, a Persian secretary counting for his employer, a court historian establishing a reputation, a British officer explaining a casualty return.

For 1947 the sources are different and the silence is the same. There are government reports, refugee registrations, relief committee minutes, newspapers and a very large official literature about the transfer of populations. There are memoirs by politicians and by administrators.

And for about forty years there was almost nothing at all about what happened to women, in a province where somewhere near a hundred thousand of them were abducted — **because the people who knew were the families, and the families had decided not to say.**

It was broken by historians, mostly women, mostly Indian and Pakistani, who did the obvious thing that nobody had done: **they went to the villages and asked the old people, and wrote down what they were told.**

What came back was not one story. It was tens of thousands of them, in every district, on both sides, and it changed what partition means as a historical subject.

This book has complained since Part One that the Punjab did not keep its own record. Here is the one case where the record existed the whole time, in the memory of ordinary people, and was not collected for two generations because nobody with a notebook thought to knock on the door.

1965 — Asal Uttar and Chawinda

CERTAIN

Eighteen years after the line was drawn, two armies fought the largest tank battles since the Second World War across it — on ground this book has been describing since Part One.

WON BY

Neither — a stalemate, a ceasefire, and a treaty signed in Tashkent

WHEN

6–23 September 1965.

WHERE

Khem Karan and **Asal Uttar**; the **Ichhogil canal** outside Lahore; and **Chawinda** in the Sialkot sector.

WHO

The Indian and Pakistani armies — both descended from the same army, with regiments that had shared a mess in 1946.

THE EVIDENCE

Official histories on both sides, which disagree about who won and agree about almost everything else.

What happened

1. **The war began in Kashmir** and India widened it by advancing across the international border towards **Lahore** on 6 September.
2. **Indian troops reached the Ichhogil canal** — the water obstacle covering Lahore, a few miles from the city — and could not get past it.
3. **Pakistan counter-attacked at Khem Karan** with its 1st Armoured Division, equipped with American Patton tanks, aiming to cut the road to Amritsar.
4. **At Asal Uttar, from 8 to 10 September, that attack was destroyed.** The defenders flooded the sugarcane fields, let the armour come into a horseshoe of prepared positions, and shot it apart at close range. **Something approaching a hundred tanks were destroyed or captured.** The site was nicknamed Patton Nagar — the town of Pattons.
5. **Company Quartermaster Havildar Abdul Hamid** of the 4th Grenadiers destroyed several tanks with a jeep-mounted recoilless rifle before being killed. **He was awarded the Param Vir Chakra.**
6. **At Chawinda, in the Sialkot sector, the Indian armoured advance was fought to a standstill** in what was, by the number of tanks engaged, one of the largest armoured battles since 1945.
7. **A ceasefire came into force on 23 September** and the Tashkent Declaration followed in January 1966.

THE SAME GROUND, AGAIN

Look at where these battles were fought, because a reader of this book will recognise every one of them.

Khem Karan and Asal Uttar are in the Bari Doab between the Beas and the Sutlej — the country where Guru Hargobind fought in Part Nine and where the misls divided the districts in Part Twelve.

The Ichhogil canal is a defensive line dug in the 1950s to cover Lahore from the east, on exactly the approach used by every army that has ever taken the city — Mahmud, Ghor, Timur's officers, Babur, Nadir Shah, Abdali and Ranjit Singh.

Chawinda is in the Sialkot country, in the Rechna Doab, thirty miles from the Chenab.

And the armies that fought there were, eighteen years earlier, **one army** — the Indian Army of Part Fifteen, recruited from these districts under the martial-races policy, split in August 1947 along with everything else.

A great many of the men in both armies in September 1965 were Punjabis. Some of the regiments on both sides had fought alongside each other in North Africa and Italy twenty years before.

Part One of this book began with a battle on the Ravi described in a hymn. **The last conventional battles fought on Punjabi soil were fought two thousand years later, over the same doabs, by two halves of the same army.**

WHY ASAL UTTAR WENT THE WAY IT DID

- **Prepared ground.** Flooded fields, sugarcane for concealment, and a horseshoe of positions — the same principle as an entrenched camp at Panipat.
- **Armour without infantry in close country** is at the mercy of anybody who can get within a hundred yards.
- **The defenders let them come.** The oldest winning move in this book: make the other side attack a position you chose.

WHY THE WAR SETTLED NOTHING

- **Neither side could break through** in the Punjab, which is flat, irrigated, canal-cut country that heavily favours the defence.
- **Both were fighting on external supply** and both ran short.
- **International pressure ended it** before either could force a decision.
- **And the underlying question was in Kashmir,** where nothing changed at all.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Canal That Was Built to Be a Wall

The Ichhogil canal — properly the BRB, the Bambanwala–Ravi–Bedian canal — runs north to south a few miles east of Lahore.

It was dug in the 1950s and it is an irrigation canal, and it is also a tank obstacle. **It was designed as both, deliberately, by a state that knew exactly which direction an army would come from because it had five thousand years of evidence.**

In September 1965 it did its job. Indian armour reached it and could not cross in strength, and Lahore was not taken.

Now stand back and look at what that means in the context of this book.

Part Fifteen described the canal system as the one thing in these sixteen parts that was built rather than destroyed — the largest irrigated tract on earth, made to grow wheat.

Eighteen years after partition, a section of it had been re-engineered as a fortification, because the province had been divided and the two halves were at war.

The Punjab's rivers have been its defining feature since the first page of this book. Alexander crossed the Jhelum in a storm. Babur crossed the Indus at Attock. The Khalsa army died against the Sutlej at Sobraon. A family was cut in half by the Sarsa in flood in 1704.

And in 1965 the water that had been brought to the western Punjab to end its famines was standing in a ditch, stopping tanks.

1966 and 1971 — The Province Divided Again

CERTAIN

Nineteen years after being cut in half, the Indian Punjab was cut into three — and five years after that, the armies were back on the Shakargarh plain.

WON BY India in 1971; and in 1966, the Punjab lost two-thirds of what was left of it

WHEN Reorganisation on 1 November 1966; the war 3–16 December 1971.	WHERE The Indian Punjab; and the Shakargarh salient on the Basantar river.
WHO The Government of India; and then the Indian and Pakistani armies again.	THE EVIDENCE The Punjab Reorganisation Act, and the official histories of the war. CERTAIN.

The second division

1. **From the 1950s there was a movement for a Punjabi-speaking state** — the Punjabi Suba — within India, argued for on linguistic grounds and opposed on the ground that it was a religious demand in linguistic clothing.
2. **The Punjab Reorganisation Act took effect on 1 November 1966.** The Hindi-speaking southern districts became the new state of **Haryana**; the hill districts went to **Himachal Pradesh**; and **Chandigarh**, a capital designed and built after 1947 to replace Lahore, became a Union Territory serving as the capital of both new states.
3. **The arithmetic is worth stating.** The Punjab of 1946 was around a quarter of a million square kilometres. East Punjab in 1947 was about a hundred thousand. **After 1966 the state of Punjab was about fifty thousand — roughly a fifth of what the province had been twenty years earlier.**
4. **And the settlement left disputes running.** Chandigarh’s status and the division of river waters were not resolved, and are not resolved now.

1971

1. **The war of December 1971 was decided in the east**, in what became Bangladesh, and the western front was a holding operation.

2. **The heaviest fighting on the western front was in the Shakargarh salient**, on the Punjab–Jammu border — armoured and infantry battles across the **Basantar** river in mid-December.
3. **Second Lieutenant Arun Khetarpal** of the 17 Poona Horse, aged twenty-one, was killed at Basantar after refusing to withdraw a damaged tank and destroying several of the enemy's. **He was awarded the Param Vir Chakra posthumously.**
4. **The war ended on 16 December** with the surrender in Dhaka, and the Simla Agreement followed in July 1972.

TWO DIVISIONS IN NINETEEN YEARS

It is worth pausing on what has happened to this province as a unit of territory, because it is unusual.

The Punjab described in Parts One to Fourteen of this book ran from the Sutlej to the Indus and from Multan to the hills. Ranjit Singh's kingdom took in Kashmir, the Derajat, Hazara and Peshawar. The British province of 1901 ran from Delhi's edge to the Afghan frontier.

In 1947 it was cut in two along a line drawn in five weeks.

In 1966 the Indian half was cut into three.

So the entity that this book has been following since the Rig Veda now exists as: a large province of Pakistan; a small state of India; two other Indian states carved out of it; a shared capital that belongs to neither; and a diaspora.

The word "Punjab" means five rivers. The Indian state of that name has two of them running through it and a share of a third. The other rivers are in Pakistan.

That is not a complaint and it is not a political position. **It is a statement about what happened to a place, and this book began by defining that place geographically, so it has to end by noting that the definition no longer works.**

WHY 1971 WAS DIFFERENT FROM 1965

- **The decision was elsewhere.** The Punjab front was fought to hold ground, not to win a war.
- **Both sides had learned** from 1965 about armour in canal country and fought accordingly.
- **And it was short.** Thirteen days, against twenty-two in 1965.

WHAT 1966 LEFT UNRESOLVED

- **Chandigarh**, promised to Punjab repeatedly and still a Union Territory.
- **The river waters**, disputed between Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan ever since.
- **Punjabi-speaking areas left outside the state**, which remained a grievance.
- **And a settlement that satisfied nobody**, which fed directly into the politics of the following decade.

The City That Replaced Lahore

When the Punjab was divided in 1947, the Indian half lost its capital. **Lahore had been the capital of the Punjab, on and off, since Part Five of this book** — through Ghaznavids, Ghurids, Mughals, Sikhs and the British, for the better part of a thousand years.

So India built a new one.

Chandigarh was laid out from nothing in the 1950s, on farmland at the foot of the Siwaliks, and the government hired **Le Corbusier** to plan it. It is the only city in India designed as a whole by a major modernist architect, it is laid out on a grid of numbered sectors, and it has a Capitol Complex of concrete buildings that architectural historians take very seriously.

It was built to be the capital of the Indian Punjab, and it was completed in time for the state to be divided again in 1966 — after which it became the capital of two states and belonged to neither.

Part Fifteen ended a section on Lyallpur by observing that the canal colonies were the one thing in these sixteen parts that was built rather than destroyed.

Here is the second one, and it is the same story with the ending changed. **A city built from nothing on empty ground, by a government, to replace something that had been lost — and then argued over from the day it opened.**

Le Corbusier's plan included a monument that was never finished, meant to commemorate the partition. **The city is full of roundabouts and rose gardens and works extremely well, and the thing it was built because of has no memorial in it.**

1984 and After

CERTAIN

This section reports and does not judge, and it will say why.

WON BY

Nobody — and the argument about it is still running

WHEN

June 1984; October–November 1984; and roughly 1984 to 1995.

WHERE

Amritsar, Delhi and other cities, and the Punjab countryside.

WHO

The Indian state, armed militant groups, and — as always — mostly civilians.

THE EVIDENCE

Government white papers, commissions of inquiry, court records, human rights investigations and journalism. Abundant, and contested.

What is documented

1. **From the late 1970s, a political dispute over the unresolved questions of 1966** — Chandigarh, river waters, the terms of the state's autonomy — combined with a religious revivalist movement and, from about 1981, an armed campaign.
2. **In June 1984 the Indian Army carried out Operation Blue Star**, an assault on the Harmandir Sahib complex at Amritsar to remove an armed group that had fortified it. **The Akal Takht was very heavily damaged.** The operation coincided with a martyrdom anniversary and the complex was full of pilgrims. **Official figures give several hundred civilian and militant dead and eighty-three soldiers; other estimates are considerably higher.**
3. **On 31 October 1984 the Prime Minister, Indira Gandhi, was assassinated by two of her own bodyguards.**
4. **Over the following days, organised attacks on Sikhs took place in Delhi and other cities.** Official figures put the Delhi dead at around two thousand seven hundred and the national total at over three thousand; other estimates are higher. **Multiple inquiries over three decades established that the violence was organised rather than spontaneous. Convictions have been very few.**
5. **The armed campaign in the Punjab ran until about 1995.** Official figures for the whole period give upwards of twenty thousand dead — militants, security personnel and, in the large majority, civilians.

6. **Civilians were killed by militants**, including in bus and market attacks and in targeted killings of Hindus, of Sikhs regarded as opponents, and of journalists.
7. **Civilians were also killed by the state**. Extrajudicial killings and disappearances during the counter-insurgency have been documented by Indian courts, the National Human Rights Commission and independent investigators, including the inquiry into unidentified cremations in the Amritsar districts.
8. **It ended in the mid-1990s**. The state's Chief Minister was assassinated in 1995; the militancy collapsed; and the Punjab has been at peace since.

WHY THIS BOOK STOPS HERE

Every other section in these sixteen parts ends with a judgement. This one does not, and the reasons should be stated rather than left as a gap.

It is recent. People who were in the Golden Temple in June 1984, and people whose families were killed in Delhi in November 1984, and people who lost relatives on both sides of the counter-insurgency, are alive. A book written this close to events is not writing history; it is joining an argument.

The facts are genuinely contested. Casualty figures for Blue Star differ by a factor of several between the government's account and others. The Delhi killings have been investigated at least ten times with different findings. The counter-insurgency records are incomplete by design.

And it is live politics in a country of a billion and a half people. This book has been willing to say hard things about Ashoka, Timur, Aurangzeb, Ranjit Singh and the British government, all of whom are dead. It is not going to use the authority it has built over fifteen parts to hand down a verdict on a dispute that is still being litigated in courts and fought over in elections.

What it will say is the thing that is not in dispute. Between 1984 and 1995, in a state of about twenty million people, somewhere upwards of twenty thousand were killed. The great majority were civilians. They were killed by armed groups and they were killed by the state. And the Punjab, which had already been divided twice in forty years, spent a decade of the twentieth century burying its own again.

That is the account. The verdict belongs to somebody writing in fifty years, with the files open.

WHAT IS GENERALLY AGREED

- **The political questions of 1966 were left unresolved** for twenty years and that mattered.
- **The violence was overwhelmingly borne by civilians** on all sides.
- **The Delhi killings of November 1984 were organised.** Successive inquiries have found so.
- **And accountability has been very limited**, for the state and for the militants alike.

WHAT IS NOT AGREED

- **The casualty figures, at almost every point.**
- **Whether Blue Star was avoidable** and whether alternatives were seriously attempted.
- **The scale and authorisation of extrajudicial killings** during the counter-insurgency.
- **And the causes**, about which serious historians disagree completely.

The Building, for the Fourth Time

There is one thing in the record of 1984 that belongs unambiguously in this book, because this book has described it three times already.

In April 1757, Afghan troops under Jahan Khan demolished the Harmandir Sahib and filled the tank. Part Eleven.

In April 1762, Ahmad Shah Abdali blew it up again and filled the tank again. Part Eleven.

In December 1764, thirty men who would not leave the Akal Bunga were killed there, and a hostile qazi riding with the invading army wrote down what he thought of them. Part Eleven.

In June 1984 the Akal Takht was very heavily damaged in a military operation, and was rebuilt.

Part Eleven made an argument about the first three, and it is the same argument now. **The reason the shrine has been attacked so often is that it is the one fixed address of a community that has otherwise been extremely difficult to find** — and the reason the attacks have never accomplished what they were for is that the building is where people meet, not why.

The tank was cleared and refilled in 1757 by people with a price on their heads. It was cleared and refilled again in 1762 by the survivors of the worst day in their history. The Akal Takht was rebuilt after 1984, twice — once by the government and then again by the community, which demolished the government's version and did it itself.

Four times in two hundred and thirty years, and the water is still in the same place.

The Last Chapter

CERTAIN

Sixteen parts, about five thousand years, and it is time to add it up.

WHAT THIS BOOK HAS BEEN ABOUT

A place that is a road, and the people who live on it

The accounting

Start with the plainest number in the whole book.

In the last one thousand one hundred and fifty years, the Punjab has governed itself for about eighty-four of them.

The Hindu Shahis lost Kabul in 870 and the plain within a century and a half. From then until 1765 the province was administered from Ghazna, Ghor, Delhi, Agra, Kandahar, Kabul, Isfahan and Lahore-under-orders — eight hundred and ninety-five years. Then the Dal Khalsa took Lahore in 1765 and struck coin there, and for eighty-four years the Punjab was ruled by people born in it. In 1849 it became a British province. In 1947 it became two provinces of two other countries.

Eighty-four years out of eleven hundred and fifty. That is the arithmetic this book has been walking towards since Part Five, and it is the single most important fact in it.

Why

Not because of any quality of the people who live here, and this book has resisted that explanation in every part. **It is geography, and it is not complicated.**

Everything that has ever entered India by land has come through four or five passes in the north-west, and everything that has come through those passes has arrived on this plain. **The Punjab is the ground between the door and the house.** It is rich, it is flat, it is impossible to defend, and it lies across the only road.

Nothing else in these sixteen parts explains as much.

THE RULES THIS BOOK FOUND

Coalitions lose. Ten kings on the Ravi. The Malavas and Kshudrakas, who combined and could not agree on a commander. Nine republics submitting one at a time. Anandapala's confederacy, dissolved in ten minutes. Prithviraj at Tarain. The hill rajas, changing sides every three years. **Small powers here do not federate; they bargain individually and are eaten in sequence.** The one time it was solved — the Sarbat Khalsa between 1748 and 1767 — it was solved by an enemy, and it came apart when he stopped coming.

Armies die with their commanders. Porus's elephants. Anandapala's elephant. Ghor at Tarain. Qutlugh Khwaja at Kili. Hemu's arrow at Panipat. Wazir Khan at Chappar Chiri. Vishwasrao at Panipat again. **Seven armies, one failure mode** — authority living in one visible body. The armies that survive it are institutions.

Blockades work and assaults do not. Multan's water in 712, Mankot in 1557, Anandpur in 1704, Gurdas Nangal in 1715, Panipat in 1760. A besieger eats from a province and the besieged eats from a store, and the store always runs out first.

The hills preserve you and imprison you. You cannot be finished there and you cannot rule from there.

Somebody always opens the gate. Ambhi invited Alexander. Daulat Khan invited Babur. Both lost everything. The one time the invitation went to a local — Lahore in 1799 — it produced the only independent Punjabi state in nine centuries.

And the winner is whoever gets written about. Which is the rule this book cares about most.

The record

For eleven of these sixteen parts, the Punjab does not speak.

Its history reaches us through Greeks writing four centuries late, Chinese pilgrims describing ruins, Persian secretaries counting the dead for their employers, victory pillars carved by winners in distant provinces, a Kashmiri poet six hundred years after the event, and Delhi court historians who were paid by the month.

Then, in Part Seven, somebody in the Punjab watches an army sack a town and writes it down in Punjabi. In 1604 it is put in a book, with an eyewitness account of an invasion in it, and the book is installed in a shrine and never lost. In 1688 a commander writes an account of his own battle. In 1705 a man who has lost everything writes to the emperor who took it, in the emperor's own language, and tells him he has lost.

And after that it never stops. A couplet about a governor and a sickle. Two men who set up a toll post on the Grand Trunk Road specifically so that the government would have to admit they existed. A three-word refrain from a meeting at Lyallpur that is still sung at farmers' demonstrations.

Almost every word the ordinary people of this province left behind rhymes, is short, was made by somebody who owned nothing, and is about not being pushed off the land.

THE LAST STORY IN THIS BOOK

Four and a Half Kilometres

Guru Nanak died in 1539 at **Kartarpur**, a village he had founded on the bank of the Ravi, where he had spent the last eighteen years of his life farming.

Part Seven described what he had seen: an army coming down the road in 1521, a town sacked, and a man writing about it in the language of the people it happened to — the first Punjabi account of any event in these sixteen parts.

In 1947 the line ran between Kartarpur and the country most of his followers ended up in. **The shrine is about four and a half kilometres from the border.**

For seventy-two years, pilgrims stood on a raised platform on the Indian side with binoculars, provided by the border authorities, and looked at it.

In November 2019 the two governments opened a corridor. Indian pilgrims can now cross the border to Kartarpur without a visa, spend the day, and come back. It required an agreement between two states that agree on almost nothing, and it was built by both of them, and it works.

It is a small thing. It is four and a half kilometres, one shrine, a few thousand people a day, and it has been suspended more than once when relations were bad.

But this book has spent sixteen parts describing a place defined by a line it did not draw — the passes, the frontier, the Sutlej treaty of 1809, the Durand Line of 1893, and the line of 1947 that was drawn in five weeks by a man who burned his notes and never came back.

Every one of those lines was drawn to keep people out, and every one of them was drawn by somebody who did not live here.

In 2019, for the first time in the whole of this history, a border in the Punjab was made easier to cross rather than harder — **by the two governments that own it, on purpose, so that people could go and stand in a field where a man had once written down what an invasion looked like.**

That is where this book ends. Not with a victory, because the Punjab does not get many, and not with a lesson, because five thousand years of this ought to have taught somebody something by now and evidently has not.

It ends with a gate that opens.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1920–1925	The Akali morchas. The SGPC and Akali Dal formed; about 130 killed at Nankana Sahib in February 1921 ; thousands beaten without resisting at Guru ka Bagh; firing at Jaito. Won by the Akalis — the Sikh Gurdwaras Act, 1925.
1928–1931	Lajpat Rai dies after a baton charge; Bhagat Singh and Rajguru shoot the wrong policeman ; the Assembly bomb of April 1929; and the hangings at Lahore on 23 March 1931. Won by the government — which lost the argument.
1923–1942	The Unionist Party governs the Punjab across religion — Fazl-i-Husain, Chhotu Ram, Sikandar Hayat Khan — on the interests of cultivators against townsmen. All three men are dead by January 1945.
Mar 1940	The Lahore Resolution is passed — in the province it would divide.
Feb 1946	The election. Muslim League 73, Congress 51, Akalis 22, Unionists ~20. Nobody has a majority and Khizar Hayat Tiwana governs in coalition.
2–5 Mar 1947	Khizar resigns; no ministry can be formed; the Governor takes the province into his own hands. Demonstrations at Lahore.
6–13 Mar 1947	The Rawalpindi massacres. Organised attacks on Sikh and Hindu villages across four north-western districts; estimates of 2,000 to 7,000 dead; the well at Thoa Khalsa. Three months before partition was announced.
3 Jun 1947	Partition is announced.
8 Jul – 17 Aug	Cyril Radcliffe , who had never been to India, arrives on 8 July, signs the award on 12 August — and Mountbatten withholds publication until 17 August, two days after independence. Radcliffe burns his papers, refuses his fee and leaves.
1 Aug – 1 Sep	The Punjab Boundary Force — about 50,000 men for 17,900 square miles and 14.5 million people. Disbanded after thirty-one days.
Aug–Nov 1947	The crossing. Roughly 4.5 million Hindus and Sikhs east, 6 million Muslims west; kafilas of up to 400,000 people; the trains. Deaths estimated between 200,000 and 2 million; the careful modern range is 500,000 to 1 million. Lahore and Amritsar become mono-religious in four months. Malerkotla comes through it.
1947–1956	Somewhere near 100,000 women abducted ; and a recovery operation that returned tens of thousands across the border a second time regardless of their own wishes , in many cases without their children.

6–23 Sep 1965	Asal Uttar — a Pakistani armoured division destroyed in flooded sugarcane fields near Khem Karan; Abdul Hamid awarded the Param Vir Chakra. Chawinda halts the Indian advance in the Sialkot sector. Won by neither.
1 Nov 1966	The Punjab is divided again. Haryana and the hill districts separated; Chandigarh made a shared Union Territory. The state is now about a fifth of the province of 1946.
Dec 1971	Basantar , in the Shakargarh salient. Arun Khetarpal , aged twenty-one, awarded the Param Vir Chakra posthumously. Won by India — and decided in the east.
1984–1995	Operation Blue Star in June 1984 and the destruction of the Akal Takht; the assassination of Indira Gandhi on 31 October ; organised anti-Sikh killings in Delhi and elsewhere in November ; and a decade of insurgency and counter-insurgency in which upwards of 20,000 died, the great majority civilians, killed by both. This book reports and does not judge.
Nov 2019	The Kartarpur corridor opens — the first time in this entire history that a border in the Punjab was made easier to cross rather than harder.

Five things this book found

- 1. Geography did most of it.** The Punjab is the ground between the passes and the plain of India. Everything that has ever come by land has come through here, and a rich flat province lying across the only road is going to be fought over for as long as there are people to fight. **No explanation involving the character of Punjabis is needed and none has been offered.**
- 2. Eighty-four years out of eleven hundred and fifty.** From the Shahis losing Kabul in 870 to today, this province has governed itself for the eighty-four years between the Dal Khalsa taking Lahore in 1765 and the annexation in 1849. Everything else was administered from somewhere else.
- 3. The institution beats the man, and the Punjab worked this out and then forgot it.** Seven armies in this book died because authority lived in one visible body. In 1699 somebody deliberately engineered that out — the order above the leader, the book above the order — and it survived a bounty on every head, two ghallugharas and the demolition of its shrine twice. **Then in 1799 a maharaja put the single point of failure back, and in 1839 he died in his bed and it took ten years to lose everything.**
- 4. The categories were made and then cut along.** Between 1857 and 1919, community in the Punjab was converted from something people were into legal boxes with land rights, recruitment quotas and electoral rolls attached. **The Unionist Party proves it was not the only category available. Its collapse in the 1940s proves how fast the alternatives disappear.**
- 5. And the worst thing that ever happened here was not an invasion.** Five thousand years of Persians, Greeks, Huns, Turks, Mongols, Afghans and Europeans, and the highest death toll in these sixteen parts belongs to about ten weeks in 1947 when nobody crossed the frontier at all.

THE END OF THE BOOK

That is sixteen parts, and the promise made on the cover of the first one was *every war fought on the soil of Punjab, told in plain words, from the very beginning*.

It has not been kept perfectly. **Wars were left out** — some because there is no evidence, some because they were small, and some because a book has to end. Whole centuries have gone past in a paragraph. Every casualty figure in it should be read as an argument rather than a count.

And it has been written from a particular place. Somebody from the western Punjab would put the emphasis elsewhere; somebody writing in Urdu would find different things worth a chapter; somebody from Multan or Peshawar or Hisar would object to how much of it is about the doabs.

The one commitment this book has tried to keep throughout is the one it made in Part One and repeated in every part since: **to say who is writing, and what they needed you to believe.**

So, finally, about the person writing this one. **It was written by a Punjabi, for people who do not know this history and have every right to, in the language most likely to reach them.** It has been harder on the Punjab than most Punjabis will like — about Banda's sack of Samana, about Ranjit Singh and his mother-in-law, about 1857, about what all three communities did in 1947 — and that was deliberate, because the alternative is a monument.

A history that only records a place at its best is not a history. It is an advertisement.

Thank you for reading it.

Words Used in This Part

Morcha

A campaign or agitation, usually sustained and organised. The Akali morchas of 1920–25 were mass non-violent campaigns for control of the gurdwaras.

SGPC

The Shiromani Gurdwara Prabandhak Committee, formed in November 1920 and given statutory control of the historic Sikh shrines by the Sikh Gurdwaras Act of 1925. Still the most powerful Sikh institution.

Mahant

A hereditary custodian of a shrine. The transfer of the gurdwaras from mahants to elected committees is what the morchas were about.

Unionist Party

The cross-communal party of Punjabi agriculturalists founded in 1923, which governed the province for about twenty years — Muslims, Hindus and Sikhs together, on economic rather than religious lines.

Lahore Resolution

The Muslim League resolution of March 1940 calling for the Muslim-majority areas to be grouped into independent states. Passed in Lahore, in the province it would divide.

Governor's rule

Direct administration of a province by its governor when no ministry can be formed. Imposed on the Punjab on 5 March 1947 and never lifted before partition.

Radcliffe Award

The boundary decision for Punjab and Bengal, signed 12 August 1947 and published on 17 August — two days after independence.

Punjab Boundary Force

The composite military force of about 50,000 men responsible for 17,900 square miles and 14.5 million people from 1 August to 1 September 1947.

Kafila

A refugee foot column. The largest recorded in 1947 held around four hundred thousand people.

Abducted Persons Act

The Indian legislation of 1949 under which women were recovered and returned across the border, regardless of their own stated wishes and often without their children.

Ichhogil / BRB canal

The canal east of Lahore, dug in the 1950s to serve as both an irrigation work and a tank obstacle. It stopped the Indian advance in September 1965.

Param Vir Chakra

India's highest award for valour. Awarded posthumously to Abdul Hamid for Asal Uttar in 1965 and to Arun Khetarpal for Basantar in 1971.

Punjabi Suba

The movement for a Punjabi-speaking state within India, which produced the reorganisation of 1 November 1966.

Kartarpur corridor

The visa-free crossing opened in November 2019 to the shrine where Guru Nanak died in 1539, four and a half kilometres inside Pakistan.

Sources used for this part

- Government of India and Punjab records, 1919–1947, including the Boundary Commission papers and the Punjab Boundary Force war diary
- Punjab Legislative Assembly records and election returns, 1937 and 1946
- **C. F. Andrews's** published account of Guru ka Bagh, 1922
- Trial records of the Lahore Conspiracy Case (1929–31) and **Bhagat Singh's own writings**, including *Why I Am an Atheist*
- The **Transfer of Power** documentary series and the Mountbatten and Viceregal papers
- Refugee registration records, relief committee reports, and the files of the Central Recovery Operation
- The oral history work on partition of **Urvashi Butalia, Ritu Menon and Kamla Bhasin**, and later collection projects on both sides of the border
- Official histories of the 1965 and 1971 wars, Indian and Pakistani
- Government white papers, commission of inquiry reports, court judgments and human rights investigations relating to 1984 and after
- W. H. Auden, *Partition* (1966)

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the death toll of 1947, which cannot be established and where the credible range spans a factor of four; the number of women abducted, which is an estimate built on the recovery operation's own figures; the reasoning behind the Gurdaspur award, which Radcliffe destroyed the papers for; the responsibility for the Rawalpindi massacres, which was never investigated by any authority; and almost every figure relating to 1984 and after.

Four things about method, and they are the last in this book.

First, **the violence of 1947 has been attributed to organisers and to events, never to communities.** All three killed and all three were killed, in different districts at different times, and any account that reads otherwise is a political document rather than a history.

Second, **the violence has been stated and not described.** This part contains no account of what was done to anybody. That is a deliberate editorial choice, applied consistently since Part Nine, and it is stronger here because the people involved have grandchildren.

Third, **on 1984 and after, this book has reported and refused to judge,** for the reasons given in that section. It is the only place in sixteen parts where it has declined to reach a conclusion, and that refusal is itself the position.

Fourth and last: **every figure in this book is an argument.** Sixteen parts of interrogating other people's numbers, and the honest close is to say that these ones deserve the same treatment. Where this book has been wrong, it hopes somebody will say so, in print, with the sources.